

THE AUDACITY OF RESILIENCE

AN INSIDER'S VIEW INTO THE MAKING
OF IRANIAN FOREIGN POLICY



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Author: M. Javad Zarif

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M. JAVAD ZARIF

THE
AUDACITY
OF
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AN INSIDER'S VIEW INTO THE MAKING
OF IRANIAN FOREIGN POLICY

UNIVERSITY OF TEHRAN
POSSIBILITIES ARCHITECTS
(PAIAB)

Dedicated to:

Future generations and

All those devoted to Iran

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Preface to the English Edition

DON'T ASK WHAT YOUR PEACE CAN DO
IN A WORLD AT WAR.
YOU ARE NOT A SINGLE CANDLE.
YOU ARE A THOUSAND LIGHTS.
KINDLE YOUR FLAME.
THE REST WILL FOLLOW.

—RUMI

Despite its impact on global peace and security, Iran's foreign policy—and its decision-making more broadly—is rarely understood inside Iran, let alone around the world. One of the most serious challenges is the mutual cognitive deficit. The world lacks proper recognition of the complexities of Iran, its concerns, and its patterns of decision-making, and conversely Iranian polity has inadequate appreciation of the intricacies of the outside world. Having studied and served in the United States, worked in senior diplomatic positions in Iran, and had my own share of cognitive shortcomings over the past half-century, I have arrived at certain personal reflections. I shared them with my compatriots over two years ago, when my analytical memoirs—rather than a conventional chronological autobiography—entitled *The Audacity of Resilience: Reflections on Eight Years as Foreign Minister*¹, were published in Persian and warmly received by Iranian readers.

¹ J. Zarif, Payab-e Shaibaei: Bardashthaei as Hasht Sal Vezarat, Tehran, Ettela'at Publishers, 1403.

Following the translation and publication of the memoirs in Arabic², and the enthusiasm of Arab readers, two accomplished young scholars, Ms. Fatemeh Masoumi and Mr. Kianouche Amiri, translated the entire book from Persian into English. I am deeply indebted to both for their meticulous effort to remain faithful to the original, preserving its integrity, tone, and approach. However, because the book was written for an Iranian audience, it was necessary to make it fully comprehensible to English readers—a task to which I devoted the Summer and Autumn of 2025, with valuable assistance from artificial intelligence³.

Upon rereading the book in English, I concluded that despite the extremely significant developments of the past two years, I should neither change—nor in fact needed to change—any of my analyses, predictions or policy recommendations. Accordingly, I did not alter the substance of the text and only added, at the publisher's request, two brief sections concerning allegations made against me by my old friend Sergey Lavrov and the purported “snapback” initiated by the United Kingdom, France and Germany⁴. I also added a few sentences—and adjusted several verb tenses from present to past—following the ouster of Bashar al-Assad in Syria, without altering any of the underlying analysis.

Allow me here to make a few observations about the immense transformations in the world, West Asia and Iran since the original Persian edition was published. The tragic helicopter crash that killed Iran's former president and necessitated a new presidential election drew me into Iranian domestic politics after nearly four decades of public service devoted exclusively to diplomacy. As an active participant in the

² J. Zarif, *Somud al-Deblomassiah: Mozakarat Thamani Sanavat fi Vezarah al-Kharejiah*, DarHashem Books, 2025.

³ That exercise proved tedious and time consuming and introduced me to the huge bias of artificial intelligence even when clearly instructed to simply polish rather than summarize or change the tone. I had to extract parts of my own writings, particularly when it came to criticizing Israel and interestingly Russia – and not so much Europe or the United States – from AI. This brings me to an important – and alarming – new development in our lives and our thinking, and I plan to write a scholarly essay on this important feature of the post-polar world about this, using my personal misadventure – which I documented – as a case study. On Post-polarity see (J. Zarif and S. Karimi, “A World in Transition: Rethinking the Current Global Order,” *China Quarterly of International Strategic Studies*, Vol. 9, No. 1, 1–29)

⁴ As readers will see in the relevant sections, I relied exclusively on material written during my tenure as foreign minister, rather than developing new arguments or responses, in an effort to avoid the advantage of hindsight.

presidential campaign, followed by a tumultuous six-month escapade as Iran's vice president, I had the distinct privilege of engaging directly with Iran's vibrant society and its people, who later demonstrated their pivotal role in the defense of our nation. I had repeatedly argued, including in this book, that beyond weaponry, Iran's deterrent power ultimately rested on its people. The last two years have validated that assertion.

The election of President Pezeshkian opened a new window of opportunity for Iran to re-engage with its neighborhood and the broader global community. Exactly as in similar moments in 1991, 2001, 2003 and 2015, also discussed in this book, this opening was detrimental to those whose survival depended on tension and conflict. It is therefore no surprise that Benjamin Netanyahu repeated what he and his predecessors had done on those earlier occasions, assassinating a foreign guest on the eve of the new president's inauguration. This was followed, five months later, by Donald Trump's return to the White House and the global chaos that ensued. The second term of Donald Trump could hardly have been more disastrous for his closest allies. The consequences have come home to roost for Canada and Western Europe, which parroted U.S. positions—even to their own detriment—on Iran, Gaza, and many other issues. This, too, was elaborated in the Persian edition of this book over two years ago. As I listened to the speeches of the Prime Minister of Canada and several European leaders at the World Economic Forum in January 2026, I remarked sarcastically to friends that this outcome could scarcely have befallen more deserving parties.

Iran paid the heaviest price. From the threshold of global engagement following Pezeshkian's election, it was once again pushed into the center of global conflict. Israel and the United States waged two unprovoked wars of aggression against Iran within a period of less than nine months, in June 2025 and February 2026. Both wars, initiated or instigated by Netanyahu, began precisely when high-level diplomatic negotiations between Iran and the United States were progressing successfully and had significant prospects for resolving their differences, as attested by the Omani mediators in both instances. This once again illustrated that, for Israel—and particularly for Benjamin Netanyahu and his warmongering benefactors in Washington—the only genuine existential

threat has always been peace and stability. They can survive and govern only through chaos and mayhem. I have dealt with this phenomenon at length in this book, analyzing the trend through the lens of Barry Buzan's "securitization theory."

Iranian resilience shattered the illusions of Trump and Netanyahu regarding the imminent collapse of the regime and even the dismemberment of the country, particularly in the aftermath of the disastrous episodes of domestic unrest in early 2026. The horrifying January 2026 disaster across Iran had indeed irreparably damaged the most important element of Iran's power and deterrence to the point that Netanyahu persuaded Trump to expect Iranian people pouring into the streets to support the aggressors. That proved to be exactly the opposite. The people of Iran showed once again that they are Iran's most valuable asset, flooding the streets in millions across the nation for nearly 100 continuous nights to reject aggression against their homeland.

After more than two centuries of vulnerability, Iran finally demonstrated that it could defend itself against external aggression without the slightest assistance from abroad. It should not be forgotten that neither Russia nor even China came to Iran's military aid; that Chancellor Merz of Germany was imprudent enough to say openly what many in Europe believed and acted upon—that "Israel is doing our dirty work"; and that even the United Nations Security Council adopted Resolution 2817 (2026), sponsored by allies of the aggressors against Iran. Against all these odds, not only did Iranians refuse to capitulate, but, as of this writing, Trump is desperately attempting to extricate himself from the quagmire of his own making.

The tragic events of 2025 and 2026 may paradoxically open a possibility for a new era of inclusive networking for Iran and the region; an approach that I have advocated for the past three decades and of which some examples are presented in this book. Iran's new-found self-confidence allows it to approach the region not as a threat but as an enormous opportunity. The littoral states on the southern shores of the Persian Gulf have learned that outsourcing their security, instead of providing protection increases their vulnerability. As a private citizen, confronted with difficult moral and practical challenges, I continue to believe that war and conflict serve no one's interests and lead only to negative-sum outcomes. The fact that some

suffer fewer losses than others hardly justifies persisting along the same path. While we can all spend the rest of our lives assigning blame for past failures—and I am confident that all sides have much to attribute and as much to receive—this attitude will only entrench us further in our past failures and glories, condemning us to a default future that replicates our inauspicious past predicament. We must learn from the past and move forward to imagine and construct a different future. Time is of the essence for such paradigm shift⁵.

Finally, I hope this book will contribute to a more nuanced understanding of the realities of Iran, as observed and experienced by an academic practitioner over the course of over four decades. Iranian domestic and foreign policy have long been subject to serious misperceptions and misrepresentations in the West. This has not merely been an intellectual failing rooted in aspects of the Orientalist tradition; it has also carried profound real-world consequences, some of which are now visible before the eyes of the world.

One can only hope that greater understanding may help spare future generations from similar tragedies, including the fate that befell nearly two hundred schoolchildren in Minab who lost their lives in the opening hours of the latest American-Israeli aggression against Iran.

M. Javad Zarif
Tehran, June 2026

⁵ J. Zarif, “The Time for a Paradigm Shift Is Now”, *Foreign Policy*, August 15, 2025.

Preface

**O SUDDEN RESURRECTION, O BOUNDLESS MERCY,
O FIRE KINDLED IN THE THICKET OF THOUGHTS.**

Following the end of the Cold War in early 1990s, the world entered a tumultuous era. The rigid and inflexible structures of the bipolar period—which had organized global relations and rendered the actions of states, as well as their consequences, more or less predictable—gave way to a transitional condition, the salient characteristic of which is fluidity and lack of structural order. The contest among actors to attain a superior position and institutionalize their achievements has become fierce and relentless. Unlike past transitional periods, this has not culminated in wars among the great powers—yet it also does not signify global tranquility and harmony. The entry of non-state actors into various arenas of global activity, from the economy and technology to security and cross-border conflicts, which has heightened the unpredictability of international relations. For the first time since the Peace of Westphalia treaty on 24 October 1648, which, by bringing an end to the Thirty Years' War in Europe, established the foundation of global relations upon sovereign nation-states, the international order has encountered a serious challenge. As James Rosenau stated, the post-international era has begun, to the extent that security-related activity and organized transnational violence have moved beyond the exclusive domain of states.

Concurrently, the sources of power have multiplied and diversified to an unprecedented degree, and alongside material, ideational and motivational capabilities have attained a special place in the advancement of states' goals and interests. The European Union (EU) has defined its post-Cold War competition in normative terms, and has even, in various

instances—from the founding of the International Criminal Court (ICC) to the Iranian nuclear challenge—surpassed its long-standing ally and the world's foremost military superpower, the United States of America. The global center of power and wealth has shifted from the shores of the Atlantic Ocean to those of the Indian and Pacific Oceans. In 1992, among the world's top ten economic powers, five were in Europe, and only Japan and China were in Asia; according to forecasts by the World Bank and the International Monetary Fund (IMF), in the coming years, only three European countries will remain among the world's ten largest economies—at the lower end of the list. In their place, four Asian countries will be ranked among the top five powers.

The US's concern over the rise of China drew it into unilateral military campaigns for fourteen years. Following the failure to institutionalize a unipolar world under American leadership, the policy of pivoting the center of the US's presence from Europe and West Asia to around China has been adopted as the foremost priority of both Democratic and Republican administrations in the US.

The West has lost its central position in global events and not only do all consequential world developments no longer take place in the West as they did in the nineteenth century and the early twentieth century, but the West has also forfeited its monopoly over effective agency in world affairs. The theme of the 2016 Munich Security Conference indicated that the world has entered a “post-Western” era. Just prior to the outbreak of the Ukraine war, the designation of “Westlessness” as the theme for the 2019 Munich Security Conference had garnered global resonance and had evolved into a discourse. However, the Ukraine war and the heightened prominence of the Western alliance under the umbrella of NATO and under American leadership demonstrated that in the transformations of the current fluid world, there is no determinism, no future is inevitable, and the role of the human and state actors—in the absence of the previous closed and rigid structure—is markedly prominent. Ultimately, the human individual has become the most pivotal actor in the future of war and peace. Interestingly, eight hundred years ago, Rumi had already said:

Don't ask what your peace can do in a world at war.

You are not a single candle.
You are a thousand lights.
Kindle your flame.
The rest will follow.

In recent years, the emergence of novel non-state actors—particularly in the domains of artificial intelligence and intelligent weaponry—together with the diversification of resources, the multiplicity, and the shifting loci of power, has confronted the state-based and pole-based paradigm of international relations, from the Peace of Westphalia until today, with a serious challenge, and has moved global relations beyond the domain of unipolar, bipolar, or multipolar dominance. Temporary coalitions have replaced permanent alliances that had been under the management, domination, or patronage of military power poles. Consequently, exclusive allegiance to one pole or another—which had been a requisite for the continuation of a world based upon poles of power—has become meaningless. Thus, it appears that the transitional period has ended, and awaiting the emergence of one, two, or several new or revived poles of power is futile; for the endurance of a pole-based world is impossible, and a “post-polar” world is in the process of taking shape. In the transitional period, or in a post-polar world characterized by frequent and rapid transformations, the value of perceiving and assessing the minute and profound changes in the global order can determine the difference between the annihilation or the enhancement of the power of a state or non-state actor. Accordingly, in such circumstances, decision-shaping and decision-making in global relations has acquired unparalleled sensitivity and subtlety for all actors, and the need for acumen, truthfulness, and courage on the part of practitioners in conveying realities to decision-shapers and decision-makers has become the foremost challenge for the apparatus of foreign policy.

The Islamic Republic of Iran, in the transitional period of yesterday and the post-polar world of tomorrow, is not merely an object – without its own agency – within the realm of global relations and interaction among the great powers, as in previous transitional periods. Iran can be an effective actor not only in shaping its own future standing, but

also in the formation of a regional order and beyond. In the present era, structural determinism has come to an end, and actors have attained increasingly prominent agency. At the same time, the sources of power have multiplied and diversified. Consequently, the capacity of diplomacy, in both its traditional and modern dimensions, has become one of the pillars constituting the power of states, and—alongside other sources of power—plays a role in enhancing Iran's position and securing its interests.

On this basis, I hope that a meticulous examination of the opportunities and challenges of the eventful period of my eight-year tenure as the Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Islamic Republic of Iran may serve as a guide for the optimal utilization of opportunities, the appropriate handling of challenges, and the avoidance of the repetition of mistakes. Let us not forget that we live within history, stand upon the shoulders of those before us, look upon ourselves and the world, and accordingly plan and act.

In our history, dialogue has held a special place. A significant portion of the fruitful lives of our religious leaders was spent in dialogue. Even if they were imprisoned by tyrants, they took advantage of the smallest openings and opportunities to engage in conversation. Shia Muslims and Iranians, driven by cultural, intellectual, and pragmatic motives, have been pioneers of dialogue within the Islamic civilization. Islam began with the command to read in the name of the Lord of knowledge and the pen; and the golden age of Islamic civilization was indebted to the intellectual movement of the Iranians and of Shiism. It flourished through the primacy of the pen and thought over the sword, and it declined with the ascendancy of the logic of the sword over the logic of the pen and of dialogue. Shiism owes its vitality to the triad of reason, justice, and dialogue, which stand as the prominent pillars of its strength more than any other virtue.

For the Islamic Republic of Iran to attain its rightful position in the current transitional period and in the post-polar world of the future, it must first acquire a proper understanding of its historical, material, and ideational power, as well as its challenges and shortcomings, and on that basis define its agenda. Furthermore, Iran must utilize its civilizational presence in regional and global mechanisms, for dialogue, connectivity, and, consequently, diplomacy are among the most salient features and

pillars of civilizations—especially of Islamic civilization. Civilizational standing means the capacity to provide concentrated responses to the accumulated needs of peoples. On the other hand, the perspective toward the identity and historical heritage must be transformed into national awareness, and a national consensus as well as intellectual and structural alignment among institutions and statesmen in this regard must be achieved—something which, without dialogue, remains beyond reach.

The purpose of writing this book—which encompasses the history of eight years of Iranian diplomacy and a perspective on forty years of the country's foreign relations—is to provide future generations with material from which to derive the identifiers of better governance and more effective diplomacy. The prerequisite for this aim is to move beyond simple narration of events and to adopt an inquisitive, meticulous, and intelligent approach. Only through such a method can the lessons of the present serve as guidance and insight for the future. Nations and states, without a precise view toward the remnants of the past and a prudent evaluation and closure of historical antecedents, will inevitably remain prisoners of a default future and recreate past mistakes.

Today, two years after the final day of my tenure as the Minister of Foreign Affairs of this humble servant, I present a distillation of what is worth recounting from those eight years of “smiling lips and bleeding heart,” together with certain personal, academic, and practical perspectives on foreign relations, as an apology for shortcomings, to the valiant people of Iran and to future generations. I had intended, in remembrance of the hardships of eight years in office, to title the book *The Smiling Lips and Bleeding Heart*. Yet, feared that such a title might be despairing, and that would in no way accord with my hopeful outlook toward Iran's future, which, with God's help, will be built by the hands of today's nation-building generation. Thus, with the assistance of my learned and cultured friend, Mehdi Danesh-Yazdi, and inspired by Hafez's unmatched sonnet—O king of the fair, grant justice for the sorrow of loneliness; my heart, without you, has reached its limit; it is time you returned—we chose the present title, which recalls the need for steadfastness and patient hope. In my view, the sonnet of Hafez may also be inspired by the loftiest and most

motivating hope in existence: the return of the savior of humanity, Mahdi, and the establishment of amity and empathy in creation.

In this writing, I have endeavored not to forget the imperative of truth, truthfulness, and plain speech, so as to make examination, analysis, and constructive critique possible for researchers, students, and others devoted to the history and destiny of the country. Without doubt, neither the prevailing outlook of this writing is beyond the need for assessment, critique, and revision, nor was the performance of eight years of responsibility devoid of misjudgments and errors. In this work, I have acknowledged numerous instances of my own cognitive and operational mistakes—undoubtedly, the examples go far beyond these. I hope that, with the keen and penetrating gaze of present and future researchers, this writing will be evaluated and its lessons tested in order to prevent the repeat and recurrence of such mistakes.

In preparation of this volume, my dear brother and esteemed colleague. Mohammad-Mehdi Raji—whose eloquent pen authored Mr. Ambassador—has held an outstanding place, for which I am deeply grateful. I have also benefited from the assistance and guidance of distinguished scholars, in particular Messrs. Seyed-Ali Mojani, Seyed Mohammad-Kazem Sajjadpour, Majid Takht-Ravanchi, Seyed Abbas Araghchi, Mehdi Danesh-Yazdi, Bagher Assadi, and Ms. Shah-Mohammadi, as well as from the images of my artist colleague Seyed-Hamid Mirdamadi. Yet the responsibility for the writings and errors rests solely and entirely with the author. May it cast no shadow upon any heart, and may it be an effort toward the brilliant future of our land, Iran.

M. Javad Zarif
25 August 2023

CHAPTER I

RETURN TO THE FOREIGN MINISTRY

The Fleeting Tenure of Retirement

In the closing days of June 2010, after several months of pursuit, the order for early retirement was received. Like a traveler who, light of burden, steps upon an unknown path, I murmured under my breath, a poem in the sweet tongue of Sa'di.

Let all the faults be said against us
O people until when?
We ourselves have thrown the cup on the stone
Do not throw stones on the cup again.
So much have we broiled in your desire,
And yet we remain uncooked.
The cure for the captive of love is patience,

Unknown is the ultimate destination.

From more than three decades of striving and endeavor, it was only that retirement order that remained as a keepsake. On the first day when I voluntarily entered the Consulate General of the Provisional Government in San Francisco, I was a second-year student of international relations, not yet nineteen years of age. At the time of retirement, at fifty-one years old, I had passed through a career of many ups and downs: volunteer at the Consulate General in San Francisco; volunteer in charge of transferring the Consulate General following the severance of Iran-U.S. relations; local employee of the Permanent Mission of Iran to the United Nations; Chargé d'Affaires of the Mission to the United Nations, still with the status of a local employee—unprecedented in diplomatic history; advisor to the Minister of Foreign Affairs and senior member of the negotiating team to end the Iran-Iraq war under United Nations Security Council Resolution 598; Ambassador and Deputy Permanent Representative of Iran to the United Nations; negotiator for the release of American hostages in Lebanon; negotiator for the report under paragraph six of Resolution 598 concerning responsibility for the imposed war; Chairman of the Legal Committee of the General Assembly of the United Nations; Deputy Foreign Minister for Legal and International Affairs; Chairman of the United Nations Disarmament Commission; Chair of the Expert Meeting and spokesperson for the Summit of Heads of State of the Organization of the Islamic Conference in Tehran; Chairman of the Political Committee of the Non-Aligned Movement Summit in Durban, South Africa; member of the Group of Eminent Persons selected by the Secretary-General of the United Nations for the Dialogue Among Civilizations; member of the Group of Eminent Persons on Global Governance; Ambassador and Permanent Representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran to the United Nations; nuclear negotiator with the three European countries; Chairman of the Cultural Commission of UNESCO; teaching, resting at home, and at last, retirement.

In those thirty years, during which my entire youth and middle age had passed, there had been little opportunity left for family. It was as though days were arriving that promised both relief from the clamor of the world and liberation from the tumult of the political arena, bringing

with them the joyful hope of serving my mother and family. Without delay, I set my course towards my mother's home. The pure image of you was always with me—within me. As Sohrab Sepehri, a great Iranian poet has said: "The air of your words carries a man through the orchard-lanes of tales." And how could I have known that this opportunity would soon turn to separation? My brief departure from the tumult of the surrounding world, and my devotion to home and to the faculty, were truly years of the descent of the Lord's grace and divine openings.

Encounters found a renewed vitality and became a fresh opportunity to cleanse the heart of all dust, and to pause in reflection upon the past days, the course of events, and the global engagements in which I had spent my precious life in examining and assessing the good and the adverse. Dialogue, consultation, research, and teaching—of which I had always been enamored—revealed, more than ever, that life amidst the complexities of the modern world requires, in addition to knowledge and mastery, a multi-dimensional act equal to that of other actors, large and small, upon the world stage. Observing the daily worries and anxieties of ordinary people, who looked upon their future with misgiving, and occasionally participating in consultative meetings regarding Iran's foreign policy, seemed to be searching out a destiny for me of which I myself was yet unaware.

Without doubt, the most cherished memory of those days was the family journeys to the holy city of Mashhad, when, twice a year, my mother would gather all the children and grandchildren as guests for two weeks in the heavenly court of the Imam of kindness. Pushing my mother's wheelchair after the dawn prayer along Imam Reza Street towards the holy shrine of the Imam was among the most beautiful moments of my life. Alas, how swiftly it became too late. My mother's life ended in the first days of the initial winter of my ministry, and the good fortune of late service to her was lost.

Bridges, Elephants, and India

In the final year of President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad's administration, it was evident that due to various developments—detailed in the first

chapter of *Raz-e Sar be Mohr*⁶—the country was rapidly approaching a phase of dialogue. In September 2012, in a report submitted alongside several colleagues to the nation's leadership, it was stated that the passage of time was not in the country's favor; for as sanctions intensified, Iran's strategic capacity did not correspondingly increase. Iran had achieved a level of nuclear capability whereby its further advancement depended on simultaneous progress across all branches of science and technology. Yet, in the interim, only sanctions were escalating. These sanctions not only exacerbated internal pressures but also stifled production and industrial growth, while impeding the advancement of other scientific drivers. Intellectual elites stood on the verge of emigration, society suffered from stagnation, and the economy's machinery risked grinding to a halt.

Meanwhile, the region and Iran's neighbors were undergoing significant transformations. Several neighboring countries were rapidly attracting foreign investments and actively planning for advancement. In contrast, Iran's strategic gains were minimal compared to what it was losing under sanctions, since nuclear weaponry was neither considered nor desired in the country's defense doctrine. Moreover, the Bushehr nuclear power plant required around 190,000 centrifuges, and the difference between having 10,000 or 20,000 centrifuges with the necessary 190,000 was negligible. For a country unwilling to enter the arena of military nuclear calculations, merely expanding facilities and equipment could not realistically provide commensurate progress. Thus, based on the authors' projections in that report, sooner or later the country would need to initiate a dialogue, weighing costs and benefits. The most intriguing revelation was learning that, unbeknownst to us at the time, those dialogues had already begun.

For this modest foreign policy researcher, who was engaged in independent study outside the government, only the metrics were visible, and I sought insight from prior diplomatic knowledge and experience. The commencement of the Muscat talks was astounding. Despite the strong opposition of Saeed Jalili and internal concerns from President Ahmadinejad, the talks had started with Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei's

⁶ Zarif, Mohammad Javad et al., *Raz-e Sar be Mohr*, Barjam; Kusheshi Setorg Baray-e Hoqouq, Amniatv a Tos'ey-e Iran (The Unsealed Secret, JCPOA; An Effort for Iran Rights, Security and Development), Tehran, Ettela'at Edition, 2021

approval and under four key conditions, based on a courageous report by then foreign minister, Dr. Ali-Akbar Salehi. What we had only conjectured in our research had already transpired within the external world of politics. At that time, our understanding was largely academic, and among diverse individuals and factions—less connected to principalist groups—this assumption was cautiously considered during consultations.

Between November 2012 and March 2013, as speculation and dialogue regarding the presidential election unfolded within the country, I occasionally shared my global assessments in various forums. Among these were the Strategic Research Center, where I served as an advisor to Mr. Hassan Rouhani, and in foreign policy meetings convened by President Mohammad Khatami concerning the country's need for dialogue and the optimal composition of negotiators. I expressed the view that the country required a diplomatic solution, and it would be preferable for those who had previously pursued policies underpinning sanctions, often built on illusions, to themselves pioneer the challenging path of dialogue and compromise. These propositions were not an evasion of difficulty or challenge; they were founded on concern for national interests. My assessment was that if these actors failed to take the initiative, and groups like ours attempted the complex task, not only would we be indebted, but the country's future would become hostage to internal political games. Individual or group sacrifices and debts were insignificant; what was crucial and worrisome was the country's future. It should not be forgotten that the ultimate outcome of any dialogue is a *quid pro quo*. If the arrangement is to sit at a table with global powers that—rightly or wrongly—hold legal and international legitimacy within the international system, and within that system, multiple Chapter VII United Nations Security Council resolutions have been adopted against Iran, the best outcome of such a dialogue will not be a one-sided, euphoric victory for Iran. I often used a popular saying among the people: "Everyone knows today that dialogue is necessary; but tomorrow, once today's challenges are resolved and we have crossed the river, some will not only destroy the bridges but also start fault-finding and reproach; the challenges will be reproduced in a new form." I frequently drew on the well-known Iranian proverb centering around "Bridges, elephants, and remembering India." Unfortunately, that

prediction was not unfounded, and ultimately, what esteemed readers know came to pass.

We Chose It Ourselves

The author's theoretical and historical interpretation of foreign policy, expressed during his tenure as minister in a live televised interview in the somewhat veiled but provocative sentence, "We chose to live this way ourselves", became a pretext for unfair attacks — and remains, to this day, the centerpiece of reproach toward me. This historical understanding of Iran's foreign policy over the past five hundred years was best articulated by Professor R.K. Ramazani. From the 1960s — when few researchers in the West considered the foreign policies of developing countries to be worthy of study, viewing them solely within the framework of great-power politics — this distinguished scholar began research, teaching, and writing on Iranian foreign policy in the United States. He left behind invaluable works, particularly *The History of Iranian Foreign Policy from the Safavid Era to the End of the First Pahlavi Reign*.

In Professor Ramazani's view, for the past five centuries Iran's foreign policy has suffered from a profound inconsistency between aspirations and capabilities. While aspirations — expressed in lofty, idealistic goals — can inspire action and progress, and when balanced and proportionate can form a strong pillar of a nation's ideational potential, goals must be shaped with an orientation toward those aspirations but grounded in actual capabilities. Regrettably, realistic approaches are not considered commendable in our Iranian political culture.

Thus, those who have acted on the basis of aspirations without regard to capabilities — even if they failed to achieve those aspirations, or worse, inflicted damage on the nation's interests and even territorial integrity — have nevertheless been celebrated as our heroes. Conversely, those who have worked within the limits of capabilities to attain national ideals or reduce damage have often been labeled as timid, compromising, or deceived. Although peace and compromise are not condemned in our religious tradition, and although in the wider world no achievement is realized without some form of compromise, and no harm is prevented

without it, in our political culture flexibility and compromise are regarded as abandonment of ideals and values and thus are censured. By contrast, intransigence, rigidity and refusal to compromise or, more plainly, insistence on aspirations is deemed admirable and praiseworthy.

It is precisely on the basis of this widespread cognitive pitfall that those who, with the noble aspiration of reclaiming Iran's lost territories after the first Iran–Russia war, initiated the subsequent war without considering the country's relative capabilities, — which resulted in the loss of significant portions of Iran's territory in the battlefield up to Qazvin — are seldom blamed for this grave historical misjudgment. Yet those who, in the Treaty of Turkmenchay, tried to minimize the loss at the negotiating table and in fact regained parts of the lost territory are to this day regarded in public opinion and school textbooks as blameworthy and even traitorous. Undoubtedly, the Treaty of Turkmenchay was highly detrimental to Iran, and the motivation to preserve the throne was prominent within it; but no one asks what process led to such a treaty, in which Iran was compelled to negotiate after defeat and exhaustion — and in which that humiliating treaty at least restored a valuable portion of territory that had been lost in the battlefield. This disregard for capabilities is also evident in our daily behavior: when stopped at a traffic light, we block the entire width of the street to make a left turn, obstructing everyone's way; or when approaching a tunnel or a road where two lanes narrow into one, we form several lanes instead, causing delays for ourselves and others. This is the same historical choice that we have made — and which we continue to make in every corner of our lives. I do not consider myself an exception, nor do I stand aloof on some ivory tower of intellectuals enamored of foreigners.

Offers to become Foreign Minister

The recognition of the historical inclination of all of us Iranians to set our goals based on aspirations instead of capabilities led the author in 2013 to propose to Mr. Khatami and Mr. Rouhani not to participate in the presidential election. Both gentlemen expected that upon winning the election, I should serve as their foreign minister and undertake the

responsibility for nuclear negotiations. My response was to request to be excused from this important task. Before the election, in February 2013, Mr. Rouhani requested that I become active and accept the responsibility of Minister of Foreign Affairs in his Administration if victorious in the election. I did not accept this proposal, which he reiterated once again in April 2013. After his election in June 2013, he insisted again, and for the third time, I apologized.

Cooperation with other candidates during the election campaign leading to nomination as their foreign minister was also proposed from mid-summer 2012 by representatives of other candidates, all of which I had declined. For example, during radio debates, a representative of one candidate declared that Zarif would be that candidate's Minister of Foreign Affairs. Such a statement caused distress to another candidate. All these gracious offers occurred at a time when no agreement existed and even meetings and talks with candidates were avoided. Motivated by the aforementioned reasons, I was not prepared to accept the responsibility and had resolved to pursue seclusion, education, and research.

Policy-making cannot be based solely on scientific findings or personal tendencies. Anyone selected as a foreign policy official—from expert to minister—must support and implement the country's politics and approach in the world, even if they do not agree with all aspects of it. No country can have multiple approaches, models, and programs for foreign policy; rather, all institutions of a country must follow a single policy in foreign relations. Ignorance of diplomatic methods and misperception of global trends, intertwined with lack of knowledge about national interests, have severe consequences on the country's major decisions. Sometimes individuals take inappropriate and uncoordinated steps whose consequences eventually fall upon foreign policy, and the Minister of Foreign Affairs, in the role of executor and national agent for the country's global ties, must support certain policies which are contrary to their own advice and judgment, in order to safeguard national interests and the collective good. Of course, during the term, in addition to honestly and frankly presenting my views during the decision-making processes, I also did my best to avoid active involvement in policies that I considered misguided.

On the other hand, the consequences of foreign policy decisions and steps affect not only more than eighty million Iranian citizens but also people worldwide. In other words, for every decision, policymakers and executors become indebted to billions of human beings; decisions such as closing the nuclear dossier, ties with neighbors, participation in a process, turning away or neglecting an event, and other examples, because with one decision, the work does not end; consequences will arise that can affect the fate of large groups of human beings. Sometimes, consensus is reached on a policy, but due to internal or external constraints, it cannot be selected. Other times, the right decision is taken, but an external element, from inside or outside the country, enters the scene and disrupts the decision-making system. Conditions may occur where taking or not taking a step affects not only one person but millions or even hundreds of millions of people, causes harm, and—God forbid—at its highest level, may cause the destruction and annihilation of humanity and nature.

The culmination of these concerns made accepting such responsibility truly difficult from a moral perspective as well as foresight. During those hard decision days, one of the elders made a thoughtful observation that refusing responsibility might also lead to loss of human lives. If you can save a few lives and refuse to accept responsibility, someday you must answer for that difficult decision with equal hardship. This statement left a deep impact on the final decision to accept the ministry.

The initial avoidance of responsibility was not out of desire for personal comfort, and the final acceptance was not accompanied by enthusiasm, but what eventually led to acceptance was the relentless insistence of my family. After several rounds of President Rouhani's insistence to accept the MFA, I proposed a list of qualified individuals, but he rejected all the suggested candidates and insisted that I myself must accept. After that meeting, I returned home, my refuge and place of peace. Sharing the story with my family had an unexpected result. Contrary to their usual approach and attitude to avoid responsibility, my wife and children reminded me of the pains, worries, and sufferings of the people and said that the people had hope, came to the streets, and celebrated. Their hope was based on the belief that the nuclear challenge and sanctions would be resolved. Therefore, anyone who had gained the great asset of these

people's trust must step forward when needed and spend that asset for them. These words were expressed so sincerely that they removed my resistance and left no way to escape. Nevertheless, I entered this path with a deep conviction that this was not the road to becoming a hero but rather to sacrifice everything.

After a day or two, President Rouhani happily announced that the Leader, with minimal questioning, approved my selection as Minister of Foreign Affairs, although reaching consensus on some other candidates was not easy. Many elders from both political currents insisted on my acceptance of the MFA responsibility. At the Center for Strategic Research (CSR), weekly meetings of the Foreign Policy Committee were held regularly under the exemplary management of Mahmoud Vaezi, a friend of many decades since student days in the United States. After President Rouhani's election, drafting the foreign policy program of the 11th Administration was placed on this group's agenda. At that time, I was aware that I was President Rouhani's choice for the MFA. However, other members believed that the Minister of Foreign Affairs would be Mr. Vaezi. Interestingly, Mr. Vaezi was also the first name on my list of suggested candidates to President Rouhani.

At that time, alongside other friends in the Foreign Policy Committee, we began reviewing the foreign relations program, and the friends entrusted the writing of the program to me. The theoretical background of the foreign policy program was group research on the transitioning world carried out in 2009–2010 commissioned by Kamal Kharrazi for the Strategic Council on Foreign Relations. The outcome of that research was published in a book by the MFA in 2016.

Other than writing the foreign policy program, and separate from the Foreign Policy Committee, I also undertook drafting a proposed solution for the nuclear challenge, at President Rouhani's request, although at the beginning I was unaware of the nuclear talks held in Muscat; I learned of them mid-way and had to align my proposal with that background. That proposal is recounted in later sections of this book.

When President Rouhani's decision regarding the candidate for Foreign Minister was finalized, he informed Mr. Vaezi of the decision and offered him the Ministry of Communications. From the moment Mr. Vaezi heard

the decision, with magnanimity and brotherhood, he provided all facilities and assistance. My friendship with Mr. Vaezi dates back to when we were both students in the United States and active in the Muslim Student Association. Student activism under the previous regime was costly for all of us. Therefore, we learned how to cooperate in sharing costs. During our cooperation on the Council of Deputy Ministers under Ministers Ali Akbar Velayati and Kamal Kharrazi and also in President Rouhani's Administration of which we never lost the value inherent in our long-standing friendship. This family friendship has continued to this day, including beyond the end of that Administration.

Preparation for Parliament

Following the President's nomination, the drafting of the confirmation testimony before the parliament became the first order of business. At the same time, we had to engage in consultations with members of Parliament. With the assistance of the Deputy Foreign Minister for Legislative Affairs, a series of meetings with MPs were organized. I was not well acquainted with the political inclinations of most of them, but conversations were held prior to the vote of confidence with many including those who, during my ministerial tenure, repeatedly insulted me.

The confirmation testimony before the parliament was of great strategic significance, for it had to clearly convey the new administration's approach to foreign policy not only to the members of Parliament, but also to the Iranian people and the international community. We therefore resolved to select every word and expression with the utmost care and precision and ultimately decided that the speech would be delivered from a prepared text. After several days of work on an excellent draft that had been prepared by a group of colleagues, the confirmation speech was delivered on 13 August 2013. That address became the basis for a written piece published in *Foreign Affairs*—perhaps the first time that the writings of an official of the Islamic Republic appeared in that journal, a leading platform for foreign policy discourse in the United States and indeed the world.

The speech began with the following statement: "Brothers and sisters, the Islamic Republic of Iran is powerful; believe in Iran's power." At the

outset, I articulated my view on the foundation and pillars of the country's strength as follows:

The broad participation of the people in the elections and their endorsement of the President's approach sends a clear message to the world. This message reflects the determination of the great people of Iran to engage with the world in a dignified manner—without the slightest concession on Iran's inalienable rights—based on the principles of dignity, wisdom, and expediency, so that the interests of the nation and the objectives of the system are safeguarded, both in ideational as well as material realms—which, in my view, are inherently aligned. In recent years, hegemonic powers have imposed unjust sanctions and pressures upon the people of Iran. Yet despite these irrational pressures, the people, through vigilance and self-confidence, and by strengthening national solidarity in the recent elections, have guaranteed the independence and dignity of Iran.

I then referred to another dimension of the nation's ideational potential, setting out my perspective on the concept of power:

Respect for democracy in line with Divine values, adherence to the will and rights of the people, and observance of Islamic and ethical principles can present a model of effective and good governance in Islamic countries... This is the genuine and authentic essence of the discourse of the Islamic Revolution, and it is the legacy of the late Imam Khomeini—may his soul rest in peace—that, within the ideational and semantic structure of today's transitional world, has endowed the Islamic Republic with a unique, indigenous, and undeniable power at the regional level and beyond. We must believe in this unparalleled power—believe in it not merely in words, but in deeds—and with this self-confidence, we must engage actively, constructively, and effectively in the international arena.

In the statement, I also touched upon the country's regional role in confronting extremism, stating: "Iran's participation in political processes in an unstable, yet strategic region, will be a fundamental factor in preventing war, violence, and extremism." At the same time,

I stressed the necessity of contributing to the well-being of the people: “Iran’s political and strategic power and position can—and must—serve the cause of comprehensive, purposeful progress, sustainable economic development, and the improvement of welfare and livelihoods for the noble people of Iran, who are the benefactors of us all.”

After addressing these theoretical foundations, I elaborated on the policy of moderation in foreign affairs, which is “based on realism, self-confidence, and self-awareness, with the aim of fostering mutual understanding and trust so as to enhance the nation’s capacity, power, security, and development.” I further reiterated my long-held belief that “moderation is the product of self-belief and confidence; extremism is the manifest expression of weakness and fear.”

Alongside this view, I articulated the value of a realistic idealism, emphasizing that “the ideals, interests, and national security of the Islamic Republic are inseparable, and they constitute our principal, indivisible objectives. Dialogue and competition, coupled with prudence, consistent pursuit of programs, and the building of mutual trust, are essential instruments of this policy.”

Throughout the speech, targeted messages for the world were interwoven, such as the following:

- Trust is mutual. Trust cannot be one-sided. The world must earn the trust of our great people.
- The goal of foreign policy is the dignified, self-confident, and prudent defense of the nation’s interests and welfare—articulated in a persuasive language, and conducted with composure, wisdom, and foresight.
- The Administration, with confidence in its own power, is prepared to compel other actors on the global stage to transform their hostile relations and conduct into fair relations grounded in mutual trust and cooperation.

Then, turning to the complexities of global trends, I stated that “foreign policy is the domain of national interests and national security, and it must not be subjected to factional infightings.” I went on to state clearly and candidly that I would not refrain from expressing my views:

Foreign policy is the realm of foresight, patience, and resolve; it must remain untouched by daily emotions and costly assertions.

In the field of foreign policy, the sphere of implementation must be distinguished from that of analysis. In the realm of analysis, I consider it my duty—along with my colleagues—to act as an honest sentinel, conveying to the authorities, and above all to the Leader, a complete, objective and frank assessment of regional and global situation along with challenges and opportunities for the country. In this responsibility, with the help of Almighty, we shall employ the entirety of our professional capacity and analytical strength, presenting our assessments in full honesty and good faith, without fear of negative publicity, intimidation, or rejection. In the realm of implementation, however, the diplomatic apparatus regards itself as bound to carry out the decisions that, after passing through the decision-making process of the highest bodies of the system, are communicated to us. In this sphere, we shall mobilize all our expert capacity to pursue these decisions to the highest possible standard and to achieve the best attainable outcome—whether or not they align with our own views or analyses—for the country must have only one foreign policy.

In another section of the speech, I referred to the pillars of foreign policy, and, reiterating my academic perspective on a world in transition, once again made clear my views of the foundations and pillars of the nation's strength:

Among the most complex causes of this transformation is the transformation in the very concept of power. The shift from an emphasis on military power toward other emerging dimensions of power—the growing prominence of cultural, ideational, normative, discursive, and asymmetric characteristics, and the increasing focus on economic power, scientific and technological capacity, the ability to have global agency, and the capacity to build consensus—have been a defining feature of this change. As a result, unprecedented space has opened for actors such as the Islamic Republic. Theories such as the “end of history” and the “clash of civilizations,” alongside political efforts to intensify Islamophobia and Iranophobia, reflect apprehension about precisely this power of the Islamic Republic of Iran. If we are to advance in the very domains that most concern

our rivals, we must place emphasis on these very dimensions of the Islamic Republic's power, and align the nation's diplomacy in their service.

In another part of the speech, I challenged the view held by many scholars and researchers who deem only the actions of great powers in the international community to be worthy of study and scholarly attention, stating:

In this era, Iran itself is one of the principal sources and subjects in shaping the global order. Given the reality that non-military sources of power—especially inspirational and persuasive capacity and effective discourse—hold prominent places in shaping the future structure of international relations, the Islamic Republic of Iran enjoys a distinguished standing in global affairs, particularly in the normative, ethical, and value-based domains.

The theoretical perspective on global relations in a transitional period was then made explicit:

Zero-sum games have lost their place in international relations. Although many governments still seek to advance their interests and objectives at the expense of other actors, those who persist in a zero-sum or win–lose approach ultimately impose lose–lose conditions upon themselves and others.

Alongside these opportunities, the many challenges facing the nation were also candidly and frankly acknowledged, and the foundational principles of the MFA's program were presented to the representatives in the following terms:

- Constructive and effective engagement based on interaction and dialogue from a position of equal footing, mutual respect and benefit, reduction of hostilities, reciprocal de-escalation, and mutual trust-building;
- Operational and targeted planning to neutralize the U.S.–Zionist project of promoting Islamophobia and Iranophobia, and the global securitization of the Islamic Republic of Iran;

- Placing foreign policy in the service of the country's sustainable development and the welfare of the people;
- De-escalation, reconstruction, and reform of interactions with influential transnational powers in line with the national interest;
- Normalization and improvement of relations with regional countries, particularly neighboring states;
- Reconstruction of relations with traditional partners in Europe and Asia;
- Gradual and prudent resolution of the nuclear dossier while safeguarding the nation's rights;
- Management, reduction, and removal of transnational, multilateral, and unilateral sanctions;
- Theoretical and diplomatic challenge to unilateralism and the global domination-based structures;
- Constructive influence on global developments, particularly in combating terrorism and extremism and preventing the proliferation of weapons of mass destruction;
- Reviving and strengthening Iran's inspirational role through articulating the vision of Islamic-based democracy;
- Enhancing Iran's international image, restoring its credibility and identity, and supporting the individual and collective rights of Iranians abroad;
- Promoting Iranian culture and civilization;
- Utilizing religious and cultural capacities to develop and deepen the identity of authentic Islam;
- Defending Muslims and oppressed nations—especially the people of Palestine—on the basis of the Constitution, political wisdom, and national interest, and preventing the penetration and entrenchment of the Zionist regime in the region, in Islamic countries, and in transnational institutions;
- Restoring the role of the MFA in the cycle of policy formulation, decision-making, and policy implementation, and ensuring programmatic integration and coherence in the management of foreign policy; and
- Making calculated, programmatic, coordinated, and effective use of bilateral, multilateral, public, economic, cultural, parliamentary,

defense, security, and informal diplomacy in pursuit of the country's development and security objectives.

At the conclusion of the speech, I responded to certain personal criticisms made by members of Parliament. One representative had stated: "Among them, Mr. Zarif is an exception—he thinks one hundred percent like the West, studied in the United States, and allow me to say with whom he did his master's and doctoral dissertations." The gentleman in question meant Henry Kissinger—though, of course, out of ignorance, for Kissinger had no role whatsoever in my education. Accordingly, I replied to that representative:

I am well aware of whom you are referring to. But you have been given incorrect information. The gentleman you mention was never my teacher. But, for heaven's sake, is it so shameful for an eighty-year-old, seasoned statesman to call a forty-something son of the Revolution a "respectable adversary"? What would you have preferred him to say to please you? Moreover, I do not know how many seconds this honorable representative has ever spent in my company, or from which of my writings, actions, political record, beliefs, or family background he has concluded that I think not eighty percent, not ninety percent, but one hundred percent like the West! What can I say! "Do not pursue that of which you have no knowledge; indeed, the hearing, the sight, and the heart—about all those [faculties] one will be questioned." [Qur'an, 17:36]

The Cabinet

For someone who is becoming a minister for the first time, membership in the Cabinet is exciting. Before formally nominating the members of Cabinet for confirmation by the Parliament, President Rouhani invited all ministerial candidates to a meeting at his office at the Center for Strategic Research. So, when we met officially in the Cabinet chamber, it was the second time we were meeting. Before that, I had never been to the Cabinet chamber. When I was deputy minister, I frequently went to the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council; I also participated in meetings of the Supreme National Security Council held in the President's Office

building. But I had never been to the Cabinet chamber, which is in the building of the First Vice President. I think it is customary that no other meetings take place in the Cabinet chamber, and only Cabinet meetings are held there. At least, during the years I was in the Administration, that was the case. Therefore, that chamber was new to me.

The seating arrangement was alphabetical; of course, in the 12th Administration, there were some changes; at one point, some Vice Presidents sat forward, and some sat further back. In the 12th Administration, after three Vice Presidents, the Minister of Intelligence would sit; then the Minister of Foreign Affairs and the Minister of Education. In the Cabinet, initially, the order was alphabetical; on my right side sat the late Vice President and head of the Martyrs Foundation Mr. Shahidi, and next to him the Minister of Economic Affairs and Finance. On my left side sat the Minister of Health. Vice Presidents would sit wherever they wanted. In the 11th Administration, the Central Bank Governor was one who sat at the head of the table; but in the 12th Administration, the Central Bank Governor sat after the Minister of Economy and the Minister of Communications. The Chief of Staff of the President influences this arrangement. He decides the seating arrangement.

At the first meeting of the 11th Administration, all Cabinet members stood and read and signed a written pledge. This signed copy was framed and given to the Cabinet members. The most notable point of that meeting was this Cabinet pledge, which was not repeated in the 12th Administration.

More or less, I knew most Cabinet members, either as former deputy ministers or as former ministers like Bijan Zangeneh (Minister of Petroleum), Mahmoud Hojjati (Minister of Agriculture), Mohammad Reza Nemat-Zadeh (Minister of Industry, Mine and Trade), and Mohammad Shariatmadari (Vice President for Executive Affairs). Mr. Vaezi (Minister of Telecommunication) was an old friend; I had also known Ms. Masoumeh Ebtekar (Vice President and Head of Environment Protection Agency) for years. I had known Ms. Aminzadeh, (Vice President for Legal Affairs) as a colleague at the Faculty of Law of University of Tehran. I did not know one or two people, among them Hassan Qazizadeh Hashemi, the Minister of Health. However, we sat next to each other in Cabinet meetings and later became very close, a friendship that still continues.

I also did not know Ali Tayebnia (Minister of Economy and Finance), but I soon became close to him as well. Interestingly, the three of us were born in 1960 and of the same age. At that time, we were the three youngest Cabinet members after Sorena Sattari (Vice President for Science and Technology). We were 54 years old, but the average age of the Administration was much higher. However, in the 12th Administration, I became one of the old men of the Administration.

The Cabinet meetings are designed mainly for ministers dealing with economic issues and are not very attractive for other ministers. There are a few ministers who do not intervene much in Cabinet discussions: the Minister of Foreign Affairs, Minister of Intelligence, Minister of Culture and Islamic Guidance, Minister of Science, and to some extent, the Minister of Education. The Vice President for Science and Technology, the Vice President and head of Atomic Energy Organization, the Vice President for Women's Affairs, the Minister of Defense, and the Minister of Interior also have similar status. However, since the Ministry of Defense has many economic activities, factories, and industries, the minister participates in some meetings. Likewise, the Minister of Interior, because of his internal and provincial responsibilities, involves himself in many cases. Cabinet discussions are mostly executive and economic, not political, except for the first part of Cabinet meetings, which is the news section where the most significant events are reported. In that section, perhaps the person who spoke most in the Administration was the Minister of Foreign Affairs, because foreign policy and nuclear negotiations were central to the Administration and took up a good part of most Cabinet meetings.

In more than seven hundred meetings during the eleventh and 12th Administrations, few cases related to the MFA or the aforementioned ministries arose, except in exceptional cases. For example, when the MFA wanted to import official cars or sell property abroad. But other agencies always have matters that were discussed and decided upon in Cabinet meetings. Therefore, these ministers run the Cabinet: Minister of Economy and Finance, Minister of Petroleum, Minister of Roads and Urban Development, Minister of Welfare and Social Security, Minister of Industry, Mine and Trade, and the head of the Plan and Budget Organization. Most Cabinet discussions occur among them, and there may be several Cabinet

meetings without any word from the Minister of Science or Minister of Culture and Islamic Guidance. The Minister of Foreign Affairs or Minister of Intelligence's position is somewhat different because they always have some news to report at each meeting. Except for the news section, I mostly remained silent in the cabinet meetings. Some brought their bureaucratic papers to the meetings and reviewed and signed them during that time. But since the MFA's documents were all electronic, I could not check papers during Cabinet sessions, so I mostly listened and tried to learn—though I must honestly admit that those meetings were not that instructive.

The government is responsible for running the country, so it has an extensive executive mechanism, which seems unavoidable. For example, if education was discussed at some meetings, it was not the educational policies of the Ministry of Education but executive issues such as virtual education during the COVID-19 pandemic and other administrative challenges. Most policy discussions take place outside the Cabinet and in relevant councils. Military-security files are reviewed in the Supreme National Security Council (SNSC), where some Cabinet members such as the Ministers of Foreign Affairs, Interior, Intelligence, Defense, and the head of the Plan and Budget Organization participate. Military commanders also attend, so major security and military decisions are made there. Major cultural and educational policies are examined by the Supreme Cultural Revolution Council, with the participation of Vice Presidents for Women and Science and Technology, and ministers of Culture, Education, Higher Education, and Health, along with non-state individuals involved in those matters. The Supreme Cyberspace Council has a similar status. These supreme councils are inter-agency and set policies and sometimes engage in operations and execution. However, policy execution is in theory handled by the executive branch.

Although the Cabinet had two four-hours meetings every week, there was still shortage of time. Various commissions also exist alongside the Cabinet. The MFA is only a member of the Cabinet's political commission. Since the Minister of Foreign Affairs is usually out of the country, most often a Deputy Minister participates in the political commission. Although only ministers can attend the Cabinet meetings, deputies were permitted to attend the commissions.

Foreign policy had a very central role in the 11th Administration. Within the first ninety days, we reached the Geneva interim agreement, or the Joint Plan of Action. In other words, the MFA was the Administration's pride and received much attention. Other Cabinet members somewhat supported the MFA, while organizational rivalries always existed. For example, very few helped the MFA in the Cabinet debate on budget allocation. But in fairness, the Plan and Budget Organization supported the MFA as much as was financially possible during the 11th Administration.

Meanwhile, the MFA was targeted before other ministries. The attacks began with the early Geneva talks and intensified after the interim agreement. Especially after winter 2013, when comprehensive talks began, attacks on foreign policy increased considerably. It seemed Cabinet members wanted to benefit from nuclear talks but were not prepared to share the pressure. Therefore, my complaints in the Cabinet about unfair criticism by the media and state TV were not enthusiastically received by colleagues, and some even criticized us for reporting them. One minister always said, "Why do you anger the president?" I reminded my colleagues a couple of times that if the attacks against the MFA continue, they will spread to the whole Administration. However, other ministers showed little sympathy in this matter. Some said, "Just as you gain popularity, this is your fate; let a few insults be thrown at you." This impression has remained with me from those meetings. But my concern was not personal; it was national interest. If such a bipolarity forms in the country, it would surely never end and would involve others. Unfortunately, in the 11th Administration, not only was there no support for this concern, but sometimes confrontation was seen. Therefore, after the first year, although the pressure increased greatly, I reduced the reporting of this pressure in the Cabinet. Gradually, other ministers also began to complain as they faced similar difficulties. In the second Rouhani Administration, dissatisfaction with politically motivated attacks was widely expressed within the Cabinet.

The 2017 Election

Now that the internal Cabinet relations and the dynamics between ministers and within the Cabinet have been discussed, it seems appropriate to pay attention to another point: the re-election campaign of President Rouhani. At that time, the Administration's achievements at the end of its first four-year term were mostly recognized in foreign policy; and the accomplishments of foreign policy and the MFA were leveraged during the election. Some colleagues expected the Foreign Minister to be actively involved in the electoral campaign. Such an expectation, however, did not align with the professional tradition and practice of the MFA. I had remained on the sidelines during the first presidential election, and therefore, it would not have been prudent to choose a different approach for the twelfth election—especially since that election turned out to be more difficult than expected.

On the other hand, as a Cabinet member, the Foreign Minister was expected to fulfill certain roles. One was to defend the foreign policy achievements of the first Rouhani Administration; which, of course, was not inappropriate. If in debates or in the campaigns of other candidates, there were criticisms of a ministry's performance or of the president's handling of certain issues related to a ministry, it was the organizational duty of that ministry to defend its record and achievements. From this perspective, such advocacy was not an electoral action per se but a part of the government's work and a natural defense of its services—necessary both for enlightening the domestic public and informing the global audience. Some of the criticisms raised amid the media uproar surrounding the presidency harmed the entire nation.

The presence of foreign policy in the electoral campaign was a key challenge. Foreign policy issues had become prominent in that election period. Due to the openings created by foreign policy, the country had experienced an economic growth of over 10 percent during the period 2016–2017, which seemed remarkable. Also, for the first time, inflation dropped below 10 percent. The combined effect of these two achievements increased hope and social capital. Many observers believe that the rise in hope during those years lowered inflation expectations, and this psychological factor itself helped the economic situation. These indicators were among the

topics that President Rouhani and others used in presidential debates and campaign ads, and they were generally accepted by the public; thus, this was not an unnatural stance.

The next question concerned the personal presence of the Foreign Minister in programs that could be considered electoral campaigning. I never wanted to enter that arena because I always believed that foreign policy should be above partisan currents and should be regarded as a national matter. For this reason, I only appeared once in a campaign event. On a Wednesday evening after a Cabinet meeting, I took an official leave and traveled to Isfahan. I always paid the cost of my personal travels. But to be legally on the safe side, for this trip I even paid the depreciation costs of vehicles and the travel expenses of my security detail. On Thursday morning, the president gave an election speech at the historic Naqsh-e Jahan Square in Isfahan. As a courtesy, I accompanied him. Early Friday morning, I left Isfahan for Karaj (a city just outside Tehran), to participate in the groundbreaking ceremony of the first nuclear hospital in Iran alongside Vice President Salehi (the head of Iranian Atomic Energy Organization), the Austrian ambassador, and a delegation from Austria that was helping in the technology for that hospital. The trip to Isfahan was a very short trip during which personal and official matters were intertwined.

Many election campaign events had been planned for me, such as a program in the 12,000-seat Azadi Stadium. Although Mr. Rouhani's campaign manager was upset, I apologized. But at a meeting with artists in Vahdat Hall, I accompanied Mr. Zangeneh (the Minister of Petroleum). That gathering was mostly to hear the voices of the culture and art community, but in that atmosphere, it also took on an electoral tone. I was quite reluctant to participate in such activities. This caused many complaints—not from Mr. Rouhani himself but from some colleagues—with the implication: "Remember, you did not put in enough effort."

Many considered me the sole candidate for the MFA in Mr. Rouhani's second Administration. Some even messaged that if other candidates became president, there was a possibility they might also request me to stay. But I did not think much about it. Perhaps I was one of the last people Mr. Rouhani spoke to regarding their participation in his second Administration. This delay in contact and meeting created hope that maybe

he had another candidate in mind, which would be an opportunity to try a new approach. The JCPOA negotiations had been concluded, and the duty which I was thought best suited to perform had been accomplished. Therefore, there was no need for a second term as minister.

I was invited to see the president in the final days of Mr. Rouhani's discussions with possible ministerial candidates. Although I had no desire for the responsibility, the only condition I put forward to Mr. Rouhani was that the dignity of the MFA must be preserved. He agreed, though such conditions are rarely realistic or enforceable.

The vote of confidence session was not very exciting. The first round four years earlier was a new challenge; but in the second round, I tried more to support other ministers—especially those who were new. Contrary to claims that the tenth parliament was a "JCPOA parliament," the number of positive votes in the tenth parliament was not greater than in the ninth. We faced very difficult tasks. Trump had come to power, and we had no choice but to confront much tougher conditions. It was foreseeable that the MFA would be under intense internal and external pressure during this period.

CHAPTER II

FOREIGN MINISTRY

A Look from Within

From Parliament to MFA

Setting about working at the MFA required formulating a conceptual foreign policy framework, a solution to the nuclear issue as well as a befitting management of affairs. Naturally, expectations were high from the MFA of the Rouhani Administration. In his election campaign, President Rouhani had underlined the necessity to overcome external challenges. Faced with such big task was the first Iranian Foreign Minister after the revolution who had a PhD and taught for three decades in this field, had gone through the ministerial hierarchy from an embassy staffer to ambassador and deputy minister, and spent his entire civil service at the MFA. In addition to that background that had increased expectations, the conceptual presentation of foreign policy in my confirmation speech to the parliament had given cause for fresh assessments. Therefore, in the

first step, it was necessary to develop an intellectual and organizational foundation to work smoothly together and facilitate achievement of objectives through their convergence.

As a graduate of international relations, who had studied and taught classical IR literature, with more than three decades of action in global relations, I believed from the very beginning of my responsibility that the foreign minister should not be a mere mobile bibliography of theories of international relations and follow them to the letter. Foreign relations have never followed theoretical constructs carved in stone; rather, they represent a roller coaster which, after you step in it, you must roll up and down with it while trying to steer it towards national objective. Therefore, I have never been dogmatic when it comes to conceptual theorizing. I have always believed that theory is a cognitive tool, not an ideology. I never strive to remember which theorist has said what or in which article or manuscript. Although I studied and taught theory and tried to maintain a dynamic theoretical framework for myself, I do not believe that one should always be constrained by atheoretical framework--often borrowed from others or copied from somewhere.

I favor free thinking, dynamism and transformationalism in theory and vision, having accordingly encouraged my colleagues and students to follow suit and present their views and analyses regardless of the views of their superiors or professors. While vehemently defending my views, I never act with prejudice and revise my views in case they conflict with facts. Therefore, I feel compelled to regularly have dialogue with thinkers of different inclinations and views and veteran actors and avoid groupthink. Regular weekly meetings like the strategic meetings that were held every Tuesday at the Institute for Political and International Studies (IPIS) with academics and veteran diplomats of various intellectual and political persuasion in attendance profoundly contributed to the development of thought and pragmatic transformation of discussions. I hope that I never considered myself not needing advice and consultation.

Some of my colleagues at the MFA had a different view about me, accusing me of dogmatism and neglecting expert views; I hope they were wrong. Such impressions may have been caused due to the realities of the process of decision-making. In many cases, despite having defended

MFA experts' opinions, I was obligated to comply with the outcome of the decision-making process which was not controlled by the MFA, and I was duty-bound to communicate decisions adopted in spite of MFA and my own views to my colleagues in the ministry and even justify them.

Since July 1982 when in parallel with beginning my PhD at Colombia University I joined the Permanent Mission of the Islamic Republic of Iran to the United Nations, I had to deal with the Iraqi war against Iran (1980-1988), and other international developments and regional disputes that were handled in the corridors of the United Nations more than any other place in the world. Definitely, the way the Iraqi imposed war ended, and the background of Iran-Iraq negotiations had left a permanent imprint on my mindset. I can never forget about the modalities and timing of the acceptance of Resolution 598. Nor can I erase off my mind the shameful response of the U.S. Secretary of State George Shultz to the UN when Secretary-General Javier Pérez de Cuéllar, when Shultz proposed to him to postpone the Iran-Iraq ceasefire for three months after Iran agreed to implement the resolution 598 in July 1988. In my negotiations for implementing paragraph 6 of Resolution 598, I saw with my own eyes how the Americans reneged on their pledges and evaded their obligations. George Bush Sr. had said "goodwill begets goodwill", based on which the Iranian government helped secure the release of American hostages in Lebanon. But in the final days, the Americans claimed they could not reciprocate. It would take ages to discuss the numerous instances of American refusal to live-up to their promises.

I was also involved in the events revolving around the 1991 Iraqi invasion of Kuwait and Saddam Hussein's miscalculations before his aggression, the dominant emotional atmosphere in Iran and the wise decision of President Akbar Hashemi Rafsanjani during that critical period. In the course of nuclear talks under President Khatami, I served as the senior negotiator and involved in the details of that episode. When the Bosnian War broke out in 1992, I served as a member of the Contact Group as well as the Assistance Mobilization Group (AMG) at the Organization of Islamic Conference, the forerunner to the current Organization of Islamic Cooperation (OIC). These experiences gave me a firsthand look at the consequences of the miscalculations of various actors particularly during

the transitional period in the global system and I deeply felt how a simple miscalculation may push a country to devastation.

Those experiences and my presence in these events brought me closer to the mechanism and foundations of power in international relations. I learned through participation and observation Europe's functioning and the US's decision-making process. For one year (autumn 1992 to autumn 1993), I presided over the 47th session of the UN General Assembly's Legal Committee (also known as the Sixth Committee), during which I could see with my own eyes that allies do not necessarily support one another on all fronts. That gave me a firsthand look at the limits of alliances and the concept of issue coalitions.

I had already studied such models. I had also studied and taught international regimes; however, when chairing the Sixth Committee, I saw in practice how a Europe-Latin America-Africa coalition took shape against the US and countries like Iran and China in the discussion about the establishment of the International Criminal Court (ICC). Or another issue, coalition that was formed to request an advisory opinion from the ICJ about the US arrest of a Mexican drug trafficker – all of them being incompatible with the prevailing alliances. It may sound risible to see an Iranian ambassador, chairing the Committee, mediated between the US and its allies – an image unacceptable for policymakers in Washington and incomprehensible for policymakers in Tehran.

These are all my impressions of the developments that occurred at the high level of global policymaking and not merely at the national level. Such experiences obtained by me and other veterans of diplomacy and complemented by the theoretical knowledge of prominent academics contributed to a project sponsored by the Strategic Council of Foreign Relations (SCFR) during nearly 40 brainstorming sessions, held in 2009 and 2010. During those instructive sessions, the most prominent professors of international relations with long experience in thinking, research and writing spent long hours generously alongside us. The conclusion of those talks was drawn up in a 38-page report. Even if it is referred to now, it becomes clear how we had managed in 2010 to predict forthcoming global developments. Most of our forecasts turned out to be true, particularly about international issues. Throughout these deep and long discussions,

we realized how Iranian thinking and concerns is absent in international relations. It became clear that strict compliance with a theoretical vision and converting theory to ideology would prove detrimental. Sanctifying theories of international relations should be avoided, particularly because all of them are imported and all of them pursue specific interests.

My foreign policy vision is produced by a combination of continuous learning, diplomatic activity, deep assessment of political facts and involvement in Iran's experiences in various cases. Iran has no option but to be assertive in global affairs – and its decisions cannot be solely based on prevailing theories. Therefore, theoretical understanding, participation in decision-making and execution of decisions and direct experience in multilateral diplomacy have driven me to a different framework.

With such background, along with friends and advisors, we concluded that the most outstanding objective of the MFA should be to break the global securitization consensus against Iran, which had culminated in UN Security Council resolutions and in eliminating Iran from regional and global networks. On the other hand, a development-oriented vision of foreign relations—at least removing foreign barriers to development—was an undeniable need. These two priorities were paramount in my agenda as foreign minister and I highlighted them in unambiguous terms in my confirmation speech to the parliament. With this vision, I started vetting my colleagues for senior positions in the MFA.

Remembering the Past

When I took over as foreign minister, I found the MFA totally different from what I was used to in the 1990s and early 2000s. Under President Mahmoud Ahmadinejad (2005-2013-), the MFA and more broadly Iran's foreign policy experienced major changes. Although my relations with his Ministers of Foreign Affairs – Mr. Manouchehr Mottaki and Dr. Ali Akbar Salehi – were respectful, I had been estranged from the MFA for eight years. I had remained as Iran's UN ambassador during the first two years of Mr. Ahmadinejad although he and I were both reluctant. As soon as Mr. Ahmadinejad was elected president, I had asked Ayatollah Khamenei to relieve me from that office, but he had disagreed. Mr. Ahmadinejad

also insisted on my dismissal to the extent that in our first meeting, his advisor asked me when my mission would end. During the first weeks after Ahmadinejad's election, I came to Tehran to attend my daughter's wedding. President Ahmadinejad was set to travel to New York to attend the UN General Assembly, which was going to host many heads of state and government. I had to arrange the details with him. In August 2005, I met the president-elect in the former building of the parliament; a meeting which did not start or end pleasantly.

On the first night of his arrival in New York, the newly elected president had asked Dr. Ali Larijani and Mr. Mottaki to dismiss me and name one of my colleagues at the Permanent Mission, who was a graduate of Imam Sadeq University, as caretaker. Mr. Larijani had apparently told the President that the Leader would have the final say on this issue. As soon as he was back in Tehran, President Ahmadinejad asked the Leader to sack me, but he refused. The Leader asked President Ahmadinejad to nominate a successor to be vetted. Nonetheless, despite the President's insistence, the Leader said in summer 2006: Zarif should remain in office.

For two years under Mr. Ahmadinejad, I remained as ambassador to the UN, but I was marginalized in foreign policy decision-making. I was the chief nuclear negotiator before Mr. Ahmadinejad was elected, but under his presidency, I had been dismissed as negotiator. We in the Mission were assigned no task, nor did we receive any report about nuclear talks while Iran's nuclear case was being referred to the UN Security Council. The disconnect between Tehran and the Permanent Mission in New York was such that we were even unaware of Mr. Ahmadinejad's letter to President Bush. I read it in the news. I contacted the First Deputy Foreign Minister, an old friend and colleague, requesting to receive a copy of the letter. I was told that the letter had been handed over to the Swiss Ambassador in Tehran in a sealed envelope to be sent to Washington and that he was not authorized to open the envelope. I told them the envelope would never be sent to Washington. It was 6 or 7am in New York. I said at 8:30, the Swiss ambassador would contact Washington which would ask him to open the envelope and send the letter by coded fax. That occurred. At about 10 am, Condoleezza Rice spoke about the letter. About 1pm, John Bolton—my U.N. counterpart—commented on the letter. I cabled

a sarcastic message to Tehran, asking if I should ask Bolton to give me a copy of the letter. Even then I received no response. At 3pm, I received the letter from a veteran journalist of The New York Times, who was serving as chief of bureau in Paris. The receipt of letter from Paris meant many had already got the letter while I was kept in the dark.

The Ahmadinejad Administration's estrangement with its UN ambassador, who is the most senior member of the ministry after the minister, was regrettably very deep. In some countries like the US, ambassador to the UN is a member of the cabinet. I was sidelined in foreign diplomacy despite the significance of this post in foreign policy. When I arrived from New York in 2007, I asked the then Minister of Foreign Affairs to allow me to simply teach at the School of International Relations (SIR) and the Minister promised to help. Unfortunately, the Ministry of Science, Research and Technology refused to cooperate. Meanwhile, the MFA had been instructed by the Leader's office to appoint me to a senior position, but—thankfully—it had fallen on deaf ears. I was appointed as chief assistant to the Minister of Foreign Affairs without receiving the pay grade. Finally, in 2010, after two decades of holding senior positions at the MFA, I retired with a meagre expert pension.

All Ministers of Foreign Affairs, from Mr. Ali Akbar Velayati and Mr. Kamal Kharrazi to Mr. Mottaki and Mr. Salehi, were highly kind to me, but I was never recognized as an MFA insider. In early 1980s, my appointment as a local staffer at the Permanent Mission in New York was rejected. Even after my appointment was approved, despite being close to obtaining a PhD with two master's degrees, my salary was lower than that of a local chauffeur who had just a high school diploma.

When I went back to Iran in 1988, I was named advisor to Minister of Foreign Affairs for negotiations associated with Resolution 598. But a "graduate of American" universities was not tolerated. The Minister's instruction to the then director-general of consular affairs to issue a diplomatic passport for me was refused. The passport was finally issued and signed by the First Deputy Minister.

The "Smiling Lips and Bleeding Heart" was denied his basic legal rights when serving as deputy minister, ambassador and even minister. In a bid to spare any accusation of influence-peddling, I refused to intervene even

in order to prevent bureaucratic injustice against me, negatively affecting the welfare of my family. For example, pursuant to MFA regulations, I was qualified to be a career ambassador, as endorsed by the then minister Mr. Kharrazi. However, some administrative staffers decided to file the Minister's decree to deny me that status and its pay scale.

Another case I am still grappling with was my transfer to the University of Tehran. In full disregard of a long-standing national legislation that would guarantee my transfer with full professor salary, the letter of transfer sent by my own ministry recognized me as assistant professor after nearly three decades of teaching—which even without that law would have qualified me for professorial rank. The negative financial consequences of that injustice shall remain with me until the end of my service and even after retirement from university. I swallowed all of this in order to avoid any accusation, little knowing that my detractors would never fail to raise trumped-up charges.

Back to MFA

In 2013, during the period starting from the time I was nominated for foreign minister until I obtained vote of confidence from parliament, MFA officials were very cooperative. They presented me with very helpful reports about the latest developments pertaining to foreign relations and the Muscat talks. That had been ordered directly by Minister Salehi. All friends showed maximum cooperation and empathy.

I returned to the MFA building on August 17, 2013, after a 6-year hiatus. I did not feel like a stranger, but rarely could I find a familiar face. Many senior officials had been given early retirement, as was the case with me. I regret that I could not bring most of them back to the MFA. They were major assets whom we lost. Some of them had been isolated entirely. That was exactly one of the reasons I had filed for early retirement. On paper, I was senior assistant to Minister of Foreign Affairs, but in practice, I was assigned nothing. That is why I decided to retire.

Nonetheless, I have never said I received an MFA in ruins. MFA experts are the diplomatic assets for the country. Efforts had been made to give a spin to the MFA at that time, not by Mr. Ahmadinejad's ministers, but

by others whose legacy remains until today. However, upon my return to the MFA, I did not intend to settle my scores.

An inauguration ceremony was held for me. The outgoing minister Salehi had been appointed director of the Atomic Energy Organization of Iran (AEOI). Mr. Salehi was very welcoming. Then we went to the Mirror Hall (Talar-e Ayeneh: the official reception area of the foreign ministry) where a group of senior and junior MFA officials were in attendance. What was intriguing there was the colorful environment. The halls there had been adorned with color, painting and offerings varying from pen to goldwork. The gypsum work in the halls had been painted crimson, green and blue. What I saw after six years of absence was not in my view in line with the original internal architecture of those grand halls. That was not appropriate for the headquarters of a foreign ministry.

One of my first steps at the MFA was to redesign and redecorate those grand halls back to their original internal architecture. Everything matters in foreign policy. A diplomat or non-Iranian entering an Iranian building should be captivated by our architecture, culture and civilization. That is a key point which is often ignored. Therefore, during the first months in office, reconstruction and rearrangement of official meeting and reception halls was pursued under the supervision of cultural heritage experts.

The inauguration was held with President Rouhani in attendance. The MFA was among rare organizations where the President attended in person for inauguration that would have otherwise been handled by Es'haq Jahangiri, the first Vice President, or Mohammad Nahavandian, the Chief of Staff. It became a memorable event. Mr. Salehi confused the words "inauguration" and "farewell", which brought smile to the lips of all participants. That marked the beginning of my work at the MFA.

One of the first steps was to meet with the outgoing deputy foreign ministers. Some of them had joined the MFA from outside and they were not interested in continuing to work. Each MFA official was offered a new post. Some were offered ambassadorial nominations while one or two were not offered any senior position for various professional reasons. Four or five MFA officials had set up a cabal along with some officials from the Office of President Ahmadinejad to manipulatively run the MFA. That cabal had to be broken, which was done with full respect. It must

be noted that some supporters of the new Administration were unhappy with my approach of dealing respectfully with former officials instead of purge and vengeance.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs serves the state rather than any political faction and is not guided by partisan considerations. Therefore, it had to be administered by experts without any factional or personal persuasion. MFA officials should not be purged because of personal or political affiliations, be it those who had been promoted based on the established standards and procedures of foreign ministry civil service or those who had got promotion without going through the procedure. All MFA officials have gained valuable experience—paid for by government—and such experience should not be wasted for merely personal and political differences.

In the meantime, the world had to see that the Rouhani Administration's approach was different from the previous administration. On the one hand, the experience and incumbent expertise had to be preserved while on the other, the world should not have thought the same approach would go on. This point was taken into consideration in appointing new deputy ministers.

My three decades of experience, ranging from a local embassy staffer to ambassador and deputy minister, had proved that the Office of Deputy Foreign Minister for Administration and Finance is the pulse of the MFA. The Administrative and Finance Division has its own specific organizational culture. Although prominent and committed experts are in this division, it functions bureaucratically like a closed group, unfriendly to those considered outsiders.

I had two options. One option was to pick a deputy minister from within this division. That would be prudent bureaucratically; however, the decades-old dominance of bureaucracy on diplomacy would continue. The second option was to name an experienced and competent diplomat from outside the administrative and financial structure. The second option was adopted, which faced tough resistance. As minister, I hoped to end the dominance of logistics over diplomacy. However, I failed; realities overcame aspirations and I paid a heavy price for my aspiration and audacity.

The MFA bureaucracy is not much different from other organs and thus allergic to change. Or maybe they have learnt from experience that such transformations would not lead to any improvement. Therefore, the Administrative and Finance Division experienced minimal improvement that I aspired to and, coincidentally, our MFA colleagues have been most critical of my record in this sector. In my capacity as minister, I came to have firsthand experience of the *modus operandi* of the bureaucracy. They would tell an employee that their request would be fulfilled only if the Minister gave a simple instruction to the bureaucracy to do it. At the same time, in a report to the Minister, they underlined the legal obstacles, explaining that such work is illegal unless “Your Excellency orders otherwise”. It meant that any intervention by the Minister would have personal legal consequences. Yet the requesters were intentionally kept in the darks about those consequences. That was when I realized that some of my own judgments about my predecessors had not been fair.

It may be appropriate to highlight the first directive I issued on the first or second day of my responsibility as the Minister. The Minister is referred to in internal ministry correspondences as “the Supreme Minister”. This is customary in most Iranian ministries. I never liked this title which I had never used in correspondence with my predecessors. Another bad tradition that was deeply rooted was that when Iranian ambassadors travelled to Iran, they brought expensive gifts for the minister, which had been paid for either by the ambassador or more often from the official budget of the embassy.

In my first directive, I imposed a ban on this tradition. Although during my eight-year tenure as Minister, rarely did I use imperative verbs, I made it clear in the directive that using the “Supreme Minister” title and offering gifts to the minister would be illegal in any form whatsoever. My colleagues were asked to use simply “Minister of Foreign Affairs” or at the very most “Esteemed Minister of Foreign Affairs”. During my eight-year term in office, some colleagues insisted on using “Supreme Minister” and presented me with gifts. First, I gave them notice. If repeated, I declined their gifts unless I was assured that the gifts were not expensive and had been purchased on their personal accounts.

MFA Staff Remuneration

As noted before, the MFA is an organization comprising competent and educated staff. In recent years top graduates of disciplines needed at the MFA are chosen through national exams like national university entrance exam. Such method was uncommon in the past. In the wake of the 1979 Islamic Revolution, many MFA experts had been purged—correctly or incorrectly—or had quit. As a result, individuals who firmly believed in the Islamic Revolution had been hired regardless of their professional qualifications just to fill the vacancies.

Nonetheless, over the past two decades, the most competent applicants were chosen for vacancies. Of course, I do not mean they were the best of the elite. Certainly, there are more competent individuals, but they are either not interested in government jobs or do not meet the MFA employment regulations—imposed by longstanding national legislation. Doubtlessly, they are qualified to express their views about foreign policy, criticize Iran's foreign policy and offer proposals. However, taking other factors into consideration, like requirements in terms of profession, beliefs and performance, the staff hired in recent years at the MFA are among the best. The School of International Relations (SIR)—Ministry's in-house graduate school—has managed to train the most competent graduates. A basic indicator is the high number of SIR graduates who are admitted to top universities for PhD, even though universities usually prefer to take their own students. That shows the quality of MFA human capital.

Despite such positive points, the MFA is confronted with serious financial challenges to the extent that it was among the poorest state organs. In 2013, the average salary of MFA staff was lower than the national average for civil servants. That means that an average diplomat would face financial difficulties in everyday life. Furthermore, unlike other organs, MFA staff are not authorized to hold any other job in their spare time. An engineer working for technical ministries can have an office or engineering company to work in their spare time. Except for a small group of very senior officials—like ministers and deputy ministers, all other civil servants have a second job associated with their own specialties. But MFA staff are banned from a second job which is considered as jeopardizing national security. The salaries and benefits of similar agencies, including

Ministry of Intelligence, are much higher than those of their foreign ministry counterparts.

The low salary of MFA staff creates another problem; that is an unhealthy competition to be posted outside the country. MFA employees need to be posted abroad in order to meet their basic financial requirements. That gives rise to an inappropriate culture in the agency, which is first and foremost a culture of extreme timidity and submission to superiors caused primarily by a constant preoccupation with being posted abroad. Such culture destroys personal motivation and downgrades intellectual dynamism and practical vitality to the lowest level.

That culture constitutes the fundamental shortcoming and challenge of the MFA. There is no fault with the MFA staff's competence; rather, the problem lies with the structure that has failed to provide minimum remuneration for the MFA staff. Various administrations have not shown sufficient sympathy with the MFA because of widespread misperception that MFA staff are a group of well-dressed people living in luxury, who spend half of their lives walking in Champs-Élysées. This misperception existed under all administrations. Government organs have always envied the MFA, which explains why rarely any bill aiming to improve the remuneration of MFA employees has been passed by any Cabinet. One of the toughest jobs during my eight-year tenure was to improve the living conditions of MFA staff in Tehran. The staff who are stationed abroad receive salaries that are much lower than their counterparts from other developing countries. However, compared with those stationed in the capital, even that meager salary can help diplomats make ends meet. But this salary was revised down in 2020 due to budget crunch in the country following imposition of sanctions and outbreak of the covid-19 pandemic, which elicited dissatisfaction from our colleagues.

We had several rounds of pay raises for staff in both diplomatic and administrative divisions. That may sound easy in words, but it was hard considering the above-mentioned prevailing view. Despite all these challenges, the hidden objective of sending MFA staff abroad was to enable them to make ends meet more than advancing national priorities. And that remains a fundamental challenge at the MFA.

Families of Diplomats

The first victims of sending MFA staff abroad are their own children as they would face disruptions and difficulties in their education. One may say that applies to diplomats everywhere in the world. That is not true. First, other countries do not have our religious and cultural considerations. Second, the possibilities provided by other countries to the children of their diplomats go beyond our imagination. Even less developed nations pay for the education of their diplomats' children to study at Harvard University, where tuition fees amount to \$60,000 per year. No Iranian diplomat can pay such fees. Therefore, MFA staff's children, except for a minority, do not make significant progress.

That scourge applies to children of MFA staff going through a normal procedure of foreign posting. For instance, when someone is admitted to the MFA, he is sent on mission to an African nation by the time his child is about 7 years old. But four years later, they are back in Tehran, and their 11-year-old child is faced with a new environment. Two years later, they are sent to an Asian or European country. This would have negative impacts on the schoolchildren. Families also feel lonely and homesick due to our religious limitations. Women wearing hijab may be mistreated in the streets. That is why I always insisted to my colleagues to give their families highest priority when they are abroad, be it in terms of schooling of their children or spending time with their family and being empathic and considerate of emotions.

On mission, the ambassador acts as the father of diplomats stationed in his mission. A father is required to bring colleagues together. But in practice, professional tasks bring about preoccupations that would leave our colleagues, be they ambassadors or other staff, no time to think about their social and family issues. Because of such challenge, willingly or unwillingly diplomats' spouses would suffer many psychological problems, varying from depression to absorption in the host society. Mission staffers, albeit exhausted with work, deal with compatriots, but their spouses who stay at home feel lonely and are prone to outside impacts. Homesickness, loneliness and depression, absorption by the host society, development of certain overdependence on TV are among scourges striking families of diplomats, which would give rise to damaging consequences.

That is why I always warned our colleagues both in Tehran and abroad not to stay in the office more than required. I suggested that they go home as soon as their administrative hours end and stay with their family. They were expected to spend their time in the office working and not chatting with one another. Those living abroad, in a bid to avoid homesickness, spend a lot of time in the office chatting with colleagues, thereby wasting valuable time. This makes them work overtime to fulfil their tasks. But in fact, if they make correct planning, they can carry out their duties during official hours and then have time with their families. With current advanced communications tools, it is possible for them to even work from home, if need be, because attention to families living abroad is very instrumental⁷.

The diplomats' spouses are important assets in all countries; a value that we have rarely appreciated. When Minister Velayati's wife was alive, the wives of top diplomats in Iran were engaged in group social activities, mainly philanthropic work. They, in collaboration with the wives of foreign diplomats stationed in Tehran, established charity foundations, visited and helped rehabilitation centers, and visited various Iranian institutions, leaving a positive image of Iranian cultural and industrial capabilities with spouses of foreign diplomats in Tehran.

Foreign ambassadors stationed in Tehran are socially engaged and interact mainly with individuals and families who are not sympathetic to the Islamic Republic negatively, giving a one-sided image of Iran to them and through them their governments and societies. That is why communications between the spouses of senior MFA officials with spouses of foreign diplomats in Tehran can to some extent make up for this shortcoming.

Under the Rouhani Administration, efforts undertaken by the spouses of senior diplomats, under my wife's supervision, expanded, turning into a noteworthy project. In addition to group visits to cultural and social monuments and industrial achievements as well as contribution to holding charity events, thanks to my wife's background in mysticism and her excellent command of English, a new chapter opened in bonds

⁷ O believers! Protect yourselves and your families from fire. (The Quran, 66:6)

with the spouses of ambassadors. For ten years, she was instructed by the late Haj Esmail Doulabi—a highly respected Iranian wiseman—whose vision and foresight has left a lasting impression on our family through my wife. Furthermore, familiarity with the holy Quran and Rumi's poetry and broad knowledge of mystic literature from across the world had made my wife's lectures attractive to every Iranian and non-Iranian listener.

During my tenure as ambassador to the UN, she had found many friends and even followers among wives of ambassadors and socialites in New York. She was regularly invited to make keynote speeches in exclusive social clubs in New York. She is still being invited to such events, but she refuses to attend. After I became minister, her lectures were held regularly on a weekly basis with the ambassadors' spouses who attended enthusiastically. After my ministerial term ended, the lectures ended despite the persistent requests of ambassadors' wives.

Gender Bias

At many institutions, particularly the MFA, phallocracy has always prevailed, thereby preventing our female colleagues at the MFA from advancing and exhibiting their capabilities. That is while many of us, when teaching at university, have seen that female students have fared better than their male counterparts. Some say with sarcasm that women get better scores because they have no other preoccupation. But the fact dismisses such hypothesis. We have seen that mothers with family or professional preoccupations have been pursuing education seriously and showing initiative and innovation. That is a national asset which should not be overshadowed by gender bias.

On the other hand, due to Islamophobia and Iranophobia, the Islamic Republic has been misrepresented to the world. The world ignores the fact that women constitute an active segment of Iranian society. Such perception may be modified through a wider engagement of female diplomats in negotiations and missions. In North European nations, I was asked on several occasions why we do not have female colleagues. They were wrong—as we do have capable women diplomats, but the fact is that despite having highly efficient diplomats and qualified female

university graduates, the MFA has not benefited from their capabilities on the global scene. Of course, no fake behavior should be adopted, like what some Arab nations do. For instance, before Mohammed bin Salman came to power, Saudi Arabia hired female staff only for propaganda. At international fora, quite opposite to strict domestic restrictions, women showed up in diplomatic fora in Western attire.

Iran does not need such fabricated symbols. In our country, we have committed and highly capable women to represent Iranian women abroad; women who not only symbolize their own professional status, but also indicate the lofty standing of a woman who is the foundation of family, a competent mother, wife and a very capable diplomat. These qualifications do not contradict one another because phallocracy has no base in Islamic values and teachings. Therefore, in a bid to counter this misogynous view, the MFA sought to benefit from the potential of efficacious women. Although hiring women at some positions had started under former administrations, this view became more outstanding during my tenure. It was a hard job due to tough resistance.

I regret to say that some male colleagues stonewalled women's progress and, in some cases, used inappropriate language. There is a tight rivalry at the MFA for management positions and foreign postings. Unlike other agencies, the MFA has a low number of senior positions. When a woman is appointed at the head of a division or sent abroad, some male colleagues feel they have lost an opportunity and cause some difficulties. Men need to develop a more balanced and realistic view.

Even based on male-dominated criteria inherited from the past, women can make progress at the MFA. However, since women's employment at the MFA and their promotion had been treated for many years with a narrow-minded, selective and even discriminatory perspective, the MFA's promotion mechanism had to be reviewed in this regard.

It would be no remedy to merely assert that from now on we will tackle the issue with an open mind. Within the framework of the MFA Statute, it would take 15 years to acquire the prerequisites for even the lowest managerial position. That timeframe is suitable for normal circumstances, because 15 years of experience would provide a new director with the necessary expertise to shoulder heavy responsibility. However, this would

be a bottleneck for women. Therefore, we tried our best to facilitate the procedure for women. For instance, before qualifying to become an ambassador, one had to go through all diplomatic ranks up to the level of minister counsellor. For women, that requirement was eased and having reached the level first secretary sufficed, although all women who were nominated by me and appointed as ambassadors by President Rouhani were in fact minister counsellors. But given the government policy and instructions from the Cabinet and Administrative and Employment Affairs Organization, we benefited from a legal possibility to allow women fulfilling two-thirds of those requirements to be named to such tasks.

During the Rouhani administration, four women from inside and one from outside the foreign ministry were named ambassadors. All four career diplomats were senior MFA officials: Ms. Marzieh Afkham, deputy minister and spokesperson; Ms. Forouzandeh Vadiati, director-general for women and human rights affairs; Ms. Afsaneh Nadipour, assistant to minister for citizens' rights; and Ms. Zahra Ershadi, director-general for women and human rights affairs. They were named ambassadors to Malaysia, Finland, Denmark and the UN (ambassador and deputy permanent representative) respectively.

Another measure that was carried out during my tenure was to nominate ambassadors of Sunni faith. The MFA did not have an appropriate senior official of Sunni denomination. Therefore, owing to his brilliant background, Saleh Adibi, academic and director of Kurdistan Province Elites Foundation, was named ambassador to Vietnam. He was born in Sanandaj and was among few ambassadors to serve for more than four years. The second Sunni ambassador was Ms. Homeira Rigi from Iranian Sistan and Baluchistan province. She had already held key posts in Sistan and Baluchistan Province, serving as a senior official in provincial Interior and Health departments. During her tenure as a city administrator in her native province, she had left behind a brilliant legacy. Ms. Rigi was named ambassador to Brunei, with a remarkable track record.

It should be noted here that appointing women as diplomats in Iranian missions abroad is much more challenging than naming men. The most important challenge is the profession of their husbands. In some cases, the wives of our colleagues who were sent abroad were university professors

or medical doctors. But they left with their husband after taking unpaid leave because based on the MFA regulations, diplomats should be with their spouses. That issue becomes more important for women due to phallocratic views. Perceptions and views are such that a female diplomat's husband becomes jobless. But that is not necessarily the case all the time. A scientist can boost his or her knowledge anywhere or conduct research. One may also choose to undergo training or learn new skills.

Economic conditions require many women to work too. Therefore, when they must leave with their husbands, they quit or even lose their jobs. That causes trouble mainly for our younger colleagues whose wives are mostly civil servants or schoolteachers. When they leave Iran, they distance themselves from the profession they exercised in Iran. Now, when a woman is set to go on mission, this challenge becomes more difficult. MFA diplomats, male or female, know quite well they should win their spouses' consent for foreign postings. In some cases, women may disagree with their husbands' departure on mission as they would have to quit their job.

The Role of Diplomatic Experts

In my capacity as Minister, my expectations from experts were much greater than what had been the case before. That might be wrongly interpreted as toughness, but the fact is that I had already served as an MFA expert and even as Minister, I continued to consider myself as an expert. In addition to my ministerial responsibilities, I carried out the normal duties of an expert such as drafting and editing reports. Of course, I concede that a minister doing expert duties is not the best management practice; but sometimes that was unavoidable.

At the MFA, some tasks were not fulfilled perfectly. A parallel lean structure was proposed so that important tasks would be carried out by a small group of elite diplomats, unconstrained by the cumbersome bureaucratic structure. The same practice had been in place under certain special circumstances in the past. But I resisted undermining and circumventing the entire organization as I believed that the existing organization and expertise should be preserved by improving structures

and procedures. In improving the MFA organizational structure, which would be explained in detail later, we tried our best to make best use of the MFA staff and experts. Everything did not go as planned. Some claim that the ministry—with almost 4000 staff of which nearly 2500 are diplomats—is too big, but if we really want to carry out all our tasks, we would be short of experts. But the problem is that nothing goes as planned.

Our colleagues can carry out expert work, but they lack necessary motivation, as seen in most reports. To write down a letter, report or article, I spend long hours. I revise my text regularly and immerse myself in. That is time-consuming and I may even forget about time. For instance, after performing my morning prayers, I start reading and writing. Suddenly I remember that I have a meeting, and I am getting late. Due to my own experience, it was easy for me to distinguish a copied text from an original one. Therefore, we brought our colleagues together and we held a training course for writing expert reports, including policy papers.

The weakness of experts in writing policy papers can be partly blamed on their superiors. As soon as most experts become directors, they stop reading and writing as experts and dump everything upon their subordinates. A competent director should not do everything alone either; rather they should try to improve the abilities of their subordinates. Enhancement of expertise depends on two conditions: First, the director should offer guidance to colleagues before assigning them the job; second, she/he should review the product carefully, make necessary changes and inform experts of their shortcomings or missteps. There should be a constant exchange between directors and their expert subordinates. At the MFA in the past, there were directors unfamiliar with their own job. Our current directors have already served as experts and therefore have good knowledge and experience of issues. They might not be fluent in English or Arabic, but they have already been experts and reached the senior positions gradually. They have been writing reports for many years before reaching their current position. That shows their good knowledge of every aspect of the job. But some of them turn into rubber stamps: assigning duties to their subordinate, who in turn do the same until the task reaches the newest expert in the department; and signing off the product in the same manner. Therefore, instead of management and

guidance, we witness serial assignments of tasks from up to down and reverse. The directors simply push a keyboard or mouse sending down duties and signing products often without even taking time to read them.

That is why after consultation with the Council of Deputy Ministers, one structural modification was to reduce layers of management. These layers were such high in number that managers did nothing but assign tasks to others and then only attended meetings. These managers did not have even time to read anything and train their experts.

The workflow at the MFA should be such that when the Minister assigns something to a Deputy Minister, the latter should instruct the Director-General of the Division about how to go ahead. Then, the Director-General should detail the task to Director of the Division before being finally assigned to an expert. That means that an instruction should become more precise after passing each stage while when something moves from down to top, it should become more optimal at each phase until it reaches the final station. But that did not occur at the MFA. The Minister received reports and letters with rudimentary grammatical and even spelling errors. The chain of officials who had signed off on the product had not even bothered to review the letter or report to correct grammatical and spelling mistakes, let alone improve the content of the expert analysis or policy paper. That was very painful. That is when I confronted my colleagues harshly and frankly.

On some occasions, I had to give harsh warnings to my colleagues for their negligence. Some criticized me for not tolerating views of colleagues, but that is not true. I personally think that I was more than patient and when my patience ran thin, I showed harsh reaction. I exercised restraint and hid my discontent. Sometimes I told my close aides to warn a colleague that the minister's patient was running thin.

Words and diplomacy are intertwined. Scrutinizing the content of a report, contract or letter is a necessity of our profession. In diplomacy, it is of high value to choose the correct and precise word and adopt the appropriate language. We always tried our best to remind our colleagues and if need be, train them on how to prepare a proper policy paper in which well calibrated words would be used. It is not clear to what extent such negligence in collocation and methods of expression constitutes a

cultural challenge; but it is a must for everyone who deals with politics and diplomacy.

The following parallels would better clarify the dilemma: An engineer develops a building or a car. A construction project is a combination of electricity, water and gas. A physician's output is to help a patient recover. Now what is the output of a diplomat? It is his/her words, be it verbal or in writing. A diplomat writes down a report for his superior, converses with his foreign counterpart, and produces documents. They are all in words. What else does a diplomat do? A diplomat neither engages in violence nor designs a building. Nor is he/she a healer. A diplomat just produces words about views and visions, which would be expressed and recorded with appropriate tools.

When a diplomat does not show sufficient precision in producing his words in the form of report, speech, letter, negotiations and documents and fails to reflect adequately on them, he does nothing. The best way to evaluate a diplomat is to focus on his words and writings. Certainly, a diplomat should be attired appropriately and have good manners, but that is a prelude to higher efficiency in words and not a substitute for the latter. When someone wears a beautiful suit but proves to have no understanding and knowledge when speaking, it would be of no value and can even backfire.

Policy Paper

Policy papers were briefly referred to earlier. Insisting on producing policy papers by all experts was based on two fundamentals: first, the imperative of having a framework and procedure for MFA outputs. As it was said earlier, the MFA output is its words, manifesting in various forms. The MFA occupies an outstanding and pivotal position through reporting and presentations when it comes to decision-making and implementation of decisions. However, when it comes to taking decisions particularly about fateful cases, only a portion of the process is rested with the MFA. Therefore, producing a thoughtful, comprehensive and insightful policy paper for higher authorities would be instrumental in optimal decision-

taking. The second imperative is the necessity to tackle and remedy the common challenge of all organizations.

Most people work for their personal advancement; some for worldly profits and believers for other worldly rewards. In every organization in any country, employees and experts work for personal or bureaucratic advancement. Bureaucratic benefits finally benefit employees and experts. Therefore, in an organization like the MFA whose product in terms of policymaking and execution is just words, experts, without having any clearly designed framework, take advantage of words for their own advancement. That means when they know which policy or course of action their superiors support or dislike, they would prepare their reports in line with the policy preference of their superiors, with the aim of pleasing them and getting promotion. This is so, because as human beings, most superiors welcome reports matching their own views and disfavor reports not compliant with their opinions.

That also constitutes a challenge for the positivist view of humanities. In data selection, researchers tend to pick data compatible with their views and set aside conflicting data. That may occur unwittingly. Researchers offer arguments for their selective approach: they may claim that the sidelined data is distorted or colonial or designed to strike fear.

In reports drawn up at the MFA and other organizations, policy papers that aim to study circumstances and suggest solutions along with cost-benefit analysis give way to advocacy papers that propose a single solution with its advantages. The result of such procedure would be autocracy or corruption. In other words, when an expert sanctifies his/her boss's view out of sycophancy, such behavior ends in autocracy. Bureaucratic decision-making theories show that employees adjust their views with their superiors' opinions in a bid to make personal progress within the hierarchy of the organization. They would write and say whatever their superiors would like to read or hear. In this way, the views are adjusted and censored at each level. When the report reaches the final decision-maker, he/she will find that the report validates his/her views and preferences. In this manner, employees often end up endorsing their superiors' views. This bureaucratic caveat in the Rational Actor Model in decision-making literature would result in the confirmation of the superior's views, no

matter how wrong they may be. Coupled with the principle of self-fulfilling prophecies, this process will only create a vicious cycle where predictions by highest decision-makers are realized and their views—right or wrong—repeatedly reaffirmed by their expert subordinates⁸.

Therefore, when the starting policy is incorrect, a vicious cycle takes shape, and no policy improvement will ever happen. That would be just a policy endorsement that repeats itself. If a policy is right, it does not receive good feedback and does not improve and if a policy is wrong, it will continue until it ends in disaster. Therefore, a policy continues without any improvement and modification and without knowing if it was right or wrong.

Another consequence of this erroneous bureaucratic policy is rent-seeking and corruption. When the expert is corrupt, and the issue is not vital for the hierarchy, the expert will suggest a policy and invent advantages for it to be beneficial for him/herself. That profiteering might be political, commercial or cultural. That would end in political and economic rake-off whereas if the expert is tasked with a standardized procedure, requiring the expert to present a variety of policy options, he/she will not get entangled in bureaucratic decision-making to please the boss nor prepare the ground for rent-seeking because single choice solutions are not an option. Not only the MFA, but also the entire bureaucratic system should profoundly deal with this challenge. In the Islamic Republic, the decision-making mechanism needs the most fundamental reform.

With the same theoretical background and professional experience, from university classrooms to MFA management, I have always encouraged intellectual independence alongside documented and reasoned opposition to my views as professor and superior. Nearly a year and a half after taking over as minister, I decided to develop a framework for the written products of the MFA, which we called it “Policy Paper”. Every expert had to draw up

⁸ To better understand self-fulfilling prophecies, imagine the majority shareholder of a factory, who concludes even based on wrong data that his factory is no longer competitive and will go bankrupt soon. Relying on such prophecies, he would start selling his shares. Other shareholders will follow suit and offer their own shares for sale. The result of this decision that is based only on the majority shareholder's prophecy is growing offering of shares on the market, which would slash prices and bring about bankruptcy. I have explained it in a brief TEDx talk in Persian available on <https://www.aparat.com/v/hHJdz>.

policy paper(s) with regard to case(s) within the purview of their official duties. Depending on the importance of the issue for the country, this policy paper was to be reviewed and implemented under the supervision of director, director-general, deputy minister, minister or even higher authorities like the Cabinet, Supreme National Security Council or even the Leader. Finally, the MFA or another organ would be tasked with its implementation. The philosophy behind this method is to shed light on the question, explain its value, present various approaches for answering the question, predict expected achievements, losses, challenges and opportunities of each approach, consequences, method of implementation and modalities of evaluation for the expert and decision-making authority.

After hours-long meetings, the following framework of policy paper was decided for all MFA diplomatic experts.

- Introduction and Statement of Problem
 - Background
 - International Value
 - Value for the Islamic Republic of Iran
 - Central Challenges to Foreign Policy
- Explaining Objectives and Policies of Main Actors
- The Islamic Republic of Iran's Objectives
 - Short-Term
 - Mid-Term
 - Long-Term
- Assessment of Opportunities and Obstacles to Achieving Goals
 - Opportunities
 - Internal Barriers to Objectives
 - External Barriers to Objectives
- Planning at Least 3 Diverse Options and Examining All Options
 - Strengths
 - Weaknesses
 - Internal Standing
 - Global Standing
- Proposed Strategy for the Islamic Republic of Iran
 - Reasons for Choice
 - Methods of Optimization

- Expected Consequences
- Predicting Diverse Possibilities and Making Necessary Planning
- Minister of Foreign Affairs' Notification of Strategy
- Adoption of Action Plan for Strategy Implementation by Relevant

Director-General

- Studying Various Methods of Implementation of Strategy
- Drawing Up Action Plan Based on Facts and Capabilities
- Phasing Action Plan
- Predicting Expected Results at Each Phase
- Time Estimate for Completing Each Phase
- Defining and Breaking Down Tasks by Determining Results and

Necessary Timing

- Breaking Down Tasks of MFA and Other Agencies
- Notifying Tasks to Other Agencies
- Agreement on Method of Information, Evaluation and Arrangement

with Relevant Agencies

- Determining Level and Method of Applying Semi-Official and

Unofficial Diplomacy

- MFA Task Breakdown

** Expert's Tasks

** Director's Tasks

** MFA Officials' Tasks

** Diplomatic Missions' Tasks

- Determining and Notifying Results Expected After Each Step
- Determining and Notifying Necessary Time for Completion of

Assigned Tasks

- Monthly Reporting and Evaluation by Executor of Steps in

Fulfilling Tasks Assigned Thereto

- Listing Steps Taken
- Executor's Evaluation of Success in Achieving Results within

Set Timeframe

- Presenting Results of Failures
- Evaluating the Impact of Global Transformations on Achieving

Determined Objectives

- Evaluating the Impact of Internal Factors

- Presenting Proposal About Output Enhancement and Dealing with Transformations and New Conditions

- Evaluation and Revision of Action Plan Every Three Months by Relevant Director-General

- Measuring Level of Success in Achieving Objectives of Action Plan

- Measuring Level of Success of Semi-Official and Unofficial Diplomacy

- Determining Reasons for Failure and Share of Each Reason

- ** Executor's Inefficiency

- ** Internal Misarrangement

- ** Incompatibility Between Action Plan, Objectives and Timeframe

with Facts

- ** Incompatibility of Strategy with Facts

- ** Sudden and Unpredictable Change in Internal or Global Conditions

- Planning Methods to Improve Implementation of Action Plan

- Modifying and Revising Action Plan, If Need Be, Within the

Framework of Devised Strategy

- Proposing Modifications or Changes in Strategy If Need Be

- Presenting Annual Conclusion About Level of Progress and

Problems of Action Plan and Strategy by Relevant Director-General

- Annual Evaluation, Revision, Completion or Modification of Foreign Policy Strategies by Strategic Council

- Determining Common Problems

- Presenting Solutions to Common Problems

- Revising Strategies in Case Common Problems Are Unresolvable

- Studying Methods of Benefiting from Success in One Case in

Other Cases

- Revising and Modifying Strategies, If Need Be, for Sharing Experiences and Harmonizing with Latest Transformations

Regrettably, due to the reluctance of a large number of senior officials and experts to implement the plan and my own failure to insist on the implementation of the plan, the project did not prove successful at the MFA. However, for fundamental optimization and rebuilding the decision-making apparatus and procedures in the country, attention to such details of bureaucratic conduct and culture is much more fundamental than the policy options that are proposed based on mere aspirations and

illusions rather than realities and capabilities. The failure of this project might also be blamed on my own vacillation between aspirations and capabilities. In other words, we had aspirations for the MFA that did not match bureaucratic realities. On the other hand, island optimization is tough, if not impossible, in Iran's administrative system. As Persian poet Sa'di said:

A thousand strivings did I undertake to veil the secret of Love's flame,
Yet over the fire, it was not granted that I might not boil and proclaim.
To wander forth on desert ways is better than to idly stay,
For though my hopes remain unreached, I'll strive as best I may.

Pensioners

Every organization is required to retire its staff after a specific length of service to bring new blood ensuring renovation. It would be wrong to stock manpower so that a specific group would be always superior and another group always inferior. The MFA was a case in point. Those who entered as senior officials remained on the top until retirement, moving between senior positions at home and ambassadorial assignments abroad. In the aftermath of the Islamic Revolution, as veteran diplomats and experts quit the MFA, a large group comprising persons in their 20s joined the MFA only on the grounds of their connection with new revolutionary leaders and activists. These novices were immediately appointed as ambassadors or chargé d'affaires across the globe. After returning from mission, they were appointed as directors-general in various sections of the ministry. Then, they were appointed intermittently as ambassadors and directors-general. The departure of such forces did not inflict too much of a loss on the MFA although they thought otherwise themselves and they did not like to retire.

Nobody is willing to retire at the MFA. The MFA's pay in Iranian currency is very low to the extent that experts and even officials face financial strains after retirement. They no longer receive benefits they did during foreign postings and thus have no option for making ends meet. Mindful of low pension, they feel they are close to premature death as they approach the

age of retirement. During my tenure, MFA employees saw significant pay rise, but their pay was still below the average of other state agencies.

During retirement, MFA staff are not authorized to engage in any related field. At best they may have a capital to finance property development or step into the capital market; otherwise, they will run into financial difficulties. This is why major efforts were undertaken to send retirees to semi-official research centers to conduct research and produce options with a view to benefiting from their experience. It was appropriate to give back whatever they had learnt through trial and error over the years in the form of policy advice for the benefit of the entire nation. Alas, a variety of pretexts blocked these attempts; the Administration and Parliament's lack of cooperation with the MFA along with internal and external bureaucracy stonewalled our efforts.

A similar structure exists at the Ministry of Intelligence where a deputy minister is tasked with following up on pensioners' affairs. Certainly, Intelligence Ministry retirees are not allowed to have intelligence activity anywhere else. They need to work for the Ministry of Intelligence. The same problem exists for MFA retirees. But the MFA does not enjoy the same standing as the Ministry of Intelligence. I proposed to the pensioners to take the initiative themselves. I had experienced retirement, and I knew how they felt. A senior official who was routinely picked up by a chauffeur and had an office and secretary until retirement is now out of job; just like a retired ambassador who takes the backseat of a car but there is no driver. That creates a tough psychological situation for that person. A pensioner without an alternative profession would have a tough life. For all these reasons, diplomats show resistance to retirement.

New Recruits

A new strategy was needed to recruit capable young professionals at the MFA. During my 10-year tenure as deputy minister, five-year term as ambassador and eight years as foreign minister, I never peddled influence to bring anyone to the MFA. We decided that every recruit should be based on merit and in line with the MFA Statute—officially known as the Employment, Finance and Discipline Regulations of the Ministry of

Foreign Affairs⁹, particularly its article 5¹⁰. Second, in order to recruit the best young professionals at the MFA, article 20¹¹ was applied. Article 20 allows individuals with doctorate degrees or vast experience to enter the MFA under preferential conditions. For instance, they may be above 30—the age limit for new recruits, they are not required to take the entrance exam, nor are they required to undergo initial training. They may be hired at higher diplomatic ranks—for instance instead of starting as attaché, they can begin as first secretary. A person aged 39 or 40 who holds a PhD and has authored works could not be asked to start with an apprenticeship or attaché, because he would be a second secretary at the age of 60. Experienced individuals would never accept such humiliating conditions. In this regard, article 20 of the MFA Statute is extremely useful. Some have said that article 20 served as a pretext to let like-minded recruits into the MFA. But a review of the records indicates that even a single person has not been recommended by the minister, citing article 20. During my tenure, a handful entered the MFA under article 20. Few others tried but failed. Under my two terms as Minister, less than 10 holders of PhD joined the MFA under Article 20. Coincidentally, most of these competent recruits were opposed to the policies of the Rouhani Administration. As qualified experts of various political persuasions are needed in the MFA, they were recruited under article 20.

⁹ Effective since 1973

¹⁰ Article 5: Requirements for employment applicants for the diplomatic division are as follows: 1. Iranian nationality provided that it is not acquired; 2. Not having any foreign spouse or a spouse with acquired Iranian nationality; 3. Aged between 21 and 30; 4. Health and ability to work; 5. Having done military service or been exempted therefrom; 6. Having no criminal record; 7. No notoriety for moral corruption and not being a drug user; 8. Holding bachelor's or higher degree in political sciences, law, economics, judicial affairs, administration, sociology, history or geography and for graduates of foreign universities, endorsed by competent Iranian authorities; 9. Clearing entrance exam (The MFA shall announce the date and requirements for participating in the entrance exam through advertising in newspapers); 10. Completing the trial period.

¹¹ Article 20: The Minister of Foreign Affairs can from the date of adoption of these regulations accept persons with scientific ranking who are aged below 40 into the political division, upon recommendation from the Council of Deputy Ministers, notwithstanding provisions of Sub-Articles 3, 9 and 10 of Article 5. Note 1: The ranking of such persons shall be determined upon the proposal of the Council of Employment and endorsement by the Council of Deputy Ministers and the Minister. Note 2: The criteria for distinguishing scientific ranking shall be master's certificate in the disciplines needed by the MFA in addition to the following: 1) Having at least 5 years of experience in the disciplines needed by the MFA; 2) Having authored books, research work or important articles regarding disciplines needed by the MFA. Note 3: Beneficiaries of this Article that are not government employees, shall be classified under a category based on their rank.

I had joined the MFA under Article 20 in 1988 upon Minister Velayati's insistence and despite tough opposition. I had all necessary requirements for joining the MFA; having served as local employee in the permanent mission, holding a PhD in international studies, and being under 30 at age 28. However, I entered the MFA as first secretary instead of attaché. That was the only benefit of Article 20 for me. After nearly eight years of working in New York, I did not have to start from attaché.

The same regulations hold that new employees should have a meeting with the Minister of Foreign Affairs at the swearing in ceremony administered by the Minister¹². Unfortunately, this statutory requirement has yet to be fulfilled and during my ministerial term we failed to implement this provision. It is not merely a ceremonial procedure; rather, it is a rather substantive requirement which I hope will be implemented in the best manner in the future.

Under the Rouhani Administration, transferring people from other agencies to the MFA was occasional and structured. The first condition was that an MFA division declares its need for that particular expertise. In some divisions like the Office of Deputy Minister for Economic Affairs or Office of Deputy Minister for Legal Affairs, the transferee had to prove his/her capabilities to convince the MFA that such legal or economic expertise would help the MFA to perform its functions more effectively. Then, the transferees were given a one-year temporary assignment to get familiar with the environment because the MFA is a manifestation of the famous proverb "distance lends enchantment to the view". Outsiders are not aware of the challenges inside. As Minister Velayati put it, it is not so that the MFA staff wear smoking attire and go to receptions and get remarkable salary. Therefore, trial transferees should work for one year to see if they can cope with the MFA, and vice versa. If affirmative, the transfer would have to go through to the Council of Deputy Ministers for final permanent

¹² Article 17: The swearing ceremony is held in the presence of the Minister, Deputy Ministers and the Director of MFA Employment Division and applicants sign the oath whose text is as follows: "I take Almighty God as witness and swear by this heavenly book that I shall be faithful and loyal to the homeland and the Constitution of Iran, and that I shall be diligent in performing my duties and responsibilities with utmost honesty, trustworthiness, and sincerity, and that I shall consider preserving state secrets as my indisputable duty and absolute obligation, and that I shall fully observe the laws and regulations of my country."

approval. Based on this procedure, the number of transferred colleagues was low, and most new experts had joined the MFA under Article 5.

Council of Deputy Ministers

The Council of Deputy Ministers is a key structure within the MFA. As provided for in the MFA Statute, some decisions need the Council's approval, which are mainly administrative and internal. Many organizations, institutions and larger institutes have similar bodies, albeit with different names. For instance, the University of Tehran has a Board of Directors which acts as its Council. Conversations within the Council of Deputy Ministers are mainly about administrative and executive issues rather than political affairs although occasionally, political and substantive debates are also held in the Council.

After accepting to serve as the Minister of Foreign Affairs, some decisions were adopted regarding the Deputy Ministers and Council of Deputy Ministers. By keeping some former directors and deputy ministers in place, some others were gradually named ambassadors or replaced. Some changes were also made to the modalities of meetings of the Council of Deputy Ministers. During Ahmadinejad Administrations, the meetings of the Council were recorded, which was a new tradition. Under Minister Velayati and Minister Kharrazi, the Council's meetings were never recorded and there were no microphone and recorder. I came to realize on the first day of my work as Minister that microphones and a recorder were installed on the conference table of the Council of Deputy Ministers. I did not like it.

Some officials like President Rouhani always record all their meetings. I always express my views without any reservation about being recorded. But in most cases, recording is a deterrent because some people would become more cautious and even more conservative for fear of future consequences. It is always prudent to speak carefully, but it would harm the State when it turns into self-censorship. I ordered all recorders and microphones removed. A table designed for 611- people did not need any microphone. Of course, now that my tenure has ended, I should accept that my 40-year practice of not recording my meetings and not taking notes

during negotiations was itself a product of what I always warn against: acting based on unrealistic aspirations rather than realistic capabilities.

Shortly after assuming office, I felt the need for morning senior staff meetings to review events and make diplomatic decisions. That began and expanded gradually. In the process of changing the bureaucratic structure, when regional deputy ministers were replaced with regional assistant ministers, the meetings turned into forums with 25 people around the table. These meetings were held regularly even on the days I was absent. That was a constructive initiative. That had already begun under Minister Kharrazi. Even then, the Council of Deputy Ministers met regularly every morning to review news and developments but a bit later than 7:30 am when we started. Under Minister Kharrazi, such meetings were simply for news management rather than policymaking. The spokesperson presented a report, and participants exchanged views and made decisions about how to adopt position vis-à-vis developments. But during my eight-year tenure, these meetings were not devoted to merely news management; rather, they were aimed at political management, i.e., decision-making about what should be done. News was also discussed, but that was not the focal point.

In addition to these daily meetings, we invited experts and academics outside the MFA for consultation. Even during the talks leading to the JCPOA¹³, we took some legal and media experts with us to consult with them. We also consulted regularly with economic and trade experts. When the economic aspect of the JCPOA became serious, a separate group was set up for economic negotiations. So was the case with nuclear aspects. We had nuclear experts with us until finally Minister Salehi was personally tasked with steering the nuclear part of the talks.

Strategic Council

Three years into my tenure as foreign minister, I felt the need to have conversation and consultation with academic and veteran MFA colleagues on a regular basis with a view to engaging others' views in policy formulation

¹³ Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA), as the 2015 Iran nuclear deal with 5+1 is formally referred to.

and implementation. In these meetings, MFA officials were asked to listen rather than speak so that the invitees would have enough time to express their views. That was a highly instrumental experience that dealt with various aspects of foreign policy issues.

We held weekly meetings with a group of academics and senior diplomats, which was known as the Strategic Council. The meetings served as a bridge between theory and practice. When most prominent professors of political sciences and international relations come together with senior diplomats, a link is established between university, MFA and other foreign policy institutions, which in addition to formation of friendships, allows for exchange of information and consensus-building.

Learning from each other would bring an end to negative perceptions that theorists and practitioners have vis-à-vis one another. The professor should not assume that he has theoretical knowledge and the agent doesn't. The agent should not assume he sees the realities and the professor only fantasies. Another outcome of these meetings was that at least everyone realized that each person has a specific degree of understanding, covering all operational aspects. Nobody would be limited to theoretical or practical aspects.

These meetings contributed to further friendship and amity but did not yield much in terms of consensus-building. I regret to say that foreign policy has turned into a factional concept in our country. We tried our best to reach unanimity and synergy, but in the end, what dominated was political and factional considerations that continue to harm foreign policy even today. The faster we can separate foreign policy from domestic politics, the faster we can benefit from such discourses for national consensus and solidarity.

Steering Council

The valuable achievements of weekly meetings with academics and veteran diplomats drove us towards setting up a body to benefit from the experiences gained by senior diplomats. In the MFA restructuring, the Foreign Policy Steering Council was set up to be led by the minister and comprising former ministers, deputy ministers and some senior ambassadors.

Owing to the difficulty of coordination between such busy people, we could not convene more than six meetings between its establishment in 2018 and end of my tenure as foreign minister in 2021. Arranging such meetings was difficult, but institutionalizing such a body was constructive. By setting up this body, there will be always a place at the MFA to benefit from the views and experience of elders and retired diplomats. A similar body exists at the US Department of State. In some other countries, a senior diplomat forms a body with which the minister consults. However, incorporating that body into the official organizational chart of the foreign ministry may be new.

Morning Meetings of Senior Management

Morning meetings were held to enable senior MFA officials to learn about latest foreign policy developments at the regional and global levels and build consensus within the MFA. For instance, it is necessary for the director-general for Persian Gulf to know about latest developments in Afghanistan, because he may be asked about it by a foreign ambassador from the region under his supervision. At the MFA, a director who works on the Persian Gulf is not regularly kept informed of developments in the US or our ties with Europe. But the European ambassadors are well informed. Therefore, regular morning meetings allowed systematic internal exchange of latest developments, consultation and proximity of views.

Another advantage is that such meetings would break factional groupings and put everyone on equal footing. In the past, among senior MFA officials and at times even within the Council of Deputy Ministers, factionalism was visible, dividing deputies based on their political inclinations or prior friendships and affiliations. During my tenure, we managed to foster an atmosphere of empathy by building comradeships instead of factional division. Efforts were made so that despite diverse visions and views, senior MFA officials would not fall into separate and sometimes conflicting categories.

From the position of minister, I never held a vertical hierarchical approach to my colleagues, because I served in the foreign ministry during my entire civil service. All senior foreign ministry officials were already

my colleagues in a different setting. For instance, we were both deputy ministers or one was a director-general and another a division head when I served as Deputy Minister for Legal and International Affairs. We were friends and we had already worked together. The relationship between me, as minister, and my colleagues was always horizontal. Never was it vertical. In many cases, instead of my colleagues preparing a draft for the minister to express his views, the procedure was upended. I never remember having written something and disseminating it before consulting with others. That applied to my speeches, tweets, reports and policy papers.

In the MFA restructuring, I took note of some ideas and views of our administration experts in meetings and forwarded them to colleagues in the Council of Deputy Ministers for their views and comments. That avoided duplication because administrative experts did not attend all meetings. On the other hand, due to the dominant bureaucratic culture that considers drafting a report not-befitting a senior official, none of the participants in our high-level meetings were ready to write down the conclusion of the meeting. If they were assigned the task of drafting, they would pass it on to an expert who had not even been in attendance, thereby unaware of the details of views and discussions. My horizontal view of the MFA management hierarchy prevailed during my tenure as minister, ambassador to the UN, deputy minister and deputy head of UN Mission. Following this *modus operandi*, I called my colleagues by their first name in a bid to break the superior-inferior culture. Many others may prefer vertical management, and they may be right, and their method may prove more effective. But that goes against my personality. Or maybe choosing this method was still born out of being torn between aspirations and realities that I frequently cite.

Virtual Contact with Minister

The method of communication with employees and colleagues was born out of the same horizontal relationship mentality. I always tried to be available, which was a new tradition at the MFA. Due to numerous preoccupations of the foreign minister, I decided to be available to all colleagues, ranging from deputy ministers, assistant ministers and regional directors to junior

experts, as well as academics and journalists outside the ministry via email. The basis for reaching this decision was the real conditions at the MFA. The ministry has three thousand employees, over one thousand diplomats, more than one hundred heads of mission—ambassadors and consuls-general, many deputy ministers, assistant ministers, directors-general, ministerial advisors, deputy directors-general, heads of division and deputy heads of division. That means nearly three hundred senior and mid-level officials. If the minister decides to meet one-on-one only with officials without seeing any expert and gives five minutes to each that would amount to 2,500 minutes per week. That requires allocating three days of the week to such meetings. Now if experts are included with each expert wanting to see the minister only once a year, a large amount of time would be spent at such meetings.

In ideal conditions, such one-on-one meetings with colleagues would be preferable, but a brief review of the foreign minister's weekly schedule shows that such an aspiration is far from real. The minister must sit twice per week, each time four hours, in the Cabinet, which lasted from 8am to Noon every Wednesday and from 4 to 8pm every Sunday. Add to this, 23- hours of presence at National Security Council meetings that are held every two weeks. About 10 hours or a full day had to be spent at these meetings every week. Morning senior officials' meetings were held five days a week, each session lasting 1 ½ to 2 hours. Except for Wednesdays, the minister was in attendance. Therefore, at least 68- hours per week were spent in morning senior officials' meetings for policy coordination. Two meetings of the Council of Deputy Ministers per week took at least three hours to avoid any disruption in the MFA internal affairs. That required one full working day. There were also numerous meetings at parliamentary committees or the plenary, which needed at least two hours. The minister was also required to attend many other meetings to which he was invited.

In addition to these mandatory weekly meetings, visits by foreign dignitaries, receipt of credentials and dozens of other administrative tasks all together took an average of 2 ½ days of the five working days. And all of that was only for the time the minister was in Tehran. Obviously, I also had to spend a lot of time on foreign visits.

Those who demanded a meeting with the minister thought they were the only ones making such a request and were not aware of huge demands on my time. Some said they would want a brief meeting that would last several minutes, but no meeting lasts less than 15-20 minutes. Greetings alone take five minutes. Therefore, I decided from the very beginning to not accept any one-on-one meeting. First, we did not have time. Second, some meetings pertained to requests which did not lie within the purview of my responsibilities or expertise. What could be done during half an hour?

The minister could not directly and personally handle everything at the ministry. On the other hand, no new idea was raised in none of these meetings. Insistence on meeting with the minister was mainly for personal requests. A private meeting needed 10-30 minutes during which one colleague would complain about his/her personal problems. The nature of administrative work is that the head of the apparatus can never follow up on issues personally. That would stir disorder into the apparatus. After hearing complaints, the case had been forwarded without the necessary precision or detail to one of deputies or directors. Therefore, even after half an hour of meeting, the requester would continue to be unhappy, as I could not personally resolve the problem. The minister cannot simultaneously act in lieu of all MFA structures, from vetting and evaluation to administration and finance.

Therefore, I announced at the beginning that I would be available to all via email. The reason for choosing this method of communication was to use non-working hours for reading and replying to emails. My official hours were from 7:15am to 6pm. But from about 4:30am to 10pm, I worked on my laptop. Even if we had guests at home, my laptop was with me to monitor news, write and revise reports and respond to emails. In this way, I used my dead time for what I had to do during administrative hours. The fault with this method was that many became unhappy for not having given time for one-on-one meeting. But the advantage was that instead of meeting with a few colleagues, anyone could contact the minister by sending an email. During the time I was at home with my wife, children and grandchildren, and while they were busy working, talking and playing, I was reading emails, replying to them or forwarding them to relevant officials inside and outside the foreign ministry. Many of

those staying in office from 78-am to 1011-pm may spend much of their time in friendly chats. I do not like it. If I had extra time, I preferred to spend it with my family while doing my work.

MFA Restructuring: Objectives, Challenges and Achievements

Since I was serving as deputy minister and ambassador, I believed in the need for transformation, restructuring and innovation. During my tenure as minister, the same vision continued. There was a series of legal obligations. For instance, management layers should not exceed four, but at the MFA there were seven or eight of them. In addition to the statutory requirements, my personal concern partly resulted from three decades of experience at various ranks of the MFA, drawing parallels between Iran's foreign ministry and its counterparts in other countries. Therefore, to improve the MFA structure, there were both legal obligations and functional needs.

From a functional standpoint, like every other organization, the MFA should have a mechanism for experience sharing. The MFA is a hierarchal body in which a counsellor should learn from the ambassador, the second counsellor from the first counsellor and so on and so forth. In other words, there should be education and experience sharing within the structure. But how was it in practice? The smart structure of the MFA had been pushed aside, and many layers had been created based on short-term needs or maybe for merely ceremonial purposes. Within this establishment, at the top of the hierarchy was the minister followed by first deputy minister, deputy ministers, directors-general, deputy directors-general, directors, and deputy directors, and finally the experts/diplomats. In some cases, ministerial advisors and aides, advisors to deputy ministers, aides to directors-general and directors of divisions were added to management layers, thereby adding to the distance between the expert and the first management layer.

In the seven or eight layers of the structure of the MFA, the executor and the decision-maker were distant. There was no meaningful link between the expert and the decision-maker. Due to these numerous

management layers, middle managers had to spend most of their time attending meetings, forwarding tasks to lower layers or initialing reports to go to higher-ranking directors, thereby having no time to learn. Most of times, they did not even read what they had forwarded or initialed. The reason was that they were flooded with letters, documents and reports, which were received from the lowest rank junior staff members—without any experience and there was no sufficient time to modify the reports or train the drafters. The statutory requirement of reducing the layers to four may have been caused by this bureaucratic malfunction. Therefore, the seven or eight layers that existed within the MFA had to be reduced to minister, deputy ministers, directors-general and heads of division. In this way, at least two official layers – deputy director-general and deputy head of division – were eliminated.

The MFA Statute requires that the heads of division should hold the ambassadorial rank¹⁴. Of course, due to the conditions explained before about the changes in senior management during the first years following the Islamic Revolution, these regulations were often ignored. In addition, over the past one or two decades, returning ambassadors preferred to take the title of “senior expert” if they were not offered positions of deputy minister or director-general. The pay grade was like the head of division. That filled the ministry with more than 100 senior experts, mostly having no output. As a remedy, we at the Council of Deputy Ministers designed a structure to eliminate the senior expert position so that ambassadors could not evade taking director level responsibility after their terms abroad ended. In that way, to receive higher salary and benefits than a simple expert, former ambassadors would have to lead several experts to work together as a small group to facilitate direct monitoring as well as training and education. Therefore, in the first step, we revised the MFA structure vertically. We drastically reduced senior expert positions and instead increased heads of division so that no new financial and administrative burden would be imposed on the Treasury. The objective was to make the MFA expert based. The expert could sit in the same

¹⁴ Directors-general and heads of divisions at the MFA are chosen from official staff who have already reached the rank of ambassador and the acting heads of divisions are required to be at least second counsellor. (Article 22, Note 3)

room with an ambassador as his/her superior, cooperate and exchange views, cooperate in drafting reports and hence learn. The boss would give guidance to the expert, the expert would write, and the director would revise and send back to the expert. They would share a working space and there would be constant communication between them. The initial plan was thoroughly discussed at the Council of Deputy Ministers. It was revised several times until we reached consensus. I even had to intervene in dividing offices so that the inflexible structure of the MFA would not impose itself upon us again.

However, the plan to improve the vertical structure of the MFA failed. Again, the distance between aspirations and realities was to blame. We had not noted that the MFA bureaucracy is a node in the overall bureaucratic structure of the country, which could not be improved as an isolated island. That might have been why only a handful of apparently minor difficulties bogged down the MFA vertical restructuring plan.

In the new structure, we envisaged four to eight heads of division for each director-general and three to five experts for each head of division to facilitate their direct communication. In accordance with statutory obligation, deputy heads of divisions had been eliminated. By removing this layer, a sort of collective resentment emerged. The removal of that layer destroyed one possibility for experts to move upward and reach the level of deputy head of division. In addition, a seemingly trivial bureaucratic obstructionism buried the plan.

This final nail in the coffin was the “room challenge”. In our project, the directors and their experts had to interact with one another in a single room. The point we had ignored was that under Iran’s administrative system, heads of divisions are accustomed to having a separate room. We could not do otherwise at the MFA. Apart from that, the MFA had encryption and confidentiality regulations that added to this prestige impetus.

Nearly one year after implementing the new structure, two ministerial aides were designated to study the functional consequences of restructuring so that, if need be, the structures and processes be optimized anew. Through these investigations, we found out that the foundations of our idea had been destroyed. Each head of division was sitting in a separate room while experts were in other rooms, distant from one another. The

question was to know why it had happened. The response was that the Encryption Division would not give the head of division access to the encryption system unless they had a separate room. The heads of division who did not want to lose this special privilege put an end to the entire project in full silence. Once more, I fell prey to the distance between aspirations and realities.

The entire plan for vertical structure had to be deconstructed and the former hierarchy was back. Unfortunately, all the efforts undertaken by the minister, Council of Deputy Ministers and the Cabinet's Administrative and Employment Affairs Organization (AEAO) to make the MFA an expert-based body failed due to lack of cooperation by a handful of junior staff members. Everything was back as it was. The heads of divisions sat in their separate rooms and experts sat far from them. It was clear that while the number of divisions had risen, the heads of division did not have the chance to communicate with their subordinates and exchange views with them as planned. Finally, we had no option but to decrease the number of divisions because we failed to convince our own subordinates to give heads of division, sharing rooms with experts, access to the encryption system of the MFA.

Amid investigations within the Council of Deputy Ministers about restructuring, we faced another challenge: that was the parliament's insistence on setting up an Office of Deputy Minister for Economic Affairs. My experience as the Deputy Minister for Legal and International Affairs showed that the MFA's region-based structure could not coexist with an issue-based structure. Before the Islamic Revolution, the Minister of Foreign Affairs had a Deputy for Political Affairs, a Deputy for Economic and International Affairs, a Deputy for Consular Affairs and a Deputy for Administrative and Financial Affairs. In mid-1980s, it was decided to eliminate positions of Deputy Ministers for Economic and Political Affairs and create three positions at deputy minister level for regional affairs—Asia, Middle East and Africa and Europe and Americas. The general understanding was that after that change, the MFA was being managed by the deputy ministers for regional affairs. Even the Deputy Minister for International Affairs had been dwarfed by his regional counterparts.

The region-based structure of the MFA continued until the end of Minister Velayati's term in office. After him, Minister Kharrazi decided to revive the Office of Deputy Minister for Economic Affairs. Although he appointed prominent diplomats to the Office, it was not a successful experience. There were always disputes with deputies for regional affairs. After the end of Minister Kharrazi's tenure, the Office of Deputy Minister for Economic Affairs gradually disappeared under President Ahmadinejad.

Under the Rouhani administration, I appointed the first deputy minister to serve concurrently as coordinator of economic affairs, a sign of primacy over other deputy ministers. When all deputy ministers are at the same level, the deputy minister for regional affairs would handle all regional matters including economic issues, leaving the deputy for economic affairs without any serious responsibility. On the other hand, the idea was for the MFA to facilitate economic ties and help ease the economic burden on everyday life. For this purpose, it was decided that the first deputy minister handle economic affairs too. It was not useless, but the parliament insisted on the establishment of a separate Office of Deputy Foreign Minister for Economic Affairs.

All investigations and consultations indicated that establishment of the Office of Deputy Minister for Economic Affairs required changing the regional structure to issue structure. In other words, there should be a deputy for political affairs and a deputy for economic affairs. Endless talks started about how to restore the issue structure to the MFA. The horizontal structure within the Council of Deputy Ministers was also challenged as it was prejudicial to the future status of some Council members, namely the three regional deputies. As long as talks were revolving around the vertical structure, the Council members had no serious concern. They would all remain as deputy ministers and their positions were intact. But in reforming the horizontal structure, three offices of deputy minister for regional affairs would be eliminated. Naturally some deputy ministers involved could not be happy with that outcome.

In the former structure of the MFA, several regional political directors-general were operating under the deputy minister for political affairs and equivalent regional economic directors under the deputy minister for economic affairs. In this way, a director-general for Americas political

affairs and a director-general for Arab political affairs operated under the deputy minister for political affairs directors for Americas economic affairs and Arab economic affairs worked under the deputy minister for economic affairs. That was one solution. But given the fact that the MFA had been accustomed to a regional structure for nearly three decades (1987-2016-), it could not be effective.

Therefore, after extensive consultation, it was suggested that deputy ministers for regional affairs be replaced by assistant ministers for regional affairs, responsible directly to the minister. This method had two advantages: First, the deputy ministers for economic, political and international affairs were superior to regional assistant ministers, which enabled them to issue orders to the assistant ministers; Second, the minister would be directly involved in day-to-day foreign policy cases. Until that time, foreign policy cases were mainly in the hands of deputy ministers for regional affairs. The minister remained mostly uninformed of issues that were being handled by directors-general—if those issues were not important to the regional deputy under whom they operated. The new division removed a middle layer in the MFA bilateral relations, facilitating direct communication between the minister and directors-general.

We concluded to have one deputy minister for political affairs and one deputy minister for economic affairs. It was initially proposed to have two deputy ministers for political affairs, one dealing with neighboring countries and one with non-neighboring countries. But this proposal was set aside due to growing concerns about the possibility of interference. The views of management experts were also discussed at the Council of Deputy Ministers. It is noteworthy that under Minister Kharrazi, a professional management and planning group outside of the MFA conducted extensive research. But the implementation of their recommendations had faced obstructionism within the MFA. The findings of that research were available and they were used.

In addition to the expert studies of late 1990s, the structure of foreign ministries in other countries was reviewed. No universal case was found though. For instance, in Russia, the Deputy Foreign Minister for Americas also handles disarmament. Another deputy oversees international

organizations. In other words, all foreign ministries do not follow a similar structural pattern.

In the proposed structure, the challenge between the deputy minister for economic affairs and the deputy ministers for regional affairs was overcome as was the challenge between the deputy minister for international affairs and regional deputies. In the past, the deputy minister for international affairs oversaw human rights too, but when it came to dialogue with Europe, the deputy minister for international affairs was out of the loop and it was the deputy minister for European affairs that was in the game. Currently, specialized deputies and regional assistants have been defined. Furthermore, instead of assigning one official with economic affairs of a country and another with political affairs of the same country—as was the case before the revolution, all issues pertaining to any country are now handled by the relevant regional assistant minister. However, all assistant ministers receive political, economic or multilateral instructions from the relevant deputy ministers. Meantime, all of them are directly linked to the minister. Optimization of the horizontal structure of the MFA was a relatively successful experience. Future ministers may try to revive the regional structure and abandon this structure, which is not faultless and has opponents both inside and outside of the MFA.

Minister of Foreign Affairs as the Symbol of MFA

More than two centuries old, the MFA is among the oldest ministries in Iran. Although it is a living organization, not necessarily formed around any individual minister, it is symbolized by the minister in person. More than any other actor, the minister is in the public eye. Therefore, the foreign minister is known as the symbol of foreign policy both internally and externally. That is the appearance while in reality MFA's daily activities are mainly carried out by directors-general. That is exactly why the minister should be in direct contact with directors-general. For instance, in order to effectively engage with the SNSC, the minister is required to be directly linked with those who handle everyday affairs of the MFA and make executive decisions.

The MFA has an extensive field of action. In the Leader's words, the MFA is doing half of the Cabinet's tasks. Whatever state agencies do internally, the MFA should do externally and remain accountable for them. Overseas, the foreign ministry represents all other state agencies, ranging from National Registry Office to the Ministry of Intelligence, Armed Forces General Staff, Ministry of Petroleum, Ministry of Road and Urban Development, Ministry of Energy, Ministry of Industry, Mine and Trade, and Ministry of Agriculture among others. As much as the Ambassador to the UN represents the Minister of Foreign Affairs, he represents the Minister of Interior and the Minister of Energy. With such variety of tasks, a minister and few deputy ministers cannot handle all MFA affairs. That explains why the MFA has always been run by directors-general. Before the Islamic Revolution, the following catchphrase was common: "In the MFA, after the Shah, the directors-general are in charge."

Anyway, under the Rouhani Administrations, due to the immense impact of the outcome of the work of the MFA on public welfare—which is not ideal—and my strong presence in domestic and foreign media of various inclinations, the people in Iran, region and even the world identified Iran's foreign policy with the Minister, which imposed a heavy burden upon me. Many people in the streets still blame me for the current internal and external problems. They definitely have every right. I and people like me will remain accountable both in this world and in the hereafter.

Minister's Office Arrangement

Many may not care about the arrangement of objects in the office of Minister of Foreign Affairs. But that may be interesting for curious readers and useful to researchers. In his office, the minister sits to read and write. In my office, I spend my time mainly behind my computer screen. Ever since I was writing my PhD dissertation, in 1984 when very simple PCs became available in the US, I have set aside handwriting and used a keyboard. This is why my handwriting has lost its relative beauty. Therefore, a modern desk was needed in the minister's office. For the past five decades, the minister had a very nice—but dysfunctional—antique desk. It could not serve my tasks. We paid nothing because an Iranian

company offered a desk to us as a gift. Under President Ahmadinejad, the same company had provided woodwork for the National Assembly of the Union of the Comoros.

The minister's office was decorated with gold-coated classical furniture. For a room in which the minister sits and rarely receives foreign guests, such outlandish furniture was too much. That furniture was moved to the official reception hall, where foreign guests are received. The furniture that was used during Minister Kharrazi was moved back into my office. It was simple and practical; yet, it was also suitable for meeting with foreign dignitaries.

Another modification in the decoration of the minister's office was to move the library to minister's private room and remove the display of gifts. Of course, it is just a matter of taste. I prefer simplicity for my life and workplace because it gives me peace of mind. Therefore, this new arrangement was made for personal reasons and somewhat for safety of the room from spying equipment. A large number of items can cover bugging devices although with modern technologies, such precautionary measures are not very effective. Anyway, absence of extra items would make infiltration tougher.

Another action was to install Iranian paintings in the minister's room and the MFA halls. Earlier, beautiful paintings by Western artists were on display. They were all priceless and valuable, but not Iranian. Upon recommendation by art exports, the ceremonial space of the MFA was adorned with Iranian artworks. The MFA has numerous valuable paintings that had been stored. The warehouse turned into a museum in 2019. There were famous works by famous artist Mahmoud Farshchian that had not been put on display for fear of criticism of impropriety by hardliners. A very beautiful painting by Farshchian now adorns the minister's room. Other Iranian paintings were placed on the walls of official and ceremonial reception halls. We had also very valuable carpets in the warehouse that had been abandoned. Most of them became the new floor coverings in the ministerial and ceremonial halls.

Two woodwork calligraphies were added to my room. One bore the Quranic verse "That 'eternal' Home in the Hereafter We reserve 'only' for those who seek neither tyranny nor corruption on the earth. The ultimate

outcome belongs 'only' to the righteous"¹⁵. It was a frequent reminder of the necessity to steer clear of excessive demands and supremacy. The other—"We alternate these days among people"—bore part of the Quranic verse 3:140¹⁶. I believe that we should keep it always before our eyes to remember that our mundane positions are ephemeral and short-lived.

The secretaries of the minister used to sit at the entrance hall, for whom several tables had been set. Whatever was on their desks was visible to any visitor. The ministerial secretary's desk is never empty. That was not acceptable both in terms of adornment and security. All desks were removed.

The room adjacent to the minister's room, which used to host meetings of the Council of Deputy Ministers under Ministers Velayati and Kharrazi, had been used for foreign visits during the Ahmadinejad administration. In my view, when splendid halls have been built inside the MFA edifice, receiving foreign dignitaries in a small 40 sqm room was not what Iranian people deserved. Therefore, this room was once again repurposed for the Council of Deputy Ministers' meetings and morning meetings of senior officials. That added to the beauty, efficiency and safety of the entire ministry.

Imam Khomeini Hall, which used to display gifts to the minister, was remodeled as the official venue for bilateral talks with foreign counterparts and large high-ranking delegations. That hall may well be the most elegant, yet practical, ceremonial hall in Iran. By moving the classical furniture from the minister's office to the entrance hall and moving the conference table from there to Imam Khomeini Hall, the entrance hall turned into a room to receive foreign visitors and credentials from newly appointed ambassadors stationed in or accredited to Iran.

¹⁵ 28:83

¹⁶ If you have suffered injuries, they suffered similarly. We alternate these days among people so that Allah may reveal the believers, choose witnesses from among you—and Allah does not like the wrongdoers.

CHAPTER III

RELATIONS WITH STATE INSTITUTIONS

Relations with the Leader

Under the Constitution, the general outlines of foreign policy are determined by the Leader, whose presence in the high-level decision-making of foreign policy is extensive. In my view, the foundational pillar of the Leader's approach to foreign policy has always been dignity—the first of the triad of dignity, wisdom, and prudence that he has articulated. Due to both the explicit provisions of the Constitution and to his personal concern with preventing foreign domination over the Islamic Republic and safeguarding national dignity, the Leader is extremely vigilant and exacting. Thus, in cases which, in his view, are related to national dignity, he has even involved himself in the details.

If analysts, instead of becoming entangled in the logic of deterrence and other constructs of the securitization game, were to examine the

nuclear dossier from the perspective of “national dignity,” they would readily understand why the Leader has shown such sensitivity regarding the nuclear issue—which, while important, is not existential. Many have questioned why a country possessing the largest oil and gas reserves in the world should endure so much external pressure merely to possess a nuclear power plant or the fuel for it—to the extent that it faces difficulties in exploiting its primary source of energy. If the country does not intend to build a nuclear bomb, why invest so heavily in nuclear energy? From such a viewpoint, this level of expenditure could only be justified if a country sought to obtain nuclear weapons, in line with the words of the late Pakistani Prime Minister, Zulfikar Ali Bhutto, who declared that the nation was prepared “to eat grass but build the bomb.” The outcome of the deterrence discourse—or of insisting on the necessity of nuclear energy—would thus be the conclusion that Iran seeks to build a nuclear bomb; otherwise, it would not be logical for a state that does not intend to build one to accept such costs. Yet, if we examine the matter through the lens of the Leader’s discourse of dignity, the pieces of the puzzle readily fall into place—without falling into the contradiction manufactured by the securitizers.

The Leader has always emphasized three pillars in foreign policy: dignity, wisdom, and prudence. Dignity stands above the others; that is, dignity must be secured through the methods of wisdom and prudence. Thus, the foundation is dignity, and the means to attain it are wisdom and prudence. In my understanding, this has been a highly central point for the Leader and should likewise be foundational and focal for all foreign policy officials. Iran is the oldest country in the world; it must always be remembered by those in office that the dignity of this country and its people is not something to be bargained away.

Another aspect of his view has been that the foreign policy apparatus is the representative and the face of the Islamic Republic of Iran in the world. He has often stated in ambassadors’ seminars that the MFA constitutes half of the Cabinet, for while other institutions are each responsible for one domestic sphere, the MFA is tasked with pursuing all external matters. Based on this view, there should be concentration and unity in foreign relations. Such concentration does not exist in practice, and he

has repeatedly warned about this. The absence of a central nucleus to coordinate external relations is highly dangerous and, before anything else, undermines the country's dignity. Institutions abroad can neutralize each other, projecting a chaotic and conflict-ridden image of the nation. When two institutions speak in opposite directions regarding a foreign country, it reveals internal disarray.

I first met the Leader during his trip to New York, when in 1987 a few months after the adoption of Resolution 598, he visited New York as President. At that time, I was pursuing my doctoral studies and serving as a local staff member at Iran's Mission to the United Nations. In an exceptional situation, I was also *Chargé d'affaires* at the Mission. As I explained in *Aqay-e Safir*¹⁷, local staff members are generally assigned only service-related or, in some cases, administrative tasks in diplomatic protocol. Due to the special circumstances of that period, I may have been the only local staff member in the history of the United Nations who, in the absence of the Permanent Representative, acted as *Chargé d'affaires* and interim head of mission.

The then-Permanent Representative, the late Dr. Saeed Rajaei Khorasani, was completing his mission and returned to Iran aboard the President's plane. As a result, the affairs of the Mission fell to me, which brought me into close contact with the advance team and entourage of the President. During that trip, to follow up and coordinate matters, we met with the President several times daily. From that time, he extended his personal kindness toward me. On one occasion, Dr. Velayati requested that I brief the Leader on the implementation process of paragraphs six and seven of Resolution 598, concerning responsibility for the imposed war and reconstruction. That was my second in-person meeting with the Leader.

During my tenure as Deputy Minister for Legal and International Affairs at the MFA, direct contact was less frequent, and he received my reports through the usual channels. When I was nominated as Permanent Representative to the United Nations, malicious rumors circulated in the

¹⁷ Raji, Mehdi. *Aqay-e Safir* (Mr. Ambassador) (2013), Interview with Mohammad Javad Zarif, Edition Ney

corridors of the Ministry claiming that the Leader did not approve of my appointment. In reality, the Leader had conveyed his agreement to Dr. Kharrazi, who, after President Khatami's approval, instructed that my U.S. visa be requested for myself and my family. At the time, I was Deputy for Legal and International Affairs, and therefore, the instructions for issuing my passport and requesting the visa had to be issued by myself.

At the same time, I received a call from the Leader's office informing me that he wished to see me and hence I went to meet him. We discussed methods of work and approaches to the United States, given that the Permanent Representative to the United Nations is the highest-ranking Iranian official in America, and consequently, that country's portfolio falls, to some extent, under his purview. The Leader underscored his awareness of my views regarding the United States and the difference between my perspective and his own. I replied that as an expert, my duty was to present my view and perspective to the higher authority. Referring to the statement of Imam Ali (peace be upon him) "The greatest betrayal is the betrayal of the ummah, and the most terrible deception is deceiving the leaders"—I added that once the higher levels have taken a decision, as a diplomat, I carry it out; for the country must have a single foreign policy.

I have always repeated this theoretical vision and practical conviction in my classes: in the role of expert, one must practice *ijtihad* (independent reasoning); in the role of executor, one must practice *taqlid* (emulation). Yet the method of many is inverted: in the stage of policymaking, they refrain from frankness, merely repeating and endorsing the views of higher levels, imitating them in analysis; but in the stage of execution, they engage in *ijtihad* and fail to implement the state's decision. This is where the problem lies. Some colleagues believe in saying nothing, expressing agreement, and then pursuing their own course: "push it through, make it stick." I am wholeheartedly opposed to this method. It may yield greater short-term efficiency, but without doubt, in the long term, it will destroy the country.

The Leader responded that the duty of an expert is to convey his view honestly to the Leader, even if he is certain that it is diametrically opposed to the Leader's own opinion. From that day until the end of my tenure, he consistently expected this from me and appreciated that

I conveyed realities without omission or embellishment and expressed my assessments with clarity.

I should note that I was not inclined to go to New York. I wished to step down from the position of Deputy Minister and take on a mission that would be free of challenges and difficulties, for during the ten years I served as Deputy Minister—particularly in the Reformist administration—I was subjected to relentless slanders and extensive smearing campaigns, and especially in the case of the CTBT I faced tremendous pressures.

It is true that during my tenure as Minister these pressures increased greatly, yet at that time I was younger, with less experience, and the pressures I endured in those earlier years weighed heavily upon me. Some of those who fabricate cases today were also engaged in extensive smearing and defaming campaigns back then, to the extent that even tried to convince intelligence authorities to arrest me for disloyalty. Indeed, the individual who wrote the most negative bulletins against me was later executed for espionage on behalf of Britain—though I do not wish execution, or even imprisonment, upon anyone.

In the six-year interval between the end of my tenure in New York and my appointment as Minister, the Leader's office approached me on several occasions to offer my opinion or assistance in cases such as President Obama's message to him, his reply to that message, and other matters. Thus, this channel of communication was not disrupted. According to President Rouhani, at the time of forming his cabinet, it appeared that the agreement between the President and the Leader regarding the Minister of Foreign Affairs was reached without debate or disagreement. In some other cases, agreement had only been reached after three rounds of discussions; yet for the MFA—both in the first and second terms—the Leader immediately consented that I assume the post.

The third point is the Leader's tolerance of dissenting views. Something that has been less often stated is that although the Leader holds firmly defined views, he is willing to hear the opinions of others and reflect upon them. This is despite the great distance in position between him and a minister or ambassador, the substantial difference in age—he could easily be in the position of our father—and the breadth of his experience: more than three decades of leadership and eight years of presidency. In other

words, since the years of our youth, he has been in the first or second highest position in the country. Even so, he listens with great patience to expert views and takes them into account. Frankly expressed expert opinions are not only appreciated by him but also highly effective.

Perhaps one example may be of interest to readers. In meetings of senior officials with the Leader on foreign policy, in addition to the heads of the three branches of government and the Secretary of the Supreme National Security Council, the Foreign Minister, Dr. Velayati, and in some cases Martyr Soleimani were also present. The Leader would begin such meetings by presenting the issue from his own perspective. In these sessions, two types of responses were typically given: one group, basing themselves on the Leader's position, would rephrase the same view in other words; the second group—myself and one or two others—would present our own perspective with reasoning, outlining other aspects of the matter and drawing attention to them. In the conclusion of these meetings, I rarely saw the Leader's final summation simply repeat what he had stated at the outset; in other words, the discussions presented—whether in agreement or disagreement—had a tangible effect.

Indeed, there has been a significant misunderstanding in our perception of the Leader. Many of us officials enter meetings with a fixed position and leave with that same position, regardless of what the experts have said in the session. One of the causes of the country's shortcomings is the sense, among many officials, of not needing expert opinion. The Leader has never had this shortcoming.

Some have taken certain statements of the Leader to mean that there is a division or dichotomy between diplomacy and revolutionary identity. He has, perhaps on a few occasions, stated: "I am not a diplomat; I am a revolutionary." This expression has sometimes been used as a pretext to disparage and criticize diplomacy. The Leader of the Islamic Republic of Iran occupies a unique position, in which diplomacy and other affairs of state are defined beneath that position—not on a parallel level with it. In other words, the unifying link between all the officials of the Islamic Republic is their devotion to the country, the Revolution, and the national interest; yet one may have military responsibilities, another economic, another security-related, another educational, and so on. For this reason,

the Leader—who is the unifying link between all these officials—cannot himself be a “diplomat” or an “economist” or a “security official,” and so forth; he is a revolutionary. The officials, too, are all revolutionaries, but one works in the field of economics, another in defense, and another in diplomacy. Furthermore, he has repeatedly stated that if a matter can be resolved through diplomacy, this is the less costly course and may yield greater and more enduring results.

Every act of resistance must, in the end, be brought to a conclusion through dialogue and diplomacy; otherwise, the fruits of that resistance cannot be reaped. Thus, the principle is one, and no duality exists. If the foundation of dignity is upheld, then the diplomat, too, in meetings abroad, will pursue that same foundation. An example of this is the video conference with the foreign ministers of the remaining members of the JCPOA in the winter of 2021. This was the first time such a meeting was held via video conference, and the entire session was recorded. Should the day come when diplomatic protocols and considerations allow its release, it will become clear that as the foreign minister of the country, in that international meeting and in the midst of adversaries, I defended the dignity of the nation in such a way that some—even within the country and among friends—would be unable to do.

For this reason, I do not believe in any supposed dichotomy between being revolutionary and being a diplomat. In the Leader’s meetings with heads of state, he speaks with complete logic, courtesy, and observance of protocol, yet in the most assertive way. For my part, I have always sought, in a profession filled with complexities, to combine assertiveness with complete civility. I never played games with individuals or with matters, and I maintained this approach both at home and abroad: with full courtesy and firmness, I safeguarded the honor of the country.

Relations with the President

My acquaintance with Dr. Hassan Rouhani dates back to the tripartite talks between Iran, Iraq, and the UN Secretary-General on the implementation of Resolution 598 in 1988. These talks began in Geneva in September 1988, with the key issues being withdrawal, prisoners of war, and the

1975 Algiers Agreement. Alongside these tripartite discussions, Iran also held separate talks with the UN Secretary-General on determining responsibility for the war (paragraph 6), reconstruction (paragraph 7), and regional cooperation (paragraph 8) of the Resolution.

At that time, Dr. Rouhani, on the one hand, shared responsibility for the war alongside the late Ayatollah Hashemi Rafsanjani, and was therefore more familiar with war-related matters than others; and on the other hand, he was Chairman of the Parliament Defense Committee. As such, he was one of the principal members of the tripartite negotiations. In those talks, there were some who took a slogan-driven approach to issues such as dredging the Arvand river, withdrawal, prisoners, and so on. From my youth, however, I approached such matters with realism and expressed my views without reservation or self-censorship. Dr. Rouhani, at that time, perceived that I was among those in the group whose thinking was close to his own; I likewise had the same perception regarding him.

Following the tripartite talks, and after three years of service in New York as Ambassador and Deputy Permanent Representative to the United Nations, I was appointed Deputy Foreign Minister. During my ten years in that role, as a member of the Political Committee of the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council, I attended most foreign policy meetings. I was a constant presence in sessions on the repercussions of Iraq's invasion of Kuwait, and in meetings concerning the United States at the Secretariat. My responsibilities on the Chemical Weapons Convention, the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty (CTBT), and the nuclear challenge also brought me frequently to the Supreme National Security Council.

Throughout this period, Dr. Rouhani extended his kindness to me, and I, for my part, held special respect for his profound and realistic view of world affairs and for his constant courage and boldness in expressing his opinions.

Naturally, our relations experienced ups and downs. What was painful and very bitter for me, however, was the CTBT case. Together with colleagues in the Department for Legal and International Affairs of the MFA, we opposed the draft treaty on two or three points from an expert standpoint. When the matter reached the stage of deciding whether to sign

the treaty, some of our experts' view was that it should not be signed. The issue was reported to Dr. Velayati, who presented it in a meeting of the Supreme National Security Council in the news segment of the meeting, and the Council—guided by the deep and discerning perspectives of the Leader and the late Ayatollah Hashemi Rafsanjani—had decided that the treaty should be signed by Iran, our expert critique notwithstanding.

The day after the Council's meeting, Dr. Velayati raised a point more crucial and beyond our expert considerations: we were not pursuing nuclear weapons, so why should we oppose the ban on nuclear testing? Why should the country be unnecessarily subjected to accusations? It was a deep and sound observation. He instructed me to go to New York and sign the treaty on behalf of the Islamic Republic of Iran.

Here, the statesmen, seeing the larger picture, had arrived at a conclusion different from that of some of the experts. The statesmen were correct; we experts had become caught up in minutiae and failed to see the bigger picture. This was one example illustrating that an expert must present his perspective and the results of his research without hesitation or self-censorship; but at the same time, he must accept that higher-level decision-makers will take the final decision after weighing a range of considerations—some of which the expert may not even be aware of. Therefore, an expert cannot, in the execution phase, act solely within the confines of his own expert opinion; he must implement the decision of the higher authority.

After the end of the late Ayatollah Hashemi's administration and the beginning of the Reformist administration, in the new composition of the Supreme National Security Council, objections were raised by the then Ministry of Defense concerning the treaty—based on the views of one or two university professors—and, to my complete astonishment, the MFA was accused of having signed the treaty without permission. After Dr. Velayati left the post of Minister, a group from the opposing political faction sought to place responsibility for the “unauthorized” signature upon him. This was the height of unfairness, for Dr. Velayati had acted not on his own opinion but in accordance with the correct directive of the Supreme National Security Council.

The only documents proving our position were in the Secretariat's possession; yet for nearly two years, they refrained from confirming that the signing of the treaty had been approved by the Council. The justification was that the CTBT item had never been on the Council's formal agenda during Ayatollah Hashemi's administration. This, procedurally speaking, was accurate; yet it was inconsistent with the Council's actual practice. In the Supreme National Security Council, many decisions are taken under the first agenda item—"news". An item may remain for months on the Council's official agenda without ever being reviewed, because the news segment includes many important developments that most of the Council's discussions take place under that section, and decisions are made there. This practice is neither in conformity with the procedural rules nor the optimal method for addressing the country's vital issues. Special sessions should be held for major developments—but such instances are rare. The same applies in the Cabinet: the first item on every agenda is news. Many decisions are taken in this section. When the time comes to review the official agenda items, it may be the closing moments of the Cabinet meeting, and decisions on the formal agenda items are taken at the end. This is not particularly unusual.

The CTBT case became a major headache for the Legal and International Affairs Department. The group I mentioned earlier—one of whose members was later executed on espionage charges—constantly wrote against our "arbitrary decision" to sign the CTBT and to establish a CTBT seismic monitoring station in Charan¹⁸. That was an extremely bitter experience from those days. It left us with a sense of grievance toward the government and the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council. Perhaps for the same reason, I accepted the post of Representative to New York in order to escape domestic pressures, though my heart was attached to remaining in Tehran near my mother.

It may be hard to believe today, but in the late 1990s, the anti-CTBT campaign was orchestrated by the reformists—albeit with the backing of the usual hardline factions. Contrary to popular belief, I have never

¹⁸ A case in point was the frontpage headline by Kayhan daily newspaper "Here is Charan; Let's go to CTBT" on 23 April 2002; however, it recanted its story a day after.

belonged to the reformist camp; indeed, for more than half of my forty years of service, I was under pressure from the left due to my views. Over the past two decades, I have been targeted by the right-wing faction known as “principlists” for the very same positions. Thus, I have never had factional affiliation, nor relied on the support of one group or another. I hope that my heart has truly been with the people and the interests of the country; otherwise, surely my life would have been spent in vain. Here I can refer to a verse of poem called *The Gambler*, by Molana:

Blessed is the gambler who lost all he had,
Yet nothing remained for him but the desire to gamble again.

In the end, as predicted, after two or three years, Dr. Rouhani acknowledged that Dr. Velayati had raised the matter in the news section of the Supreme National Security Council’s meeting, and the late Ayatollah Hashemi had summed up the debate concluding that the treaty should be signed. But by then circumstances had changed; with the nuclear issue turning into a public controversy, the reformists had reversed their position.

When the nuclear issue was securitized in the summer of 2003, many of the warnings we had raised over the previous years—dismissed at the time as “capitulation”—were realized. After the IAEA’s September 2003 resolution and the letter from the foreign ministers of the three EU countries, Dr. Rouhani—who had been appointed to lead the nuclear portfolio at the Foreign Ministry’s suggestion—asked Dr. Kharrazi to have me join the nuclear negotiation team from New York and take charge of the negotiating team. He conducted the negotiations with prudence, made strategic and selfless decisions, and stood courageously against all pressures of the time, fully supporting the negotiating team at great political cost to himself. The same was true during the JCPOA talks—he led the process wisely and backed the negotiators with courage.

When Dr. Rouhani was elected president, I proposed that he should personally lead the nuclear negotiations. However, with magnanimity, he entrusted the responsibility to the Foreign Ministry and managed the process wisely until the end, supporting us with bravery and selflessness. Every member of the negotiating team is indebted to his support.

Yet despite his kindness toward myself and a number of other senior foreign ministry diplomats, his view of the foreign ministry was never positive. In most cases, senior officials outside the foreign ministry do not have good relations with it, and this is truly a fundamental challenge. I believe the reason is that the foreign ministry holds responsibility abroad, and heads of other agencies resent this, seeing the ministry's opposition to certain meetings or trips not as constructive coordination but as obstruction.

The truth must be told, even if it reflects poorly on the minister or the ministry. At times, in giving opinions to other agencies, the foreign ministry does not intend to help. Sometimes an officer or official, without good reason, simply rejects a proposal in order to avoid the consequences of approving it and creating trouble for themselves. Bureaucracies have their own logic: if an officer approves an official's trip or action, they must repeatedly coordinate, take on additional burdens, and there is no guarantee the trip or action will succeed or even be beneficial, yet the officer will never get the credit but is always held accountable. Thus, officers are often reluctant to endorse the programs of officials outside the ministry, which in turn fuels mistrust and resentment.

This is a general challenge that afflicts the country's entire bureaucracy. Getting something done not only entails difficulty but also brings consequences. One must answer to multiple higher authorities, and the possibility of facing oversight bodies—even a form of trial—cannot be ruled out. The officer who issues a permit is ultimately held responsible, whereas higher ranks or oversight bodies rarely hold an employee to account for inaction. As a result, facilitating the public's affairs in administrative bodies has shifted from being a duty to being seen as a favor—creating all manner of corruption-prone outcomes.

In any case, the foreign ministry's ties to the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council are extensive. Three agencies intersect with the foreign ministry abroad: the ministry of intelligence, the Quds Force, and the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council. There have always been tensions among them, and one should not expect that the staff or even leaders of the Intelligence Ministry, the SNSC, and the Quds Force will always have cordial relations with the Foreign Ministry. Such

challenges are not unique to Iran—they exist in other countries too. For example, in the United States there has long been friction between the CIA and the State Department, and between the National Security Council and the State Department. The tensions during the tenures of Henry Kissinger and Zbigniew Brzezinski as National Security Advisors are well known, and such frictions have persisted in other administrations as well. In particular, when the Secretary of the SNSC is a strong and capable figure, these tensions become more fundamental.

Dr. Rouhani, having held senior positions related to foreign relations from the beginning of the Revolution and having served as SNSC Secretary for sixteen years, held a negative view of the Foreign Ministry's bureaucracy. He believed that most of our embassies were inactive, that our diplomats should perform better, or that the Foreign Ministry's School of International Relations was ineffective and that diplomats should be recruited from among graduates of the University of Tehran or other top universities.

In many respects, his views were correct: perhaps Foreign Ministry diplomats had indeed become accustomed to playing it safe—because in this way, an officer or manager preserve their own reputation. But we must ask deeper, structural questions: if we believe our diplomats are risk-averse and overly focused on securing assignments, what have we done to make them so dependent on foreign postings? What have we done that discourages them from expressing their opinions? What has happened to the diplomat whose only concern is to survive their time in the headquarters unscathed, so they can secure their next assignment without stepping on anyone's toes in the meantime? We must take an organizational, systemic view and ask what we have done to our diplomats. A look at the pressures and forty-year challenges faced by the “smiling yet heavy-hearted minister¹⁹” is enough to dissuade any Foreign Ministry officer from “another gamble” and to persuade them to “choose the path of safety.”

Flee from me, lest you too fall into calamity,

Choose the path of safety, and forsake the road to peril.²⁰

¹⁹ A phrase used by a senior ambassador in reference to me.

²⁰ Rumi

As Foreign Minister, I was in a complex and difficult position: I had to manage the Ministry, safeguard its achievements, and at the same time avoid a direct clash with a president who held such views of the institution. On several occasions, Dr. Rouhani suggested that we recruit 200 top University of Tehran students, train them for a year, and if they could not be sent as ambassadors, assign them as deputy heads of missions. It was an excellent proposal. But on the one hand, finding 200 top University of Tehran students who could pass the Ministry's vetting process was impossible, especially since the vetting process is beyond the Foreign Minister's control. Many would pass the entrance exam because they were outstanding, but a large number would still be disqualified during vetting. On the other hand, such a move would destabilize the Ministry from within, and no head of the institution could go along with it. An internal corps that is demoralized, hopeless, unmotivated, and resentful—especially in an agency whose staff have the most contact with the outside world—creates profound security vulnerabilities.

Moreover, given his three decades of continuous work with the Foreign Ministry and his direct observation of the deep-rooted problems of bureaucracy, as outlined earlier, Dr. Rouhani believed there was no need for the Foreign Ministry to coordinate other agencies' foreign relations—mere notification to the Ministry was sufficient, and in many cases, even that did not happen.

Resignations

From the outset, I felt no inclination toward accepting the ministry, nor did I have a need to stay, and on several occasions matters reached the point of resignation. None of these reasons were personal; rather, they were either to preserve the identity of the MFA or to show that the situation had become intolerable. The foreign minister was highly visible in domestic and foreign media and in global relations; yet the ministry itself was under considerable pressure, and its influence in dealings with other institutions had been reduced to the bare minimum. In the forty-year period from when I began my career as a local employee in 1982 until

my roles as advisor, ambassador, deputy, and eventually minister, never had the MFA been under such pressure from all directions.

The first time I came close to resigning was during the president's first trip to New York in 2013. Some of the president's advisors, without coordination, had tried to turn the meeting between the foreign ministers of the P51+ and Iran into a summit of heads of state. At that point, of the heads of state, only Obama was still in New York, while the rest of the delegations were headed by foreign ministers. This move would have completely undermined all the planning we had done for the nuclear talks, which had been in preparation for a long time. Our intention was to correct the level at which the nuclear negotiations were conducted. In the past, the secretary of Iran's Supreme National Security Council negotiated with deputy ministers or even directors-general from the other side—neither dignified for Iran's foreign minister to engage with a deputy or director-general of the counterpart's foreign ministry, nor equal and proper in terms of negotiation strategy. It was not merely a matter of ceremonial inequality; when a minister negotiated with a deputy or director-general, the content of the talks was also affected: after extensive bargaining and agreement, the other side could simply respond that "our minister did not agree." To prevent this, we had planned that the minister would only negotiate with ministers, while the deputy ministers would conduct the other meetings with their counterparts. To start this new approach and put an end to the improper practice of previous terms, we had agreed that the talks would begin with a ministerial meeting in New York. But suddenly, we saw that some of the president's advisors, without consulting either with me or even the president, had gone in another direction—putting the president in front of the ministers—which upended all our careful planning. In reaction to this move and the interference of the advisors, I came close to resigning. The two-year process of negotiations later proved how critical the presence of Secretary Kerry and other ministers was in bringing the JCPOA to fruition.

The next episode came in late March 2014, when we were about to head to Vienna for nuclear talks. Before the trip, we discovered internal obstruction from within the cabinet itself against the negotiations. Under such conditions, talks would have been impossible. A proposal

regarding the country's minimal nuclear needs had been sent to the national leadership without any coordination with the MFA—effectively condemning the talks to failure in advance. At the same time, Baroness Ashton had visited Iran and her meeting with a group of women had stirred controversy. The deputy of one of the ministries wrote a false report about that meeting and sent it to the leadership in order to exonerate his own institution and portray the MFA as being at fault, even though, in truth, no wrongdoing had occurred.

On the other hand, despite all the assistance the Geneva Interim Agreement had provided to the state treasury—placing over \$600 million in cash at the government's disposal each month, the budget of the MFA was so meagerly allocated that it was not even possible to pay the March salaries of that year. Before heading to the airport, I wrote a cordial two-page letter to Dr. Rouhani and I stated that after this trip and these negotiations, I would no longer be the foreign minister, and I requested that, in the meantime, he consider appointing a new minister. I placed the letter in my handbag so it could be delivered to the president's office by one of my security guards. After boarding the plane, I suddenly remembered that I had not delivered the letter to my ground security detail. I told myself that it was God's will that this action should not take place and thus this was the second resignation that never became public.

The third instance came after my complaint regarding the neglect by other ministries of the fundamental imperatives of foreign policy—particularly with respect to the lack of coordination in relations with Russia—which had rendered the duties of the foreign minister impossible. It should be noted that the MFA had in fact intervened to support relations with Russia.

Another occasion was over the visit of Bashar al-Assad in March 2019, which stirred significant controversy. Two individuals were eager to exploit the absence of Iran's foreign minister to their own advantage: Pompeo and Netanyahu; both immediately tweeted with undisguised delight. Assad's visit to Iran had, from the outset, been arranged in coordination between me and Martyr Soleimani. We had agreed on the plan together, and I had also coordinated with the president to extend the invitation and make the visit possible. For certain reasons, the trip did not take place

on the originally scheduled date, and Assad eventually came to Iran on a different date. But the “smiling-lipped yet heartbroken minister” was kept unaware of the visit. I first learned of it from news websites and then saw it on national television.

What was remarkable was that in all of the Leader’s private meetings, only a photograph of the Leader with the foreign guest was ever released. In Assad’s meeting with the Leader and the president, however, photographs were broadcasted showing all those present, making it plainly evident that the foreign minister was absent. This mischief had been devised within a particular circle—not in the Leader’s office, not in the president’s office, and not connected to late General Soleimani. Upon seeing the way the news had been disseminated, it was clear that no one in the world would henceforth regard the foreign minister of the Islamic Republic as having any real standing; at best, he would be considered merely the country’s media spokesperson. Regrettably, following the United States’ imposition of sanctions on me, certain statements revealed that some powerful domestic centers only recognized precisely that limited role for the foreign minister.

For me, as foreign minister, there were always two options. The first was to construct, as some officials do, a dual image abroad—that I was an enlightened and trustworthy figure seeking engagement with the world, but that there was also an opposing internal faction pursuing its own policies. The second option—which I adhered to throughout my tenure—was to affirm that the foreign policy of the Islamic Republic was unified, and that both the foreign minister and the commander of the Quds Force were implementing the same policy.

Never before had anyone in the realm of foreign policy spoken in this way, openly associating themselves with the events and policies from which others sought to distance themselves. I might have agreed or disagreed with a given policy, but in any case, I was the representative of the country’s entire foreign policy and could not selectively choose my positions. Had I adopted the first approach, this visit would have served as the perfect demonstration that I had nothing to do with Assad. It is even possible that such a narrative might have earned me the Nobel Prize—since for two consecutive years I was a leading nominee for the

Peace Prize²¹. But for issues such as Syria, the award was not given to me, nor even to other non-Iranian participants in the JCPOA negotiations. Of course, this may well have been a hidden blessing from God, because otherwise certain quarters would have stirred a commotion had I received the Prize, accusing me of serving the interest of “global arrogance” and thus being qualified for it.

After hearing the news, I sent two messages to two individuals in the Leader’s office and one message to the president’s office, stating that from this point onward, continuing my work would be impossible. Although I do not often resort to an *istikhara* (consulting the Quran), because of the consequences of such a decision I asked a respected figure in Isfahan to perform one. At 11:30, I received only one reply from the message recipients, stating, “It will be made up to you in the next trip, and Mr. Bashar al-Assad is very eager to see you.” Without receiving a response about my *istikhara* and for the first time, I publicly announced my resignation on my Instagram page. At midnight, the *istikhara* reply finally arrived: “It is very good; do it without delay.” With that confirmation, I also prepared a resignation letter and sent it to the president.

That night, I did not sleep at all, and the following day I did not go to the office. The Prime Minister of Armenia was scheduled to visit Iran, and my absence from that meeting would have given the resignation global visibility. On Wednesday morning, Martyr Soleimani called and said, “We all consider you responsible for foreign policy, and it is clear that this incident was a matter of miscoordination.” I replied that such words have no place in a private conversation; they belong in the newspapers. The resignation had not been due to personal offense, but because it was no longer possible to function on the world stage in the position of Iran’s foreign minister. Martyr Soleimani immediately gave an interview and made this point publicly. A few days later, he came to the Ministry’s Institute for Political and International Studies for our weekly meeting—wearing his military uniform—and said, “Take a photo and release it.”

²¹ <https://www.bloomberg.com/politics/articles/2017-10-01/derided-by-trump-iran-nuclear-deal-may-fetch-nobel-peace-prize> <https://www.prio.org/news/2200>

For the president, however, making a public announcement seemed more difficult. The Armenian Prime Minister was enroute to the Sa'dabad Palace. From the president's office came the message that "the text you wanted is being prepared." At Sa'dabad Palace, I sat waiting in the car for the president's statement to be issued. After it was released, I attended the welcoming ceremony.

Another resignation took place in November 2019 after the petroleum price protests, and the final one concerned our diplomatic efforts to defeat the United States' attempt to reinstate UN Security Council resolutions against Iran in the summer and autumn of 2020. Despite all the MFA's efforts, certain officials were unwilling to provide even the smallest measure of cooperation. Yet the world saw that, as a result of our extensive diplomatic work, Europe stood with us, and the United States was defeated 13 to 2 in the Security Council and 110 to 10 in the UN General Assembly. Even Russia and China—although there was no procedural need for a veto or a negative vote—voted against, ensuring America's defeat at the Security Council. Russia, through our efforts, had also once vetoed a Yemen-related resolution—something unprecedented in post-revolutionary relations between Iran and Russia. These two achievements were not won easily. Prior to that, in the Board of Governors, Russia and China had for the first time both voted against a European resolution.

President Putin had made a proposal which, in the view of the MFA, should have been handled diplomatically²². In the Supreme National Security Council (SNSC) and in the Cabinet, the proposal was rejected with a very harsh objection from the President, which was insulting to the Ministry and to the foreign minister. After that, I requested to be excused from attending cabinet meetings, but the request was denied.

With all these grievances, none of the challenges or difficulties were resolved. What Martyr Soleimani did in this matter only pushed the concern back slightly and reduced its intensity, though it did not resolve it. Out of friendship with him, I did not insist further on my resignation, although

²² The interesting point is that on two occasions, my decision to resign was due to differences of view over Russia, in both of which I favored ties with Russia. I lay emphasis on this point because my detailed explanation about Russia's vision of Iran would not mean opposition to Russia; rather, it means expanded ties with Russia with open eyes.

the manner of Assad's visit was in no way justifiable. Many believe that my return after resigning that night was a grave mistake. Perhaps they are right, and had I not returned, my prestige would have remained intact. But was that prestige mine? The prestige belonged to the people, and it had to be spent for their sake.

Relations with the Judiciary

From my tenure as Deputy for Legal and International Affairs and as Permanent Representative to the United Nations, I have always maintained professional engagement with the Judiciary. The most prominent field of divergence with the Judiciary concerned human rights and the surrounding challenges—a domain rendered profoundly complex by intellectual, doctrinal, religious, legal, administrative, and judicial considerations. This also encompassed cases involving Iranians abroad or dual nationals, such as imprisoned dual nationals or Iranian detainees held overseas. These were matters that required a non-politicized humanitarian approach and extensive and delicate efforts behind the scenes. Respectful relations with the Judiciary were not founded on similarity of perspectives; rather, they were grounded in mutual respect and dialogue, despite fundamental differences in outlook.

The human rights dossier, beyond its intrinsic value from a humanitarian and ethical standpoint, is pivotal for two reasons directly tied to Iran's national security. First, there is hardly any issue that can tarnish the Islamic Republic's reputation abroad and in the global public opinion as severely and as irreparably as human rights. Other issues lack the power to mobilize world opinion. For example, while nuclear allegations may cast a state as a security threat in the eyes of other governments, human rights concerns strike at the legitimacy of a government not just among other states, but among the people of the world.

Second, the foremost imperative for Iran's national security lies in safeguarding human rights, for the people are the foundational support of this country. Without the people, there would be neither the Sacred Defense nor resistance in the face of sanctions. Iran has no external backers, nor is it a military dictatorship that might imagine it could survive without

its people and through sheer force of repression. Thus, respecting the rights of the populace is not only a moral, humanitarian, and religious obligation, but also a fundamental necessity for national security.

On a personal and professional level, since my college years I have been a student of human rights. From the early 1990s, I have been among the first instructors to teach courses such as Human Rights in International Relations, the International Human Rights System in Iran, and Human Rights and Global Politics at the master's and doctoral levels at the Faculty of Law and Political Science, University of Tehran, and the School of International Relations of the MFA. Accordingly, I have long been a critic of many policies and practices in the field of human rights.

One key difference between my own perspective and that of certain security officials is that I consider the Islamic Republic far too resilient to be threatened by verbal or written criticism from opponents or by lawful civil protests. As the unrest of 2022 demonstrated, tolerance toward dissenting views strengthens both the leadership and the country, whereas intolerance of criticism only weakens them. This is a fundamental divergence in governance philosophy between me and many officials in the country. In the early 1990s, during a meeting between the International Affairs Department and several judicial officials and academics, I remarked that the strength of the Islamic Republic lay in the fact that, statistically, sixty percent of Revolutionary Court verdicts were overturned on appeal. I argued that this fact should be presented to the world, for the world often perceives the Revolutionary Court as a kind of field tribunal where a person is brought in bound, accused of a crime, sentenced, and executed on the spot. One attendee—now deceased—countered that such a statistic was a sign of weakness, and that appellate courts should affirm one hundred percent of verdicts. It was evident that we were speaking in entirely different universes.

In an Islamic system of justice, rulings must be based on fairness. It is related that Imam Jafar al-Sadiq- the sixth Shia Imam (peace be upon him) said that a judge renders judgment in four ways, three of which lead to Hell: knowing the truth but ruling unjustly; not knowing the truth and ruling unjustly; not knowing the truth but ruling justly. Only knowing the truth and ruling justly constitutes acceptable judgment. This is the

Islamic model of adjudication—one that would merit full affirmation. But in a state where judges are not infallible, one cannot make such absolute pronouncements. Thus, a fundamental difference in perspectives toward human rights persisted.

Another sphere of cooperation—and at times divergence—between the MFA and the Judiciary was the Human Rights Headquarters. This body could have supported the foreign policy apparatus in addressing domestic human rights cases. The Ministry has its foreign responsibilities; ideally, the Headquarters should have served as the mechanism whereby the Ministry could refer cases—such as allegations of human rights violations, the rights of Iranians abroad, or issues facing dual nationals—to be pursued internally within the Judiciary by this body. This is the natural mandate of such an institution and is consistent with the principle of separation of powers. Yet, during the Ahmadinejad administrations, the Headquarters claimed authority over human rights both domestically and internationally—an overt encroachment upon the functions of the executive branch and the MFA, and a violation of the separation of powers. Under the Rouhani Administration, we objected in the Supreme National Security Council to the Judiciary's interpretation of one of the Council's resolutions, but to no avail.

Cases involving dual nationals had multiple dimensions, with not only the Judiciary but also the Ministry of Intelligence and the IRGC's Intelligence Organization involved. Most dual national detainees faced espionage charges. The MFA pursued such cases through the Supreme National Security Council and its Secretariat. A noteworthy episode bears recalling here: the Council had approved the simultaneous exchange of all dual national and Western prisoners in Iran for all Iranian prisoners accused of sanctions violations or similar charges in the United States and Europe. Accordingly, during a speech at the Council on Foreign Relations in New York, I presented this proposal. Opponents of the Islamic Republic had dispatched several individuals to the meeting to raise the issue of dual national and American prisoners to provoke a confrontation. However, by announcing readiness for a comprehensive exchange, their attempt was thwarted. Days later, the Judiciary's new spokesperson declared: "The Foreign Minister has no authority in this matter." At the Supreme National

Security Council meeting, the new head of the Judiciary was reminded that the Foreign Minister's statement was, in fact, in line with the Council's resolution. But in the Islamic Republic, no one apologizes—perhaps reserving all explanations for the hereafter.

Preserving individuals' dignity, safeguarding the honor of families, and even protecting the livelihoods of those who encounter administrative troubles are essential, so that the fabric of families is not torn apart. Belief in the afterlife should be the foremost deterrent against violating people's rights. I recall a telling anecdote: between my tenure in New York and my ministerial appointment, I had a student who was also a seminary cleric. Once he asked, "Why do you not run for Parliament?" I replied, "Because I fear for my afterlife—I fear being complicit in legislation that may be a burden and a sin upon me." He responded, "You've already lost that—don't worry about it!"

In that seemingly light satire lay a profound and serious concern: without regard for the next world, those who hold such positions may find themselves losers in both realms. For if one has no intention of exploiting power and domestic connections for personal gain, public office brings no worldly benefit. From the beginning of the Revolution, I have relied on the financial support of my parents, and after their passing, on their inheritance. Without it, I might well have never had the financial ability to purchase an apartment and may still be renting my residence today. During my years in office, I sold their gifts and parts of that inheritance—often below market value—to maintain a decent and honest livelihood, to the point that little of that significant estate remains today. I have no complaint; this was the chosen path for myself and my family. Yet, without vigilance and exacting care in upholding the rights and needs of the people, a public official truly becomes a loser in both worlds²³. In national decision-making, the error of a single official can inflict harm upon eighty million Iranians—and perhaps many more abroad. Thus, despite all the challenges, I still consider myself indebted to the people.

²³ "And there are some who worship Allah on the verge 'of faith': if they are blessed with something good, they are content with it; but if they are afflicted with a trial, they relapse 'into disbelief',¹ losing this world and the Hereafter. That is 'truly' the clearest loss." (The Quran, 22:11)

If we look closely, this burden rests on the shoulders of every single civil servant and all government agencies. I often reminded colleagues: the salaries you receive, however small in comparison to foreign counterparts, are drawn from the sweat of workers; from the pockets of the homeless and destitute. Before they complained that their salary was half that of experts in a poor country, I told them: I, too, have been an ambassador, an expert, and even a local employee. I know your salaries are low. But remember—every single dollar you receive comes from the pocket of those homeless people on the streets.

The Human Rights Record

It may be appropriate here to address the defense of Iran's human rights condition abroad—a matter that often arises as one of the most frequently heard challenges and questions. What is clear is that, as in many other countries, the degree of respect for human rights in the Islamic Republic of Iran leaves ample room for criticism. Moreover, such a state of affairs is unworthy of a government that bears the name of the first Shia Imam; Imam Ali (peace be upon him) and every effort should be made to improve the human rights situation. It must be re-emphasized that adherence to human rights is not merely a moral and religious necessity but also a national security imperative, for the people are the greatest pillar of national security, sovereignty, and territorial integrity in Iran.

From the Qur'anic perspective, the people are considered the primary foundation of governance, and the method of securing their support is explicitly described as kindness toward them. In the verses following verse 55 of Sura al-Anfal (8:55)—which concerns dealing with those who break treaties and the necessity of preparing military capabilities for deterrence—God commands the Prophet (peace be upon him) that if such treacherous disbelievers incline toward peace, he should also incline toward peace. The subsequent verses beautifully address the possibility of renewed treachery and the means of removing such fear, highlighting the central role of the people, rather than weaponry or resources:

And if they intend to deceive you—then sufficient for you is Allah.

It is He who supported you with His help and with the believers

(62). And He brought their hearts together. If you had spent all that is on the earth, you could not have brought their hearts together; but Allah brought them together. Indeed, He is Exalted in Might and Wise (63). O Prophet, sufficient for you is Allah and those who follow you of the believers (64).

Thus, from a Qur'anic viewpoint, the most valuable support for governance and the foremost deterrent against the treachery of pact-breakers—after reliance upon God—is the people. The method for gaining this support is also stated plainly in the Holy Qur'an. In verse 159 of Sura Ale Imran (3:159), God the Merciful addresses the Prophet, describing kindness and respect toward the people as the means of fostering solidarity, and harshness and severity toward them as causes of the disintegration of the community:

So, by mercy from Allah, you were gentle with them. And if you had been harsh and hard-hearted, they would have dispersed from around you. So, pardon them and ask forgiveness for them and consult them in the matter²⁴.

The Qur'an thus goes beyond treating respect for human rights merely as a legal necessity for societal cohesion; it not only regards the iron-fist policy toward the people—even for the Prophet of God—as a source of weakness, but also urges forgiveness in this world, intercession for their afterlife, and consultation with them in decision-making. In other words, it advances beyond legal obligation toward a policy of benevolence and magnanimity.

Accordingly, respect for human rights is a religious, rational, and strategic obligation. Yet, the human rights controversy on the global stage is another matter entirely. From long ago, political and legal writings, as well as debates in international human rights fora, have recognized the abuse of human rights for advancing political ends as one of the principal challenges to genuine global promotion of human rights. Because few accusations can so effectively undermine the legitimacy of governments

²⁴ The Quran, 3:159

and leaders in public opinion as allegations of human rights violations, such claims have long been among the most potent tools in diplomacy, particularly public diplomacy.

Accusations of human rights violations in international fora have invariably served the policies of the accusers, rather than the defense of people's rights. In other words, the very governments that raise the loudest outcry in global fora and public pronouncements over alleged human rights abuses in countries like Iran are often those that, at some point, were themselves the worst violators of the rights of minorities and indigenous peoples within their own borders, and they have been the principal backers of oppressive regimes both in the past and the present. A glance at the voting records of the UN General Assembly and the Human Rights Council on systematic human rights violations in apartheid-era South Africa and in present-day Israel reveals that countries such as Canada have consistently supported the violators.

The conduct of Western governments toward Saudi Arabia following the brutal murder of Jamal Khashoggi—and their ongoing support for the slaughter of women and children in Gaza, coupled with their shameful opposition to Security Council resolutions that merely sought to halt war and the merciless killing of women, children, and the elderly—strips these governments of any credibility in claiming to defend human rights. It is therefore evident that their invocation of human rights in Iran is not in defense of the Iranian people but in pursuit of political objectives. The net result of these claims has been the intensification of sanctions to the detriment of the Iranian people. Decades of scholarly research²⁵ and field studies have shown that sanctions never punish the rulers; rather, as recent years have starkly demonstrated, it is the people—especially the most vulnerable—who bear the brunt of these so-called human rights pressures.

The protection of human rights must take place within the country, not outside it and certainly not in deference to such false claimants of support for human rights. That said, the manner of confronting human rights accusations abroad remains an ethical challenge for any practitioner

²⁵ In 1982, I wrote my master's dissertation on "Sanctions in International Relations" and I have since pursued the issue of sanctions from both academic and executive perspectives.

of foreign policy—one that must be managed with full consideration of all dimensions, balancing aspiration with realities.

Relations with Parliament

Relations with Parliament encompassed several dimensions: interactions with the Speaker of the Parliament as an individual, engagement with the institution of Parliament as a whole, and relations with the National Security Commission. Over the eight years of my tenure as Minister, relations with Parliament were never good. For several reasons, these relations remained fraught and tense. From the very first day in office, efforts were made to establish constructive dialogue with the members of Parliament. Upon returning from the President's first trip to New York, I held a frank and forthright conversation with the representatives regarding the highs and lows of that visit. I reminded them—several times—that our discussion was not for the media. The next day, the same content appeared in one of the newspapers, distorted and slanted, with one manipulated statement even becoming the paper's front-page headline. This inappropriate and unethical conduct inflicted such psychological pressure upon the “smiling-faced yet anguished” Minister that it led to chronic back pain, which persists to this day.

This incident occurred at the outset of the negotiations leading to the Geneva interim agreement. One round of talks had been held at UN Headquarters in New York, and the next round was to be conducted at the UN's European headquarters in Geneva. The nerve strain in my back muscles had pressed upon the sciatic nerve, impairing my ability to walk. As a result, I was compelled, on one or two occasions during the first round of the Geneva talks, to attend in a wheelchair. Even this became a source of harassment from certain representatives, who declared that “the Minister's wheelchair has undermined the dignity of the nation.” No one considered that the Minister was attending meetings in pain from start to finish yet refusing to abandon national imperatives and interests. Instead of gratitude or sympathy, there were barbed remarks that the dignity of the nation had been diminished.

Following this episode and the experience of having my words turned into newspaper headlines, I reached an understanding with the Chairman of the National Security Commission that the discussions in our meetings would remain confidential, and that only the commission's spokesperson would issue a brief summary to the press. Yet one representative objected to the Chairman, insisting that he would speak to the media about whatever he deemed expedient. I replied that in that case, they should not expect anything beyond what we were prepared to have published to be said in Commission sessions. Consequently, certain remarks in the Commission were deliberately framed with the understanding that we wanted the United States to hear them—since some representatives routinely gave interviews to media outlets, revealing the content of our sessions. This fundamental difficulty persisted until the end of the administration across the ninth, tenth, and eleventh parliaments. Various measures, including holding meetings outside the Commission's offices, proved ineffective, and inaccurate, damaging reports from those sessions continued to surface in interviews.

In both sessions and interviews, numerous unfounded accusations were leveled against the MFA and the Minister personally. Responding to some of them would require disclosing classified information. Certain representatives would then ask rhetorically, "Are the people not to be trusted?"—a blatant populist ploy, since in the age of globalized communications, one cannot choose one's audience. In the midst of negotiations with foreign parties, openly revealing negotiating strategies and tactics would mean that the other side would hear them as well, adapt accordingly, and thus neutralize the country's position.

Another difficulty arose from the Parliament's own internal rules of procedure: when a representative questions a Minister, the representative has the last word after all of the Minister's responses. The stated purpose is for the representative, after hearing the Minister's reply, to declare whether he or she is satisfied, or whether the matter should go to a vote. Under these self-adopted rules—clearly in Parliament's own favor—the Commission first presents its report, then the Minister speaks, then the questioning representative replies, then the Minister responds again, and finally the representative announces satisfaction or dissatisfaction. But

the rules also allow the representative, at that last stage, to say whatever they wish, instead of simply stating “yes” or “no.” As a result, politically motivated representatives would speak very briefly in the first round, saving all their allotted time for the second round, during which they could say whatever they want, while the Minister has no further opportunity to respond or defend himself. Many questions in open session followed exactly this pattern, leaving no chance for rebuttal.

Although it was widely believed that most candidates for the tenth Parliament had won their seats under the banner of supporting the JCPOA and moderation, opposition members ensured that confrontational relations with that Parliament would also persist. I, as the foreign minister, faced the highest number of formal questions in open session of the plenary. From June 2016 to June 2020, twenty-four questions were put to me and answered in the open sessions of the plenary. In the history of Iran, no Foreign Minister had ever been required to respond to so many questions in open session. Many more questions were asked and answered in the National Security Commission. Some questions were consolidated together for open session, but most went to vote, after the questioner declared dissatisfaction with my response. None of those motions in the tenth Parliament managed to secure a majority of votes against me. Yet creating a hostile atmosphere in the nationally broadcast plenary requires no majority, only a small group of representatives can throw the entire floor of the chamber into a commotion, even when the majority disagrees. After nearly an hour of chaos and accusations, the session would end with a one-minute announcement that “the question did not pass,” and that would be the end of it. Some questions were brought before the open session of plenary twice, even three times. A question posed by one representative and answered would be repeated—by slightly rewording it—by another. Then they would complain that the “smiling-faced yet anguished” Minister’s answers were repetitive, as if it were possible to invent entirely new responses to identical questions.

At the beginning of the 11th Parliament, two questions were brought to the plenary floor, and, as expected given its anti-JCPOA and anti-government makeup, in both cases the Parliament declared itself unsatisfied and issued “yellow cards” against me. After that, although

dozens of questions remained on the agenda, none were ever brought to open session—otherwise, I would undoubtedly have set the record for the most “yellow cards” ever issued to a Foreign Minister.

Another difficulty concerned the participation of Members of Parliament in the Foreign Minister’s overseas trips²⁶. Most ministers—and even some lower-ranking officials—take along one or more parliament representative on both domestic and foreign trips. I had no personal objection to this practice, because anyone who accompanied me on foreign visits could attest that, despite the smiles, my conduct was firm, grounded in self-confidence and dignity, while also marked by reason and the subtleties of diplomacy.

Theatrical Diplomacy

A fundamental challenge lies in failing to distinguish between genuine diplomacy and theatrical diplomacy or diplomacy for show. The proper method of negotiation is one in which the other party can trust that the discussion will not be exploited for media purposes, and that the goal is to reach a substantive outcome. Of course, it may be that the aim of both sides—or of one side alone—in a meeting, conversation, or telephone call is merely to derive media advantage. In such a case, one should expect no other result from the exchange²⁷. Diplomacy for show has its uses under certain circumstances. But if every meeting and negotiation serves solely for publicity, sensational announcements, and one-sided, triumphalist proclamations, little of genuine diplomacy remains. From this perspective, at the conclusion of negotiations, I would refrain from speaking publicly of any achievements or concessions obtained. Contrary to the long-standing practice of offering the press a one-sided account of gains, after negotiations I would limit myself to a brief, general report to journalists. Naturally, a full and detailed record of all discussions was always submitted to the country’s leadership.

²⁶ Annex II lists my foreign visits.

²⁷ The most important exception to this principle is “blame game” which would be reviewed in the following sections.

A painful yet instructive example of the damage caused by the prevailing method of showcase diplomacy occurred during my first meeting with President Putin, on my trip to Moscow in the winter of 2013. During that visit, a member of the ninth Parliament accompanied me. Together, we met with President Putin. Under Putin's protocol, meetings with foreign ministers are not customary—except in the case of the foreign ministers of the permanent members of the UN Security Council. This particular meeting was especially productive, notably with respect to an agreement under which Russia would take delivery of Iranian oil in exchange for cash and goods. This proposal had first been raised by Iran in an earlier meeting between Presidents Rouhani and Putin, and in our meeting, Putin accepted it. After the session, however, the parliament representative disclosed the detailed outcome of the talks in an interview. The Americans promptly contacted Russia and threatened Russian companies with sanctions if the arrangement were implemented. The result of that disclosure was that an agreement that was supposed to take effect in the winter of 2013 never materialized—not even by the end of the Rouhani administration—because once the deal had been revealed and subjected to US threats, prominent Russian firms feared the consequences of sanctions.

Another example, useful for understanding the difference between publicity-driven diplomacy and goal-driven diplomacy, took place after the conclusion of the JCPOA. In a two-hour meeting with President Putin in the resort city of Sochi, he expressed Russia's willingness to invest \$50 billion in Iran's oil industry. He had instructed the head of Rosneft to join the meeting at its conclusion in order to resolve the issues that I raised. An agreement in principle was reached in Putin's presence. Yet, in the press engagements following the meeting, I made no reference to this agreement; the offer and understanding were mentioned only in the confidential report sent to the leadership.

Several months later, news of Putin's \$50 billion investment pledge surfaced following Putin's meeting with another senior official as if it were the outcome of another meeting. The Russian co-chair of the Iran–Russia Joint Commission, in an extraordinarily impertinent response, remarked: “Russia is ready to send humanitarian aid to meet the needs of the Iranian people.” In other words, diplomatic discussions are not

intended for public consumption; if they were, there would be no need for travel or face-to-face meetings; messages could simply be exchanged through public media. Moreover, given Iran's particular circumstances, the other side is generally unwilling to bear the costs of transactions with us, meaning that once an agreement becomes public, it is almost immediately nullified.

On one occasion, a senior Democratic senator in the United States had met with one of our officials. Reportedly, at the start of the meeting, the senator had criticized the then-US President. The Iranian official's entourage persuaded him to reveal this remark in the news release about the meeting, on the pretext that otherwise he would be criticized for meeting with an American senator. Sometime later, the senator's aide met with me and lodged a sharp complaint: would it be acceptable if we likewise publicized what your official said? Is this the standard practice of diplomatic dialogue?

In foreign meetings, our counterparts have learned that they must say something that will make the news. As a result, the exchange becomes meaningless and misleading. In some encounters, the other side offers nothing but criticism, knowing that if a single positive word is uttered, it will be reported. Those with prior experience in dealing with Iranians will begin with a few positive remarks about Iran's history and culture, then proceed to voice their criticisms. Such patterns have eroded trust in our foreign policy at the international level.

Ultimately, after the disclosure of the confidential conversation with President Putin by that parliament representative, we resolved that no Parliament member would accompany me on official trips abroad. I raised this matter openly and frankly with the relevant commission.

The Challenge of Protocol Status

A very interesting point is that currently in the country, perhaps more than five hundred civilian and military officials—such as 290 members of parliament—consider themselves equivalent to a minister. Representatives or other officials who see themselves as ministerial peers expect to be present at key meetings, even if it means excluding the ambassador or the

relevant deputy from the meeting. Such an action sacrifices substance for form; because the person who should handle the details of the meeting and follow up on its matters is the ambassador, the relevant deputy, or even the desk expert—not parliamentarians who have assigned themselves a ceremonial rank higher than the ambassador.

One of the country's challenges is that there is no coordination system for defining the rank of various officials. The number of officials who rank above the Minister of Foreign Affairs in formal state protocol may not be less than fifty. In contrast, in any foreign country, only the president, vice president, prime minister, and at most the deputy prime minister rank above the foreign minister. Of course, not all countries have all these positions. But in our country, there are dozens of officials equivalent to the president or vice president, which is a large number. In the Islamic Republic of Iran, the Chief of the General Staff of the Armed Forces is equivalent to the president, whereas in most countries the defense minister outranks the chief of staff. This itself becomes a challenge in foreign trips. Even the speaker of parliament and the head of the judiciary in many countries have a protocol rank lower than a minister. This is one of those seemingly trivial but highly cumbersome and challenging issues in foreign relations.

Relations with Supreme National Security Council (SNSC)

Beyond the MFA, other governance institutions play decisive roles in foreign policy. In some cases, their views may differ from those of the MFA. One group is the armed forces, encompassing the General Staff, the army, the IRGC, the police, and affiliated institutions. Another group comprises intelligence and security organizations. The duty of the Supreme National Security Council (SNSC) is to coordinate among the various institutions active in national security. Its most critical aspect concerns foreign relations. During the Rouhani Administration, this coordination was not carried out properly, and many key and vital foreign policy decisions were made by a small group within the secretariat, of which the foreign minister, as a principal member of the council, was unaware.

It may be useful to recall a few points here. The SNSC was established based on Article 176 of the Constitution, added in the 1989 revision. Paying attention to the text of Article 176 is crucial, as it indicates the constitutional perspective on national security, national interests, and the balance intended by the Constitution. The Constitution logically and reasonably defines the composition of members²⁸ based on the foundations of national security. In addition to the heads of the three branches and the representatives of the Leader—who over four decades have had differing preferences and backgrounds—five pillars of national security are equally represented in the council: military affairs represented by the Chief of the General Staff, development affairs represented by the head of the Planning and Budget Organization, foreign relations represented by the foreign minister, issues related to social cohesion represented by the interior minister, and security affairs represented by the intelligence minister. These five pillars of national interest and security are present on an equal footing to ensure that decisions affecting national security are balanced and that no pillar dominates or is sacrificed for others.

This is a comprehensive and balanced approach to national interests and security, where neither the military dimension nor other aspects dominate. Just as a military commander participates with one vote, the foreign policy official participates with an equal vote; the national cohesion

²⁸ Article 176: In order to safeguard the national interests and preserve the Islamic Revolution, the territorial integrity and national sovereignty, a Supreme Council for National Security presided over by the President shall be constituted to fulfill the following responsibilities:

¹ Determining the defense and national security policies within the framework of general policies determined by the Leader.

² Coordination of activities in the areas relating to politics, intelligence, social, cultural and economic fields in relation to general defense and security policies.

³ Employment of material and intellectual resources of the country for facing the internal and external threats.

The Council shall consist of: heads of three branches of the government, chief of the Supreme Command Council of the Armed Forces, the officer in charge of the planning and budget affairs, two representatives nominated by the Leader, ministers of foreign affairs, interior, and information, a minister related with the subject, and the highest-ranking officials from the Armed Forces and the Islamic Revolution's Guards Corps. Commensurate with its duties, the Supreme Council for National Security shall form sub councils such as Defense Sub-council and National Security Sub-council. Each Sub council will be presided over by the President or a member of the Supreme Council for National Security appointed by the President. The scope of authority and responsibility of the Sub-councils will be determined by law, and their organizational structure will be approved by the Supreme Council for National Security. The decisions of the Supreme Council for National Security shall be effective after the confirmation by the Leader.

and social security official, or interior minister, participates under the same conditions; the chief development officer or head of the Planning and Budget Organization participates similarly; the security official also has one vote equal to others. The legislator's aim was that when a policy is considered, its various dimensions and angles are taken into account. In other words, the country's fundamental policies are not determined solely by the executors of one sector. Neither the foreign minister nor the military commander can decide alone. For a decision taken by the foreign minister, the development sector has a stake, and similarly, for other areas, decision-making must be multi-faceted rather than unilateral and one-dimensional. This is the comprehensive and logical composition of the SNSC.

However, apparently from the inception of the council, the defense minister and the commanders of the army and IRGC also attended all council meetings without voting rights, even though under the Constitution they should only participate in sessions related to their organizations, just like non-member ministers: "As appropriate, the relevant minister and the highest military authority of the army and IRGC." It may be argued that observers have no voting rights. What matters in council meetings are discussions and the expression of viewpoints, in which the IRGC commander and the head of the national broadcasting organization participated even more than ministers and intervened from an advisory position. Ultimately, the president summarizes. Only in few instances where a member disagrees with the president's summary is voting conducted. Therefore, having or not having voting rights is often inconsequential.

In council meetings, all members and observers express their viewpoints. In the end, the president, as chair of the SNSC, summarizes, and that summary is sent to the Leader. If approved, it is promulgated; if corrections are needed, it is returned. Sometimes a clause may be deleted or a point sent back for review; these one or two clauses—or the entire resolution—return to the council. This is the authority that the Constitution established based on precise equality among the pivotal pillars

of national security. It seems, however, that the intended constitutional equality has been skewed in favor of the military sector²⁹.

These long-standing organizational challenges, combined with my academic and discursive perspectives, led to misinterpretations of my lecture at the University of Tehran and a fabricated tape. In response to a question at the University of Tehran in December 2013, I said: "Do you think American forces are afraid of our weapons? They are afraid of our people and their culture of resistance and sacrifice." This statement, aside from being based on internal U.S. discussions prior to the invasion of Iraq, also contained a rhetorical nuance highlighting the role of the people and the culture upon which the IRGC is founded as a popular force. Unfortunately, selective excerpts in the lecture and Q&A, coupled with unfair accusations and baseless labels, created a binary narrative that continues to be perpetuated.

The statements of the Founder of the Islamic Revolution and the numerous speeches of the Leader affirm this perspective on the people. Imam Khomeini's remarks to parliament representatives on January 24, 1983, clearly expressed this view: "Do not think that military power has preserved you; your faith and the support of the nation have. This support must be maintained. If we lose it, we will all be destroyed, and Islam will face other challenges³⁰." Similarly, the Leader's words among the people of Kerman and Khuzestan on December 24, 2023 explicitly highlight the people's role: "National unity and the strong presence of the people in the arena bring national power, and national power ensures security, which in turn provides the foundation for scientific advancement, economic prosperity, and resolving various economic, political, and cultural challenges³¹."

The second point is the need to distinguish the SNSC from its Secretariat. The Secretariat coordinates and prepares the work of the council and, except for cases delegated to it for final decision-making by the SNSC, cannot make independent decisions. Problems arise when the

²⁹ The issue of field and diplomacy in the recorded tape pertained to this problem and not the conduct expected from a field commander, which is natural and inherent.

³⁰ http://www.imam-khomeini.ir/fa/C207_43924

³¹ <https://farsi.khamenei.ir/news-content?id=54687>

Secretariat assumes final decision-making or execution. The Secretariat's role is decision-crafting, which is very valuable and central. It must examine various aspects of agenda items, meet with experts, prepare policy papers, and present it to the council for final decision. When the SNSC delegates a case to the Secretariat, it is implemented with the president's coordination and the Leader's approval, without further council review. Otherwise, the Secretariat has no executive responsibility; it is responsible for coordination. Execution lies with the relevant institutions.

At times, the Secretary of the SNSC is asked to act as the government representative or governance system. During President Khatami's administration, the MFA proposed that the nuclear dossier be assigned to the Secretariat because the ministry was outside the decision-making circle and suddenly faced a case it believed, rightly or wrongly, it had no authority to coordinate and that its input was ignored. From 2003–2013, during the tenure of Mr. Rouhani, Mr. Larijani, and Mr. Jalili as secretaries, negotiations were handled by the Secretariat.

Perhaps our difficulties began when the nuclear dossier, which had been under the SNSC Secretariat in the previous two administrations, returned to the MFA, and the minister was appointed responsible. Simultaneously, the SNSC and its Secretariat were involved for eight years in all key foreign policy issues, such as the nuclear challenge. When responsibility for negotiations was transferred from the Secretariat to the MFA, tension arose between the two institutions, especially as some issues, like inspection procedures requiring coordination with other institutions, had to be resolved within the Secretariat.

In the 1980s and 1990s, the MFA coordinated all foreign policy cases itself. Details of disarmament negotiations, such as the Comprehensive Nuclear-Test-Ban Treaty, the Chemical Weapons Convention, the Biological Weapons Convention, and even talks on military aid to Bosnia and Afghanistan, were all coordinated and managed by the MFA, with the assistance of the relevant military and other state institutions. Only if there was disagreement or a need for decisions on general policies were matters referred to the SNSC. But this changed during the last years of Khatami and throughout the Ahmadinejad administration.

The Ukrainian Plane Tragedy

Here, I must inevitably turn to the most bitter experience during my tenure in dealing with the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council: the tragic shooting down of the Ukrainian aircraft. Following the criminal act of the United States in the cowardly assassination of Martyr Lieutenant General Qasem Soleimani and his companions in the early hours of Friday, 3 January 2020, the last decision I was aware of was that there was no urgency for a retaliatory action, and that the most effective approach—consistently pursued by Hezbollah in Lebanon—was to impose a protracted state of alert on the adversary forces.

However, in the early hours of Wednesday, 8 January 2020, at approximately 4:30 a.m., I received a message from my deputy, Mr. Araghchi regarding the attack on Ain al-Asad. The Secretariat had woken Mr. Araghchi at around 3:00 a.m., requesting that he deliver a message to the United States via the Swiss Ambassador. Despite the late hour, he was able to awaken the Swiss Ambassador and convey the message. It appears that the Americans had been informed of the attack beforehand—prior even to the President and Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Islamic Republic—through the Prime Minister of Iraq, Mr. Adel Abdul-Mahdi, who had been briefed on the operation on the evening of Tuesday, January 7, 2020. Informing the Iraqi Prime Minister was appropriate; what is questionable is the lack of notification to the Iranian President and Foreign Minister.

From the early hours of Wednesday onward, together with Mr. Araghchi and other colleagues, we were occupied with managing the international dimensions of the action against Ain al-Asad through formal notes to the Swiss Embassy, routine correspondence with the UN Secretary-General and the President of the Security Council, and public diplomacy measures, including official statements and tweets. It was through social media that we first became aware of the tragedy involving the Ukrainian aircraft. The catastrophe was immense; yet all official reports and even confidential communications sent to the MFA indicated a catastrophic accident caused by a technical malfunction.

On the same day, I received several calls from the Foreign Ministers of Ukraine and Canada requesting an investigation into the incident. Our

response was naturally affirmative. In discussions with the Ukrainian Foreign Minister, there were explicit and implicit references to the possible involvement of Russia in this tragedy, which we attributed to the ongoing political tensions between Ukraine and Russia and duly reported them to authorities.

By Wednesday evening, reports began emerging in foreign media suggesting that a missile had struck the aircraft, gradually dominating the media and political discourse in Ukraine, Canada, the United States, and the West. Nevertheless, civil aviation authorities continued to emphasize a technical fault, and Iranian state media, by inviting various experts, elaborated on technical explanations to refute Western claims. Over time, phone calls from the Canadian and Ukrainian Foreign Ministers and other foreign officials adopted a more serious tone, insisting on a missile strike, though without providing concrete evidence. Requests to military commanders, executive officials, and the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council for details of the tragedy were met with the same standard response citing technical malfunction.

Finally, on the afternoon of Thursday, January 9, 2020, and upon receiving some alarming reports, I contacted the President, stressing the need for his intervention to clarify the circumstances of the tragedy. He instructed that a special meeting be held at the Secretariat of the Supreme National Security Council at 11:00 a.m. on Friday, January 10, 2020, with the Secretary of the Council, Chief of Staff, Minister of Roads and Urban Development, and Minister of Foreign Affairs in attendance. The meeting began at 11:00 a.m., with the Minister of Roads arriving half an hour late, visibly distressed. During the session, I highlighted the global attention and the necessity of clarifying the case. All present reiterated the technical fault narrative, and one assistant of the Secretary of the Council, in a discourteous and out-of-place manner, criticized my susceptibility to Western pressures. I insisted that the missile strike narrative had achieved global consensus, and if the Foreign Minister was to “address” the case, it was essential to understand the details.

The term “address”, used in a confidential interview later with Mr. Leilaz, taken out of context from the steps I undertook after becoming aware of the tragedy, became a pretext for slander and a smear campaign

by extremist groups abroad and ultimately resulted in baseless sanctions by the Canadian government after the end of my tenure. A brief review of the background and the actions of the “smiling yet anguished” foreign minister from the early hours of Saturday, 11 January 2020, reveals that the term “address” in that meeting referred to acknowledging the truth, issuing apologies, compensating victims’ families, and investigating and punishing those responsible for the tragedy.

In any case, participants in the January 10 meeting insisted on technical faults and insisted that I should issue statements and tweets refuting the missile narrative, which I strongly opposed. Consequently, the meeting ended without conclusion. The Secretary of the Council and the Chief of Staff then convened separately to make the final decision without my presence. Around 2:30 p.m., Mr. Araghchi was contacted by the Secretariat and informed that the final decision regarding the aircraft incident would soon be communicated. This was the first time, due to my insistence in that meeting, that the Armed Forces, following the President’s instructions, were prepared to courageously acknowledge the missile strike three days after the event.

It is noteworthy that the acceptance of such a grave error, while not unprecedented globally, is nonetheless exceptional. The courage and honesty of the Armed Forces in assuming responsibility merit commendation, despite attempts to distort the narrative by portraying the 72-hour delay as evidence of negligence. A brief review of similar incidents, where governments have yet to accept responsibility even decades later, highlights the political motivations behind pseudo-legal controversies initiated by states such as Canada and the United Kingdom. Their historical biases—Canada’s tacit support for Israeli actions in Gaza, and Britain’s alignment with the United States in the downing of an Iranian Airbus³²—undermine the credibility of their claims.

Subsequently, the President convened the special Supreme Council session that evening. In that session, the Secretariat and the Armed Forces proposed a statement, which was read on state television at 7:00 a.m. on Saturday, 11 January 2020, exactly reflecting the information provided

³² <https://www.bbc.com/persian/iran-62268298>

during the Council meeting: a human error by the anti-aircraft operator stationed at the airport. Even my hypothesis regarding potential radar interference was swiftly and unanimously rejected by all participants. Minutes after the Armed Forces' statement was broadcast, I issued a tweet reflecting the second component of "address"—the apology.

In subsequent steps, the MFA established a round-the-clock special hotline at all diplomatic missions, while within the government and the national administrative system, serious and transparent measures commenced to investigate the causes, determine responsibility, and provide compensation to the victims' families.

Until the end of my tenure, I received no official account clarifying the full circumstances of this catastrophic incident. I abstained for a year from attending all SNSC Secretariat meetings due to lack of transparency and the perfunctory nature of the Foreign Minister's presence. During this period, I endured various affronts, including unjust sanctions imposed by Canada, yet I remain profoundly ashamed before the families of those who perished in this tragic event.

Relations with Military Establishment

The nexus between foreign policy and military institutions, particularly in the context of tensions with the United States, is of utmost sensitivity. In most cases and developments, there was exemplary synergy between the MFA and the military establishment. From cooperation in Syria and Iraq to the Astana Process and the strengthening of strategic ties with Turkey (Türkiye) and Pakistan, the coordination between the foreign policy apparatus and the armed forces was notable. My cordial relations with the late Lieutenant General Qasem Soleimani were so extensive and well known that, following his martyrdom, I was invited to appear on the main evening news program of the Islamic Republic of Iran Broadcasting for an interview and analysis.

It is perhaps fair to say that on the global stage, the most frequent and ardent defenses of Iran's defensive and missile capabilities, the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps (IRGC), the Quds Force, and General Soleimani himself—both during his lifetime and after his martyrdom—

came from me as the foreign minister. Some of these defenses, such as my remarks at the University of New Zealand, the European Parliament, and the Munich Security Conference, became viral online in the form of clips spontaneously produced by the public. In private discussions, and particularly in the context of the JCPOA negotiations, our positions were even more forthright and resolute than in public speeches, some of which are documented in my book *The Untold Secrets*.

Familiar statements such as “The world is indebted to General Soleimani,” made in response to unseemly remarks by certain journalists and politicians after his martyrdom; “We will not abandon the defense of our people for a few dollars,” in reply to a Japanese journalist in New Zealand regarding ballistic missiles; or “We will not allow future Saddam Hussein’s to massacre our civilians for lack of defensive means,” in response to a question from a member of the European Parliament in Brussels, are but three examples of standing firmly in defense of the armed forces and the nation’s defense capabilities at the international level. Sadly, some groups, through distortion and selective quotation, have fueled the notion of a false dichotomy—a practice they continue to this day.

In the strategic culture of the Islamic Republic of Iran, military capability is regarded as the most vital pillar of national power. The fundamental reason for the centrality of military strength is clear and logical: at its inception, the Islamic Republic faced a broad foreign aggression in which the United States and other powers sided with the aggressor. Owing to this external assault and the constant threats from the United States and the Israeli regime, the entirety of state policy was devoted to defense—an imperative and existential necessity. The Sacred Defense became the primary foundation for governance, and over time, the vocabulary of that war entered the general lexicon of state administration.

This position has endured and become institutionalized even thirty years after the end of the imposed war. Both public and political culture in post-revolutionary Iran have been shaped by the experience of the Sacred Defense. Nonetheless, in my view, one must not counter non-military pressures with a purely military mindset. Over the past three decades, the most significant pressures have been economic, political, media-driven, and in the form of securitization, all of which are non-military in nature.

A military response to a process of securitization effectively means playing into the very logic of securitizers. But since we have perceived the nature of the challenge as military, we have, even in matters of securitization, sought to respond militarily—thus, inadvertently reproducing and reinforcing the very securitization we face.

Of course, one must never forget that the selfless members of the armed forces are noble individuals who abandoned the comforts of life, made sacrifices, and fought courageously—and who are far superior to people like me. We all feel humbled in the presence of those who have pioneered in the arena of martyrdom. Yet, in conducting social analysis, we must not overlook the fact that many of our political and international think tanks carry a military orientation and receive institutional support from military bodies. As social scientists would phrase it, Iran's strategic culture remains deeply influenced by the experience of the Iran–Iraq war.

Another important issue is the challenge of command and coordination. For example, when a particular institution or individual is responsible for selling gas to Turkey, their primary objective is to ensure uninterrupted sales at the highest possible price. From their perspective, the construction of a pipeline to transfer Turkmen gas to Turkey poses the greatest challenge, as it creates competition. Hence, they may insist that such a pipeline must not pass through Iran, on the assumption that Iran is the sole actor in this domain.

This example, taken from the oil sector within the government, is offered to illustrate that the challenge is not confined solely to military domains or to issues outside governmental purview. An oil official may believe that by preventing the construction of a pipeline through Iran, Turkmen gas will never reach Turkey. They may justify this by claiming that building a pipeline under the Caspian Sea is impossible. Yet, in the absence of alternatives, the impossible has often been made possible. Neither they nor their country are the only actors involved. The oil official may block Iran's transit route, but the other party will find another way to deliver gas to Turkey. When a sectoral mindset overrides strategic vision, the result is that the entire country, including the energy sector, suffers losses and deprives itself of any role or influence. Similarly, an official responsible for combating smuggling might argue that it is necessary to

ensure that any truck entering from Turkey or transiting through Iran to Turkey does not carry smuggled fuel. As a result, they may impose heavy fuel tariffs and taxes on a truck entering from Turkey bound for Turkmenistan, or one coming from Turkmenistan headed to Turkey. The outcome is the loss of all transit traffic. Turkey then pursues an alternative route, building a road that, under normal circumstances, would have been far less cost-effective than transit through Iran. Yet we, by our own actions, have removed the Iranian option from the table, despite it being the best route.

This is the sectoral mindset—a strategic interest sacrificed for a sectoral outlook. The same pattern can be observed in the military sphere. An institution tasked with achieving a particular military objective will, quite understandably, focus above all on how to secure that specific goal. The members of such an institution are undoubtedly true patriots and selfless defenders of national interests. Yet, if those same individuals are placed in charge of all foreign relations, the result may well be that, in the pursuit of a single military victory, the country's vital interests are compromised.

Nowhere in the world is the field commander the principal architect of defense policy, just as those who carry out diplomacy or economic affairs are not the ultimate decision-makers in foreign or economic policy. Each actor in the fields of defense, economy, and diplomacy must operate as an executor of the country's overarching policies in their respective domain. If the individual responsible for the economy were able to veto military action, no military capability would ever be developed, since building such capability entails costs for the economy and national development. Conversely, if the field commander were given veto power over economic matters, the economy would collapse.

The Supreme National Security Council—comprising the five constitutional pillars of national security—exists precisely to examine the proposals of each institution comprehensively, assess them across sectors, and approve and coordinate them. Thereafter, the field commander acts under that policy in the operational arena, the economy official advances economic affairs, and the other actors do likewise.

Under this constitutional design, the Council is a body of equals. Its composition prevents the dominance of any single mindset, orientation,

or professional sector over the others. However, if—due to political leanings or any other reason—the country moves exclusively in a military, economic, cultural, or diplomatic direction, other perspectives, and thus other national interests, will inevitably be sacrificed. In such a scenario, the country may emerge as the most powerful military force in the region, but find itself so encircled by an adverse security environment that it can no longer even use its military assets to defend its values or deter threats.

Alongside the need for balance among the pillars of national security, attention must also be paid to the actions and reactions of other players. Our moves do not occur in a vacuum—others respond to the levers we build. The United States and Israel, in line with their longstanding strategies of securitization, threat projection, Islamophobia, Iranophobia, and Shiaphobia, have magnified Iran's military capabilities, portraying them as a threat to the peace and security of regional states. The U.S. has then used alleged Arab concerns over Iran's military strength as a pretext to launch the Abraham Accords, bringing Israel into the region and placing it right on Iran's doorstep. The question is: why has this happened? No social phenomenon has a single cause, but one of the most prominent reasons for the present situation is the dominance of the military-security outlook, which Israel has exploited to exaggerate threats, frighten others, and draw them into its fold. My emphasis has always been on a balanced, multi-dimensional, and multi-faceted perspective. The essence of my argument is that each sphere—military, economic, cultural—is of great importance in its own right and must pursue its legal and intrinsic functions in a manner that is balanced and mutually reinforcing.

A proper understanding of capability requires avoiding rigid, narrow, and inflexible thinking. Iran's armed forces, with remarkable self-reliance, have developed capabilities of which the nation can be proud, and these achievements must be sustained with determination. Certainly, it is laudable to acquire the maximum possible military, economic, and political power. The challenge lies in conflicts of priority: how far can economic capacity be sacrificed for military strength? How far can a nation's ideational and inspirational assets be traded for material capability? Or can a country's defense capacity be sacrificed for economic development and

welfare? In a situation where part of the homeland is under occupation, can one afford to dwell on the economic costs of resistance?

If military capability must not be sacrificed for political or economic power, why should the reverse not also hold true? Can we, by focusing solely on the country's economic needs, deploy military strength as a tool to secure cross-border sources of revenue? The answer is clearly no, because such an approach would diminish military capability; others would intervene militarily to counter it, and the final result would be the erosion of military strength. Likewise, an exclusive focus on military power will gradually undermine ideational capacity, economic resilience, political capital, and—under the strain of economic hardship—erode public satisfaction and social cohesion.

When we speak of competing priorities, the nation's primary strength and comparative advantage—rooted in legitimacy and public consent—must not be sacrificed for secondary capabilities in which no such advantage exists. This is precisely the point underscored by both the late Imam and the Leader. It is indisputable that missiles and military strength are essential. I myself have delivered some of the most impassioned global defenses of these capabilities, drawing attention to the disgraceful record of East and West in supporting Saddam. Yet, the issue of priorities in times of competing values must be addressed soberly, without noise or demagoguery, in a friendly atmosphere and with the national interest at the center.

The optimal path lies in coordinated and mutually reinforcing action between the MFA and the armed forces, while respecting priorities when conflicts arise. As Foreign Minister, I sought to pursue global relations through a national—not sectoral—lens, maintaining cordial and cooperative ties with all military commanders. My relations with the Chiefs of the General Staff and the commanders of the Army and the IRGC were friendly, and my bond with the late General Soleimani was marked by the highest degree of empathy, friendship, and brotherhood. I hold the utmost respect for all those who have offered their lives, wealth, and honor for the benefit of the people, for whom sacrifice is an inseparable part of both their personal and social existence. I feel a profound sense of

humility and eternal indebtedness to them all—especially the martyrs, the war-wounded, former prisoners of war, and their esteemed families.

Relations with Security and Intelligence Agencies

The intelligence services of the Islamic Republic of Iran, like the nation's armed forces, possess considerable capabilities—rooted in their emergence from among the people, sustained by self-reliance, and grounded in indigenous capacities. This strength is self-made, deeply rooted, and enduring. The reality is that these popular military and security institutions have, for nearly five decades, safeguarded the territorial integrity of Iran through sacrifice and devotion. One must not forget that the Islamic Republic is the only system of government in the country's modern history that, despite all external hostilities, has not lost a single inch of Iranian territory—a record made possible only through the perseverance of Iranian people and the sacrifices of these popular military and security bodies. It is these same institutions that have shielded the nation and its people from grave military and security threats, particularly the scourge of Takfiri terrorism. This truth must never be lost sight of amid theoretical debates, political discourse, or differences of opinion.

The country maintains two principal intelligence organizations in constant contact with the MFA: the Ministry of Intelligence and the Intelligence Organization of the Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps. We endeavored to maintain the closest possible cooperation with each, insofar as they served the interests of the Islamic Republic. Abroad, we consistently defended policies that—on more than a few occasions—we not only disagreed with, but of which we ourselves had been the target through unfriendly measures. For practitioners of foreign policy, it is essential to keep these two realms separate. We voiced our differences of perspective on domestic and international issues in confidential reports and meetings, but in the face of foreign powers seeking their own interests—and who cared nothing for the welfare of our people—we always stood in defense of the intelligence and security institutions.

Worldwide, cooperation between foreign ministries and intelligence agencies is a given, even if differences in outlook and sectoral tensions

are inevitable. In Iran, one major point of divergence concerned the challenge of “infiltration.” A sound security apparatus must adopt a multi-dimensional view of threats. Yet too often, security has been defined narrowly—as the need to counter infiltration according to a specific, and at times partisan or politicized, definition. But who is actually an infiltrator? An individual arriving from the West wearing a necktie? As years of experience have shown, foreign states have never relied on such obvious figures for espionage or infiltration. Rather, they have done so through individuals who attract the least suspicion³³.

At the same time, our security agencies have in many cases shown heightened sensitivity toward dual nationals and those groups that have played a prominent role in opposing war and sanctions against Iran. The pretext has been that such individuals have, at times, expressed critical views on issues like human rights. Harsh treatment of these citizens diminishes the nation’s ideational capital, alienates the Iranian diaspora, angers domestic public opinion, mobilizes international opinion against Iran, weakens the country’s capacity for influence abroad, and renders ineffective—and disillusioned—those who could otherwise act as Iran’s advocates and lobbyists overseas.

A further difficulty lies in the definition of espionage, which in certain security circles diverges significantly from the prevailing global understanding. This difference in outlook has led to a situation where a range of activities are, in the eyes of some institutions, deemed espionage. Such an approach is incompatible with the requirements of lobbying. A

³³ On 23 September 1953, an arson erupted at Qal-e Morghi military airport, which must have been committed by infiltrating officers. In the light of the significance of the matter, the military prosecutor appointed the most seasoned officer to investigate the crime. Col. Mobasheri, a senior officer, was named to launch an inquiry. It was not long before suspects were identified and put on trial. After the hearing, Col. Mobasheri angrily protested the military court’s lenience. He protested the court’s life term given to the main suspect who deserved the death penalty. A couple of months later, an underground cell comprising military officers affiliated with the Tudeh party was identified. Col. Mobasheri was among the senior officers arrested, the same officer who was assigned security cases for investigation and was infuriated at the court’s ruling. (Mehdi Tadayoni, *Insaf News*, 1 September 2023).

Eliyahu Ben-Shaul Cohen (26 December 1924 – 18 May 1965) was an Egyptian-born Israeli spy. He is best known for his espionage work in Syria between 1961 and 1965, where he assumed the name of Kamel Amin, became famous for his hardline stance against Israel and moved up the ranks in the Syrian political and military hierarchy, reaching the position of deputy defense minister. In 1965, his true allegiance was uncovered by Syrian intelligence, and he was publicly hanged in Damascus in May 1965. Cohen is highly regarded in Israel for his important contributions to Israeli war effort.

person can only become an effective lobbyist for the country if they are able to meet and exert influence upon decision-makers in the executive and legislative branches of the target country. It is self-evident that the most effective actors in this field—whether in foreign ministries, defense ministries, intelligence agencies, national security councils, or the political and security committees of legislatures—are precisely those with whom meetings and exchanges are essential for lobbying. In Iran, however, the boundary between such legitimate engagement and espionage is often unclear.

Equally important is the recognition that a lobbyist must focus their advocacy on the particular issue in which they seek to exert influence. There may be areas where, to gain the credibility needed for success, the lobbyists must voice criticism of their own country in order to maintain their standing; otherwise, they will be dismissed as mere agents of the state. These are self-evident realities of the lobbying profession. Yet we tend to approach the matter in absolutist terms: either one must support all our policies, or one should remain silent. How, then, can we expect someone struggling abroad to oppose war and sanctions while also defending Iran's human rights record? An academic who refrains from criticism and defends Iran's human rights record abroad will lose all credibility to speak against sanctions, as negatively affecting the Iranian people. Regardless of political motivations of the accusers, public perceptions will make such efforts doubly difficult.

Some institutions lack this broader, multi-faceted vision, instead creating a binary of "supporter" or "opponent." This is despite the fact that there are individuals who, while proclaiming their support for Iran's revolutionary policies in domestic fora and newspapers, fail to mount even the smallest defense of Iran on the global stage. Not only do they refrain from supporting Iran's revolutionary positions internationally, but they do also not even trouble themselves to explain or promote Iran's globally defensible policies—lest their "academic credibility" be diminished. A simple search will show that certain academics, drawing pensions from Western universities yet publishing fiery articles against "compromise" in Iran's domestic press, have not produced a single piece in a foreign journal defending Iran or the Islamic Republic. Their writings are limited

to domestic publications, aimed at fueling factional disputes among the country's officials.

In short, professed loyalists at home have, in critical moments and on the world stage, supported Iran far less than honest critics have. Those who shout the loudest within the country are often so “gentlemanly” and reserved abroad that they are never sanctioned, never denied privileges—and yet have, time and again, provided pretexts for sanctions against the Iranian people. It is a sobering fact that some who live comfortably in London, Washington, and other Western capitals—sometimes on stipends from Western institutions—feel free to question my revolutionary credentials, even though I bear the burden of two U.S. sanctions and one Canadian sanction.

Due to my extensive time abroad and wide circle of friends among Iranians and Muslims of diverse political and intellectual orientations, I have often witnessed those who posture as fiery revolutionaries at home, when asked abroad, even hide their Iranian citizenship or national background, let alone openly supporting Iran or its policies. Some of our intelligence and security agencies have not yet recognized that such individuals are of no practical value to Iran, whereas the political activist who may criticize Iran's human rights record but is prepared to make sacrifices to prevent war and sanctions is precisely the one most despised by the Mojahedin-e Khalq (MEK). Ironically, they are accused of being “regime agents” because of their public efforts against war and sanctions. The defamation campaign against these individuals and groups following the unrest of autumn 2022 made this reality abundantly clear.

Here too, the central issue is one of understanding—a cognitive challenge that calls for rigorous research into our cognitive framework regarding ourselves, the world, our priorities, and the trade-offs we face.

Support for Intelligence Agencies Abroad

In many critical and difficult junctures, the responsibility of defending the activities of security and intelligence institutions abroad fell upon the minister and senior officials of the MFA. What led to the discontent of some of our compatriots was that our defense was articulated in a manner

that at times it convinced counterparts and interlocutors. It is said that, on one occasion, a British Ambassador to the United Nations remarked that the manner in which Ambassador Zarif defended difficult Iranian positions ought to be taught to British diplomats.

In a roundtable organized by the Körber Foundation—a key German institution—nearly 25 leading figures, including the former Prime Minister of Denmark, members of European parliaments, and the heads of major research institutes such as the director of Chatham House, visited Iran. During a meeting with this group, I engaged in questions and answers with an individual who had, for 12 years, presided over the largest foreign policy research institute in a European country. One of the participants in that meeting, who himself was a former columnist for respected newspapers and a distinguished thinker in the field of international relations, reportedly told a colleague that “unfortunately, he (Zarif) is very convincing”.

Effective advocacy of the country’s positions and interests has not been without hardship. Certain defenses have been the source of frustration for segments of the Iranian public. Perhaps they forget that I was not the spokesperson of Javad Zarif, nor the spokesperson of the MFA, nor even the spokesperson of the government; rather, I was the spokesperson of Iran. We were compelled to defend actions that were not always aligned with our own views. At times, we were obliged to defend policies that we had ourselves advocated against and paid a price domestically. Even some of those policies had initially been designed to defame and undermine me personally or my political inclinations. Yet, as the minister or senior officials of the MFA, we had no choice but to defend them.

A consolation for the difficulties in defending Iran against such allegations abroad, is the fact that the accusers were neither genuine defenders of human rights and non-proliferation—attested by their blind support in international fora for Israel’s genocide in Gaza, apartheid in the occupied territories and its illegal nuclear arsenal ;nor were they concerned for the Iranian people, as evidenced by the sanctions they imposed, which inflicted suffering primarily upon ordinary people, while many of those responsible for the current conditions continued to profit from sanctions and the corruption that has always been associated with sanctions.

Nevertheless, such defense remains unacceptable to many of our compatriots, leaving them pained and disillusioned. On one occasion, during a public program, as I was leaving the hall, a respected lady approached me. She was trembling, in tears, crying out, even hurling insults. I stopped my security detail who attempted to move her away. The lady shouted: “You said that we chose this ourselves. I have two children, both educated, both unemployed. Why do you say we chose this? We did not. Why do you defend these policies that undermine the JCPOA?” It was a bitter moment that stayed with me after many years.

It was painful to witness firsthand that the measures I was compelled to defend—even to the detriment of my own foreign policy—had angered and caused a compatriot, a fellow human being, to suffer. Perhaps she had hoped that the Minister of Foreign Affairs would defend her rights. She could not—and justifiably so—distinguish between the role splitting of the minister: on the one hand, as an analyst and observer obliged to convey his insights and dissenting views to the leadership—something I had repeatedly done even on those very issues; and on the other hand, as the representative and advocate of the Islamic Republic of Iran abroad, who was duty-bound to safeguard the nation’s rights in the face of Iranophobia, Shiaphobia, securitization, and the portrayal of Iran as a threat—all of which harmed the people of Iran. Thus, I had to defend state policies, even as my own guiding principle—both inside and outside the country—remained a belief in the people and a concern for their rights and interests. I remain convinced that, with a humane perspective, one can always envision a better future for the people and strive toward its realization.

Relations with Other State Institutions and Economic Diplomacy

The MFA is perhaps the only ministry that maintains mutual interaction with all other ministries and state institutions. Some of these institutions are administrative in nature, while others are political bodies that engage with the MFA within the framework of the SNSC. Relations between the MFA and other institutions are rarely smooth or without tension—a reality not unique to Iran. Other agencies often perceive an institution of equal

rank as unjustly exercising oversight or authority over their expanding global functions.

Given that today, linkages and exchanges are increasingly globalized and that the work of every agency now carries an international dimension, most institutions are unwilling to submit such external dimensions of their functions to obligatory coordination with the MFA. This challenge exists everywhere. However, in all countries where foreign policy is conducted effectively, the foreign ministry is both informed of, and involved in, all foreign and external relations. For instance, should the Prime Minister of the United Kingdom meet with a minister or official of another country, the British Foreign Secretary may not personally attend, but without question the relevant country desk officer from the Foreign Office will be present. The rationale is clear: all information must be centralized in a single institution.

In Iran, such centralization has never existed. Not only has the MFA long suffered from the resentment and jealousy of other agencies, but never has there been true unity or consolidation of information regarding the state's foreign interactions within the institution responsible for foreign relations. As a result, the MFA often remains unaware of important developments in foreign policy—an omission that carries grave risks.

Typically, the MFA only learns of foreign interactions in the economic, military or cultural domains after they encounter obstacles or difficulties. Otherwise, other institutions deliberately avoid engaging the Ministry for as long as possible. When coordination is absent and the MFA is brought to the picture only after challenges arise due to missteps or lack of alignment, valuable time will often have already been lost and remedial opportunities foreclosed. Prior consultation can prevent missteps; after-the-fact correction is often either impossible or interpreted as a sign of weakness. In certain cases, such retreat may even eliminate established rights and inadvertently create entitlements for the counterpart.

Public opinion, the media, parliament, and government all expect the MFA to deliver effective economic diplomacy. Yet little attention is paid to the fact that such weakness in economic diplomacy stems primarily from the Ministry's lack of knowledge and information regarding economic linkages. Most institutions neither deem it necessary nor beneficial to

recognize the MFA as the coordinator of foreign relations or to keep it informed of their own external dealings before challenges arise. Because each agency pursues its own sectoral mandates, the problem intensifies when a given body concludes that its interests are best served through harsh or adversarial conduct toward a foreign state. Such hostility may yield costs to the nation many times greater than the intended sectoral benefit; indeed, even the original sectoral objectives are seldom achieved.

For example, Iran's national gas company may conclude that Turkmenistan has dealt with Iran unfairly in a gas-related dispute and thus determine that the government should adopt a more confrontational approach. Yet it may fail to realize that such hostility, even if yielding a short-term gain of two billion dollars for the gas company, could simultaneously deprive the country of eight billion dollars in technical and engineering service exports. Since the gas company bears no responsibility for such exports, it cannot be reproached for the broader consequences. Months later, however, when the official body responsible for engineering exports discovers the decline, it will reproach the MFA for failing to act—despite the fact that the Ministry was never involved in the process because another agency pursued its own objectives in isolation. This is a fundamental knot in state governance that only the parliament can untangle. It is the parliament that must oblige all institutions to coordinate their external relations with the MFA as the national authority in foreign relations. Unfortunately, the reverse has occurred: in both the Sixth and Seventh Development Plans, more agencies have been formally exempted from coordinating with the MFA. In effect, this has indicated to the world that the country operates with two, three, or multiple foreign policies.

Coordination with the MFA does not contradict the principle of institutional parity. Just as the MFA or the Ministry of Interior must coordinate their construction projects with municipalities or with the Ministry of Roads and Urban Development—and this obligation does not undermine institutional equality—so too should all other agencies coordinate their external relations with the MFA. Contrary to the arguments of some members of parliament, notions of rank or superiority have no logical or legal basis. For instance, the Presidency, though formally several levels above municipalities, must nonetheless obtain municipal

permits to construct buildings. Yet when it comes to the MFA, the logic is inverted: its rightful role in foreign relations is disregarded, leaving it marginalized in matters not only in the military and national security realms but across the full spectrum of economic, cultural, and other foreign-related domains.

This structural deficiency prevents the MFA from developing and advancing initiatives. Deprived of authority, it cannot act proactively but only reactively, as it is consulted solely in times of crisis. Initiative presupposes authority: without authority, innovation and coordination cannot be expected.

At the same time, the MFA must avoid encroaching upon the operational and executive domains of other agencies, confining itself strictly to coordination of their external dimensions. It cannot and must not dictate commercial, energy, or military decisions. For this reason, at the start of my tenure, I respectfully dismissed a senior and influential official of the Ministry who, without coordination with the Ministry of Petroleum, had engaged in oil-related negotiations.

Moreover, the ministry itself is partly to blame for refusal of others to coordinate. It must see its role as that of a facilitator and advisor, not an obstacle or enforcer. In some cases, officials of the MFA have assumed an air of superiority over their counterparts in other institutions—an attitude that, by human nature, alienates others. One must always recall the admonition of Imam Ali (peace be upon him): that every form of arrogance ends in humiliation and degradation.

If the MFA positions itself above others, resistance is inevitable. Thus, its mission must be to facilitate and advise, not to obstruct or complicate. During my tenure as Deputy Minister for Legal and International Affairs in the 1990s, I repeatedly reminded colleagues that the duty of the Ministry's Legal Department was not to reject or dismiss every draft communication received from other ministries as invalid, but rather to provide necessary legal clarifications—without imposing subjective preferences—and to propose solutions and legal pathways in consultation with other agencies. Whenever the Ministry failed in this regard, parallel institutions emerged. Indeed, many of the Ministry's natural functions in the area of international agreements and memoranda of understanding are now performed by the

Legal Department of the Presidency, as agencies prefer to consult that office instead of the Ministry's Legal Department—despite the fact that legally this responsibility is granted to MFA Legal Office.

Further complicating matters is the entrenched bureaucratic mindset: by refusing requests, an official avoids personal risk. Thus, some Ministry experts shy away from offering assistance, preferring instead to emphasize difficulties and shield themselves from future blame. Meanwhile, with every agency expanding its cross-border engagement, ministries are increasingly reluctant to involve the MFA in their dealings. As a result, the belief that the Ministry should serve as the central hub of coordination has steadily eroded. Agencies now consider it sufficient merely to notify the Ministry once problems arise. In this arrangement, the losers are the Iranian people, foreign policy, and the nation's economy and trade.

Another factor must also be acknowledged: the question of "need." The MFA must recognize that the level of dependency upon its services today is far less than it was twenty or thirty years ago. In the past, if a deputy minister wished to contact his counterpart abroad, this had to be arranged through the embassy and required the Ministry's involvement. Today, such intermediaries are no longer necessary; any deputy minister can reach out to his counterpart via digital communication. Mere contact does not constitute a problem, as such interaction is intrinsic to the work of every ministry. What is problematic is the absence of a broader national perspective, the lack of coordination, and the narrow, sectoral outlooks of certain agencies.

Contrary to popular perception that the greatest tension exists with the military, the truth is that the greatest lack of coordination lies within the civilian executive branch, precisely because coordination is weakest there. In military affairs, though the MFA lacks sufficient authority, cases are at least coordinated through the Supreme National Security Council. In cultural matters, too, coordination is somewhat better, since culture and politics are naturally interlinked. The state has cultural centers and attachés abroad, who, by law, operate under the authority of embassies. Likewise, the Islamic Culture and Relations Organization, despite its shortcomings, at least functions through embassy structures. By contrast, in economic affairs, because of sectoral thinking, perceptions of self-sufficiency, and

even competition with the MFA, the highest degree of disarray and lack of coordination prevails. The situation is disorganized, and the MFA plays only the most minimal role in the activities of state institutions and private sector enterprises with economic mandates.

Public Diplomacy

Public diplomacy has become one of the most pivotal branches of diplomacy and, with the increasing centrality of the human agency in international relations, it is gaining greater significance every day. Within public diplomacy, engagement with the media continues to hold special value, though the advent of virtual space has itself created new challenges and opportunities for diplomacy. Universities, think tanks, and research institutes have also assumed an ever-growing role in shaping not only national policy but also the policies of other states.

The media, as one of the pillars of democracy, maintains constant interaction with the MFA. Indeed, media may be regarded as the most influential social institution in shaping public opinion. During the Rouhani administration, the relationship between the media and the MFA gained greater prominence. The speed of response to developments became immediate, and the Minister of Foreign Affairs himself came to be recognized as a media actor—perhaps the most media-savvy foreign minister since the Revolution, in terms of influence and effective use of media. The minister's presence, particularly in international media, acquired a distinctive character, as foreign outlets themselves displayed extraordinary eagerness and interest. Domestic media, by contrast, tended to operate with partisan inclinations, framing statements, positions, and remarks through specific political and factional lenses.

The position of the Islamic Republic of Iran—and its outward face, namely the MFA—in the global media sphere has never been favorable. The intensity of media onslaughts directed against the Islamic Republic has been immense. Each time Iran's profile has risen on the international

stage, these attacks have only multiplied. During the JCPOA negotiations, for at least two years, Iran's nuclear dossier remained at the forefront of international news, with the world closely following developments in Iran. Similarly, under the Trump administration, when Iran became the foremost priority of U.S. foreign policy, it was continuously at the top of media headlines and programming. For these reasons, the global media assault on the Islamic Republic was formidable, rendering the MFA's active media presence at the international level both inevitable and indispensable.

Virtual Space

In today's world, virtual space has created conditions in which media presence need not always take the form of official statements or even interviews. Indeed, one might argue that the issuance of communiqués now has the least impact in public diplomacy, though they may still be necessary for historical record. From the perspective of the nation's principal decision-makers, however, official statements continue to be valued more highly than tweets and newer digital methods. Twitter, nevertheless, provides an exceptionally swift vehicle for conveying positions to the global community. There is no longer any need for reliance upon major news agencies to disseminate—or to suppress—messages. In the past, there was always the added concern of whether the world's news monopolists would faithfully transmit one's views, or whether they would spin the message into its very opposite.

A fundamental transformation has thus occurred in the transmission of news and viewpoints: monopoly and even editorial selection have been wrested from the hands of global media conglomerates and returned to the individual actor, who now holds the power to publish his or her message directly. During my tenure, the use of this instrument assumed special importance. Prior to my ministerial responsibilities, I had conducted numerous interviews with international outlets and was already a familiar presence in the global media sphere—particularly in the West—more so than any other Iranian official.

Once in office, X (formerly Twitter) and other virtual tools of public diplomacy became invaluable in enabling us to project our perspectives

worldwide without waiting for, or depending upon, the machinery of news agencies. All the leading international news services would republish my tweets, which in turn dramatically increased both the speed of our outreach and the breadth of our audience. Even now, more than two years after leaving office, I retain over 1.6 million real followers on Twitter. At one point, I ranked seventh among the world's foreign ministers in terms of followers. Those above me held the advantage of access to Twitter in their own countries and the ability to tweet in their native tongues. Some had also acquired followers through digital marketing strategies or through the use of "bots." We, however, possessed neither the financial resources for such endeavors nor—thanks to God and the support of the people—any need for them.

Of course, the "bots" have not ceased their assaults, even now that I am an ordinary citizen with no political office. Coordinated attacks, launched from Albania, Saudi Arabia, and certain domestic circles, seize upon any pretext to vilify. One of the reasons for discontinuing my Facebook page—which carried content in Persian—was precisely the vulgar, sacrilegious attacks instigated from within, aimed at polluting the atmosphere. Once I discerned the shocking origins of this sinister campaign, I decided to cease posting on Facebook, despite having nearly one million followers there.

In Nowruz of 2017, on the eve of the presidential election, we discovered that a large number of fraudulent accounts had been created in my name. We feared that these accounts might be exploited for electoral purposes. Several times we reached out to the administrators of these false accounts, urging them to suspend activity or transfer control. In one case, an exorbitant price was demanded. Consequently, it was agreed that I should open an account on Instagram—a lawful and accessible platform—to begin limited activity. From Nowruz 2017, my presence on Instagram commenced, and within a short period followers reached 900,000. Yet I scarcely found time to use it. Today, though nearly 800,000 Iranians follow me on Instagram, I make little use of it.

Throughout, my principal avenue of direct public engagement has remained email. In addition to personal addresses, I maintained an official address at the MFA, and now one at the university. Anyone wishing to communicate could avail themselves of this channel. The volume of

messages has always been immense. Many people, facing difficulties wholly unrelated to my official duties, would write to me: “You are the only person in government accessible to us, and we know that you read your emails yourself.” This practice continued even after I relinquished my post.

Perhaps many officials have accounts in their names, but do not manage them personally; they delegate the task to administrators. Few could believe that I alone managed my highly active Twitter, Facebook, Instagram, and email accounts. But I never accepted that government employees should be paid merely to manage a minister’s personal accounts. Moreover, if citizens wished to contact their foreign minister, then I myself had to be the one to respond—not an anonymous administrator.

Naturally, the absence of skilled account managers also had its downsides. For example, at the beginning of my ministerial tenure, when I had only just begun using Twitter, I mistakenly believed that replies to comments beneath a tweet were private. Thus, in response to a remark by the daughter of Speaker Nancy Pelosi regarding the Holocaust, I wrote: “The man once thought to have denied the Holocaust is now gone.” Minutes later, a prominent CNN anchor called to confirm whether the message was indeed mine and whether they might publish it. Only then did I realize that replies on Twitter are public. That single comment exploded like a news bomb, generating enormous attention—yet by God’s grace, it proved useful in breaking the suffocating atmosphere of securitization surrounding Iran³⁴.

Another challenge lay in preparing visuals, charts, and infographics, which had to be created by myself or with the voluntary assistance of friends. Contrary to public perception, there was no professional apparatus for this. For instance, on the night that an American drone was shot down by Iran’s air defense over the Persian Gulf, I was in Isfahan, a guest at my late sister’s home. In the middle of the gathering, I received the news. With Dr. Araghchi’s help, we obtained maps from the General Staff of the Armed Forces and, to prevent escalation, swiftly turned those very hand-drawn maps into a powerful tweet.

³⁴ <https://www.businessinsider.com/javad-zarif-tweets-with-christine-pelosi-2013-9>

Secretary Pompeo, enraged at seeing his sinister designs thwarted, sneered that Iran's foreign minister had used a "child's drawing" in his tweet³⁵. Yet our prompt message had succeeded in preventing unnecessary conflict, even if it handed a warmonger such as Pompeo an opportunity for a cheap shot.

There were also sweet memories from Twitter and its consequences. One of the sweetest occurred at the Coburg Hotel in the tense final days of the JCPOA negotiations. After a particularly difficult session, some colleagues and I returned to my room for consultations. The room overlooked the hotel entrance, where journalists used to congregate. This created a unique opportunity for wordless communication between us and the press. That day, we observed Secretary Kerry's team preparing the stage for his press conference at the hotel entrance. We suspected he intended to seize the initiative by presenting the American position and blaming Iran for the deadlock.

After consultation with members of our negotiating team, and with those who—without expectation of reward—advised us on how to address American and European audiences (though they were often harshly treated at home), we resolved to prevent Secretary Kerry from gaining the upper hand. Thus, I issued a brief tweet employing an American proverb: "Do not change horses in midstream." By releasing it before Secretary Kerry's press conference, we deprived his media team—despite their numbers and efficiency—of the initiative they sought.

The Blame Game

In negotiations, one must always remain mindful of a key principle: among the essential techniques of diplomacy is the art of narrative construction—framing the counterpart as the intransigent and unreasonable party in the talks. This diplomatic tactic is known as the "blame game." From the very outset, a negotiator must prepare for the possibility of failure and, accordingly, anticipate in detail the potential pathways for breaking

³⁵ <https://www.qatar-tribune.com/article/166795/GULF/Drone-map-released-by-Iran-child-like-Pompeo>

deadlocks, or at the very least, for shifting blame onto the opposing party in the eyes of other stakeholders and public opinion.

Within Iran, local media outlets and public opinion have too often become accustomed to a counterproductive practice—namely, the fabrication of headlines and narratives that exaggerate the “achievements” of meetings and negotiations. This approach, though popular in the short term, is profoundly damaging. Superficial and cosmetic diplomacy cannot secure national objectives in serious negotiations, even if such theatrics are met with public and media enthusiasm.

By contrast, genuine and effective methods of public diplomacy—those aimed at undermining America’s and Israel’s strategy of securitization, or at prevailing in the blame game—rarely find positive domestic reception. Instead, such efforts are frequently met with indifference or even outright rejection by domestic media and large segments of public opinion. This dismissive attitude not only makes the task of negotiators exceedingly difficult, if not impossible, but also, in practice, amounts to playing directly into the securitization strategy of Israel and the United States—a matter I address more extensively in later sections of this work.

Traditional Public Diplomacy

An active presence on Twitter never implied the abandonment of traditional methods, such as interviews or publishing articles in leading domestic, regional, and international newspapers and journals³⁶. During my tenure as Foreign Minister, I conducted numerous live and, in some cases, recorded interviews with most of the world’s renowned media outlets, in addition to written interviews.

Recorded interviews carry a particular challenge: no matter how strong the assurances regarding unedited publication, the final decision always lies with the media outlet. In the event of broken commitments, one is faced with a *fait accompli*, and neither subsequent corrections nor even official apologies can undo the damage caused. For this reason, the majority of my interviews were conducted live on television, or otherwise in the

³⁶ See Annex I.

form of articles for newspapers and scholarly journals. In such cases, even when editors made alterations under the pretext of “editing,” they would at least coordinate with the author prior to publication.

I was privileged to engage with many of the world’s most prominent journalists and anchors in highly challenging interviews. It remains a source of satisfaction and honor that many of these interviews—often resembling heated debates—were well received by audiences, and excerpts from them continue to circulate widely in the digital sphere.

As noted earlier, throughout my tenure—and indeed both before and after it—I authored numerous essays in leading academic and scholarly journals explaining and defending the Iranian foreign policy. These ranged from contributions to Harvard and Columbia University publications, to two articles—perhaps for the first time since the Revolution—published in *Foreign Affairs*, as well as dozens of op-eds in *The New York Times*, *The Washington Post*, *Los Angeles Times*, *The Atlantic*, *Financial Times*, *International Herald Tribune*, *The Guardian*, *Le Monde*, *Al-Safir*, *Asharq al-Awsat*, *Al-Rai*, *Al-Akhbar*, *Kommersant (Russia)*, *Global Times (China)*, *Jang (Pakistan)*, among others.

Unfortunately, following my designation by the Trump administration, American and even European outlets published fewer of my writings, as global sanctions created significant complications for the publication of work authored by designated individuals and, indeed, by many Iranians more broadly³⁷.

Engagement with Academia and Think Tanks

Active participation in global academic and policy forums constituted another vital avenue of public diplomacy and dialogue with the elites and the general public alike. I had the honor of addressing major international gatherings as a keynote speaker, including the World Economic Forum in Davos, the Munich Security Conference, the Doha Forum, the Tehran Security Conference, the Tehran Dialogue Forum, the Antalya Diplomacy Forum, the Raisina Dialogue in India, the Valdai Discussion Club in Russia,

³⁷ Keven Glöckner, Analysis of the phenomenon of systematic fast rejections of Iranian Authors of scientific literature, Faculty of World Studies, University of Tehran. 2023.

and many others. At some of these events, I was invited as an annual participant. The positions of the Islamic Republic were presented in a manner comprehensible to international audiences. Regrettably, those very remarks were frequently misrepresented inside the country—through selective editing, distortion, or mistranslation—and then weaponized as the basis for harsh attacks.

Almost every official trip included a lecture at a leading think tank or research institute in the host country. Among the most prominent of these were the Council on Foreign Relations, Chatham House, the European Council on Foreign Relations, SIPRI, the Helsinki Commission, the PRIO Institute in Norway, the Mediterranean Dialogues, the New Zealand Institute of International Affairs, the Institute of Strategic Studies in Islamabad, the Observer Research Foundation in India, the Australian National University, and many more. Portions of these lectures, particularly the question-and-answer sessions, remain available online and continue to circulate in digital spaces.

It is a source of regret that, due to lack of time, personal negligence, a shortage of institutional motivation, and perhaps even indifference within parts of the Foreign Ministry itself, my speeches, interviews, and articles during my tenure were never systematically compiled. From time to time, fragments resurface in cyberspace, shared by unknown individuals. I remain sincerely grateful to these unseen friends.

Relations with IRIB

Among the domestic and official media outlets, the general orientation of state radio and television (IRIB) was, by and large, to denigrate the foreign policy of the administration, particularly the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA). Of course, there were moments of fluctuation in the span of eight years. The directors of the so-called “national media” preferred to use my statements and presence, as well as those of my colleagues, in those cases and programs where they knew that our perspectives aligned with the prevailing sentiments of the organization’s leadership. For instance, on the night of the martyrdom of General Qassem Soleimani, I was invited to appear on IRIB’s main news-analysis program, precisely because they

were aware of the profound bond of friendship between us. Yet, beyond such exceptional circumstances, there was little inclination to provide us with an equitable platform for views that diverged from the institution's dominant outlook.

The prevention of the broadcast of an interview recorded at the insistence of Mr. Adel Ferdowsipour—a distinguished and highly respected former host of the program Navad—is one notable example, which later became a matter of public controversy. It is even conceivable that this very interview, though entirely harmless and potentially beneficial even for IRIB itself, contributed to Ferdowsipour's eventual dismissal from IRIB. The official justification given was that the broadcast coincided with parliamentary elections. Yet I was neither a candidate nor had I endorsed any candidate. Even if one were to accept this justification, another case occurred two years removed from any electoral process: at the insistence of a talented satirical host, I had agreed to appear on a special Nowruz program, with the stated aim of “bringing some joy to people's weary hearts” by making myself the subject of humor. After several days, I was informed that IRIB's management had vetoed my participation. What pretext they offered in that instance remains unknown to me.

Most of our appearances on IRIB, in fact, were framed as confrontations with anchors who insisted on presenting adversarial views, thereby forcing us to engage in inherently unequal debates. Due to considerations of national interest, we could not respond to certain questions with the freedom of our interrogating interlocutors. As a matter of principle and protocol, cabinet members do not participate in televised debates. This also applies to senior MFA officials. However, most of my appearances on IRIB were in practice conducted in the form of a debate rather than an interview, albeit the debate took place with the host rather than another guest.

Following the conclusion of the JCPOA, one such program, initially scheduled for a little over an hour, turned into an interrogation lasting from close to 11 p.m. until 2 a.m. Yet not a single one of my answers was ever reflected in subsequent IRIB programming, which relentlessly attacked the agreement. In all my TV appearances, producers and directors put heavy pressure on the interviewer, barking instructions into their earpieces.

In one instance, during an inter-session break, a senior manager even stormed into the studio and told the host: “Why are you being so soft? People demand answers. Ask tougher questions.” He was so incensed that he appeared oblivious to the fact that “the adversary” he demanded be cornered was none other than the foreign minister of his own country.

That episode revived the memory of an interview I once gave to a leading Fox News anchor during my tenure as Permanent Representative to the United Nations, in the lead-up to the U.S. invasion of Iraq in 2003. The anchor posed a barrage of leading questions, clearly designed to elicit statements that could be construed as support for the American aggression. By God’s grace, she failed. What was meant to be a fifteen-minute exchange abruptly ended in less than ten minutes. Later, my colleague responsible for public diplomacy at the Mission, who had been in the control room, explained what had transpired: the producer had been screaming instructions into the anchor’s earpiece— “press him harder,” “corner him,” “trap him.” When my final response exposed the hypocrisy of U.S. policy, the enraged producer shouted: “Cut him off B...!”—using profanity toward the female anchor that I cannot repeat. Only then did I realize why several of my past interviews had ended prematurely. For those who still insist on portraying the United States as the bastion of free expression, perhaps the verse of an anonymous Persian poet serves as the best rejoinder:

Do not wander to distant lands—turn instead to your own God;
For wherever you may go, the heavens are but of the same hue.

The prevailing approach of IRIB was the systematic denigration of foreign policy and its officials—through news programming, so-called documentaries, and even films. This approach ultimately eroded national dignity and public trust. The tragic consequences of this distrust became all too evident during the unrest of autumn 2022, when the skepticism—fueled in no small part by IRIB’s partisan treatment of the foreign policy of the Rouhani Administration—spread to the entire apparatus of governance. Indeed, the language and tropes employed by IRIB did not merely target the foreign minister but undermined the credibility of the entire state.

Relations with IRIB grew particularly bitter following the production of tendentious programs such as *Gando*³⁸ and several so-called documentaries built on the false claims of a handful of individuals. These productions inflicted profound damage not only on my own reputation, but on that of the nation and its leadership as a whole. Those responsible failed to realize that, in undermining the state's foreign policy for the sake of factional rivalry, they were in fact "cutting the very branch upon which they sat." Alas, the realization—if it has come at all—arrived far too late.

Relations with print and digital media were similarly polarized. On one side stood outlets, both online and in print, that extended continued support and goodwill. On the other side were those that, even today—two years after my departure from office—cannot publish a positive headline without immediately neutralizing it with a disparaging sub-headline or a sarcastic twist.

It is doubtful whether any foreign minister since the Revolution has been subjected to such relentless attacks by IRIB and certain media factions, or been forced to answer the same repetitive accusations so frequently in the open session of the Islamic Consultative Assembly (Parliament). Even in the pre-Revolutionary era, during those rare moments of relative openness, the MFA was never assailed with such brazenness and vitriol, either in Parliament or in the press.

No Iranian foreign minister has ever engaged with global media on live, high-profile programs as extensively as I did³⁹. Admittedly, this was facilitated by my relative ease in speaking English compared to many of my predecessors. But the very act of appearing on international outlets—an arena of both great opportunity and great peril—was of unique strategic value, precisely because none of these platforms were operated by "friends of Iran."

Yet ironically, I can assert that interviews with hostile Western journalists were often less acrimonious than those with IRIB. With foreign outlets, one expected nothing but hostility and was therefore mentally prepared. But when faced with unfair treatment at the hands of a fellow

³⁸ The name of a series depicting the activities and eventual arrest of an alleged spy and the behavior of MFA in a false and demeaning manner.

³⁹ See Annex III.

countryman—be it a domestic journalist, a parliamentarian, or a political actor—the psychological impact was altogether different. At times, even the most disciplined self-control faltered, leading to reactions that were then themselves weaponized for further attacks. This campaign of distortion ultimately crystallized in the fabricated narrative: “The foreign minister smiles with the enemy, but shouts at his own compatriots.”

The Impact of Media on Politics

Can mass media—given the sheer diversity and multiplicity of outlets and actors—reshape the very nature of foreign policy? The reality is that the media has stripped diplomats of the monopoly they once held over narrative for both national leaders as well as domestic and international publics. In the past, diplomats enjoyed such a monopoly: they alone conveyed what was transpiring in the outside world. Today, this is no longer the case.

In our time, it is often the case that a head of state first learns of developments through media reports, long before hearing the accounts of his diplomats. A diplomat, engaged in negotiations or occupied with the unfolding of an event, cannot simultaneously produce and transmit the developments for the benefit of national leaders. Meanwhile, a statesman, with a mere glance at his smartphone, can instantly access the latest global developments—in multiple languages and from divergent perspectives—and thereby form his own interpretation of international affairs. In such circumstances, the diplomat’s role is reduced to reinforcing or moderating that perception; rarely can he/she alter it completely, even with facts supporting his version of reality.

If the understanding that has already taken shape in the mind of the official corresponds with the diplomat’s own, then the diplomat’s report or cable can strengthen that orientation. But if the media has disseminated false or distorted information, whether through deliberate mistranslation or error, then the diplomat’s utmost achievement is limited to tempering the resulting perception.

A case in point: following the Geneva interim agreement of November 2013, officially known as the Joint Plan of Action (JPOA) the White House

published a totally one-sided “fact sheet” A month later, The Washington Post—a paper renowned for its proximity to the U.S. foreign policy establishment—openly declared “The fact sheet distributed by the Obama administration about the nuclear agreement with Iran is notable for its omissions,” meaning it had deliberately omitted Washington’s concessions to Tehran. In fact, in an editorial headlined with striking clarity, the paper wrote: “Final Iran deal needs to balance out the concessions”⁴⁰.

Yet in our own country, ordinary citizens, media outlets, and even senior officials treated that American fact sheet—not the actual agreement, which we had translated word for word with utmost fidelity—as the basis of their judgments. Even today, many persist in relying on that document, despite the fact that the falsehood of its claims has been repeatedly demonstrated in the JCPOA and its aftermath.

This marks a profound transformation in global affairs: the end of diplomats’ monopoly over narrative. In many respects this transformation is positive, for it has also deprived powerful states and major news conglomerates of their exclusive hold over narrative, though they continue to wield disproportionate influence. At the same time, it has likewise ended the diplomat’s ability to monopolize perceptions and shape policies. This reality reinforces the imperative that under all conditions, what is required of the diplomat is honesty and factual reflection of events and developments.

It must be remembered that every person or institution producing news does so with a particular objective in mind. Newsmakers frame realities in order to advance a set of defined goals and interests. Such framing may be achieved through a subtle conceptual twist—what in media parlance is called a “spin”—through the highlighting of a single phrase from an entire paragraph, or through a misleading headline. Numerous techniques exist for this purpose. Importantly, framing does not necessarily entail outright lying; it can consist merely of wrenching a subject out of its proper context. These devices wield tremendous influence over public consciousness and, by extension, the very nature of foreign policy.

⁴⁰ Editorial Board, The Washington Post, November 28, 2013.

At no time—and especially not in the post-Revolutionary era—has the war of narratives, the relentless construction of competing accounts, and the immediacy of news been as intense as in recent years, posing challenges of an unprecedented magnitude for foreign policy.

Constructing Humiliation

The most painful reality in this regard was the narrative constructed by our own domestic media: a distorted account designed to discredit the agents of foreign policy. President Trump repeatedly declared: “I think it was one of the most incompetently drawn deals I’ve ever seen...we got nothing”⁴¹. In an interview with CNN, he stated: “They didn’t read «the art of the deal» obviously. They’re incompetent people. I watched on Charlie Rose their chief negotiator; I watched. After watching him for 5 minutes, I tweeted, I said, do not let Kerry deal with this guy. This guy [Zarif] is too smart for Kerry.”⁴²

Yet rather than using these remarks to boost national morale, our domestic media inverted them. They sought to portray matters as though America had deceived Iran. They claimed that Trump’s statements were merely ploys designed to mislead us. But when Trump praised our steadfastness on the Syrian front—an assessment that was indeed accurate—all our domestic outlets eagerly broadcast his words and exploited them to their fullest. Thus: two weights and two measures, employed with disconcerting ease.

I have long believed that national dignity and pride are, to a large extent, constructs of narrative. In 2007, when Mr. Ahmadinejad delivered a speech at Columbia University and Lee Bollinger, then President of that institution, brazenly insulted him, calling him a “petty dictator,” Iranians across the spectrum—supporters and critics alike—were outraged at the affront to the president of eighty million citizens. Yet our national broadcaster and many political currents within the country reframed that

⁴¹ <https://www.nbcnews.com/politics/white-house/art-worst-deal-trump-blasts-iran-agreement-n809986>

⁴² <http://edition.cnn.com/TRANSCRIPTS/1508/11/nday.04.html>

See also <https://www.atlanticcouncil.org/blogs/iransource/why-iran-and-the-united-states-should-negotiate/>.

same episode as a triumph of national honor. Perhaps this reframing was not entirely without justification.

Conversely, however, when an event occurred that the world universally regarded as an honor for Iran and indeed for the Islamic world, it was domestically reconstructed as humiliation and defeat. During visits to shrines within the country, a small number would shout: "You betrayed the nation, you brought disgrace upon us!" Yet when I traveled to the holy sites in Iraq, a wounded Lebanese resistance fighter embraced me and declared: "You are the pride of the Shi'a world." Iraqis, Bahrainis, Hezbollah members, Pakistanis—all echoed the same sentiment. Their perspective stemmed from international news coverage, for these were not men enamored of the West; they were steadfast members of Hezbollah. Meanwhile, our own compatriots had been fed only the narrative of our national broadcaster.

Why did a Hezbollah member from Lebanon hug me, kiss me, and thank me in Tehran, Mashhad, Karbala, and Najaf? The non-Iranian defenders of the shrines behaved the same way. When I visited the shrine of Lady Zainab (peace be upon her), the Lebanese shrine defenders and their commander, the late martyr "Dhu al-Fiqar," one of Hezbollah's prominent members who was later martyred in Syria, showed great affection. He said: "You have made the Shi'a proud." On one of my trips to Karbala, many Iraqis and Lebanese at the holy shrine kissed me, embraced me, and thanked me for making the Shi'a proud. That same day, upon leaving the shrine, an Iranian cleric angrily cursed me: "May God humiliate you for humiliating our country."

What explains these contradictory behaviors? One has seen domestic media, the other global media. Domestic media, instead of creating pride, produced humiliation; but non-Iranian Muslims and Shi'as were not influenced by Iranian media—they saw part of the truth and therefore felt pride and honor. The partisan behavior of domestic media has caused one of the greatest harms to the country, some of whose consequences were reflected in the 2022 unrest and public distrust of the authorities.

Another consequence of domestic media propaganda, detrimental to the MFA, was its destructive effect on the mindset and judgment of the middle class. The middle class believed that the foreign minister could

fulfill some of their objectives and interests. The affection shown to the foreign minister reflected trust and hope in the country's policies. However, IRIB saw this affection as a threat and did everything possible to destroy it. Most people consumed IRIB content, and the humiliation it stirred affected public perception, especially within the middle class. Ultimately, the result of this approach was the erosion of public belief in the efficiency of the governing system and not just destroying the standing of an individual.

Today, few believe that the JCPOA was a national achievement. At best, people consider it a well-intentioned but ultimately failed effort. Has anyone, even in the past few years, told the public: "The same JCPOA that we repeatedly buried actually defeated the U.S. twice in the Security Council and once more, even more humiliatingly, in the UN General Assembly?"⁴³

For eight years, domestic media bombarded people with the idea that the JCPOA was a massive trick against them. IRIB did not even attempt to publicize the above-mentioned three Iranian victories in the Security Council and the General Assembly against Trump. When the restrictions on arms and missiles ended, opponents of the JCPOA loudly celebrated it—but no one said, "Where did this achievement come from?" They even tried to claim, based on a misquoted statement from the Russian foreign minister, that the JCPOA caused the restrictions rather than lifting them.

Hypothetically, if during Ahmadinejad's administration, Dr. Jalili had managed to defeat the U.S. 110 to 10 in a General Assembly resolution, what celebrations would have erupted in the "national media"? Even if he had been able to limit a U.S. victory in the General Assembly with a ten-vote margin (against Iran) he would have been glorified for limiting U.S. victory. Surely, in that case, abstentions and absences would have been added to the negative votes in order to show that the U.S. did not receive the majority support.

⁴³ The Trump administration tried to extend the arms restrictions against Iran in the Summer of 2020 after a year of heavy campaigning in New York and in the capitals of Security Council members. The U.S. could secure only two positive votes, with 11 abstentions (including all Europeans) and 2 negative votes of Russia and China. After failing to achieve that, Pompeo wrote to the Security Council advancing a legal argument in order to restore terminated Security Council resolutions. Thirteen Council members wrote to the Council President rejecting its validity. Finally, the U.S. tried to revive sanctions enforcing mechanisms in the Secretariat through the General Assembly and it was defeated by 10 votes in favor to 110 votes against.

IRIB, which turned Columbia University's disaster into "victory," barely covered the 110 negative votes against a US amendment to reestablish sanctions monitoring bodies in the UN Secretariat—a huge slap to America and its allies. This victory should have inspired hope among the Iranian people, but because it would have enhanced the public standing of President Rouhani and me, they chose to downplay and even ignore it.

Meanwhile, for a parliamentary legislation⁴⁴—which has only had negative international consequence, the media began aggrandizing its illusional achievements, even before it was passed. The IRIB erroneously claimed that Biden's change in position for unconditional JCPOA return was due to that resolution. In fact, Biden's initial shift occurred two months earlier and mainly due to my steadfast position in a virtual speech to the U.S. Council on Foreign Relations and the extensive diplomatic efforts of the Foreign Ministry and the president. In reality, following that parliamentary legislation, Biden's stance became harsher, as can be seen in the current JCPOA challenges.

It must be acknowledged that IRIB's distortion of facts affects the middle class's perception. Most of our middle class consumes these sources and gradually believes that the country's foreign policy has failed.

Since the revolution, the MFA has always been recognized as Iran's representative abroad and supported in the most difficult circumstances. Yet during the Rouhani administrations, I was portrayed as America's representative in Iran, and anyone who wanted to criticize the U.S. insulted me instead. The ministry, which stood up to the U.S., thwarted its plots, and, as Trump admitted, tricked Kerry, showing the world that "Iran is a wise, intelligent, and capable country," was humiliated domestically. An all-out campaign to destroy the reputation of the minister and the ministry was carried out at great cost to the nation.

"Gando" was not an ordinary film. It was produced with a huge budget, based on disrepute sources, and, according to reliable reports, even IRIB managers were not allowed to view it before broadcast. The so-called "documentary" had only one objective: destroy Zarif. Truly, the fact that the

⁴⁴ The law that was enacted by Parliament in December 2020, following the terrorist assassination of the renowned Iranian nuclear scientist, Dr. Mohsen Fakhrizadeh by Israel, which imposed strict conditions for revival of JCPOA.

negotiation team can still walk in the streets, receive people's affection, and not face harassment is a great blessing and undoubtedly a manifestation of God's grace and the generosity of the people.

I have always tried to be accountable to the public for my actions. During my tenure as minister, along with my colleagues, I participated in lengthy interviews—what many called unprecedented “interrogations”—on IRIB and answered all questions clearly. Yet despite our answers, accusations continued, and our responses were ignored. After leaving office, I remained silent for nearly two years in the face of unjust and false allegations against myself and my colleagues. Finally, out of respect for the people, I participated in a six-and-a-half-hour Clubhouse session addressing all questions from internal skeptics to foreign opponents about my eight-year tenure with honesty and transparency. The discussion was immediately met with uproar from both sides, reflecting the fear and hostility of extremists toward revealing the truth.

Of course, whether as foreign minister or now as a citizen without any responsibilities other than being an associate professor at the University of Tehran, I have never allowed myself to speak in a way that would endanger Iran's national interests and security. This book has been written within that framework; I hope I have not strayed from this path.

Our hearts hold a secret vow with thee,
Though the world turns foe and our lives may flee,
Even as heads fall, steadfast we'll stay,
Bound to that oath, come what may.

(Sa'adi)

CHAPTER IV

FOREIGN RELATIONS FRAMEWORK

Foreign Policy and National Interests

Foreign policy is simply defined as planning and implementing a framework for a country's ties with other global actors with the aim of

advancing national interests. On this basis, diplomacy is the science and art of advancing national interest with minimum costs and maximum sustainability. The focal pillar of diplomacy and foreign policy is “national interests”. Therefore, in the absence of articulating and building national consensus around national interests, it would be impossible to reach understanding about diplomacy and foreign policy.

Thinkers and policymakers define national interests based on their own vision and inclinations in various forms and by taking into consideration the material pillars or a group of material and ideational components. As far as Iran’s foreign policy is concerned, Iranian thinkers have become entrapped in the unscientific and groundless dichotomy of “national interests” and “ideological interests”, born out of uni-dimensional view of power and national interests also affected by elements of external framing. National goals constitute the fundamental pillar of the material and ideational potential of every nation, especially countries like the Islamic Republic of Iran, which have relative superiority in the ideational and inspirational aspects arising from the values of the Islamic Revolution.

This valuable feature cannot and should not be dwarfed by imported intellectual propositions. “Realistic idealism⁴⁵” constitutes one of the strong pillars of Iran’s ideational power. Insistence on this approach is not only underlined in this book, which is intended for domestic Iranian readers, but has also been raised several times in my discussions with Henry Kissinger, who first underlined the inaccurate dichotomy between State and Cause. In my conversations in private meetings and broader forums, Dr. Kissinger repeated his famous fallacy about Iran, which is often repeated by some of our own intellectual without any reflection, that “Iran’s leaders [should] decide whether they are representing a cause or a nation.”⁴⁶ I responded: “Is America ready to do the same and set aside one of the pillars of its power? If you’re ready to do so, you can expect the same from Iran”. Interestingly, one of the best known and oldest students of Kissinger – himself a renowned scholar – said in one

⁴⁵ This concept has often been used by Ayatollah Seyed Ali Khamenei.

⁴⁶ Henry A. Kissinger, “The Next Steps With Iran”, *The Washington Post*, July 30, 2006.

of those meetings: “For the first time, I have to support a dissenting view from that of my professor.”

Therefore, erasing ideational dimensions off national interests would by no means help develop the economy, improve public living conditions, strengthen political clout or accelerate Iran’s all-out progress; rather, it would leave Iran more vulnerable.

Within the various sources of power, ideational dimensions are extremely important and inspiring assets. The fundamental challenge is to strike a balance and equilibrium between the pillars of national interests and national security. Under optimal conditions of good governance, all pillars of national interests and national security can be pursued without any tension or conflict. But should any conflict arise either due to mismanagement and the absence of good governance or even due to internal and external factors beyond the control of the state, which pillar of national interests and national security should be prioritized? Which component of national security should be safeguarded at any cost? Which one should not be prioritized, could be ignored or even sacrificed? If the country faces aggression, between independence and territorial integrity on one side and economic development on the other, which one should be safeguarded regardless of cost to the other? Doubtlessly we can see resisting hegemony and a uni-polar world as a pillar of Iranian national interests. But when it comes to the tough choice between resisting hegemony and supplying fundamental needs of people, which side should be picked? What if there are inconsistency and incompatibility between pillars of national interests? In order to be equipped to face challenges and crises requiring quick decision-making and urgent action, it is imperative to have a prior consensus about priorities and the ranking of national security components. The consensus building should not only encompass the polity but should also expand to the general public. Therefore, our challenge is not about individual components but the agreement upon priorities.

Diversity of Sources of Power and the Role of the People

In debates about the sources of power, those with economic responsibility insist that gross domestic product (GDP) determines power. The military actor regards the number of missiles and warships as determinants of power. Those in charge of dissemination of information claim that public opinion is the ultimate source of power. Those responsible for multilateral diplomacy maintain that the number of votes at the UN General Assembly is the deciding factor. Depending on their position, government agencies and bureaucrats view power differently; in other words, power is defined based on sectoral affiliations and interests. In this midst, the MFA is required to hold a trans-sectoral view because it represents the entire governing structure and is the symbol of national power beyond borders.

In a uni-dimensional view of power, depending on the theoretical or sectoral view of the speaker or a combination of both, military equipment, economic capabilities or global fame become indicators of national power, while in fact national power encompasses all these pillars and beyond. If military might and equipment were the single determinants of the power and influence of a nation, then for a country like Iran it is wise to submit to whims of a country whose military budget is 6070- times that of the Islamic Republic. The point I made at the University of Tehran in December 2013 and was misperceived after biased distortion was that missiles cannot represent Iran's power. Because the US can destroy these missiles and has much better hardware. What cannot be obliterated by the U.S. or any country is people's resilience. If the US receives the message that Iran's only deterrent is missile and the state has lost public support, it may not hesitate to apply its superior military power.

My words were misinterpreted as having downplayed Iran's defense power or having opposed boosting national defense. What I intended to say was that just relying on military or economic power while ignoring and sacrificing other components of power like the ideational and inspirational capabilities of the Islamic Revolution would not serve Iranian interests or augment national power to deal with the delicate complexities of the modern world. This approach would only neglect multiple aspects of national power and ultimately undermine them.

The late Imam Khomeini and the current Leader have made even stronger statements to the same effect. In a meeting with MPs on 24 January

1983, the imam said: “Never imagine that it is the military power that has kept you in place; rather, it is the power of faith and the support of the people. You have to safeguard this support. Should we lose this support, we will all be gone and Islam will fall prey to other issues”⁴⁷. Similarly, addressing people from Kerman and Khuzestan on 24 December 2023, Ayatollah Khamenei also highlighted the role of people, saying: “National unity and people’s strong presence on the scene bring about national power, which would in turn provide security, which for its part facilitate scientific progress, economic prosperity and resolution of a variety of economic, political and cultural problems”⁴⁸.

My perspective is not solely based on my theoretical or discursive approach; rather it is also based on the American analyses of Iranian power. For instance, in the late 2000s, a group of US scientists designed a plan for the obliteration of the Fordow nuclear facility, but they argued that it was not in the best interest of the U.S. to do so. They might have destroyed an enrichment facility which they suspected of being used for developing a nuclear bomb, but that would strengthen people’s will and may even push many to call for Iran to acquire nuclear bomb. Simply put, even US nuclear scientists view people’s willpower and resistance as the fundamental deterrent against military aggression on nuclear sites and not the nuclear sites providing deterrent to safeguard security.

Another case in point is the US invasion of Iraq in 2003. Since 2002 and between the US war on Afghanistan in 2001 and the aggression against Iraq, heated political debate was underway in the US about choosing the next target: Iran or Iraq. What was underway behind the scenes mainly in research and political circles was how to institutionalize the US’s temporary superiority following the defeat of the Soviet Union in the Cold War. Worries about emergence of China had panicked the US to speed up its effort to institutionalize a unipolar world. The solution agreed upon by both parties and the overwhelming majority of the polity in the US consisted of benefiting from the US’s unrivalled military strength to reach this objective. Therefore, the US invasions of Afghanistan and Iraq

⁴⁷ http://www.imam-khomeini.ir/fa/C207_43924/

⁴⁸ <https://farsi.khamenei.ir/news-content?id=54687>

were more of an attempt to institutionalize the American dominance through its superior military power than battling terrorism or weapons of mass destruction.

The Israelis and the Arab lobby embarked on a major public relations offensive to direct the US militarist urge against Iran and persuade Washington to launch military operations against Iran. Israel's then prime minister, Ariel Sharon, travelled to Washington to warn the Bush administration that Iran poses a greater threat than the Iraqi regime of Saddam Hussein⁴⁹. Emboldened by the Zionist lobby, the Arab lobby started pushing the message that "Boys go to Baghdad, but men go to Tehran" in a bid to push the US to launch the second post-911/ invasion on Iran. Disclosure of the Natanz enrichment project in summer 2002 was timed to coincide with the joint effort by Israel, Arab governments and their mercenaries in the Mujahideen Khalq Organization (MKO) to direct U.S. military preparations against Iran instead of Iraq. However, the US invaded Iraq for two reasons although Iraq was probably more capable than Iran in terms of the amount and sophistication of weapons and traditional military power:

1. Global security consensus against Iraq from 1991 to 2002, built through a large number of UN resolutions under Chapter VII of the UN Charter, which had even rendered war-weary countries like Russia, China, France and Germany incapable of backing Iraq. Twelve years of intense securitization had increased political costs of supporting Iraq while reducing diplomatic costs of an outright military aggression.

2. The Iranian people's support of their governing structure during President Khatami as opposed to Saddam Hussein's lack of majority support had brought the US to the conclusion that war on Iraq despite its sophisticated weapons would be a blitzkrieg victory while invading Iran, with solid public support, would result in a quagmire stranding the U.S. forces in this vast country.

Therefore, we need to reconstruct our own cognitive system about various sources of power, causes of vulnerability and even means of deterrence against invasion and external security and intelligence

⁴⁹ "Israel Emphasizes Iranian Threat", Washington Post, February 7, 2002

infiltration. As it was noted, our Constitution's view of national power and security is multi-faceted, which is very constructive and prevents uni-faceted view of national power and capabilities. A uni-dimensional political, economic or military view or any other view neglecting numerous and diverse sources of power and various exigencies of governance would fundamentally impair the decision-making process. The rationality system in each of these sectors is born out of necessities and characteristics of that specific sector, and measuring one with criteria of others would result in strategic missteps. For instance, when the system of rationality and social concepts and even terminology are militarized and other pillars of national interests are addressed through a military prism, it would mean that in all domains, zero-sum approach would dominate, just like in the battlefield. Using such words as "frontline" and "bunkers" in diplomacy and "garrison and barracks" for economy and culture would imply the dominance of a military approach in various agencies of national governance system. Diplomacy, economy, culture, social solidarity and even security cannot be successful and achieve optimal results through a zero-sum perspective and approach. Success cannot be achieved unless interests of all participants are taken into account and addressed. Zero-sum games are detrimental to all actors, invariably resulting in negative sum outcomes. Everyone will lose, albeit in different measures and quantities. In my view, that constitutes one of the fundamental cognitive difficulties and challenges in the country and the world for that matter. Unless it is remedied, our diplomacy would remain unsuccessful and vulnerable.

Another challenge is associated with the requirement for diplomacy to be trans-sectoral. Foreign policy should not be limited to the shuttling of ambassadors. Because of its responsibility for all external relations, the MFA is required to hold a military, economic, security and political perspective of development at the same time. In our country, the MFA has been downgraded to an apparatus responsible for implementing only a portion of foreign policy and not even the entire foreign policy, let alone foreign relations. In fact, the MFA is not able to exercise strategic management of foreign ties. In some other nations, the Minister of Foreign Affairs may represent foreign policy rather than symbolize foreign ties, but in fact the MFA is required to hold a trans-sectoral vision. That is why

Ayatollah Khamenei has said time and again that the MFA is shouldering half of government's job⁵⁰. The reason is that the MFA is responsible for the external activities of all domestic agencies. That is one vision of foreign policy.

The other vision is that each agency has its own foreign policy with the MFA regulating only ties with ambassadors and similar tasks, in which case the MFA would turn into a department of diplomatic relations. Today, this second vision is dominant in the country. Nonetheless, every time any challenge emerges, everyone refers to the MFA. More clearly, the MFA is not given sufficient authority, but it is held accountable for all and everything. That constitutes a fundamental challenge for the foreign policy establishment. The challenge is not limited to the military sector. When such divergence and discord exist within the cabinet, not much can be expected from agencies outside the Cabinet.

In short, diplomacy is the manifestation of the compilation of power of a country and constitutes in itself a key instrument to augment national power. That is my cognitive framework and doubtlessly it has had behavioral and discursive reflections. In my view, the cognitive approach and professional inclinations of various practitioners and analysts must be transparently articulated, as they fundamentally impact their conceptual perception of power and their behavior in its pursuit in the outside world.

Priorities

After agreement on the concept of power and the status of diplomatic apparatus in advancing national interests, we must reach internal consensus about prioritization of national interests. Of course, before this phase, thinkers and leaders of political parties and groups are required to clarify their own approaches and perspectives on pillars of national interests and their priorities. There are those who see GDP as the top priority in the pillars of national interests while there are those who give priority to military power and missiles. Some intellectuals believe that GDP decides which country is powerful and some others maintain that

⁵⁰ "The foreign policy apparatus is administering half of the political establishment and prepares the ground for security and national interests." (<https://farsi.khamenei.ir/news-content?id=18427>)

development and prosperity constitute the main priority of a national government. In my view, the priority of national government is to offer a coherent approach to augmenting all pillars of power to yield the best output for increasing influence and reducing the vulnerability of a country. What are the factors to help reduce vulnerabilities and make national influence optimal? Doubtlessly, in all assessments, people should enjoy a focal standing because good governance, development and even military power and deterrence would result in no actual and meaningful power in the absence of the support and backing of the people. Only within such framework may we be able to classify Iran's national interests as follows and determine a conceptual framework of foreign policy.

In all schools of thought and traditions, the most pivotal component of national interests is survival. The survival of a country and nation is not identical with regime survival and is the highest priority in the rankings of national interest of all nations. Morgenthau puts it as follows: "The meaning of national interest is survival—the protection of physical, political and cultural identity against encroachments by other nation-states".

Within our framework, national sovereignty and independence and then territorial integrity constitute the most fundamental pillars of national interests and national security. However, in my view, for the Islamic Republic, there are two ideational pillars on a par with territorial integrity: first, domestic legitimacy and public satisfaction and second, national dignity. Safeguarding these two pillars would be essential for survival, independence, national sovereignty, national identity and territorial integrity. Although dignity is constructed, a dignified image of the Islamic Republic internally and externally is imperative for national interests and national security. In the following layers lie sustainable development and public welfare, which can be considered prerequisites for public legitimacy and even national dignity. Domestic security and solidarity also constitute pillars of national interests, which is firmly linked with the deterrence power of a country like Iran.

Increasing international power in the sense of bolstering influence and reducing vulnerability constitutes another pillar of national interests. As it was said, power is not limited to material components. Military power is the key element in national power, but ideational capabilities, particularly

presenting an inspiring model of governance, are inseparable sources of power as well. Inspiration is the focal pillar of influence that should be pursued through ideational dimensions and not physical extension of presence. This fact has become more than clear for even the top world military power. Other pillars of national interests may include useful global links, presence in regional arrangements and the global image of the country.

Post-Polar Global Order

After the Cold War ended, global structures have become fluid, and they can no longer impose the former strict and rigid frameworks on actors that determined the consequences of acts in advance. In such fluid circumstances, significant or aspiring actors take a revolutionary attitude, trying to enhance their standing through calculated endeavors in the areas of their relative advantage. In the same manner that a correct realization and analysis of prevailing global conditions and smart planning based on such knowledge can significantly augment the status of actors in the global community, an inaccurate calculation may lead to annihilation.

The sources and centers of power have become numerous and diverse, and states have lost their monopoly on global interactions. Three decades of efforts to construct a unipolar hegemonic order through “forever wars”, “securitization” and “economic coercion” ended in failure after inflicting immense sufferings and unforgivable human losses while wasting immeasurable blood and treasure. On the other hand, ideologically oriented and biased theories like the “end of history”, “clash of civilizations” and “construction of enemy” in addition to similar theories and political constructs have failed to achieve the intended outcomes.

Academic research, four decades of practice in the global field, and theoretical and practical reflections have led me to the view that the emerging global order is a “post-polar” order; not unipolar, bipolar, multipolar, or any combination thereof. Although vast disparity will continue to exist in the amount of material and ideational capabilities that various actors possess, and while the US, and few other actors will retain much greater material and ideational power than others for the

foreseeable future, this asymmetry will not lead to the formation of new poles. Formation of a pole in the global system is not achieved by having great power alone; rather, it also requires mutual loyalty between center and the periphery.

A large number of state and non-state actors are engaged in "cooperation", "competition" and "networking" in various sectors simultaneously. Gone is the era of permanent alliances. Temporary and issue coalitions are emerging across the globe at a high pace. In this framework, networks with state and nonstate actors will be the most outstanding manifestation of cooperation and synergy alongside competition in transnational issue regimes. Evidently, all network nodes are not homogenous and identical.

In the post-polar fluid world, human agency holds a key and fundamental standing, whether acting as national, transnational or nonstate decision-makers and decision-formers. Geopolitical determinism is obsolete and meaningless in today's world. Although restrictive or facilitative political, geographical and strategic factors are not without impact, all these factors cannot force human actors to follow a specific policy. Despite all significant progress in technology and artificial intelligence, human agency will remain a decisive factor in the foreseeable future.

Under such circumstances, the most decisive prerequisite for constructive behavior is a realistic knowledge of our own situation and the circumstances in the world around us. Based on such well-grounded appreciation of the reality coupled with sober assessment of one's comparative advantage, one can improve the standing of his/her country and enhance national security and peace of mind for citizens.

Post-Cold War international relations have become specially complicated in that war and conflict among big powers that previously marked periods of transition have now turned into a tense rivalry for institutionalizing relative advantages in order to obtain and maintain an enhanced and elevated position in the future world order.

Most global actors of significance have adopted a revolutionary posture. In this period of transition, where the strict and rigid structure of the bipolar order has evaporated and the role of the human agent and his/her intelligent choice has increased, global decision-makers aim to enhance and improve their standing in the future order through calculated action

focusing on the area(s) of their relative strengths: the US in security affairs, the EU in normative standard-setting, China in trade, industry and innovation, Russia in the energy sector and other actors in fields they deem to have potential capabilities.

The end of the Cold War was a failure for the Eastern bloc rather than a victory for the Western bloc. However, motivated by the illusion of victory in the Cold War, which was further entrenched by its leadership of a UN-backed global coalition to drive Iraqi forces out of Kuwait and its ability to topple Iraqi government even without UN approval, the US endeavored to utilize its undeniable military superiority to establish and institutionalize a US-dominated unipolar world order. That policy was pursued by US presidents, both Democrat and Republican, since the end of the Cold War from 1991 until the invasion of Iraq in 2003. Bill Clinton's wars on Sudan, Somalia, Libya, Iraq, Yugoslavia and Kosovo among others were indicative of the US polity's relative consensus on the method of belligerence and even direct conflict in the war with middle powers for constructing a "New World Order" and the "New American Century" with the US military superiority and dominance. The growing aggressive unilateralism of the United States under President Bush Jr. and Neoconservatives reached its climax during the so called "War on Terror", invasion of Afghanistan in 2001 and Iraq in 2003 – which later became known as "forever wars", all of which were designed to institutionalize and entrench U.S. global dominance.

This policy clearly proved to be inefficient in achieving its intended real objective. Failure of American "forever wars" during a 14-year period between the end of the Cold War until war on Iraq and their fallout were such that in 2005, the bipartisan "Iraq Study Group" commission, led by Republican James Baker and Democrat Lee Hamilton, was established by Congress to investigate the failure. The commission's investigations concluded that the so-called War on Terror, which in reality was a pseudo name for a battle for control, had failed⁵¹. By admitting to the inefficiency of war, the US decided in mid-2000s to shift its policy from "Forever

⁵¹ <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/GPO-IRAQSTUDYGROUP/pdf/GPO-IRAQSTUDYGROUP.pdf>

Wars” to “securitization” and toughening economic warfare in the form of sanctions and weaponizing the US dollar, particularly following the 2008 global financial crisis.

One idea that can give cause to researchers for more study may be the fact that the initiators of wars in the 20th and 21st centuries failed in their war efforts or were even obliterated. Doubtlessly, before waging any war, the initiators always imagine relative or total superiority over the target. However, extremely few of them achieved their declared objectives once the conflict ended. That does not mean forecasting the end of war; rather, it implies its inefficiency and disutility. The inefficiency of war portrays another growing trend in global relations: zero-sum game is no longer possible. There would be positive-sum or negative-sum games.

Islamic teachings also favor peace and compromise over conflict and bloodletting. The holy Quran (verses 8:5564-) while recommending preparation for war as deterrent, the Quran underlines that ultimate power rests on divine aide and public support. Some may only consider verses 8:5560- where harsh action against belligerent non-believers is recommended, but immediately after the strongest call for defense preparations as means of deterrence against treaty-breaking non-believers, the Holy Book holds: “If the enemy is inclined towards peace, make peace with them”. The following verses reiterate that in the case of continued enemy betrayal, the pillar of power stands on divine help and people’s support and not weaponry or even means of communication.

Securitization: Israel’s Weapon of Choice

Securitization is a very useful concept theorized by Barry Buzan and his Copenhagen School to underline a process that Israel had already developed into a manipulative scheme. Through disinformation campaigns, a securitizer portrays issues that are not essentially threatening to domestic or global communities as a serious, even existential, threat to them, justifying extraordinary measures. This theory provides useful means to explore how the idea of threat is generated, how enemies are constructed and how specific actors use the constructed discourse in their political favor. It involves four elements: a securitizing actor; a speech act to

aggrandize an issue to the level of an existential threat; a referent object that is threatened requiring protection with extraordinary measures; and an audience whose acceptance is required for the extraordinary measures.⁵²

Securitization, manufacturing of enemies, fearmongering and “threat relocation” have been exploited by the Israeli regime as preferred tools for domestic governance and global interactions. First, Zionists exploited the dark history of European antisemitism followed by their Holocaust atrocities to blackmail major European powers into transporting Europe’s “Jewish problem” into the Middle East and then acting as accomplices in driving Palestinian out of their ancestral homeland. After Nikbah, newly founded Israel tried to portray the victims of Israeli occupation as the culprits, using the same securitization tactics that they had already mastered in Europe.

The new Zionist rulers of Palestine developed a two-pronged strategy of victimization and invincibility in a more advanced pursuit of their old policy of occupation, repression and expansionism. Through this wicked duo, relocated the focus of fearmongering and securitization to Palestinians and Arabs framing them as antisemitic terrorists, posing a grave danger not just to the repressive occupiers but to the entire global community. Their well-publicized motto of “never again” deceptively exploited the historical guilt of Europeans to bridge victimization with invincibility, quieting global horror over their apartheid, repression and massive violation of human rights of the original inhabitants of the now-occupied Palestine. That is, they tried to justify brute force by claiming imminent existential threat that would repeat the Holocaust. Ironically, Holocaust culprits accepted their victims to victimized Palestinians and more generally the people of West Asia, who not only did not participate in that crime, but even open their doors to Jewish refugees fleeing Nazi atrocities. This wicked strategy has worked so well that Israel uses “existential threat” more often than any other country. In reality, serious scholarship would establish that the only “existential threat” to Israeli aggressors is peace and tranquility in the neighborhood, which they have historically obstructed and undermined.

⁵² M. J. Zarif and Seyed Jamal Aldin Afjei, “Trump’s Campaign to Re-securitize Iran”, *International Studies Journal (ISJ)*, Vol. 20, No. 2 (78). Fall 2023, pp. 236–7.

Iran entered the picture in early 1990s, when under pressure from the Bush administration, the Israeli regime had to opt for peace talks with Palestinian and Arabs. To justify to their own population that they were ostensibly opting for peace with their long-advertised “existential” enemy, Yitzhak Rabin and his administration had to manufacture a new enemy, Iran. Helped by then leftist hardliners (turned reformist later in the 1990s), they portrayed Iran as the new enemy, an existential national threat⁵³ even distorting their scripture.

By mid-1990s, they expanded their securitization audience to the entire international community by fabricating a nuclear threat emanating from Iran. Interesting but painful is that the Israeli securitization of Iran began precisely following the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait and when the Islamic Republic had found an appropriate space for global act. Saddam Hussein and his Arab allies had conducted a securitization of their own against the new inexperienced Iranian revolutionary leaders, exploiting their rhetoric to portray Iran as a dangerous regime against whom a war of aggression in which chemical weapons had been used and targeting civilian quarters had become a routine practice was justified. When Saddam Hussein turned his guns against his closest ally and war accomplice by invading Kuwait, the vilification of Iran was shattered, and Iran was allowed to participate in regional and global activities. I personally was one of the beneficiaries of that new atmosphere, being elected in 1992 as chairman of an important main committee of the UN General Assembly at age 32, while the average age of members of that committee – all prominent international jurists – was no less than 60. Iran’s Arab neighbors started warming up to Iran and the United States engaged with Iran through the United Nations. However, the Israeli lobby in the United States magnified Iran’s opposition to the so-called peace process – using the conference organized by the Majlis bringing together the rejectionist factions of the

⁵³ Israeli political scientist Ephraim Inbar noted that Rabin exaggerated the Iranian threat partly to strengthen U.S.-Israel ties post-Cold War and “sell the peace process.” This contrasts with Rabin’s earlier 1987 view of Iran as Israel’s “best friend,” highlighting the pragmatic evolution in rhetoric to support diplomatic goals like the Oslo Accords. (Menashri, David and Trita Parsi, “Israeli Relations with Iran,” *Encyclopedia Iranica*, Vol. XIV, Fasc. 2, pp. 213-223) Also see Porter, Gareth, “Israel’s Construction of Iran as an Existential Threat”, *Journal of Palestine Studies*, Vol. 45, No. 1 (177) (Autumn 2015), pp. 43-62.

Palestinian movement – in order to reverse that trend to the point that Brent Scowcroft – Bush Sr.’s National Security Advisor – sent a message to Iran through the representative of the UN Secretary-General saying that President Bush is unable to deliver his campaign promise of “good will begets good will” in return for Iranian assistance in releasing American prisoners in Lebanon in 1991. Bush finally lost his re-election bid, probably as a result of losing favor with Israel and its strong supporters in American media and financial and political establishment.

The accusations against Iran pursuing nuclear weapons were instrumental in convincing the global audience of Iranian imminent threat, requiring extraordinary measures. Very interestingly, these accusations were leveled by first of the four non-NPT nuclear weapons possessors (sequentially Israel, India, Pakistan and North Korea) against a country that was an NPT non-nuclear-weapon state with comprehensive safeguards agreement with the IAEA and the main sponsors of the 1974 UN General Assembly resolution to declare a nuclear weapons free zone in the Middle East – a resolution that has been left unimplemented because of Israel.

This fact indicates that securitization is more about creating narratives and perceptions and far less about realities on the ground – a fact that has regrettably been neglected by Iranian decision makers and general polity with grave consequences to the detriment of Iran’s national security and economic prosperity of Iranian people. The persistent messaging by Israel, most stubbornly by Netanyahu since early 1990s, coupled with the dominance of the Zionist lobby in the media and “Israel firsters” in Washington and some European capitals turned this misinformation campaign into an unchallengeable “political reality”. The impact of this securitization campaign has been so pervasive that it has now become a habit to call the Iranian nuclear program as “Iranian nuclear weapons program”, despite repeated IAEA reports – even under the worst circumstances – that there is no evidence of diversion of Iran’s peaceful nuclear program.⁵⁴ Even academics, including Iranian academics have seldom found the courage to challenge this pseudo-scientific orthodoxy, trying to use meaningless concepts such as “legal capability” – creating

⁵⁴ GOV/2006/15

the infrastructure but stopping short of producing an actual nuclear bomb – unknowingly admitting the ultimate goal of weaponization.

Israel's persistent securitization effort is the primary culprit in this self-perpetuating lie – something one of my students has called “securitization cycle.” In 1992, Netanyahu, as a member of Knesset, alleged in a speech before Israeli Knesset that “Iran is 3 to 5 years from being able to produce a nuclear weapon.”⁵⁵ In a book in 1995, he repeated the same time frame for Iran developing an actual bomb.⁵⁶ Shortly after becoming the regime's prime minister, Netanyahu told U.S. Congress on 10 July 1996 that “Iran is racing to arm itself with atomic bombs... deadline⁵⁷... getting extremely close... time is running out.”⁵⁸

Israel intensified its securitization campaign in the 2001 to 2003 period against Iran in two important potential turning points, when windows of opportunity were briefly opened and immediately shut primarily by Israeli campaign. Following the terrorist operations of 11 September 2001 and Iran's invaluable assistance in removing the Taliban from Kabul and its pivotal diplomatic role in breaking the impasse at the Bonn Conference in 2001 – which included the first direct Iran-US engagement since the revolution, everyone expected a breakthrough in U.S. Iranian relations. Positive statements were made by Secretary of State Collin Powel and U.S. representative James Dobbins at the U.S. Senate⁵⁹ attesting to Iran's pivotal role.

However, hardly a month after the historic Bonn Conference, Iran was included in the “Axis of Evil” along with Iraq and North Korea by President Bush in his State of the Union address to U.S. Congress. That speech not only shattered the hope of any immediate improvement but added to the already long list of Iranian grievances. The hardliners still use that episode as a proof of U.S. betrayal and hostility even in the face

⁵⁵ K. J. Heller, “Yet Another Estimate of When Iran Will Have the Bomb,” <https://opiniojuris.org/2013/01/28/yet-another-estimate-of-when-iran-will-have-the-bomb/>

⁵⁶ B. Netanyahu, *Fighting Terrorism: How Democracies Can Defeat Domestic & International Terrorists* (NY: Farrar, Straus and Giroux)

⁵⁷ As far as I can remember, he even made a time estimate of six months, but I was unable to find a reference.

⁵⁸ <https://theintercept.com/2015/03/02/brief-history-netanyahu-crying-wolf-iranian-nuclear-bomb/>
<https://www.nytimes.com/1996/07/11/world/in-netanyahu-congress-sees-familiar-spin.html>

⁵⁹ <https://2001-2009.state.gov/r/pa/rmo/hglt/01/octdec/7183.htm>

of Iranian good will – compounding the previously mentioned negative experience of 1991 Lebanon prisoner exchange.

Just like 1991, this time too, Israel had a central role in preventing de-securitization of Iran. On January 4, 2002 – about two weeks before the State of the Union address – Israeli foreign ministry issued a statement claiming that “A ship carrying weapons intended for the Palestinian Authority was captured in the Red Sea by Israel's Navy and Air Force... The shipment included both 122 mm. and 107 mm. Katyusha rockets, which have ranges of 20 and 8 kilometers respectively. It also contained 80 mm. and 120 mm. mortar shells, various types of anti-tank missiles, anti-tank mines, sniper rifles, Kalashnikov rifles and ammunition. From Gaza, the 122 mm. Katyushas could have threatened Ashkelon and other coastal cities; while from the West Bank, Ben-Gurion International Airport and several major Israeli cities would have been within their range... The ship was purchased by the Palestinian Authority, loaded with weapons by the Iranians and the Hezbollah...”⁶⁰

President Bush's speech writer, David Frum, a conservative Canadian American Zionist – who later wrote speeches of Israeli ambassador⁶¹ – used the excuse to torpedo any possible U.S. Iran reproachment by including an unlikely candidate – Iran – as the third member of the “Axis of Evil.”

There may have been some justification for including Iraq – under UN sanctions for 11 years following the invasion of Kuwait – and North Korea – having withdrawn from the NPT and detonated a nuclear device. But Iran under President Khatami that promoted dialogue among civilization and had just played an instrumental role in establishing a U.S. supported transitional government in Afghanistan was the most far-fetched candidate for third place. However, while the Karine-A story had many holes in any reality-check, it came exactly at the opportune moment for Israel to justify a very effective securitization speech act, which may have changed the course of history. This episode once again proved that securitization occurs in the realm of discourse and narratives with fundamentally different operational mechanics than objective reality.

⁶⁰ “Seizing of the Palestinian weapons ship Karine A - Jan 4- 2002”, Press Communique from Israeli Ministry of Foreign Affairs.

⁶¹ <https://www.dropsitenews.com/p/david-frum-douglas-murray-secretly>

The next episode started with sinister attempt to push the U.S. into war with Iran instead of Iraq, which despite failing opened a new chapter that has dragged until today and probably much longer. Few weeks after the Axis of Evil speech, Ariel Sharon – then regime’s prime minister – visited Washington in early February 2002 and in the midst of the U.S. internal debate about the next target of the U.S. campaign to institutionalize a unipolar global order using its military superiority – dubbed as “the War on Terror.” While Bush and his team were inclined to invade Iraq, Sharon argued that the “Baghdad is the wrong address” and the real threat comes from Tehran.⁶² This campaign coincided with an Arab drive to prevent a war against Iraq – what they considered to be a great gift to Iran by destroying its arch enemy and a major disruption of regional balance to their perceived detriment. “Boys go to Baghdad, while real men go to Tehran” was heard in Washington more often than expected.

The last episode in this diversion effort occurred in early August 2002. A triad of Israeli securitizing intelligence, Arab money and MEK (Mojahedin-e-Khalq) subservience to Saddam Hussein – coupled with their illusion of grabbing power in Iran – came together to create probably one of the biggest securitization operations in history. Financed by Saddam Hussein’s money, augmented by Saudi fortunes and Israeli aerial photos of Natanz, on 5 August 2002, the MEK and its front organization NCRI (National Council of Resistance of Iran) organized a press conference in the National Press Club to expose a huge secret Iranian enrichment facility in Natanz. While they claimed that they had gathered the secret information themselves, it was clear and later established by incontrovertible evidence that the source of information was Mossad.⁶³

The show failed to convince the Bush administration to change the target of its next “forever war” and Sharon conceded defeat by supporting the war against Iraq later in August. The reasons were clear. Iran was a much larger country, with difficult train and resistant people, and a “shock

⁶² <https://www.washingtonpost.com/archive/politics/2002/02/07/israel-emphasizes-iranian-threat/>

⁶³ G. Porter, “Guess who credits the Mossad with producing the ‘laptop documents’?”, *Middle East Eye*, 13 February 2015, <https://www.middleeasteye.net/opinion/guess-who-credits-mossad-producing-laptop-documents>. See also J. Lewis, <https://www.armscontrolwonk.com/archive/201274/ncri-did-not-discover-natanz/>

and awe”⁶⁴ victory was impossible. Furthermore, under the reforms of President Khatami, the Iranian public were much more sympathetic to their government than the Iraqis who had been brutalized by Saddam Hussein for decades – particularly the Shia majority and the Kurds. Second, a war against Iraq was much less difficult to justify after 12 years of ultimate global securitization through a barrage of Security Council resolutions as opposed to Iran which had somehow mended its global image under Khatami.

But the show was successful in staging a long and bitter crisis for Iran. The audience of the securitization act had strong reasons for not falling into the trap of war against Iran at that time. But they were receptive to the idea of preventing Iran from reaping the benefits of the fall of Taliban in the East and Saddam Hussein in the West. It is hard to imagine any country having difficulty with such an eventuality. It has to be underlined that Iran had committed technical violations of the safeguards agreement. The Iranian Atomic Energy Organization, naively believed that it was not important to refrain from very small enrichment activity that had been carried out in a rather insignificant facility called Kalay-e-Electric, which had enriched small quantities up to 1.2%. In fact, it was a technical violation. But that could not have been the subject of so much fanfare. Natanz facility – which in 2002 was no more than a huge construction project – was a different story. Its aerial photographs could attract fear and concern. Once again, facts in securitization do not matter as much as narratives. The framing – speech act – was so professionally developed that no one took the technical details and legalities into account. Iran was not legally obliged to report Natanz earlier than 180 days before fissile material was introduced. And none had been. While Kalay-e-Electric was a violation, but it was quite insignificant. But the professional Israeli narrative made it a huge deal that continues to haunt Iran to this day. Every time we argued with the Western countries about their hypocritical approach, they parroted this sentence “but you didn’t report your program. What were you hiding?” It is all about securitization, narratives and framing. It cannot be countered with legalities, as many in Iran wish.

It requires the same techniques in a so-called de-securitization process. Regrettably in Iran, the public perceives that as weakness and timidity. And that is how Israel won the securitization game from 1991-2013- and again from 2021 till now. Imagine an illegal nuclear weapon possessor becoming a claimant in a non-proliferation dispute and imposing six Chapter VII Security Council resolutions against a member of the NPT in relatively good standing. The significance of Chapter VII resolutions is the title of that Chapter of the U.N. Charter: "Threats to Peace, Breaches of Peace and Acts of Aggression." When a country is under Chapter VII, it connotes that at the least the Security Council considers that country a significant threat to peace and security. In securitization jargon, that would amount to the ultimate success of securitizer's speech act, convincing the most important security audience in the world – that is the UN Security Council with primary responsibility under the Charter for maintenance of international peace and security.

The brief de-securitization by the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) was never understood in Iran. Yet, it was aptly understood by Netanyahu who vowed to destroy it and eventually did, because unlike Iranian polity which played into his hand by neglecting securitization, he approached it 100% within that paradigm. I will deal with JCPOA later in this book but let me just make a few points here in this discussion.

In my confirmation testimony before the Majlis in August 2013, I made it clear that my first and foremost priority was to reverse the global security consensus against Iran. In an essay I wrote in the prestigious American journal, *Foreign Affairs* in its May-June 2014 issue, I rephrased some of what I had already testified before Iranian parliament as follows: "The top priority is to diffuse and ultimately defeat the international anti-Iranian campaign, spearheaded by Israel and its American benefactors, who seek to "securitize" Iran—that is, to delegitimize the Islamic Republic by portraying it as a threat to the global order. The main vehicle for this campaign is the "crisis" over Iran's peaceful nuclear program—a crisis that, in Iran's view, is wholly manufactured and therefore reversible."⁶⁵

⁶⁵ M. J. Zarif, "What Iran Wants," *Foreign Affairs*, May, June 2014.

Fifteen months after that essay, following the conclusion of the JCPOA on 14 July 2015, the United Nations Security Council adopted resolution 2231 on 20 July 2015, terminating all previous Chapter VII resolutions against Iran. To underline the importance of this paradigm shift – de-securitization – of Iran, the resolution in paragraph 7 of its preamble “Affirm[ed] that conclusion of the JCPOA marks a fundamental shift in its consideration of this issue...” It is a source of deep regret for me that in the political climate overwhelmed with the dignity it saw in enrichment and economic opportunity in the lifting of sanctions, I was unable to impress upon my compatriots the singular importance of de-securitization. Netanyahu did not oppose the nuclear deal because it provided economic relief for Iran, nor because it did not address the issue of proliferation. In fact, had he been concerned with an alleged imminent Iranian bomb within six months (for 30 years) he should have jumped at the opportunity to at the very least postpone that threat for 1015- years. But as my colleague has argued in his scholarly essay⁶⁶, the primary reason for objecting to the JCPOA, particularly by Israel, was the fact that it was capable of reversing the process of securitization of Iran. Alas, some in Iran unwittingly aided and abetted Israel and are even proud of it.

Securitization has also been growingly used by the U.S. particularly in the aftermath of Baker-Hamilton report of 2006, confessing the failure of U.S. overt military intervention during 19912003- to achieve their ultimate objective⁶⁷. Iran’s nuclear challenge and the Ukraine crisis are two outstanding examples of this US strategy on the global stage. The United States has been reluctant ever since the Baker-Hamilton report to engage in direct military operations abroad – particularly ground offensives – and resorted increasingly to trapping its adversaries in securitization traps. Even Obama’s diplomatic gestures to Iran during 20092010- period were conning securitization moves to convince the global audience of the peaceful intentions of the United States and the intransigence of Iran under President Ahmadinejad. These maneuvers paved the diplomatic

⁶⁶ Soltaninejad, M. (2022). “Netanyahu’s Rhetoric on Iran: Securitization or Sincere Expression of Fear”. *Journal of World Sociopolitical Studies*, 6(2), 305-341.

⁶⁷ <https://www.govinfo.gov/content/pkg/GPO-IRAQSTUDYGROUP/pdf/GPO-IRAQSTUDYGROUP.pdf>

road for the adoption of UN Security Council resolution 1929 – one of the worst and most far-reaching Security Council decisions against any country. It is only in this context that the value of JCPOA and UNSCR 2231 as a successful de-securitization campaign at the height of US-Israel securitization as well as Netanyahu's violent opposition to the JCPOA can be understood.

The deceptive role of the United States in the Russian war against Ukraine is a very interesting and instructive example of securitization trap. The United States had been concerned for some time over Russia's growing energy and economic ties with Europe in spite of its annexation of Crimea and the increasing calls in Europe for "strategic autonomy" particularly during the first Trump administration. Without becoming a victim of conspiracy theory, my limited readings on the subject and following the news in the media indicate to me that the plan by the United States to kill three birds with one stone involved trapping Russian into "overextending" in Ukraine.⁶⁸ By cynically using Ukraine as the proverbial sacrificial lamb, the Biden administration would provoke the confident and prudent President Putin into a securitization trap of invading a European country, thereby killing all normalization efforts with Europe, imposing heavy economic, military and prestige cost on Russia, proving to the European their total dependence on the United States even for the security of their continent – which was gradually eroding after 1990 Balkan crisis, and reviving NATO under U.S. leadership thus compelling Europe to shelve its desires for strategic autonomy. And the U.S. achieved this through clever multi-layered securitization speech acts. While this fact does not absolve President Putin of his accountability with regard to aggression against Ukraine, it indicates how discursive power can in fact have geopolitical ramifications of immense magnitude.

Securitization is intertwined with the "enemy paradigm." The unifying parameter in many global acts of the United States, be it in unilateral invasion strategy or securitization strategy or economic warfare, is the "need for enemy as a tool for global governance" and hegemonic

⁶⁸ J. Dobbins, "Overextending and Unbalancing Russians", https://www.rand.org/pubs/research_briefs/RB10014.html

domination. The same hold true for Israel at the regional level. As an effective, albeit imprudent, tool for governance, the “enmity paradigm” diverts and projects the source of all difficulties and challenges simply into an “enemy” or even a manufactured enemy. This approach divides the world into “either with us or against us” or “friends and foes”.

In this age-old method, the strategy for tackling difficulties and achieving global peace, security and progress lie in blaming the “enemy” and eliminating the “enemy” from all processes while ignoring and justifying all errors of “friends”.

The need for an “enemy” in this governance paradigm is so fundamental that, if need be, such enemy should be constructed and even fabricated. As we discussed earlier, after choosing to enter the Oslo accord and Madrid talks, Israel had to replace the “old enemy” with a “new enemy” in order to safeguard domestic solidarity in negotiating with the Palestinians. At the same time, it continued to commit violence, repression and persistent and systematic violation of Palestinian human rights.

In the US, following the end of the Cold War, efforts got seriously under way to construct and even fabricate a new enemy in political and even academic circles. To that end, the idea was to replace the Soviet Union – or the “Evil Empire” as President Reagan put it – with a new enemy identified by “Clash of Civilizations”, “War on Terror” and “Axis of Evil”.

In the prevalent American and Israeli military-security perspective, global relations are planned and implemented within the cognitive framework of inevitable conflict and zero-sum games. As discussed earlier, the ultimate outcome of a zero-sum approach with those conveniently labeled as “enemy” is “negative-sum” in the current globalized world. In other words, actors lose albeit in varying amounts.

Contrary to this US vision born out of its military superiority, other major global actors have opted for economic and normative competition. In these fields, positive-sum games are deemed possible and even favorable and in the interest of actors. Despite the shift in the US approach from military conformation to securitization, the dominant American approach is still security-based and zero-sum. The prevailing paradigm is exclusion and enmity and attempting to drag rivals to play in the American preferred field, because of the perceived U.S. superiority in the security realm.

As a more complicated method in advancing the objectives of security actors, securitization requires convincing domestic and global audiences for building global consensus against the target nation. The discursive nature of securitization and the globalization of communications, information and even emotions have resulted in such complexities. Because of this, the target actor can be vigilant to avoid falling in the trap set by “securitizing actors” and neutralize or even reverse this complex and multilayer strategy. This requires proper appreciation of modern world complexities, and thereby distinguishing real “security considerations and concerns” from “securitizing narratives” and “threat” from “fearmongering”. Smart securitization targets must avoid the lucrative trap of playing into of the hands of securitizers who always try to massage the ego of the unknowing targets enticing them to verify and corroborate the exaggerated claims of securitizer about the target’s strengths and capabilities. Without such sober awareness of the trap, it is impossible to neutralize “securitizing speech act” and the threat perception they want to project onto domestic and global audience. This is difficult, but completely possible to thwart the efforts to build domestic and global consensus against the target.

The foregoing considerations provided a sound conceptual framework for the foreign policy pursued by the Rouhani Administration, based on the smart pursuit of national interests within the fluid and tumultuous global structure based on constructive interaction. This policy was presented as the Minister of Foreign Affairs’ agenda and program of work to the parliament and was endorsed through the vote of confidence I received on 16 August 2013.

The two fundamental pillars of the plan included breaking the global security consensus against Iran and removing sanction obstacles to facilitate economic development and improve people’s livelihood. To that end, nuclear talks – including with the United States – were unavoidable, because breaking the global security consensus required terminating the six UN Security Council resolutions adopted under Chapter VII of UN Charter could not be achieved without agreement of all five permanent members including the United States. Similarly, lifting sanctions which were deemed essential for people’s prosperity and welfare were not possible

without dialogue. In this vein, Kissinger aptly defined dialogue to be synonymous with diplomacy.

To operationalize this general approach in our foreign policy, I had to focus from the day I entered office till the very last day on improving and broadening ties with neighbors, actively participating in the shaping of regional cooperation arrangements, upgrading ties with China and Russia to a strategic level, expanding ties with like-minded nations in Asia, Africa, and Latin America, resolving challenges and improving ties with Europe, managing disputes with the US, and expanding relations with the world. My colleagues and I pursued these goalposts with perseverance and hope from the first day of my presence at the MFA until the end of my term in office, some aspects of which we will examine in this book.

Dignity

For Iran, dignity is a top priority in my definition and ranking of national interests, in par with survival and independence and a pre-requisite for safeguarding both. It topped my agenda and that of my senior MFA colleagues for eight years. I never experienced anything even remotely resembling patronizing attitude in meetings with any foreign minister or even president or prime minister. On rare occasions when I felt that the opposite party was showing any sign of arrogance, I immediately reacted harshly or at least reciprocated the same behavior. In one lunch meeting in Europe, my European counterpart politely sought to preach to me about human rights. I told him: "You know what the problem is with you, the Europeans? We had the same problem with you in the JCPOA. You don't see your counterparts from the global south as partners; rather, you see us as subjects. As long as you maintain this supremacist attitude, you can be certain that you will fail to properly engage". Caught off guard, the European official was frustrated and had to change the subject.

Another case was the behavior of Sweden's Minister for International Development Cooperation and Foreign Trade, who later became minister of foreign affairs. When the US decided to designate and impose sanctions

on me personally, in a bid to counter the US's inappropriate decision, the Swedish foreign minister sent me an invitation to visit Sweden. The two-day visit occurred in August 2019 with stopovers in Finland and Norway. The two-day visit included meetings with Sweden's prime minister, foreign minister and minister for international development cooperation and foreign trade. There were also constructive meetings with entrepreneurs, Iranians living in Sweden as well as political and research elite. I delivered a speech at the Stockholm International Peace Research Institute (SIPRI) where I also had a challenging question-answer session.

The meeting with the minister for international development cooperation and foreign trade got off to a bad start. Unlike my Swedish counterpart, the Swedish trade minister did not blame the Trump Administration and OFAC⁶⁹, even trying to justify US illegal interference in our economic cooperation with Sweden. She went on to claim that the US is their friend and that if Sweden and Europe purchased oil from Iran and go through the INSTEX⁷⁰ mechanism for payment, that would elicit negative reaction from the US. The meeting was held at the minister's office. As required by protocol, the minister was near the entrance, and we were seated in front of her with our backs against the wall. As the discussions were not going anywhere, I sought to break the deadlock by raising and hopefully resolving a purely humanitarian issue. So, I asked her to resolve the refusal of a Swedish firm that almost had a monopoly on the production of the necessary material for treating the wounds of children afflicted with EB. Even there, she sought to evade and offer justification, citing European procedure. I told her that EB children were suffering pains and Sweden, in total disregard of its obligations, was complying with illegal US sanctions. Seeking a way to justify this inhumane behavior without offering any commitment, she said: "The Americans are our friends". I interrupted her, saying: "Your friends are murderers of our children. I've nothing more to tell you. Our meeting is over. Goodbye."

⁶⁹ The Office of Foreign Assets Control (OFAC) of the US Department of the Treasury

⁷⁰ The Instrument in Support of Trade Exchanges (INSTEX) was a European special-purpose vehicle (SPV) established on 31 January 2019 and liquidated in March 2023. Its stated mission was to facilitate non-USD and non-SWIFT transactions with Iran to avoid breaking U.S. sanctions.

As I stood up and walked behind her toward the door, she adopted the all too familiar European tone, saying: "I'm not finished yet. I want to discuss a human rights case". I replied without stopping: "If you want to raise the case too so that you can report it to the media, you can go ahead and tell them whatever you want. I've already discussed human rights with my counterpart". The bitterness of this which was my second meeting during my two-day visit to Sweden did not overshadow the entire trip thanks to the deputy foreign minister of Sweden and Iran's ambassador to Stockholm. In a break with protocol, Swedish prime minister welcomed me at the entrance of the Sager Palace, from where we walked to the second floor for our meeting.

I do not remember having stayed silent in the face of any aggressive behavior. In my meetings and conversations, I never confined myself to parroting the official position. I always tried to explain our case in a comprehensible language to the other party. Some foreign ministers read from prepared talking points. Their colleagues prepare them in advance and even provide answers to anticipated questions and comments, and the minister reads them out. That is common for political ministers without diplomatic background. But I tried in my meetings to hear the opposite party's concerns and views before offering my responses in clear terms in a bid to address concerns and reach agreement.

Another important consideration in representing the questionable policies of a government is the ability of a diplomat to distinguish his roles as an advisor and an advocate. When studying international law in the US, I got familiar with the concept of *dédoulement fonctionnel* or role splitting. I was able to defend the Islamic Republic's policy in my encounters with foreign officials, and the press was that at the time of decision-making, I had already performed my duties as the advisor by frankly, sincerely and even harshly expressing my criticisms of policies that I disagreed with. So, in facing my counterparts and the press, I tried my very best to present the policy which I may have been opposed to in the best possible manner.

Every phenomenon may be viewed from different angles. A defense attorney goes to court to defend the actions of a client that he may have even advised against. He/she can do so because every phenomenon may be

viewed and reviewed from different perspectives. Nothing in this world is absolute and every perspective or policy has its strengths and weaknesses. In a court, a lawyer has to represent their clients by using the arguments and facts that are most favorable to the client.

In negotiations, one needs to go even a step further. To reach understanding in dialogue, we have no option but to see the issue from the standpoint of the opposite party in order to find a basis for compromise. Putting ourselves in the shoes of the other side is a pre-requisite for reaching an agreement. For this purpose, it would be highly instrumental and effective to practice studying various perspectives about different human, social and political phenomena. We may look at a policy which we oppose from the standpoint of its proponents. When facing foreign parties, we should explain our national policies from the position of their respective proponents.

What gives serenity to foreign policy executives is knowing the fact that any foreign party views a case only from their country's interests and not whether our policy is right or wrong. That would facilitate the task. When an executive in the country is in the position of preparing for or taking decisions, he/she has to analyze every aspect with vigor and sincerity and openly and honestly express his/her analyses and views to superiors and decision-makers. In case he/she is opposed to any policy, he/she should express his/her views without fearing the consequences. This enables the government decision-makers to adopt appropriate and well-considered decisions. A sincere executive should not follow his superiors' analysis and remain silent in the hope of others speaking out because nobody else may be courageous enough to speak about shortages and negative consequences of the policy in question.

Another imperative in pursuit of national interests in foreign relations pertains to considering the fact that no one-sided deal or relationship would be sustainable. There should always be a win-win outcome. In defining diplomacy in previous pages, sustainability as well as cost-effectiveness were underlined. Of course, it should be kept in mind that the opposite party may not always have this approach. But if we intend to establish our bonds with the opposite side only based on short-term and one-sided gains, the opposite party will definitely reciprocate, in which case we will

claim: “Now you see that I was right”. But in reality, our own analysis and prediction lay the foundation for our conduct; the opposite party, having witnessed and gaged the essence and direction of our conduct, usually responds in the way we predict. That is called self-fulfilling prophecies.

That is a vicious cycle that has always existed and there is no escape from it. In my view, the traditional realist approach, like any other theory, does not simply offer explanations and descriptions, but in fact provides prescription, purporting a specific – and mostly suspicious and unfriendly – course of action to be the only “rational” choice, thereby entangling the world in the vicious cycle of its self-fulfilling prophecies. If we intend to reach understanding, we should know that the most instrumental factor is to be able to think in lieu of the opposite party. That is the lesson I learnt from four-decades of experience in dialogue and negotiations. When we make our own assessments, we should take into account the opposite party’s assessments as well. To have a successful foreign policy, we should be able to look into any case from the standpoint of the opposite party.

We are faced with complexities and dynamism in foreign relations, and we are in a world of action and reaction. Understanding complexities mixed with the necessary cognitive and practical dynamism require expertise. To sum up, foreign policy is not a place for emotion and enamor or fear and resentment.

The closing point that might be of interest to some readers is the manner I usually received and bid farewell to my foreign counterparts. I had two different approaches. During my eight years in office, I would always accompany my counterparts all the way to their vehicles in the MFA garden. But I would receive them at the top of the staircases leading to the grand reception hall of the foreign ministry ornamented with mirrors. I applied this protocol when receiving Western foreign ministers, which resembled their own way of welcoming guests. I think that insisting upon this method was necessary at the beginning of talks in a bid to break the arrogant attitude of the Europeans. However, when receiving my counterparts from neighboring countries or African and Arab nations, I intentionally walked several steps down to receive them in the middle of rather long and ceremonial staircase from the garden to the reception hall. In most cases when regional counterparts had received me at airport, I

reciprocated. However, I must acknowledge that I rarely went to the airport whereas my regional counterparts often welcomed me at the airport.

CHAPTER V
RELATIONS WITH NEIGHBORS

AND GLOBAL SOUTH

Primacy of Relations with Neighbors

Relations with neighboring states hold a highly strategic place in the foreign policy of every country. One of the priorities in our foreign policy agenda was likewise the improvement and expansion of ties with neighbors. Certain countries—particularly the United States and Russia—define for themselves unique positions and special relations in the global arena. Yet even for them, the relations of the United States with Mexico and Canada are far more pivotal than those with distant countries. Russia is similarly sensitive with regard to its neighbors, especially the Commonwealth of Independent States and what it refers to as the “near abroad.” The type of relations that a country like China establishes with its neighbors, such as Pakistan or India, is also of a special character. India follows the same pattern. Thus, neighborhood constitutes a highly strategic portfolio in foreign relations. All states assign a distinct place to their neighboring countries within their foreign policy. A country’s security is also intimately tied to its relations with its neighbors, since most security challenges and threats emanate from neighboring states. In addition, economic relations with neighbors consistently account for the greatest share of any country’s external trade.

For a country such as Iran, which has a large number of land and maritime neighbors—fifteen states with which it shares either land borders, maritime borders, or continental shelf boundaries—neighborly ties are exceptionally strategic. Given the linguistic, religious, sectarian, cultural, and ethnic diversity of Iran’s neighbors, as well as the long historical record of relations that has been imprinted in the collective memory of both the Iranian people and its neighbors, the value of such ties is doubled. Beyond immediate geographical neighbors, one must also take into account the broader Iranian cultural sphere, particularly in relation to eastern and northern neighbors. These states belong to the civilizational sphere of Iran, as they have historically arisen from Iranian civilization. European Russia is less a part of this grouping. There also exist profound civilizational affinities with certain Arab countries such as Iraq, Lebanon, and Bahrain.

From an economic perspective, neighbors are not only the natural economic partners of every country, but for Iran—long subject to

international pressures and sanctions—they have represented the most viable breathing space to alleviate such constraints. The United States has the least capacity to exert influence and pressure along our land and maritime borders with our neighbors. Even in times of heightened political tension with the United States and with certain neighbors, and despite sanctions, the U.S. has been unable to fully obstruct trade with surrounding states. Hence, the importance of neighbors is evident in this respect as well.

From an institutional standpoint, however, the status of Iran's Ministry of Foreign Affairs in managing regional relations is significantly weaker than that of the foreign ministries of more effective states. Earlier, reference was made to the flawed mutual perceptions between the Ministry of Foreign Affairs and other domestic institutions. The most damaging consequence of this misperception is seen in relations with neighbors. The interactions of other institutions with neighboring states—in the fields of economy, security, water, electricity, refugees, and energy—carry consequences far greater for foreign policy than any other area, and if these are not properly coordinated, they can prove highly destructive.

It is natural that each institution pursues its own needs and sectoral interests, and that none assumes responsibility for the challenges created by another. This pattern, absent a comprehensive perspective, is deeply damaging. There are numerous examples of this unfortunate trend. As mentioned previously, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs often only learns of an issue, and intervenes, once it has already escalated into a crisis or when another ministry encounters difficulties abroad. This challenge is most acute in relations with neighbors. For instance, a ministry might decide to increase transit charges on trucks carrying cargo from Turkey to Turkmenistan via Iranian territory. Or another agency, in order to combat fuel smuggling, may choose to inspect the fuel tanks of Turkish trucks at the Iranian border, or to collect a substantial fee for the fuel consumed enroute. On the surface, the ministry in question is merely performing its own mandate. Yet when an Iranian truck subsequently seeks to enter Turkmenistan, the Turkmen authorities retaliate by charging three times the tariff of the previous month. At that point the Ministry of Foreign Affairs is drawn in, while the very ministry that raised the tariffs is faced

with a difficult decision, one that often results in a lose-lose outcome. The other side has already acted, our country has suffered damage, and any response either escalates the dispute or is perceived as retreat.

Such challenges arise repeatedly in relations with neighbors. By contrast, in dealing with more distant countries such problems occur far less frequently, simply due to the distance. In matters ranging from water to security, our neighbors engage on a daily basis with various Iranian institutions. This is especially true given our vast geography: with each neighbor – with the exception of Armenia-- Iran shares hundreds of kilometers of border; the shortest border stretches 44 kilometers. In total, our country has more than 8300 kilometers of shared land and water borders with neighboring states. This creates a unique environment in which at every border point there is potential for interaction between one or more Iranian institutions and a neighboring population. Moreover, cultural, familial, tribal and ethnic ties link populations across these borders, further intensifying the sensitivity of such relations.

Due to developments and decisions taken in the Islamic Republic over the past twenty-five years, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs has not only lost responsibility in specialized areas, but in certain cases has been stripped even of political authority regarding specific neighbors. This fragmentation generates serious tensions and challenges in foreign relations and imposes heavy costs. Some neighboring states—whether rightly or wrongly—perceive certain non-traditional steps by some Iranian institutions as detrimental to them. Such perceptions sour political ties, and the cost is borne by foreign policy. At times, the very institutions responsible for ruining neighborly relations fault the foreign ministry for the very consequences of their own policies and behaviors. We hear questions like the following from the very agencies who are themselves responsible: Why does the Republic of Azerbaijan pursue adverse policies? Why cannot the Ministry of Foreign Affairs prevent Azerbaijan's relations with Israel? Why has Tajikistan, one of the three Persian-speaking countries, or Azerbaijan, one of the four Shi'a-majority countries in the world, developed bitter relations with Iran? Why does the Ministry of Foreign Affairs not take decisive action?

Relations with neighbors have thus suffered greatly from the decline in the authority of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs in foreign relations, concurrent with the rise in authority of other domestic institutions in external dealings. Inevitably, it is foreign policy that ultimately pays the heavy price of such incoherence. This is the neighborhood environment confronting the Islamic Republic of Iran: on the one hand, neighborly relations are more vital for Iran than for almost any other country; yet, on the other hand, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs' capacity and authority in this sphere—both within the executive branch and outside this branch—remains at its weakest. Paradoxically, the Ministry's role in managing relations with countries such as Germany or states in Africa may, by virtue of geographical distance, appear stronger and more effective, precisely because those states are less accessible to other domestic institutions.

From border control to railways and trade, multiple entities are engaged with neighbors. Such relations are primarily administrative and economic in nature, and in many respects resemble the transactions of petty merchants. Government agencies and private enterprises often behave as if they will interact with a neighboring country only once, thereby undermining the prospects for long-term bilateral markets and exchanges.

The Persian Gulf has always held a strategic and fundamental place for the Islamic Republic of Iran and ensuring the security of this waterway has consistently been essential and indispensable for us. Over the past three decades, with respect to Iraq and the southern littoral states of the Persian Gulf, I have consistently endeavored to steer regional relations toward de-escalation and cooperation. In the mid-1980s, at the height of rising tensions and the "tanker war" in the Persian Gulf, I prepared the draft of Dr. Velayati's letter to the Secretary-General of the United Nations⁷¹. Since then, I have continuously pursued the Persian Gulf security dossier through political and diplomatic efforts as well as academic research—efforts which, for various reasons, have not achieved significant success.

In 1985, at the peak of the tanker war and the American navy entry into the Persian Gulf under the pretext of escorting Kuwaiti tankers, Iran presented its proposal for collective security in the Persian Gulf to the UN

⁷¹ S/18381, 6 October 1986

Secretary-General⁷². This matter was followed in the negotiations over the drafting of Resolution 598, and in 1987 a version of the same proposal was adopted as paragraph 8 of Security Council Resolution 598⁷³. This provision, focusing on collective cooperation for ensuring security in the Persian Gulf region, was never implemented, as the military balance in the war shifted during the year between the adoption of Resolution 598 and the ceasefire. Following Iraq's invasion of Kuwait, Iran reminded the international community that had its proposal and paragraph 8 of 598 been implemented, that war might have been averted.

With the Iraq–Kuwait war, another opportunity arose. Two meetings were held between Iran's foreign minister and those of the GCC states on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly in 1990 and 1991. The process even advanced to the drafting of a joint communiqué, prepared by me on behalf of Iran and the late Ma'moun al-Kurdi, a Saudi senior official on behalf of the GCC. Yet, due to the unfortunate incident involving the al-Khater vessel and the opposition of Rashid Abdullah, then foreign minister of the United Arab Emirates, the initiative collapsed.

During the same period, in consultation with Mr. Jan Eliasson, senior Swedish diplomat and Special Representative of the Secretary-General in the Iran–Iraq talks under Resolution 598, a framework for Persian Gulf security was developed. Drawing inspiration from the Helsinki Process and the Conference on Security and Cooperation in Europe (CSCE)—which later evolved into Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe (OSCE)—we formulated a proposal, which I presented in a university lecture in the United States in December 1991⁷⁴ under the title “Security and Cooperation Arrangements in the Persian Gulf.”

Throughout my decade as deputy foreign minister (December 1992 – July 2002), I used every opportunity to advance the case for regional cooperation. In numerous speeches at global fora—such as at the UN Institute for

⁷² This letter was originally confidential and later circulated on Iran's request in 1986 as S/18381, 6 October 1986

⁷³ SCR 598 (1987) Paragraph 8. “Further requests the Secretary-General to examine, in consultation with Iran and Iraq and with other States of the region, measures to enhance the security and stability of the region;”

⁷⁴ Montclair State College, New Jersey.

Disarmament Research in Geneva⁷⁵ and the World Economic Forum in Davos⁷⁶—I presented proposals for Persian Gulf security. Both speeches were later published, one in a book and the other in an academic journal.

During my five-year tenure as ambassador in New York (2002–2007), which coincided with the U.S. invasion of Iraq, I also emphasized, in numerous speeches and published articles, the necessity of focusing on security and cooperation in the Persian Gulf. After the United States' second war in Iraq, I addressed this issue in two articles published in *The New York Times*—the first in May 2003 under the title “A Neighbor’s Vision of New Iraq”⁷⁷, and the second in February 2007 under the title “How to Not Inflamm Iraq”⁷⁸. In both, I outlined ways to establish security and cooperation in this sensitive region.

After the fall of Saddam, the Arab states—and especially Saudi Arabia—were deeply concerned by the disruption of the balance of power in the Persian Gulf. They had believed Saddam served to neutralize Iran’s regional power. Once they lost the leverage of Saddam, they sought to destabilize Iraq and return it to its pre-invasion condition. This effort lasted nearly thirteen years, from 2003 until about 2016, when Saudi Arabia appointed an ambassador to Iraq for the first time. Until 2011, Saudi Arabia and Turkey pursued this policy in coordination with Syria; when relations with Syria collapsed, that policy also failed, as the central pillar supporting anti-government activities in Iraq was removed.

In Rouhani’s second term, neighbors—and especially the security of the Persian Gulf—remained among our top priorities. Domestically, however, certain currents have sought to reduce the focus of our foreign policy to the West and the JCPOA, portraying it as though the Foreign Ministry regarded the nuclear agreement as its sole concern while neighbors were a lesser priority. This is a false and biased narrative. Given my record of

⁷⁵ «Security Considerations in the Middle East, An Iranian Approach» Arms and Technology Transfers: Security and Economic Considerations Among Importing and Exporting States, (Geneva: UNIDIR, 1995.)

⁷⁶ “Security and Insecurity in the Persian Gulf”, *Iranian Journal of International Affairs*, Volume VIII, No. 2, 1996

⁷⁷ “A Neighbor’s Vision of New Iraq,” *New York Times*, May 10, 2003. Reprinted in *International Herald Tribune*.

⁷⁸ “How Not to Inflamm Iraq,” *New York Times*, February 8, 2007. Reprinted in *International Herald Tribune*

attaching theoretical and diplomatic priority to Persian Gulf security since the 1980s – before most of my critics were even born, I treated the issue as a top priority from the very first weeks of my tenure as minister. On that basis, I sent an initial constructive message to Prince Saud al-Faisal, then Saudi foreign minister, seeking to mutually address regional difficulties. His short, inappropriate and discouraging reply, however, was that “Iran has nothing to do with the Arab world.”

At this point, it may be fitting to briefly review the history of Iran Saudi relations after the Revolution. Undoubtedly, there have been mistakes on Iran’s part, the most stupid and damaging being the attack and arson at the Saudi embassy and consulate in Tehran and Mashhad on 12 January 2016, the night following the execution of Sheikh Nimr al-Nimr. Terrorist operations orchestrated by Saudi intelligence against the Islamic Republic have been numerous both inside and outside Iran. One example during my tenure as minister was the terrorist attack on Iran’s embassy in Beirut by Saudi mercenaries. The mastermind of the attack escaped prosecution under Saudi government pressure. Although the unforgivable attack on the Saudi embassy and consulate in Iran caused no casualties, the Beirut embassy bombing on November 19, 2013, left over twenty people dead, including Iran’s cultural attaché in Lebanon.

The roots of Saudi attitudes toward post-revolutionary Iran trace back to the previous regime and the 1970s. At that time, President Nixon under the Nixon Doctrine shifted Johnson’s “twin pillars” policy for the Persian Gulf security—based on U.S. support for both Iran and Saudi Arabia as two regional pillars—into an informal “single pillar” policy, centered on the Shah as the Persian Gulf’s gendarme. Dissatisfied with this shift, which weakened its role to Iran’s advantage, Saudi Arabia sought to alter the balance. With the opportunity presented by the Islamic Revolution, Riyadh never ceased its efforts to undermine Iran’s power and eliminate its regional influence. Supporting separatist groups and other anti-government forces, including the Mojahedin-e Khalq (MEK), began immediately after the Revolution. Likewise, Saudi financial support for Iraq’s invasion of Iran was among its earliest measures. To this day, Saudi Arabia continues to finance and back the MEK, Iranian separatist groups, and especially Takfiri extremists.

The Saudi government, for its part, refrained from any efforts to normalize relations or reduce tensions between the two countries as long as Iran held the upper hand in the region. Saudi Arabia consistently sought opportunities to restore the disrupted balance of the 1970s—which were further exacerbated by the loss of Iraq in 2003, Syria in 2011, and its failure to achieve objectives in the Yemen conflict—in a way favorable to itself, or, if feasible, with Iran’s acceptance. China’s initiative, proposed in coordination with Saudi Arabia, should be considered in this context. Nevertheless, despite this bitter reality, I consider any de-escalation between Iran and Saudi Arabia as constructive and beneficial for both countries and the wider region. If the attack on the embassy and consulate did not occur, improvements in relations could have been realized under far more advantageous circumstances for Iran.

Despite this analytical and historical perspective, I did not refrain from efforts to improve ties with Saudi Arabia and the GCC—which in practice served as Saudi Arabia’s political and diplomatic arm—for two main reasons. First, low-tension, realistic relations with Saudi Arabia and other southern Persian Gulf states are essential and beneficial for regional security and Iran’s vital interests, and such de-escalation must be initiated by Iran, the larger and more capable state.

The second reason relates to Saudi Arabia’s and its regional allies’ strategic securitization of Iran, particularly under U.S. and Israeli influence. From the onset of the Islamic Revolution, Saudi Arabia has actively sought to restore the balance of the 1970s in its favor through a persistent effort to securitize Iran, promoting both Iranophobia and Shiaphobia. It has consistently portrayed Iran and Shiism as security threats to the region and the world. By embedding this narrative in the global community, Saudi Arabia not only demonized Iran but also advanced the global propagation of Wahhabism for decades. Unsurprisingly, powers with domineering aspirations around the world were receptive to this toxic Saudi propaganda, although they abruptly awoke to the threat after September 11. At the same time, Iran faced a rapid and potent process of securitization, into which some domestic actors fell.

New terminology, such as the “Shia Crescent,” must be understood within the broader framework of the securitization policy against Iran.

For example, King Abdullah of Jordan first introduced the notion of the Shia Crescent as a tool for fearmongering and securitization against Iran. Some domestic elites have also been quick to fall into this securitization trap. For instance, when Israel asserts that Iran has the capability to build nuclear weapons, we sometimes celebrate and repeat this claim without realizing that Israel is crafting Iran as a global threat. Similarly, when it claims that Iran's missile range could reach European countries, Israel's aim is not to showcase Iran's capabilities but to instill fear in Europe. We, however, are immediately drawn into this securitization narrative. This cognitive distortion has repeatedly recurred.

For this reason, Saudi actions needed to be addressed in two complementary ways; Negatively—by exposing the intentions and consequences of Saudi exclusionary strategies and positively⁷⁹—by proposing constructive solutions aimed at regional calm and normalization of ties with Saudi Arabia⁸⁰. This approach was successfully pursued until the dubious attack on the Saudi embassy, which reversed Iran's winning strategy into a losing one, ultimately allowing Mohammed bin Salman, in January 2017, to escape the consequences of his self-inflicted weakness and isolation⁸¹.

A review of foreign policy under the Rouhani Administration shows that my first article, dated November 21, 2013—just three months into the administration—was published not in English-language newspapers but in Asharq Al-Awsat in Arabic under the title “Our Neighbors Are Our

⁷⁹ “The Imperative of a Comprehensive Strategy to Fight Violent Extremism” Harvard International Review, June 18, 2015

“Riyadh's Reckless Extremism” New York Times, January 11, 2016.

“Why Iran is Building-Up Its Defenses” Washington Post, April 21, 2016.

“Let Us Rid the World of Wahhabism” New York Times, September 13, 2016.

“How to Handle the Enabling Conditions for Extremism and Terrorism” Iranian Review of Foreign Affairs, Vol 7 No. 1, Winter and Spring 2016.

«كيفية التعامل مع الظروف المواتية للتطرف والإرهاب» الرأي، 23 أبريل 2017

“Beautiful Military Equipment Can't Buy Middle East Peace” New York Times, May 26, 2017.

⁸⁰ «جيراننا اولويتنا» الشرق الاوسط، 18 محرم 1435

“Our Neighbors are our Priority” Al-Sharh Al-Awsat, November 21, 2013.

«الجار ثم الدر: توصية اخلاقية او ضرورة استراتيجية»، الرأي 3 اغسطس 2015

“Peace in Syria is Vital. And It's Within Our Grasp” The Guardian, 18 December 2015.

«مستعدون لاهداء السلام الى المنطقة» العربي الجديد، 20 مايو 2017

“Foreign Meddling Has Wrought a Fractured Middle East,” The Atlantic, October 9, 2017.

⁸¹ “The Obama Doctrine”: The Atlantic's Exclusive Report on the U.S. President's Hardest Foreign Policy Decisions”, The Atlantic, March 10, 2016.

Priority.” Contrary to claims that we neglected the region, this was my first article after assuming office which focused on regional policy, clearly establishing neighbors as a priority.

The first initiative I proposed after taking office was a dialogue and de-escalation plan with Saudi Arabia in collaboration with the late General Qasem Soleimani. In the first weekly meetings I hosted from the early days of the ministry until the week before his martyrdom, in the main building of the Institute for Political and International Studies (IPIS) of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs—now named after Martyr General Soleimani—we developed a joint plan for serious dialogue with Saudi Arabia on five areas of conflict between the two countries: Lebanon, Iraq, Syria, Bahrain, and Yemen. In the first four countries, the sources of disagreement were clear. However, based on Soleimani’s prediction in 2013, Yemen would become a future source of tension. Accordingly, at his suggestion, Yemen was added to the original four. This plan was placed on the agenda of second-track talks in September 2013. Our proposal was to collaborate for regional peace and progress rather than pursue hostility.

In this plan, we also provided a solution for addressing the perception that countries in the region—and particularly Saudi Arabia—held about Iran’s foreign policy. That perception is that the Iranian Foreign Ministry is ineffective; hence, they insist that the Iranian interlocutor in dialogue be drawn from security institutions outside the Ministry. This view manifested during China mediation, when Saudi insisted on negotiating with the Secretary of the Supreme National Security Council rather than the Director-General of the Foreign Ministry, as Iran had proposed. Naturally, this perception is not entirely unfounded. In certain dossiers, as mentioned previously, the Ministry lacks sufficient capacity and leverage with neighbors. In the eyes of Arab countries, the Iranian foreign minister is seen as a figurehead for formal and public diplomacy, while the Quds Force acts as the real operative in the region. To address this perception, we agreed with General Soleimani that if the Saudi side appointed a representative at a high level, an equivalent Iranian representative—General Soleimani himself—would participate at a mutually agreed location.

This was the first proposal for collaboration with Saudi Arabia. Prior discussions under the previous government had taken place in Switzerland

between the IPIS and a Swiss institute – Geneva Centre for Security Sector Governance (DCAF) – and the Saudi Arabia’s “Gulf Studies Institute,” and were intended to continue under our administration. Accordingly, in the first meeting of our administration, two colleagues who had participated in these prior dialogues presented our proposal to the Saudi side. The then Saudi foreign minister, Saud al-Faisal, responded in a single line: “The Arab is none of Iran’s business.”

Thus, even before addressing the nuclear issue, we focused on neighbors. Despite this negative response, I visited Saud al-Faisal in New York, who was ill and seldom left his hotel, even refraining from addressing the General Assembly. That meeting was met with childish and obstructive criticism at home. We engaged in frank and extensive dialogue. I explained that there were two ways forward: we could review past grievances, of which we had a long list, and presumably they did as well. However, I suggested that it would be better to focus on future cooperation and collaboration in the region. From his response, I understood that the Saudi Foreign Ministry was not ready for effective and productive dialogue.

I was not certain whether the negative attitude stemmed from the Saudi Ministry of Foreign Affairs, or even personally from Mr. Saud al-Faisal and his intelligence-affiliated brother, Prince Turki al-Faisal, or from the entire Saudi establishment. For this reason, during a regional visit to the southern Persian Gulf states, it was deemed necessary to also visit Saudi Arabia and understand the perspective of its rulers, particularly King Abdullah, who was known for his pragmatism in relations with Iran. However, when the regional Persian Gulf visit was scheduled at the end of 2013, Saudi Arabia was not prepared to schedule a meeting with the King, as was customary in Iran-Saudi bilateral relations.

It is noteworthy that my first bilateral foreign visit as foreign minister, during the initial weeks of my tenure, was to Iraq. Additionally, within the first six months, my first regional tour included Oman, Kuwait, Qatar, and the United Arab Emirates. As noted, Saudi Arabia did not respond favorably to this visit. In retrospect, it might have been better to have proceeded without attention to formalities.

Visits to the UAE, Kuwait, Oman, and Qatar were very friendly and constructive. Notable moments included Sheikh Abdullah bin Zayed, my

Emirati counterpart, personally driving me in a cute Mini-Miner in Dubai, after accompanying me by helicopter from Abu Dhabi to Dubai to meet Sheikh Mohammed bin Rashid, Ruler of Dubai and Prime Minister of the UAE, and also meeting Sheikh Khalifa bin Zayed, the late President of the UAE, outside Abu Dhabi, while he was seriously ill and seldom received foreign visitors. Unlike my successor, I did not bother to publicize these gestures, which again in retrospect may have been an innocent omission on my part, which actually worked against me at home.

Substantive and cordial meetings were also held with the late Sultan Qaboos of Oman, the late Amir Sabah al-Ahmad al-Sabah of Kuwait, and Sheikh Tamim, who had recently become the Emir of Qatar. We did not publicize the reception and farewells of these leaders outside their palaces. However, domestic opposition media created bitter, unfounded, and nationally damaging narratives.

During a press conference in Kuwait, an Arab journalist asked about the UAE foreign minister's visit to Tehran and the "islands" dossier. Having closely followed this sensitive matter since 1992, I expressed satisfaction with the success of the visit and reiterated Iran's consistent position: "Iran is ready to engage in dialogue with Sharjah and the UAE regarding misunderstandings about Abu Musa." Certain domestic partisan media, however, exploited a biased report from an Arab newspaper, falsely claiming that the foreign minister was prepared to negotiate Iran's territorial integrity.

Although the Ministry's spokesperson immediately clarified the historical background and the mischief of the Arab media, partisan attacks persisted. In 2023, to whitewash Russian foreign minister's disregard for Iran's territorial integrity in a joint statement with GCC foreign ministers, the same false narrative was resurrected from the "dustbin of history." Rather than criticizing Russia, some domestic actors attacked their own foreign minister to cover up an unfriendly move by Russia. For example, on July 17, 2023, Keyhan published an article entitled: "Patriotism Does Not Suit You!" citing my statement in Kuwait on December 2, 2013: "Iran is ready to negotiate regarding ownership of Abu Musa Island." Critics accused me of following Qajar, Reza Shah, and Mohammad Reza

Pahlavi-era diplomacy, claiming that no patriotic diplomat would agree to negotiate over part of their country's territory.

It may be useful here to explain the origin of this problem, which reflects cognitive challenges in assessing regional and global realities. In the summer of 1992, following Iraq's expulsion from Kuwait and the special conditions in the Persian Gulf region, few Iranian authorities blocked the vessel *Al-Khater* from entering Abu Musa. The UAE viewed this as a violation of the 1971 Memorandum of Understanding between Iran and Sharjah and used it as a pretext to create an international row, not only regarding Abu Musa but concerning all three islands. Since then, the islands dossier has been raised in the GCC, Arab League, UN General Assembly, and joint meetings—including those with China and Russia in 2022 and 2023—globalizing the issue and garnering international support for their viewpoint.

Interestingly, as in other cases framed through the lens of securitization, the *Al-Khater* incident occurred just as Iran and six southern Persian Gulf states were ready to issue a joint declaration for Persian Gulf security at the second meeting of foreign ministers alongside the UN General Assembly in New York. As I said in an earlier segment, the first meeting had taken place in October 1990 two months after Iraq's invasion of Kuwait, at the Iranian mission to the UN, with the foreign ministers of all six GCC countries, hosted by Dr. Velayati.

In the context of the Persian Gulf countries' shock and concern following their ally's attack on Kuwait, Iran, adopting a magnanimous stance without reminding GCC members of their support for Saddam during his eight years of imposed war, provided an opportunity to establish a regional cooperation framework. Accordingly, a draft declaration for the second meeting was prepared by me and the late Mamoun al-Kurdy, a senior Saudi diplomat representing the GCC. It was ready to be signed and issued during the second meeting in October 1991. Two months after the *Al-Khater* incident, and simultaneously with Iraq's defeat in joint operations with the U.S., the meeting took place in Saud al-Faisal's suite at New York's Waldorf Hotel. However, due to opposition from UAE foreign minister Rashid Abdullah al-Nuaimi, the declaration and continuation of meetings and cooperation were canceled.

It is regrettable that other negative events occurred simultaneously in different dossiers, preventing Iran from leveraging the post-Iraq invasion environment to improve its global standing. Over the past thirty-plus years, having closely observed key events in Iran and the world, I have witnessed a consistent pattern: whenever Iran's international position approaches improvement or provides the country with breathing space, unwise actions serve as a pretext to revert to the previously contaminated global environment, or even worsen it. What is striking and worthy of research is the persistence and unbreakable nature of this pattern, which transforms opportunities into threats.

In 1991, the Supreme National Security Council, acting upon foreign ministry's suggestion, decided that Iran's stance to neutralize UAE provocations and its attempt to gain international support should be to announce Iran's readiness for bilateral dialogue with Sharjah and the UAE regarding misunderstandings arising from the implementation of the 1971 Memorandum of Understanding concerning Abu Musa Island. This position has been consistently expressed annually in the UN General Assembly in response to statements by UAE leaders and has repeatedly been conveyed by Iranian officials and spokespeople over the past thirty years without causing controversy or objection. For example, in September 2008, the Foreign Ministry spokesperson stated: "Any misunderstandings regarding implementation arrangements on Abu Musa Island can be resolved through bilateral dialogue without third-party involvement." In March 2011, the spokesperson reiterated: "The Islamic Republic of Iran has always maintained its readiness for direct bilateral dialogue regarding misunderstandings on Abu Musa Island concerning the implementation of the 1971 Memorandum of Understanding." These statements were made by the representatives of the administration favored and supported by my critics.

In the Kuwait interview, I repeated the same longstanding position. However, this time a domestic controversy erupted. Spokesperson Mrs. Marzieh Afkham promptly clarified the matter, yet the partisan outcry did not cease and continues even today—not in defense of Iranian territorial integrity – which I wholeheartedly endorse, but rather to cover-up and whitewash the actions of another country. I remain to be a victim of such

smear campaigns every now and then, in spite the fact that I have always supported and continue to support in words and deeds excellent relations with all neighbors including Russian.

At that time, in response to the controversy, we noted that even if hypothetically the Iranian foreign minister had made such a mistaken statement, the proper course of action would have been to try to downplay it, rather than publicizing it. The claim by a domestic official newspaper that the Iranian foreign minister was “ready to negotiate over Iranian territory” could provide an unfounded pretext for misuse against Iran in the future, regardless of the Foreign Ministry spokesperson’s denial. Yet in 2013 this warning was ignored, and in 2023, in the midst of partisan disputes, no regard was given to national interests or territorial integrity. The domestic attacks have several times went as far as criticizing the former foreign minister to shield Russia from complaints about its joint statements on the islands.

Following that regional tour, efforts to visit Saudi Arabia continued, but no opportunity arose. In winter 2015, after King Abdullah’s death, I immediately left the World Economic Forum in Davos midway and went to Saudi Arabia. Ceremonial reception was excellent, and I was seated among presidents and princes; however, no meetings were arranged, and no substantive discussions took place.

In other words, we tried all feasible avenues for this engagement. Despite these setbacks, we did not lose hope and continued this approach. When the new Saudi foreign minister was appointed, I met with him and demonstrated Iran’s interest in resolving issues with Saudi Arabia. Additionally, at the Islamic Summit in Istanbul, I again encountered the Saudi foreign minister. At that time, Saudi policy was deliberately provocative, as they sought tension. Our own approach, contrary to some perceptions of weakness, was deliberate and informed — aimed at neutralizing Saudi securitization strategies.

Alongside this diplomatic push, numerous initiatives for regional dialogue were proposed—entirely independently, despite domestic and foreign obstacles. In March 2014, during the president’s visit to Oman, Dr. Rouhani presented the proposal for a Regional Dialogue Forum to Sultan Qaboos. The two heads of state instructed me to prepare details for the

Omani foreign minister. In early April 2014, two drafts were presented to the Omani foreign minister: a concept paper for regional dialogue, and a draft declaration on the subject. To entice Saudi participation in this initiative, the declaration was named the “Mecca Declaration.” Both texts appear in Annex IV. Minister Yusuf bin Alawi of Oman later informed us that Saudi Arabia had not welcomed Iran’s proposal.

After this setback, I raised the regional dialogue initiative in several global forums and in an article for *The Financial Times*⁸². Subsequently, during a visit to Kuwait, I proposed a regional non-aggression pact, which received significant attention⁸³. Yet again, Saudi Arabia did not endorse either. Internally, the initiative also faced indifference. During the final weeks of the JCPOA negotiations, the Organization of Islamic Cooperation ((OIC)’s foreign ministers’ meeting was held in Kuwait. Because I was engaged in Vienna, one of my deputies attended. The Qatari foreign minister reportedly told the deputy: “Since your minister has conducted P51+ negotiations, it would be good to initiate 61+ (GCC + Iran) discussions”.

Immediately after the Vienna talks and JCPOA’s conclusion, I traveled first to Qatar, then Kuwait and Oman. These countries expressed readiness to begin the Iran-GCC dialogue. The Emir of Qatar suggested holding the meeting as soon as possible. We responded that if the meeting were held in Doha, we would participate immediately; otherwise, it could be held alongside the UN General Assembly, which was agreed upon. During the General Assembly, despite the tragedy of Mina and Iran’s mourning over the loss of nearly 450 of its citizens in a tragedy in Saudi Arabia, we confirmed our readiness to participate. Saudi Foreign Minister Adel al-Jubair stated he could not attend, and even avoided a bilateral meeting to follow up on the Mina tragedy.

It is important to highlight another episode, which, despite its serious ethical dimension, has been exploited for slander. Following the Mina tragedy, which claimed nearly 450 Iranian lives, returning the bodies to Iran was the foremost priority for the country and the victims’ families. Iran was far more concerned than other countries and many non-Iranian

⁸² “Iran Can Set a Post-ISIS Security Policy for the Region,” *Financial Times*, 21 January 2018.

⁸³ “Zarif Proposes Regional Dialogue Forum Amid Tension,” *Pak Observer*, 23 January 2018.

⁸³ “Zarif proposes non-aggression pact for region,” *IRNA*, 26 May 2019

families, who might have been more at ease if the bodies were interred in Saudi territory close to the holiest Islamic sights. Thus, the Saudi government, without facing significant pressure, sought to bury the Mina victims in the Mecca area.

To prevent the burial in Saudi Arabia and ensure the identification and repatriation of all bodies, Iran decided to send a delegation led by the Minister of Health, accompanied by the consular deputy of the Foreign Ministry, to Saudi Arabia. The Saudi embassy in Tehran delayed visas and flight permissions. Our attempt to meet with the Saudi foreign minister in New York to follow up on this matter was also unsuccessful. Families were deeply concerned that their loved ones' remains would be buried unidentified and that no proper repatriation or funeral could take place.

During this critical period, as we were all seeking a way to secure visas for the Iranian delegation, I noticed at the UN General Assembly that the then-Emir of Kuwait, Sheikh Sabah Ahmad Jabir Al-Sabah, whom I had known and interacted with for many years during his tenure as foreign minister, was seated behind Kuwait's desk to listen to the speech of one of the Arab heads of state. It is worth noting that, normally, heads of state do not attend General Assembly sessions in person; only lower-level officials sit at the country desks, unless a head of state wishes to show special respect to another head of state who is speaking. By fortunate circumstance, the Emir of Kuwait, who enjoyed respect and influence in Saudi Arabia, was present.

Seizing this opportunity, I immediately approached the Kuwaiti desk to pursue the delegation's visa issue. In international meetings, the customary way to lobby is to sit next to the other party and engage in brief conversation; standing and speaking disrupts the session and, especially during a head-of-state speech, would violate diplomatic etiquette. With nearly thirty years of experience at the UN, I followed this norm and took a semi-standing position beside the Emir of Kuwait. He listened attentively and with great respect to the Iranian government's concerns and immediately issued instructions to address the matter. Within a few hours, the Kuwaiti foreign minister confirmed to me that visas and flight permissions had been arranged. By God's grace, the Iranian delegation

flew to Jeddah that very night and, through diligent effort, was able to identify the bodies of all Iranian victims and return them home.

I consider this action as a meritorious deed, which would serve me when I face my God in the hereafter. Yet, it was immediately exploited by well-known malicious circles inside Iran, who, taking advantage of the public's unfamiliarity with international meeting protocols, turned it into a media scandal—claiming that the Iranian foreign minister “knelt before the Emir of Kuwait, humiliating the country.” Even after nearly eight years, despite extensive clarifications and the publication of numerous domestic and international photographs showing the standard international practice—which is also common in our own parliamentary sessions—this image is still invoked whenever certain domestic factions seek to cover-up and whitewash their own failures in foreign policy through attacking me.

In reality, regional leaders consistently showed the highest respect for me as Iran's foreign minister, often going beyond ceremonial protocol to ensure a place for Iran's minister alongside regional emirs.

Many of these critics seem unaware that disrespecting the foreign minister is tantamount to disrespecting Iran itself. Even assuming, for the sake of argument, that any impropriety had occurred—which, as noted, did not—appropriate use of the abundant photographic evidence demonstrating respect for the minister would have sufficed to clarify the matter, rather than allowing partisan agendas to degrade the nation's dignity.

A brief overview of the preceding sections shows that, even during the height of the JCPOA negotiations, and alongside numerous articles in Arab and English-language media inviting neighboring countries to dialogue, at least two regional initiatives were presented shortly after the start of my tenure as minister, which Saudi Arabia ignored.

In addition, in 2013, a four-point initiative to resolve the Syrian crisis was developed in consultation with martyr General Qasem Soleimani, and discussions were held with Sayyed Hassan Nasrallah and Bashar al-Assad. The initiative included a ceasefire, a national unity government incorporating opposition figures, constitutional revision, and elections under the new constitution. It was first presented to the Turkish foreign minister and then publicly during the UN General Assembly in September

2013. Turkey rejected the proposal due to Assad's continued presence in power. Ultimately, the same proposal formed the basis of UN Security Council Resolution 2254 on Syria, and John Kerry later acknowledged in the International Syria Support Group (ISSG) that Resolution 2254 was based on Iran's proposal.

Thus, the claim that the Islamic Republic or the Foreign Ministry focused solely on the JCPOA and neglected other issues, particularly relations with neighbors, is inaccurate. Both the media record and the initiatives we presented, as well as the number of regional visits conducted during the JCPOA talks, demonstrate that neighboring countries were consistently a priority for Iran and the Rouhani Administration.

However, due to domestic obstacles, as previously explained, and external factors, including Saudi Arabia's unwillingness, these initiatives did not advance—particularly after Trump's election, which itself has historical context. Even before Trump's election, following the highly suspicious attack on the Saudi embassy on January 2, 2016—six months after conclusion of the JCPOA and just two weeks before its implementation—bilateral ties were effectively severed.

The embassy attack is highly suspicious from multiple angles. It must be analyzed within the context of numerous unprecedented events orchestrated to prevent the JCPOA from being implemented between July 2015 and January 2016. Rarely, if ever, in the history of the Islamic Republic have so many unnecessary provocative measures occurred within a six-month period. We compiled a confidential list of these actions in the JCPOA monitoring committee and sent it to the country's leadership, but it is not yet in the national interest to publicly reveal it, even if it is justified and instrumental in response to the baseless accusations and slanders.

The attack on the Saudi embassy in Tehran strained Iran's bilateral relations with Saudi Arabia, the broader region, and even the Arab and Islamic world, effectively rescuing Saudi Arabia from a global crisis at Iran's expense. This was among the most bitter episodes of my tenure, with the greatest negative impact on our work in the region, globally, and even regarding the JCPOA. On the afternoon of Saturday 2 January 2016, we held a Council of Deputy Foreign Ministers meeting, followed by the Supreme National Security Council meeting that night. We learned that

a group planned to demonstrate in front of the Saudi embassy the next day, Sunday. At the Deputies' meeting, it was decided to ask pertinent authorities to take stringent precautionary measures to protect the embassy from any threat. During the NSC briefing, I raised the possibility of an attack on the Saudi embassy. Interestingly, Mr. Jalili was also supportive of my concern. This was one of the rare cases where not only did we not have any disagreements, but he confirmed my assessment, stating: "It is possible that the action may even occur tonight instead of tomorrow; we must begin special precautions tonight."

At the Supreme National Security Council, we decided that nothing should happen to the Saudi embassy. The Minister of Interior issued the necessary orders to his deputy for security. After leaving the NSC meeting, I contacted the Foreign Ministry and conveyed that the consensus of the Council was that no incident should occur at the Saudi embassy; any deviation from this would be the greatest service to Mohammad bin Salman and the most severe blow to Iran.

I placed several calls to colleagues in the regional and protocol departments to reinforce this directive. Later, when I was about to leave for home, my security detail informed me that the area around the Saudi embassy was crowded and that it was not advisable to use the usual route. Based on this information, I checked again with my colleagues, who reassured me, citing the police commanders' reports, that nothing was happening and that we were in constant contact. Yet, evidently, a plot had been orchestrated and executed, which brought no benefit but instead worked entirely against the country, while serving the interests of a faltering Saudi government.

The attack on the Saudi embassy and consulate effectively rescued the Saudi government from its precarious position without any cost or consequence, shifting blame from the culprit to a claimant. It should be recalled that in winter 2016, Saudi Arabia and other Arab governments supporting Syrian Takfiri groups were in a very negative position in global public opinion. The brutal execution of Sheikh Nimr al-Nimr along with over 40 other Saudi opponents had further deteriorated the credibility of the new Saudi government and of Mohammad bin Salman personally. Despite consultations that night with Saudi authorities to control the crisis,

bin Salman broke all agreements and used the attack as a “heaven-sent” opportunity to escape political and propaganda deadlock. A domestic group, motivated by electoral and factional goals, staged the attack just before the parliamentary elections and the JCPOA’s implementation. The consequences, however, benefited the Saudi government, undermining both Iran’s prestige and the memory of Sheikh Nimr and other victims of that mass executions.

The attack on the Saudi embassy in Tehran and consulate in Mashhad is also highly suspicious from another perspective. At the time of JCPOA negotiations, Saudi Arabia and other Arab U.S. partners in the region were anxious about a potential shift in U.S. behavior and policy. They openly expressed their concern, especially given that the anticipated resolution of Iran’s nuclear issue coincided with the U.S. decision to pivot from the Middle East to Asia to confront China. President Obama responded to these concerns by stating that Saudi Arabia and Persian Gulf countries must resolve their disputes with Iran themselves and should not attribute all difficulties to Iran⁸⁴.

This was the balance of power between Iran and Saudi Arabia in fall 2015 and winter 2016, with Saudi Arabia feeling disappointed and humiliated by its most important ally, the U.S. Compare this to the situation in 2022 in Beijing, where the same initiative to reduce tensions occurred under entirely reversed circumstances. Although engagement with Saudi Arabia and neighboring countries is always commendable, in 2022, it occurred when Iran’s most important strategic partner, China, clearly sided with Saudi Arabia against Iran during President Xi’s visit to Riyadh. Xi Jinping not only aligned with the GCC’s stance on the three Iranian islands but also publicly described Saudi Arabia as a pillar of the emerging global order, while jointly declaring Iran a destabilizing force in the region. Shortly after, China became the mediator and guarantor of the Iran-Saudi agreement, based on Saudi proposals and perspectives.

Nearly a year after the embassy and consulate attack and the severing of relations with Saudi Arabia, the Kuwaiti foreign minister, on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly session, indicated that the Emir of Kuwait

⁸⁴ Jeffrey Goldberg, “Obama Defends the Iran Nuclear Deal” *The Atlantic*, May 21, 2015.

had a proposal for dialogue between Iran and the GCC. In presenting the proposal, he made three stipulations:

1. Iran's respect for the sovereignty and territorial integrity of its neighbors;
2. Non-interference by Iran in the internal affairs of regional countries; and
3. Treating citizens of regional countries as citizens of another country rather than through a sectarian lens.

I responded to the Kuwaiti deputy prime minister and foreign minister on two points: first, if these conditionalities were presented officially, we would also set a condition that Kuwait (and partners) first compensate Iran for the losses of the eight-year war, after which dialogue could proceed. Second, it would be better to first hold direct talks between Iran and Saudi Arabia to resolve the crisis, and only then engage in dialogue between the seven countries. Nevertheless, I left the door open to pursue the Emir's proposal.

Two months later, the Emir of Kuwait sent a revised proposal to Iran, along with a letter to President Rouhani. The tone of the letter was moderated compared to earlier comments by his foreign minister at the UN General Assembly. It addressed the three main concerns in a respectful and mutual reciprocal tone: non-interference in internal affairs of another, good-neighborliness, and recognition of citizens of one another as citizens rather than through a sectarian lens. The Kuwaiti foreign minister presented the letter with even a softer and more conciliatory tone. Following receipt of this message, President Rouhani traveled in winter 2017 to Oman and Kuwait. The President welcomed the proposal and expressed readiness to begin discussions based on the letter from the Emir of Kuwait.

The trip to Oman primarily aimed to visit Sultan Qaboos after his prolonged illness, marking his first post-recovery hosting of a foreign head of state. Yet, the visit held additional value. Given Iran's special ties with Oman, the intention was also to keep Oman informed of this regional initiative. Oman was already aware, as the proposal had originated from the GCC summit in Kuwait, thus making the Emir of Kuwait the responsible intermediary.

Dr. Rouhani met with the Emir of Kuwait and responded positively to his proposal. The Emir welcomed this with satisfaction and then requested that, since he needed to present this response at the Manama Summit of Leaders, it be given to him in writing. After returning to Iran, Dr. Rouhani prepared and signed a written response in which he presented all three conditions of the Cooperation Council as the policies of the Islamic Republic. The letter conveyed both a position of strength and a sense of cooperation.

Here, two points deserve attention:

First, Iran's superior capabilities compared to the southern Persian Gulf countries are evident in many respects—geography, human capital, natural resources, historical and civilizational background, and so on—and do not require overt emphasis. Verbal insistence on capabilities often signals weakness or at least a lack of self-confidence. Moreover, openly emphasizing one's capabilities can serve as a pretext for adversaries to securitize the issue.

There is a well-known Persian proverb that conveys this wisdom: "The musk is that which smells of itself, not that which the perfumer claims." As Theodore Roosevelt, former U.S. president, put it: "speak softly and carry a big stick". More importantly, based on God's instructions to Moses and Aaron regarding Pharaoh—the ultimate symbol of tyranny in the Quran: "Go to Pharaoh, for he has transgressed; but speak to him gently, perhaps he may heed or fear." God instructs gentleness even toward the epitome of tyranny, and regarding other disbelievers, He commands: "And argue with them in ways that are best; indeed, your Lord knows best who has strayed from His way." How, then, could the approach demanded toward fellow Muslims be anything other than kindness and forbearance?

Second, global and regional conditions do not stop moving or changing based on the will of any single country, even the United States. Abstaining from participation in a process does not halt it—whether it concerns transport corridors in the Caucasus, U.S.-Taliban talks, China's Belt and Road initiative, or Persian Gulf security.

In multilateral relations, non-participation only leads to marginalization, not prevention. Rigid textual views of international law and legitimacy

would lead one to consider the totality of the global legal system as colonial and dominated by great powers. Another dangerous outcome of this approach is to imagine that one can deprive a given process of legitimacy by simply refusing to participate in it. But in today's world, this is not the case. In diplomacy and multilateral processes, refusing to participate does not stop any multilateral arrangement; the process will continue without the participation of the refusing party and its ability to have any impact. The minimum cost of this approach is that one's interests are ignored; the maximum and most common cost is that the participants will negotiate and bargain over the refuser's rights and interests, thus sacrificing them for their own benefit.

Put simply: absence from multilateral negotiation tables is meaningless. Either we sit around the table and negotiate, or we are "on the table" while others will negotiate over our rights and interest. That is why Iran's adversaries have always sought to deny Iran the ability to participate in multilateral negotiations and conferences—from Syrian talks in the early 2010s to negotiations on the resolution of the crisis in Karabakh in 2020s. What is astonishing is that the interests and intentions of Iran's external competitors and adversaries often coincide with domestic hardliners who have portrayed Iran's engagement in global negotiations and multilateral agreements as a "soft" threat to national security.

Regarding Kuwait's proposal and our suggestions for cooperation on Persian Gulf security, the same pattern appeared. While some domestic groups strongly opposed any collective Persian Gulf initiative, seeing it as "restricting Iran's maneuvering ability within its sphere of authority," our external rivals similarly opposed any regional initiative involving Iran. The outcome of these two seemingly opposing tendencies was the shaping of regional security arrangements without Iran, even going as far as bringing Israel to the Persian Gulf region under the Abraham Accords.

I heard from several foreign ministers of GCC that when the Emir of Kuwait presented Dr. Rouhani's letter at the Manama Summit (Spring 2017), the King of Bahrain said: "Trump has now been elected and will start a policy of pressure on Iran. Therefore, we should wait and not rush into these discussions, so that Trump's pressure affects Iran; then we can negotiate with Iran from a position of strength." Consequently, the Emir of

Kuwait's proposal at the Manama Summit failed. Later, elements aligned with Saudi Arabia in Kuwait began a malicious propaganda campaign to blame Iran for the failure of the Emir's proposal.

This propaganda effort from Kuwait is an example of the "blame game," as previously mentioned. Unfortunately, in our country, not only is little attention paid to the blame game, but actions are often reversed. A negotiator must be careful and simultaneously plan to avoid being identified as responsible for any negotiation failures. With globalization and the increasing influence of public opinion on policies — especially those involving security matters that require both domestic and international persuasion — the blame game becomes highly effective.

In this matter as well, the pro-Saudi faction within Kuwaiti establishment resorted to "blame-shifting" tactic. That is, simultaneously with the failure of the Emir of Kuwait's initiative due to opposition from Bahrain and Saudi Arabia, they resurrected and raised an old case concerning the "Abdoli group"⁸⁵ dating back to the Iraq-Kuwait war. Several arrests and detentions were carried out, and Iran was accused. They used that as a pretext to lower bilateral ties and claim that the Emir's plan had failed because of Iran's involvement in activities inside Kuwait. In reality, the arrests had begun before the Manama summit, and the Iranian Minister of Intelligence had traveled to Kuwait to explain Iran's position regarding these detentions. Ironically, during that same trip—which was the first high-level visit following President Rouhani's meeting with the Emir of Kuwait—the written response of the President to the Emir's initiative was delivered by the Minister of Intelligence. In any case, when the Emir returned from the Manama summit having failed to secure the support of Saudi Arabia and Bahrain for his initiative, the failure was blamed on Iran rather than on Saudi Arabia and Bahrain; but all involved knew that Saudi Arabia had rejected and blocked the proposal.

The final initiative of the Rouhani administration for cooperation and de-escalation in the Persian Gulf was the Hormuz Peace Initiative (HOPE), which the President presented on 25 September 2019 at the United Nations General Assembly. That same afternoon, I explained the

⁸⁵ a group of Kuwaiti Shiite citizens

initiative in a special Security Council session chaired by the Russian Foreign Minister. The Russian Foreign Minister had organized a special ministerial meeting of the Security Council to discuss cooperation among regional organizations and the UN, attended by a large number of foreign ministers, particularly from Eurasia.

After returning from the General Assembly, the President sent his HOPE initiative in separate letters to seven Persian Gulf heads of state—namely Iraq and the six member states of the GCC—and suggested that they provide proposals for improving the initiative and cooperate in its implementation. However, Saudi Arabia, the UAE, and Bahrain did not even respond to the President's letter. Further efforts were made, but since the region was experiencing a new political and economic conflict involving Saudi Arabia, the UAE, Bahrain, and Egypt against Qatar, and the GCC was on the brink of an internal crisis, most of the initiatives remained at the level of bilateral contacts. After the Manama summit decided not to initiate dialogue with Iran, Bahrain, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, and Egypt imposed a blockade on Qatar. This move led to a crisis in the GCC from 2018 to 2021 and was eventually resolved through Kuwait's mediation, resulting in a cold peace among the southern Persian Gulf states.

The HOPE initiative was a comprehensive proposal. Others, such as Russia and China, had also put forward initiatives. Their proposals had some similarities to President Rouhani's plan, but I believe our proposal was more mature than the others. For example, Russia's proposal involved a large number of actors, making it unmanageable—that is, the five permanent members of the Security Council, the EU, the GCC, the Arab League, and the OIC. I told Lavrov: "If you want to give four votes to Saudi Arabia, very well, give four votes. Why unnecessarily involve others?" Russia's plan represented an unreasonable mechanism. China's plan seemed more reasonable, but it still lacked the maturity of the HOPE initiative. The initiative was more operational, more advanced, and more detailed. Iran, as the principal stakeholder in the Persian Gulf, had worked on it extensively, even finding a way of not arousing debate over toponyms, using "Hormuz" — which is not only a universally accepted toponym, but also connotes the strategic importance of this body of water and the region surrounding it, which we called the Hormuz Community.

A strange incident revealing the European sense of arrogance and self-centeredness occurred at the Security Council. During the Security Council session in which we presented the HOPE initiative, the British representative stated in his speech that "Iran is part of the problem and should not propose anything." I replied to his foreign minister in the session of the remaining JCPOA foreign ministers: "You are so arrogant that you say at the Security Council that Iran should not make a proposal. But you, who have created all the misery in the region, have the right to propose?"

During the Rouhani administrations, the Persian Gulf experienced many fluctuations. In some cases, these ups and downs disrupted Persian Gulf security, mostly due to foreign interference. Saudi Arabia's refusal to reconcile with Iran, when Iran enjoyed a more advantageous global position, was one of the fundamental roots of the Persian Gulf crisis, as previously discussed. However, to be realistic, we must also consider our internal impediments too.

We can view the Persian Gulf in two ways: first as a backyard in which Iran holds unrivaled power and seeks to exercise that power without any international mechanism. In this perspective, Iran sees itself as the unspoken regional hegemon, and such a view inevitably leads to tension. One consequence is the entry of external forces into the region, which ultimately reduces Iran's influence in the Persian Gulf. Iran's power is an undeniable reality in the Persian Gulf, and this fact remains a permanent asset. At the same time, imprudent attempts to exploit this capacity invite other actors to intervene, undermining the foundation of Iran's strength.

If our strategy in the Persian Gulf were to be determined from a purely military perspective, we would conclude that no contractual obstacles should limit the exercise of our military power in the Persian Gulf. However, the outcome of such a strategy in today's world would be that the very same military power could become ineffective and ultimately transform into a threat. No action in the external environment goes unnoticed. When neighboring countries perceive that one of them seeks dominance, they will attempt to invite extra-regional powers to counter our definite superiority in the Persian Gulf. Naturally, military commanders want Iran's superiority for deterrence, not as a means of imposition or

bullying; yet the resultant perception and constructed narrative are often used to portray Iran as a threat.

In the second perspective, through recognition and confidence in the country's material and ideational capabilities, it is understood that Iran possesses an intrinsic and absolute advantage for deterrence. Thus, the method for maintaining Iran's preeminence in the Persian Gulf is to instill confidence in neighboring countries rather than fear. Neighboring states cannot threaten us. But if they feel threatened—or if the United States and Israel manipulate such perceptions—they will turn to those who can and will threaten us. If, instead of fear, they feel assured, there is no need for such behavior. Currently, Israel has entered the region and is establishing itself in the Persian Gulf precisely because there is an illusion that Iran is becoming a hegemon and Israel's presence in the region will protect small Arab states in the Persian Gulf from Iran. The historical fact is that Israel has never sacrificed for any other nation, including the United States. Its presence in the region will further endanger regional states as its only aim is to establish forward offensive capability close to Iran. Neither Iran, nor the smaller regional states, have anything to gain from giving rise to such misperceptions of Iran's intentions in the Persian Gulf region.

Some may argue that no matter what we do, our smaller neighbors will perceive a threat. This possibility can be managed and controlled. The essence of asymmetric relationships is that if the smaller party cannot rely on itself or trust its neighbor, it will seek the assistance of another power. This is inherent in international politics. Iran does not seek support from other powers because it is confident in its own capability to defend itself. Without this self-confidence, we would certainly have sought the assistance of external powers against a nuclear neighbor that has at times in our contemporary history, made territorial and political acquisitions and claims against us. We do not turn to others because we are certain we can defend ourselves. This should not be assumed for everyone else, as they lack the necessary capability and self-confidence to resist.

On this basis, the Islamic Republic's policy since the Iran-Iraq War has been to try to assure the neighboring countries that they can coexist with us. Unfortunately, after the end of the war and the strengthening of Iran's military power, some have believed that any limitation in the

Persian Gulf is detrimental, assuming the Persian Gulf is merely a stage for displaying power. This notion rests on several incorrect assumptions: that Iran is the only actor, or that by rejecting all initiatives perceived as limiting militarily, we can prevent or delegitimize them. This assumption is inconsistent with reality. In practice, even with Iran's abstention from regional arrangements, different arrangements emerged with Israel's participation. Had the people of these countries not been made to perceive Iran as a threat, they would have never accepted the disgrace of relying on Israel, nor would they have allowed their rulers to do so.

Iran is the only country among immediate neighbors that has existed throughout history as a civilization-state. Other countries result from colonial divisions and borders imposed during the Ottoman period or after its collapse by the British. Iran, however, is a civilization-state, and in terms of aggregate power resources—natural resources, territory, geography, population, and human resources—has superiority over neighboring countries. Before the revolution, during the latter Pahlavi era, a special connection with the dominant global system further augmented these resources, making Iran the regional gendarme; whereas most countries in the region were small tributaries, deriving stability and even legitimacy from the same source.

After the revolution and the war imposed on Iran by Saddam Hussein, Iran's relationship with the global hegemonic system changed. Initially the Persian Gulf states tried to respond to the new imbalance through financial support and military aid to Saddam. The Iran-Iraq War was a combination of a principal and proxy war, and Saddam did not hesitate to state that he was the eastern barrier of the Arab world against Iranian "aggression". Following the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait, the southern Persian Gulf states delegated his role to the United States, Iranian separatist groups, and now increasingly to Israel.

It must always be recognized that these countries do not feel secure vis-à-vis Iran. Our region is inherently asymmetric. On one side, there is a revolutionary system whose mode of engagement with the global hegemon has fundamentally altered regional conditions. As a result, the southern neighbors perceive that they cannot easily maintain tension-free relations with Iran.

Before the revolution, Iran and the Arab countries were like branches and tributaries of the same river. Iran's greater power was always a source of envy for them. However, since they were all dependent on a single center of power, they could maintain unequal relationships without broad security concerns, although they always had issues of prestige. After the revolution, this order was disrupted. The source of Iran's power, instead of being connected externally, became internal and tied to the capabilities of its own people. This shift—from an external to an internal source of strength—fully crystallized those inequalities and asymmetries. As a result, the previously existing dependency links were reinforced across the southern Persian Gulf. For this reason, the Islamic Republic of Iran must always provide reassurance and confidence to these countries. In its communications and statements, it must consider both the reality and the constructed threat perceptions.

As previously mentioned, some Iranian officials mistakenly believe that “others, especially neighbors, must always fear Iran.” If we trace the root of our difficulties with regional countries, the problem lies precisely in this assumption. Instead of believing that we should act with paternal care and magnanimity toward the region, some think that these countries must feel fear and insecurity from us because they have wronged us, invaded us, and killed our people—which indeed they have done. However, we must understand that the more they feel insecure, the more they turn to extra-regional powers. This inclination is not limited to rulers but extends to the people as well. What unites and integrates the populations of these countries is the perception of an external threat. Israel seeks to portray this external threat as originating from Iran, not just the Islamic Republic. It should not be forgotten that in the strategic view of today's Israel, even among its so-called “peaceful” faction, the obstacle to future Zionist plans in the region is a powerful country called Iran, irrespective of its government. Israel aims to instill this perception in others, particularly in regional countries, through security-framing and threat-construction. Most of our political leaders have been unreceptive to the need to initiate and maintain a process of trust-building by Iran. One of the reasons for opposition to visiting Saudi Arabia was precisely this consideration. In my view, diplomatic formalities and protocols should not be an issue; we

must move toward our southern neighbors. The belief that our behavior with the southern neighbors should be based on reciprocity is flawed in many respects. This vicious cycle must be stopped. Reciprocity with a smaller neighbor is not a sign of strength; it is a sign of weakness and lack of self-confidence. If we wish to weaken a global hegemonic system and reduce the dependence of small regional states on external powers, we must establish the source of strength in the region. How? Through integration and interdependence. For sustainability, this relationship must be mutual; otherwise, it will collapse with the slightest disturbance.

Naturally, the small states on the southern Persian Gulf coast are never ready to form the same kind of reliance on Iran that they have on the “river” of the United States. Some ask why they have these links with the U.S. but not with us. It is because they need that link to maintain some parity with us—they fear that if they formed the same link with us, they would be “swallowed.” The U.S. is a distant power, while we are on top of them. Connections with Israel are similarly justified by concern about Iran and the attempt to establish a regional balance. Therefore, if we do not adopt the perspective of a magnanimous father toward these asymmetries and inequalities in our region, and instead adopt the stance of a big brother, the result will inevitably be dangerous, especially for Iran.

Another mistaken view we hold is that during the Shah’s time, the governor of Fars hosted the rulers of the Persian Gulf, and we should do the same. But why did that happen? At that time, the “Persian Gulf family” had another “father,” and the Shah was the “big brother.” In other words, someone else was the “master,” while the Shah was the “big subordinate,” and they were considered “minor subordinates.” After the revolution, Iran’s status changed; it is no longer dependent externally and stands on the power of its own people. Iran’s place in the region is better understood as paternal than hegemonic. The paternal metaphor implies responsibility rather than domination: a father does not cease caring for his children because they repeatedly challenge or even insult him. In practice, however, we did not approach our regional neighbors from such a paternalistic perspective. Instead, we treated them as sovereign equals.

Even our perspective considered the region as having wronged us. The wrongs were real, but they were like the actions of a frightened child, and

we had to correct that relationship. The foundation of failure in our regional policy was this mindset, which even among colleagues in the government and Ministry of Foreign Affairs has not changed. I do not claim that my perspective is flawless. I may be wrong: I have already noted the roots of Saudi rulers' envy and anger toward Iran. This can also be the cause or at least one of the ingredients of all regional failures despite actions by Iran. These factors may persist even if we change our attitude. But they can also reinforce each other.

In any case, our administration's foreign policy always paid special attention to neighboring countries, and in many cases—such as with Turkey, Pakistan, Russia, India, and China—we were more successful than previous administrations. However, regarding the Arab region, especially the Persian Gulf, for reasons previously mentioned, we were unsuccessful. It cannot be claimed that all the blame lies with the other side. Previously elaborated internal challenges arising from conflicting perspectives, along with longstanding domestic and foreign interests, were also major obstacles to achieving results. I must also acknowledge that my own lapses—such as not insisting on visiting Saudi Arabia at the start of my tenure despite formalities and failing to clearly articulate the conceptual basis of our proposals internally—contributed to these failures. We also consistently faced imprudent statements that fueled concern and tension. For instance, some in the media claimed that “four Arab capitals are under Iran's control.” This incorrect statement caused concern among Arab governments, provoked reactions among the Arab public, and provided tools for security-framing.

In conclusion and as a preface to the section dealing with various neighboring countries, I wish to make a comment for reflection. Many in Iranian polity and populace consider diplomacy—whether regrading cooperation in the Persian Gulf, the nuclear file, peace initiatives in Syria and Yemen, or similar cases—as the last resort when everything else fails and only in order to find a temporary breathing space to navigate crises and weaknesses. This is detrimental to Iran's security and interest, and I have elaborated on this fundamental flaw elsewhere in this book.

The Yemen War

Together with Martyr Soleimani, we believed that the Yemen war would produce no positive outcome for any party and had to end. Martyr Soleimani insisted strongly on this and repeatedly asked me and my colleagues to find a way to end the war. Accordingly, in the early days of the full-scale war, during a trip when Mr. Erdogan visited Iran on his way to Saudi Arabia, President Rouhani presented a four-point proposal to end the Yemen crisis in a joint press conference with Erdogan. Although Erdogan showed a willingness to cooperate in that interview, it seems his advisors told him that Saudi Arabia might not agree to such a plan—which indeed happened—and that he should proceed more cautiously.

Given Martyr Soleimani's insistence on stopping the Yemen war, during the peak of the JCPOA negotiations in April 2015—and despite the time constraints to reach an agreement on the one hand and our long-standing refusal to enter non-nuclear portfolios on the other—I proposed to John Kerry an initiative for immediate ceasefire in Yemen. He welcomed my proposal with minor adjustments. At that time, Saud Al-Faisal was still alive as Saudi Foreign Minister, and Adel al-Jubair was Saudi ambassador to Washington. Kerry conveyed our proposal to Saudi leaders through al-Jubair and, using his own diplomatic methods, secured the agreement of Saud Al-Faisal—and likely King Salman—for a ceasefire. Martyr Soleimani also coordinated with Yemen's Ansarullah (Houthis) to stop the war.

Later in April 2015, as I was boarding the plane to accompany the President to Indonesia for a summit initiated by the Indonesian President, Kerry called to say that Riyadh had agreed to the ceasefire and wanted me to coordinate with the Yemeni side. I told him, "I won't be available during the eight-hour flight," since the President's plane had no communications equipment due to sanctions. I therefore gave him the phone number of one of my deputies and said, "If Iran's intervention is needed during these eight hours, contact him; he will coordinate with General Soleimani." I also informed the colleague, "Kerry may contact you to coordinate the Yemen ceasefire. If he does, immediately inform General Soleimani, who has been involved in this case from the beginning, so he can take the necessary steps."

When we arrived in Indonesia, news was circulating on social media and in the press that a Yemen ceasefire would soon occur. Happily, I contacted the same deputy to confirm whether it had been done. The answer was negative—Kerry had not called. At the first opportunity, I followed up with Kerry. It became clear that Mohammad bin Salman, who at that time had apparently not yet become crown prince but was responsible for the Yemen war, had blocked the ceasefire and claimed that he could achieve victory in Yemen within three weeks. Of course, instead of three weeks, eight years passed with hundreds of thousands of casualties, and Saudi Arabia remained stuck in Yemen's quagmire.

This underscores a historical and theoretical perspective: since World War I, with few minor and insignificant exceptions such as Grenada and Panama, countries that initiated wars rarely achieved success. Some were defeated outright, such as Germany and the Ottoman Empire in World War I; Germany, Italy, and Japan in World War II; China and North Korea in the Korean War; the United States in Vietnam; the Soviet Union in Afghanistan; Saddam Hussein in his invasions of Iran and Kuwait; and Milosevic in his aggression against Croatia and Bosnia. Saddam destroyed himself and his regime, while Milosevic even erased his country, Yugoslavia, from the map.

Others, like the United States in Afghanistan and Iraq, failed to achieve their stated objectives. In Afghanistan, after twenty years of war, bloodshed, hundreds of thousands of Afghans and American casualties, and several trillion dollars, the U.S. ultimately handed the country back to the Taliban, the very group it had ousted. In Iraq, not only did the U.S. fail to achieve its goals, but it also facilitated the emergence of ISIS and heightened extremism throughout the region and beyond.

This is why war—once a tool of foreign policy in the international balance of power and also considered a necessary feature of sovereignty under international law—was prohibited except in cases of legitimate self-defense against prior armed aggression, first in the 1928 Paris Pact and later in the United Nations Charter. International law reflects the practical realities of global conditions and international relations. In other words, war became legally prohibited at the point when it had already lost its practical and even military utility.

As previously mentioned, relying on the flawed and outdated doctrine of “preemptive and preventive defense,” the United States, from 1991 to 2006, imagined it could become the unchallenged global power through war, leveraging its vastly superior military capabilities. Yet just a few years after the Second Iraq War, the famous Baker-Hamilton report—commissioned by Congress and prepared by bipartisan experts—acknowledged the failure of this unchecked militaristic policy. Interestingly, over the past two decades, the U.S. has avoided direct involvement in wars and increasingly relied on lower-cost, more complex strategies of securitization. The latest example is the strategic entrapment of Russia, leading to its deadly involvement in war and the suffering of Ukraine, all aimed at reconstructing the West and NATO under U.S. leadership.

Relations with Iraq

Iraq is an important neighbor for Iran and has always held a key place in Iran’s foreign policy. The main security concern of the Pahlavi II era was Iraq’s increasing power and the delivery of advanced Soviet weaponry to the country. Beyond past conflicts, we also share the legacy of the eight-year war following the revolution. After Saddam’s fall, a close and strong bond developed between the Islamic Republic of Iran and Iraq. Devotion to the holy shrines and shared religious culture has significantly deepened these ties. Beyond geographic proximity, the connection with a country that hosts sacred sites, and to which our people have profound emotional and religious attachment, is inevitable. From this perspective, maintaining ties with both Iraq and Saudi Arabia is essential.

During Saddam’s rule, I made several official trips to Iraq. I accompanied Foreign Minister Velayati on his first visit to Iraq in 1991. Later, I traveled with Foreign Minister Kharazi to meet Saddam Hussein. Before departing for New York for my assignment at the Permanent Mission to the United Nations, my wife insisted that we first visit the holy shrines in Iraq and immunize our family against the trials of life in the West. Therefore, in August 2002, at the height of Iraq’s famous summer heat, we undertook a family trip to Iraq.

My first bilateral trip as Foreign Minister was also to Iraq. Interestingly, the President's first trip was to Bishkek for a Shanghai Cooperation Organization summit, with a concurrent bilateral visit to Kyrgyzstan. In this way, bilateral visits at the level of President and Foreign Minister began with neighbors and the region.

On the first trip to Iraq, I met with all the key leaders and political parties. The President of Iraq hosted a dinner, and we held friendly, constructive meetings with the Speaker of Parliament and the Prime Minister. On one visit, to follow up on the assassination of General Qasem Soleimani, I met with the head of Iraq's Judicial Council due to the relevance of the matter. Visits also included party leaders, resistance groups, and Shiite, Sunni, Christian, and Yazidi leaders. During a six-day trip across five cities, I met with Iraqi entrepreneurs and the Iranian community in Iraq. All these meetings were warmly received.

Perhaps the most significant memory from the first visit was meeting Grand Ayatollah Ali al-Sistani⁸⁶. He was very kind. I visited him twice personally and once accompanied the President. Beyond his high personal stature, he is an exceptionally knowledgeable and well-read expert across many fields. During our first visit, he mentioned that he had read the recently published book of the ambassador (my memories) twice. In all three visits, he showed immense kindness to me, especially in the presence of the President. I have met with leaders from many countries, but in no foreign country have I encountered a figure of comparable stature. Ayatollah Sistani offers political insight but does not express his views directly, and in some cases, he deems intervention unnecessary. Moreover, he plays a unifying role not only among Shiites but also among Sunnis, Christians and other groups. Few in Iraq hold a negative view of him. Regarding Iran, he consistently supported and emphasized that the Islamic Republic must engage the world wisely and defend its rights.

Unfortunately, except for photographs taken alongside the President, these visits were not properly documented. At the time, I believed I should refrain from taking notes or photographs as a matter of modesty

⁸⁶ <https://namayande.com/news/64898/>

and confidentiality. I thought that was the right thing to do. But now, especially while writing this book, I seriously question that judgment.

In short, ties with Iraq have always been critical, but became even more pivotal after the war. For many years, we have faced challenges regarding land and water borders with Iraq. Until 2003, we also had ideological and doctrinal disagreements. At one time, Iran was aligned with the West and Saddam Hussein with the Soviet bloc. Later, shifts occurred, but during the imposed war, all major and minor powers stood with Saddam Hussein. The Iranian people, despite differing perspectives, can never—and must never—forget this unprecedented support for the aggressor and its broader legacy, which will forever remain in the collective memory of all Iranians. The world should also keep this dark page in mind when dealing with Iran and our region.

From a natural geographic perspective, Iraq occupies a challenging position. Its very limited access to open waters has made its foreign policy toward Iran and Kuwait highly tense. Issues such as the dredging of the Arvand Rud (Shatt al-Arab) based on the 1975 treaty remained unresolved for nearly twenty-eight years after the end of the imposed war. Finally, during President Rouhani's visit to Iraq, then-Prime Minister Adel Abdul Mahdi agreed to dredge the river according to the 1975 treaty.

In September 1988, when the first round of talks to implement UN Resolution 598 began, the two delegations clashed over the dredging of the Arvand Rud. This dispute remained officially unresolved until 2018 and is still practically incomplete. During President Rouhani's 2018 visit to Iraq, through the combined efforts of Martyr Soleimani's and myself, we were able—for the first time in nearly thirty years—to reach a joint statement by the leaders agreeing on the dredging of the Shatt al-Arab based on the 1975 treaty. This was a major achievement, made possible by the coordination between the Foreign Ministry, the Quds Force, and President Rouhani's personal follow-up, although the Iraqi government still delays implementation using various pretexts. Perhaps only President Rouhani and I were present at both the initial 1988 dispute session and the final 2018 agreement session.

Certain elements of the Iran-Iraq relationship have remained constant over the years. These include Iraq's territorial concerns and limited access

to open waters. Saddam was unable to achieve his objectives through the two wars with Iran and Kuwait. These geopolitical concerns continue to shape Iraq's relationship with Iran. Additionally, post-Saddam Iraq's alignment with Arab countries is undeniable. Even the tendencies from Saddam's era toward Egypt and Jordan, and cooperation with them, continue to prevail.

Iraqis' approach to cooperation with Iran—even on shared projects such as the Basra-Shalamcheh railway and the dredging of the Arvand Rud—has often been cautious, marked by reservation and a “zero-sum” mindset. Even if leaders are committed to collaboration and agreement, the bureaucratic apparatus in Iraq rarely reflects this intent. A sense of competition, even strategic rivalry, with Iran persists among Iraqi experts and Iraqi polity in general. Consequently, many mutually beneficial proposals either remain unimplemented or progress very slowly.

Iraqi experts view the Basra-Shalamcheh railway as a competitor to the large, long-term project connecting Faw to Europe via Turkey. Despite successive political agreements, they have sought to obstruct its implementation through every available means and conceivable pretext. This short railway could connect Basra to the Persian Gulf in a very short period, whereas the Faw project, at best, would take years. Interestingly, during late President Raisi's administration, they explicitly conditioned the railway's operation on passenger transport only, excluding cargo, to avoid competition with the Faw-Europe transit line.

Iraq has benefited most from Iran's sanctions, capturing, perhaps, more of Iran's market share than any other country. While this does not indicate hostility, it also does not signify close friendship with a country that fought alongside Iraq against ISIS. Even when Iran exports gas and electricity to Iraq—desperately needed by Iran itself—collecting payment is extremely difficult. Their behavior cannot be classified as friendly; at best, it is commercial, based purely on cost benefit analysis. Neighborly behavior is largely absent, and sanctions are implemented in meticulous detail. Yet, if gas or electricity deliveries are interrupted for even a few days, they immediately respond with intense media campaigns in both countries, compelling Iran to quick restore the status quo ante, because of the importance we attach to being in good terms with the Iraqi people.

Interestingly, Iraq, like Iran, has experienced heavy UN sanctions for years and understands their pain; yet it has meticulously implemented all anti-Iran sanctions. Ironically, Iran's assistance to its foe, Saddam Hussein, in circumventing UN sanctions and alleviating Iraqi suffering was much greater than the assistance provided by the Shia-led governments of Iraq to Iran to evade the illegal U.S. sanctions.

In recent years, Iraq has often benefited from Iran's resources without paying sufficient compensation. While Iranian technical and engineering services have had a significant impact on Iraq's reconstruction, Iranian service providers receive minimal payment, and Baghdad and the Kurdistan Region give extremely low priority to Iranian contractors' claims in comparison with those of other nations' contractors.

Many of these difficulties arise from the lack of balanced, reciprocal interests in Iraq. In the perception of Iraqis, Iran helps primarily for its own benefit. Statements such as "If we had not fought ISIL in Iraq, we would now be fighting them in Iran" exacerbate the feeling that not only Iraq does not owe Iran anything for its sacrifices, but even we are indebted to them for being our forward defense. Some in Iraq claim that by bearing the costs of the war against ISIS, they helped maintain Iran's security and tranquility. This has hindered Iran's ability to engage in proper negotiations with Iraq on matters not related to military operations against common adversaries.

Of course, no foreign policy is unilateral. Our perspective on terrorism and U.S. presence in Iraq is based on our own interests, and Iraqis understand this. Nevertheless, pan-Arab and anti-Iranian tendencies among Iraq's political elite have contributed to these perceptions and assumptions.

In some areas, such as transit, Iraq views itself as a competitor to Iran. Connecting the Persian Gulf to the Mediterranean through Iran—to Basra, Syria, or Turkey—would benefit both countries; however, Iraqis believe that linking Faw to the Mediterranean via Turkey offers them greater advantage. From Iranian perspective, Iraq should be a complementary partner, but they tend to see Iran only as a rival. This explains why they block the Basra-Shalamchah railway while pursuing the Faw-Turkey route with determination. All post-Saddam Iraqi administrations have assumed office with Iran's blessing. However, despite very amicable lip service by

Iraqi political leadership, the bureaucracy continues to approach Iran quite like the Saddam Hussein's era.

Many Iraqis unjustly hold Iran responsible for their government's inefficiencies and challenges. If problems arose within the Popular Mobilization Forces (Hashd al-Shaabi) or during the administrations of Maliki, Adel Abdul Mahdi, or Haider al-Abadi, many Iraqis immediately blamed Iran. The Iraqi populace generally believe that Iran is conducting its disputes with Saudi Arabia and the United States on Iraqi soil.

Given the services and sacrifices of figures such as Martyr Soleimani, Iran should have been far more popular in Iraq. Mistakes on our part, combined with internal and external Iraqi factors, have meant that our assistance and achievements have been less visible, while shortcomings are wrongly attributed to us. Many countries engage in security cooperation while showcasing political or economic achievements. In contrast, Iran's engagement with Iraq is presented and perceived as primarily military in nature and appearance. This does not create a positive Iranian image among the Iraqi public.

Another factor in Iran-Iraq bilateral ties is the large volume of Iranian exports to Iraq. In reality, much of this volume consists of subsidized goods, providing minimal benefit to Iran. In other words, in many areas we effectively exported subsidies to Iraq. Goods produced with subsidized raw materials were sent there, making border-market purchases very cost-effective for Iraqis. For example, while Iranian candies and chocolates using subsidized flour and sugar are very popular in Iraq, Iranian potato imports are banned, and they are imported from Pakistan.

Regional countries, including Iraq, do not want effective detente between Iran and the West, as they understand Iran's role, weight, and influence. They know that normalization of Iran-West relations would greatly reduce their global appeal. We have observed both private and public discussions of Arab leaders in Western countries, and there is no evidence that Iraqi leaders have supported Iran in these dialogues.

Nevertheless, long-term, profitable economic cooperation with Iraq is possible and necessary. Achieving this requires a different approach. When we perceive our interests in Iraq as primarily security-related, we must bear the costs of securing those interests. Although Iraq may rely on

us for security, we are the ones insisting on helping them. Consequently, to our surprise, they expect us to bear the costs. Therefore, we should not assume that security assistance will yield direct economic returns. Turkey benefits more economically from Iraq than we do because it leverages security to gain economic advantages.

Beyond shared religious interests, Iraq has historical, ethnic, and tribal ties with Iran and could serve as a bridge to the Arab world. Iraq is a key and central country in the Arab world. Iraq's close relationship and coordination with Iran, will undoubtedly augment Iran's influence and capability in the Arab world. Achieving this requires dealing with Iraq based on reality, not wishful thinking.

Good ties with Saudi Arabia are also important, but we cannot hope for Iran and Saudi Arabia to become the "two wings" of the Islamic world. This is a wish that will never be realized. Iran and Saudi Arabia will never be strategic allies and will always remain competitors. However, this rivalry can take on a constructive form. Similarly, Iraq and Syria will not unite with us against the Arab world, but they can serve as a bridge for improved relations with our Arab neighbors.

My approach here is not against pursuing the moral and inspirational dimensions of foreign policy; rather, it emphasizes pursuing them within the framework of realities on the ground. For example, if Syria under Assad acted contrary to our wishes within the Arab League, we should not have been disheartened or angry. Even after preventing the overthrow of Assad, the Arab League still sided against Iran on the fabricated UAE claims regarding the three Iranian islands. Iraq is similar: from the viewpoint of Iraqi strategists, Iran and Iraq are competitors, and Iraqi society will never accept Iran as the dominant power within their country.

A few brief remarks on war reparations from the Iran-Iraq War are also warranted. In the final paragraph of his report implementing Paragraph Six of UN Resolution 598 on war responsibility⁸⁷, the UN Secretary-General recognized Iraq as responsible for initiating the imposed war⁸⁸ and recommended that the issue not be pursued further⁸⁹. As a participant

⁸⁷ S/23273, 9 December 1991

⁸⁸ Ibid, Paragraph 7

⁸⁹ Ibid, Paragraph 9

in all trilateral Iran-Iraq-UN Secretary-General dialogues and having played a central role in the arduous process of implementing Paragraph Six, I emphasize that pursuing war reparations will not bear fruit and would only harm Iran-Iraq relations. Paragraph Seven of Resolution 598 stipulates that reconstruction costs for both countries should be met through international assistance. We insisted with success that the United Nations must validate Iran's position on Iraq's responsibility for the conflict. Securing this recognition is an achievement of historic proportions, honoring our martyrs and ensuring that their sacrifices were not in vain. We should leave it there.

At the same time, full implementation of the 1975 Algiers Accord benefits both Iran and Iraq. We must not allow bureaucratic obstruction in Iraq to prevent dredging of the Shatt al-Arab. Iraqis must finally reconcile with this misperceived historical wound and implement the treaty to prevent another war. Until Iran and Iraq agree on dredging, the possibility of renewed tensions remains, though it is hoped that their cooperation, as two Muslim and majority Shiite nations, will serve as a model of collaboration and solidarity among peoples.

The Dichotomy between Influence and Presence

Among Iranian elites, the question has often arisen: despite Iran's heavy expenditures in Iraq, Syria, and Palestine, why have other countries, such as Turkey, gained greater economic and even political benefits from these countries than Iran? After Mr. Erdoğan's electoral victory in Turkey in 2023, Palestinians celebrated at Al-Aqsa Mosque, even though Turkey maintains diplomatic ties with Israel and high-level political and economic exchanges are ongoing. The number of Palestinian children named Erdogan was also notably high.

As a general rule, the primary source of any country's power beyond its borders lies in its ideational and inspirational influence, not in military presence. Even the United States, with all its military might, has learned—albeit reluctantly and in the hard way—that it is more important to win hearts and minds than territory. It is important to remember that Iran's ideational power in the early years after the Islamic Revolution inspired

many in the Global South to the extent that they named their children Ruhollah or even Khomeini. This inspirational power can sometimes be enhanced through military assistance or the provision of certain capabilities. But we should never be confused that all of this must be geared to augment national power through inspiration and influence. A material, overt presence has the opposite effect: it exposes the country to being blamed for inefficiencies, difficulties, and losses.

The United States has reached a similar conclusion: its military presence overseas lacks popular support domestically and abroad. It has significant human and financial cost for Americans, thus consistently facing domestic opposition. Moreover, the local population in the host country never wholeheartedly accepts foreign troops. This is why one campaign promise of presidential candidates—including Trump—was to end “Forever Wars.”

Why do Iran’s development aid efforts elicit negative reactions abroad? The adverse public response is largely due to the negative perception and psychological effect of Iran’s material presence. This form of engagement does not generate popularity or influence domestically or globally; instead, it provokes friction at home and resistance abroad.

The Islamic Revolution and the Islamic Republic of Iran possess unmatched capacity to inspire, generating influence and ideational power. The armed forces can contribute to this tremendous potential by focusing on the ideational dimensions of national power. The uplifting message of the Islamic Revolution coupled with the resilience of Iranian people in the face of huge and unfair adversities have inspired many oppressed people around the globe. This can be further augmented through efficient and equitable governance instilling hope and inspiration. Iran’s Vision Document forecasts Iran to be an inspiration to others, thus recognizing the value of ideational power. Others must perceive hope and a promising future in Iran to be inspired to emulate the Islamic Republic. People worldwide and in the region should see Iran as a capable, proud, advanced state, supported by its people—and be drawn to it. The comparative advantage of the Islamic Republic lies in ideational and moral power because the revolution offered a fresh perspective on governance. As long as we focus on inspirational influence based on our ideals and values, our ideational power grows. Attempting to convert this influence into

military presence gradually diminishes ideational power, while material gains remain limited. This approach risks expanding vulnerabilities rather than influence. Military capability can be the key pillar of national capability and diplomatic success, but the goal should not be to deploy military forces abroad. In all countries, undercover military and intelligence personnel and not diplomats establish contact with domestic groups. Regional influence does not require physical presence. Influence can be exerted through inspiration, and, if necessary, through support for resistance—including training—without deploying military forces. Military involvement, however, brings endless costs, irreversible pressure, and local and global backlash, while at the same time corroborating U.S. and Israeli narratives.

According to Iran's Vision Document, the country's goal is to be "inspiring, active, and effective in the Islamic world, consolidating the model of Islamic democracy, promoting efficient development, ethical society, innovation, intellectual and social dynamism, and influencing Islamic and regional convergence based on Islamic teachings and the thoughts of Imam Khomeini." Therefore, expanding influence—not physical presence—in the region is prescribed in the national vision statement, and all government agencies should act accordingly.

If the goal is to increase influence, pursuing ideational power becomes highly valuable. For instance, if we aim to become the region's most influential power through inspiration, success is achievable—as Iran has often demonstrated. Conversely, if we attempt to secure influence through military presence, we risk losing even the ideational power we already have, let alone economic benefits. In short, if we plant apple seeds, we should not expect an orange harvest.

For example, in Iraq, we must also consider economic outcomes, not focus solely on countering U.S. presence or ISIS. We use the leverage of assisting in security primarily for security-related concessions. Consequently, we cannot expect substantial economic or even political returns. Utilizing economic advantages and ties in Iraq requires high-level strategic decisions and does not directly fall under the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. The influence of Iraq's domestic issues on our decisions means that we will provide them with gas and electricity under any circumstances;

therefore, it is unrealistic to expect significant reciprocation from Iraq for these services. This approach explains why, when Iraq used some of our own funds to cover the costs of our Hajj pilgrims or to settle our debt with Turkmenistan, we considered it as favor achieved through our hard diplomatic effort. This was the case both under our administration and the subsequent one.

Priorities need not be exclusively economic or even political. They must be balanced, taking into account the economy, diplomacy, global image, security arrangements, and countering adversaries. Consideration must also be given to actors like the U.S. and Israel, who aim to undermine Iran. Ignoring or overemphasizing any factor in this complex equation ultimately harms all priorities, including the success of our primary objectives.

It should not be forgotten that the rise of ISIS prompted a heightened Iranian military presence in Iraq. Terrorism knows no borders, and when it emerges in one region, it poses a threat to all. One of the Islamic Republic's major regional achievements has been the fight against ISIS and extremism. Martyr General Qasem Soleimani was a hero in combating terrorism, and the world owes him a debt of gratitude. However, we were unable to reap the full benefits of this struggle. Even countries that combat terrorism for their own interests gain the corresponding rewards—but we did not receive what our sacrifices in Iraq warranted. This is because our objective was to fight terrorism, not to advance national interests.

Undoubtedly, combating terrorism is part of our national interest—but it is not all of it. Our professed need to confront and defeat extremism in Iraq and Syria was arguably greater than that of the Iraqi or Syrian governments, which were directly facing these threats. Therefore, we cannot expect Iraq or Syria to compensate us for our efforts. From their perspective, Iran was acting primarily for itself. Benefits can only be negotiated when aid is provided at the request and insistence of the recipient government, and not when the persistence comes from the help provider.

Another goal after confronting and eliminating ISIS was to push the U.S. out of the region. While it is true that American presence in the region—whether in Afghanistan or Iraq—is not advantageous to Iran's security, our goals, concerns, and priorities must be ranked, deeply analyzed, and

carefully assessed. For instance: Is U.S. presence in Iraq preferable under a government friendly to Iran or under one opposed to Iran? There is no guarantee that U.S. forces would leave under a government opposed to Iran. Similarly, was U.S. presence in Afghanistan better under Ashraf Ghani's administration or under the Taliban? We have observed that U.S. military presence in Taliban-led Afghanistan is steadily increasing. Is U.S. presence in Iraq better under a Shiite government or an anti-Shiite government? Under a pro-Iran government or a pro-Saudi government?

Empathy and Proxy

A key point in Iran's regional relations is the distinction between empathy and proxy relationships. As mentioned earlier, one of the Islamic Republic's advantages in my view is that it does not maintain proxies. Proxies are those who fight on your behalf for your interests, while their own interests and perspectives are subordinated to yours. For example, the fighters in Idlib are proxies—they may fight one day in Syria, the next in Libya, or even in Somalia. These same forces were also deployed to Azerbaijan during the Karabakh conflict to support Baku. Interceptions of their communications revealed they were not pleased to participate in the Karabakh war, because from their perspective, they were fighting to help “infidel” Shiites at the behest of a “nonbelieving” government like Ilham Aliyev's. But as proxies, they ultimately act according to the whims of the sponsoring state even when that is contrary to their own beliefs and perspectives.

Iran does not have a single one of such proxies. This fact is one of the pillars of Iran's strength, as no one has been hired anywhere in the world to fight for Iranian interests. Under the Shah regime, however, this was different; the Shah acted in Lebanon and Kurdistan to advance Iran's interests, at times sacrificing Kurdish populations for Iranian national aims. The Islamic Republic has never behaved in this manner. Even in supporting resistance groups with whom Iran maintains cooperative ties, Iran mostly incurs costs and sacrifices its own interests, rather than enhancing them. This is the fundamental difference between the Islamic Republic's approach and that of the Shah, Turkey, or Saudi Arabia.

Those governments act solely to advance their own national interests, whereas Iran supports those who resist oppression, injustice, and foreign domination, while these groups act based on their own interests and perspectives. Internationally, Iranian leadership does not allow diplomats to negotiate on behalf of these groups; rather, Iranian negotiators must reflect and advance the groups' own priorities. For instance, in global diplomacy regarding Yemen, Iran inquired what these groups wanted us to convey to serve their interests. Similarly, during the adoption of UN Security Council Resolution 1701 to end the 33-day Israeli aggression against Lebanon, as Iran's permanent representative to the UN, I engaged in negotiations based on the priorities of Hezbollah and Lebanon's resistance, receiving guidance from Beirut and not from Tehran. The instructions from Tehran were simply to ensure that the interest and objectives of the Lebanese were advanced. In the Bonn talks concerning Afghanistan, Iran also focused on and advanced the perspectives and interests of friendly Afghan groups.

This is Iran's strength. The goal is not to create proxies, but to support the authentic aspirations of oppressed people. But acting prudently for the benefit of the oppressed can simultaneously enhance Iran's own ideational influence. This very approach constitutes a pillar of our aggregate strength. However, when we attempted to transform it into military presence or worse yet boast about it—claiming, for example, that we “rescued Iraq from ISIS” or “control four Arab capitals”—negative reactions emerged, gradually diminishing our inspirational capabilities.

Hence, contrary to Western propaganda, the relations between Iran and the so-called “Axis of Resistance” does not follow customary master-proxy relationships; rather, it is a relationship of empathy, solidarity, and often one-way support. Members of the Axis of Resistance do not and are not expected to sacrifice their interests for those of Iran. If anything, it is Iran that incurs significant costs for supporting them. A clear illustration of this dynamic is their behavior during heightened U.S. economic pressure on Iran or Israeli assassinations in Iran. If they were a proxy force, we would have witnessed a surge in their operations in the occupied territories concurrent with the intensification of sanctions and assassinations—but this never occurred.

Another indication is the pattern of cooperation. For instance, in pursuing Iran's stated objective of expelling the U.S. from Afghanistan, none of Iran's traditional allies assisted, as they considered it to be detrimental to their own objectives. Iran thus had to engage new actors such as the Taliban, who fought for their own interests in ousting the U.S., not ours. The Taliban's subsequent behavior toward Iran and Iran's traditional allies in Afghanistan—after “victory” over the U.S. and NATO—was exactly as expected. Similarly, in Iraq, many Arab nationalist groups close to the Baath Party, with anti-Iranian tendencies, were willing to confront the U.S. Apparent contradictions, such as Muqtada al-Sadr's positions—opposing the U.S., while aligning with Saudi Arabia, and criticizing Iran—represent another example of these dynamics, which should not be surprising.

These historical realities do not contradict supporting the Axis of Resistance. In my view, Iran's relations with authentic resistance to Israeli aggressions are the most robust and enduring type of relationship. This engagement is not only consistent with our Islamic and human principles but can also augment our influence. However, sustaining such ties requires accurate comprehension of their nature and alignment of expectations with the realities of principled, long-term partnerships.

Iran's Focus on the Arab World instead of the Iranian World

In analyzing Iran's behavior and relationships with its neighbors, a key point emerges: the impact of the imposed Iran–Iraq War on our perspective toward neighboring countries. Here, two outcomes of the imposed war in relation to our neighbors should be highlighted:

The first outcome is that, due to the imposed war and the threats we faced during it, our view of neighbors shifted from an opportunity-oriented perspective to a threat-oriented one. The primary source of threat lay among the western neighbors of the country, beginning with Iraq and extending to the Arab countries, based on Saddam Hussein's assertion that they were the “eastern barrier of the Arab world against Iran.” This caused us, consciously or unconsciously, to feel that we must neutralize

this threat. Consequently, we focused our regional policy toward the western part of the country, even though the western neighbors do not represent our area of comparative advantage among neighboring states.

The imposed war drew our attention more toward the Arab world than toward the Iranian world. The Iranian world lies to our east and north, not to our south and west. Within this civilizational domain of Iran there are solid and historical mutual proximities and a strong affinity toward Iran, notably in Pakistan, India, Afghanistan, Tajikistan, and the Caucasus.

One such proximity is that Iran acted as the western barrier of the non-Arab world against Arab domination; Islam entered Asia from Iran and thus this region was not Arabized. The Arab expansion accompanying Islam stopped on Iran's borders, and the Islam that spread eastward from Iran had a distinct Iranian flavor. Therefore, our proximity to the east and north is greater than our affiliation and attachment to the west and south. Yet, in my view, our threat perception forced us—probably unintentionally—to concentrate on the west and south—a point that deserves careful reflection.

The second outcome of the Iraq–Iran war was to refocus Iran's neighborhood policy from one based on economic and cultural opportunities into one focused on neutralizing the threat through a securitized policy. As a result, security forces dominated our regional policy. We did not have the opportunity to focus on economic, political, cultural, and civilizational pillars in our regional strategy. This predicament originated from the war and extended not only to the Arab world but even to Central Asia and the Caucasus.

Our security-focused view of the region led us, despite being the more powerful country, to perceive ourselves as “threatened”—contrary to our true standing. This sense of anxiety reflects self-diminishment rather than capability. Those portending extremist views suffer from a lack of confidence and self-belief. This is caused more by self-diminishment, not by actual weakness: a powerful civilization-state, envied by all its neighbors, perceives itself as under constant threat and thus relies on securitized policies toward its neighborhood. In other words, the persistence of this securitized approach over the past decades reflects a siege mentality caused primarily by lack of self-confidence and not

a desire for domination. As I have noted, this lack of self-confidence itself stems from the imposed war and the lingering effects it left on the collective mindset. In an environment where the U.S. and Israel use every opportunity as an excuse to demonize and securitize Iran, Iran's siege mentality leads to self-securitization and contributes to formation of anti-Iran coalitions. Today, Israel has established a presence in our south through the Abraham Accords and in the north in the Republic of Azerbaijan. When even our cultural activities in the region stem from a securitized, defensive perspective of self-diminishment, the smaller countries in the region become increasingly concerned about us. The greater their fear, the closer they move toward our rivals and opponents.

Securitized relations with some do not extend to all neighboring states, with whom we have had normal ties. For instance, although we have experienced economic challenges with Turkmenistan, these disputes were gladly not securitized, thus allowing our relations to remain normal. By contrast, in Tajikistan, because that country perceives us as having security presence or objectives there, our ties have faced significant difficulties. The same has been true in Afghanistan. In Pakistan, however, our presence has been more cultural. It is true that sectarianism has affected relations to some extent, but our situation there has been far more favorable than in Afghanistan, precisely because our presence in Pakistan has been political and cultural rather than security driven. That said, even our cultural presence in Pakistan has not always been channeled appropriately. Those following sectarian narratives have failed to grasp unifying tendencies that have always bridged sectarian divides. A vivid example is Muhammad Iqbal; he was not a Shi'a; yet he not only composed poetry in Persian, but also produced remarkable verses in praise of the family of the prophet revered by Shiites.

It seems that four main factors distanced us from the inspirational pursuit of the ideals of the Revolution—ideals that were fundamentally value-based, cultural, and ideational—and instead propelled us hastily toward a militarized and self-securitized path that neither corresponds to the objectives of the Islamic Revolution nor offers us any comparative advantage: the imposed war, the terrorism of the Mojahedin-e Khalq

Organization, the threats posed by the United States and Israel, and the intellectual influence of Soviet Union and leftist groups.

Leftist groups implanted in certain revolutionary circles both the doctrine of “ends justifying the means” and applying the Marxist notion of “principal contradiction” to the United States. Yet it was the war and the Mojahedin that securitized the internal and external policies of the country—whereas our Revolution itself was decidedly cultural and Imam Khomeini never condoned violent means of resistance against the Shah. Early research in the months following the victory of the Revolution regarded the Iranian Revolution as historically unprecedented, precisely because it triumphed through the capacity and unity of the people, rather than through a “revolutionary vanguard party” or armed guerilla faction. What diverted us from that principal path of the revolution and introduced violence were, first, the war imposed upon us by Saddam, and second, the terror and atmosphere of fear imposed upon Iranian polity by the MeK. The constant threats from the United States and Israel and their presence in the region also played a significant role in perpetuating a securitized outlook. As mentioned above, the influence of Marxist culture—which enshrines “the end justifies the means” and considers the United States the “primary contradiction”—left a profound imprint on the securitization of our decision-making and the tendency to construct enemies. On this basis, it appears that our regional policy has become overly securitized, with the result of reinforcing among Iranians a mentality shaped by enmity.

I have seldom employed the word “enemy.” This is not out of naiveté or wishful thinking, but rests upon several theoretical and practical foundations. First, the term “enemy” is premised upon the inevitability of war. While it is true that war and peace are among the foundational questions of international relations, as noted earlier, war has lost its utility for more than a century. Until the late nineteenth and early twentieth centuries, war was regarded as the central instrument of foreign policy. Yet since the First World War and the emergence of “total war,” states that have initiated wars have failed to emerge victorious or achieve their objectives, and in many cases, the aggressors themselves have been destroyed. Some assume this means that war has ended or become obsolete. Such a conclusion is inaccurate. States continue to indulge in the illusion

that they can win wars, and wars continue to be launched—yet they fail to deliver results. After the Cold War, the United States believed it could entrench its global dominance through military power. Consequently, from 1991 until 2003, both American parties pursued policies of war. Yet the consequences of the invasions of Iraq and Afghanistan proved disastrous for the United States. Since the Baker-Hamilton report in 2006, America has sought to avoid war. Still, this does not preclude the possibility of repeating the same error. What is certain today is not that war is obsolete, but rather that it is futile and indeed detrimental to all. “In war, everyone loses.”

Second, although hostility toward Iran is a reality, enmity is neither an effective nor a proper foundation for governance. The first victim of an enmity-based global order would be Iran and its leadership. If global powers—or what may be termed “global governance”—wish to define a singular enemy, they would cast Iran in that role. In the past three decades, the major powers engaged in fierce rivalries. Nonetheless they came together against Iran at three critical junctures: first, in supporting Saddam during the imposed war of the 1980s; second, in adopting Resolution 598 in 1987 to prevent Iran’s victory; and third, in referring Iran’s nuclear dossier to the UN Security Council in 2006. The outcome of Iran’s historical experience and the character of the Islamic Revolution have been that a global atmosphere of hostility serves only to intensify the securitization of and demonization of Iran.

As noted earlier, securitization is constructed upon the fabrication of enemies. To securitize, one must manufacture, construct, or at least exaggerate a threat. Israel is a prime example of a securitizing actor. With its historical background and fierce internal rivalries, Israel has always required an enemy—both for internal cohesion and for justifying repression and state terrorism. Initially, it constructed the Nazi crimes of the Holocaust as an existential threat, and used it as a tool to create Israel by usurping Palestinian land. The Holocaust was and remains a grievous historical crime. Yet it occurred in Europe, not in West Asia. The transformation of the Holocaust into an immediate, existential threat within West Asia was the product of deliberate and malevolent Zionist planning aimed at extracting concessions from Europeans.

When, over time, the Holocaust lost its efficacy as an instrument of securitization, the Zionists employed the label of terrorism to the same end. They constructed Palestinian and Arab terrorism and exploited it for forty years—despite the fact that the establishment of Israel itself was born above all through Zionist terrorism. In the early 1990s, when Israel entered the Oslo process with the Arabs, its leaders initiated a new wave of enemy-construction, this time framing Iran as the existential threat. By the beginning of the twenty-first century, when the Holocaust—after more than sixty years and over two generations—had lost much of its utility for Zionist victimhood politics, imprudent statements served as a pretext for reinvigoration of Iranophobia, from which Israel reaped maximum benefit. As discussed earlier in the book, historical evidence, statements by Israeli leaders, and studies on securitization all confirm that Israel has pursued this objective through a deliberate and malevolent program.

Perhaps it is useful here to restate the two key and seemingly contradictory concepts in Israeli diplomacy: victimhood and invincibility. One of the principal pillars of Israeli leaders' policies in justifying their crimes has been the invocation of the historical victimhood of the Jewish people—which has no intrinsic connection to Zionism, and indeed, the Jewish people may themselves be its greatest victims⁹⁰. The Holocaust, and the alleged possibility of its repetition through renewed Nazi-like atrocities, has become the cornerstone of this propagandistic instrument.

The European mindset—which has regarded itself as the cradle of civilization and global norms, thus compelling others to compensate for European crimes—has provided Israel with a pretext to suppress the Palestinians under the guise of preventing future holocausts. Such a justification is entirely unfounded, for the history of West Asia has always been one of offering refuge to Jews, not of persecuting them.

Israel's second key instrument of both peripheral policy and domestic governance is enemy-construction and the narrative of invincibility. The brutality inflicted upon Palestinian civilians after every operation by resistance groups serves one primary purpose: to preserve and reinforce the myth of Israel's invincibility—a myth that for decades proved highly

⁹⁰ Alan Hart, *Zionism the Real Enemy of the Jews* (2 Volumes), Clarity Press, 2009

effective in Israel's surrounding region and among the Arabs. The victories of Lebanese and Palestinian resistance movements, through Israel's withdrawal from southern Lebanon in 2000 and from Gaza in 2005, dealt a significant blow to this constructed image. Yet Israeli leaders, through extreme violence, have attempted to reconstruct it. One of Israel's most central strategies for sustaining the narrative of invincibility has been the externalization of its wars—fighting beyond Israel's borders—an approach first enshrined by Ben-Gurion, the founding father of the Israeli regime.

Propaganda has been among the most effective tools of Zionism. The global Zionist network has always devoted special attention to media, alongside its deep involvement in banking and financial markets⁹¹. In Zionist global narrative-building, the two seemingly incompatible concepts of victimhood and invincibility have been interwoven under the phrase "Never Again". This synthesis has formed the backbone of Israel's media strategy for the past seventy-five years and has served as a central instrument in justifying its war crimes, crimes against humanity, and acts of genocide against the Palestinian people. Within this construct, the concept of the enemy is indispensable.

The United States, too, constructs and even manufactures enemies. A close examination of the ostensibly scholarly and scientific book *The Clash of Civilizations*⁹², and the timing of its publication⁹³, reveals that after the United States lost its Cold War adversary, American neoconservatives elevated the level of enmity to the civilizational scale. The ideological antagonism of the Cold War was thereby transformed into something even more sweeping and sinister. Through this lens, "Chinese civilization" and "Islamic civilization" were recast as new and even more formidable adversaries than communism or the Soviet Union. By the early 1990s, close observers of American academic and media discourse could already anticipate the shift: the "Red Threat" was being replaced by the "Green Threat"—with Islam supplanting the Soviet Union as the new existential

⁹¹ Alfred Lilienthal, *The Zionist Connection*, Scranton, PA, The Haddon Craftsmen, 1978

⁹² Samuel P. Huntington, *Clash of Civilizations*, New York, Simon and Shuster 1996.

⁹³ It must be noted that immediately after the collapse of the Soviet Union, Huntington presented this new enemy in a speech at the neoconservative "American Enterprise Institute" in 1992, followed by an essay in the *Foreign Affairs Journal* in 1993. The book published in 1996 is the culmination of this theorization process serving a political objective.

danger. In my view, the consequence of this enduring need for an enemy, and of this threat-centered approach to global affairs, has been the securitization of Iran, Shi'ism, and Islam itself. The simplified terms "Iranophobia," "Shiaphobia," and "Islamophobia" do not fully capture the depth of this strategic design of the global hegemonic aspirants.

No constructed discourse is ever devoid of some basis in reality. In the securitization theory of Barry Buzan and his colleagues in the Copenhagen School⁹⁴, one or more external events are employed to anchor and legitimize the process of securitization. Securitization involves complex stages that must be understood. Hence, in my view, reliance upon enmity at the global level is ultimately detrimental to us. Of course, as always, I concede that my perspective may prove mistaken; yet after half a century of research, work, and teaching in the field of international relations, I have consciously chosen to minimize my use of the term "enemy."

Through securitization, threat-construction, and enemy-building, Iran was gradually excluded from the global order, regional linkages, and even from international oil markets. The expulsion of Iranian oil from global markets became acceptable to our traditional buyers, precisely because Iran had been securitized as a threat to global security. Although, following the JCPOA, and with the collapse of the Iran-securitization project, coupled with the valuable efforts of the National Iranian Oil Company (NIOC), Iran managed to export 2.5 million barrels to global markets, when under Trump's pressure we were once again expelled from the world energy market, it had no significant impact. Contrary to those who expected oil prices to soar to \$200 per barrel, prices briefly plummeted to zero. Through enemy-construction, the dominant global powers had already marginalized Iran from regional and international equations.

No country opposes the securitization of Iran or its construction as an enemy. Russian experts themselves publicized the claim of Iranian drones in the Russia–Ukraine war. Thus, Russia has not only shown no objection to portraying Iran as a participant in its war but has even found advantage

⁹⁴ Barry Buzan and Ole Wæver, *Regions and Powers: The Structure of International Security*. Cambridge: Cambridge University Press, 2003.
Barry Buzan, Ole Wæver, & J. Wilde, *Security: A New Framework for Analysis*. Boulder, Colo.: Lynne Rienner Pub, 1998.

in it. Everyone prefers to make others complicit in their crime or even the direct target of retaliation. My own record demonstrates that I have consistently supported close ties with Russia and China and devoted all my efforts toward this end. Yet why did China and Russia, between 2006 and 2012, fail to stand firmly by Iran at the Security Council? Why did they align themselves with numerous anti-Iranian resolutions, statements, and measures? Why did they assist Iran only at the minimal level necessary for its survival? Because both China and Russia preferred that Iran—not themselves—be cast as America's primary threat. They pursued their own interests, fully aware that American leaders had an ongoing need to construct an enemy. Thus, they sought to evade confrontation, allowing others to become the target, in order to minimize harm to themselves. Such is the logic and rationale of governance.

It may be noteworthy that, for months after being ensnared in the securitization trap that led to the war in Ukraine, Russian leaders refrained from employing the word "enemy" in reference to the West. They even continued to refer to Americans as "our American partners." The Chinese, too, have advanced their diplomacy in this same manner.

Because securitization primarily involves speech acts—constructing narratives, it can be de-constructed, neutralized and even reversed using the same modalities. At its heart, the process of turning an issue into a major security threat is about powerful language and public persuasion. Think of it like a politician or a leader making a speech. They don't just describe a problem; they frame it in a way that demands immediate and drastic action. For this to work, the leader must follow a kind of "recipe": they must present the issue as an existential threat (a matter of survival), say it's urgent, and propose a bold solution. They also need enough public trust and authority to be believed.

The reverse process is just as important. This is when a major security issue is moved out of the emergency spotlight and back into the realm of everyday politics and diplomacy. Instead of using alarming language and threats, governments can choose to handle a crisis through practical problem-solving, negotiation, or by turning it into a routine policy matter.

While all countries do not have an equal chance to define what counts as a security threat, and powerful nations like the United States, with their

strong economies and militaries, or Israel with its massive domination of major media outlets have a much greater ability to shape the global conversation and make others accept their definition of a threat, it should not lead to others conceding the ground altogether.

The 2015 Iran nuclear deal (JCPOA) is a perfect example. World powers stopped relying primarily on threats and sanctions and turned to multilateral diplomacy. This shift happened partly because sanctions failed to achieve their intended objective of pushing Iranian people to revolt against government. The high turnout in the 2013 presidential election in Iran revealed that while Iranians preferred change, they were not ready to accept securitizers' demands. Another related issue was that Iran also used persuasion through speech acts focused on problem solving and compromise rather than solely defiant arguments about its right to peaceful nuclear technology. Iran's nuclear diplomacy, culminating in the 2015 JCPOA, enabled a notable process of de-securitization. The agreement fundamentally, if temporarily, reshaped the global landscape—a shift formally endorsed by the UN Security Council in Resolution 2231, which expressed a commitment to forging a new relationship with Iran. The case illustrates that disrupting securitization cycles of conflict is quite possible and must begin with fostering domestic political unity.

Relations with Turkey

Turkey serves as our gateway to Europe and holds a highly strategic position in Iran's economy—particularly in times of sanctions. Among our neighbors, Turkey is valuable in several respects: it produces domestic goods that are useful for us; it depends on our oil and gas; it connects us to Europe; and it plays a key role in re-export and re-import trade. Thus, as a NATO member on our border, as a bridge to Europe, as a country with a degree of industrial production, and as a consumer of our oil and gas, Turkey is of great importance.

A second point is the necessity of a correct understanding and accurate analysis of Turkey's Islamists. They are at once our rivals and our partners. We must study them carefully. If we claim leadership of the Islamic world, then Turkey is our foremost rival. Yet we must also recognize that

Turkey's competition is more intense with Saudi Arabia than with us, because their arena of rivalry is the Sunni world, whereas our influence lies more within the sphere of the Resistance. Before the Syrian war, however, Turkey sought to compete with us even within the geography of the Resistance—whether in Lebanon, Syria, or Iraq. We are absent from Libya, but if we were present there, the competition would certainly extend to that theater as well.

The Turkish Islamists exhibit strong traces of Ottomanism. I first realized this during the Erbakan government, through interactions related to the formation of the “D-8” summit. It seems that deep within their consciousness lies a form of Islamic solidarity culminating in the Ottoman Empire, with Turkey as its core. It appears that, apart from the recent Syrian episode, even Turkey's secularists have not opposed this outlook of the Islamists. In the 1990s, even the West showed no objection to Turkey serving as a model of political Islam; indeed, it seemed to prefer Turkey as an alternative to Iran. Only two to three years after the outbreak of the Syrian war, and Turkey's role in turning a civil movement into a takfiri one, did the West come to realize the dangers of this orientation. Prior to that, Islamism, even of the Erbakan variety, was considered a serious and acceptable alternative to Iran, particularly with figures such as Fethullah Gülen, who openly regards himself as a cultural rival of Iran. In retrospect, following the publication of the original version of this book in Persian, recent developments in Syria and the red-carpet welcome of “wanted” Takfiris in Western capitals confirm the doubts about their dubious origins and sponsors.

Understanding these two aspects is crucial: Turkey is our rival, and also the rival of our rival. Yet at the same time, it is our partner. Properly treated, Turkish Islamism is not necessarily anti-Iranian. In fact, compared with Pan-Turkism—which could emerge as a competitor to Islamism—Islamism is less problematic. Interestingly, in recent years Erdogan, having lost a portion of his electoral base, was compelled to ally himself with the most radical Pan-Turkist party, thereby losing some of his original Islamist base. Pan-Turkist priorities and slogans do not align well with Islamism. Pan-Turkism focuses on the Turkic world, whereas Pan-Islamism concentrates on the Islamic world. This explains why, since Erdogan allied

with Bahçeli, he has gradually lost Islamist and moderate allies. His fierce competition with Kılıçdaroğlu is another sign of his political challenges. Although Erdogan ultimately defeated him in the second round of the 2023 elections, the difficulties facing Erdogan's political future remain.

If our policy is pursued with sufficient subtlety and sophistication, we can always maintain strong ties with Turkey. In Iran, there is considerable effort to portray Turkey as an instrument of Zionism. This is an inaccurate perception. Perhaps Israel would prefer the Islamic world to gravitate toward Turkey rather than Iran; yet, if possible, Israel would certainly prefer it to move toward Saudi Arabia, rather than toward an Erdogan-led Turkey and the AK (Justice and Development) Party.

It is always essential to be mindful of the context in which we are speaking. In certain situations, Turkey could be Iran's partner vis-a-vis Saudi Arabia and the Emirates, which—because of their hostility toward the Muslim Brotherhood—have strong dislike for the present Turkish government. Indeed, it was Iran and Turkey together that managed to save Qatar from the blockade imposed by Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates. Neither Iran, nor Turkey, alone, could have accomplished this; but when we acted in concert, it became possible.

In a meeting I held with Erdogan after the announcement of Qatar's blockade by the above-mentioned four countries, I told him: "We oppose your policies in Syria, and we have come close to confrontation. Yet we are even more opposed to the destruction of Islamic tendencies. We believe that Qatar has come under attack precisely because it supports Islamic movements within the Islamic world. If Qatar is defeated, you will be next." In that meeting, we reached an agreement on trilateral cooperation among Iran, Turkey, and Qatar to rescue Qatar from the blockade and to stand together against the new quadrilateral coalition.

Preaching or "Getting to Yes"

Perhaps it is appropriate here to note an important principle concerning negotiations, inter-state dialogues, and even private-sector commercial negotiations. In a single meeting or negotiation, even in the course of several meetings, it is extremely unlikely to change the other party's

perspective. Negotiation is not preaching in a sermon; it is the pursuit of common ground. Neither side abandons its positions or interests through persuasive preaching. If we imagine that we have changed the other side's mind in one session, it is far more likely that we have been deceived. In negotiation, you cannot alter the other side's convictions. This is a fundamental cognitive challenge in our own intellectual culture: across the political spectrum, we assume that strong logic will suffice to change our interlocutor's views. This is an unrealistic illusion. Put plainly: one may, in the course of a negotiation, deliver a speech to underscore the strength of one's position, but it is highly unlikely to persuade the other party—especially in mid-level talks, where even if an interlocutor is personally convinced, he/she lacks the authority to alter their leaders' views, the entrenched perception of national interests, or his/her country's internal consensus.

Persuasion is the task of public diplomacy, which has its own specific methods and subtleties. One must be able, through the instruments and techniques of public diplomacy, to present one's true interests within the boundaries of the other party's interests, and to craft a narrative for their public accordingly. It is not effective to lecture and preach to the other side that they are unjust or aggressive. Such rhetoric may please domestic audiences, but it has little to no impact on foreign public opinion—the true target of public diplomacy—and may, in fact, prove counterproductive.

In negotiations, even this degree of persuading the other side occurs less frequently. First, because the interlocutors are not expressing their personal opinion, but rather the official stance of their country. Second, they are not the final decision-maker, and even if they were in today's complex world they could not decide alone. One must enter dialogue prepared to listen, and to find a middle ground that serves both our interests and those of the other party. It is exceedingly rare that one side is persuaded in a single exchange or even a series of exchanges to abandon their interests in favor of ours, just because it's fair or because they suddenly recognize that we are on the right side. It is more accurate to say that, at some point in the dialogue, a spark emerges which signals a potential common ground. Those sparks can then be linked together

and evolve into a shared point between the two sides. To achieve this, a negotiator is much better off listening than talking.

From this perspective, one should not assume that, without my meeting with Mr. Erdogan, Turkey would not have assisted in saving Qatar. At best, our dialogue helped identify a basis for cooperation. Otherwise, it is highly unlikely that a short—or even lengthy—conversation could alter the policy of a government or a state. We can cooperate with Erdogan's Turkey to support Islamic tendencies and movements, provided that we remain aware that underneath such cooperation simultaneously lies a fierce competition. If we act through our emotions toward Turkey—whether as competitor or as friend—we will encounter difficulties.

Iran and Turkey possess ample grounds for economic synergy, and these can be harnessed. Cooperation in countering the blockade of Qatar became a platform for trilateral, followed by a five-party, and afterward a broader collaboration with Turkey and Qatar. Following the successful cooperation between Iran and Turkey in breaking the blockade of Qatar, a trilateral meeting of the foreign ministers of the three countries was convened on our initiative. This even extended further, as security officials of the three states were added in joint sessions alongside the foreign ministers. This cooperation later paved the way for a five-party framework in the region, with the participation of Oman and Iraq, which held four meetings quietly and without publicity.

Notably, all four sessions were conducted with great discretion, without any leaks to the outside world. Meetings were deliberately convened outside capital cities and away from the media. In Iran, the session was hosted at an isolated resort outside the busy central part of the Kish island. Through constructive dialogue among the ministers and the diligent work of senior experts, several documents were prepared for political and economic cooperation among the five countries. Unfortunately, due to Iraq's acute political crisis, the fifth session—scheduled to be hosted in Baghdad—was postponed several times and ultimately never took place.

The next step in this cooperation, proposed in Doha to the Emir of Qatar and the foreign ministers of Indonesia and Malaysia, was a summit of leaders from Malaysia, Turkey, Qatar, Iran, Pakistan, and Indonesia, hosted by Dr. Mahathir Mohamad, then Prime Minister of Malaysia.

Although the summit—held concurrently with the Conference of Political and Civic Leaders of the Islamic World in Malaysia—yielded valuable discussions among the leaders of Iran, Qatar, Malaysia, and Turkey on comprehensive cooperation, the heavy pressure exerted by Saudi Arabia compelled Pakistan's prime minister to withdraw, and Indonesia participated only at the foreign ministerial level.

Another effective regional cooperation between Iran and Turkey, coordinated with the central government of Iraq, was the joint defense of Iraq's territorial integrity and foiling of the separatist referendum in Iraqi Kurdistan. That separatist scheme could have plunged the region into unprecedented bloodshed and chaos, while fulfilling decades-old ambitions of Israel. The tripartite meeting of the foreign ministers of Iran, Iraq, and Turkey in September 2017 on the sidelines of the UN General Assembly—alongside effective field coordination among the three states and the decisive measures of the martyred General Soleimani—succeeded in foiling this sinister plan, which would have sacrificed the honorable people of Kurdistan to Zionist and Western plots.

Our cooperation with Turkey was not confined to the region or the Islamic world. During the American campaign to topple the Venezuelan government, Iran and Turkey, acting in coordination, took the lead in preventing the success of the U.S. project and provided significant assistance to the Venezuelan government and people. Beyond practical support, a serious international diplomatic initiative was organized by Iran, Turkey, Russia, Venezuela, and China within the framework of the UN General Assembly, and ultimately at the Non-Aligned Movement summit in Venezuela. Despite not being a NAM member, Turkey participated at a high level. With the accession of more NAM members, the "Group of Friends in Defense of the UN Charter" was established. Joint opposition to U.S. sanctions and interventions in the internal affairs of states formed the core of its declarations and initiatives. Of course, given the heavy costs imposed by the United States on participants in such arrangements, the practical outcomes of such temporary issue-based coalitions often do not go beyond preventing the collapse of the Qatari and Venezuelan governments. Yet even these two achievements had significant implications in neutralizing hegemonic efforts in both the region and the world.

One of the pivotal events during my tenure as foreign minister was the coup attempt in Turkey. Our response required confronting two major challenges: first, Iran could not accept that a government in our region be overthrown through a coup; and second, we had to remain mindful of Iran's many nationals and interests in Turkey. At any given time, thousands of Iranians reside in Turkey, and it serves as a vital source of many of our needs. We could not afford to burn bridges with the Turkish government or with any segment of Turkish society. What ultimately mattered were Iran's national interests, the protection of Iranians, and the safeguarding of our borders. For this reason, the night of the coup was an extremely difficult one. We had to monitor and manage developments moment by moment. I did not sleep for even a minute that night. I spoke by phone five times with Turkey's foreign minister, both to offer support and to stay informed of the situation.

During the night of the coup, we issued two statements. The first expressed respect for the will of the people, which was self-evident. The second was far more explicit. At that initial stage, the coup's success was not out of reach. We assisted President Erdogan in weathering the crisis. We stressed to him the necessity of mobilizing the people, and he acted very effectively and promptly in this regard. His televised address to the public, and the subsequent mass mobilization of people into the streets, marked the turning point in defeating the coup plotters.

In those hours, Erdogan was receiving extremely negative messages from Saudi Arabia and the Emirates. He had evidence that one of Sheikh Mohammed bin Zayed's Palestinian advisors had provided major financial support to the coup plotters. What ultimately convinced the Turks that Saudi Arabia was behind the conspiracy was a message from Mohammed bin Salman to the Emir of Qatar, stating: "After Turkey, it will be your turn." This message was sent before the confrontation between Qatar, and the four countries had even begun. When I later met Erdogan to discuss supporting Qatar, I cited this message as proof that Qatar was part of a broader current in which Turkey itself was also targeted.

Iran sought to assure the Turkish people that their government had not been abandoned by the region and deprived of regional support. After the coup, I was among the first foreign ministers to travel to Ankara, where

I met with Erdogan and other senior Turkish officials, and visited the Turkish Parliament building that had been attacked by coup plotters. That visit was not only a necessity for Iran's official diplomacy but also had a profoundly positive impact on Iran's public diplomacy and the perception of Iran among the Turkish people.

Turkish Strategy in Syria

While recent development following Assad's ouster from Syria—which occurred after publication of the original Persian edition of this book—are astonishing, many of the observations made at the time of publication continue to hold true.

Turkey's policy in Syria will continue to be a victim of a misguided notion of reviving the sphere of influence of the Ottoman Empire. Syria appeared to Ankara as a unique opportunity. It held immense value for Erdogan; it was among the countries to which he drew very close. His ties with Bashar al-Assad, despite their fundamental dissimilarities, were even elevated to close family relations between a very secular and a very religious household.

The sole point of convergence among Assad, King Abdullah, and Erdogan was their shared opposition to the emerging post-Saddam Iraqi state. This issue alone drew three leaders of markedly different—and at times contradictory—orientations into alignment. After the fall of Saddam Hussein in 2003, the Syrians feared meeting the same fate. Saudi Arabia and Turkey, meanwhile, were concerned about Iran's growing influence and the spread of Shi'ism. Thus, the three countries found common ground in a shared anxiety. Syria placed its mosques at Saudi Arabia's disposal—later, Assad himself admitted that those mosques became breeding grounds for extremist militancy. Simultaneously, Damascus built deep economic and social linkages with Turkey, to such an extent that Turkey retained access to the Syrian market throughout the reign of Bashar al-Assad, despite nearly twelve years of war.

At the outset, the unrest in Syria had little religious foundation and was largely driven by civic motivations. Yet Erdogan's Turkey, informed by its own Muslim Brotherhood background, sought to exploit that context,

drawing on the Brotherhood's history in Syria and the suppression of Hama under Hafez al-Assad, to transform the movement into an apparently Islamic one—in retrospect. What Turkey and the Persian Gulf Arabs supported ultimately devolved into an apparently Takfiri movement. The result of the civil war was that Assad was drawn back into the orbit of the Resistance Front, after having distanced itself. While relations between Iran and Assad were strong, Damascus did not support Iran's policies in Iraq, and at times even obstructed their success.

When the anti-Assad movement began in 2011, Turkey believed it could replace a temporary anti-Iraq ally with a permanent partner, or even a client state. Thus, instead of consolidating its considerable political, social, and economic influence in Assad's regime, Ankara pursued the aspiration of hegemonic dominance. While the jury is still out on the eventual inclination the new regime in post Assad Syria, Turkey has for now created a grave security threat for itself. One of the most critical outcomes of Turkey's policy was the empowerment of Syrian Kurds, who maintained close ties with their counterparts in Turkey and with the Kurdistan Workers' Party (PKK). Ankara viewed the YPG and PYD—two armed Kurdish factions in Syria that controlled swaths of territory along Turkey's border—as direct offshoots of the PKK.

The recent drastic developments in Syria following the fall of Bashar al-Assad represent the fluidity of the post-polar international system on the one hand and the imperative of people's backing for the sustainability of governments on the other. While Western countries have given red carpet treatment to those who until recently were placed on their own "most wanted" posters with multi-million rewards on their heads, the future of Turkish investment in Syria is far from certain.

The deadliest mistake of the Assad regime was his refusal to broaden the base of his government after achieving victory in the battlefields. He miscalculated the regional and global dynamics, believing that time was on his side and thereby procrastinating in the talks for constitutional reforms through the Astana Process. Evidently, our suspicions about the West being behind the so-called Takfiri movement as well as behind the scene arrangements between Russia and Turkey—which we suspected to be underway even before Astana Process—were well placed.

Be it as it may, the Jolani—aka Al-Sharaa—regime is committing the same mistake by refusing to allow major segments of Syrian population to have a say about their future. The same procrastination tactics are being applied vis-à-vis the Kurds, the Druze and the Alevites, already providing Israel with an excuse to commit aggression against Syria. Let us hope that the Turkish government would prudently advise its proteges in Damascus, and also hope that they will be better listeners than the Assad regime was.

Another matter requiring serious attention, and corresponding policy recalibration, is the potential pivot of Turkey—and Erdogan personally—from Ottomanist policies, which primarily targeted the Islamic world, toward the so-called “Century of Turkey” strategy, which emphasizes Central Asia, the Caucasus, and the concept of “Blue Turkey.” Given the humiliating status imposed upon Turkey after the First World War, whereby islands in the Mediterranean situated only a short distance from its coasts were ceded to Greece, maritime issues have acquired special importance among Turkish elites. Such a strategic reorientation could create a new dynamic in Iran-Turkey relations, particularly in the Caucasus.

The appropriate response to this tendency is to consciously and astutely expand multilateral cooperation and to participate in all regional transit initiatives. It must be acknowledged that no country can veto such projects through non-participation or military threats—most of which lack operational feasibility and are rarely in the interest of any people. Instead, through active and effective engagement, Iran must secure its interests while accounting for those of others, ensuring positive-sum outcomes. One must recognize that if we do not sit at the negotiating table with our neighbors, we will inevitably become the subject on the table—whether in the Caucasus, the Persian Gulf, Syria, Iraq, or Afghanistan.

Caspian Sea Legal Status

The legal status of the Caspian Sea is a longstanding and complex case. In 1995, following the collapse of the Soviet Union and the emergence of new republics, by decree of Foreign Minister Velayati, the first meeting of the legal directors of the Caspian littoral states was convened in Tehran, chaired by me in my capacity as the Deputy Foreign Minister for Legal and

International Affairs. That session produced the first joint communiqué of the Caspian littoral states. Yet shortly thereafter, the regional deputy of the Ministry convened a meeting of Iranian ambassadors to the four Caspian states to discuss the legal status in bilateral contexts. I immediately wrote to Dr. Velayati, stressing that this file was already sufficiently complex at the international level and should not be further burdened with internal complications. I therefore requested that the locus of deliberation and negotiation on the Caspian legal status be transferred to the regional deputy's purview, which indeed happened.

In the early days after the Soviet break-up, Iran and Russia held a common position: the Caspian Sea was to remain a condominium. Both countries invoked the treaties of 1921 and 1940 between Iran and the former Soviet Union, which referred to the Caspian as the "Sea of Iran and the Soviet Union." On this basis, Iran and Russia jointly registered a document at the United Nations affirming that the Caspian was to remain indivisible, with a *sui generis* legal status derived from the 1921 and 1940 treaties. Given that the waters adjacent to the Iranian coast are of great depth and that exploitation of seabed resources in those areas is technically arduous, Iran had a significant interest in maintaining joint ownership of the seabed's resources.

The assumption underlying the condominium thesis was that Russia would stand by this principle alongside Iran. The three smaller states, heavily dependent on Moscow, would then be compelled to accept the Russo-Iranian position. In reality, however, Soviet-era practice had drawn an imaginary line from the land border at Astara in the west to Husseingoli in the east, effectively limiting Iran to the waters south of this imaginary boundary, while the northern waters were apportioned among the Soviet republics.

These internal Soviet divisions, aside from certain disputes between Azerbaijan and Turkmenistan, had become entrenched. The claim was made that Iran had never conducted any maritime activity north of the Astara–Husseingoli line. At the time, only the Soviet Union possessed the technical capacity to exploit the Caspian's seabed hydrocarbons, and it was indeed active in doing so. Although disputes over the "Northern Oil" issue had persisted since the Second World War, Iran, with its abundant southern resources and the prohibitive costs and technologies required

for Caspian exploration, had not engaged seriously in developing Caspian oil and gas prior to the Revolution.

While multilateral negotiations on the Caspian legal status were underway and Iran continued to insist on the condominium principle in alignment with Russia, Moscow, without Iran's knowledge or agreement, concluded bilateral arrangements with Kazakhstan, and later with Azerbaijan and Turkmenistan, on the basis of the very Soviet-era lines it had previously dismissed. Under these accords, exclusive zones for seabed exploitation were apportioned, giving Russia and Kazakhstan together 49 percent of the seabed. Their southern boundaries with Azerbaijan and Turkmenistan were also settled on Soviet-era lines, leaving 51 percent to be divided among Iran, Azerbaijan, and Turkmenistan. Although Ashgabat and Baku remained at odds over their median line, both assumed that Iran would receive only 11 to 13 percent of the seabed, while 38 percent would be shared between them. Exploration and drilling were launched on that basis.

Iran, confronted with a *fait accompli*, objected and even took military measures. When Azerbaijan began drilling in what it assumed to be its sector, Iranian fighter jets flew over the area, prompting the foreign contractor to withdraw.

Iran still clung to the condominium thesis. Yet the *de facto* division of 49 percent between Russia and Kazakhstan—roughly 20 percent for Russia and nearly 30 percent for Kazakhstan, owing to the sea's indentation into Kazakh territory—was consolidated and operationalized. Thereafter, Iran informally set aside the condominium principle and focused on claiming a 20 percent share of the Caspian. Given the sea's configuration, however, Iran's claimed 20 percent extended into areas close to the Azerbaijani and Turkmen coasts. This necessitated recourse to equitable principles of maritime delimitation that would be defensible internationally yet supportive of Iran's position. Concepts such as equity were therefore emphasized, as Iran's concave and relatively smooth coastline disadvantaged it under conventional methods of delimitation.

Nevertheless, the core issue of the Caspian legal status—the exploitation of seabed resources—progressed contrary to Iran's national interests. Iran's perception was shaped by misplaced optimism toward Russia on the one

hand, and by the notion that unless Tehran consented to a multilateral outcome, such an outcome could not materialize.

As noted earlier, this mindset reflects a structural flaw. The same fallacy is evident today with respect to the Financial Action Task Force (FATF). We tend to believe that signing an agreement leaves us with no choice, while withholding signature renders us free of all obligations. Yet many rules and norms take shape without our signature or participation. Even if we reject conventions or commitments, global public and private actors will not treat our position differently. Moreover, such norms emerge without our input, whereas active participation might allow us to insert safeguards, reflect our concerns in the text, or impose legal constraints on the application of such norms.

This cognitive flaw—an extreme oscillation between cynicism (“the law of the jungle prevails, international law is nothing”) and naïveté (“if we do not sign, nothing will be binding; if we do, it is unbreakable”)—remains deeply ingrained in Iran’s political and intellectual elite. It reflects a purely textualist approach to international law that is, paradoxically, both rigid and untenable.

There is another fundamental malady: the pursuit of individual comfort, making officials overcautious and risk-averse in the extreme and finding all sorts of excuses to justify their omissions. An unwritten dictation has no mistakes. Most of us in positions of responsibility act upon this principle. No one has ever been held accountable for the costs of omissions: refraining from action or withholding a signature. Simultaneously, we erroneously believe that unless we sign, nothing will happen. On the other hand, every agreement entails both concessions and gains, and our officials are unwilling to accept the reality that in exchange for a set of advantages, one must also make certain commitments. Thus, we refrain from agreeing, refrain from signing, and in doing so, absolve ourselves from accountability and shield ourselves from the barrage of accusations and slanders that inevitably follow any agreement. This is, in truth, the pursuit of comfort.

Yet after nearly four decades of withstanding all forms of accusations and insults from every political faction—ranging from charges of illiteracy and ignorance of the text, to naïveté, appeasement, treachery, and so-called

“pleading diplomacy”—I can now understand why patriotic, yet prudent individuals in our country tend to simply repeat positions endlessly and shy away from entering into binding agreements. It is unfortunate, however, that this approach has now become institutionalized within our system.

Within such an environment, the division of the Caspian seabed between Iran, Turkmenistan, and Azerbaijan has turned into an incurable dispute—one which the current comprehensive convention does not address. It should be recalled that in the very first meeting of the legal directors of the five littoral states in 1995, it had been agreed that the comprehensive convention would also encompass the issue of seabed resources. However, since the four former Soviet republics had already carried out the division of the seabed among themselves without Iran’s participation or consent—and since the issue between Russia and Kazakhstan had been fully resolved through that arrangement—it was ultimately decided that the disputes between the remaining three states would have to be addressed through bilateral and multilateral negotiations outside the framework of the comprehensive Caspian convention.

Accordingly, from the late 1990s onward, the negotiations for the comprehensive legal convention of the Caspian were focused on other key issues: the delineation of national and shared jurisdictions; the method of dividing the water surface; baselines; internal waters, territorial waters, and exclusive fishing zones; fishing regulations and aquatic resources; navigation; environmental concerns; and the prohibition of foreign military presence in the Caspian Sea. These issues required precise legal deliberations that spanned nearly two decades, resulting in a series of texts, some of which had reached the stage of partial agreement.

When I assumed office as Minister of Foreign Affairs in August 2013, I once again encountered the challenge of the Caspian legal status after nearly eighteen years. Iran had already appointed special representatives on the matter, who had been conducting negotiations with their counterparts from the other four littoral states and had prepared a number of texts. The convention had progressed considerably. However, there remained one serious obstacle: within the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, there was no genuine will or determination to finalize the convention. As mentioned

earlier, colleagues—quite rightly—were concerned that once the convention was finalized, they would come under severe domestic pressure.

When I entered the first meeting of the foreign ministers of the Caspian littoral states as the new minister, the first anomaly that struck me was the fact that Iran appeared as a stranger in the negotiations. It had been decided that the negotiations would proceed in Russian and Persian. The natural outcome of this arrangement, given that the other four states were Russian speaking, was that the main bulk of the discussions was conducted in Russian, while the Iranian delegation remained oblivious to much of what was being said. At that first meeting of the Caspian foreign ministers, I was compelled to interrupt the session sharply. In any international meeting, when a delegate speaks, he must turn on the microphone so that the interpreter seated in the adjacent booth can hear and translate his words. Even assuming that an interpreter could convey the meaning accurately (which in practice is rarely the case), it is commonly acknowledged that at least thirty percent of the content is lost in translation. If the subject matter is legal, it is virtually impossible to convey the speaker's precise intent and the subtleties of legal argument through translation.

In the Caspian negotiations, it became clear to me that Iran was not genuinely part of the discussion. Whenever the talks reached contentious issues, the four other ministers would converse heatedly among themselves in Russian without switching on their microphones. Our interpreter, listening through the headset, would remark that he could hear nothing—since only one microphone was active at a time. One participant would say something, another would interject in Russian, and so forth. It had clearly become a habit.

At one point, I pressed my microphone and, in English, asked: "Do you wish me to leave the room?" Lavrov, taken aback, asked, "Why?" I replied: "Because you are speaking amongst yourselves while the Iranian delegation is seated here. There is no opportunity for translation to reach us. What kind of conduct is this?"

After that exchange, they were somewhat more cautious, though the general pattern remained largely unchanged. The negotiations revolved around the details of the text. The Russian draft was projected on the

monitor, scrolling up and down continually. Our Persian interpreter could only update the Persian version once every five iterations of the Russian text. This meant that the others were working on the fine points of the Russian draft while we were left unable to follow the details. Consequently, after each session our translators had to carefully render the final draft into Persian so that we could formulate our comments. This cumbersome method made defending our national interests extremely difficult, especially since the other four states would insist that agreements had already been reached. We persevered, nonetheless.

The decision to conduct negotiations in Persian carried an outwardly appealing and patriotic appearance. In reality, however, it served more as a cover for the inability to communicate in foreign languages. This populist approach gave rise to complex professional challenges. Revolutionary zeal, nationalist sentiment, and the defense of the Persian language became mere pretexts for delivering fiery, yet futile and ineffective, speeches in Persian—rhetoric that had no tangible impact on the actual course of negotiations.

Had I been responsible from the very outset of the Caspian negotiations, I would have insisted—without hesitation—that the talks be conducted in a common language, namely English. It should be noted that, at the conclusion of the negotiations on the comprehensive convention, after agreement had been reached on the Russian and Persian drafts, a full year of fruitless effort was spent attempting to reconcile the two versions. In the end, however, we were compelled to settle upon a single English text as the authoritative reference, with each side subsequently revising its own translation against it.

In the negotiations over the JCPOA as well, one of the criticisms leveled against us was: why do you negotiate in English? They insisted that we should speak in Persian and have our words translated. Later, with a populist flourish, they even declared: “Even the Treaty of Turkmenchay had a Persian text, but the JCPOA did not.” Yet no one asked: “Did Resolution 598 have a Persian text?” It did not. Resolution 598 existed in Arabic—the language of the other party and one of the six official languages of the United Nations—but not in Persian. Nor should it have. Why then should the JCPOA have been treated differently? Unlike Resolution 598, the JCPOA

was negotiated solely in English, with no translations prepared even into the UN's official languages. Yet, alas, demagoguery spares no occasion.

My consistent approach has always been to act in accordance with what I judged to be in the national interest. For this very reason, in 2015 I was named the "World's Risk taker of the Year."⁹⁵ The negotiations on the Caspian legal status continued for three years during my tenure. In those arduous three years, we concluded the talks through the most intense bargaining possible, guided by the directives of the Supreme National Security Council, and with the indispensable expertise of our finest jurists—above all, Professor Jamshid Momtaz, a distinguished legal scholar of our country and arguably the world's foremost authority on the law of the sea. With immense effort, we succeeded in incorporating our essential positions into the final text. Of course, some adjustments in our favor had already been achieved by previous negotiators, whose efforts must also be duly acknowledged.

One of the most critical issues for our legal experts was that, in our view, the United Nations Convention on the Law of the Sea (UNCLOS 1982) was neither legally applicable to the Caspian nor favorable to Iran. By contrast, the other four states were both members of the convention and beneficiaries of its provisions, and thus they insisted upon applying it. One of our key accomplishments was to demonstrate that the principal provisions of UNCLOS were not incorporated into the Caspian convention, and therefore the convention could not be applied to the Caspian. Under UNCLOS, the breadth of territorial waters is set at 12 nautical miles, with an Exclusive Economic Zone extending 200 nautical miles. In the Caspian negotiations, the four other states pressed to adopt the 12-mile standard. Through determined effort, however, we succeeded in establishing territorial waters of 15 miles and an exclusive fishing zone of 10 miles in the Caspian. This distinction proved that the foundation of the Caspian convention was not UNCLOS. Indeed, these two provisions are among the most important achievements.

Another major obstacle to finalizing the convention was the dispute over submarine gas pipelines. Iran and Russia opposed the laying of pipelines

⁹⁵ <https://globalriskinsights.com/2015/12/gri-person-of-the-year-in-political-risk>

along the Caspian seabed, citing strategic, economic, and environmental reasons. Yet in the later stages of negotiations, we discovered that Russia had once again struck an understanding with the three other states, abandoning its opposition. Previously, both Iran and Russia had insisted that any such project required the unanimous consent of all five littoral states—thus giving us veto power. But once again Russia reached a separate arrangement, leaving us isolated. Faced with this unfavorable situation, we proposed—with Russia's support—a new formula to ensure environmental safeguards. A protocol was to be appended to the environmental convention, establishing strict standards such that any future pipeline would have to conform to them. Achieving consensus on this matter required protracted and difficult negotiations.

NIOC had always opposed the transit of Turkmenistan's gas through Iranian territory. This opposition rested on two premises. First, NIOC was convinced that constructing a pipeline along the Caspian seabed was neither technically nor financially feasible and would therefore never materialize. Second, based on the flawed assumption that Iran's veto power through non-participation would forever block alternative routes, NIOC refused to permit Turkmenistan to transport gas across Iranian soil, fearing that such an arrangement would create a gas competitor for us at the Turkish border. Yet, as so often happens, Turkmenistan both found alternative routes and reached understandings with Russia to pursue a trans-Caspian pipeline. Advances in technology rendered what had once seemed impossible, feasible. While the trans-Caspian pipeline has not yet been built, Turkmenistan has succeeded through other means in delivering its gas to Turkey and Europe.

Perhaps the most critical dossier of all concerned the delineation of baselines. This issue was the subject of intense disputes—both in principle and, toward the end, over the harmonization of the Persian and Russian texts describing the applicable method. Ultimately, we reached agreement on one or two words in English. Baselines are drawn using either the “normal” or “straight” method. A normal baseline follows the coastline, accounting for the natural state of the shore at low tide. Where the coastline is deeply indented, straight baselines may be drawn by connecting the points of protrusion, enclosing the intervening waters as

internal. Beyond the baseline, territorial waters commence—now defined at 15 miles in the Caspian convention.

In Iran's case, two realities stood against us: our coast is deeply concave and lacks significant indentations. Thus, under the definitions of the other four states, Iran's baseline was to be considered a normal line. This would have left Iran with virtually no internal waters, a grave disadvantage both in terms of surface rights and in future negotiations over the seabed with our neighbors. The other four states, drawing from Soviet-era divisions, had already defined their baselines and assumed Iran's would be normal. We were compelled to insist on a different treatment. This dispute persisted until the final days.

In the closing stages, a ministerial meeting was convened in Moscow—restricted to the five foreign ministers, conducted in English—to resolve the baseline issue. Turkmenistan strongly opposed Iran's position. Following our forceful intervention, Lavrov, with his usual cunning, interjected: "Javad, this is not television for you to speak in such a manner. This is a private negotiation." His intent was to defuse the atmosphere, though he failed.

In the end, under our pressure and with Russian mediation, a clause was added requiring that, in drawing baselines, the special circumstances of states disadvantaged by the natural shape of their coasts be taken into account. It was agreed that a special committee of experts from the five states would determine the baselines by consensus after the signing of the convention. We, in turn, declared that until Iran's baseline was duly agreed upon, we would not submit the convention to our parliament for ratification. By doing so, we ensured, on the one hand, that the other four states could not bypass us and reach an agreement among themselves, and on the other, that Iran's special coastal conditions were formally recognized as a necessary consideration. This was the best formula our negotiating team could devise. Of course, every agreement entails unpleasant consequences for those who sign it. Nevertheless, both President Rouhani and I accepted these personal costs in the service of the national interest.

In 2015, simultaneously with the final stages of the JCPOA negotiations, the Caspian talks also approached their conclusion. President Putin

insisted that the Convention be finalized and signed without delay, with successive meetings being held. Russia, with justification, asserted that it was concerned about Kazakhstan and Azerbaijan's military agreements with the United States and sought to block foreign presence in the Caspian through the adoption of the Convention. Eventually, we managed to untie the knot concerning Iran's baseline. However, only the general framework was included in the comprehensive Convention, while the specific demarcation—namely agreement on the geographical coordinates of the baseline—remains Iran's principal concern. Therefore, at the presidential and ministerial levels, we emphasized that until the baseline is definitively determined, the Convention would not be submitted to Parliament for ratification. It was reiterated to the foreign ministers that, should we submit the Convention before finalizing acceptable and precise coordinates of the baseline, Parliament would not ratify it, given the qualified majority required for territorial agreements. For Iran, the exact delineation of the baseline is crucial, as Iran's share of the internal waters must be commensurate with that of the others. Kazakhstan has claimed 3 percent of the sea as internal waters, Russia close to 2 percent, and Azerbaijan and Turkmenistan between 1 and 1.2 percent.

Once all matters had been agreed upon, one of our esteemed academic colleagues and Russia experts—concerned about my political standing and reputation at home—warned me of the possible domestic repercussions of signing any agreement. Within our delegation we had distinguished jurists and diplomats. In an informal meeting, I asked them: "Can we obtain a better agreement than this?" All replied: "No; this text is the best achievable outcome." I assessed that if we refrained from finalizing the agreement, the post-Soviet states would, just as they had unilaterally divided the seabed, once again reach their own arrangements on the sea and other matters, confronting us with another *fait accompli*. No legal forum exists to contest that. Even if, hypothetically, such a tribunal could be found, no legal grounds exist upon which an international court could rule in our favor against the consensus of four littoral states, especially considering the precedents in international law and the UN Convention on the Law of the Sea—which many jurists consider embodying customary international law. Moreover, from the perspective of experts, this Convention represented

the optimal outcome achievable. Our principal concerns regarding the Caspian were duly incorporated. Furthermore, the Convention did not address division of seabed resources. The notion of common ownership of the seabed had already been abandoned. Those who claim that 50 percent of the Caspian belongs to Iran have never provided a single valid legal or historical corroboration for such an assertion.

When the agreement was finalized and ready for signature at the summit level, unprecedented uproar erupted. On one side were monarchists and opposition groups. At the same time, populist rumors were spread regarding the Persian Gulf, alleging that the Chinese had seized its fisheries and even taken over Kish Island. A storm of propaganda was unleashed, claiming that the Caspian had been ceded to Russia and the Persian Gulf to China, under the slogan: "The land of Iran has been surrendered." Parallel to these, domestic hardliners also attacked us, and deputies from the Caspian provinces created a highly charged atmosphere.

Amidst this uproar, some academics criticized us, arguing that negotiations should not have been conducted during a period of weakness. In reality, we concluded the Convention at the height of our strength—just as the JCPOA had been finalized. It is true that by the time the Persian and Russian texts were harmonized and endorsed, we had entered the bitter era of Trump. However, the Convention itself was finalized in both Persian and Russian during the Obama administration, almost simultaneously with the JCPOA, and only the harmonization of the two texts remained. This process took more than a year. Consequently, the signing of the Convention coincided with Trump's maximum pressure campaign. The Caspian Convention became a matter of public debate when the President signed it in Aktau, Kazakhstan. It was then that criticisms and attacks began, among them the charge that negotiations had been conducted during weakness.

Following the Aktau summit, intense domestic pressure ensued. I was summoned to Parliament on several occasions. I also participated in the popular television program "Hala Khorshid," in what became a controversial appearance. To counter the media storm, colleagues advised me to explain the details directly to the people. After consultations, all agreed that "Hala Khorshid" was the most widely viewed program on

national television; appearing there, rather than in evening programs, could neutralize the media onslaught surrounding the Convention. The program proved extremely challenging and confrontational; nevertheless, its producers were furious, accusing the anchor of being soft on me. During the live broadcast, he asked provocative questions: “How much did you sell the Caspian for? How much the Persian Gulf? Why is it that Malaysia and Turkey have no problems with the world, but you do?” Such questions, if directed at any other official, would surely have led to the host’s being banned from television. Yet with composure, I provided detailed and reasoned responses. Nevertheless, the program gave rise to a noisy campaign centered on my phrase “We ourselves chose,” to which I alluded briefly at the beginning of this book.

Beyond the earlier discussions of complacency and unrealistic viewpoints, a fundamental challenge concerning the Caspian is that our four principal neighbors are all littoral states. Of these, we share both land and sea borders with two, while with Russia and Kazakhstan we share only maritime boundaries. A policy of neighborliness cannot be predicated upon endless and unnecessary quarrels. Such an approach would harm all Caspian littoral states and would inevitably invite foreign presence in the Caspian, posing a security threat particularly for Iran and Russia. Should the Caspian become an arena where littoral states resort to foreign navies under any pretext to secure their interests, Iran would be the foremost loser. Under the comprehensive Convention, only ships of the littoral states are permitted in the Caspian. Moreover, littoral states are prohibited from joining military alliances against one another—one of the most crucial provisions of this Convention.

The legal status of the Caspian is not merely a matter of dividing maritime shares. It is a comprehensive and complex dossier, encompassing numerous concerns and variables. Yet much of the public discourse on the Caspian legal status is based on delusion—such as the false claim that Iran’s share was once 50 percent. If Iran were to hold sovereignty over half of the Caspian, this would mean that the coastlines of Turkmenistan and Azerbaijan would lie within Iranian territorial waters—an absurd proposition no tribunal or rational mind would accept. Moreover, such conditions have never existed. Had Iran, after the 1921 and 1940 treaties

with the Soviet Union, exercised or even claimed sovereignty over half of the Caspian, perhaps such an argument could be advanced today. But Iran has never held such a position. The domestic uproar and the propaganda of opposition media—particularly the monarchists—claiming that the late Shah personally stood up to Russia in such matters, or struck one official and slapped another, are nothing but fabricated myths. Anyone with even a basic knowledge of history knows these are baseless claims. One simple case illustrates the fallacious nature of these demagogueries: the Soviet Union exploited oil and gas fields off the coast of Baku for decades. Had Iran owned half of Caspian, the Shah's government should have taken their share, or at the very least, launched formal complaints. There is no record of either. Domestic demagoguery at the expense of national interest. Period.

Relations with the Caucasus

Iran shares borders with two countries in the Caucasus, Armenia and Azerbaijan. Under the Rouhani Administration, relations with both were simultaneously good and complex. In the final year of my tenure as Foreign Minister, the Karabakh conflict, after thirty years, erupted again into military confrontation. This war, in terms of its nature, technology, number of actors, and final outcome, is a case worthy of in-depth study.

From various perspectives, especially historically, the Caucasus is extremely significant for Iran. The region was once part of Iran, and major cities—from Tbilisi and Yerevan to Baku and Ganja—remain embedded in our historical memory. Many Iranian family surnames derive from cities in the Caucasus. While these families are now in Iran, their ancestral roots originate from regions that were once Iranian territory. Therefore, historically and through personal and ideational attachments, the Caucasus is a key region for Iran. Several ethno-linguistic and religious groups in Iran share historical connections with all three countries in the Caucasus. Even Iranians of Georgian descent still reside in Iran, though their presence is less widely recognized. Most Iranians of Georgian ancestry live in the Fereidan area of Isfahan province. Iranian Armenian presence in Iran is extensive and well-known; two members of the Iranian Parliament are

Armenian. Iranian Azeris constitute a large portion of the population throughout the country. All of these groups consider themselves fully Iranian, yet they share linguistic, religious, and ethnic affinities with the peoples of the Caucasus.

A third factor influencing Iran's ties to the Caucasus is the history of these relations following the independence of these countries from the Soviet Union. From Iran's perspective, this history has presented challenges, many of which originated from Turkey. Under the Rouhani Administration, these concerns were managed, and thus, in few periods since the Revolution have Iran's ties with Turkey been as steady as during the Rouhani administrations. Prior to the Revolution, Iran's relations with Turkey and Pakistan were extensive and strategic, with the Regional Cooperation for Development (RCD) playing a key role in these ties. After the Revolution, the same organization became a source of contention, as it had been composed of former Central Treaty Organization (CENTO) members, leading some to perceive a tripartite relationship among Iran, Turkey, and Pakistan as colonial and illegitimate. Nevertheless, cooperation between Iran, Turkey, and Pakistan—as neighboring, non-Arab, key countries of the Islamic world with complementary economies—is inherently valuable and legitimate.

This tripartite cooperation remained outside the core of policymaking until the Rouhani administration and was sometimes seen as undesirable. In certain international fora, we diverged with Turkey and Pakistan on issues such as Cyprus and Kashmir. These two countries were consistently aligned, whereas we maintained a different stance. From an external perspective, the divergence might not have seemed significant, but for those working within the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, particularly in the multilateral department, the difference was clear. I believe that the historical misstep was our assumption that a counterbalance against Turkey was necessary in managing relations.

In regional cooperation concerning the Caucasus and Central Asia, the Economic Cooperation Organization (ECO) is highly significant. Its capacity for Iran is particularly crucial, given that its headquarters are in Tehran. From the outset, Iran, Turkey, and Pakistan, as founding members, decided that ECO would be an economic organization with no political or

security orientation—likely due to early post-Revolution concerns about the revival of the RCD. To this day, ECO remains primarily an economic approach, and measures have been taken to prevent its politicization. These concerns were likely shared heavily by Turkey as well.

During the Rouhani administration, we managed to overcome the shadow of RCD on the tripartite relations and dismantle many unfounded “red lines.” Perhaps for the first time since the Revolution, we were able to hold a meeting among the Chiefs of Staff of Iran and Turkey. Likewise, the first opportunities for Iran, Pakistan, and Turkey to cooperate—particularly in security, military, and political domains—emerged during this administration. The Iranian Armed Forces played a major role in facilitating these ties, with martyr Major General Mohammad Bagheri, Chief of Staff, spearheading engagement with Turkish military commanders.

The Astana process was also influential. At the Astana summits, the Chiefs of Staff of Iran, Turkey, and Russia were present, bringing us to de-taboo military cooperation with Turkey. This does not imply that we overlooked Turkey’s misguided policies in the region, but rather that the determining factor in our ties with Turkey and the Caucasus has been shared interests, not the missteps of others.

Another important factor was the imprudent actions of some Azerbaijani leaders at the country’s inception. Pan-Turkic tendencies were particularly strong, and Abulfaz Elchibey steered Azerbaijan’s policy toward hostility with Iran. However, with the election of Heydar Aliyev, Azerbaijani leaders understood, in his words, that “if the hand is severed from the body, one does not attach the body to the hand but rather attaches the hand to the body.” The Caucasus—including Azerbaijan—separated from Iran, not the reverse. This understanding led to a relative improvement in relations. Nonetheless, the negative perception formed during the Elchibey era in Iran persisted, reinforced by certain separatist elements within Azerbaijan.

During the first Nagorno-Karabakh war (1992–1994), Iran provided substantial assistance to Azerbaijan. At that time, Azerbaijan was internally weak and suffered a severe defeat from Armenia. In addition to Nagorno-Karabakh, nearly 20 percent of Azerbaijani territory was occupied. Several Iranians also lost their lives in this conflict. Iran prepared extensively to

host Azerbaijani refugees along its border regions. However, Iran did not engage directly against Armenia.

Regrettably, the Azerbaijani leadership did not appropriately acknowledge Iran's balanced and even supportive policy. After Azerbaijan's defeat in the war, Iranian mediation for a ceasefire and peace in Nagorno-Karabakh were largely ignored, and they turned to the Organization for Security and Cooperation in Europe (OSCE), the Minsk Group, and other actors. At that time, Turkey offered little assistance to Azerbaijan, as its policy was more oriented toward Europe and the West, unlike Erdogan's later "regional-focused" approach. Azerbaijan, taking Iranian support for granted, sought to strengthen its international position through the Minsk Group and Israel, which created a rift in Iran-Azerbaijan relations.

Before the Rouhani Administration, relations between Iran and Azerbaijan were very cold. At the start of our administration, during the World Economic Forum in Davos in winter 2013, there was a productive meeting between Presidents Rouhani and Ilham Aliyev. The Foreign Ministry's view was that relations with Turkey and Azerbaijan, as two key neighbors, should be extensive, and relations should not be built on hostility; otherwise, Iran's relative advantage would be lost. Fortunately, over the following eight years, Iran-Azerbaijan relations became very close. During President Rouhani's visit to Azerbaijan, agreements were reached on the North–South corridor, Azerbaijan's participation in the Rasht–Astara railway, joint exploitation of Caspian Sea resources, and numerous other cooperative projects.

Under the Khatami administration, Azerbaijan attempted unilateral exploration of oil and gas in the Alborz field (known as "Alu" in Azerbaijan). To prevent this, Iran even conducted fighter jet flights over the platform established by a British contractor, bringing the situation close to conflict. However, during our administration, we reached an agreement to exploit the Alborz and Alvand fields jointly—a key achievement. Had sanctions not returned during the Trump administration, exploration and production in a field estimated to contain 40 billion barrels of oil and gas might have already begun.

All our agreements were stalled during Trump's four-year term. Among these was the Rasht–Astara railway project, in which Azerbaijan had

committed to invest \$500 million for completion. Additionally, discussions between Iran, Russia, and Azerbaijan on energy transit were underway. We decided to connect the South–North corridor—from the Persian Gulf and Oman Sea ports to northern Russia and from there to Europe via rail. All of these initiatives fundamentally strengthened Iran–Azerbaijan relations. Simultaneously, close and friendly ties with Armenia remained stable and even expanded.

Regrettably, after the end of the Rouhani Administration, Iran–Azerbaijan relations have gradually reverted toward the pre-Rouhani era. I believe the main reason for Azerbaijan’s bold stance is the “re-securitization” of Iran. When a country becomes increasingly securitized, the cost of confronting it decreases, allowing even a minor actor to behave aggressively. Why did Azerbaijan not speak in such terms during our administration? Because the JCPOA had disrupted the security consensus against Iran.

Even after the second Nagorno–Karabakh war, Azerbaijan had no objections to Iran’s involvement in Caucasus peace efforts. Iran had become an influential regional and global actor, which they recognized. When we proposed a “three plus three” framework or Iranian presence in a joint Russian–Turkish operations room in Azerbaijan, Azerbaijani leaders did not oppose it, unlike Russia.

The stronger the global security consensus against Iran, the more actors concerned with Iran attempt to challenge us. Why does the Taliban confront Iran today? Could Azerbaijan have spoken to Iran in 2015–2016 with the same tone? We aim to counter global security consensus against ourselves through military force, exercises, and similar measures—but such actions play into the adversary’s hands and strengthen the securitization of Iran. Azerbaijan, facing political conflicts with Europe, particularly France, during the Karabakh war, exploited military activity on its border and the attack on its embassy in Tehran to mitigate some of its challenges with Europe at our expense.

Iran’s relations with Armenia have always been positive, with no major difficulties, and have expanded over time. In contrast, relations with Georgia remain distant. After independence, particularly during the Saakashvili administration, Georgia aligned almost entirely with the West,

which caused significant disadvantages. When Georgia needed support, the West did not provide it. During Russia's interventions in Abkhazia and South Ossetia, Western powers only applied pressure on Russia in line with unrelated Western objectives, but no real assistance was given to Georgia. Today, Georgia is fully under Western influence. Consequently, aside from a brief period during the JCPOA when Georgia attempted to attract Iranian private sector investment, our relations with Georgia have consistently faced challenges stemming from Georgia's Western alignment.

During my tenure as minister, the most significant event in the Caucasus region was the 2020 conflict, which resulted in the return of Nagorno-Karabakh to Azerbaijan and the liberation of Azerbaijani occupied territories. Armenia had humiliated Azerbaijan for nearly 25 years. During this period, Iran repeatedly warned Armenian leaders not to continue the misguided path that began with seizing Azerbaijani lands. Holding onto the lands of others is never a source of strength.

During my visit to Armenia after the 2020 conflict and Armenia's humiliating defeat, Armenian officials admitted that when they had the opportunity to reach a better agreement, they acted with arrogance and did not even engage in serious negotiations. Our efforts, and those of others, had limited effect.

The Azerbaijani military response, after nearly thirty years of humiliation and preparation to reclaim its territories, utilized all domestic and external capabilities. Azerbaijan is a very wealthy country, while Armenia is relatively poor. Azerbaijan leveraged all its resources, amassing considerable capabilities. Direct Turkish involvement and indirect Israeli support were also critical. From the outset, it was evident that if Russia did not intervene directly, Azerbaijan could advance as far as it wished. Two months before the outbreak, political analysts in the Eurasia and Caucasus section of the Foreign Ministry anticipated that Azerbaijan's offensive and Armenia's imminent defeat were forthcoming.

Possibly due to Prime Minister Pashinyan's consistent Western orientation and his efforts to confront pro-Moscow elements within Armenia, Russia chose not to intervene in this war. Analysts also note that Putin's personal relations with Ilham Aliyev, as with Erdogan, likely

played a role. Strategically, Russia may have decided that Azerbaijan offered greater prospects than Armenia given its growing capabilities.

In any case, Russia only initiated its mediation once all of Azerbaijan's occupied territories had been reclaimed, Armenia's territorial integrity was at risk, and had the war continued for a few more days, the Armenian government could have collapsed. At that point, Russia intervened and ended the war decisively through heavy-handed diplomacy in Moscow.

The Islamic Republic of Iran sent Deputy Foreign Minister Araqchi as the special representative of the president to present Iran's proposal to Azerbaijan, Armenia, Russia, and Turkey. This proposal was similar to the one Moscow implemented two weeks later. Araqchi presented the proposal at the highest levels: to Pashinyan and Ilham Aliyev in Armenia and Azerbaijan, and to the foreign ministries in Russia and Turkey. Although Azerbaijan and Turkey accepted Iran's proposal, Armenia did not, and the Russians were lukewarm.

Iran's proposal included the withdrawal of forces from each other's territories, protection of minority rights, reconstruction of transport routes, Iranian assistance in establishing a corridor between Nakhichevan and Azerbaijan, and the creation of a corridor connecting Armenia and Nagorno-Karabakh. Another element was a tripartite Iran–Turkey–Russia meeting to mediate the Nagorno-Karabakh issue, initially suggested by Lavrov in a phone call. While pursuing this proposal, Russia showed little interest; a similar proposal was later advanced, but with Iran removed and Turkey placed at the center. In the ceasefire monitoring room in Baku, both Turkey and Russia were present, although the peacekeeping forces are all Russian. Iran repeatedly emphasized the necessity of its presence. Azerbaijan and Armenia agreed, and Turkey had no objection. However, Russia considered Iran's presence unnecessary, even though it arguably strengthened Russia's strategic position in the tripartite Azerbaijan–Armenia–Turkey dynamic. This seemingly unreasonable reluctance may indicate a broader and more strategic assessments of Iran's role by Russia.

The main obstacle to implementing Iran's proposal, presented by Araqchi, was Armenia. The strategic error of Armenia was its refusal to accept a dignified ceasefire proposal while it had not yet been decisively defeated. Pashinyan's handling of Araqchi reflected this attitude, bluntly

telling him: "You want to force Armenia to accept defeat." Nonetheless, Araqchi, through excellent diplomacy, managed to calm Pashinyan and prevent this incident from negatively impacting his view of Iranian role.

We closely monitored the trajectory of the war, aiming to ensure that the region reached sustainable peace. We believed that durable peace must be based on positive-sum balance and mutual gain, not zero-sum victory and defeat. Ultimately, Azerbaijan advanced sufficiently that Russia was compelled to mediate. Pashinyan and Aliyev were summoned to Moscow, where a framework agreement was reached. Armenians believe they had no choice but to accept it.

During the Nagorno-Karabakh crisis, I traveled in two phases to Azerbaijan and Armenia. In the first phase, I visited all five countries involved and took the lead on the "33+" initiative (the three Caucasus countries along with Turkey, Iran, and Russia), which had been proposed by Erdoğan and Aliyev at the victory celebration in Baku. We presented this proposal in detail to all five countries. All accepted it except Georgia. Russia, in line with its usual policy, responded positively but with reservations. For reasons that will be explained, Iran was bound to be the central hub of the project, which Russia did not like.

Under this proposal, a consortium of six countries would rebuild transport routes in the Caucasus and the war-affected areas. Considering the long-standing hostility between Azerbaijan and Armenia and to prevent future conflicts, a framework for regional economic cooperation was to be established. Georgia, harboring an illusory reliance on Europe and the U.S., envisioned a different composition of participants. Their preferred configuration was 13+1+: three Caucasus countries along with the European Union and the United States—a combination both unrealistic and delusional.

We observed a profound sense of defeatism in Georgia. This same sense of defeatism was also very evident in Armenia after its loss in the second Nagorno-Karabakh war. Both countries clung to a false hope in Europe, rejoicing over several European Union statements and declarations. They misunderstood the situation fundamentally: in the power dynamics between these countries, such support serves as leverage for Europeans to exert pressure against their rivals, not to provide real assistance. The

“rivals” could be Turkey at one time, Azerbaijan at another, or Russia at yet another. These Western maneuvers offered no concrete benefits to Georgia or Armenia and did not protect their vital interests.

We proposed establishing a six-party consortium for transit and economic cooperation in the first trip. During the second trip, concerns arose that some parties might attempt to redraw the regional map in light of Armenia’s psychological collapse. Armenia as nation, at that time, was mentally fractured. And a nation that is psychologically collapsing is likely to collapse materially as well. Once people lose their self-confidence, as it happened in Armenia, material collapse is not far.

Even within Iran, there was not a unanimous support for our proposal. Some hoped that Azerbaijan would remain dependent on Iran for its connection to Nakhichevan. Persistent emphasis was placed on holding the 33+ meeting, which, due to clashes between Russia and Georgia and between Turkey and Armenia, could only be hosted in Iran. Unfortunately, this did not come to fruition. Our view was that Iran should host the 33+ meeting, and even if the Georgians did not attend, the meeting should still take place. Fortunately, the meeting was later held in the Raisi administration, first at the expert level in Moscow and then at the ministerial level in Tehran, although Georgia, as anticipated, did not participate.

During this period, we held extensive internal discussions regarding transport routes and the interpretation of paragraph 9 of the Moscow Agreement. In one of our Tuesday morning brainstorming sessions with university professors, one leading Caucasus expert at the Foreign Ministry proposed a railway connection linking Nakhichevan to Azerbaijan through Iran by building only two railway bridges over the Aras River at the end of Nakhichevan and the start of Azerbaijani territory. The proposal was considered feasible and interesting by the participants. Interestingly, the same day I met with the head of Turkish Intelligence Organization who suggested a similar plan. During a visit to Azerbaijan, Ilham Aliyev also welcomed this proposal. I believe that under the Raisi administration, work on this project began.

For the success of this proposal, it is essential not to view the issue with a zero-sum mindset. The benefits that Azerbaijan and Turkey gain here

are also gains for Iran. If Iran's strategic choice is to insist on capturing all advantages in a way that leaves no benefits for the other parties, ultimately Iran will be sidelined, and this policy will harm the country in the long term. This phenomenon is observed frequently in international relations.

A zero-sum approach dominates global relations. Although changing or even moderating this mindset is difficult, it is dangerous for humanity to perpetuate this cycle. If we approach neighborhood relations from a zero-sum perspective, seeing our neighbors' gains as our losses, we will resist regional cooperation that should benefit all. In such a scenario, no cooperation involving Iran will take place; in fact, cooperation will proceed without our presence, as has historically been the case. In the latter case, Iran must either accept exclusion or join late in collaborations that were established without considering our interests and concerns. This zero-sum mentality is why Iran is increasingly being excluded from regional transit projects. Whenever one party insists on securing all gains for itself, the likelihood of securing any benefit diminishes.

I never claim that other actors necessarily view events through a win-win or positive-sum lens. They may also operate with a zero-sum perspective. When one party approaches a situation this way, it tends to impose zero-sum logic on the interaction as a whole. It is extremely difficult to achieve positive-sum outcomes when one party evaluates the action with a zero-sum mindset. Eventually, one or all parties must break this vicious cycle.

Despite the strategic and valuable capabilities of the Islamic Republic, there is a real risk of Iran being sidelined in regional affairs due to the schemes of numerous powerful adversaries. In today's world, given the Islamic Republic's characteristics and its challenges with global powers, zero-sum, exclusionary approaches are common: all efforts are made to marginalize Iran. In an exclusionary game, Iran is the first to be sidelined. Therefore, it is better for Iran not to pursue exclusionary strategies from the outset.

Some mistakenly believe that adopting an exclusionary, adversarial approach benefits Iran. In fact, in such a scenario, the country and its government are excluded and end up as losers. This is an analytic perspective on statecraft, not an emotional or ideological stance. The global and regional environment is such that if international relations are

based on exclusion, the one excluded is Iran—and many parties benefit from our exclusion. Israel, in particular, thrives on enmity: its existence depends on having an external enemy. To maintain internal cohesion, the Zionist regime requires an external threat.

As explained earlier, since its inception, Israel has employed “securitization” and “fearmongering” as tools for both domestic governance and global action. It has leveraged the Holocaust and antisemitism first against Europeans, then Palestinians and Arabs, and since the early 1990s also against Iran, developing a unique expertise in securitization through fearmongering. Regrettably, the Islamic Republic, precisely after Iraq’s invasion of Kuwait—when opportunities for global engagement arose—fell into this trap, similar to the way Putin, with all his cunning, was caught in a U.S.-engineered securitization and over-stretching trap in Ukraine.

If Iran adopts a zero-sum, exclusionary approach toward Turkey and Azerbaijan, then Israel, Russia, Saudi Arabia, and others will exploit this. Likewise, if Iran does not engage the Persian Gulf states in positive-sum regional cooperation—or, more concretely, in mutually beneficial political, security, and economic exchanges—Israel will intervene via the Abraham Accords. In my research, Israel’s existence is fundamentally founded on the existence on a real or manufactured enemy, and it consistently leverages this for its strategic actions. The situation in the Caucasus is analogous: if Iran pursues positive-sum cooperation after the Nagorno-Karabakh crisis, it will secure a key regional role. If zero-sum thinking dominates, Iran will be sidelined.

Moreover, as the Nagorno-Karabakh crisis demonstrated, victory and defeat are never permanent. All regional assessments must aim for a balanced, equitable process. Even for our own benefit, the principle of balance must be observed. Thus, even when defining an adversary, we must provide a pathway for that adversary to exit a confrontation in a manner acceptable to them. If Azerbaijan today seeks to exploit Armenia’s defeat unfairly in order to impose its will, it creates a smoldering fire that may flare in the future.

Thirty years ago, when Armenia captured Azerbaijani territory, Azerbaijan was weakened and fragmented, much like Armenia is today.

Internal disputes and leadership struggles rendered Azerbaijan incapable of defending itself, allowing Armenia to seize its territories. Armenia failed to recognize that superiority is never static. Conditions change over time. Interestingly, the Armenian president himself acknowledged, during a post-defeat visit, that Armenia had taken a wrong path over the previous thirty years.

He asked me to convey to Aliev that they should not repeat Armenia's mistake. Armenia's strategic error was failing to reach an equitable agreement with Azerbaijan during the twenty-eight years when it held the upper hand. Today, that previous "victory" has been replaced by defeat.

This is the logic of creation: victory and defeat are not permanent. As the Quran states: "If a wound touches you, a like wound already has touched the heathen; such days We deal out in turn among men, and that God may know who are the believers, and that He may take witnesses from among you; and God loves not the evildoers; (Quran, 3:140)

Iran's Ties with Central Asia

Iran's connections with Central Asian countries—Turkmenistan, Tajikistan, Kyrgyzstan, Kazakhstan, and Uzbekistan—are multi-layered. One layer is cultural and linked to the ongoing flow of Iranian civilization, which is expected to continue. This cultural layer is strongest in Tajikistan and parts of Uzbekistan, though it exists, to varying degrees, in the other countries as well. Although Turkey has attempted, through the establishment of the Turkic Council, to situate most of these countries within a separate sphere, when these nations trace their historical roots, they recognize that many aspects of their civilization are indebted to Iranian culture. These cultural influences are visible in Uzbekistan, Kazakhstan, and Turkmenistan, even though these countries primarily identify themselves with Turkic heritage.

The Islamic Republic should engage consciously with this dynamic, taking care not to transform Iran's cultural influence into a perceived threat to the identity of these nations. As long as we avoid turning our cultural strengths into a source of anxiety for them, the deep-rooted appeal of

Iranian civilization remains a powerful influence across these countries, even extending to Turkey.

Here, it is worth noting a particularly controversial challenge. Zero-sum thinking toward culture and civilization is not only futile but also disruptive to Iran's civilizational influence. Debates over the nationality of scholars, poets, and mystics who lived within the great Iranian civilization and wrote in Persian are unbecoming for Iran, which constitutes the roots of this enduring cultural tree. The flourishing branches and flowers of this tree may take pride in their fruits, but the grandeur of Iran itself comes from the robustness of the root, not its deficiencies. We must not allow adversaries to exploit self-doubt to sever the tributaries from the mighty river of Iranian civilization. Figures such as Rumi, Rudaki, Nizami Ganjavi, Avicenna, and Al-Farabi form the sturdy foundations and continuity of Iranian civilization, not instruments for division. How can one quarrel over the nationality of Jalal al-Din Muhammad Balkhi, who identified himself as not belonging to any particular place?

What shall I do, O believers—I no longer know my name;
 I am not Christian, Jew, nor Magian, nor Muslim I proclaim.
 Not of the East, nor of the West, not land-bound nor sea-driven,
 Not mined from earth's deep elements nor traced in orbits of heaven.
 I am not soil, nor water, air, nor flame that leaps and dies,
 Not dust, not throne, not being, not the void that never lies.
 Not India's, nor China's son, nor born of Bulgar plain,
 Not from the two Iraqs, nor Khorasan's wind-swept grain.
 I belong not to this-world, nor the world that is to come,
 No Paradise, no pit of fire, no angel's beating drum.
 Not Adam's seed, nor Eve's, nor Eden's guarded gate I claim,
 My place is placelessness, my sign bears no sign, no name.
 Neither body am I, nor soul—for I have slipped the net,
 I am the soul of the Soul-Beloved, and in that love, I am set.

The second point concerns transit. The most efficient access for all these countries to international markets passes through Iran via the Persian Gulf and the Sea of Oman. Likewise, the best route for Turkmen gas to reach global markets in Asia and Europe is through Iranian territory. Leveraging

this strategic advantage requires the understanding that Iran, by serving as a transit hub, can achieve long-term strategic benefits. If, however, Iranian institutions exploit this advantage for short-term gain—for example, by imposing high transit fees or burdensome regulations—the country will lose these strategic opportunities. While Iran may be the optimal route, it is not the only route; if made economically unviable, these countries will seek alternatives.

Owing to challenges like these, much of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs' work focused on clarifying, neutralizing, and coordinating the consequences of uncoordinated policies by other agencies. Fragmented and departmentalized diplomacy can obstruct the optimal use of Iran's strategic capabilities. This challenge persists in the Islamic Republic, and during our administration it continued, particularly regarding Turkmenistan. In Turkmenistan, fragmented foreign policies hindered the strategic benefits Iran could gain, often due to uncoordinated actions by individuals rather than entire institutions.

For Tajikistan, security concerns are central. While the Tajik government values Persian culture and, in their own words, the heritage of their Aryan ancestors, security considerations often prevail. Rogue actions by overzealous individuals meant that much of the Ministry's efforts over eight years were devoted more to managing tensions than to expanding ties. The primary obstacle to Iran's accession to the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) after the termination of UN Security Council sanctions under Resolution 2231 was Tajik opposition. It took us over 6 years of long and tedious efforts any meetings at various levels to resolve the tension at a final meeting with President Rahmon in winter 2020. In May 2021, at the SCO foreign ministers' meeting in Dushanbe, Iran's accession was finalized and formally communicated to the Ministry of Foreign Affairs before Iran's presidential elections.

Overall, Iran maintains commendable relations with all Central Asian countries. These ties are perhaps less the result of our efforts than of enduring historical and cultural bonds. Nevertheless, there remains enormous potential to leverage this heritage and capability for enhanced cooperation with Central Asia.

Relations with Afghanistan

After the September 11, 2001, attacks, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs devoted its utmost efforts to pursuing a balanced policy in Afghanistan. The results of these efforts were particularly evident in the Afghan Constitution. In the years preceding the Rouhani Administration, the aim was to establish balanced ties with the central government while simultaneously securing Iran's eastern borders through informal dialogue with the Taliban. The challenges in Afghanistan have always been significant. I personally maintained very strong ties with the Afghan president, the chief executive, foreign ministers, and national security advisors. Mr. Ebrahim Taherian, the most prominent Afghanistan expert who served as Iran's special representative in Afghanistan during my tenure, was able to meet and engage with Afghan leaders more easily than any other foreign actor.

Iran's peak success in Afghanistan occurred when both diplomacy and field operations were mutually supportive. During that period, we achieved the greatest gains. I have often acknowledged that Iran's achievements at the Bonn Conference in 2001 were more the result of the late General Soleimani's operational groundwork than solely my efforts as Iran's lead negotiator in Bonn. While diplomacy engaged in talks, General Soleimani coordinated field operations, providing mutual support. This cooperation results in many achievements: Shi'a was recognized as an official religion in Afghanistan; 18 out of 27 cabinet positions were allocated to Iran-aligned figures in the Northern Alliance, including five seats for Shi'a representatives. These were tangible outcomes of coordinated diplomacy and field operations, where each actor performed its role effectively.

During President Ahmadinejad's tenure, the Supreme National Security Council decided to entrust diplomacy to field commanders, which prevented us from participating in international discussions regarding Afghanistan. Although the Taliban ultimately seized control after the end of our administration, as early as 2019 I had foreseen such developments in various meetings. It was evident that prioritizing field operations and focusing on defeating and pushing the U.S. out of Afghanistan instead

of pursuing Iran's own national security interest would eventually lead to Taliban dominance and the collapse of all joint diplomatic and field achievements. The events of spring 2023, and the Taliban's subsequent provocations against Iran, marked the culmination of this flawed policy.

A fundamental difficulty with Afghanistan during the Ghani administration was security. Afghanistan demanded security guarantees in return for allowing Iran to receive its rightful share of water from Hirmand river. Today we not only are prevented from receiving our rightful share of the river waters, but the Taliban have also come to dominate Afghanistan. As mentioned, in the final years of my tenure, we were prevented from participating in international dialogues on Afghanistan. This policy contributed directly to attacks such as those on Shi'a schools in the heart of Kabul.

Afghanistan became a victim of being turned into a domestic political issue for the U.S. The Trump administration, for internal political gain, solicited the Taliban to facilitate U.S. withdrawal. History's irony is clear: the U.S. came to Afghanistan to remove the Taliban but ended up negotiating with them to exit. Many of the reasons behind this were beyond Iran's control. However, Iran's own mistakes—though minor in the larger scheme—rested on two key misunderstandings that are not unique to Afghanistan.

First, in our foreign policy priorities, confrontation with the U.S. has been placed above all other priorities. Political opposition to U.S. unilateralism, preventing a unipolar world, and forming global coalitions against U.S. dominance is indeed beneficial for Iran and enhances its power. Many state and non-state actors around the world oppose the formation of a U.S.-dominated order. Thus, smart political opposition to a unipolar world is a legitimate and productive global action. Leading or participating in such an effort expands Iran's influence. The era of a unipolar world is over, and the current global trajectory is moving toward post-polarity rather than unipolarity—or even traditional multipolarity. U.S. expectations of establishing a unipolar world were, therefore, a costly fantasy. Opposing U.S. unipolarity politically has been both a successful and beneficial endeavor.

However, unlike Iran, no other actor in the world—from China and Russia to the Taliban—sacrifices its national or group interests solely to oppose the U.S. As such, the Taliban exploited Iran's support while negotiating with the U.S., enabling them to gain control of Afghanistan at Iran's expense. Over several years, Iran has paid multiple costs in this process.

Some may argue that U.S. presence in the region represents the greatest threat to Iran and its ouster therefore must be the top priority. This perspective overestimates U.S. power and underestimates structural challenges posed to global hegemonic tendencies. Based on research and analysis of global events, I believe that even without Iran's involvement or costs, the U.S. would have become mired in Afghanistan and Iraq and indeed it did. As shown by the Baker-Hamilton Report⁹⁶ in 2006—before Iran became entangled with the U.S. in Iraq and Afghanistan—U.S. leadership had already realized the futility of forever wars, making a similar strategic misstep elsewhere unlikely. U.S. actions over the past twenty years confirm this.

The second major misunderstanding was the belief that one could prevent or delegitimize a process by refusing to participate in it. Consequently, despite extensive efforts, the Ministry of Foreign Affairs could not obtain permission to participate in dialogue on Afghanistan along with U.S., Russia, China, and Pakistan. The Taliban had convinced their Iranian "field" interlocutors that that they would never make a deal with the U.S. This was the first reason for preventing Iran's participation in the quad-partite talks. However, the deeper cognitive error was believing that refusing to be a part of a process, or refusing to sign a multilateral agreement, could prevent its formation, diminish its impact on Iran, or undermine its legitimacy. Such thinking might have been valid fifty years ago, particularly in the context of bilateral relations, but in today's world, it is both incorrect and harmful.

U.S.-Taliban talks did in fact take pace and reached conclusions without Iran's participation. Russia, China, and Pakistan secured their interests in this four-party dialogue or at least managed their losses, while Iran

⁹⁶ Lee Hamilton and James Baker, *The Iraq Study Group Report*, New York: Vintage Books, 2006.

has only borne costs. As noted previously, in multilateral discussions, “if a player is not at the table, it is on the table.” Complaints regarding the legitimacy of a process accomplish nothing; there is no tribunal to adjudicate such claims, and even if there were, the absent actor would likely gain no advantage.

It is worth repeating that our political elite maintain a dual attitude toward international law. On one hand, they view it as serving the interests of dominant powers; on the other, they assume everything operates strictly according to written legal texts, often with imprecise readings and outdated interpretations. We tend to think that international law applies only to agreements we have signed, and if we have not signed a document, we are free from its obligations. Such an understanding may have been relevant in the 19th and early 20th centuries, but it is fundamentally flawed today. Membership in international conventions and treaties can create opportunities for legitimate engagement, whereas non-membership neither prevents the application of rules nor protects a state from intervention; in fact, it can expose the state to more intrusive oversight. In short, multilateral and bilateral treaties are not inherently the cause of sources of intervention; nor can they prevent it. What conventions can do is to contain it through codification, enabling all actors to anticipate and plan accordingly. This is the essence of multilateralism: containing and limiting power in exchange for legitimizing its limited and constrained exercise.

Relations with Pakistan

The bond between the peoples of Iran and Pakistan has always been unique and exceptional, and it will remain so. Under the Rouhani Administration, these ties expanded to a strategic level. Perhaps due to the JCPOA, Pakistani prime ministers—Nawaz Sharif and Imran Khan—showed me special respect, which enabled serious and productive dialogue despite difference in rank.

Additionally, close interactions between the senior military commanders of Iran and Pakistan, similar to those with Turkey, became routine. Previously, the chiefs of staff of Iran, Turkey, and Pakistan rarely met. During this period, regular ties were established between the chiefs of staff

of Iran and Turkey, and our relations with Pakistan's senior commanders were also at their best. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs was the initiator of these links. By the end of my tenure, we enjoyed excellent relations with Pakistan's military leadership.

During my first visit to Pakistan as foreign minister, I met General Raheel Sharif, the highest-ranking military official in Pakistan. He had made special arrangements for this meeting, even holding a ceremonial salute contrary to usual protocol. Subsequently, our relations with his successor, General Qamar Javed Bajwa, were very cordial and close and brought significant benefits to Iran.

The Ministry of Foreign Affairs and the Iranian Armed Forces worked in close synergy on Pakistan- and Turkey-related matters. On numerous occasions, we traveled to Pakistan with military commanders to address border challenges, which proved highly effective. These friendly ties enabled us to safely recover Iranian hostages from terrorist groups through the assistance of the Pakistani army. Similarly, we improved border security and opened two border crossings, Rimdan and Pishin, which had been waiting to open for years—benefiting Iranian border communities. Coordination between the governments of Iran and Pakistan increased significantly.

It can be said that the relationships established during our administration with Pakistan and Turkey were unprecedented since the Revolution. Likewise, ties with Russia and China during my tenure were stronger than in previous periods.

Foreign policy is not a theater for creating emotional stories. Diplomacy and international relations are arenas for pursuing national interests with open eyes and composure. If foreign policy is approached with emotional attachment or infatuation, one will inevitably face disappointment, because affection must be mutual:

How sweet is love, at both ends of the string,

For love at even one end is nothing but suffering.

No country builds diplomatic relations based on emotional attachment.

During my tenure, with eyes wide open—assessing mutual interests while acknowledging divergent viewpoints—we established the best possible ties with Russia, China, Pakistan, and Turkey. The same approach

cannot be applied to Afghanistan, as the Ministry of Foreign Affairs was not responsible for the Afghan portfolio, and the prevailing dynamics, as discussed earlier, ultimately led to Taliban dominance and the subsequent unfortunate events.

Relations with Africa and Latin America

The two geographical regions of Latin America and Africa have always been a priority of the foreign ministry. Among the countries of the Global South, Iran is one of the main actors, playing a particularly prominent role in international organizations. It seems that there is an expectation for Iran to take a leading role. In managing these ties, we tried to adopt a realistic approach. Our relationship with any country should not be viewed in black and white, because each country in the Global South can cooperate with us in one or more areas.

In 2016, in the book *The Transition Period of International Relations in a Post-Western World*, we wrote that the era of permanent alliances has ended, and the era of temporary and issue-based coalitions has arrived. For this reason, we should not expect the formation of new global poles. I believe the era of global polarity has ended, and we have now entered a post-polar world. Instead of following conspiracy theories or unfalsifiable hypotheses, we must accept that actors operate in different areas with varying tendencies, priorities, and even contradictory coalitions and alignments. For example, Europe was unable to act as a reliable economic partner for Iran against U.S. treaty violations and pressures in the JCPOA. Yet without Europe, we could not have embarrassed the United States three times in the Security Council and the UN General Assembly in an unprecedented manner. We must separate these spheres so that our relations with countries are based on the current complex and fluid developments.

We need to understand in which areas different countries are willing to cooperate with us. To understand this, we must put ourselves in their place. Many countries in the 1990s were ready to cooperate with Iran on disarmament issues; they knew that we would stand firm on our positions. However, with the controversy over the nuclear file—and even before that, at the 1995 Review and Extension Conference of the Nuclear Non-

Proliferation Treaty—these countries distanced themselves from us and our allies. We needed to understand that we could not indefinitely rely on the support of those countries. Therefore, we should not sacrifice ourselves for another country. We must recognize that temporary coalitions can be formed in specific areas. Accordingly, countries should be understood and accepted based on their own capabilities, tendencies, and perspectives.

Most countries of the Global South do not want to join Iran in a costly struggle against the United States. Perhaps Venezuela may wish to do so—but only as long as it is itself fighting the U.S. Venezuela's conflict with the United States is not as deep-rooted as Iran's; it is situational and issue-based. Yesterday they were opposed; today there is *détente*, and tomorrow they may even become allies. Therefore, we should not expect other countries to behave as we do. We must recognize that Venezuela may align with us on the U.S. one day, and not the next. Turkey may participate in a Coalition to Support the UN Charter alongside us one day and have another orientation the next. Indonesia may support us on nuclear disarmament one day and be separated from us because of pressures or needs the next. We must be able to form temporary and issue-based coalitions based on our perspectives and those of others in various matters. When Israel attacks Gaza, a global coalition against Zionist genocide might be formed—but we should not assume that members of this coalition have adopted all our views on Israel. By maintaining this perspective, we can establish proper ties with all countries of the Global South.

Relations with Africa fit within this framework. We can have healthy ties with Africa. Africans are aligned with us on many international issues, and not on others. We can benefit from the areas of alignment. Economically, Africa offers very good opportunities for cooperation, and unfortunately, we have not been able to make the best use of these opportunities. It should be noted that due to sanctions and Africa's dependence on European banks, one of the heaviest challenges is barriers to banking transactions. However, during my trips to Africa, entrepreneurs who came with determination gained the most benefit. In knowledge-based industries, we were able to establish a presence in Africa, including a permanent knowledge-based exhibition in Kenya. In areas where we carefully matched Iran's capabilities with the considerable needs of African countries, especially in areas of

relative advantage, we were able to achieve results. These were areas where Africans were not forced to choose between us and the United States. Some of our exports to Africa and imports from Africa were effective because we utilized mechanisms that did not involve the U.S.

During trips to Africa, many representatives of the Chamber of Commerce accompanied us. Apart from China, the most populous trips were to Latin America and Africa. Private sector participants were satisfied. All private sector participants were selected by the Chamber of Commerce, and we did not interfere in decisions regarding the attendance of individuals and companies. Those who came to establish commercial relations could create very good and profitable ties. The only condition for success was to accept that Africa faces constraints in trade relations with Iran and to accommodate those constraints. I repeated in all my meetings with African authorities that “We have not come to cause you problems with the U.S. We do not want to put you in difficulty or trouble.” Countries approach dialogue with Iran with extreme caution and concern, careful about how and from where Iranians might involve them in conflict with the United States.

To reach an understanding, the first prerequisite is to place oneself in the position of the other party. The second prerequisite is to regard the other party as at least as intelligent and shrewd as oneself. This is a reality that must be accepted. Therefore, one should not try to convince the other side through speeches or preaching that they should reverse a decision they have already made. Instead, various ways of pursuing the same decision should be presented to the counterpart. One should never assume that the other side can be deceived.

Many developing countries in Africa and Latin America can be good partners for us. All of them are interested in establishing ties with us. They hold great respect for Iran’s culture, history, revolution, and independence—provided that we see them in the scope of their own capabilities, not in the measure of our expectations. We must align our expectations with their realities. We need to find a place for ourselves within the framework of their national policies, rather than attempting to impose our own policy on them. One of our mistakes has been that we did not examine the other party’s policies in order to find a place

for ourselves; instead, we assumed: “This is our policy; where does this country fit into our policy?” The answer, in most cases, is that there is no place for us.

In these two continents, some countries have been priorities for Iran. In the Americas, Brazil has been a priority economically, and Venezuela, Bolivia, Cuba, and Nicaragua politically. In Africa, South Africa has been a priority across all areas, while others—such as Kenya, Tanzania, and Francophone Africa—were more focused on trade and politics. We have established strong, targeted ties with most African countries. For instance, in the automobile and mining sectors, specific capacities have been identified. A business may enter a country, find a suitable opportunity for cooperation, and make good progress. In some cases, we gain more benefit; in others, the partner benefits more. Currently, Africa is the best market for Iranian household products. Therefore, we must find ways to engage them without entangling them in U.S. sanctions—through barter or other mechanisms.

Another issue we faced in working with these two continents was the pressure by some senior officials to close a number of our diplomatic missions in Africa and Latin America because of financial constraints. Such action, in the Ministry of Foreign Affairs’ comprehensive assessment, did not serve our national interests. The government officials proposing this were concerned with financial constraints: embassies incur costs, and the government faced countless budgetary limitations. There was also a widespread belief that our embassies were inefficient—and to some extent, this criticism was accurate, reflecting issues within the Ministry of Foreign Affairs, which we were aware of. However, the Ministry’s considerations were broader. Although closing a mission might be simple, reopening the same mission presents numerous challenges from the standpoint of our domestic legislations, which require various approvals, as well as from the perspective of the host country. The authorities sought to resolve a functional or even structural challenge with a huge strategic mistake. Our colleagues worked skillfully and delicately to manage this challenge. To this end, in some African countries we did not appoint ambassadors; the mission was managed by a *chargé d’affaires*, in order to postpone their closure.

CHAPTER VI

IRAN AND MAJOR POWERS

Relations with Russia

Russia is a permanent member of UN Security Council, a vast nuclear-armed nation, rich in oil and gas. Above all, it is Iran's neighbor. But we suffer from excessive tendencies at both ends of the political spectrum when it comes to Iranian relations with Russia. A group in the country profoundly resents Russia while another group are Russophiles. That is similar to the situation vis à vis the United States. This is detrimental to healthy neighborly relations with Russia.

First and foremost, we should make a sober and realistic assessment of how Russia perceives Iran and its place in Russian policy. We should have a correct understanding of Russia. The same goes for China. Many of us imagine we can be a strategic ally of Russia in its war with the United States. Such outlook has driven us into excess and defect; both in admiration for and resentment against Russia.

Russia's fundamental strategy in global affairs is to preserve its standing as a "great power". In Russia's vision of global relations, which is based on the Great Powers Game, other actors are just peripheries and not allies. In post-USSR period and the U.S. superiority in political, economic and even military terms, Russia's presence at the great powers' table is possible only through mutually assured destruction (MAD) in a nuclear war or what the Russians refer to as "strategic stability"⁹⁷. For this reason, Russia views most global acts from the angle of highly complicated nuclear deterrence calculus. The implications of this perspective in involving Iran in the war on Ukraine can give rise to serious consequences for Iran's national security.

As far as historical perspective is concerned, Russia does not view Iran as an anti-U.S. ally. From Russian standpoint, Iran merely seeks close relations with Russia because of its disputes with the United States, trying to exploit Russia as a tool against the United States. Should Iran be able to settle its disputes with the U.S., it will not hesitate to distance itself from Russia. That is how Russia's polity views Iran; Russian Foreign Minister Sergei Lavrov made this anxiety clear to me more than once.

In international dealings, Russia neither wants nor can confront the U.S. except in terms of "strategic stability" or nuclear MAD. It maintains that only "strategic stability" may safeguard its security. For many astute observers, Ukraine was a securitization trap set by the U.S. for President Vladimir Putin. Doubtlessly, Russia would not be ready to sacrifice its own interests for Iran by standing against the US; however, like every other country, Russia is ready to sacrifice Iran for its own interests in its challenges with the U.S. and others as it happened in disclosing alleged purchase of Iranian drones and back in summer 2015, the visit to Russia of Gen. Qasem Soleimani—both of which were leaked to the press by Russians. What is more regrettable is that certain Iranians publicly boast that the world's second military power has purchased Iranian weapons. This indicates misperception of the complicated reasons behind the alleged purchase and more importantly its disclosure. In our interaction with Russia, we face these severe cognitive challenges. We need to deconstruct

⁹⁷ For instance, see Sourtchi, Mohammad Reza; *The Role of Strategic Stability in Russian Foreign Policy in Relation with the USA (2000-2022)*, PhD Thesis, University of Tehran, 2023

and revise our perspectives about Russia in order to have mutually beneficial relations with this important neighbor. Until we do this, we are doomed to a misunderstanding-laden relationship.

A significant part of our assumptions about our surroundings and foreign policy objectives are mere fantasies. What is not mere fantasy is outdated, belonging to the Cold War period when the world was fundamentally different. The world is evolving constantly, but we still think of a rigid world which used to be. That is why we take steps in the wrong direction that would not take the country to the intended destination. Russia is a case in point.

We should develop very good ties with Russia, as a key neighbor and a global actor who is also a UN Security Council permanent member. We should keep in mind that Russia's power as a Security Council member is different from Russia outside the Council. Within the Security Council, Russia is one of five great powers, but outside, except for "strategic stability", it requires the assistance of China and even Europe. Apart from energy exports, it has no specific leverage on others. And in its energy advantage, Russia is our rival and not our ally.

Therefore, we should not have a merely positive or negative emotional vision vis-à-vis Russia. If we managed to have positive cooperation with Russia during my tenure, it was because we accepted Russia as it is. Russia an important neighbor of Iran. That explains clearly why we have failed to establish meaningful dialogue with Iranian politicians who are either Russophile or Russophobe. They are seeking pretexts to prove their pro- or anti-Russian inclination. The fundamental problem lies in our expectations from Russia that we have not determined based on a realistic vision. That is why we are constantly frustrated with Russia. Russia can take advantage of us and such exploitation drives us to frustration. We have to recognize Russia as it is.

Russia does not want Iran to have normal relations with the West and the United States. It is opposed to seeing our tensions with the West and the US end in war. Russia believes that normalization with the West and the U.S. would drive us away from Russia and towards the West. From the Russian perspective, following normalization, even if Iran does not become a strategic ally of the United States against Russia, it would at least

become closer to the United States than Russia. One Iranian official was once quoted as saying: "The first and second priority of the United States are Russia and China. Iran can therefore have a valuable standing for the U.S.". This is the perception shared by a large number of our elite. I do not intend to assess its veracity or falsehood here. But the implication of this statement is that Iran is ready to team up with the US in tackling its vital priorities, i.e. Russia and China. Russia knows this perfectly as it has done exactly the same. For this reason, it aims to obstruct normalization of Iran's relations with Europe and the US.

On the other hand, Russia does not want to see our tensions with Europe and the U.S. lead to war. Russian assessment is solely driven by its purely materialistic perspective, which would predict that Iran would certainly lose that fight. Such an eventuality would put Russia in a very unenviable position: either it should join the war in favor of Iran or accept a losing Iran to the Western camp. Russia does not want to be forced to making that decision. Of course, it is difficult to predict where Russia would stand in case Iran and the West go to war. That may depend on the quid pro quo the parties would be ready to pay to Russia. Russia may be ready to offer relative support to us, but it would demand concessions from Iran that would go beyond our constitutional abilities.

In a low-intensity conflict like Syria, Russia may be ready to cooperate with Iran in line with its own interests, in which case we should be also ready to pay its price. Even in that conflict, Russia showed that it would pull the plug on Iran in order to preserve its own interests. But if we were dealing with a war to the scale of our eight-year armed conflict with Iraq (1980-1988-), would Russia be ready to stand with us? If a war was to break out between Iran and Persian Gulf littoral states, would Russia stand with us? Definitely not. But if we expect it to veto a UN Security Council resolution on Yemen, we may have hit the target. We all witnessed that Russia verbally rejected Israel's 12-day war against Iran but refused to take any practical step to assist Iran in the face of a blatant Israeli aggression, supported by the United States and the West. The statement by President Putin is very revealing: "I would like to draw your attention to the fact that almost two million people from the former Soviet Union and the Russian Federation reside in Israel. It is almost a

Russian-speaking country today. And, undoubtedly, we always take this into account in Russia's contemporary history." ⁹⁸The misplaced and unrealistic expectations of the Ahmadinejad administrations from Russia in the nuclear case is another case in point. To the chagrin of the Iranian political establishment, Russia and China did not veto any of anti-Iran resolutions drafted by the West and adopted by the Security Council. The Ahmadinejad administration expected Moscow to veto resolutions that advanced Russian interests. I was serving as Iran's UN ambassador. I reiterated that based on my almost three decades of experience at the United Nations, the manner of negotiations between Russia and the West did not indicate its intention to veto the resolutions; but nobody believed me. The warnings from the Permanent Mission to the UN were ignored, accusing us of being intimidated by the United States. Finally, a couple of nights before Resolution 1696 was adopted, the secretary of Russia's National Security Council told his Iranian counterpart that Russia could not veto the resolution. Not only did they not veto in the resolution, but they also voted in favor of that and all the following resolutions.

I have a different understanding of Russia and based on that I sought to establish constructive ties with it. While my Russian counterparts never developed a liking for me—this goes back to the time of Iran-Iraq war as I indicated earlier—but during my tenure as foreign minister, I maintained cordial and cooperative relations, because I always kept in my mind that they are ready to cooperate with Iran within certain boundaries. Unfortunately, domestic actors in Iran-Russia relations are numerous and are mostly ignorant. To illustrate this reality, let me refer to two cases that I already mentioned in previous segments of this book.

In winter 2014, I travelled to Russia where I met with President Putin. A member of parliament was also in our delegation. In the meeting, President Putin accepted a proposal from President Rouhani to purchase Iranian oil. The MP revealed the agreement to media, after which Iran-Russia oil deal was shelved. He had wrongly perceived that the Russians would take pride in having stood by Iran. As soon as the agreement was revealed, U.S. Secretary of State John Kerry made a threatening call to

⁹⁸ <https://tass.com/politics/1977955>

Minister Lavrov. Kerry also called and threatened me while I was still in Moscow. I responded that Iran would certainly pursue any possibility to evade the American illegal sanctions. Anyway, the deal was never operationalized *inter alia* for this imprudent revelation. The second case pertains to disclosure of news of Russia's planned investment in Iran. In a second meeting with President Putin in Sochi, he expressed his willingness to invest \$50 billion in Iranian oil projects. He even called in the CEO of Rosneft to jump start the project. I reported the details of the meeting to the government, but kept it secret from media because I knew that any revelation would expose Russian companies to sanctions and wreck the entire investment agreement. A couple of months later, the same \$50 billion investment pledge was raised in another meeting and announced immediately by the Iranian interlocutor at an ensuing press conference. The Russian chair of the bilateral joint commission immediately talked to the press saying that Russia was ready to send humanitarian aid to Iran. In other words, Russia would not pay any strategic and sanctions-induced costs for its ties with Iran. Russia would have benefited exorbitantly from investing \$50 billion in Iran, but would it ever be ready to make such gains at the expense of confrontation with the U.S.? Our misperception is primarily caused by cognitive deficit leading to inaccurate assessment.

The Rouhani administrations made significant achievements with regard to Iran-Russia ties. We won Russia's support on numerous occasions at the Security Council, even its veto. The oil deal and investment agreements became possible. But it had a precondition: no one in Iran would reveal the deal—for the purpose of getting political mileage at home and abroad at the expense of Russia. Russia would not gain much from such revelations but would have to endure significant pressure; and that was never to be. President Putin's interests lied in obstructing normalization of Iran-West ties. For this very purpose Russia insisted to use Iranian airspace and territory for its missiles and refueling for its planes targeting Syrian opposition, even though it had no real need for such use with its warships off the coast of Syria and its huge airbase inside Syria. The promise of \$50 billion investment would also serve the same purpose in a more sweetened way.

Because of the same strategic approach and in order to prevent an imminent confrontation between Iran and the West, Russia was supportive of détente in the nuclear issue, but it did not want the nuclear case to be closed. That explains why Russia supported Iran during the 2013 Geneva talks that resulted in an interim deal. Interestingly, after it was revealed that the Americans had been in secret talks with us in Oman for three to four months and we prepared the text that had been worked out between Iran and the U.S. without E3/EU+3 participation or knowledge, the Russians showed the best behavior, telling us: “We weren’t happy with this, but good for you for being so close to an agreement”. China, Britain and Germany did not show any negative reaction, unlike France. Russia might have been kept abreast of the Oman talks through its intelligence network, but considered the interim agreement that reduced tensions in its own interest. Therefore, it did not show any negative reaction to being kept in the dark.

Nonetheless, Russia’s strategy was based on the prolongation of managed tensions between Iran and the West and Iran’s dependence on Russia at the Security Council via resolutions adopted under Chapter VII of the UN Charter. That is why from the very beginning of the comprehensive talks in Vienna in February 2014, Russia adopted a negative role. The first step was to destroy Iran’s basis of negotiations about Tehran’s need to enrich uranium. Iran’s great achievement in the Geneva interim agreement was the recognition of Iran’s enrichment in accordance with its needs. We had reached agreement with the U.S. and others that Iran will be able to enrich uranium within the framework of its needs. How had we defined our needs? The Natanz enrichment plant had been designed and built to produce fuel for the Bushehr nuclear power plant. Russia defeated this argument during the first days of the Vienna talks and pushed the would-be JCPOA to possible failure. The talks that were initially supposed to reach conclusion within six months lingered on.

During bilateral U.S. Russia talks prior to Vienna, the Russian government had told the US that it would guarantee permanent fuel supply to the Bushehr power plant. The clear meaning of this position was to destroy Iran’s need for enrichment, thereby preventing any Iran-West agreement on enrichment, which was the most fundamental element of

the Geneva agreement, without which a comprehensive deal would be impossible. Despite our extensive efforts at the highest levels in Moscow, Tehran and Vienna, Russia never backed down from its position. In a bid to counter Russia's ploy and having a good knowledge of US concerns, I told Secretary Kerry: "It's clear that Russia wants to keep us dependent on it. Do you also want Iran to be dependent on Russia?"⁹⁹

After this counterattack, the Russians notched up their demand, saying: "We'll not allow the fuel produced in Iran to be used in Bushehr. We'll never license Iran's domestically produced fuel for use in Bushehr". A manufacturer license for fuel is required as per the IAEA safety regulations. We offered to Russia an agreement for joint fuel production. They replied: "We'll do so only on condition that Iran signs agreements with Russia for eight new nuclear power plants". Each power plant costs about \$5 billion, i.e., in total \$40 billion. To deal with this challenge, I suggested at a Cabinet meeting that we sign an MoU with Russia for eight power plants but sign a contract for only two due to budget crunch. One impetus for agreement on the second phase of the Bushehr power plant was to remove this challenge. It did not work.

The third step was the initiative the Russians took during the sensitive round of talks in March 2015 in Lausanne, Switzerland, for "snapback"—a phrase that does not exist in the JCPOA¹⁰⁰. What was enshrined for in the JCPOA is reciprocal return to pre-JCPOA conditions as guarantee for compliance with obligations, as set forth in Articles 36 and 37 of the JCPOA. It would mean Iran's full or partial return to its previous nuclear program and/or reinstatement of sanctions and UN Security Council resolutions.

What we had agreed upon, examples of which are seen in the JCPOA, was that Resolution 2231 terminates all previous resolutions. However, signatories to the JCPOA had the chance to restore the resolutions after going through a procedure. This is a complicated process and could not happen immediately and automatically. The US failed to apply it during the first term in office of President Trump.

⁹⁹ That is the negotiating strategy I earlier noted; you point to the opposite party's interests not yours. In Iran, this strategy has detractors.

¹⁰⁰ The term was used by the US to persuade the public opinion of an automatic reimposition of sanctions.

In our talks with the Americans, we had agreed upon very tough and complicated conditions for the possible reinstatement of UN resolutions. But in the middle of Lausanne talks, the US delegation presented us with a new draft prepared by France and Russia. The draft agreement was technically prepared and apparently attractive. After a precise study of it, I said: "This is the biggest failure for us. We have to win endorsement from the UN Security Council every six months so that the JCPOA would continue and the six resolutions would remain terminated". More clearly, instead of lifting sanctions so that any re-imposition would depend on our non-compliance, the draft terminated sanctions for six months only. The draft agreement had been written technically, using the UN Security Council language. Only Minister Lavrov could do so, given his background as Russia's long-time ambassador to the UN. Definitely, the opportunist Americans also made their best use of it. Some of our friends who were not familiar with the Security Council texts had not noticed the trap. I had a furious chat with Secretary Kerry who said the draft had been prepared by your own friends. I reacted harshly and finally managed to return the draft. In the end, what we had agreed with Kerry, which is incorporated in the JCPOA, was a little bit better.

Another case of obstructionism occurred at the end of the talks. Russian negotiators abruptly raised a new red line to be stipulated in the JCPOA that "JCPOA inspections shall not set a precedent for the future". This method was aimed at humiliating Iran and stonewalling the agreement. It puts us in a very difficult situation. We insisted a lot, but the Russians did not back down. In the end, thanks to God and applying drafting skills, we incorporated phrases into the text to consider requirements of the agreement would not set a precedent. In other words, the final text implies that "concessions like enrichment given to Iran will not set any precedent"¹⁰¹. The interesting point is that an Iranian member of parliament—who claims to know the details of the JCPOA—referred to

¹⁰¹ All provisions and measures contained in this JCPOA are only for the purpose of its implementation between E3/EU+3 and Iran and should not be considered as setting precedents for any other state or for fundamental principles of international law and the rights and obligations under the NPT and other relevant instruments, as well as for internationally recognized principles and practices. (JCPOA, PREAMBLE AND GENERAL PROVISIONS, xi)

Russia's initial draft to assail me, and not to the final JCPOA text. It is not clear who had given him the Russian draft instead of the final text¹⁰².

Russia's last act was to humiliate me and Iranian negotiators inside Iran, giving our opponents ammunition to attack us. Upon returning to Moscow, Minister Lavrov said in an interview that Russia and China were opposed to arms restrictions, but they had no option but to accept after the Iranian delegation agreed to them. This unscrupulous tactic gave ammunition for heaping scorn on negotiators. The reality was quite opposite. It is right that Iran, Russia and China were opposed to the continuation of arms embargo, but it was Iran that fought alone to persuade the other four to lift the restriction. These sanctions had not been imposed via Resolution 2231 so that opposition from Iran, China and Russia could block them; rather, these sanctions had been imposed by the concurring vote of China and Russia to previous resolutions. Therefore, their removal required the acceptance of all seven parties (Iran, the US, France, Britain, Germany, China and Russia) plus the EU. We struggled until the end and without any help from Russia and China, we managed to change the language and limit the timeframe of sanctions enshrined in former resolutions to five-year restrictions. But my longtime friend upended the developments leading to the tough final days, and knowing well about the atmosphere in Iran, he exposed me and my colleagues to unfounded challenges and undue accusations¹⁰³. In reviewing my notes after the latest accusations

¹⁰² It is a reminder of the Russian-induced mistranslation of the verb "compel" in Resolution 1929 to reverse the meaning. The main text read: "Stressing that nothing in this resolution compels States to take measures or actions exceeding the scope of this resolution, including the use of force or the threat of force...", but in official translation, inspired by Russia, "compel" had been wrongly translated as "allow".

¹⁰³ It was not my first experience of such Russian conduct. Nearly 27 years earlier, during the months leading to Iran's acceptance of Resolution 598, the USSR mission to the UN did the same to us, which I have recounted in the book *Aqay-e Safir* (Mr. Ambassador). Here is the translation of that passage: "The Americans were insisting that a second resolution had to be issued because Iran still hadn't accepted Resolution 598... Of course, the Soviets and the Chinese resisted accepting the American proposal for quite a while... I think it was in late February when the Soviet representative told me: 'We've received instructions from Moscow that on Monday — that is, at the next meeting of the permanent members — we're to stop resisting, and the resolution will move forward.' ... We reported this to Tehran. In Tehran they consulted with Imam Khomeini, and it was decided to write a letter saying, in effect, that accepting the Secretary-General's implementation plan was "tantamount" to accepting the resolution... Three weeks later... the Soviets sent a KGB delegation to Iran. They told their Iranian counterparts: 'Your New York mission betrayed you. We had told your representative that we would block the second resolution, but then they went and wrote that letter.'"

by Minister Lavrov, I noted that it was actually Lavrov who pushed me to accept the final language on arms restrictions at the last hours of the JCPOA negotiations on July 13. We recounted the full story with all its details on page 453 of Volume 5 of our Persian book, *JCPOA: The Untold Story*, including this passage: “The final showdown over the arms restrictions took place at 11 p.m. on Monday, July 13, 2015, in John Kerry’s hotel room. When Dr. Zarif walked in, Federica Mogherini and John Kerry—along with their aides—were trying to persuade Lavrov to give the talks just a few more hours to reach a conclusion, but he was refusing. The moment Dr. Zarif entered, Lavrov immediately turned to him and said: ‘Why won’t you accept this five-year (arms embargo) period? I promise you—these people (pointing at the Westerners) are never going to give you anything better than this.’”

Finally, Russia sought to limit the JCPOA benefits for Iran. Only two weeks after the JCPOA was concluded on 14 July 2015, Russia invited Gen. Soleimani to visit Moscow for a meeting with President Putin, scheduled for August. This is while Gen. Soleimani had expressed willingness for a high-level meeting with Russian officials since early 2015 when everyone feared the fall of Syrian President Bashar Assad. Syria’s unstable conditions ended in in spring and Gen. Soleimani and President Assad had managed in late spring to defeat extremist armed groups around Damascus and clear the way from Damascus Airport to the capital.

After resounding triumphs on the battleground and conclusion of JCPOA talks, Russia secretly invited Gen. Soleimani to Moscow without even informing the MFA and the Islamic Republic’s embassy. More interestingly, although Gen. Soleimani’s numerous visits to various countries had been kept secret, it was Russia that this time revealed his visit. So was the case of alleged Iranian drones in Ukraine, which apparently non-state Russian experts revealed in their televised interviews. Based on every piece of evidence, it seems that Russia aimed to prevent any normalization of Iran-West ties after the JCPOA and block any restoration of the nuclear deal after the Ukraine war. It is regrettable that it achieved its objectives in both cases. Gen. Soleimani was later infuriated with the Russians’ handling of Syria and had transmitted his fury time and again through me and other MFA colleagues including Araghchi.

Russia's conduct showed its preference for *détente* between Iran and the world so that no war, which was one of its two red lines and of course was eclipsed after the Ukraine war, would break out. However, it was not ready to overstep the other red line, i.e. normalization of Iran-West ties. When nuclear talks were under way, I travelled to Moscow on several occasions to allay their concerns with the possible success of the JCPOA. I reminded Russian officials of the fact that we have always had challenges with the West, but our ties with Russia and China would remain as strategic as they have been. During the final weeks of negotiations, I said during my visit to Russia that China and Russia would be the primary beneficiaries of any agreement and that we can broaden our ties with Russia without any obstacle caused by sanctions. But alas, as I said earlier, dialogue can rarely change the perspectives and interests of counterparts.

Despite all twists and turns, Iran-Russia ties experienced significant progress. The first achievement of the JCPOA with regards to Russia was the delivery of S-300 air defense missile system to Iran. A key point here is often ignored. Air defense missiles systems are defensive weapons which were not subject to sales bans under Security Council resolutions. Therefore, S-300 sales to Iran were not banned. Another piece of evidence corroborating this contention is the timing of its delivery to Iran. Pursuant to Annex B of Resolution 2231, arms restrictions were lifted in October 2020 while Iran took delivery of Russian S-300 system shortly after the JCPOA was implemented in 2016.

The reason for the delay in the delivery of air defense missile systems to Iran before the JCPOA lay in a global security consensus against Iran, which made it costly for Russia to have close ties with Iran. The JCPOA broke the Iran "securitization" project. In its Preface, Resolution 2231 said the JCPOA will "mark a fundamental shift" in the UN Security Council's handling of the Iran nuclear issue. It was under this new atmosphere that Russia was able to deliver S-300 systems to Iran. If we optimistically view Russia's invitation to Gen. Soleimani after the JCPOA was approved, we can say that the JCPOA made it possible for the Russians to receive Gen. Soleimani. Why did they refuse to receive him before the JCPOA? In August 2015, apart from the JCPOA, what else happened that they agreed after months of procrastination to receive Gen. Soleimani? No sanctions

were yet lifted and even Resolution 2231 had not taken effect. So why did they invite him?

Giving Russia the benefit of the doubt, the JCPOA de-securitized Iran, thereby clearing the way for Iran's stronger presence in the region. That is why Russia agreed to cooperate with us in Syria. As a Security Council member, Russia was not ready for strategic cooperation with a country under Chapter VII resolutions. As a reminder, in response to the Ahmadinejad administration's application for full membership in the Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO), it had been decided—upon Russian initiative—that a country under UN sanctions could not become a full member. As Minister Lavrov said after the JCPOA agreement, this barrier was removed after Resolution 2231 took effect. It should be always kept in mind that Russia's permanent membership in the UN Security Council is one of the most effective leverages left for Russia on the global scale. Thus, Security Council as an institution and respect for its resolutions are of strategic significance for Russia, far beyond mere legal and international obligations.

President Rouhani and President Putin had numerous constructive meetings. President Putin visited Iran twice and Minister Lavrov four times. Reciprocally, President Rouhani visited Moscow on several occasions, and I visited Russia roughly 30 times. That indicated the extent of ties during the eight years of the Rouhani Administration, which ended in instrumental agreements. In addition to military cooperation, positive developments transpired Iran-Russia ties on the international scene. By March 2018, Russia vetoed a Security Council resolution on Yemen because it negatively referred to Iran twice in its preface. Russia had not vetoed any nuclear resolution when the Ahmadinejad Administrations was in office in Iran. Resolution 2216 on Yemen was also supposed to be vetoed by Russia, but as Minister Lavrov told me, Saudi King Salman's last-minute phone call to President Putin the night before voting made Russia abstain.

Another positive achievement in Tehran-Moscow ties was Russia's constant support of Iran's membership in the SCO following the entry into force of Resolution 2231. That takes on added significance when we take into account the fact that upon Russia's initiative, Iran had been banned

from SCO membership under the pretext of Security Council resolutions. Nonetheless, without producing any evidence, some attribute Tajikistan's six-year opposition to Iran's membership to Chinese reluctance, but evidently Russian president and foreign minister covertly and overtly endorsed Iran's membership, which came to fruition in spring 2021.

Another sign was Russia's support for Iranian membership in the Eurasian Economic Union (EAEU). Given Iran's tough trade regulations, in the absence of Russia's political will, the first step for Iran's integration would have not taken place. As long as sanctions are in effect, EAEU membership can be more lucrative for Iran than membership of other bodies.

Negative votes by Russia and China against IAEA Board of Governors' resolutions under the Rouhani and Raisi Administrations are positive and unprecedented events in Iran-Russia ties. In the wake of President Trump's unilateral withdrawal from the JCPOA, Russia's constructive cooperation in supporting Iran's legal position to halt application of the mechanism set forth in Article 36 of the JCPOA by the three European signatories of the agreement proved to be decisive and effective. Minister Lavrov's 15 January 2020 letter addressed to the EU foreign policy chief was instrumental in defeating the EU's policy of pressure on Iran. As Josep Borrell had just taken office, the European troika saw the time ripe to deny the existence of any record of Iranian invocation of paragraph 36 of the JCPOA. The official written endorsement of Iranian position by Russia and China brought that abuse of the mechanism to an immediate halt in January-February 2020.

The Russian foreign minister's effective dismissal of US proposal to the Security Council for extending arms embargo, through a letter dated 14 June 2020 to the Secretary General of the UN and the President of the Security Council, followed by Russia and China voting against President Trump's proposed resolution to the Security Council are among unprecedented examples of Russia's political support for the Islamic Republic under our administration.

Positive outcomes were not limited to the political domain. Russia's agreement to purchase Iranian oil was a fruitful result of the JCPOA. But as it was said earlier, Iran imagined that Russia would view this agreement strategically and therefore it did not come to fruition. The first blow was

struck after news of agreement was revealed, only to be followed by the second blow which was dealt by extended bargaining and low profits for Russia from the planned oil deal. President Putin did not see any strategic benefit in this agreement. After its revelation in the press, it had imposed strategic costs too. Under what condition would Putin agree to do so? Only in case it would be economically lucrative. Iran was not ready to give significant economic profits to Russia because the assumption was that Russia would help Iran because of its own strategic interests.

Iran was trying to offer the minimum discount possible in oil prices to Russia. Meantime, National Iranian Oil Co. (NIOC) was offering more discounts to buyers of Iranian oil as it was struggling to bust sanctions. President Putin said Russian companies would finally have to sell Iranian oil to other buyers, but Iran was already selling its oil directly to potential buyers at discounts which it did not give to Russia.

The agreement envisaged by the Iranian president rested on Russia processing Iranian oil in its domestic refineries for domestic consumption and exporting its own oil. The advantage for Russia would be that it could export more oil and rival Saudi Arabia more effectively to finally find a higher place in global markets. But Russia was not ready or willing to rival Saudi oil. It preferred to take Iranian market and sell oil to the same buyers of Iranian oil. That would be detrimental to Iran in the long term. The Ministry of Petroleum was well aware of the consequences. Minister Bijan Zangeneh was right in noting that a traditional buyer of Iranian oil that wants to buy our oil smuggled into Russia via a Russian front company had better buy directly from Iran at a discount. Instead of supplying oil at cut-price to Russia which would pocket profits and resell it to our own customers, we would sell directly to our customer at cut-price and make profits. Meantime, we would not be giving our market to Russia in the long term either. Based on such financial and operational scrutiny the deal never materialized. The failure of oil negotiations resulted from our cognitive deficit. As stated earlier, in my view most of our foreign policy challenges are due to our inaccurate view of our own standing as well as main international actors' game that would finally turn into a Gordian knot.

Despite all these hardships, we reached good agreements with Russia. First, we took delivery of S-300 systems. We struck major military

agreements with Russia, including for the purchase of Su-35 warplanes that faced financial hurdles. We also reached lucrative deals like the Garmsar-Incheboron railway and the Silik power plant construction. They were useful projects, but they hit snags in Iran from the very start. The Russians concluded that they were not our preference. After overcoming difficulties inside Iran, challenges started inside Russia with President Trump's sanctions. Top Russian companies were unwilling to be exposed to US sanctions and pulled out. The enterprises that were ready to operate projects were little-known and even front companies, which Iran could not trust to sign agreement with. Therefore, all these projects that had been initiated before Washington's exit from JCPOA got nowhere up to the end of the Rouhani administration.

Meantime, another seemingly lucrative proposal proved, one more time, Russia's serious attempt to prevent any normalization of Iran-West ties. In the final months leading to the JCPOA agreement and after Russia's annexation of Crimea in 2014, we heard that Russia had placed an order with Iran's MAPNA that manufactured turbines under Siemens license to manufacture turbines for the Crimea power plant. MAPNA is the licensee, competitor and customer of Siemens at the same time. The Russians did not ask MAPNA to supply them its own turbines; rather, they placed order for a specific Siemens turbine that MAPNA manufactured under license. Europe had imposed an embargo on Russia due to the annexation of Crimea and Russia was seeking MAPNA's assistance to supply a turbine manufactured under European license to a powerplant under European sanctions. What was most valuable for Russia was to pit the Europeans against Iran. In order to test the waters, MAPNA suggested to supply Russia with turbines destined for a Russian power plant and then Russia could use the similar turbine in that plant for Crimea. As it was predicted, Russia dismissed the proposal. This apparently commercial deal was so important for Russia that it was raised in the meeting between the Iranian and Russian presidents, and they heard our previous response. Our totally justified decision proved to Russia that Iran was not ready to expose itself to European sanctions in favor of Russia.

That proved two key points. First, normalization of Iran-West ties was Russia's red line. Second, which is more important, we should not expect

any country to bear costs of violating sanctions imposed on Iran. We also refused to expose ourselves to sanctions for our “strategic neighbor”, i.e. Russia. In Iran, everyone expects Iraq, Russia, China and Turkey to not comply with the Iran sanctions. But were we ready to violate the sanctions against Russia? Did we accept to expose MAPNA to European sanctions to have helped our “strategic partner” and neighbor? Then how do we expect Russia’s Lukoil to take the risk? Why do we expect Russia to expose Rosneft to sanctions? Russia can also establish a front company to blunt the impact of sanctions and face less penalty. So will do China. Therefore, our challenge is cognitive. Once more, the distance between aspirations and realities.

Every time I expressed these words, I heard: “Are you Russia’s foreign minister?” I regularly hear this insult. In response, I said: “No! I’m Iran’s foreign minister. I have been betrayed extensively by Russia throughout my career from Resolution 598 talks to JCPOA talks. But I don’t want my country’s government to go astray and have undue expectations.”¹⁰⁴

When the Islamic Republic, which often adopts emotional policies—refuses to violate European sanctions against Russia, how does it expect Russia, whose policy is always based on cold cost benefit calculations—to sacrifice its interests for Iran? The Russians have gained fame for being frosty in politics. They seek immediate profits and they are frank. The Americans think of long-term benefits and behave in a more sophisticated manner. In the final years of his mission in Iran, the former Russian ambassador Levan Dzhagaryan had adopted a non-diplomatic and even impolite language. Senior officials insisted that I remind Russia of the necessity for its ambassador to change his tone. They were right and Dzhagaryan was speaking from a position not befitting an ambassador. But I told Iranian leaders that Russia has always acted in the same direct and frosty method and it would most probably continue to do so. That is Russia’s vision and *modus operandi*. As it was noted earlier, Russia is largely interested in the “Great Powers Game” and therefore, it recognizes

¹⁰⁴ Of course, those strategic miscalculations led to the blunder in Ukraine under the Raisi administration. But as I had always expected and noted in this book before the 12-day war, our suicidal support was not reciprocated by Russia when Iran needed its military assistance during Israeli and American aggression.

no country other than great powers as a potential ally or even partner. In its own view, Russia has satellites. You have to know this in the Russian political culture. Russia has partners and friends. It says, “Western partners”, but “Iranian friends” or “Syrian friends”. I never heard Russia say, “Syrian partners”. The Russians are very direct and maybe cold in such simple expressions and that is a fact.

Over the past forty years, I have seen the same *modus operandi* from the Soviets and later from Russians. My first experience in dealing with Russia dates to the 1980s at the UN General Assembly Third Committee. Soviet representative suggested a joint procedural motion against two separate resolutions proposed on situations of human rights in Afghanistan and Iran. We were at the extreme opposite ends of spectrum with the Soviet Union. Those who voted in our favor were opposed to the Soviet occupation of Afghanistan. But my Soviet counterpart said in a very direct manner: “Either you join us for joint action against the two resolutions on human rights in Iran and Afghanistan and in return we will try our best to win. Otherwise, we will ensure that you will be defeated”. This is the *modus operandi* of Russia: direct, cold and diktat-like.

My personal relationship with Sergey Lavrov began in 1994 when he was named Russia’s ambassador to the UN while I was serving as deputy minister of foreign affairs for legal and international affairs. I travelled to the UN several times a year. Especially, when I visited New York frequently to follow up on the issue of Dialogue among Civilizations, I met with Sergey Lavrov on several occasions and we became friends. From 2002 to 2004, both of us were Permanent Representatives to the UN, which strengthened our friendship. When he became Russia’s foreign minister, 10 years had already passed since our friendship started. Despite a 10-year distance between his ministerial promotion and my return, we knew one another and understood each other’s language. We were both familiar with the language of international law and organizations. We understood each other deeply and we could not easily cheat on one another.

Regarding the so-called “snapback” mechanism, Minister Lavrov had applied his skills and used the Security Council language to conceal his mischievous design in protecting Russian paramount interest in safeguarding its veto privilege. Only those who know the Security Council’s

practice and vocabulary could realize the intent behind his attractive wordings. Under normal conditions, a diplomat, even a UN diplomat, does not acquire a sufficient mastery of the Security Council's language. After the Islamic Revolution, Iran has never been a Security Council member, but due to my responsibility in New York during the Iraqi imposed war on Iran as well as the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait, I had followed Security Council meetings. The topic of my PhD dissertation was also "self-defense" and I had studied the details of Security Council meetings and resolutions on the subject. Therefore, I was familiar with the language of the Security Council. Lavrov had also served as Russia's UN ambassador for ten years after having served as deputy foreign minister for international affairs. After his mission ended at the UN, he became foreign minister.

Minister Lavrov's dexterity and maturity may be unrivalled in the world. Therefore, Russia is not ready to lose him easily. A skillful diplomat, he has been foreign minister since 2004. In Russia's history, only Andrei Andreyevich Gromyko had served as the foreign minister of the Soviet Union for nearly 30 years. Igor Ivanov was minister for six years and other foreign ministers had served only two to three years.

Multilateral diplomacy has never received adequate attention even in the community of political science and international relations. It has been seriously underestimated, particularly in Realist theories. In Iran, political science and international relations have not sufficiently understood the *raison d'être* and complexity of multilateral bodies. In multidisciplinary sciences, understanding the Security Council is of high significance. Owing to his long record at the Security Council, Lavrov is endowed with such expertise. Therefore, along with France, he sought – and failed -- to incorporate a self-serving mechanism into the JCPOA.

The experience of shuttling "snapback" drafts indicates the opportunistic flip flops of U.S. negotiators. Over the course of the JCPOA, the Americans showed on many occasions that if any opportunity comes up, they will not hesitate to renege on their own pledges and take advantage of it in their own interests. Such conduct stands squarely opposed to a common perception among our intellectuals that "the Americans negotiate fairly". My experience of negotiations with the U.S. in JCPOA corrected my own impression of American negotiating behavior before the JCPOA talks.

I knew quite well that the Americans were very skilled in managing opportunities, but I never imagined they would be so skillful in flip flopping without a shred of shame.

During the second round of the negotiations for Geneva interim deal, the French stood against the Americans. For France, opposition to being sidelined was a matter of prestige. However, after France's position, the US took advantage of it for raising excessive demands and wresting concessions from Iran regardless of its previous bilateral agreements with Iran. France relented, but the Americans did not back down. However, in the end, the Americans failed to score any gains in the text of the interim deal through their unethical opportunism.

Allegations by Sergey Lavrov

After the adoption of JCPOA in Summer 2015 and also following the purported restoration of terminated Security Council resolutions in 2025, my longtime friend and colleague made a number of unfounded allegations against me and my colleagues in our capacity as Iranian JCPOA negotiator. They involved our acceptance of arms restrictions and the so-called "snapback" provision of the JCPOA against the advice and disagreement from Russia and China. These allegations were unsolicitedly repeated in his interview with the IRIB in December 2025. During my tenure and in the years since, I have consistently regarded any form of East-phobia or West-phobia as detrimental to Iran's national interests, and have instead emphasized the necessity of a comprehensive balance in foreign policy. I have repeatedly stressed that close and constructive relations with the Russian Federation, as an important neighbor and a permanent member of the UN Security Council, are essential. This assessment is articulated at length in this book.

The Russian delegation's role in shaping the Security Council snapback mechanism was meticulously reported four years ago in *The Untold Story of the JCPOA*. Mr. Lavrov's unusual assertions even contradict the memoirs and interviews of other senior negotiators, including Wendy Sherman, who explicitly praised Mr. Lavrov's role in preserving Russia's

veto rights—a mechanism that inevitably also preserved U.S. veto power in the so-called “snapback” process¹⁰⁵.

For the sake of historical clarity, it must be recalled that Russia, as a permanent member of the Security Council, voted in favor of all Chapter VII resolutions against Iran during the Ahmadinejad administrations. From the outset of negotiations, Russia was strongly opposed to the termination of Security Council resolutions. In discussions with John Kerry, Mr. Lavrov reportedly characterized the Iranian delegation’s insistence on the immediate termination of those resolutions as “idiotic”¹⁰⁶.

Although, through sustained effort by the Iranian negotiating team, the termination of resolutions was ultimately achieved, Russia consistently advocated suspension rather than termination¹⁰⁷. Without the knowledge of the Iranian delegation, Russia cooperated with France in submitting a draft text that would have only suspended resolutions for renewable six months periods, effectively rendering termination impossible. While this draft was eventually excluded from the final agreement due to Iranian intervention, even some Iranian observers initially failed to recognize its legal implications—an oversight later exploited extensively by domestic critics. Contrary to Mr. Lavrov’s claim that the so-called “snapback” resulted from a last-minute agreement between Kerry and me, *The Untold Story* documents—by date and participants—that reversibility (dubbed as snapback by the West for political purposes) had been discussed since May 2014 following Iran’s decision to abandon phased implementation. The final text resulted from collective negotiations from March to July 2015. In this struggle over text, Russia—like other permanent members—acted against Iran’s interests, even collaborating with France on a draft that only sought to preserve their own Security Council veto privileges to the detriment of Iran.

During the Montreux, Switzerland negotiations held from 1 to 4 March 2015, the U.S. delegation claimed that “Russia, like the United States, opposes the immediate lifting of all UN Security Council sanctions.” In

¹⁰⁵ Wendy Sherman, *Not for the Faint of Heart: Lessons in Courage, Power, and Persistence* (PublicAffairs, 2018), p. 180.

¹⁰⁶ *The Untold Story*, (Vol. 3, p. 199)

¹⁰⁷ (Vol. 4, p. 246)

those same talks, Lavrov emphasized to me that, in order to preserve the credibility of the Security Council, a mechanism had to be found for the suspension—and ultimately the termination—of the Council's sanctions. Suspension, he argued, should constitute the initial step, with full termination to follow after the IAEA confirmed the absence of any diversion and the non-existence of any program, or any plan, to build a bomb¹⁰⁸. Given the Agency's methods and record, however, this approach rendered the lifting of Security Council sanctions virtually impossible and would have kept Iran permanently entangled with the Security Council.

During the 9–10 April 2015 meetings in Lausanne, Switzerland, while opposing the automatic re-imposition of Security Council resolutions, I called for the establishment of a three-member arbitration committee. All permanent members of the Security Council, including Russia and China, stated unequivocally that they were “in no way prepared to delegate their sovereign rights to another party”¹⁰⁹.

At the end of April 2015, in Vienna, the Russian delegation announced that Moscow had accepted the Western-proposed mechanism. Their reasoning was also made explicit: there was no alternative, but under this solution a heavy political cost would at least be imposed on the United States—or any other country—seeking to trigger the return of the resolutions¹¹⁰.

It appeared that Russia, in light of developments related to Ukraine, found itself in a relatively stronger position vis-à-vis Europe and the United States and had therefore resolved to reduce tensions with the West. As a result, Moscow showed no inclination to confront the Western members on any aspect of the nuclear negotiations¹¹¹.

As for the claim on arms restrictions, following the conclusion of the negotiations, Lavrov, stated in an interview in Moscow—an interview that has been widely used in Iran against me—that Russia had opposed the continuation of the arms-related restrictions but had nevertheless gone along with them because of Zarif's agreement¹¹².

¹⁰⁸ (Vol. 4, p. 246)

¹⁰⁹ (Vol. 4, p. 290)

¹¹⁰ (Vol. 5, p. 45)

¹¹¹ (Vol. 5, p. 199)

¹¹² (Vol. 5, p. 456)

In Volume Five of *The Untold Story*, our intense efforts to lift these sanctions are described in detail. The well-known remark “Never threaten an Iranian” was also made in this very context. The outcome of these efforts was that the strict sanctions contained in resolutions that had been adopted with Russia’s consent were converted into positively worded restrictions for a period of five years.

Despite its declared opposition to the arms embargo, Russia took no practical steps to lift or even restrict it and instead aligned itself with the Western parties on this issue, a point documented in detail in the book.

On 1 July 2015, during the final round of negotiations in Vienna, Lavrov noted that some parties had divided the arms embargo into two categories—“imports” and “exports”—and had proposed separating the two, adding that Iran did not appear to attach great importance to this distinction. I responded with complete clarity: “*...we have a problem with the very principle of sanctions.*”¹¹³

The strongest pressure exerted on me by Sergey Lavrov to accept the Western proposal regarding arms restrictions occurred in the final hours of 13 July 2015. As mentioned earlier, when I entered Kerry’s room, Lavrov immediately asked me: “*Why don’t you accept these five years? Rest assured, they*”—gesturing toward the Western parties—“*will not give you anything better than this.*”¹¹⁴

In my view, previously articulated in this volume, Russia opposes both normalization of Iran-West relations and direct military confrontation between Iran and the West, the latter of which Moscow anticipates would ultimately weaken Iran and paradoxically lead to normalization on unfavorable terms. Based on this traditional strategy, Russia played a very positive role in the Geneva Interim Agreement negotiations in autumn 2013 but adopted a different approach with the start of comprehensive negotiations in winter 2014.

For instance, under the Geneva Interim Agreement, Iran could enrich uranium according to its needs. Accordingly, during the second round of comprehensive solution negotiations, the Iranian delegation informed P51+

¹¹³ (Vol. 5, p. 385)

¹¹⁴ (Vol. 5, p. 453)

experts that Iran required 190,000 SWU to fuel the Bushehr power plant. Russian diplomats, however, stated that Russia would supply Bushehr's fuel throughout its lifetime. This contention rendered Iran's definition of its "practical needs" inappropriate and created a profound challenge.¹¹⁵

During the sixth and seventh rounds of negotiations in July 2014, Russia strongly opposed including Bushehr among Iran's practical needs, even proposing that Iran's needs be defined solely based on two research reactors—only 8,000 SWU¹¹⁶. Despite the tense U.S.–Russia relationship over Ukraine, extraordinary cooperation between them against Iran existed. In one meeting, the U.S. delegation stated that Russia had promised to refrain from cooperating on joint fuel production in Iran throughout the comprehensive agreement period (which the U.S. wanted to be 20 years). Mr. Lavrov similarly told me that, from Russia's perspective, joint fuel production in Iran was impossible¹¹⁷. Russia went as far as threatening to withdraw its safety assurances of Bushehr if fuel produced in Iran were to be used¹¹⁸.

Additional examples could be added to this list. It should be noted, however, that on numerous occasions the Russian delegation also came to Iran's assistance. All such instances are transparently and faithfully documented in *The Untold Story*, where interested readers can consult the book to compare our fair and balanced account with Lavrov's portrayal. I have also repeatedly expressed my appreciation for the support provided by Russia and China in the face of the United States' and Europe's breaches of their commitments. I hope that Iran and Russia, as two important neighbors, will move beyond the bitterness of both the distant and the recent past and strive to expand their relations in a manner that serves the interests of the two great nations of Iran and Russia.

Relations of Choice or Necessity

For many in the Iranian society and polity relations are often viewed through need rather than merit. For instance, if you ask "why should we

¹¹⁵ (Vol. 2, pp. 243–244)

¹¹⁶ (Vol. 3, p. 7, fn. 2).

¹¹⁷ (Vol. 3, p. 292, fn. 1)

¹¹⁸ (Vol. 4, pp. 24–25)

have ties with Turkey? Or why should we have ties with Afghanistan and Iran”, the usual response is: “We have no other option”. In other words, if we could sell gas to Europe, we would not sell it to Turkey. If we could trade with a rich country, we would not focus on trade with Afghanistan. If we could develop ties with the West, we would not go towards China and Russia. If we could import Mercedes Benz, we would not import Chinese vehicles. For many Iranians, relations with many countries are an out of desperation or as means of leveraging pressure for ties with others, and not because of the essential merits of such relations.

Such vision will yield two results: First, we do not reach our objective because the opposite parties will eventually realize that we have gone to them as a means of last resort or to achieve other ends. When they realize to what extent we are desperate, they will raise the bar. In other words, this approach will not enable us to benefit from our counterparts but will help them realize how valuable they are for us. Second, our counterparts will not seek a long-term relation with us because they realize two points: that from our perspective, the ties are not based on their own merits and are merely short-term bridges to more lasting relations with our preferred partners; and that we are desperate with no other alternative. The two combined will lead our counterparts to consider the relations as temporary, not worthy of any long-term investment. Therefore, they should exact as high a return for those short-term relations. Worse yet, they know that we have to pay that premium because we are desperate; otherwise, we would not have gone to them.

We must realize that our counterparts realize – and believe me, they do sooner or later – from our behavior that we are not a permanent partner with whom they can depend on and plan accordingly. For a permanent trade or political partner, a concession today will yield big returns for years to come, in which case those concessions become a rational choice. But if they are convinced that we have turned toward them out of need, it will not only be rational to give any concession but instead to exact a premium. Many of our partners outside Europe perceive that they are our desperate choices. That makes us a very inexpensive partner.

Another cognitive challenge is that some wrongly view others as ignorant or easily fooled. For some, that rule even applies to human

relations. However, to be a successful negotiator, the assumption should be that the opposite party is always smarter or at least as smart.

We should realize that Russia is our neighbor and China is a rising power and already the top trading partner of most countries in the world. Merit-based relations of choice and not necessity mean even if we have the best of relations with the U.S., we should have ties with China. Which one is more vital for China: ties with Saudi Arabia or with Iran? Doubtlessly, ties with the Saudis. Saudi Arabia is a U.S. ally, but it has chosen to maintain strong ties with China too. However, China does not need to depend solely on Saudi Arabia for its energy supply because it already knows that Iran has no option but to sell its oil to China. For this purpose, it can replace the entire oil it receives from Iran and know that Iran will always be there whenever China needs oil. In 2011, Iran was the top supplier of oil to China. As sanctions were tightened from 2011 to 2013, Saudi Arabia, Iraq and other countries replaced Iran, thereby driving Iran down to 5th position. China was receiving less than 70,000 b/d from Iran. After the JCPOA, it raised it to 600,000 b/d, before being slashed to below 100,000 b/d due to President Trump's maximum pressure policy. China met its remaining oil needs through Saudi Arabia and Iraq among others. That had no impact on China's economy. In 2023, China's official oil imports from Iran were far below 100,000 b/d, but it was receiving hundreds of thousands of oil barrels a day from Iran at huge discount and under terms decided unilaterally by Beijing. China is assured that Iran has no option but to sell in whatever way China decides. Therefore, it imposes unfavorable conditions on Iran and still considers this a huge favor.

Russia has a similar status. It is a neighbor, a key global player and top regional power. We have cooperation with Russia in many fields, and we are Caspian Sea neighbors. Russia supplies our military and nuclear needs. If one day we can procure our military needs from the West, we should still preserve Russia; otherwise, the Western governments would not show any flexibility and compromise. Therefore, ties with Russia should be merit-based ties of choice and not necessity. So should be our ties with China and the West.

In other words, the diversity of ties in foreign relations is vital and only diverse ties can bring balance. The opposite party should also recognize

you as a reliable partner and not a rainy-day partner. For a large segment of Iranian polity, our partnership with China and Russia is not a matter of choice but of necessity and even desperation.

When financial sanctions were imposed under President Ahmadinejad, Iran owned more than \$20 billion assets in China, but it was entirely frozen and the Chinese did not or could not release them. His Administration reached an admittedly one-sided agreement with China because in time of desperation, any agreement would naturally tilt in favor of the opposite party. China agreed to hold Iranian financial assets as collateral—which is highly unusual in inter-state economic relation. In return, China agreed to finance its own projects in Iran. The mechanism worked out in this deal required Iran to take loans from China, which would be subject to interest and insurance. No country would offer its own money as collateral for a loan. Therefore, this “one-to-one” agreement was totally one-sided. But under the Ahmadinejad Administration, it had been accepted out of necessity as a means of last resort to make some use of those otherwise frozen assets.

Some friends in our Administration compared it to the Treaty of Turkmenchay. The MFA believed that although it was a desperate one-sided agreement, it had been reached between the Islamic Republic and China and therefore it should not be subject to bargaining anew; rather, we must create conditions for more balanced future agreements. As soon as the Rouhani Administration came to office, Iran offered a \$50 billion investment package to China. The Chinese leader replied: “After Iranian projects have been implemented up to the ceiling of the previous agreement, a new agreement shall be signed based on new mechanisms for another \$50 billion”. Iran said: “Times have changed”, which meant we no longer need to abide by that agreement. Efforts to modify the agreement got nowhere and the same agreement that had not been implemented under Ahmadinejad was implemented under Rouhani. But we confirmed to China with that one brief phrase that we consider our ties with China as relations of necessity and not choice.

Iran and Russia in Syria

The undeniable fact is that Like other nations, Russia was not prepared to push for the recognition of Iran's standing in Syria. Iran was not invited to international forums on Syria and Russia did not insist on Iran's presence either. After the JCPOA was signed, the United States invited Iran to those meetings. Once Secretary Kerry said: "Let's sit together and resolve the Syria crisis. We are the main powers. Let's set aside these jokers". But we were not authorized to interact directly with the U.S. on anything other than the nuclear issue. Therefore, we did not engage in bilateral talks, but we were invited to multilateral talks on Syria. Before the JCPOA, Iran was never invited. Even at the start of our Administration, the UN Secretary General had invited me to Syria Geneva II peace talks in Montreux, Switzerland, but he withdrew his invitation after Saudi Arabia threatened to boycott the talks due to Iran's presence. The JCPOA helped defeat a global securitization consensus against Iran, which enabled Tehran to join key processes as a vital actor at the regional and global levels.

In previous chapters, I highlighted the securitization project on several occasions. It may be noteworthy to highlight a key point regarding the international consequences of securitization of a country. Securitization implies that a nation or a case is presented as a threat to national, regional or global community; such threat may be either solid-based and aggrandized or even fabricated. In some cases, threats target another sector, like Iran's regional influence and Israeli concerns, but the threat is constructed in another form to draw concerns from others too. That could be exemplified in Iran's alleged attempt to develop nuclear weapons or sponsoring of terrorism. To that end, messages of securitization are dexterously insinuated into local, regional and even global audience's minds so as to convince them about the existence of a common threat. The most notable manifestation of success of a securitization process and formation of global security consensus against a target nation is falling under Chapter VII of the UN Charter by the Security Council.

Contrary to a baseless idea some have developed in our society, Chapter VII is not limited to Article 42, i.e., UN-backed collective military action; rather, it covers Articles 39-51. Chapter VII's title is "Action with Respect to Threats to the Peace, Breaches of the Peace, and Acts of Aggression". Therefore, when the Security Council issues a resolution "acting" under

any article of this chapter, it means that a security consensus has been constructed against a country or an issue on the grounds that Security Council members have deemed it at least to pose a “threat to peace”.

It becomes costly to cooperate with a country or group against which a global security consensus has been constructed. Therefore, securitization reduces the global costs of harming the target. That is why before Iran’s case was removed from Chapter VII under Resolution 2231, it was not invited to international peace talks on Syria. Nor Russia was ready to cooperate with Iran or even fulfil its obligations. For instance, Russia refused to deliver S-300 missile systems to Iran although anti-aircraft missile systems – as defensive weapons – faced no bans under Security Council resolutions. Nor did SCO accept to examine Iran’s full membership application. They were all consequences of the security consensus built against Iran. Iran’s freedom of action in the Syrian diplomacy and battlefield was the achievement of the JCPOA and the reversal – albeit temporary as it was made – of 40-year securitization project against the Islamic Republic.

In the aftermath of the JCPOA and Iran’s return to regional and international interactions, our country became a pivotal partner in Syrian peace talks. The talks came to a halt under President Trump, and his successor President Biden did not resume them. But Secretary Kerry said in an international forum on Syria that Resolution 2254 on Syria had been adopted based on a four-point proposal submitted by Iran; a proposal we had drafted in consultation with Gen. Soleimani, Hassan Nasrallah, and Bashar Assad at the beginning of my tenure.

Iran’s new global standing enabled the country to become a major participant in a variety of affairs. Again, optimistically, Russia could cooperate with Iran in Syria. In other words, cooperation with Iran was no longer costly after the conclusion of the JCPOA. Before the JCPOA, Russia was not ready for cooperation – at least overt – with us. In the midst of tough challenges in Syria in early 2015, Gen. Soleimani asked for a meeting with President Putin. Aided by Iran and particularly Gen. Soleimani’s personal leadership, Syria overcome all those difficulties, but President Putin refused to meet with Gen. Soleimani before the conclusion of the JCPOA in July 2015.

After the JCPOA, in President Putin's meeting with Gen. Soleimani, Russia had two main requests from Iran about Syria. The first one, Russia's use of Iranian airspace to fire missiles on Takfiri terrorists in Syria. To strike targets in Syria, Russia did not need Iran's space, having military bases in Syria and in the Mediterranean. So why did it insist on using Iran's airspace? As mentioned earlier, it was aimed at blocking any normalization of Iran-West ties. President Putin's second request was deployment of Iranian ground forces in Syria. That would destroy all bridges for normalizing relations between Iran and the West. Therefore, the second request pursued the same objective as the first request. It would be difficult to consider any other strategic objective behind President Putin's two requests.

Relying on its deep-seated clout with the Baath Party and Syrian military, Russia enjoyed a pivotal position in decision-makings in Syria, and it was by no means ready to give Iran any share. Russia signed a deconfliction agreement with the United States in Syria. It had also struck deals with Israel, most of which were to the detriment of Iran, even overstepping Iran's red lines. Of course, such policies are to be expected in international relations. We should have expected them. In the final months leading to his assassination, Gen. Soleimani, in our weekly meetings or before my visits to Russia, complained extensively about the Russian troops' conduct in Syria and their neglect of Iran's warnings and concerns.

The Russians often excluded us. They reached agreement with the United States, Israel or Turkey without our knowledge and pressured Bashar Assad to comply. For example, after Iranian-backed multinational volunteers operating in Syria made courageous sacrifices to retake Aleppo from Takfiri terrorists, Russia and Turkey agreed on the relocation of Takfiri terrorists from Aleppo to Idleb. This was their routine everywhere. In coordination with Turkey, Russia evacuated the Takfiris and relocated them to Idleb despite Iran opposition—a Turkish trap that eventually led to the fall of Assad through a pool of proxies ready to undertake operations demanded by Turkey from Syria to Armenia. Idlib turned into a hotbed of crisis, an extremist and terrorist camp and a permanent source for Turkish proxy forces. But Russia had taken this risk in order to satisfy Turkey and President Recep Tayyip Erdogan in person. President

Putin's treatment of President Erdogan sounded strange to observers and indicated a specific strategy. No president would like to see his own country's warplane downed or see his ambassador assassinated in another country. Had these instances of violence occurred in any other country than Turkey or Turkey had any other president than Mr. Erdogan, Russia would have definitely reacted harshly.

Anyway, Gen. Soleimani contacted me, asking me to tell Lavrov: "As long as Shias in the two villages of al-Fu'ah and Kafriya¹¹⁹ are not evacuated, we will not let the Takfiris leave Aleppo". Gen. Soleimani asked forces deployed in Syria to stop buses evacuating Takfiris. The buses carrying these terrorists and families were stopped in the desert. One Takfiri was killed in the skirmishes that ensued. A pregnant woman gave birth to her child. A strange situation was emerging.

General Soleimani had notified the Russian military commander and asked me to inform Minister Lavrov. They sent buses to evacuate some residents of al-Fu'ah and Kafriya, but the Takfiri terrorists did not let the project go as planned. The evacuation of Takfiris from Aleppo was completed. It was clear that Russia had pressured Assad who had, in turn, asked Gen. Soleimani via a reliable intermediary to allow the Aleppo evacuation. The Russians made their decisions and as usual they ratcheted up the pressure on the Syrian government to proceed with their own plan, thereby excluding us.

Another similar instance: Iran mediated meetings between Syrian and Turkish intelligence chiefs. These meetings were secret and never made public. But out of the sudden, Russia took Syria's then security chief Ali Mamlouk and his Turkish then counterpart Hakan Fidan to Moscow and revealed their meeting to the press. The Russians largely undermined Iranian mediation between Syria and Turkey. Under the Raisi Administration, three-way meetings were held between Russia, Turkey and Syria without informing Iran. It was only after an extensive diplomatic effort that Iran was invited.

¹¹⁹ These two villages in Idleb Province had been under siege by the Takfiris and they received food supply only by air.

For the observers who have studied Russia's foreign policy, these cases were natural, historical and constant, thereby indicating no hostility against Iran. On the one hand, it should not trigger any grudge against Russia while on the other, realities should not be overshadowed to give rise to incorrect analyses. I think that Iran helped Russia in Syria more than Russia helped Iran. Like every other great power, Russia took advantage of Iran's sacrifice in Syria as an instrumental tool in favor of its own policies. Iran has not been an idle actor, but any planning should be made based on sufficient information.

Russia is Iran's strongest rival in Syria. However, Russia is an undeniable reality in Syria. It was present there before Iran's Islamic Revolution and has taken root in all key centers, particularly the Army and the Baath party. Having kept this fact in mind, we told Minister Lavrov and other Russian officials that Iran did not seek to rival Russia in Syria, but to no avail.

The final chapter of Assad's rule in Syria and Russia's rather friendly engagement with his successors—as contrasted with their open hostility towards Iran—which occurred nearly two years after the publication of this book corroborate some of the contentions made here. It seems that there had been coordination behind our back between most players including Russia, Turkey, Israel, United States and Jolani—possibly even Assad.

Astana Process

With the foregoing background, it would be worthwhile to discuss the Astana peace process. In 2015, we learnt that Russia was in high-level consultations with Turkey about Syria. We also had our own bilateral arrangements with Turkey on Syria. Along with Gen. Soleimani, I met regularly with the president, foreign minister and intelligence chief of Turkey in Ankara and Tehran for serious and frank talks, but it was under news blackout. However, Turkey and Russia openly launched such initiative, and their foreign and defense ministers openly held joint meetings.

Therefore, we proposed a trilateral meeting. Russia suggested a six-party forum, including foreign and defense ministers of the three countries. I travelled to Moscow along with the then minister of defense, Gen. Hossein Dehqan. Upon our arrival in Moscow, we received instructions from the

SNSC Secretariat that Gen. Dehqan should not attend six-way talks, and he can meet bilaterally with his counterparts. The three-way meeting was held between foreign ministers, kick starting the Astana peace process.

Unfortunately, due to cancellation of the six-way forum, military agreements for the Astana process were struck only between Russia and Turkey and the relevant documents were signed by Russian and Turkish military officials and registered at the UN. That communication continues to exist and key military agreements have been implemented between Turkey and Russia. Needless to say, the de-confliction is primarily a military affair. For this reason, the first deconfliction agreement in Astana has been registered at the UN under the signatures of Russia and Turkey. The second agreement, signed in Sochi on Idlib, was again signed between Russia and Turkey. So is the agreement on Turkish military deployment to Syria.

In the wake of sudden instructions from the SNSC, whose reason I never got to know, our military sector was excluded from an initiative that had started jointly by the MFA and the Quds Force. Of course, in the following phases of the Astana process, Iranian military commanders were in attendance because talks were mainly about the battlefield and our absence would entirely drive Iran out of the Astana process. Russia and Turkey remained the focal points of military agreements in the Astana process. This experience is another example of the consequences of Iran's cognitive deficit regarding international relations, which I discussed earlier. We said time and again that it would be mere fantasy to consider that steering clear of a multilateral process or showing open opposition to it would damage its legitimacy. The military section of the Astana peace process is a tragic case in point. The final outcome cannot be more telling.

The Astana process proved to be the only efficient process for ending military battles in Syria. It managed to stop the Syrian civil war, albeit not completely. In contrast, international meetings, Western and European initiatives like the anti-ISIS coalition, Russia-US bilateral talks and the Turkey-Russia-Germany-France forum failed to have any key impact on mitigating the conflict in Syria. However, the Astana initiative stopped the war.

The Astana experience is indicative of the vision that we have discussed in *The Transition Period of International Relations in Post-Western World*¹²⁰. The transition from a bipolar world has not only not ended in a unipolar or multipolar world, but also the future world is likely to be post-polar temporary coalitions, where no permanent and rigid polarization and overarching poles could emerge. The post-polar essence of the current world is that unlike the past, neither all key global developments occur in the West that includes Russia, nor can the West manage all global developments. Therefore, whereas US-Russia cooperation and the Russia-Turkey-Germany-France alliance did fail to contain the war in Syria, a temporary coalition within the framework of the Astana process yielded such achievement.

In Syria, there was meaningful synergy between diplomacy and the field operations during my tenure and while General Soleimani was alive. This helped maintain Iran's relative impact in Syria at the time. Had it not been for the aforementioned relegation of diplomacy to a secondary – or even less – role during the Raisi administration, the Islamic Republic of Iran's regional power could significantly assist diplomacy although in the short-term it ramped up pressure. We have to keep in mind that no power and influence is achieved without cost. In other words, to become powerful, we have to pay short-term costs. But we should make sure that the costs are compatible with achievements, and that all are at the service Iranian national interests.

A solid pillar of the Islamic Republic of Iran's power has been its ideational aspect. One of its most focal causes is to support oppressed people. However, the fundamental question revolves around how to support this noble cause, and how to frame the narrative. That cause should be presented and framed in a way to be comprehensible and acceptable to global community. Some consider "supporting the oppressed" enshrined in the Constitution of the Islamic Republic of Iran as institutionalized interference in the internal affairs of others. However, if one supplants "supporting human rights" —which is exactly the same—the entire

¹²⁰ This book is co-authored in Persian by M. Javad Zarif, Mohammad Kazem Sajjadpour and Ebadollah Mowlaei.

narrative and its implications change. Isn't promoting and protecting human rights any different from supporting those who have been wronged. The holy Quran is clear in this regard: "And what is it with you? You do not fight in the cause of Allah and for oppressed men, women, and children who cry out, "Our Lord! Deliver us from this land of oppressors! Appoint for us a savior; appoint for us a helper—all by Your grace"¹²¹. We live in the world of narratives, and appropriate framing is pivotal.

The manner of support is also important. Support for the oppressed should be commensurate with our abilities and comparative advantage. It is true that resistance has material requirements, but our comparative advantage has always laid in the realm of inspiration and the liberating message of our revolution which inspired the establishment of many resistance groups exactly during the 1980s and at the height of our own struggle to defend Iran during the Iraqi imposed war when we had no weapons to spare. Forty years of experience has shown that we have been more successful anytime we insisted on our ideational power, that is the message of the Islamic Revolution.

The third point pertains to distinction between presence and influence. Military presence always gives rise to undesired consequences. The US military presence has always faced public resistance everywhere. This human behavioral inclination has nothing to do with being just or not. That is the image that is engraved in local populations' minds about the presence of any foreign force. Rarely do people view presence of foreign troops in their country positively, even if they had contributed to their freedom or helped defeat terrorism. People lay the blame for all misfortunes on the presence of foreign forces and do not tolerate it. That has been proven in opinion polls. The more unveiled the presence, the more unfriendly the people would become. Finally, they attribute all failures of their own governance to the foreign forces who supported them. The locals do not see the positive outcome of foreign presence, particularly when their prejudice and presumption against a particular foreign country.

In assessment of capabilities as well as cost-benefit analysis of acts for national interests, all data should be examined. However, the point to keep

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in mind is that our support for resistance is not to blame for reducing Iran's strength; rather it bolsters it. Following national interests and supporting causes should never be pit against one another. Ideological objectives and interests are part and parcel of national interests. While the U.S. is not sincere in supporting any cause, it will never stop advancing American ideals like pretending to promote democracy or human rights. These are not among the material interests of the United States; rather, they are its pretended moral and ideological values, and the U.S. will never allow them to be removed from its foreign policy narrative.

Ties with China

Relations with China are of extremely high value for Iran and I did my utmost to institutionalize and enhance these bonds. I think I managed to improve ties although I faced numerous challenges born out of a variety of factors. One challenge pertained to some elites' perceptions whose preconceived preference is fixated on working with other parts of the world. Another one resulted from exaggerated expectations about cooperation with China, mis-portraying it as a country engaged in a USSR style Cold War struggle against U.S. imperialism. A third challenge is associated with exorbitant profits which motivates some to prevent expansion of ties with China. Of course, there has been large-scale Western-origin propaganda against Iran-China relations.

Ties with China are pivotal for Iran. A rising power, China is poised to become the top world economy. All countries in the world have strong ties with China. The U.S. and China are largely interdependent although they are locked in deep competition. If the Chinese take their financial resources out of the U.S. Treasury bond market, it will face a huge challenge. If China stops manufacturing for the U.S., the latter will have to fill its needs at much higher costs. The economic hardships of the United States are China's too, in terms of both consumer and capital market.

Anyway, China's global position is paramount and is expanding as it embarks on an unprecedented transformation. China has grown from a global product manufacturing plant into an innovation factory for the world. Today, it leads in innovation and knowledge creation and not just

in copying. It is this fundamental transformation in China that poses the most fundamental challenge to the US. China is no longer a trailing rival; rather, it is a rival gradually catching up with the U.S. in all sectors particularly in knowledge creation and innovation.

With such impetuses, ties with China have great merit, not only for Iran, but also for all nations. Such bonds are of higher merit and value for a country like Iran due to its geographical proximity and non-existing or minor political disputes with China. In many areas, the Islamic Republic of Iran is locked in fundamental challenges with the West, while challenges with China are very few. We have to accept this fact in our assessment of our relations with China and the West although we should not ignore inconstancies. Because of a multitude of factors, China's relations with Iran are immense, making China our main trading partner.

When it comes to Iran-China ties, we need to analyze several challenges. Like in previous cases, the main challenge would be of cognitive nature. More simply put, we should know that China does not view its challenges with the US primarily through the lens of geopolitical tensions. However, China may be forced – by the U.S. – in the future to enter open geopolitical rivalry. But it would not be China's choice. We must have already identified this fundamental Chinese tendency. Since early nineties, China insisted on advancing its economy and technology over a span of 25 years before entering into open rivalry with the US. The 25-year period is apparently not ending soon. That means that China does not intend to voluntarily step into a tense geopolitical rivalry with the U.S. in the foreseeable future; rather it has focused its competition in economic and technological domains.

Due to this misperception and cognitive error, Iran has developed unrealistic and unattainable expectations from its ties with China. I believe China has never viewed its ties with Iran from a similar angle. Therefore, we have had expectations from China that will never be fulfilled. We expected China to stand up to the U.S. in favor of Iran whereas China has never been inclined to do so; not even for itself. Our assumption was flawed. We should have realized that China is neither infatuated with us nor seeking to elevate Iran's global status. China pursues its own interests. The Americans understand this tendency perfectly. Therefore, when they decided to ramp up pressure on Iran by imposing oil sanctions,

they encouraged their top allies to make the US's key rival independent of Iranian oil. From 2008 to 2011, Saudi Arabia developed close ties with China, becoming its primary energy partner before Iranian oil sanctions were tightened.

Iran gradually became China's second, then third energy partner, and I don't know where it stands now. The Chinese were seeking neither an ideological alliance nor a geopolitical coalition with Iran. They had identified their own rivalry with the U.S. in another sector, and despite U.S. efforts, they continue to evade military-security rivalry and insist on fierce economic competition. The U.S. has always sought to drag this rivalry into security sectors where it has a relative advantage. But the Chinese shrewdly resisted falling in American security trap.

China had already made up its mind. We in Iran did not want to acknowledge this reality, neither for China nor for Russia. Therefore, we were disenchanted by these two countries. First, we harbored false hopes based on which we pursued policies that we should not have. Second, when we found those aspirations to be unfeasible, we were disappointed. We blamed China and Russia to be untrustworthy and unfaithful, forgetting the bitter reality that trust and faith have no place in global politics.

Therefore, our first misstep was a misunderstanding of China's outlook. Second, we viewed international relations as a fair stage where countries treat each other based on justice. For example, since the "one-to-one" agreement Iran made with China during its desperation was a bad agreement, we expected China to improve the terms of the deal after improvement in Iran's conditions.

During periods of extended foreign ties and unfrozen assets, a one-to-one agreement is doubtless a bad one. But how come Iran make that agreement? Because access to assets in China was blocked; just as after the Trump sanctions, nearly \$20 billion of Iranian assets held in Iraq, South Korea and other countries became frozen. Cognitive pathology tells us that we did not appreciate what China was seeking in the world, assuming China's rivalry in the world to be geostrategic. We wrongly imagined China was ready to pay costs in our favor for imaginary rivalry to keep us in its own camp. Second, we expected China to treat us as a special case and help us in times of difficulty and hardship, but we could break our

pledge in times of ease and comfort. Due to its large economy, China has a higher risk tolerance. It has been able to withstand U.S. pressure for its own benefit and therefore it will not take risks for our sake.

In a meeting with President Rouhani, President Putin made a key point: "We will not provide you with discounts or low interest loans on nuclear energy and conventional weapons because we have no competition in these two sectors. Iran can only purchase these items from Russia, and it has no other option". We have to get the point. Russia knows quite well that it faces no competition in nuclear energy supply to Iran and therefore it raises prices, toughens the terms of contracts and refuses any low-interest loan. Perhaps if Russia wanted to build the same power plant in Saudi Arabia, it would offer a lower price and if need be, grant Saudi Arabia a low interest loan. Perhaps it would be ready to build the same power plant in Turkey gratuitously because it knows quite well that Turkey would depend on it for fuel supply for the life of the plant. Russia knows well that Saudi Arabia and Turkey have other options too and powerful rivals like the U.S., France and South Korea are waiting. But no country is ready to build a power plant in Iran or sell it weapons. Therefore, Russia can easily impose its own conditions on Iran.

Misperceptions lead to premature behavioral frustration, which would raise suspicions in the opposite party. China's interpretation of Iran's statement that "conditions have changed" is that should Iran's conditions improve tomorrow, it will not hesitate to renege on the entire agreement. Therefore, its commitment and readiness for any long-term investment are affected.

On the other hand, by these words, you give it the option that should Iran's conditions worsen, the other side can also exact a higher premium. The real solution is to remove barriers that obstruct ties with others, so that all of Iran's partners understand that they must bid for Iran's market and that Iran would not be an exclusive client. Then there would be no need to terminate previous agreements. They will take the initiative to offer better terms because they will start worrying about losing the valuable Iranian market.

It is widely assumed in Iran that the Rouhani administration did not give high priority to bilateral relations with China –presumably

because of its “western” orientation. That is not the case. Two major misrepresentations have been repeated so often in the media run by the opposite faction as well as in the statements of some foreign policy critics to the point of turning into a common belief¹²². The first baseless allegation is that China intended to invest \$50 billion in Iran, only to face resistance or even sabotage by the Rouhani Administration. The fact of matter is that during President Rouhani’s first visit to China, we requested \$75 billion in investment. The Chinese side made it conditional on the implementation of the “one-to-one” agreement, noting it would then be ready for another \$50 billion investment. In spite of President Rouhani’s reservations about that agreement, we presented several projects to China based on that same “one-to-one” agreement, and many industrial achievements were made within this framework. However, the \$50 billion investment allegation pertains to a proposal from a Hong Kong broker who sought a monopoly in Iran and, in return, made an empty promise for such big investment. Nonetheless, without conceding to his monopoly, he was given the opportunity to invest in a major petrochemical project in Iran.

The other big lie pertains to the alleged vacancy of the post of Iran’s ambassador to Beijing for two years. Under the Rouhani Administrations, we had four ambassadors in China. Our first ambassador was Mr. Mehdi Safari who had been appointed by the previous Administration and continued to serve out his four-year mission under our Administration, which lasted one year. Mr. Asghar Khaji succeeded him. He left for Beijing one week after Mr. Safari relinquished his post, presenting his credentials to Chinese authorities. Then in June 2017, one week after Mr. Khaji left office, Mr. Abdol-Nasser Hemmati traveled to China to submit his credentials to President Xi.

Nearly one month after his appointment, due to special economic conditions in Iran, President Rouhani decided to appoint him as the Governor of the Central Bank of Iran (CBI). This decision was made in July 2017 on the sidelines of our annual ambassadors’ seminar in Tehran, where Mr. Hemmati was in attendance as ambassador to China. Promoting Mr. Hemmati to the CBI Governor indicated the importance of China for

¹²² <https://www.farsnews.ir/news/14000509000265/> <https://akharinkhabar.ir/politics/9496590>

President Rouhani, appointing someone as prominent as a CBI governor to the post. Immediately after Mr. Hemmati's new appointment, Mr. Mohammad Keshavarzzadeh was nominated to replace him. Only three months after Mr. Hemmati's unexpected return, his successor submitted his credentials to President Xi, in December 2017. Interestingly, when submitting his credentials, the new ambassador won President Xi's consent for the visit to Beijing of Mr. Ali Larijani as the special envoy of the Islamic Republic in February 2018.

I wonder where the allegation of two-year vacancy of the Iranian embassy comes from. A point worth noting is that it would take between 6 and 12 months from the time the MFA picks a new ambassador until the submission of credentials to the president of the host nation. This is the rule for an ordinary mission, let alone an important country like China. Clearance from security organs, presidential consent, acceptance by the host nation, the president's signature of the new ambassador's credentials, the ambassador's meeting with the president before departure, and finally, setting a date for presenting credentials to the head of state in the host nation are time-consuming steps. However, despite the sudden vacancy of the Iranian embassy in Beijing, all these tasks were completed at an unprecedented pace, in less than 90 days. This would have been impossible without my personal continuous follow-up.

Nonetheless, unfounded allegations were fabricated to prove the imaginary hypothesis of the Rouhani Administration's lack of interest with non-Western nations. This is not just a regrettable lie, but it will also give rise to a misperception and ill-conceived policies whose result we see in recent failures in connection with China and Russia. In other words, the existing cognitive challenges have been exacerbated with such blatant lies.

The other point which was noted earlier pertains to delusional infatuation and resultant disappointments and resentments in foreign relations. We easily forget the fact that external ties are no place for Love/hate relations; rather, it is an arena to advance national interests. We tend to categorize our ties through the prism of loyalty vs enmity. Many years ago, a senior official told me that the U.S. is hostile to us. I told him that brotherly and friendly Syria is not in love with us either and that it only

pursues its own interests. No ruler is interested in any country other than his/her own, much less Iran. We have to understand and accept this reality.

Another problem is foreign propaganda and its widespread impact on our society. The main reason is that our domestic sources of information and national news broadcasting are fast losing their credibility as points of reference. When domestic sources lose credibility and we discredit, through our own propaganda, alternative domestic views, then we inevitably push news sources and points of reference for credible information outside our borders.

For example, exactly when foreign minister of China and I were putting the final touches to the 25-year roadmap, Iran's state TV aired a TV series – Gando – assailing me in person. When the credibility and even patriotism of the Minister of Foreign Affairs are destroyed in the public eye, state radio and television or Gando-producers would not assume the role of becoming points of reference; rather, the BBC, other foreign-based broadcasters and foreign personalities will assume this role.

External influence leaves profound impact. We saw its magnitude during the Caspian Sea legal status negotiations and the 25-year roadmap with China. Both were highly beneficial agreements for Iran, and both enjoyed consensus among the entire political establishment. But the state broadcasting and querulous media affiliated with institutions of power and wealth had run a vicious campaign to portray the foreign minister as soft and wavering about national rights and interests. In this atmosphere, a significant portion of the people considered both agreements to be colonial imposition and sell-out of national interests and even territory. As we say in Persian, "A self-inflicted wound has no cure." Or, to borrow two familiar English proverbs, "You've made your bed; now lie in it," and "You reap what you sow."

In drawing up the 25-year roadmap, Iran wielded the initiative. It was Iran who presented the first draft to the Chinese who responded in turn. It was not like that the Chinese write something down and then Iran adds or crosses some lines and affixes its signature thereupon. It was us who made the first draft. It was our own idea. I followed up the case in person because I recognized the merits of relations with China. It was me who suggested that Mr. Larijani travel to China in a new capacity as Iran's

special envoy. without adhering to normal protocol, I myself accompanied him to China rather than sending a deputy minister as customary. I was convinced that naming a high-ranking special envoy was necessary for confidence-building with the Chinese leadership. But alas, the impression in the country was totally opposite.

The idea behind the 25-year roadmap was to establish that bilateral relations between Iran and China had their own fundamental merits and were not temporary and necessity-driven. China would never invest in an ephemeral partner. We granted China no monopoly in this roadmap; however, we made it clear we are intent on long-term cooperation with China in sectors like technology, transit and industry. We did not mean exclusive cooperation either. We sought to ensure China that even if Iran settles its challenges with the West, it will not and cannot abandon China because of the long-term nature of relations foresaw in the roadmap.

In bilateral ties, we must express our views clearly and transparently about the prospects of long-term cooperation as well as each party's perception of the other's status. We should carefully listen to our counterpart's view and reach an appropriate and realistic agreement. This method would be effective particularly after a period of mistrust. When the U.S. and China established ties, the same method was applied, soon to be named "Yellow-Pad Diplomacy".

It may be appropriate to highlight the imperative of learning in international relations. The yellow-pad diplomacy may be used by Iran to manage relations with countries like the U.S. and Saudi Arabia, with which Tehran has long been locked in disputes with prevailing mutual mistrust. On this basis, since mid-1990s, I have been proposing that disputes with the U.S. be divided into three groups. The first group includes foundational disputes, which neither side want or even can resolve through compromise. Iran is not ready to accept U.S. dominance. Similarly, the U.S. does not condone the Islamic Revolution. Iran is not ready to recognize Israel and the U.S. is not ready to stop backing Israel. These intractable differences should be clarified by both sides. Even regarding these intractable differences, both sides have misunderstood one another. That should also become clear. For instance, Iran does not intend to deal with U.S. dominance violently. Similarly, the U.S. should not intend to

seek the overthrow of the Iranian government. We do not seek any military operations to wipe Israel off the map. In our view, Zionist dominance over Palestine will collapse due to internal paradoxes within the Israeli regime and the resistance of people living in occupied land. Iran favors a plebiscite for the future of Palestine. Most pro-Israel observers also say that Israel has destroyed any prospects for the two-state solution and over the span of 20 years, a Palestinian-dominated government would emerge in the region. We need to make clarifications on this case. The U.S. should also make clear that despite its opposition to the Islamic Revolution, it would not strive for the undoing of the Islamic Republic and pledge not to meddle in Iran's internal affairs. However, we should develop the necessary self-respect and self-confidence not to even express such a request from the United States because they do not have the power to overthrow the Iranian government. In any case, we should keep in mind that there are always a variety of bilateral misunderstandings about these intractable disputes that are likely to trigger unnecessary confrontation. Only through frank dialogue would it be possible to prevent undue tensions.

The second group comprises objectives upon which we may have different long-term objectives. But there is no need to take action to the detriment of short-term common interests due to possible future disputes. Cases abound, varying from combatting drug trafficking to fossil fuels, from supporting moderate and broad-based governments in Afghanistan and Iraq to fighting with al-Qaeda and Daesh. Of course, in this regard, both sides have suspicion about the long-term objectives and intents of the other party, which explains why both sides have sacrificed their own interests to harm the other side. The Taliban's return to power in Afghanistan is the result of such process.

The third group contains cases in which the U.S. and Iran are locked in dispute over their vision and policy. But they could be resolved with *quid pro quo*. None of them are linked to Iranian or U.S. identities and existential values and principles. In a trade-off where Iran still has numerous choices and has not reached the point of compulsion, intelligent dialogue would facilitate bargaining and trade-off on equal footing. Of course, it should be noted that conditions will not remain unchanged; we cannot think that some unilateral steps can help change the balance

in our favor because the U.S. will reciprocally strive to change the balance to our detriment. Therefore, the trying to build new “leverage” by either side may prove futile and even harmful. Identifying the right moment for dialogue would need simultaneous self-respect and realism. The absence of each can give rise to harmful consequences.

This proposal was submitted in the 1990s. Had we entered such dialogue then, we might have been able to stave off a nuclear dispute with the U.S. by a trade-off before Washington could take Iran’s nuclear case to the UN Security Council and launch a multilateral dialogue with Iran by applying the lever of pressure of Security Council resolutions against Iran, in which case we would have got more concessions in return for the steps we took in the JCPOA. Through mutual unrealistic demands for over ten years Iran and the United States managed to worsen the situation for themselves and the other side in a negative sum game. Iran managed to increase its centrifuges from nearly 200 in 2005 to nearly 20,000 in 2013—a net loss of over 19,800 centrifuges for the U.S. Which was seeking zero enrichment. Iran at the same time suffered huge economic downfall from +7% GDP growth in 2005 to -7% decline in 2012m as a result of Ahmadinejad’s hardline nuclear policy. Trump’s withdrawal from JCPOA in 2018 and aggression against Iranian nuclear facilities in 2025 will not have any different outcome. The Iranian nuclear program will not only not be obliterated but will reemerge stronger—and more alarming—to the U.S. in no time, while Iranian economy will further suffer. This lose-lose logic must be reversed through reasonable give-and-take by both sides.

Another case of the same category is Iran’s missile power. On the one hand, diplomats are barred from negotiating over the missile program. But without any arrangement and trade-off, military commanders said Iran would not develop missiles whose range would exceed 2,000 km. That is fine. But what concession has Iran wrested in return? Did we put an end to the missile dispute? Such commitment should have been given within the framework of a trade-off so that reciprocal concessions and an end to the fuss over our missiles would have been obtained.

Instead of engaging in a compromise based on agreed trade-offs, we normally wait until pressure leaves us no other alternative to concede without anything in return. The IAEA’s installation of surveillance cameras

in 2022 should have been done in return for something. But we waited until it was too late and the only thing we received in return was to avoid a negative report by the IAEA Director General to the Board of Governors which could have triggered the reporting of the Iranian nuclear issue to the Security Council.

If we could present a realistic picture of what can be expected in future to our partners or even opponents, we would not be forced into taking action under pressure and without anything in return. For instance, we have to articulate clearly for Saudi Arabia that we do not seek to overthrow their kingdom, and that while we do not agree with many of their policies, we understand that any alternative would be even less agreeable. We have to make it clear to them. Clarity is a key element of diplomacy. Of course, we should live up to our words. The Saudis should not claim that they have arrested a person suspected of having been funded by Iran to bring down their monarchy.

The twenty-five-year roadmap with China was premised on such intellectual and operational vision of articulating our vision for the future. The roadmap sets the foundation for many future contracts whose terms and conditions are determined individually and not by the 25-year roadmap. The roadmap does not impose any obligations for either party. Nor does it set the parameters of future agreements. The parties agreed on an outlook which hopefully shattered the perception that Iran's relations with China were temporary and out of necessity and not choice.

The fifth challenge is that Iran's bureaucratic system leans towards the West. It is not inclined to relations with China and Russia. Therefore, it always presents excuses against agreements with China and Russia. What reinforces this inclination is that we have shifted to China and Russia only because of necessity and therefore the terms of our agreements with them have not been attractive enough. Additionally, we always draw a parallel between agreements with China and Russia and those struck with the West. We ignore the fact that we have reached agreement with Western governments during periods where they had to compete between themselves and also with China and Russia. Therefore, they had to make more competitive proposals. But we started engaging with China and Russia when neither Japan, nor Europe, nor the U.S. were

prepared to engage with Iran. Certainly, China and Russia realize our special conditions and needs. Therefore, they work with us under unequal terms. Comparing China's ties with Saudi Arabia and its ties with Iran shed light on this tragic truth. As noted earlier, one reason for suggesting the 25-year roadmap with China was to shatter this perception on both sides. Let's keep in mind that ties based on long-term interests are the healthiest of global transactions. Short-term deals are prone to uncertainty and corruption. On the contrary, stable long-term relations are based on shared national interests.

Of course, it should be noted that stable and healthy ties with any country require competition and absence of monopoly. The West should not feel any monopoly in its ties with Iran and perceive that if it opens its doors to us, we will rush to it every time. Neither should the East have the feeling that we will always have to depend on them, and we have no other option. Iran needs comprehensive balance in its relations with the entire world; otherwise, we would lose. In monopolized relations, the West would imagine that you are so enamored by it that you would always remain at its disposal and would never turn to China. Under such circumstances, the West may indeed re-export low-quality items at much higher prices than high-quality items. Similarly, if China thinks that you have no option but to trade with it, it will naturally show the same behavior.

We must transform our external ties from the phase of enamor and animosity to ties mapped out on national interests. Let's keep in mind that profit is not bad. The difference between me as a student and practitioner of international relations and orthodox Realists lies in the fact that for me, stable ties require reciprocal profitability and benefit. Striving for maximum gain for one party at exorbitant expense for the other party would mean minimizing the life of that agreement. As soon as the other party feels it can change the unequal terms in its own favor it will not hesitate to do so.

Covid-19 Crisis

As we are reviewing ties with China, it may now be appropriate to address the covid-19 pandemic and efforts undertaken by the MFA and myself

to alleviate the suffering of Iranian people, not least procuring Chinese vaccines. Several months of endeavor finally came to fruition during the first days of Raisi Administration, when procured vaccines arrived. Unfortunately, leveling unfair accusations of West-orientation against Rouhani administration, the credit for procurement of vaccines was given to the new administration. The same was true regarding Iran's SCO membership, while in fact Iran's SCO membership had been finalized in May 2021 during a foreign ministerial meeting in Tajikistan's capital, before Mr. Ebrahim Raisi was elected President.

Here I intend to summarize a report produced during my final days in office about our efforts to help fight the pandemic, which was printed in the *Jomhuri-e Eslami* daily newspaper on 28 August 2021.

In a letter dated 16 January 2020, we informed the Ministry of Health of the outbreak of covid-19 in China. On 25 February 2020, I underscored the importance of the challenge and the need for decision-making at a Cabinet meeting. Again, on 27 February, in a second letter to the Ministry of Health and other relevant institutions, I warned about the need for vigilance at the country's entry points to prevent the virus from entering. In the meantime, supplying urgent needs including scarce items and raw materials for medications and purchase of vaccine turned the "covid-19 diplomacy" into one of the most central activities of the MFA in Tehran and Iranian missions abroad.

Given the little-known nature of covid-19 and its quick outbreak, the first action was to mobilize everything at our disposal to receive foreign assistance. Iran urgently needed medications and rare special equipment. In the process, by transmitting the needs of the Ministry of Health to other nations and international organizations including the World Health Organization (WHO) and intensive consultation for supplying these items, we received donations from more than 40 nations and international organizations, worth more than \$100 million, to be transferred to the Ministry of Health. Foreign-based Iranians also offered aid, which was collected and submitted to relevant bodies.

Besides receiving the foregoing aid that was supplied through UN bodies, a significant number of various types of aid including necessary items and equipment, donated by various nations and international bodies,

was flown into Iran through nearly 80 direct or indirect flights by Qatar Airways and Mahan Air gratuitously. Furthermore, necessary technical and diplomatic arrangement was made for dozens of charter flights from China, Russia, India, Germany, Japan and South Korea among others to transfer in health and medical equipment either purchased or donated.

Supplying samples of covid-19 medications (including Favipiravir and Remdesivir) for research and production and arranging for three agreements to on licensed production, joint production and contribution to vaccine research and development with Russian, Cuban and Australian companies were among other steps undertaken by the MFA to help fight covid-19. Facilitating machinery and raw materials imports from other countries for local vaccine production saved us several million euros. Scientific and academic centers as well as leading companies across the globe were identified and introduced for cooperation in treating covid-19 patients. Support was offered to science-based companies through removing barriers in the way of transactions, introducing them for exporting covid-related products, helping upgrade their medication and medical equipment manufacturing and facilitating cooperation with foreign companies in a targeted manner.

Although at the MFA, we were serving as coordinator and facilitator to link the Ministry of Health with foreign governments and companies, we assisted the ministry of health in vaccine identification, political consultation, preparation and provision of technical data for registering emergency use, supply of necessary hard currency against the backdrop of sanctions and finally proceeding with financial transactions and transferring in vaccine without any publicity.

Thanks to our intensive efforts, nearly one month after the first covid-19 vaccine was registered in the world, diplomatic talks started to purchase vaccine. Within 50 days, the first shipment arrived from India, China, Russia and Cuba by February 2021.

Vaccine purchase from Chinese manufacturers was on our agenda since the very start of vaccine productions. The MFA's first correspondence with the Ministry of Health for vaccine supply is dated 25 July 2020. China had offered to supply Sinopharm vaccines to us in return for conducting clinical tests in Iran. This attractive proposal was not accepted by executives

outside the MFA. Our neighbors like Turkey and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) accepted the proposal offered by less experienced Chinese firms like Sinovac and they overtook Iran in vaccination campaign.

However, intensive diplomatic consultations, including correspondence and phone conversation with the Chinese foreign minister, extensive talks with him in Kunming¹²³, the capital of Yunnan Province, 810- October 2020, and the Chinese foreign minister's visit to Tehran on 27 April 2021, not only led to the receipt of the first shipment of 250,000 doses in March 2021, but also came down to an agreement to purchase 10 million vaccines from China, not to mention further agreements.

The process of receiving vaccines, which began in May 2021, resulted in the supply of more than 19 million doses of vaccine from China by August that year. Moreover, we applied on 28 July for importing another 30 million doses from China for August and September. Then came the application for another 30 million doses for October and November.

From July 2020 when Russia offered its first Sputnik samples, talks began for purchasing vaccines from this country. As soon as its mass production began, four days after basic agreement for vaccine purchase, the Ministry of Health dispatched a delegation to Russia. During my visit to Moscow in February 2021, an agreement was struck for 2 million doses. Four days later, the first shipment arrived. In the second phase, an agreement was reached for 60 million doses, but the process of delivery was slow due to the Russian manufacturer overwhelmed by demand from other countries. By August 2021, nearly 1 million doses of Sputnik had arrived in Iran.

From the very beginning of the COVAX¹²⁴ initiative, we helped the Ministry of Health to join it and apply for the necessary vaccines. The result was agreement for the supply of 16.8 million doses via COVAX. In a bid to provide necessary hard currency, dozens of meetings were held

¹²³ In a bid to exempt Iranian delegation from the Chinese government's covid-19 regulations in Beijing that required two-week quarantine, the Chinese foreign minister, on his way to ASEAN, offered to stop over in this city along the border with Myanmar, which imposes easier regulations, to meet with us. The minister said upon return from ASEAN, he would have to remain in quarantine for one week. Therefore, meeting in Kunming, which was 3 ½ hours of flight from Beijing, resolved the challenge of quarantine for the Iranian delegation. That indicated the seriousness of ties with China during my term in office.

¹²⁴ COVID-19 Vaccines Global Access

between the Assistant Minister of Foreign Affairs for Asia-Pacific and South Korea's ambassador to Tehran and also between Iran's ambassador to Seoul and South Korean officials so that the first portion of financial commitments would be fulfilled by depositing \$52 million in favor of COVAX with a Swiss bank. The South Korean party insisted on OFAC's permission, which was issued after a long delay. But an agent bank was now needed for exchanging the sum from Korean currency into any convertible currency. Korean banks were unwilling to handle this processing, insisting that the transaction must be made through American banks. Due to the possibility of freezing of the money in the U.S., payment was not possible through South Korea¹²⁵. Finally, a meeting was held in the Office of the First Vice President, after which payment was done via a European bank thanks to the mediation a Middle East bank. By August 2021, nearly 2.2 million doses of AstraZeneca vaccine had been received through this mechanism. An agreement was also reached to receive 2.3 million doses of Sinopharm vaccine and 1.1 million doses of AstraZeneca vaccine. With Iran's membership in the international "humanitarian buffer" mechanism, the necessary agreement was reached to receive 6.1 million doses of vaccine for Afghan refugees in Iran.

After Bharat vaccine produced in India received the emergency use certificate, we began discussions for its purchase by December 2020 and expressed our desire to purchase at least 2 million doses of the vaccine from India. It was agreed that in the first phase, 500,000 doses would be exported to Iran by March 2021, and the first 125,000-dose shipment arrived 10 March 2021. The remaining 375,000 doses was close to being loaded for shipment that a new wave of pandemic in India prompted the country's chief prosecutor to stop any vaccine exports.

In short, by late August 2021, more than 27 million doses of vaccine including 5.5 million donated doses (worth over \$26 million) and 21.5 million doses purchased normally were received. Moreover, 20 million doses were finalized for shipment by September 2021, and 30 million doses were close to being finalized for shipment in October and November.

¹²⁵ The story of transferring money to purchase vaccines from COVAX reveals both the American lies about food and medicine being exempt from sanctions and the hue and cry of our domestic opponents.

Consultation and action for assisting in domestic vaccine production in the two sectors of national production and joint production were on the agenda of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs. In this regard, while helping import equipment necessary for the homegrown COVIran Barekat vaccine, three projects were implemented for joint vaccine production in Iran. In addition, the experimental production line of Russian sputnik vaccine in Iran became operational on 26 June 2021 for the purpose of supply of 2 million doses per month for domestic consumption and export.

In the light of the existing cooperation between Cuba's Finlay Institute and Iran's Pasteur Institute in vaccine manufacturing, I held initial talks for joint Covid vaccine production during my November 2020 visit to Havana, which resulted in an agreement by March 2021. Following the successful completion of Phase III of clinical trial for this vaccine, its production began on semi-industrial scale in July that year. Phase I of clinical trial for Iranian Australian SpikoGen vaccine – a co-product of Iran's CinnaGen and Australian's Vaxine – was done in Australia in 2020 and phase III of clinical trial began in Iran.

Necessary equipment for COVIran Barakat, weighing more than 800 tons, was transferred on eight flights and two maritime shipments owing to untiring efforts of our missions in Beijing, Shanghai and New Delhi. Meantime, upon a request from Barkat Pharmaceutical Group, some other equipment and items needed for this national project were supplied from Japan and some European countries.

In the first days following the outbreak of covid-19, we started a global effort to facilitate the return of Iranian students and tourists stranded in various countries due to the sudden cancellation of flights and closure of border. In collaboration with the Ministry of Health and in compliance with measures to prevent any spread of the virus in the country, they were flown in from China, the UAE, India, Turkey, Pakistan, Oman, Hungary, Azerbaijan, Kazakhstan, Georgia and Ukraine among others. From March to August 2020, nearly 2,000 Iranians were brought back in full compliance with covid-19 protocols and in coordination with the National Covid-19 Committee and Civil Aviation Organization (CAO).

One key challenge during the covid-19 period was of economic and industrial nature, as all channels for supplying local needs, particularly

basic commodities, were closed and the production chain had to be kept running. Our first step was to facilitate consular affairs of truck drivers who had been stranded in other countries (Turkey, Bulgaria, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Iraq, Turkmenistan, Uzbekistan, Pakistan, ...) and managing their return home by embassies or continuation of their travel to maintain exports under the centralized management of the MFA. The second step was to launch regular direct flights to Moscow, Dushanbe, Almaty, and Aktau after flights stopped and to ensure the flow of trucks into Russia and arranging for maritime shipment to Russia via the Caspian Sea due to the bottleneck for Iranian trucks to cross Azerbaijan's territory.

Furthermore, the foreign minister, deputy and assistant ministers, and ambassadors held consultation with other countries and international bodies including the Secretary General of the UN for the purpose of countering obstacles created by U.S. sanctions, explaining the negative impact of sanctions on anti-covid campaign, documenting the fallout from U.S. unilateral coercive measures on covid-19 management in Iran and associated human, social and economic damage as well as registering related documents with international bodies. Doubtlessly, the unlawful U.S. sanctions posed the biggest obstacle in the way of timely supply of national needs for fighting covid-19, from purchase of medication and kit tests to vaccines. In a professional gesture, we documented this crime on the global scene.

Relations with Europe

Although Europe is known as a unified group, it is flush with complexities and varying inclinations. As Donald Rumsfeld said, new Europe has gained fame for anti-Russian tendencies. On the other hand, in the general elections held in some Eastern European nations, sometimes pro-Russian groups come to power, which is interesting. For instance, Hungary has its closest ties with Israel and Russia, but its ties with the rest of Europe are tense.

Ethnic Russians are high in number in Israel and an important factor in right wing ascendance there. Under Mikhail Gorbachev, nearly 2 million Russian Jews settled in the Occupied Territories, after which, the Israeli

Left which enjoyed historic prominence in Israeli politics were sidelined. Therefore, understanding Israel would require an understanding its historical roots in Eastern Europe and Russia.

On the other hand, Eastern Europe is largely inclined towards the United States, mainly due to fear of Russia. Under the first Rouhani administration, during my visit to Poland, their foreign minister said: "I'm ready to give any concessions to the U.S. in return for deploying only two servicemen in our country". He imagined that U.S. military deployment in Poland would protect its independence from Russia.

Nordic nations in Northern Europe may appear to be more independent, but human rights considerations in their politics and foreign relations are paramount. In the light of these tendencies, our relations with Nordic nations have their ceilings and limited boundaries. Although areas of mutual interest and cooperation provided relative sustainability to our bilateral ties, relations rarely surpassed certain limits. Areas of cooperation and common interests may vary from time to time, but they would neither surpass a certain ceiling nor would they totally diminish.

On the other hand, in Southern Europe, i.e., Mediterranean Europe, Iran enjoys greater room for cooperation due to history. For instance, Italy has always been an important trading partner for Iran. Spain and Portugal have deep-rooted historical affinities with us. Therefore, grounds for cooperation with Mediterranean Europe is much greater than with the rest of Europe; this is further augmented by the rivalry of some of them with France and Germany.

Under Prime Minister Alexis Tsipras, Greece was pursuing strategic ties with Iran. Although his government was short-lived, our bonds were strong enough to help expand cooperation. One reason for our colder relations with Greece in the 2000s and 2010s was that anti-Turkish sentiments were eased in Iran's politics. In the wake of the collapse of the Soviet Union, trilateral meetings were held between Iran, Greece and Armenia focusing on containing Turkey. I do not believe in this type of relations. I do not believe that common anxieties against third parties provide solid grounds for cooperation. Foreign relations must be based on their own merits of mutual benefit. It has to be noted that under Tsipras, our bonds with Greece were based on common interests and similar tendencies, and not

on mutual anti-Turkish grievances. Our ties with Greece—like any other country—should be based on the interests we share with Greece and not based on animosity with another party.

As I mentioned several times in this book and elsewhere, I believe that bilateral relations with any country should stand on their own merit and not as a desperate replacement or alternative to relations with others. Relations are most sustainable when they are based on choice and not necessity or desperation. If bonds with China are stable and deep-rooted, they will help improve balanced relations with Europe. However, relations with China cannot serve as a tool for improving ties with Europe. If we regard bonds with China as a tool for relations with Europe, we will not be able to establish sustainable ties with Europe or China. The value of each bond is determined by its mutual benefits, historical background and dozens of other factors. Therefore, every bilateral or multilateral bond should be expanded and deepened based on the merits of that particular relation and should not be based on external motives.

Iran must have strong and balanced ties with neighboring Turkey. These ties should not be sacrificed for ties with any other nation, including Greece. Neither should relations with Greece be sacrificed for bonds with Turkey. We need to have balanced ties with all nations. The opposite approach has rarely achieved positive outcomes. Had it been possible to draw benefits from relations focused on extracting concessions or favors from third parties, we should have been able to extract benefits from Turkey using the leverage of our ties with Greece or Armenia. Greece and Armenia might have benefited from the situation to balance their ties with Turkey. But it did not work for us.

Let's not forget that we have a series of disabling policies inside the country, albeit based on lofty values, as well as challenges from outside. One of such challenges is tensions with the US. We should keep in mind that in relations that are not based on their own merits and bilateral mutual interest, our counterpart will have a much freer hand in leveraging those relations with others than Iran because of our domestic bottlenecks. For instance, if our ties with China are based on countering the United States, China will be in a much better position to benefit from the ties because

it has ties with the U.S. and it can leverage our relations as a bargaining tool in its interactions with America; but we cannot.

Another pillar of our relations with Europe pertains to their historical depth. Our relations with some European countries date back to much before the U.S. independence. Iran and Europe had extensive bonds going back many centuries. Although today Iran and Europe have no realistic and balanced dialogue or reciprocal understanding, there are still countries in Europe with better knowledge of how to work with Iran. Doubtlessly, the Europeans have a better perception of Iran than the U.S. and they can understand Iran's developments much better.

The Self-Arrogated Prominence of Europe

The long history of Iran's ties with Europe is overshadowed by Europe's sense of self-importance, prejudice and self-admiration. Interestingly, the Americans are not as self-righteous as the Europeans, and these European traits enrage them too. The Europeans feel they are entitled to make judgements about others, including the Americans, and offer normative guidance to the entire universe. The inhibiting challenge in the relationship with Europe is their self-arrogated normative superiority and supremacy. This attitude is inherently flawed, egotistical, and simply wrong. This same attitude has led to Europe's unforgivable behavior in the world, from colonialism to supporting the suppression of Palestinians by Israel. Iran's relationship with Europe also suffers from such deep normative inconsistencies.

Europe is the birthplace of Western civilization. When it comes to certain manifestations of Western civilization, including alleged promotion and protection of human rights, Europe even exceeds the United States. Europe is part of the West; it has its strengths and weaknesses, but it remains part of the West. Whatever afflicts the West would affect Europe too. When we speak about the post-Western world, we do not mean that the world is solely post-American; rather, Europe would be affected more than and prior to the U.S. by the global post-Atlantic orientation or the transition of global power and wealth towards Pacific. This would affect Europe more than the United States because U.S. shores stretch to both

oceans. Of course, the post-Western world has more fundamental and significant characteristics, which we discussed earlier.

The fundamental Western folly in general and Europe in particular is that the West considers itself to be the center of universe, which it's not. It is neither the moral center, nor the political center, nor the demographic center, nor even the center of wealth in the world. Europe has reluctantly realized that it is no longer the center of global wealth. It has also realized that it is no longer the center of global security, although its historical arrogance may prevent it from admitting it. Europe has come to appreciate that in the post-Western world, neither all key events occur in the West, nor the West can any longer manage key events. Even realistic Americans have realized the necessity of multilateral cooperation to advance their interests. They may even need to accept to be just spectators while others act.

The Astana peace process, launched in 2016 by Iran, Russia and Turkey to bring an end to the war in Syria, was a renewed and tragic wakeup call for Europe and the West. What was hard to swallow for the West was that three non-Western states did something in Syria that Europe and the U.S. could not do. Even when Russia and Turkey sought to end the Syrian war with European help, they failed. Russia and the U.S. released a joint statement on ending the war in Syria, but they failed. They declared ceasefire, but to no avail. Russia, Turkey, France and Germany strived again and failed. What remained stable was the trilateral Astana process. The key point is that the West depends on others for overcoming global challenges. When I went to Davos to attend the World Economic Forum in winter 2017, I was the sole supporter of the Astana process due to the absence of Turkey and Russia. All participants were unsupportive, saying this initiative was doomed to fail. "The problem with you is that you imagine no non-European initiative can succeed," I reacted. This Eurocentric — or West-centered vision is outdated.

They had the same perspective vis-à-vis the Yemen crisis. Seasoned British diplomat Martin Griffiths was serving as the UN's Under-Secretary-General for Humanitarian Affairs and Emergency Relief Coordinator, thereby dealing with the Yemen crisis, but he did not come to Iran. He imagined that only by travelling to Saudi Arabia and other West-leaning countries and excluding other actors like Iran, he would be able to bring

an end to the conflict in Yemen. In the end, he concluded that without dialogue with all actors and traveling to Iran, he would not resolve the crisis.

This does not mean that we in Iran should trap ourselves in the illusion that without Iran, the processes going on around Iran are doomed. This assumption is also hazardous. While believing in our own capabilities, we should reach the understanding that if exclusion becomes the rule in global developments, the country to be excluded by default is Iran. Naturally, we should try our best to prevent exclusion. As exclusionary approach is no longer effective in the current world anyway, Iran should avoid adopting an approach based on exclusion. Iran should not fall into the same trap as the Europeans, which resulted in their gradual sidelining. If we imagine that all processes depend on our presence, we will reach a place where exactly the opposite will come true. The rule of creation is that arrogance leads to downfall¹²⁶. This is applicable to politics too. We have to accept this rule; otherwise, we will fail.

In its capacity as security and even economic and commercial actor, Europe is weaker than other actors, particularly the US. This enrages them. Europe is now well-aware of this weakness, but it still considers itself to be the arbiter when it comes to ethics and norms. Europe expects all to submit to their self-arrogated ethical judgements; be it human rights or Israeli crimes or the JCPOA. One challenge facing the JCPOA was that the Europeans always considered themselves to be the judge of Iranian or American behavior. They were incapable of understanding the fact that

¹²⁶ Imam Ali (PBUH) says in Sermon 192 of *Nahj al-Balāgha*: "Do you not see how God humbled Satan because of his arrogance, and cast him down because he exalted himself? In this world, God made him rejected and cast out, and in the Hereafter He has prepared for him a blazing fire. Any sense of tribal superiority that appears in a Muslim comes only from Satan's whisperings—his calls that provoke pride, his instigations, and his poisonous breath. So, commit yourselves to placing humility upon your heads, to trampling feelings of superiority beneath your feet, to removing arrogance from around your necks. Take humility as a shield between you and your enemy—Satan and his forces. Therefore, fear God—fear God regarding the arrogance of tribal pride and the boastfulness of the Age of Ignorance. These are the breeding-grounds of hatred and the bellows with which Satan inflamed past nations and previous generations, until they plunged into the darkness of ignorance and the depths of misguidance. God protected His believing servants against this through prayer, almsgiving, and striving with fasting on the prescribed days—to calm their body, to make their eyes humble, to subdue their souls, to soften their hearts, and to remove vanity from them. For in these acts there is: pressing noble faces into the dust in humility, lowering honored limbs to the ground in smallness, and making empty stomachs cling to their backs through fasting in submission, along with the fact that alms divert the yields of the earth and other wealth to the people of need. Look at what is contained in these actions: the suppression of the sprouting of pride, and the cutting down of the rising shoots of arrogance."

Europe had fortified any role as Europeans had themselves failed to fulfil their economic obligations under the JCPOA.

This delusion is deeper and more pronounced in the field of human rights. The sense of moral superiority over others is stronger in Europe than in America. Without doubt, Europeans perceive themselves to be superior to all others when it comes to human rights, which even justifies their double standards. They really believe that Europe is the arbiter in every case and therefore the criterion is set by Europe's conduct and Western values. For this purpose, they choose to decide how to deal with Iranian or Saudi human rights records. In their perspective, Europe's position vis-à-vis others is one-sided, hierarchical and top-to-bottom, and therefore, Europe can decide about the entire world on the grounds of considering itself the moral and normative global center and compass.

Europe's support for Israeli atrocities is self-justified on this ground. Europe watches human rights violations by Israel. In some global fora, it votes against Israel. But why does it often declare Israeli atrocities as "self-defense"? Because it believes that Europe has done historic injustice against the Jews, and it now feels accountable. However, seeing itself as the global compass of ethics and morality, it is not worried that another nation pays for Europe's injustice against others. The crime was committed in Europe, but Muslims with no antisemitic history should pay such price because Europe deems itself to be the global compass of values and moral ethics.

This is groundless narcissism from which Europe cannot separate itself, nor does it even try. Although Europe has become aware of its incapacity in some domains, it lacks the strength and audacity to understand not being the normative compass of the world. Neither does it seek to reform this behavior. Therefore, establishing serious dialogue with Europe on human rights is extremely difficult. Dialogue per se is possible, but reaching common understanding is next to impossible. Common understanding requires accepting equal footing. The feeling of normative superiority will end in normative hegemony. In Europe's perspective, norm-setting and normative approach is exclusive to the West and even in the West, the Europeans feel themselves to be much more normative than the Americans. Therefore, they think they can judge others while nobody can judge their own conduct.

The Western governments say they have admitted any injustice they have committed, for which they have apologized and paid damages to the aggrieved parties or their survivors. For instance, Canada says it has killed 200 children; it paid compensation or apologized. Or Australia says it has apologized for the crimes it committed against Aborigines; it also claims to have paid damages and apologized. But can this clear the dark record of the West to let them sit in judgement of others? They are not sincere even in this specific claim. So many crimes were committed in Africa, but nobody has apologized or paid any damages. Britain triggered famine in Iran. Did it pay any compensation? Libya was subjected to so much atrocious behavior. But have survivors ever been compensated? The French committed crimes in Algeria. But did they pay damages to the survivors of the victims of their crimes?

On the other hand, as long as they continue with the same policies, any apology would be a mere farce. Therefore, Europe's alleged promotion of human rights is not genuine. The foregoing does not contend that human rights values are not global. These values are certainly global despite some faults in appearance and content, but Europe in no way owns them. Neither is Europe competent to judge others, because the defendant cannot be the judge or even claimant. That is a structural critique of European approach.

In fulfilment of Europe's JCPOA obligations, the Europeans themselves acknowledged that their firms were more compliant with Washington's instructions than to regulations of the European Union or various states. It was proven to them that if the U.S. decides to take any action, even detrimental to Europe's interests, Europe will have no option but to comply. The "European Strategic Autonomy" notion pursued by French President Emmanuel Macron and the German government is based, according to their own words, on the tragic experience of the JCPOA. In fact, this notion existed in Europe earlier, but the JCPOA proved to the Europeans that they truly need such independence. Of course, in the wake of the Russian aggression against Ukraine, which led to self-denigration of the entire Europe vis-à-vis the U.S., strategic autonomy slogans lost steam. Nonetheless, as the U.S. game of sacrificing Ukraine for rebuilding dominance on the West and NATO comes to bold relief anew, the strategic autonomy aspiration is making a comeback.

Europe has a relative understanding of modern global processes in various sectors. For instance, they have understood that the world is headed towards a post-Western pattern, but the West-centered and supremacist normative vision is still standing. Europe thinks that with its economic advantages, it can get the upper hand on global norm-setting, little knowing that China would wrest the economic advantage in a matter of years. Will they be ready then to accept, as Huntington speculated, that China becomes the global norm-setting center and Chinese norms dominate the world? This is the challenge Europe is yet to tackle, which has led to intellectual and practical disorders in the field of human rights and other sectors.

Opportunities in Europe

Despite the existence of fundamental challenges in Iranian ties with Europe, balanced relations with Europe are beneficial for Iran. First and foremost, that would balance Iran's foreign ties. Doubtlessly, we need to have balanced ties with the entire world and from this perspective, Europe is a key player. Despite all shortcomings and challenges, Europe is an ineliminable actor. Europe is a reality and will remain so. Let's keep in mind that we have not reached the end of Europe; rather, we are seeing the end of Eurocentric and West-centered era.

Secondly, we can learn from Europe in certain domains. If our trade with Europe can have a normal flow, we can learn many standards of global trading and specific regulations from Europe. Evidently, complying with these regulations and standards would help us become competitive in order to regain our rightful place in the midst of global competition. This key objective would be attainable only through transparent and unfettered trading bonds with Europe, which is also a basic prerequisite for economic growth.

We need to overcome sanctions and challenges associated with the Financial Action Task Force (FATF) so that our commercial and economic bonds with the world would not be clandestine and non-transparent.

In addition to being contaminated with rake-off and corruption, clandestine commercial ties would cause all sorts of hardship for entrepreneurs and investors. More importantly, as long as sanctions and

FATF challenges are in effect, our economy will never become competitive. With sanctions and other barriers in monetary and banking transactions, we can never compete at the global level and even within our own neighborhood and in the fields of our relative advantage. Only through healthy bonds with European countries and others, can we elevate ourselves to a level to compete globally, which would be otherwise impossible. Therefore, besides political advantages and creating equilibrium, ties with Europe have economic value.

Never should foreign ties be regarded dogmatically and based on black-and-white thinking. Some assert that Europe constantly follows in the U.S. footsteps. Should the U.S. decide that ties with Iran be severed, Europe will follow suit. That is why they say ties with Europe would have no benefit for Iran. But the affinity of relations between the United States and various European countries is not similar. Some European countries agree with the United States in 90 percent of all cases, while others may only align with 70 or 60 percent of U.S. policies. Discrepancies always remain and it is not so that a country remains fully cooperative and another entirely adversarial. Therefore, in our perceptions too, we should exercise moderation and contemplation. We should not see Europe with enamor or resentment. In transnational ties are not love or hate affairs. We have interests; diverse interests which are dependent on time, location, subject and target.

Under the Rouhani Administration, we had multilayer and complex cases with Europe. The complexity existed at both micro and macro levels. At macro-level, Europe was engaged in the JCPOA with us. We were interacting with the EU in the position of a multilateral entity and a political reality. We were grappling with the focal position of France, Germany and Britain. This troika is more than willing to speak for the entire Europe, but they are not in such a position. Britain is no longer even an EU member.

In the course of Iran-EU dialogue, several cases have been on the agenda: Europe put West Asia, terrorism, WMDs, human rights and most recently Iran's nuclear program on the agenda. For its part, Iran placed Islamophobia, Shiaphobia, Iranophobia, double standards, sponsoring terrorism and Israeli crimes on the agenda. Their dialogue has occasionally

included technical, economic and regional cooperation. However, at micro-level, we do not treat European countries and even the troika equally and our ties with each is subject to its own specific agenda.

Another layer of our review is the rest of Europe, i.e., Southern Europe, Northern Europe, Central Europe and Eastern Europe. As I noted before, Europe and ties with Europe constitute a complex and multilayer question. The key to balanced foreign relations is first and foremost correct understanding. That imperative is not limited to ties with Europe; rather, we need similar understanding of all our counterparts. We have to identify the strengths and tendencies of our counterparts and understand their concerns. Furthermore, we should correctly identify opportunities and challenges of each bond in order to be able to cooperate. We have to keep in mind that transnational ties are not built upon enamor and resentment; rather they take shape through finding common views, identifying reciprocal needs and accepting mutual benefits.

I have extensively spoken to the Europeans about their abject failure to fulfil their JCPOA obligations. However, we must acknowledge that our political victories in 2020 at the UN Security Council and General Assembly and the U.S. humiliation in three successive failures would not have been possible without Europe's assistance. We should realize where Europe can be of help. We cannot expect a screwdriver to function as a spanner for us. Neither would we expect the opposite. If we use a spanner for unscrewing, we risk breaking the screw. Should we use a screwdriver to unscrew a nut, it may go wrong so that even a screwdriver would no longer be of any help. That is a simple example of modalities of cooperation in global relations.

If like Armenia that was waiting for Europe to protect it militarily against Azerbaijan's invasion, we pin hopes on Europe beyond its power, interests and desires, our aspirations will never come true. We hoped that Europe could safeguard Iran's economy against U.S. sanctions. That showed we were going the wrong way and our expectations were misplaced.

Before President Trump's withdrawal from the JCPOA, the Europeans themselves were overestimating their own independent capacities in trading and banking transactions. The overcompliance of European firms with U.S. sanctions served as wakeup call for European leaders. Although

officially and based on its arrogance, Europe always shifted the blame on the US and most recently on Iran in a bid to exonerate itself of any breach, in private talks, EU leaders and even the troika admitted that Washington has more impact than Brussels over European enterprises.

But if we expect Europe to stand by Iran at the UN Security Council—and even that only for a short period of time—in support of the JCPOA against President Trump's unbridled bullying and defeat the U.S., we can benefit from Europe's strengths and tendencies in favor of our own needs because we have correctly understood Europe's tendencies, concerns and fields of competition with America. But if one imagines that such readiness exists in other sectors like the missile program, human rights or West Asia, we are once more going astray.

Therefore, the first step would be to have a correct understanding, followed by management of expectations and finally seizing the right moment. Even for longtime allies, the world is not a world of permanent alliances anymore. The post-polar world is one of temporary and issue coalitions even between Europe and the US. In order to avoid any all-or-nothing perception of Europe, we must realize this pivotal character of all transnational ties.

In dealing with Europe, we must deal with questions and challenges from various angles and alongside a philosophical and intellectual outlook, explore clearly defined political interests. The Europeans have long had ties with Iran in various spheres. On numerous occasions, they have been Iran's first trading partner and the source of modern science and technology for the country. Nonetheless, they lost this superiority even before the JCPOA. Pre-JCPOA sanctions replaced Europe with China, although China, benefitting from enormous capabilities, was able to develop similar bonds with many other countries that were not even under sanctions. China had a great advantage in Iran, because its economy was big enough to withstand sanctions while Iran was ready to accept higher financial costs as Western governments had closed all ways of economic and commercial cooperation.

One advantage the Europeans had in Iran and are now losing it at a high pace is that Iranian entrepreneurs and manufacturers have been accustomed to working with Europe and had a strong bias in its favor.

Europe was the source of modern science and technology for Iran and Iranians favored every European product, considering Chinese and Asian products, even Japanese and Taiwanese ones, as low-quality. Most factories in Iran were also built on European machinery. Science and technology in the country had a Western and European origin; training and expertise all came from Europe and the West. They could have made far better use of this advantage, but they did not. Europeans imagined that such standing would be permanent. Just like us who think that the world does not move without us. After sanctions were imposed, Europe joined the United States and pulled out of Iran, hoping that Iran's market would remain dependent on Europe forever. But they gradually lost this market. Even if all sanctions are lifted at once, Europe can no longer regain the status it had in Iran. The Europeans are badly mistaken if they imagine that all doors will be open to them if they decide to return to Iran.

The Europeans would be locked in tough competition with China and Russia to restore their past position and they may no longer succeed. The later they come back, the tougher this competition will become. The Europeans once enjoyed such superior position, but now that superiority has declined, contrary to what the Europeans and some in Iran may think. Interestingly, this erroneous assumption is shared by Europhobes and Europhiles alike. However, I think once sanctions end, Europe will no longer have the position it had before and its standing in Iran would be much inferior to what they imagine.

The JCPOA

It may be appropriate now to shift from Europe to Iran's nuclear issue. It would not be necessary to extensively discuss the nuclear issue in this chapter as I and my colleagues have already explained the entire process in more than 3,000 pages with supporting documents in a six-volume book in Persian called *Raz-e Sar be Mohr* (The Untold Story). Here I will only highlight some nuances that have not been correctly understood in Iran or have been mis-portrayed by factional misinformation campaign.

Since the end of the Cold war and preoccupied with the emergence of China, the United States, in a bi-partisan consensus—driven and

pushed primarily by the neoconservative movement--tried to entrench and solidify U.S. dominance in a unipolar world through what became known as "forever wars", taking advantage of U.S. military superiority before China could challenge "the new world order." This strategy was displayed in its most vivid form following the election of George W. Bush in 2000, particularly after the terrorist attack on the United States on 11 September 2001, enabling to label its "forever wars" for dominance as "the "war on terror."

After the U.S. intervention in Afghanistan and the pursuit of al-Qaeda at Tora Bora, influential American strategists argued that defeating a non-state actor in remote terrain could not constitute decisive victory or establish U.S. hegemony; rather, such a demonstration required the overthrow of a sovereign government. This logic was articulated by neoconservative networks such as the Project for the New American Century¹²⁷ and echoed by senior officials and commentators—including Paul Wolfowitz, Donald Rumsfeld, Charles Krauthammer¹²⁸, and Robert Kagan and William Kristol¹²⁹—who argued that regime change in Iraq, rather than counterterrorism against militants in caves, was necessary to establish American credibility and reorder the Middle East.

The WMD accusations against Iraq, coupled with Baghdad's refusal to comply with UN Security Council resolutions, only served as a pretext for an invasion that pursued long-term global objectives; the Realists' Clash of Civilizations, President Bush Sr.'s New World Order, Neoconservatives' Project for the New American Century (PNAC) and the Liberalists' End of History among others.

In U.S. circles and regional lobbies, a serious tug-of-war was underway about the target of new invasion with Iran and Iraq being the primary targets. The Israeli Prime Minister Ariel Sharon visited Washington in February 2002 and emphasized Iran as a greater strategic threat than Iraq

¹²⁷ Project for the New American Century, Letter to President George W. Bush on the War Against Terrorism, September 20, 2001. See also Bob Woodward, *Bush at War* (New York: Simon & Schuster, 2002), esp. chap. 3.

¹²⁸ Charles Krauthammer, "The Unipolar Moment Revisited," *The National Interest*, Winter 2002–2003.

¹²⁹ Robert Kagan and William Kristol, "What to Do About Iraq," *The Weekly Standard*, January 21, 2002

and sought to shift U.S. focus toward Tehran, warning U.S. policymakers that "Iran poses a greater threat than Iraq", indicating Israel's broader concern about Tehran even as Washington's policy debates were centering on Baghdad.¹³⁰ According to Newsweek: "As one senior British official put it: "Everyone wants to go to Baghdad. Real men want to go to Tehran."¹³¹

As noted earlier, the Bush Administration favored targeting Iraq for two fundamental reasons. The most important reason for not invading Iran was the difficulty of winning a potential war. In addition to its size and geography¹³², the Iranian government at the time enjoyed profound and firm popular support, which would have exposed any foreign invasion to strong resistance. The second reason was the global consensus against Iraq that had been under Chapter VII of UN Charter since 1990. Although the Security Council was not ready to legitimize any new invasion, the resolutions adopted in rapid succession over the previous 12 years justified a war on Iraq much more easily than military action on Iran that was enjoying a better internal and international standing thanks to President Mohammad Khatami and his initiative of Dialogue Among Civilizations.

It was under such circumstances that in 2002, the Iranian nuclear file was fabricated by Israel in collaboration with Arabs and promoted by the Iranian opposition/terrorist group Mujahedin-e-Khalq (MeK) whose agents were serving as Iraq's proxy across the globe, with a view to preventing a second war in Iraq and dragging the U.S. into war with Iran. That was a temporary alliance for the purpose of sparing Iraq any threat and instead destroying the financial and ideational power of Iran under a reformist administration, which was carried out through framing Iran as a threat and accusing it of military diversion in its nuclear program.

Although the U.S. Administration had made up its mind about the war on Iraq with the foregoing motivations, it had no difficulty with attempts to demonize and securitize Iran. No group in the U.S. wanted to see Iran emerge as the winner of U.S. war on Iraq. Therefore, securitizing Iran, instead of direct war, was the best solution to reach

¹³⁰ "Israel Emphasizes Iranian Threat", Washington Post, February 7, 2002

¹³¹ https://www.newsweek.com/beyond-baghdad-expanding-target-list-144099?utm_source=chatgpt.com

¹³² <https://www.independent.org/news/article.asp?id=1330>

both objectives at the same time: global dominance through a rapid and significant victory against Saddam Hussein, who was resented internally and isolated externally, while simultaneously dragging Iran into an endless securitization cycle that has continued to this day. This cycle has debilitated Iran for over two decades.

At the same time, the troika of Britain, France and Germany in Europe, set up another temporary alliance to stave off the threat of war against Iran. Each of the trio might have been pursuing different objectives. Britain's Tony Blair decided to join the U.S. war on Iraq, but he was not prepared to see U.S. enamor for a unipolar world open a new front with Iran. In Premier Blair's perspective, the invasion of Iraq enjoyed international legitimacy on the grounds of 12 years of security consensus against Iraq owing to Chapter VII UN Security Council's resolutions. But a potential war on Iran would be devoid of any globally acceptable pretext. By contract, France and Germany were opposed to U.S. belligerency and its aim of building a unipolar world. They were and continue to be inspired with the hope that in a post-Cold War multipolar world, the EU would become one of global pillars. Therefore, despite differences in motives, the three pursued an identical objective: to prevent Israel's securitization game from triggering a U.S. war on Iran.

Motivated by this common objective and enjoying a solid position within the IAEA Board of Governors, the E3 came to Tehran. After the Tehran Declaration was adopted in October 2003, E3 took the initiative within the IAEA Board of Governors. Europe's capability to outmaneuver the United States in the Board of Governors was an outcome of the aforesaid Europe normative advantage on one side and its effective consensus building ability and contribution to the IAEA on the other. Europe had both the will as well as the power to advance its agenda at the IAEA, even contrary to the policies and interests of the United States. Therefore, the E3 initiative was launched by their foreign ministers in their visit to Tehran. Some EU members, like Italy, were not happy with the E3's self-arrogated representation of the entire European Union. The U.S. was also taking advantage of this internal rivalry in sowing discord within the bloc. The E3 states were standing against the U.S. over Iran's nuclear file at the IAEA Board of Governors. The U.S. chose to form a rival coalition

called G4 (Australia, Japan, Canada and the U.S.) to stand against the Iran initiative by the E3 but failed to win the support of the rest of the Board of Governors.

In a bid to address Italy's opposition, the E3 added the EU to their group. EU foreign policy chief Javier Solana's engagement showed that other EU member states were not satisfied with the E3 representing them. Solana and his successors gradually became the focal point in the nuclear talks with Iran. However, until the last meeting between Dr. Rouhani, in his capacity as Iran's chief nuclear negotiator, and the E3 ministers in Geneva in May 2005, British Foreign Secretary Jack Straw—and not Javier Solana—coordinated the E3 side. Depending on which of the trio hosted the meetings, it represented the European party and the EU was marginal. But due to in-house differences, the EU found a central position and the E3/EU took shape.

After the IAEA Board of Governors reported Iran's nuclear dossier to the UN Security Council, other permanent members of the Security Council were added to the group. Therefore, P51+ is not a precise title. It was not Germany that was added to the list. Germany was present in the initial group; otherwise, it did not have any specific standing to join the five Security Council permanent members. When Iran's nuclear case was referred to the Security Council in February 2006, the addition of permanent members to the European initiative became necessary. Therefore, the U.S., China and Russia – three permanent members of the Security Council – were added to the group and the EU/E33+ emerged. In all official documents, the group is referred to as EU/E33+ although in journalism and day-to-day conversation the more common P51+ is used.

Another key event occurred in 2005 after National Security Advisor Condoleezza Rice was confirmed as Secretary of State. The US set aside its policy of confrontation with Europe. As soon as Ms. Rice took office at the Department of State, the Americans admitted to the failure of unilateralism and reliance on brute force, and shifted their approach to multilateralism and cooperation with Europe to the detriment of Iran. The U.S. multilateralism cost Iran much more than its unilateralism, just as with Joe Biden's election. Europe shifted back to the US.

We should also keep in mind that in 2005, an administration came to office in Iran that embraced the “brakeless nuclear train” policy without noting the U.S. policy shift away from its previous policy of “forever wars”. Similarly, when Biden was elected president, the Raisi Administration policy of “separating people’s livelihood from the JCPOA” in Iran prepared the ground anew for Europe-U.S. convergence.

The failure of Neocons’ “forever wars” and replacing it with international cooperation promoted the second Bush Administration to exploit Europe’s normative power for building security consensus against Iran. In the meantime, Europe’s eagerness to rebuild its bonds with the U.S. following an Atlantic divide caused by the second U.S. war on Iraq resulted in the formation of an issue coalition against Iran. In order to advance their own interests through presence in this new global endeavor, Russia and China joined this temporary coalition against Iran. Optimistically, the new coalition was built to encourage multilateralism or in their own words, to ward off U.S. military action against Iran. This is how the EU/E33+ arrangement came to being.

A new anti-Iran security coalition required portraying a horrible image of Iran. President Ahmadinejad’s unconventional policies provided a unique opportunity. Rarely has it been mentioned that the first statement from the UN Security Council during President Ahmadinejad’s tenure was not nuclear-related. The Security Council’s statement before Resolution 1696 was the third one against Iran just a few months after Mr. Ahmadinejad took office. President Ahmadinejad’s call for Israel to be “wiped off the map” during the “The World without Zionism” conference in Tehran provided the pretext for the first Security Council statement against Iran¹³³. President Ahmadinejad’s questioning of the Holocaust on the sidelines of the Organization of Islamic Conference (OIC)’s summit – which has its own tragic story – facilitated the second statement¹³⁴.

¹³³ The members of the Security Council condemn the remarks about Israel attributed to H.E. Mr. Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The members of the Security Council support the Secretary-General’s statement of 27 October noting that, under the United Nations Charter, all Members have undertaken to refrain from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any State. (SC/8542, 28 October 2005)

¹³⁴ The members of the Security Council condemn the remarks about Israel and the denial of the Holocaust attributed to Dr. Mahmoud Ahmadinejad, President of the Islamic Republic of Iran. The members of the Security Council fully support the Secretary General’s statement of 8 December, in

Therefore, the process of building security consensus against Iran had begun ahead of the referral of the Iranian nuclear case from the IAEA Board of Governors to the Security Council. President Ahmadinejad was pursuing unconventional, uncalculated and inconsistent policies that pushed Europe farther away from Iran and closer to the United States. Finally, after over two years of differences over Iran's nuclear case, not only U.S. and Europe came together but also brought along China and Russia, who supported all Security Council resolutions against Iran. The achievements of more than two years of patient diplomacy went up in flames. By November 2004, we had created a deep gap between Europe and the US. The American UN ambassador at the time, John Bolton, was trying hard to take Iran's nuclear case to the Security Council while Europe was successfully closing the case even at the IAEA Governing Board¹³⁵.

When Iran's nuclear case was finally reported to the Security Council in February 2006, a new temporary coalition was built. The E3 countries that were until then coordinating and managing the nuclear file, needed the three permanent members of UN Security Council. Iran's government at the time imagined that Russian and Chinese integration into the group would play in Iran's favor, little knowing that for Russia and China, non-proliferation was also an important focus in their own global strategy. Tehran made another strategic mistake, engaging Turkey and Brazil in the case, which caused Russia and China to feel that Iran was undermining their valued role as permanent members of the Security Council. All evidence indicate that this episode may have been engineered by President Obama in order to agitate Russia and China into endorsing resolution 1929 against Iran which included unprecedented provisions. I am convinced that without the Turkey-Brazil initiative which further alienated Russia and China from Iran, it would have been very difficult for the United States to convince them not to veto the resolution, let alone vote in favor.

which he recalled that the General Assembly had recently adopted a resolution rejecting denial of the Holocaust as a historical event, either in full or in part, and urged all Member States to educate their populations about the Holocaust. The members of the Security Council reaffirm the rights and obligations of the State of Israel as a full and long-standing Member of the United Nations, and reaffirm that, under the United Nations Charter, all Members have undertaken to refrain from the threat or use of force against the territorial integrity or political independence of any State. (SC/8576, 9 December 2005)

¹³⁵ Gov/2004/90

Therefore, the Rouhani Administration inherited conditions where Europe had been fully aligned with U.S. while Russia and China considered themselves as a part of E3+ rather than allies of Iran. By the end of the nuclear talks under the Khatami Administration, we handed over the case to the Ahmadinejad Administration, Europe was still standing against the US. Of course, before then and more specifically in early Spring 2005, Europe started responding positively to Condoleezza Rice's gestures and accepting U.S. proposal that in return to small concessions by the United States, E3 would join the United States in reporting Iran to the Security Council if Iran resumed enrichment in a report to authorities, I warned that Europe was tilting in the U.S.'s favor. To further persuade Europe, the U.S. had announced it would not oppose Iran's membership in the World Trade Organization (WTO). Some in Tehran optimistically imagined that the U.S. had shifted towards Europe; however, Europe had also accepted that should the U.S. help Europe fulfil its obligations to Iran under the 2004 Paris Agreement and Iran resumed enrichment, Europe would immediately join the U.S. in reporting the Iranian nuclear case to the Security Council.

It may be instructive to examine the developments of the 2002-2005-period and review key events in U.S.-Europe ties. In the course of U.S. invasion of Iraq, Germany and France stood against the U.S. while Britain joined it. The Secretary of Defense at the time, Donald Rumsfeld, divided Old Europe and New Europe. In reaction to Europe's opposition, Secretary Rice said: "Ignore Germany, forgive Russia and punish France". The political psychology of this period is very important. Unprecedented tensions had flared up between European powers and the US. The U.S.-Europe divide was an important factor in E3 effort to prevent the United States from taking the Iranian nuclear case to the Security Council. But alas, President Ahmadinejad's policies and speeches in 2005 turned Iran's nuclear file into a bridge for renewed cooperation between Europe and the U.S. and even other permanent members of the Security Council.

Since the 1979 Islamic Revolution, Iran served to close the gap between global powers on three occasions. The first one was the beginning of the Iraqi imposed war, when the five permanent members of the Security Council encouraged or at least tolerated the invasion and occupation of

important parts of Iranian territory by Iraq from 1980 to 1982. The second instance was in the drafting and adoption of Resolution 598 to end the war in 1988 where five world powers joined hands to prevent an Iranian victory at the height of the Cold War. And the third one came in 2005 when not only France and Germany but even Russia and China joined the U.S. and Britain over Iran's nuclear file. In 2002, a deep gap had been created in the Western world due to the U.S. invasion of Iraq and the refusal of France and Germany to join the US-led coalition. France, along with Russia and China, threatened to block a "second resolution" at the Security Council to authorize Anglo-American invasion of Iraq and removal of Saddam Hussein. However, in 2005, the gap was narrowed and disappeared as all permanent members came together to adopt three statements against Iran in the first 6 months of President Ahmadinejad, followed by resolution 696 in less than a year following his assumption of Iranian presidency. Iran served as a bridge between America, Europe, Russia and China for at least one decade.

When I was appointed Minister of Foreign Affairs in the first Rouhani Administration, Iran's ties with Europe were frozen. The highest-level contact with us was at the level of experts. Even European directors rarely communicated with us. The relations improved after Rouhani took office, which restarted nuclear talks with world powers in the lead-up to the JCPOA. President Rouhani and I visited Europe officially many times. Some European heads of state and all foreign ministers came to Tehran. Our relations with Europe witnessed fundamental transformation. European countries offered to invest heavily in Iran after the conclusion of the JCPOA—as Europe could not be considered independently from the JCPOA during the 2010s.

Nuclear talks under the Rouhani Administration coincided with two key events: the E3+Iran dialogue, led by the then chief nuclear negotiator Saeed Jalili, had been locked. Dialogue with EU foreign policy chief Catherine Ashton had stalled and there was no solution for breaking the deadlock. Secret talks had begun in Muscat through the courageous efforts of the then foreign minister Salehi in 2012, but two rounds of talks under the Ahmadinejad Administration were obstructed domestically. The issue of recognition of Iran's uranium enrichment as the focal point of Iranian

negotiators had not reached any bright outcome. The Europeans were unaware of the talks. The treatment of key European allies by the United States is very instructive. In the Muscat talks, the Americans promises on Europe's behalf were much more generous than those they made on their own behalf. For instance, they said that Europe would lift sanctions, but in the U.S., Congress should decide whether or not sanctions could be lifted.

Europe only has itself to blame for this state of submission. Europe was the center of dialogue with Iran up until 2005. But eager to improve its ties with the U.S., and despite the failure of U.S. unilateralism that had pushed Washington towards Europe, the EU/E3 transferred the management of Iran's nuclear case to the U.S., thereby losing its pivotal status in the talks. Of course, President Ahmadinejad's emotional and ill-considered policies played a major role in this process. The EU and E3 proved their ultimate lack of prudence on 23 March 2005 during a meeting of Iranian and E3 political directors in Paris. In that meeting, as the Iranian chief delegate and after receiving green light from high authorities, I offered a framework to the Europeans, which is available in Annex 6. France and Germany were receptive to the offer. Britain's approach was also constructive. But John Bolton—who was then Under-Secretary of State—repeatedly contacted them from Washington in the course of that session, pressuring the Europeans to not accept my offer. In the end, due to U.S. obstructionism and the Europeans' backdown, the proposal ended in failure¹³⁶. The proposal was based on reciprocal steps by Iran and the European troika on non-proliferation and extensive economic cooperation. The JCPOA follows the same logic, except that at that time, Iran was not under nuclear sanctions and therefore its central demand was objective guarantees for broader economic, technological and political cooperation and not lifting of sanctions. The situation was different during the JCPOA talks. But the logic of the March 2003 proposal consisting of transparency and limits on Iranian nuclear program in exchange for economic advantages were similar to the logic of JCPOA. A glance at that proposal would illustrate the absurdity of the contention that the JCPOA was drafted by the International Crisis Group.

¹³⁶ https://www.armscontrol.org/factsheets/Iran_Nuclear_Proposals

In the end, the EU/E3 ditched the offer and on 8 August 2005 gave a rude response to Iran, which bore no clear logic and was incompatible with previous frameworks and talks. In response, Iran resumed UF6 production at Isfahan's Uranium Conversion Facility (UCF), after which the Europeans boarded the U.S. train, but the U.S. did not treat them as partners.

When the U.S. started secret talks with Iran in Muscat in 2012, it ignored the Europeans. As we have detailed in Chapter 1 of *Raz-e Sar be Mohr* based on interviews with Iranian officials at the time, the first round of talks in Muscat under the Ahmadinejad Administration was only about the level of talks and the agenda. The second round was held nearly one year after the first round, which failed to reach the end result due to disputes over recognition of Iran's right to enrichment. During the transition following the 2013 presidential election, President-elect Rouhani and I were informed for the first time of the talks and decided to pursue them in a methodic and goal-oriented manner, as authorized by Ayatollah Khamenei.

We had an integrated plan for the confidential talks in Muscat at the start of the Rouhani Administration. Our most pivotal concern was that the step-by-step proposal that Russia had presented in the EU/E3+ talks during the Ahmadinejad Administration could not yield any result without a clear image of a what we all expected in the final agreement. No party would be willing to take the initial steps without a clear perspective about the expected final outcome. I highlighted this approach in my opening remarks in our first ministerial meeting with the E3+ at the sidelines of the UN General Assembly on 26 September 2013. In those remarks, which set the agenda for bilateral talks in Muscat and multilateral talks in Geneva for an interim deal and finally multilateral talks in Vienna for the JCPOA, I said:

We have come to New York with serious determination to define our common objective, the ultimate goal, and the initial steps, as well as to establish the framework of the talks, including an appropriate timeline and the details of the steps that both sides will take until a final agreement is reached. At the same time, within this framework we should not become so absorbed in technical minutiae that the process is unnecessarily prolonged.

We are prepared for such an agreement. If we fail to reach one, you will increase sanctions, and we will increase centrifuges. You know that even under the current sanctions we have significantly increased the number of centrifuges. From our perspective, this trajectory has been a lose–lose situation. We must transform it into a win–win outcome. A zero-sum approach benefits neither side. The very nature of this interaction must change.

Our government is ready to begin a serious dialogue aimed at changing this course. At this stage, our assessment is that reaching the shared final objective within the coming year is possible. We are prepared to move forward on this path with sustained, round-the-clock effort and firm resolve.

The vision we have for the final objective is as follows: the continuation of enrichment under IAEA supervision, accompanied by transparency-enhancing measures within a defined and specific program—particularly with respect to the number of centrifuges and the capacity of enrichment facilities on our side—concurrent with, or rather simultaneously with, the lifting of all UN Security Council sanctions and your unilateral sanctions.

However, to reach this final objective, the first step could involve the removal of some sanctions in exchange for steps by Iran to address certain immediate concerns of yours, namely the 20 percent enrichment program. While our ultimate goal is the lifting of all sanctions, and at minimum the unilateral ones, the first step may be more limited, so as to make our momentum toward subsequent steps feasible.

We must enter these talks in a professional and constructive manner, and we should not prolong them by resorting to the kind of bargaining common in Eastern bazaars. I hope you will approach the talks in the same spirit, so that a measure of trust can be established between the parties. I believe that within a defined timeframe, while clearly identifying the final objective of the negotiations, we should also specify the initial step or steps, and by taking the first step, move toward defining and implementing subsequent steps until we reach our shared goal.

In my view, this is the only solution to this file and the only way to advance a policy that benefits everyone.

These remarks—and the global atmosphere that followed the broad public participation in Iran's 2013 election—made it possible, in a short period of time, to reach results both in the confidential Muscat talks and in the multilateral negotiations in Geneva. It is important to recognize the unique role that the high turnout in the 2013 election played in achieving the diplomatic gains that followed, and to treat it as a model for the country's future conduct. The people occupy the first and most fundamental place in Iran's transnational and global power. No pillar of legitimacy and public support is taller or more solid, and nothing strengthens deterrence, expands influence, and reduces a country's vulnerability more effectively than the backing of its people. The high turnout proved that sanctions had failed in their core objective, separating the public from the government.

With this substantial backing, and through exhausting bilateral negotiations with the United States, as well as three rounds of multilateral talks with the EU/E33+, we reached an understanding on the ultimate goal: preserving enrichment while providing credible assurance that Iran was not pursuing nuclear weapons. We also agreed on initial steps and the broad outlines of intermediate steps—an understanding reflected in the Geneva interim agreement. Some have claimed that enrichment and sanctions lifting had already been granted to Iran under the Ahmadinejad administration, and that the JCPOA achieved nothing and merely imposed obligations on Iran. That claim is baseless—though I had anticipated such unfounded criticisms. For that reason, I was neither personally prepared to become entangled in this file, nor did I consider it advisable for Mr. Khatami or Mr. Rouhani to enter this arena.

Even after the Geneva interim agreement, a famous newspaper—which has never ceased to attack me over the past 35 years—wrote that the United States had given no guarantee of enrichment on Iranian soil¹³⁷. Yet after the JCPOA was concluded and Iran's nuclear achievements were formally

¹³⁷ Keyhan, Number 20648, 4 Azar 1392(25 November 2013).

recognized, some still denied this central accomplishment. They argued that the lifting of all sanctions and recognition of enrichment rights had already been secured in President Obama's letters to Iran's Leader and in the Ahmadinejad administration's talks. In reality, what Mr. Obama had written, and what William Burns—the then—Deputy Secretary of State—read out in Muscat II and even in the first round of talks with the Rouhani administration's representatives, amounted to this: the United States might accept enrichment and lift nuclear-related sanctions only gradually, and only if Iran implemented Security Council resolutions. Those resolutions—adopted under Chapter VII of the UN Charter—demanded, among other things, suspension of Iran's nuclear program (except the Bushehr power plant), adoption of the Additional Protocol, resolution of the “possible military dimensions” with the IAEA, and so on. Even symbolic enrichment was conditioned upon Iran carrying out those Security Council obligations. We accepted none of that; and under the JCPOA we did not suspend any part of our nuclear program—even for a moment.

In our very first meeting in the Security Council informal consultation room, I told my counterparts that we viewed the Security Council resolutions as the central problem in the nuclear talks—not a solution.

The Islamic Republic of Iran's position rests on the right of all countries to peaceful use of nuclear technology, to receive assistance, and to strengthen global cooperation in pursuit of the objectives of the Non-Proliferation Treaty in accordance with its Articles 1, 3, and 4. On that basis, referring Iran's nuclear file to the Security Council and imposing sanctions against Iran had no sound legal foundation. If Security Council sanctions lack legal legitimacy, then unilateral sanctions are, *a fortiori*, even less justifiable—especially given that they are unconstructive and deeply unjust. Nevertheless, despite these concerns about both Security Council and unilateral sanctions, because we seek to negotiate constructively in order to resolve the nuclear file, we have decided not to return to the past; our focus is on the talks at hand.

Iran's election created an exceptionally favorable opportunity and international climate to bring this challenge to an end. That said, we

do not believe this group represents the “international community,” because the international community is far broader than this small circle. For example, the Non-Aligned Movement—whose meeting I attended immediately before coming to this meeting—includes most of the world’s states, yet it has no place in this group’s composition. Still, we must recognize that the window now open to us is a narrow one; we should make the maximum use of it before it closes. At the same time, our approach must change if the talks are to advance. The parties have objectives that need not stand as rivals. Iran’s objective is to secure peaceful nuclear technology, including enrichment; the international community’s objective is assurance that Iran’s program is peaceful. These objectives reinforce one another and should be treated as our shared goals.

I state with complete certainty that, for political, historical, strategic, and religious reasons, the Islamic Republic of Iran has no intention of producing or using nuclear weapons. Historically, Iran has been a victim of chemical weapons, which is why we have taken the lead in preventing their use. In the Syrian case, Iran helped facilitate Syria’s accession to the Chemical Weapons Convention. Strategically, Iran is the largest country in the region and naturally possesses inherent advantages over its neighbors. In the past many centuries¹³⁸, Iran has attacked no country; it has consistently been the region’s leading power by relying on its own domestic resources. By contrast, other states in the region have repeatedly depended on outside powers to purchase security. With this inherent superiority in our surrounding region, we have no need for nuclear weapons as a means of asserting power. And religiously, the Supreme Leader’s fatwa—also referenced by President Obama—is an inseparable part of Iran’s foreign and security policy.

Given all this, your objective is our objective. And our objective—maintaining a peaceful nuclear program, including enrichment on Iranian soil—should be your objective as well, because Iran’s

¹³⁸ Many researchers believe that throughout its long history, Iran never invaded any country and rather it was invaded. They also say Iran’s wars during the past two millennia have been defensive. However, in my speech, I stressed the minimum consensus view.

nuclear program is indigenous: it is the product of the effort and creativity of the country's specialists. This means Iran will not need to turn to black markets to sustain its program. Iran has also accepted IAEA oversight as a principled policy. That is precisely what should serve your interest.

To disrupt Iran's nuclear program, they resorted to assassinating our scientists. Yet the program did not pause, because it is indigenous and firmly rooted in domestic expertise. If I were in your position and in your capitals, I would be concerned about the consequences of threats and escalating pressure against Iran's nuclear program—because such pressure cannot stop it. It will either push the program underground or drive Iran toward black markets. Therefore, the best outcome is for the IAEA to supervise the program—an outcome that is also our objective. These two aims are shared goals: they are not opposed and can coexist.

Confidence-building between the parties is unavoidable and must be achieved through negotiations that are not open-ended, and that build trust rather than erode it. The IAEA, too, has two tasks: verifying past activities and monitoring future activities, the second of which is more crucial. We are prepared to cooperate in both areas, and that forms the basis for confidence in the peaceful nature of Iran's nuclear program.

At the same time, we should recognize that the best guarantee—and the most fundamental foundation—for keeping Iran's nuclear program peaceful is the creation of a sustainable, mutually beneficial ties between Iran and other countries, such that it would be irrational for Iran to destroy such a valuable relationship for the sake of a short-term goal. Building a strong and lasting relationship should therefore be our central aim. How can we reach it? In our view, this requires negotiations that build trust and have a clear purpose and outcome. It must be clear where we are going and what we aim to achieve; otherwise, along the way we will face discord and uncertainty about whether we are moving toward a shared goal. Second, the timetable for reaching the final objective should be

short. Negotiations with an open-ended timeline are unconstructive and trust-destroying.

The French foreign minister became very upset and said, “I am astonished that Iran’s foreign minister is being insolent to Security Council members in the Security Council room.” Yet within three months we overcame these obstacles, and ultimately, through the JCPOA, we showed that we had moved beyond them.

When we began drafting an agreement with the United States in Muscat, we told them that on matters negotiated with you, we would not re-open talks with Europe. The American representatives promised they would bring the three European countries along. But when the Europeans learned of our agreement, France—despite having led European de-escalation with Iran in 2003–2005—grew angry that the United States had sidelined it and began to obstruct. In my view, France has always sought a key role in the nuclear file. When the United States was not engaging Iran, France—more than Britain and Germany—spearheaded the talks. Once the United States entered direct talks with Iran, France positioned itself as the critic. But when Trump came to office, France returned to a more constructive role. In every meeting and phone call with President Rouhani, Mr. Macron tried to act as mediator. It seemed that for France, playing the leading role mattered more than the substance.

Although Europeans describe the JCPOA as the greatest achievement of European diplomacy, everyone knows it was the product of direct Iran–U.S. negotiations. Europe wanted, and we agreed, that the JCPOA be presented as a European success. But in truth, what was achieved flowed from the secret Muscat channel and from the talks among me and Secretary Kerry, as well as Dr. Salehi and Secretary Moniz and our colleagues. Dr. Salehi and Secretary Moniz were the ones who worked out the JCPOA’s nuclear technical details. This history once again shows that Europe lacked “strategic autonomy.”

The first sparks of the need for European independence in French thinking were lit not under Trump, but during Obama—because they realized that when the United States steps in, they are pushed aside. Of course, this sentiment has surfaced repeatedly in Europe, and especially

in France, since World War II, only to sink again like embers under ash. Its most recent manifestation can be seen in the painful story of Ukraine.

Europeans worked hard to get ahead and to quickly capture the post-JCPOA economic opportunities. Airbus and Total are two examples that reveal Europe's awareness of intense competition with others. Even in my meeting with Minister Fabius at the height of France's uproar over the draft negotiated between Iran and the United States, he spoke less about the draft itself and more about the fate of Peugeot and Citroën in Iran. At the time, everyone wanted to enter Iran's unique market, compete, and claim a share. One Western business magazine wrote that beside Mars, the most untouched investment opportunity in the universe was Iran¹³⁹.

The JCPOA story may be a mirror-image example of international relations in the post-polar era. The gap between Europe and the United States reflected competition alongside cooperation in a post-polar environment; and the closing of that gap symbolized temporary coalitions—at one stage even encompassing Russia and China. Before final rupture in September 2025—as E3 once again acted on orders from the United States to unjustifiably purport to invoke the dispute resolution mechanism in the Security Council, those two states considered themselves as members of that same coalition (the EU/E33+), not as aligned with Iran. In the JCPOA's evolution, one can clearly observe the ups and downs of Europe–U.S. relations. The rupture between Europe and the United States occurred during 2003–2005. After that came a period in which Iran served as a bridge between Europe and America. From 2006 onward—after the Security Council statement and Resolution 1696—all five permanent members moved together, and their alignment became a decade-long coalition. America's sidelining of Europe from the outset of the Muscat talks, and then America's withdrawal from the JCPOA—leaving Europe isolated, politically adrift, and ultimately forced to recognize that it had no operational capacity against the United States—are only part of the broader sequence of international developments reflected in the JCPOA's mirror.

¹³⁹ <https://www.reuters.com/article/mideast-investment-iran/reuters-summit-iran-nuclear-deal-would-open-last-big-frontier-stock-market-idINL6N0S329K20141015>

Europe, however, failed to learn from this experience. Enraged by Iran's ill-considered support for Russia during the Ukraine ordeal in the Raisi Administration, Europe sided with Trump in his second term. As will be discussed in future sections, the United States literally forced Europe to resort—unlawfully—to dispute resolution mechanism under UN Security Council Resolution 2231 in September 2025. The most significant outcome of this miscalculation by the E3 was that they destroyed their unique leverage as the only Western members of the JCPOA thus effectively sidelining themselves from any deal which will ultimately have to be made between Iran and the United States. Ironically, the Trump administration rewarded Europe by effectively making it the villain in its 2025 National Security Strategy¹⁴⁰.

I do not think that during the first Trump administration there was any deliberate division of roles between Europe and the United States. Europeans tried to prevent the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA but failed. After the withdrawal, they tried to preserve their economic ties with Iran but failed again. Of course, Europe was not prepared to stand united against the United States, because it had little to gain by doing so—just as China had little to gain in that regard. China, too, complied with the sanctions; Russia did as well. Still, those two countries—especially China—had avenues, given the size of their economies and the role of the state in them, to sustain profitable economic links with Iran through various channels. Even so, despite lacking Europe's strategic attachment to the United States, both countries reduced trade to a very low ceiling.

A strategic point about the United States' overuse of sanctions deserves careful scrutiny. The more the United States sanctions, the fewer levers it has left—because it has less influence over the entities it sanctions. So, the more it sanctions Chinese companies, the fewer tools it retains for leverage with China. Gradually, Americans themselves have come to the conclusion that the United States has been destroying its own influence through sanctions. Europe created the same outcome for itself by exiting Iran's economy: today, Europe has little real influence or effectiveness in

¹⁴⁰ <https://brusselssignal.eu/2025/12/eu-leaders-see-trumps-new-security-strategy-as-interference/>

Iran because it is not present in Iran's economy. Another consequence of America's excessive reliance on the power of the dollar—what one might call “weaponizing the dollar”—is that countries have gradually moved toward replacing the dollar in parts of their trade. This does not mean the end of the dollar, but it does mean that the dollar's gradual decline could be a consequence of the coercive and excessive use of this instrument.

As noted earlier, France's key motive has been to play the leading role. From 2003, when the E3 initiative began, to the present, the most prominent feature of French behavior has been the pursuit of primacy—something that seems to matter to French leaders perhaps even more than security, regional, or economic considerations. In other words, prestige is central. The same pattern appears in other areas of French foreign policy: prestige, along with a certain transactional mindset, carries great weight for them.

German foreign policy, by contrast, appears closely tied to the individuals who run it. The approach of Mr. Steinmeier and Mr. Sigmar Gabriel—both with a Europe-centered orientation who worked hard to strengthen the JCPOA—differed markedly from that of Mr. Heiko Maas, who had a more Israel-oriented outlook. Germany generally maintained a middle position in the practical arena and negotiations from 2003 until the unrest of 2022. But Mr. Maas's personal inclinations affected how the file was handled and harmed Germany's role in the talks. From his first day as foreign minister, Germany's standing within the E3 declined rapidly and visibly. German pragmatism had long given it a prominent position, but under Mr. Maas that position not only failed to stand out—it virtually disappeared. His colleagues tried hard to compensate for this deficit, but the minister's stance is decisive; without his support, efforts went nowhere. When talks were held at the deputy level, Germany played a more important role than when the minister himself was present.

Britain's transatlantic orientation and tight attachment to the United States were striking. Even in the period between Trump's election and his entry into the White House, Theresa May's government in Britain and Boris Johnson, then foreign secretary, acted in effect as Trump's representative by blocking implementation of a JCPOA Joint Commission decision reached with the Obama administration. Under that decision,

Iran would have been allowed to receive nearly 900 tons of new yellowcake uranium. This was an extraordinary achievement: before the Revolution, the largest yellowcake delivery Iran had received was 550 tons from South Africa. Boris Johnson delayed implementation for three months so that the Obama administration would give way to the Trump administration. It was unsurprising that the new Trump administration blocked the exchange. Politically, however, Britain supported the JCPOA during the Trump era. Although it took no practical steps to enable Iran to access the JCPOA's economic benefits, it offered political support and even did not vote with the Trump administration in the Security Council.

Trump and the JCPOA

The most decisive factor in undermining the JCPOA was the coming to power of President Trump. Domestic critics of the JCPOA argue that the foreign ministry considered Trump's victory impossible and that the government's planning was based entirely on Democrats winning again and Hillary Clinton becoming president. The reality is that months before the U.S. election, I considered Trump's victory plausible and warned, in internal discussions, against ignoring the Trump phenomenon. Of course, prediction has limited standing in politics. If someone claims, for example, that two years before the November 2020 election in the United States, he/she already knew Biden would win, that mostly shows unfamiliarity with politics. I must admit that in the November 2020 election, I thought Trump's chances of returning to the White House were significantly higher until June 2020; after June I believed his electoral base was eroding. Even that assessment proved mistaken: Trump showed that he not only retained his base but expanded it. What was not properly accounted for was those new voters—people who had not voted previously—came to the polls. Trump had polarized the U.S. society to the point that new groups turned out. Violence also helped mobilize and expand his turnout. In the end, Trump's vote total rose by several million compared to the previous election. Trump's approach managed to unite all his opponents around Biden; otherwise, Biden did not have much charisma to win the presidency.

In the 2016 election, I thought Clinton could not generate the kind of social enthusiasm needed to mobilize voters—just as Biden could not in 2020. Both came from the traditional core of the Democratic Party and lacked distinctive appeal. Trump, by contrast, could create social excitement and channel some of the repressed anxieties and emotions of a significant portion of Americans. I told some friends once or twice that “Trump is the distillation of America’s vices¹⁴¹.” Many Americans choose Trump in the privacy of the voting booth because, for many of them, he embodies what they themselves aspire to become. That is why polling should not be taken too seriously.

Still, in 2016 I did not predict Trump’s definite victory. What I said was: do not erase the possibility of Trump’s success from your mind. In the final days of the campaign, I asked colleagues at the foreign ministry not to assume Clinton’s victory was certain, and to write and speak cautiously. Despite that, one of our directors went on television the night before the election and said Clinton’s victory was certain. Because I am not inclined toward intellectual imposition, I did not rebuke him harshly, but I did say: you spoke there as the representative of the foreign ministry, not as yourself—you damaged the ministry’s credibility, despite my warning. I wish you had taken seriously the caution of someone who has perhaps followed U.S. domestic and foreign policy longer than you. After that colleague’s self-centered remarks, the foreign ministry was accused of having planned up to election night on the basis of Clinton’s victory, even though that was not the case.

In the second half of November 2016—just a couple of weeks after Trump was elected—I presented a report outlining my assessment of Trump’s policy and some possible approaches for the Islamic Republic. That report was lost amid a flood of agenda-driven reports and baseless commentary, and ultimately the approach it had suggested was not adopted. The key points in that report included the following:

- Speculations such as “Trump is a dealmaker,” “he has problems with everyone,” “he will clash with the system,” “he will quarrel with

¹⁴¹ This phrase has a special meaning for Iranian readers. The late Imam Khomeini called the Iranian Parliament (Majlis) “the distillation of nation’s virtues.” In this context, I tried to show the contrast in Trump.

Saudi Arabia,” “he will move closer to Russia,” and so on, are not reliable. Until his security and foreign policy team is finalized, no judgment can be made. Likewise, it is too early to decide whether Trump’s election is “beneficial” and an “opportunity,” or “harmful” and a “threat.”

- In this atmosphere of ambiguity, all countries, political figures, and lobbying groups have begun trying to influence Trump’s direction.

- The JCPOA is the central point of contact between Iran and Trump¹⁴². One option is that Trump heeds advice to preserve the JCPOA and continues U.S. compliance. In that case, he will likely show less willingness to fulfill U.S. obligations and will scrutinize Iran’s obligations more harshly. The other option is to follow his campaign promises and withdraw from the JCPOA—since he called it the worst deal in American history and said he would not remain loyal to it. In that case, Trump has two paths: (1) openly declare noncompliance and leave the deal; or (2) pursue measures designed to push Iran out of the deal by tightening implementation and imposing new sanctions in areas such as terrorism, missiles, human rights, and even under the pretext of supporting Syria.

- It is evident that tearing up the JCPOA is costly for the United States; more likely Trump will pursue the second path so that Iran, not the United States, appears to be the one leaving. In effect, the United States would tear up the JCPOA at Iran’s expense—an approach urged by Trump’s supporters and opponents of the deal¹⁴³.

- Regionally, if confronting what Trump calls “Islamic radicalism” shifts toward fighting ISIS and other takfiri groups—and the ideological ground that feeds them, namely Wahhabism—this could be a short-term common objective or at least could prevent losses for the Islamic Republic. But if Trump turns toward confronting Hezbollah, Ansar Allah, and ultimately Iran—as Saudi Arabia was working hard to promote—then a rapid escalation of confrontation between Iran and the United States,

¹⁴² It is interesting to note that domestic JCPOA opponents were clearly contending that Trump would never withdraw from the JCPOA. See for instance an editorial in issue number 21491 of *Keyhan* on 16 November 2016 by Mohammad Hossein Mohtaram, “Trump will not tear-up the JCPOA”, or interviews by my colleague Professor Foad Izadi <https://www.jamran.news/fa/tiny/news-761408> and <https://www.mizanonline.ir/fa/amp/news/302196>.

¹⁴³ In practice Trump attempted to do exactly this. From February 2017 until May 2018, he did his best to persuade Iran to withdraw. Having failed to do so, he decided on 8 May 2018 to unilaterally withdraw from the JCPOA.

and perhaps between Iran and the West, would begin. The brutality of ISIS on European and American soil has drawn global attention, including Trump's, to fighting takfiri terrorism, which could be an opportunity for Iran; yet that opportunity could easily become a threat if Saudi Arabia succeeds, with the help of Zionist lobbying and U.S. hawkish factions.

- In this transitional period, as Trump's policies take shape between campaign slogans and real-world constraints, they may generate new opportunities and threats for Iran.

- All actors are trying to influence Trump's future policies and orientations.

- The worst course of action is "silence and inaction," which would leave others free to portray Iran as a "threat" to the new U.S. administration.

- In any decision about Iran—including the JCPOA—Trump must understand the reality of the Islamic Republic and the costs and benefits of his choices.

- Iran should, from a position of dignity and self-reliance, convey clearly to Trump and his hardline team:

- Iran is a pivotal actor in the region; Iran wants stability in the region, but no outcome is possible without Iran;

- Iran is not a costless target;

- Iran has planned for all scenarios;

- Iran will not violate the JCPOA, but if the United States breaks the deal or applies pressure, Iran can rapidly advance its nuclear program to a troubling threshold;

- Iran responds proportionately to coercion and to respect;

- post-sanctions Iran offers unique economic opportunities that could also include American economic actors if the JCPOA is implemented.

- Iran should not become Trump's number-one issue; opponents, especially in the region, want Iran to become Washington's primary focus again.

- Do not give Trump a pretext for confrontation; avoid actions and statements that are merely provocative without achieving a concrete goal.

- Trump should not receive a "signal of fear" from Iran; harsh rhetoric—especially from military commanders—tends to be read as anxiety and fear, not confidence and power.

- Iran should not be portrayed as the violator; if Trump wants to tear up the JCPOA, the cost should be borne by the United States, not Iran.

- The JCPOA should not become Iran's primary domestic issue, nor the main issue in Iran's foreign relations or in U.S. foreign policy; U.S. attention should remain focused on fighting ISIS and takfiri terrorism.

- The JCPOA should be treated as a fact and removed from domestic political quarrels and media battles; its core purpose was normalization of Iranian situation abroad, not the creation of a new arena for conflict at home.

- U.S. political cohesion regarding Iran has been weakened by the nuclear talks; divisions within the United States and between the United States and its regional allies should be maintained and even strengthened.

- Economic linkages with the United States should be taken seriously; given Trump's transactional instincts, economic connections can be created.

- Global public opinion—especially in the United States and Europe—must be taken seriously; the Islamic Republic has tools to mobilize or benefit from global public opinion and must use them, otherwise opponents will turn opportunity into threat.

- Iran–Russia relations under Trump will become more valuable, sensitive, and complex; ties should continue strongly and Russia should be used as leverage, though Russia has always had capacity to negotiate using Iran's card. Still, Russia's drive to return to great-power status is an opportunity.

- Relations with the region is imperative: where possible, tensions with neighbors—including Saudi Arabia—should be reduced.

- Relations with Europe are key and should be expanded. Iran and the JCPOA are not Europe's top priority. Europe cannot distance itself too far from the United States, but Iran should not once again become the victim of Europe–U.S. rapprochement (this time under Trump).

When the Persian original of *Audacity of Resilience* was published, it was nearly three years after the end of Trump's first term, and seven years since that foreign ministry report. Any researcher can judge how accurately those points—written only weeks after Trump's election and before he entered the White House—described the subsequent four years.

Raising this is neither self-praise nor revenge; it is a sincere question: why do the perspectives of those whose predictions and analyses repeatedly proved wrong still form the basis of decision-making? Meanwhile, careful, honest, and conscientious analyses by experts are often dismissed through various labels and ignored.

Critiques of the JCPOA

Beyond accusations of naïveté about America's domestic and international behavior, various critiques of the JCPOA have been raised, which—God willing—will be clarified more fully at an appropriate time. One central critique that perhaps encompasses many of the objections is that the JCPOA was inherently unstable in its nature and structure, which is why the United States withdrew during the Trump period.

There are two foundations for responding to such critiques. The first concerns international agreements in general and is not unique to the JCPOA. The second concerns the context in which the JCPOA was negotiated. The key pillar that prevents cross-border agreements from collapsing is ensuring that the benefits in continuing the agreement outweigh the incentives to leave it. Every agreement must generate meaningful gains for all participants—gains that outweigh the benefits of withdrawal and escaping the agreement's constraints. The durability of global agreements depends on balance rather than one-sidedness: the more balanced an agreement, the more durable; the more imbalanced, the more fragile. Strong mechanisms for implementation, legal structure, and verification are desirable, but they are not the core foundation. The true foundation is that the gains from compliance outweigh the gains from withdrawal—because no agreement is entirely in any one party's favor. This assumes all actors operate within a rational framework.

If the JCPOA could not remain durable, what could have made it durable? One option would have been to address all of America's concerns in the JCPOA, which was impossible. America's demands extended far beyond what could be achieved, and our negotiations were limited strictly to the nuclear file; it was not possible to reach JCPOA-like agreements on other issues. Dr. Jalili not only had the freedom to pursue a variety of

initiatives in talks; he also had authority to put other files on the table. Issues ranging from global security, freedom of navigation and sea piracy to crises in Bahrain and Syria were placed on the agenda of talks by Dr. Jalili. We, however, did not even have permission to answer non-nuclear questions in the JCPOA negotiations—let alone negotiate and reach agreements on them. That is why the JCPOA's nature was nuclear-only, and the agreement resulting from it could not include all of America's interests and concerns, even within the nuclear realm—just as it did not include all of Iran's demands and concerns.

From the beginning of negotiations, we knew that for the JCPOA to endure, the United States needed to gain economically from it. Trump also argued that it made no sense for others to reap the economic benefits while the United States merely facilitated them. But there were fundamental difficulties—above all, primary sanctions imposed by Congress, preventing U.S. entities to engage in economic relations with Iran. Lifting primary sanctions without addressing other issues was not possible, and Congress in that period was oriented against Obama. Still, even with Congress as an obstacle, the United States could have gained significant economic benefits—especially through Iranian purchase of dozens of Boeing aircraft, a number that could have grown to much higher numbers. Another route was allowing foreign subsidiaries of U.S. companies to participate in Iranian projects.

In February 2016, a contract was signed for 117 Airbus aircraft, and in June 2016 another contract was signed to buy 88 Boeing aircraft. Some argued we did not need Boeing and that Airbus was more beneficial. In our view, it was in our interest to deal with Boeing as well: first, Airbus needed competition so it could not impose its terms; second, we knew that unless we signed with Boeing, the United States would not grant the export licenses for Airbus either. The U.S. Treasury issued no licenses until September 2016. At that point we threatened that if they did not issue Airbus licenses, we would invoke JCPOA Article 36 and refer the matter to the Joint Commission dispute resolution mechanism¹⁴⁴. The

¹⁴⁴ Letter dated 2 September 2016 to Federica Mogherini as JCPOA Coordinator, contained in pp. 24–30 of J. Zarif, Letter to the UN Secretary General, Tehran: IPIS, 2021. Also, UN Documents A/75/968 and S/2021/669 of 20 July 2021.

Treasury then issued licenses for 18 out of Airbus's 117 requests, and 80 out of Boeing's 88 requests. Accepting this profit-driven behavior by the United States was very costly for the three European members, because once again the Americans showed how little weight they gave Europe.

For this reason, we understood that American businesses also needed to have economic interests under the JCPOA so that they would support it inside the United States. Beyond aircraft, based on a joint initiative of Secretary Kerry and I, the JCPOA included authorization for foreign subsidiaries of U.S. companies to engage in economic cooperation and investment in Iran. As previously mentioned, allowing direct cooperation with Iran by companies inside the United States required congressional legislation. Negotiators therefore recognized the necessity of U.S. economic gains, but U.S. law prevented going further than what the JCPOA contained.

We were criticized for not including a "guarantee" to prevent U.S. withdrawal. The question is: what kind of guarantee could have prevented Trump from leaving? As explained, the only way to prevent withdrawal is to make the costs of leaving higher than the benefits. How could the costs of U.S. withdrawal—especially for someone like Trump, who does not think within conventional rationality—have been increased? He has his own rationality, but it is not the standard one.

We spent, without exaggeration, hundreds of hours in internal and external discussions on this. It is absolutely unfair and untrue to contend that during the JCPOA negotiations we failed to consider the possibility of U.S. withdrawal or deal-breaking, or that we negotiated based on naïveté about U.S. motives. The dispute resolution mechanism and the text of paragraph 36 show how sensitive the Iranian side was to the possibility of U.S. noncompliance, and how carefully and firmly it negotiated.

36- If Iran believed that any or all of the E3/EU+3 were not meeting their commitments under this JCPOA, Iran could refer the issue to the Joint Commission for resolution; similarly, if any of the E3/EU+3 believed that Iran was not meeting its commitments under this JCPOA, any of the E3/EU+3 could do the same. The Joint Commission would have 15 days to resolve the issue, unless the time period was extended by consensus. After Joint Commission consideration, any participant could refer the issue to Ministers

of Foreign Affairs, if it believed the compliance issue had not been resolved. Ministers would have 15 days to resolve the issue, unless the time period was extended by consensus. After Joint Commission consideration – in parallel with (or in lieu of) review at the Ministerial level – either the complaining participant or the participant whose performance is in question could request that the issue be considered by an Advisory Board, which would consist of three members (one each appointed by the participants in the dispute and a third independent member). The Advisory Board should provide a non-binding opinion on the compliance issue within 15 days. If, after this 30-day process the issue is not resolved, the Joint Commission would consider the opinion of the Advisory Board for no more than 5 days in order to resolve the issue. If the issue still has not been resolved to the satisfaction of the complaining participant, and if the complaining participant deems the issue to constitute significant non-performance, then that participant could treat the unresolved issue as grounds to cease performing its commitments under this JCPOA in whole or in part and/or notify the UN Security Council that it believes the issue constitutes significant non-performance.'

A careful reading of paragraph 36 shows:

- The JCPOA was written on the basis of mistrust: it not only clearly anticipates the possibility that parties may violate the agreement; it also sets out a detailed mechanism for addressing such violations.
- In international relations, the way to ensure performance is reciprocity—making violations costly. By specifying a precise procedure, Article 36 not only creates such a safeguard but formalizes it.
- This provision begins with addressing Iran's concern, not the concerns of the other sides.
- If the process described here fails to produce results, the remedy for Iran's concern is explicitly stated: suspending performance of commitments, in whole or in part, at Iran's discretion.
- Referring a complaint to the Security Council is an option, not an obligation (as signaled by the formulation "and/or").

The steps Iran has taken since May 2019 under paragraph 36 further demonstrate that this reading of paragraphs 36 and 37 is correct.

Some opponents of the JCPOA, pointing to paragraph 37, have claimed that even if the United States violates the JCPOA, the case would go to the Security Council and Resolution 2231 would be terminated pursuant to paragraph 37 of the JCPOA and paragraphs 10 to 13 of the resolution—so that, in the end, Iran would be harmed even by pursuing its own complaint. But a look at the text and at the steps actually taken shows this is a major fallacy, because paragraph 37 was not—and is not—designed to be taken by Iran.

- The foundation for implementing the JCPOA is the possibility of reciprocal action by both sides.

- Iran brought its nuclear program to the nuclear talks. If the other side violated the deal, Iran had the right under paragraph 36, without breaching the JCPOA, to refrain from implementing its provisions in whole or in part.

- The other side brought unilateral sanctions and UN Security Council sanctions to the table. From Iran's perspective, this "leverage" was illegitimate; but every negotiation has two sides. From the other side's perspective, Iran's nuclear program violated international rules and Security Council resolutions.

- Under paragraph 36, the other side could only restore U.S. unilateral sanctions and EU multilateral sanctions. Paragraph 36 did not allow the restoration of Security Council sanctions.

- Paragraph 37 creates a burdensome procedure for restoring Security Council sanctions—i.e., the second part of what the Western countries brought to the table. Therefore, paragraph 37 is only for restoring part of what the other side brought to the table. Iran did not have any leverage in the Security Council, and it would have been meaningless for it to be able to restore that leverage in case of other side's non-compliance.

- The mechanism for restoring Security Council sanctions was not automatic or immediate as the Obama administration claimed. Despite Iran's full use of paragraph 36, those sanctions were not reinstated during Trump's first term in spite of its attempts in 2020.

- For the first time in the history of the Security Council, Resolution 2231 also addresses Iran's response to a potential move by the other side under paragraph 37 of the JCPOA and paragraphs 10–13 of Resolution 2231. Indeed, at the end of paragraph 13, it recognizes Iran's right to reciprocal action:

13. ... and notes Iran's statement that if the provisions of previous resolutions are applied pursuant to paragraph 12 in whole or in part, Iran will treat this as grounds to cease performing its commitments under the JCPOA;

Therefore, the only "guarantee" for implementing the JCPOA was built into paragraphs 36 and 37—and only Iran has made lawful use of it. As will be shown, paragraph 36 was used to its fullest and Iran's nuclear capabilities at the end of the Rouhani administration were greater than before the JCPOA. The purported resort to paragraph 37 by the United States in 2020 was rejected by the Security Council as unlawful. The same applies to the E3 resort to that paragraph in 2025. While they were able to abuse the Security Council through arm-twisting, that action did not correspond to the letter or spirit of the dispute resolution mechanism of the JCPOA and resolution 2231, as noted by three JCPOA participants and the entire non-aligned movement.

Other mechanisms were also considered as potential safeguards, including referral to the International Court of Justice and arbitration. Some of our legal colleagues believed that if the JCPOA included referral to the ICJ, it would have become harder for the United States to violate the agreement. But leaders in both Iran and the United States—as well as other permanent members of the Security Council—opposed the Court and arbitration. It was not only the permanent members; Iran's senior leadership opposed them as well. The permanent members opposed them because they did not want to limit their veto privilege. Iranian leaders did not trust international mechanisms and believed that entering such frameworks could bind our hands in America's favor—perhaps creating constraints that would prevent us from expanding our program if the United States violated the deal. In my view, that concern was justified. Arbitration could not have prevented a U.S. withdrawal, and under European political pressure it might even have made Iran's ability to invoke

paragraph 36 more difficult. In such circumstances, Iran's remedial steps could have been portrayed as a breach of the JCPOA.

Even assuming we had overcome political opposition and had made the ICJ's compulsory jurisdiction a safeguard for the JCPOA—would the JCPOA have fared any better than the 1955 Treaty of Amity between Iran and the United States, which Trump also left? That treaty, signed in 1955, was an international treaty which was not only ratified by the U.S. Senate and by Iran's legislative bodies, but also provided for ICJ compulsory jurisdiction. So, the claim that if compulsory ICJ jurisdiction had been included in the JCPOA, Trump's withdrawal would have been harder may be theoretically plausible in international legal debates and might have imposed legal costs on the United States—but in practice it could not have prevented the withdrawal. The Treaty of Amity included the ICJ's compulsory jurisdiction, and we sued the United States on that basis. The Court affirmed its jurisdiction and decided to proceed. It also granted provisional measures, ordering the United States—pending a final judgment—to refrain from enforcing sanctions related to food, medicine, and aviation safety.

The United States not only failed to comply with the Court's order, it withdrew unilaterally from the treaty. The Court will in the future address the treaty's violation, but even if the United States loses the merits, it will not implement the final judgment—just as it did not implement the provisional measures. In previous cases too, ICJ rulings have been legal victories for Iran but have not changed U.S. behavior. Thus, even if the Court's jurisdiction had been recognized as part of the JCPOA, the case would have taken years. Even if the ruling were entirely in Iran's favor, it would have been a significant legal victory, but it could not have prevented U.S. noncompliance or withdrawal; it would only have made them more costly. Even without the Court, as long as we acted reasonably, we enjoyed broad global legal and political legitimacy—and arguably a louder and more universal legitimacy than a Court victory would provide. So, when it is asked why the JCPOA lacked guarantees, the question is: which guarantees?

None of the above means that America's defeat at the International Court of Justice was worthless. The Court's provisional measures and America's

subsequent withdrawal were a political, legal, and ideational defeat for the United States—and a major victory for Iran—which should be pursued in similar cases. But that defeat did not prevent the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA, nor did it even compel compliance with the Court's provisional measures. Likewise, votes in the Security Council and the General Assembly were major defeats for the United States, but they did not bring the United States back into compliance with the JCPOA. Therefore, while I do not accept the claim that ICJ adjudication or international judicial mechanisms constitute a solid safeguard preventing U.S. noncompliance, I consider the value of legal and political follow-up undeniable—provided it is pursued in its proper place and without illusion.

Some argued—and still argue—that the United States violated the JCPOA because it was not approved by Congress, had not been ratified by the Senate, and was merely an executive agreement. Trump made that argument as well. But first, the JCPOA was not merely a bilateral executive agreement: it was enshrined in and endorsed by a UN Security Council resolution which, under Article 25 of the UN Charter (itself ratified by the U.S. Senate), must be implemented by all UN members, including the United States. Second, even if we accept the argument that the JCPOA was not a Senate-ratified treaty—and that if it had been, Trump could not have left it—what then can be said about the Treaty of Amity? That treaty was ratified by the Senate, yet Trump decided to withdraw from it, and he did.

Nearly 180 countries around the world condemned Trump's withdrawal from the JCPOA—or at least expressed regret and concern. But hardly any country expressed regret over the U.S. withdrawal from the Treaty of Amity; most global actors were not even aware of it, or paid it little attention. And the problem was not limited to Trump's noncompliance at Iran's expense. Trump's America also withdrew from the Paris Agreement. Was the Paris Agreement also naïve and flimsy? The United States withdrew from the Intermediate-Range Nuclear Forces Treaty, from the Open Skies Treaty, and from NAFTA as well. Were the negotiators of those agreements also weak and intimidated—or perhaps they signed without reading them¹⁴⁵?

¹⁴⁵ I have been falsely accused of signing the JCPOA without reading it.

The United States withdrew from the Trans-Pacific Partnership too, and nothing dramatic happened. Many even believe that in the treaties and agreements mentioned above, the costs of withdrawal for the United States exceeded its benefits. Even the principle stated earlier—that the only real safeguard for treaties is that the costs of withdrawal be greater than the gains—was not upheld in those cases. In the JCPOA as well, many in the United States, including the Biden administration, believe the damage caused by Trump’s withdrawal exceeded the benefits he imagined. But Trump’s rationality, and that of his like-minded circle, differed from the conventional rationality within the U.S. establishment. Therefore, the claim that if the JCPOA had been a “treaty,” the United States would not have withdrawn, does not really hold.

Some argued that a better guarantee for compliance with the JCPOA should have been step-by-step implementation: after each step, it would be verified, and only then would the parties proceed to the next steps. Our initial planning was in fact based on that approach. When deep mistrust exists between two countries—or groups of countries—the remedy is incremental confidence-building. The proposal presented in Paris in 2005 was step-by-step. The proposal presented to Dr. Rouhani in the summer of 2013—before accepting the foreign ministry portfolio—was also based on a step-by-step method.

Timeframe	Iran	E3/EU+3
Phase 1 Before UN General Assembly	Iran-US intensive and goodwill talk within the framework of March 2013 Muscat agreement to reach understanding on all stages of the plan All parties refrain from any expansion (freeze on the extent of sanctions and enrichment) Declaring final agreement at a meeting of E3/EU+3 heads of state with President Rouhani on the sidelines of the UNGA presided over by UN Secretary General (The US should persuade E3/EU+3)	

Phase 2 Three Months	S Suspending enrichment above 5% purity S Converting 20%-enriched materials to oxide or 5% materials S Verifiably converting Fordow facility to 5% S Cooperation with IAEA on PMD S Continuous stationing of IAEA inspectors at Fordow and Natanz (or similar methods of continuous verification)	S Freeze on new UN Security Council, bilateral and multilateral sanctions and/or broadening their extent S Suspending (part of) financial and banking sanctions (at least one bank with full administrative and financial capacity for transfer) S Suspending oil sanctions and easing transfer of oil money S Suspending all sanctions imposed after January 2013 by the U.S. and EU
Phase 3 Three Months	S Accepting Code 3.1 S Voluntary implementation of Additional Protocol S Adoption of the fatwa against nuclear weapons as a national law in parliament S Deceleration in Arak facility	S Suspending Security Council sanctions S Suspending bilateral and multilateral nuclear sanctions S Agreement for light-water reactor construction in Iran for medical and pharmaceutical purposes
	The US and E3/EU+3 are likely to insist on the implementation of Security Council resolutions (full suspension of enrichment) even for short-term in return for suspending Security Council resolutions, in which case, the reciprocal measures listed below may be considered:	
	Fulfilment of international obligations by both sides	
	Iran's commitments under the NPT: - Renouncing nuclear weapons - Full cooperation with IAEA Iran's commitments under the UN Charter (Article 25): - Implementing Security Council resolutions	E3/EU+3 commitments under the NPT: - Paragraph 2 of Article 4 (technology supply) - Article 6 (ICJ's advisory opinion) E3/EU+3 commitments under the UN Charter: - Paragraph 4 of Article 2 (stopping threat of force)

	Executive Measures	
	Welcoming E3/EU+3's proposal for enrichment consortium in Iran Suspending enrichment activities for three months for feasibility studies on transferring Natanz facility to enrichment consortium Readiness for transferring Arak facility to consortium after completion of light-water reactor and three-month suspension in Arak	Readiness for nuclear cooperation including in enrichment consortium in Iran Starting construction operations of light-water reactor in Iran for medical and pharmaceutical purposes Respecting Iran's right to enrichment and benefiting from all peaceful nuclear technologies on its territory
Phase 4 Three Months	Registering fatwa-based law at the UN Ratifying Additional Protocol Accepting enrichment limitations voluntarily for 5 (10) years - 5% ceiling - Number, type and location of centrifuges - Materials	Adoption of Security Council resolution - supporting agreement - lifting all sanctions Lifting all bilateral and unilateral sanctions Removing barriers to Iran's access to Europe's financial and investment barriers
Phase 5 6 Months-1 Year	Settlement of PMD issue (launch of enrichment consortium)	Official normalization of Iran's case at IAEA Board of Governors (closure of the case at Security Council)
Phase 6	Reciprocal removal of restrictions to economic and technological cooperation Removal of export control restrictions against Iran and cooperation for sensitive items export control from Iran Cooperation in peaceful nuclear technology (power plant construction, enrichment consortium, new technologies) Effective cooperation in global nuclear disarmament Creating a WMD-free zone in the Middle East as an interim measure Constructive and positive cooperation in regional and international issues based on common interests	

On this basis and given satisfactory progress in the negotiations leading to the Geneva interim deal, we prepared and presented a more ambitious step-by-step proposal at the beginning of Vienna talks for a comprehensive solution. Work started based on our step-by-step approach. The E3/EU+3 also favored this method. It raised the chance of reaching agreement quickly.

Several months after the start of negotiations, authorities in Iran decided that the step-by-step approach was not compatible with our requirements. That conclusion was based on the implementation of the Geneva interim agreement, relying on the logic that partial lifting of sanctions would not address our problems sufficiently. For instance, if the first step by the E3/EU+3 would be to lift oil sanctions, we could not sell oil as long as banking, shipping and insurance sanctions remain effective. Which ship would carry our oil then? Which bank would process our oil income? In contrast, each nuclear measure by Iran would have tangible benefits for the E3/EU+3.

Therefore, more than 4 months after the start of negotiations for a comprehensive solution, we were instructed in May 2014 that Iran, the U.S. and the EU should take their reciprocal steps all at once. We were in the middle of talks and our primary planning, and the Geneva interim deal were based on a step-by-step approach. However, we set aside all these plans and agreements and shifted the comprehensive agreement towards integrated implementation of all steps at once.

This necessitated the possibility of mutual restoration of pre-JCPOA situation, advertised by Americans as “snapback.” When you expect the E3/EU+3 to lift all UN Security Council sanctions as well as all unilateral and multilateral nuclear sanctions at once, the opposite party also expects that all nuclear steps be taken at once. That would be tough and hazardous against the backdrop of deep-rooted mutual mistrust. The only guarantee for the parties would be reciprocal action and possibility of returning to pre-agreement conditions in case of violation by the other side. Therefore, the JCPOA provides conditions for Iran, the U.S. and others to return to the pre-agreement conditions. For us, this return was automatic. We decided to return and we took necessary action. For the E3/EU+3, it has two parts: Unilateral sanctions could be reinstated automatically, but restoring UN Security Council resolutions required a weekslong cumbersome process.

The opponents of the JCPOA in the U.S. had similar complaints like their counterparts in Iran who contend that Iran's return takes long while U.S. return is immediate or Iran's costs are irreversible. In practice, the reinstatement of U.S. sanctions was done in two parts: six months for some and one year for the rest. Iran's return to the pre-JCPOA capacity also took about one year. Iran made a political decision to return to pre-JCPOA conditions gradually; otherwise, return to previous capacity would have been possible at a more rapid pace. Furthermore, the assets unfrozen for Iran could not be frozen again. Therefore, this criticism is not valid.

The JCPOA is also under fire for its allegedly ambiguous and weak text. Let's keep in mind that the JCPOA was not a unilateral statement to be worded based on the views of one party. The general expectation was that in the negotiations between one nation on one side and an alliance of the world's largest political, economic and military powers on the other, with the latter having six Security Council resolutions under its belt, the views of the world powers should prevail. However, with the grace of the Almighty, the JCPOA had been negotiated so diligently that President Trump could not find any pretext under the JCPOA to withdraw from the deal or to reinstate the Security Council sanctions. There was not even a single word or phrase to give President Trump a pretext. Were the JCPOA text weak or one-sided, the Trump Administration could have used it as a pretext. For 14 months, the U.S. sought in vain to find a pretext to justify its pullout, and it could not. That indicates the strength of the JCPOA.

After taking office in January 2017, President Trump hoped to push Iran into torching the JCPOA. He did his utmost to compel Iran to quit the agreement, but he failed due to foresight of the Iranian decision-makers at the time. For 14 months, President Trump took pains in renewing sanctions waivers every three months. The Trump Administration realized that with the JCPOA in effect, it could not impose effective sanctions on Iran. It could only add some names to the existing lists of designated persons under non-nuclear pretexts. Any new sanctions that he desired to adopt would be in breach of the JCPOA.

President Trump failed in his attempt to pressure others JCPOA participants to join the U.S. in withdrawing from the deal. Vice President Mike Pence travelled to Europe to persuade the Europeans to ditch the

deal, but he failed. From February 2017 to May 2018, President Trump was doing his best to find a pretext to lawfully terminate the JCPOA. In the end, his Administration reached the conclusion that the only option was to unilaterally withdraw from the deal. John Bolton, who had served as U.S. ambassador to UN and Under-Secretary of State, acknowledged that the so-called snapback mechanism could not achieve U.S.'s objective. This proves that despite all challenges, the JCPOA text was very precise and solid. However, benefitting from this solid text required expertise and diplomatic finesse. As I wrote in my Persian edition of the book in 2023, "if the same JCPOA is given to unskilled practitioners, they may destroy the country." Unfortunately, lack of experience on the part of the Raisi diplomats coupled with unscrupulous behavior of the E3, led to this eventuality in 2025. But had it been implemented correctly, although it was a multilateral deal and the result of many give-and-takes and no signatory was pleased with each and every word of it, it was so solid that Trump tried various tactics for 14 months to destroy it, but he failed and he finally unilaterally withdrew in May 2018.

If the U.S. could benefit from JCPOA mechanisms in May 2018 and win over the world, Trump would have done what he did in September and October 2020. By September 2020, after Iran suspended all JCPOA limits in accordance with paragraph 36, the U.S. tried and failed to activate the dispute resolution mechanism—erroneously called snapback—against Iran at the UN Security Council¹⁴⁶.

In addition to the foresight of the JCPOA negotiators in drafting a solid text, the inaccurate estimate of President Trump and his advisors about Iran's domestic challenges was instrumental in the failure of his maximum pressure policy. Following the unrest in Iran in February 2018, John Bolton who had been made paid lectures on behalf of the MeK, and who had just been appointed as National Security Advisor on 9 April 2018, convinced President Trump that in the wake of domestic unrest, the economic tremor of maximum pressures following Washington's withdrawal from the JCPOA, would accelerate the collapse of the Iranian government. Once more we witnessed people's resistance as the strongest pillar of national strength

¹⁴⁶ My address to the UN Security Council's videoconference is found in Annex 7.

and the most effective deterrence in Iran. Public resilience, in spite of all dissatisfaction and discontent, defeated President Trump.

Breaking Global Security Consensus

In order to have a better understanding of the value of the JCPOA, it is necessary to take into account not only the JCPOA text, but also the context of global circumstances at the time of the agreement. To that end, we must free our minds from a textual black or white approach about the JCPOA and other international agreements and treaties. We have an extreme textual approach to international conventions in Iran: If a country joins a treaty, it will be subjected to all privileges and restrictions set out in that agreement. Based on this perspective, membership would be synonymous with every privilege and restriction. But more importantly, non-membership would be synonymous with immunity from all restrictions. Untrue. We are not currently cooperating with the FATT. But, while we do not enjoy any privilege of cooperation, we are not only subject to all its restrictions in our international financial transaction, but we also even have to be more scrupulous than had we been a participant. Not only do we have to bear exorbitant costs of financial transactions, but Iran's transnational banks insist on over-compliance with money-laundering and terrorist financing provisions, including identification of customers (KYC), even more than their counterparts in other countries.

If we want to have an effective, constructive and consequential standing in the global community and benefit from global opportunities for national progress and people's peace of mind, we must admit that international treaties are not absolute. They do not act in void either. Treaties neither displace the power of countries nor reverse behaviors. Transnational regimes and treaties only regulate conduct. They do not change the realities of the outside world and the power of actors; rather they balance power with legitimacy and regulate the behavior of powers and make them predictable.

The circumstances of JCPOA negotiations and the status of eight actors involved were not balanced and homogenous. Adoption of several resolutions under Chapter VII of the UN charter had built a global consensus against Iran, thus increasing the costs of cooperation with

Iran and decreasing the cost of exerting pressure on the country. One may claim that UN Security Council resolutions are ineffective and only US Congress resolutions ramp up pressure. But it was thanks to Security Council resolutions that President Obama built a security consensus against Iran on the global scale, which in turn enabled him to gradually remove Iran from global energy market and push our customers to turn to others like Saudi Arabia, Russia and Iraq. Without those resolutions, President Obama could never impose as tough conditions as he imposed through 2011 to 2013. Drawing a parallel between the efficacy of U.S. sanctions under President Obama, which were backed by Security Council resolutions, President Bill Clinton-era sanctions that lacked such global legitimization would indicate well the impact of Security Council resolutions. Doubtlessly, in the 1990s, the U.S. under President Clinton was at the height of global power, prestige and even popularity. Nevertheless, the U.S. failed in its extraterritorial sanctions. Despite the stringent restrictions imposed by the Iran-Libya Sanctions Act (ILSA) on investing in Iran's energy sector, France's Total, Italy's Eni, Malaysia's Petronas and Russia's Gazprom made significant investment in the South Pars gas field. That experience may explain why Iranian authorities never believed that the Obama Administration's sanctions could be so effective. In the 2000s, the Ahmadinejad Administration did not understand the significance of the emerging global security consensus built against the country or Security Council resolutions adopted under Chapter VII of the Charter of the United Nations, describing them as worthless pieces of scratch paper.

When the Rouhani Administration took office and started running nuclear talks, even China was no longer dependent on Iran's oil. The world had found an alternative to Iranian oil. The price of oil at the start of nuclear talks under the Rouhani Administration was above \$100 a barrel, but in fact that increase dated from pre-sanctions years and associated with market conditions. After sanctions were tightened, oil prices actually dropped in 2012.

Therefore, Iran had been stripped of its strategic potential in the global energy market and lost its standing. Iran's market presence or absence did not have any significant impact. U.S. Congress oil sanctions against Iran required the U.S. President to submit a report on the impact of those

sanctions on the global energy market every six months. Since 2012, these reports indicated that removal of Iranian oil from global markets have had little impact on energy supply and prices. Those in charge of the Ahmadinejad Administrations perceived that Iran oil sanctions would push global oil prices above \$200, but oil prices dropped when sanctions against Iran were tightened.

Saudi Arabia supplied the energy needs of China, the biggest economic rival of its American benefactors. The U.S. aim was to make China independent from Iranian oil, allay China's concerns with Iran sanctions and finally remove Iran from the world oil market. The Iraqi government that was in fact indebted to Iran, took much of Iran's market share. Iraq accounted for the largest output hike. This is just a summary of conditions when Iran embarked on the JCPOA negotiations and even when President Trump pulled out of talks. The JCPOA talks started when Iran's nuclear program was deemed to threaten international peace and security. Six Chapter VII resolutions had been approved against Iran's nuclear program. These resolutions set the stage for taking other cases like Iran's missile program, conventional weapons and regional issues to the Security Council. The U.S. and the West opposed Iran's missile program because of their regional differences with Iran. But they used the argument of capability to deliver nuclear weapons in order to impose sanctions on Iran's missile program. These two files were intertwined under the pretext of "missiles capable of carrying a nuclear warhead". The real motive for imposing sanctions on the IRGC and its Quds Force was also regional challenges between Iran and Israel, but in the resolutions, IRGC commanders had been designated under the pretext of their involvement in Iran's nuclear and missile programs.

Had that trend continued, two more controversial cases – human rights and Middle East peace – would have been added to the provisions of Security Council resolutions on the Iranian nuclear program under some fabricated pretext. When a security consensus is built against a country, cooperation with that country becomes costly while pressure on that country would become easily acceptable and legitimate. Meantime, when Security Council considers a situation as a threat to international peace and security, it may impose restrictions on that country without setting

a precedent against “normal” countries. Therefore, States – particularly from Global South – with similar programs would no longer be concerned about the application of those restrictions against them. In a bid to guarantee their own future, those who may be pursuing programs similar to the target state would ironically be more vigilant in enumerating the violations and misconducts of the target State in order to differentiate themselves from that situation. This self-help practice further isolates that country. Ironically, history has shown that those in the global south who cooperate with these securitizing measures may one day find themselves in the same situation.

Some significant Iranian politicians contended in the 1990s that Iran and the West were irreversibly on a collision course. They argued that the inevitable conflict should be diverted to the nuclear issue that enjoyed a large internal consensus. This vision was promoted by those who did not have a proper appreciation of the external world and global relations. Regrettably they did not consult with experts and reached dangerously flawed conclusions based on their incorrect hypotheses. They built an overwhelming consensus within the Iranian polity around this fatal misperception. They did not realize that the only case that could build global security consensus against Iran was the nuclear issue. The efforts of Israel and the U.S. to securitize Iran bore fruit when they succeeded to take Iran to the Security Council for its nuclear program. Once under Chapter VII, it was only a matter of time before they succeeded in including conventional arms and missiles. The objective sought in arms embargo and missile restrictions was to control Iran’s regional activities and not the nuclear program. But they used the nuclear program¹⁴⁷ as a pretext. That could have been extended to other issues too. A global security consensus was possible only through portraying Iran’s nuclear program as a threat. This securitization cleared the way for opening more cases. Continuation of that trend would have enabled the adding of more files.

Doubtlessly, Russia, China and many in the Global South do not condone human rights issue and support for Palestinian resistance to

¹⁴⁷ President Ahmadinejad’s imprudent remarks about the Holocaust and wiping Israel off the map lead to the adopting of two statements by the Security Council and immensely contributed to the securitization of Iran.

be handled by the Security Council under normal circumstances. Their past behavior within the Security Council indicates the existence of this reluctance. But when a country falls under Chapter VII of the UN Charter entitled “Action with Respect to Threats to the Peace, Breaches of the Peace, and Acts of Aggression”, under other pretexts such as the nuclear file, then dealing with other files rarely sets a precedent. Therefore, no country would consider it necessary for its own interests to oppose. When the Security Council started examining the Iraqi invasion of Kuwait and Libya’s alleged involvement in the Lockerbie bombing case, other issues like violation of Kurds’ human rights in Iraq and Libyan treatment of its own population were opened. Therefore, had Iran remained under Chapter VII, the Security Council could have added human rights concerns associated with the regrettable 2022 unrest to the existing resolutions.

It should be always kept in mind that even preventing enrichment in a country is not acceptable in the eyes of many non-permanent members of the UN Security Council and Global South. However, when a country is accused of having a clandestine nuclear program and reported by the IAEA to the Security Council on those grounds, the situation is no longer normal to set a precedent for others. This explains why the insistence of some Global South nations like Brazil on stressing Iran’s noncompliance with IAEA and Security Council resolutions were sometimes even harsher and more explicit than allegations by the U.S. and its allies. First, they intended to separate the target country from themselves and others in order to go along with the application of restrictions against the target without worrying about their own future. Imposing enrichment restrictions upon a country that has been found in violation of international standards may be presented as *sui generis* instances born out of “proliferation concerns”. Under the same pretext, they demanded the shutdown of the Arak heavy-water reactor. Then, they went beyond the nuclear issue to focus on weapons that were by no means related to the nuclear case. First, they banned arms sales. Russia had no problem as it saw Iran as a competitor. They advanced one step and banned arms purchase, specially, those categories of weapons that Russia and China did not intend to sell to Iran. Then came missiles and persons and organizations unrelated to the nuclear file. What was the connection between Gen. Soleimani – who

was designated by UN Security Council – and the nuclear file? Because the Americans were bent on designating him on the UN sanctions list, they made the absurd claim that the Quds Force was supporting Iran's nuclear program. That was how they dragged the Security Council into various unrelated aspects of Iranian policy under the nuclear pretext.

To bring an end to this growing trend, dialogue with the U.S. was inevitable. Despite what our detractors have claimed, negotiations with the U.S. by the Rouhani Administration were not out of “a thirst to talk with the Americans,” “wishful thinking” or trusting the United States Government. Iran had no option but to negotiate and reach an agreement with all permanent members in order to end the Security Council resolutions. As soon as Iran's nuclear file was reported to the UN Security Council, the U.S. and fellow permanent members stepped in. Until summer 2005, we were in talks with the E3+EU and we were not compelled to talk with the US. When the case was referred to the Security Council, the U.S. was automatically added to the negotiating table. Therefore, the referral of Iran's nuclear case to the Security Council in winter 2006 had rendered U.S. consent necessary for the closure of the case. Had the U.S. not joined the effort to close the case, it could have vetoed the resolution ending the case.

My predecessor, Dr. Jalili, also participated in multilateral and even bilateral talks with the US. He held more than six years of eight-party talks (Iran, EU, US, UK, France, Germany, Russia and China) with U.S. participation. William Burns, the then Deputy Secretary of State, reportedly met with Dr. Jalili one-on-one on the sidelines of one round of eight-party negotiations¹⁴⁸. The problem was that the highest-ranking U.S. official who had a meeting with Iran's national security advisor was the deputy secretary of state and negotiators from other countries were at the level of political directors. From the standpoint of diplomatic protocol, such rank discrepancy was not dignified or even proper. More importantly, from the perspective of bargaining maneuvers it favored the opposite party, because the more junior diplomats could always claim that their political bosses rejected their compromise while Iran's representative did

¹⁴⁸ William J. Burns, *The Back Channel: A Memoir of American Diplomacy and the Case for Its Renewal*, New York, Random House, 2019, P. 351. Julian Borger, “Nuclear talks lead to rare meeting between US and Iran” *The Guardian*, 1 October 2009.

not have the same recourse. Under the Rouhani Administration, one of the first things we accomplished was to end this practice. I insisted that I would talk only with my counterparts. We made it clear that if other countries send their deputy ministers or political directors, Iran will send officials of the same level. This procedure continued up to the end of talks. While I was present along with EU high representatives (Ashton and Mogherini) in almost all the talks, we opened the round, while our deputies continued the negotiations with their E33+ counterparts, and only participated directly only when Secretary Kerry and other ministers were also in the room.

One may ask why Chapter VII resolutions were so important as to require Iran to negotiate with the US. The answer is clear. Covering Articles 39-51 of the UN Charter, Chapter VII is titled Action with Respect to Threats to the Peace, Breaches of the Peace, and Acts of Aggression. Any state falling under any article of this chapter would at least be deemed a threat to peace. This matters whether or not such labelling is fair, because the Security Council is tasked with preserving international peace and security. Adoption of resolutions under Chapter VII against a country is the highest achievement in the securitization of that target state. The consequence of such official security consensus is increased costs of cooperation with the target and decreased costs of harming that country.

On this basis, before the Rouhani Administration, the country had reached the conclusion that in order to have regular ties with the world, particularly friendly Russia and China, neighboring countries, Muslim nations and members of the Non-Aligned Movement, it was necessary to neutralize the security consensus. To that end, Iran's nuclear file had to be closed at the Security Council, which naturally required consent of the five veto-wielding permanent members. No situation is removed from the agenda of the Security Council automatically. Iran's nuclear case was added to the agenda of the Security Council based on a resolution adopted by that Council (UNSCR 1696). And the closure of the file requires a same procedure, i.e., adopting another resolution. Each permanent member has the power to veto that Security Council resolution. Therefore, most ironically, Iran was forced to negotiate with the U.S. exactly at the

same moment that the resolutions were described as “worthless pieces of scrap paper.”

JCPOA Nuclear Achievements

Contrary to our own initial assessment in summer 2013 that we would have to suspend enrichment for several months, enrichment continued under the JCPOA, without even a second of suspension. All mandatory Security Council resolutions that demanded immediate suspension of enrichment under Chapter VII of the Charter were terminated without being implemented.

Iran’s enrichment was recognized by the Security Council under its resolution 2231; the same Council that had in six previous resolutions described it as a threat to international peace and security and demanded that Iran should suspend it. As Iran refused to suspend its enrichment program, the Council had adopted unprecedented punishments against Iranian people based on Article 41 of Chapter VII. Yet, under the JCPOA and resolution 2231, Iran became the only country in the world with an enrichment program explicitly recognized by the Security Council. While our domestic critics accused JCPOA of curtailing Iran’s enrichment, the most central objective and the greatest global achievement of JCPOA was not removal of sanctions, but the de-securitization of Iran and the recognition of its enrichment program by the same UN organ that had considered it a threat against international peace and security.

The most central pillar of Iran’s enrichment industry was its research and development program on centrifuges, which was eventually authorized under the JCPOA. The E3 were insisting until the final days to limit R&D to the obsolete IR-1 centrifuges, which was more of a joke. The most advanced Iranian centrifuges were preserved and R&D continued on all of them. Thanks to the expertise and shrewdness of our nuclear negotiators, the only restrictions accepted were commensurate with the logical scientific and technological timeframe for the advancement of Iran’s enrichment industry; and even that for only 10 years. The U.S. consistently insisted on a 20-year timeframe for restrictions. The main criticism of President Trump and even President Biden against the JCPOA was the “sunset clause”:

five years for arms restrictions; eight years for missile restrictions; and ten years for the closure of Iran's nuclear case and its removal from the agenda of the UN Security Council.

Iran's remedial measures in the field of enrichment – under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA in 2020 and 2021 and in response to E3 failures to normalize Iranian economic relations following U.S. withdrawal from JCPOA – showed that the enrichment capacity had been safeguarded by the JCPOA and that the agreed restrictions were only commensurate with a natural – as opposed to politically motivated – pace of progress in the enrichment technology. And all of that had been achieved together with the termination of Chapter VII resolutions and neutralization of the Israel's securitization project.

Under the JCPOA, Iran exported its surplus stockpile of enriched uranium to Russia; but only after taking delivery of more than twice the yellowcake consumed. Three hundred and seventy tons of yellowcake were delivered to Iran before we exported nearly 8 tons of 3.7 enriched Uranium. The significance of this achievement would be appreciated if one considers that due to various export control mechanism, Iran had been prevented to import any yellowcake since the revolution, and its entire stockpile yellowcake was 550 tons imported into the country before the Islamic Revolution.

Although Western governments constantly insisted on dismantling the Fordow facility, it remained intact with more than 1,000 centrifuge machines spinning. Moreover, despite two years of firm and strong U.S. opposition to Iran's heavy-water reactor, insisting upon destruction of the reactor, the Arak heavy water reactor was kept under the JCPOA¹⁴⁹. Renovation of the Arak reactor with state-of-the-art heavy water technologies was approved under the JCPOA. Ironically, countries that

¹⁴⁹ After backing down from its initial demand and accepting that the heavy-water reactor remain intact by reconfiguring its calandria to reduce spent plutonium and boost its technical efficacy, the US demanded that the old calandria be obliterated. But the AEOL suggested that cement be poured into the calandria fuel pipes to become dysfunctional. The Americans accepted this proposal after long negotiations. The AEOL had preserved the capacity to replace the cemented pipes with new ones (to enable it to restore the original calandria under emergency conditions of non-performance by its counterparts). In a bid to cover up its backdown in the war of narratives related to the Arak facility, the US government insinuated for the American public opinion that under the JCPOA, concrete had been poured into the Arak facility. This narrative was regrettably taken on face value by many Iranian opponents of the JCPOA.

had continued to demand until the very last days that the Arak facility should be bulldozed were assigned to participate in the project. Closure of the allegation of possible military dimension of the Iranian nuclear program at the IAEA was another key achievement of the JCPOA that could only be attained following tough negotiations.

Missile and Arms Restrictions

After more than eighteen months of resistance, our Western counterparts finally abandoned their initial demands for monitoring and verifying Iran's missile program and missile tests. On the other hand, the severe embargo on Iran's missile program that even included the threat of force for blocking Iran's access to missile components and technology under resolution 1929 had to be addressed. Following intense negotiations that spanned over the entire course of the nuclear talks, we manage to turn the harsh language of 1929 into a much milder eight-year restriction under annex B of resolution 2231. Even those mild restrictions apply solely to the "missiles designed to be capable of delivering nuclear weapons". As we wrote in the Iranian Statement circulated as a document of the Security Council on the day of adoption of 2231, Iranian missiles "have not been designed for WMD capability and are thus outside the purview or competence of the Security Council resolution and its annexes."¹⁵⁰

The most important progress in resolution 2231, compared with resolution 1929, about the missile and arms program may be summarized as follows: First and foremost, the wordings used changed from orders to requests, from bans to restrictions and from vague language open to excessive interpretations to precise terms. Different terms used in UN Security Council resolutions have specific legislative history with wide-ranging consequences. For instance, when the Security Council wishes to impose mandatory enforceable obligations, it uses the expression "decides that.... shall". Non-compliance with such obligations can trigger enforcement action under Articles 41 and 42 of the Charter. However, when the Council uses phrases such as "calls upon," "requests," "encourages"

¹⁵⁰ S/2015/550 dated 20 July 2015.

and the likes, it connotes that while members should implement them in accordance with Article 25 of the Charter, violations will not have enforceable consequences. In resolution 1929, the Council uses some of its most enforceable orders “about Iran’s missile program and transfer of conventional weapons to and from Iran, while Resolution 2231 which does not address these issues in its body and only refers to them in annex B, uses conditional but positive phrases. That is why enforcement mechanisms, including the sanctions committee and the sanctions task force were dropped in resolution 2231. These significant differences were the outcome of tough negotiations.

Paragraph 8 of Resolution 1929 strictly banned any purchase of arms from Iran and selling combat hardware to Iran¹⁵¹. However, paragraph 5 of the E33+ statement (attached to Resolution 2231), such cooperation and transactions are not banned, but they are subject to UN Security Council’s permit¹⁵².

The West would doubtlessly oppose such permits, but our fundamental position was that Resolution 2231 and even its annexes could contain no embargo or ban and should not use negative phrases. Unfortunately, this major achievement was overshadowed by domestic political games. The U.S. easily benefited from our toxic domestic wranglings to avoid responding about and more importantly honoring its conceptual and practical concessions to Iran.

The most significant achievement with regards to modification of wordings pertained to the missile program, which even lead to strong

¹⁵¹ Decides that all States shall prevent the direct or indirect supply, sale or transfer to Iran, from or through their territories or by their nationals or individuals subject to their jurisdiction, or using their flag vessels or aircraft, and whether or not originating in their territories, of any battle tanks, armoured combat vehicles, large calibre artillery systems, combat aircraft, attack helicopters, warships, missiles or missile systems as defined for the purpose of the United Nations Register of Conventional Arms...

¹⁵² All States may participate in and permit, provided that the Security Council decides in advance on a case by case basis to approve: the supply, sale or transfer directly or indirectly from or through their territories, or by their nationals or individuals subject to their jurisdiction, or using their flag vessels or aircraft, and whether or not originating in their territories, to Iran, or for the use in or benefit of Iran, of any battle tanks, armoured combat vehicles, large caliber artillery systems, combat aircraft, attack helicopters, warships, missiles or missile systems, as defined for the purpose of the United Nations Register of Conventional Arms.... This paragraph shall apply until the date five years after the JCPOA Adoption Day or until the date on which the IAEA submits a report confirming the Broader Conclusion, whichever is earlier.

criticism of American negotiators in the U.S. Senate. In Iran, our achievement was eclipsed by demagogical propaganda. Paragraph 9 of Resolution 1929 had ordered Iran to steer of “any activity related to ballistic missiles capable of delivering nuclear weapons”¹⁵³. It may be described as the most dangerous provision in Resolution 1929, specifically because it ordered the adoption of any measures to prevent the transfer of technology or technical assistance to Iran for missile manufacturing. After hundreds of hours of tough negotiations, all these provisions that could even trigger a war were dropped. Instead, paragraph 3 of the E33+ statement calls on Iran to refrain from undertaking “any activity related to ballistic missiles designed to be capable of delivering nuclear weapons”¹⁵⁴. The addition of the term “designed” in this phrase was one of the most difficult topics of discussion over two years, because this term introduces the conditionality of “intent”. Iran does not seek to develop nuclear weapons. Therefore, it does not “design” any missile to be capable of delivering nuclear weapons. While the phrase “missiles capable of delivering nuclear weapons” could have applied to all Iranian ballistic missiles, the wording in annex B of 2231 does not.

Still more importantly, all mandatory and enforceable wordings in paragraph 9 of resolution 1929 that could have been abused as pretexts for taking military action in order to prevent Iranian access to missile technology and material were removed in the annex to resolution 2231 and replaced in paragraph 4 of the E33+ statement with a positive language that transfer of missile technology and material was possible after prior permission by the Security Council¹⁵⁵.

The second achievement pertained to setting a specific timeframe for terminating missile and arms restrictions. Those timeframes went into effect even under toughest conditions without any interruption. Despite

¹⁵³ Decides that Iran shall not undertake any activity related to ballistic missiles capable of delivering nuclear weapons, including launches using ballistic missile technology, and that States shall take all necessary measures to prevent the transfer of technology or technical assistance to Iran related to such activities;

¹⁵⁴ Iran is called upon not to undertake any activity related to ballistic missiles designed to be capable of delivering nuclear weapons, including launches using such ballistic missile technology, until the date eight years after the JCPOA Adoption Day or until the date on which the IAEA submits a report confirming the Broader Conclusion, whichever is earlier.

¹⁵⁵ All States may participate in and permit the activities described below provided that the Security Council decides in advance on a case by case basis to permit such activity:

U.S. endeavor and Europe's reluctance, all arms restrictions automatically expired after five years on 18 October 2020. The Security Council's missile restrictions also expired on 18 October 2023 despite heavy tension between Iran and the West.

The third achievement that has received even less attention is that with all foregoing modifications, we still did not allow any restrictions to be incorporated into the JCPOA or even the body of Resolution 2231; rather, all of them have been mentioned in the E33+ statement annexed to the resolution. Exclusion of these restrictions from the main text of the resolution and the JCPOA is of key significance because even their breach by Iran would not amount to any breach of the JCPOA to set the stage for the reinstatement of Security Council sanctions. This key achievement was clearly noted in the JCPOA text and in a statement by Iran on the day of adoption of resolution 2231 by the Security Council¹⁵⁶.

The short duration of these restrictions – the so-called “sunset clauses” – coupled with modifications of provisions regarding arms and missile technology were among key concerns of President Trump, President Biden and even Europe regarding to the JCPOA. As it was explained earlier, the U.S. and the West had unfairly exploited a security consensus built against Iran to refer these unrelated issues to the Security Council. It was impossible to negotiate the full and immediate lifting of these sanctions without negotiating about regional and missile issues and negotiators did not have such permission.

One of the baseless accusations particularly after the termination of the Security Council arms and missile restrictions in 2021 and 2023 was that while Russia and China opposed these restrictions, the Iranian delegation accepted them and thus left the two with no option but to go along. This unfair allegation came after an unfriendly post-JCPOA interview by Minister Lavrov and is repeated from time to time despite incontrovertible facts, documents and media reports and repeated clarifications by the foreign ministry. It is true that Iran, Russia and China were in favor of lifting of all sanctions. Iranian negotiators, without any effective assistance from Russia or China, remained opposed to inclusion of any

¹⁵⁶ Refer to Annex 8.

restrictions in the Security Council resolution until the very last minutes of negotiations. The issue of arms restrictions was even discussed in the 6 July 2015 ministerial negotiating session which dragged until 1:00 am. During that session, the British Foreign Secretary linked arms restrictions with regional issues, and EU High Representative threatened to break the negotiations if I insisted on de-linking the two issues. I responded vehemently and loudly: “Never threaten an Iranian!”¹⁵⁷. My longtime friend, Sergey Lavrov, helped by smiling and adding: “Nor a Russian”.

To the misperception that served as a pretext for this allegation is that arms and missile restrictions had been incorporated into Resolution 2231 from scratch and for the first time so that the opposition of three JCPOA participants (Iran, Russia and China) could have prevented their inclusion. As explained before, tough arms embargo and missile sanctions already existed in Resolutions 1737, 1747, and 1929. The negotiations were aimed at lifting these sanctions and not adding them. For this simple reason, the opposition of four Western delegations was sufficient to prevent their removal. The Western states insisted on negotiations over missile and regional issues in return for lifting those sanctions. Iranian negotiators were not authorized to negotiate about them. Therefore, without any serious assistance from our Russian and Chinese counterparts, we managed to downgrade the permanent and enforceable sanctions to time-bound (5 and 8 years) requirement of obtaining Security Council permit before any such transfer. We saw that pursuant to Resolution 2231, the restrictions were lifted automatically in 2021 and 2023 even in the midst of turbulent relations between Iran and the West. As mentioned earlier, we also managed to prevent the inclusion of these provisions in the main body of Resolution 2231, moving them to an annexed statement by the E3/EU+3. Not only that statement was not endorsed by Iran although China and Russia did sign it, but even in a letter dated 20 July 2015, immediately after adoption of Resolution 2231, we expressed our opposition to all those restrictions and declared that we will not be bound by them¹⁵⁸.

¹⁵⁷ The cover photo of this book, taken by Hamid Mirdamadi, illustrates the same meeting.

¹⁵⁸ S/2015/550 (20 July 2015) (Refer to Annex 8)

Another fallacy pertains to Minister Lavrov's absence in the group photo due to his opposition to the continuation of arms restrictions. In fact, Minister Lavrov was in attendance in the final meeting and the following group photo with a happy and smiling face. However, just before Federica Mogherini and I went before the press to read out the joint statement, Minister Lavrov had to leave Vienna as he was scheduled to travel to Uzbekistan. Of course, in a tense final and unscheduled meeting late evening on July 13, 2015, between Kerry, Mogherini and Lavrov joined later by me, Lavrov sought in vain to postpone the conclusion of JCPOA by a week on the pretext of his scheduled lunch with President of Uzbekistan the following day on July 14 – the day of adoption of JCPOA. Ironically, the main point of contention during that meeting was Lavrov insistence that Iran would not get a better deal than 5-year limitation on arms restriction and questioning whether I had proper instructions to accept it, to which I rudely replied.¹⁵⁹

Economic Sanctions

Although nearly two years of talks were focused almost exclusively on the future of Iran's nuclear program and neutralization or even reversal of international security consensus against Iran through termination of Iran's treatment by the Security Council as a Chapter VII case of threat to international peace and security, during the last three months of talks we managed to negotiate for all economic sanctions imposed by the Security Council as well as unilateral American and multilateral European nuclear-related sanctions to be lifted. The key challenge associated with the lifting of sanctions was that the only nuclear-related unilateral sanctions were terminated. But as I noted earlier, the JCPOA negotiations were only about the nuclear issue. Therefore, the achievement of negotiations could be noting but the lifting of nuclear-related sanctions. Since the very start of Muscat talks, this issue had been expressed in clear terms by the American side. The United States and E3/EU initially wanted to lift only nuclear related sanctions even for Security Council resolutions.

¹⁵⁹ The Untold Story, Volume 5, P. 453 (Persian)

Had this approach been successful, most negative provisions of Security Council resolution would have remained intact. We resisted this approach, and consequently all provisions of previous resolutions were terminated by Security Council Resolution 2231. More importantly, this resolution neutralized the global securitization of Iran in its previous resolution by clearly stating in one of its preambular paragraphs that, “affirming that conclusion of the JCPOA marks a fundamental shift in its consideration of this issue, and expressing its desire to build a new relationship with Iran strengthened by the implementation of the JCPOA and to bring to a satisfactory conclusion its consideration of this matter.” As for unilateral and multilateral sanctions outside the Security Council, there was no doubt that only nuclear-related sanctions were under consideration. The fact remains that the United States and Europe did not faithfully implement their obligations, but that was not the fault of the JCPOA, which had envisaged such non-performance and had precise provisions for dealing with them in paragraphs 26 and 36 of the JCPOA.

Another criticism pertains to “waiver” and not “termination” of American sanctions imposed by U.S. Congress. Given the opposition of the majority in Congress with Obama and the nuclear negotiations¹⁶⁰, we had only two options: Forget about the agreement by insisting Congressional lifting of U.S. sanctions—which have been tantamount to putting the future of the agreement in the hands of Netanyahu and his cohorts—or accept the current option for the U.S. president to exercise his authority to continuously waive those sanctions for specific periods set forth in each act. Negotiators presented both options to Iranian leadership and finally the latter was accepted¹⁶¹.

Another wide-spread accusation that I faced was that I had not even read the agreement. This absurd allegation came after I said in a parliamentary

¹⁶⁰ Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's attendance in Congress to speak against the JCPOA, without invitation from US President or Administration, indicated full sway of Israeli lobby on Congress, which posed an obstacle to the lifting of sanctions by Congress.

¹⁶¹ That was one of the two red lines that were not entirely observed by me. But in both cases, after receiving authorization, an alternative option was chosen. In a meeting with the Assembly of Experts on 3 September 2015, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei reaffirmed this fact, saying: “Therefore, the goal is to lift sanctions. Of course, in some cases they said that lifting sanctions is not within the power of the United States - which is one of the sides we are faced with. They said that they would suspend such sanctions and that they would use their legal rights and other such things. But those sanctions that are within the power of US or European governments should be completely lifted.”

session that the term “suspend” had not been used the agreement, while it had been incorporated at the last minute in one of the annexes to the JCPOA without my knowledge. It was used in technical provisions unrelated to U.S. sanctions and was merely an administrative and bureaucratic modification with regards to the European Commission’s “decisions” and “resolutions”. It had no legal or executive consequence. Furthermore, it had nothing to do with US sanctions that constituted our main challenge. It was related to Europe that had no legal difficulty with the JCPOA implementation. Europe’s problem was its inability – or lack of political will or both – to withstand the unlawful pressure by the United States. Although this term was added by experts after the conclusion of ministerial negotiations and in contrast with what the ministers had agreed, it had no impact on the end result and never affected EU sanctions. However, it played well into the hands of my detractors inside Iran.

Another criticism against the JCPOA inside Iran was sequencing. Iran’s initial nuclear steps required time for implementation on the ground while U.S. and Europeans commitments only required legal steps which all presumed would be instantaneous. To address this challenge, it was decided that the U.S. President and the European Commission (EC) would first sign or adopt the necessary legislation to lift nuclear-related sanctions before Iran started taking steps. But the entry into force of those presidential memoranda or EC decisions would fall after confirmation of Iran’s steps by the IAEA. This option was authorized by top authorities and incorporated in the agreement and was carried out without any major problem¹⁶².

Another criticism was why negotiators trusted Kerry’s signature. It came following an out of context quote from an interview by one of my colleagues who was reported as saying “Kerry’s signature is the guarantee.” We were attacked for placing trust in the signatures of President Obama and Secretary Kerry and this turned into another pretext by detractors to assail the negotiators. One of our colleagues was right to describe me

¹⁶² In the same meeting, Ayatollah Khamenei said: “It is clear that economic sanctions should be lifted and we said that it should be done ‘immediately’. Now, they have defined ‘immediately’ and we did not disagree with it. It is alright. Our friends in the country defined ‘immediately’ in a particular way and they adopted a specific procedure for it and we did not oppose it.”

as the “minister with smiling lips and bleeding heart”. In reality that statement referred to Kerry’s instructions to U.S., embassies regarding visas to European citizens of Iranian origin to address one of our complaints; in fairness to John Kerry, I never heard any complaints from Iranians concerning that issue after Kerry’s instructions.

In addition to accusation about trusting “signatures”, we were attacked for our pursuit of “written declaration” from the E3/EU+3 side as a guarantee for lifting of sanctions. In fact, Ayatollah Khamenei in his letter dated 21 October 2015 had instructed the government to do exactly that: “...It is necessary that solid and sufficient guarantees be arranged to avoid any infraction by the opposite parties. Written declaration by the U.S. president and the European Union for the lifting of the sanctions is among them”.

As said earlier, there are no iron-clad guarantees for compliance with transnational treaties. Letter, signature, treaty, legislation, arbitration and even compulsory jurisdiction of the International Court of Justice or other guarantees cannot prevent one side from reneging on its pledge. They are all helpful as they can make non-compliance more costly. But the only guarantee for compliance with an international agreement, treaty, or convention is that the benefits of its implementation should outweigh the costs of compliance or benefits of reneging. Inhere what is important is not the reality but the perception of the leaders, as clearly President Trump’s cost-benefit analysis for withdrawing from the JCPOA ended to the U.S. detriment. Of course, his real objective was satisfying Israel and part of his political base, which he achieved.

In the context of global political realities, the JCPOA had relatively solid foundations. The most important was Resolution 2231 of the Security Council that terminated all previous resolutions and automatically lifted all sanctions on three specific dates. The resolution was adopted on 20 July 2015 by the Security Council. Furthermore, on 19 October 2015, President Obama along with his Secretary of State and Secretary of the Treasury ordered lifting of sanctions -- published in the Federal Register¹⁶³— before

¹⁶³ <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2015/10/30/2015-27869/preparing-for-implementation-of-the-joint-comprehensive-plan-of-action-of-july-14-2015-jcpoa>; <https://www.federalregister.gov/documents/2015/11/02/2015-27863/contingent-waiver-of-certain-sanctions-related-to-the-joint-comprehensive-plan-of-action>

Iran took any action. The EU followed suit¹⁶⁴. Iran's implementation measures on the ground began after all these steps had been taken. Following fulfilment of Iran's obligations, the provisions of the resolution and U.S. and EU decisions went into force on January 16, 2016, as expected and without hindrance. Termination of the arms and missile restrictions occurred on the dates specified in spite of adverse diplomatic climate. The possibility of bad faith implementation by the U.S. or the E3/EU's inability to fulfil their commitments had been foreseen in the resolution and provisions for remedial measures had been envisaged in paragraphs 26 and 36 of the JCPOA. The unlawful abuse of dispute resolution provisions of the JCPOA and resolution 2231 by the E3/EU – the so-called snapback mechanism – in September 2025 in response to Iran's lawful remedial measures is more a testament to the state of international affairs rather than any fault of the agreement.

Another unfounded allegation by our detractors was that Iran took practical steps in fulfilment of its obligations while the other side only made promises. Interestingly, opponents of the JCPOA in the US and Israel also raised the same criticism of the Obama Administration. Two points need to be clarified. The first one pertains to the concurrence and balance of steps at the moment of the JCPOA implementation; Iran took no step before any *quid pro quo*.

¹⁶⁴ https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/PDF/?uri=OJ:JOL_2015_274_R_0001&from=EN
https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/PDF/?uri=OJ:JOL_2015_274_R_0002&from=EN
https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/PDF/?uri=OJ:JOL_2015_274_R_0003&from=EN
https://eur-lex.europa.eu/legal-content/EN/TXT/PDF/?uri=OJ:JOC_2015_345_R_0001&from=EN

Reciprocal Steps by JCOPA Participants

	Islamic Republic of Iran	E3/EU+3
Interim Agreement (Geneva)	- Freezing the number of centrifuges without suspension - Freezing construction at Arak	- Freezing bilateral and multilateral sanctions - Freezing pressure on Iran's customers to further reduce their oil imports from Iran ¹⁶⁵
	Suspending 20% enrichment	- Suspending car industry, gold and precious metals sanctions - Stopping new sanctions by US Congress ¹⁶⁶
	Converting 100 kg of 20% reserves to 3.5% materials and 100 kg to fuel ¹⁶⁷	Receiving \$700 million from frozen assets in return for each round of conversion of reserves ¹⁶⁸ , totaling \$12 billion ¹⁶⁹
	Converting unusable 20% waste to 3.5%	Receiving 700 tons of gold seized in South Africa

¹⁶⁵ The US Administration and the EU had in a coordinated and calculated move managed to bring Iran's oil exports down from 2.5 mb/d to below 900,000 b/d within two years and without impacting global oil prices. Under US secondary sections, buyers of Iranian oil were required to cut 20% from their oil imports automatically every six months, which would bring down Iranian exports to zero within two to three years.

¹⁶⁶ At the beginning of the Rouhani Administration, the US House of Representatives had adopted a new act which, if a similar one were adopted in the Senate and signed by the US President, could have brought Iran's oil exports to zero within one year. If approved, such act would strip the US President of presidential powers for waiving sanctions, in which case, any agreement would have become impossible.

¹⁶⁷ Of a total 400 kg, 200 kg had been converted to fuel under the former administration without any quid pro quo so that Iran's stockpile never reached 200 kg.

¹⁶⁸ The stockpile was exhausted during the first six months and during the next 11 months, we obligated the US to unfreeze \$700 million per month without any action by Iran.

¹⁶⁹ A sum of \$7 billion was received by the Central Bank of Iran in banknote or other forms and \$5 billion was transferred to Oman.

JCPOA Period	Formal inspection of Parchin	Agreement on modalities to Close PMD
	Reducing centrifuges in Natanz	- Recognition of Iran's enrichment program by the Security Council - Lifting of all Security Council resolutions before any action by Iran - Separating the missile from the nuclear program; removing enforceable missile embargo; removing pretext for military action
	Sending 10 tons of enriched uranium to Russia	Receipt of 200 tons of yellowcake from Kazakhstan before delivery of reserves
	Reducing centrifuges at Fordow	Accepting preservation of Fordow strategic capacity
	Taking action to remove Arak reactor's calandria	- Signing document on Arak reconfiguration by Iran and E3/ EU+3 ministers - IAEA report on PMD
	Pouring cement into Arak calandria	- IAEA Governing Board closure of PMD file - Termination of 12 resolutions and 6 decisions of IAEA
	- Provisional Implementation of Additional Protocol - Presenting Iran's 15-Year nuclear R&D Plan to the IAEA	- Publication of Europe and U.S. sanctions termination regulations - Termination of European sanctions and non-implementation of U.S. secondary sanctions - Starting SWIFT negotiations
	Exporting additional heavy water	Cash payment for 32 tons of heavy water by the U.S.

Second, the U.S.'s bad faith and non-performance as well as Europe's self-righteousness amid its impotence are undeniable. But Iranian negotiators should not be blamed for those habits which are prevalent in

the behavior of both U.S. and Europe—from Trump’s withdrawal from a multitude of conventions and organizations to Europe’s abhorrently self-righteous complicity in Israeli crimes in Gaza. However, Iran did not lose anything by engaging in JCPOA. Iran’s nuclear technology in June 2021 was in a better status than during pre-JCPOA years. During those five years of the JCPOA implementation, significant achievements were made, which have been highlighted in the MFA’s June 2021 report to parliament¹⁷⁰. And all of these achievements were attained under IAEA eyes without providing any pretext for re-securitization of Iran.

Iran’s Nuclear Capabilities

	Pre-JCPOA Status	July 2021
Number, Type and Capacity of Centrifuges at Natanz	- IR1 9,156 machines enriching 1,044 machines spinning without feed 5,220 machines installed without spinning - IR2m 160 machines enriching 1,008 machines installed without spinning - IR4 170 machines enriching	- IR1 5,060 machines enriching 4,000 machines in warehouse - IR-2m 850 machines enriching 150 machines installed - IR-4 450 machines enriching - IR-6 230 machines enriching
Number and Type of Centrifuges at Fordow	IR1 696 machines enriching 2,088 machines installed without spinning	- IR1 1,044 machines enriching - IR6 20 machines spinning without feed
Total Enrichment Capacity	13,000 SWU	16,500 SWU

¹⁷⁰ Contrary to media hype, this achievement was not the result of the parliamentary legislation titled “Strategic Action to End Sanctions” that took effect in January 2021 because the six-month period between January and June was not sufficient for any of these achievements. Reaching these objectives required infrastructure that had been built in over five years by benefiting from the JCPOA provisions and under the IAEA supervision without any breach of the JCPOA.

Maximum Purity	20%	60%
Enriched Uranium Reserves	,305.6 kg below 5% 200 kg 20% 140 kg 20% fuel plates	2,596 kg 4-5% 2.2 kg 20% 8.9 kg 60%
R&D	48 machines of 5 types with up to 10 SWU uranium enrichment capacity	490 machines of 16 types with 5.5 to 24 SWU uranium enrichment capacity
Heavy Water Reserves	About 200 tons	128 tons in Iran and 20 tons in Oman 119.6 tons exported
Yellowcake Reserves	514 tons in different forms	887 tons in various forms

Comparing Iran's nuclear status in September 2013 when JCPOA negotiations started and when our report was submitted to the parliament indicates that Iran's nuclear capabilities were not obliterated due to the JCPOA; rather, they were enhanced qualitatively.

Therefore, the only stock we had at the beginning of the negotiations that we lost after the end of the Rouhani Administration was six Chapter VII resolutions to the detriment of Iran and their replacement with three humiliating defeats for the US.

Anyway, the JCPOA negotiations constitute an unprecedented experience in Iran's contemporary history that should be studied realistically. With the unlawful action of the three European countries, the West now claims that the JCPOA has been destroyed and that the previous resolutions have returned—a matter that will be addressed in subsequent sections. However, it is necessary to note that during the nearly three years of the martyred President Raisi's administration, many of the JCPOA's former critics exerted every effort to restore the agreement "in its entirety, without any reduction or alteration." Grappling with implementation challenges has compelled me as an academic and practitioner to adopt a realistic view of domestic and surrounding conditions. As a result, my wishful ambitions faded long time ago. Yet, regrettably, this awareness often arrives only

after global conditions have changed, and what was attainable yesterday has today become nothing more than a dream or an aspiration.

JCPOA Implementation Challenges

The five-year efforts undertaken by my colleagues in safeguarding the JCPOA, particularly during the first term of President Trump, were much tougher and more challenging than the JCPOA negotiations. We will detail all events of those five years in the follow-up to our *Raz-e Sar be Mohr*¹⁷¹. Therefore, I only review briefly those five tough and bitter years.

The main challenge in the JCPOA implementation was the need for lifting sanctions in practice and not just on paper. In the JCPOA text, we incorporated, upon our insistence, the practical impact of lifting of sanctions and not solely their lifting on paper to stave off falling into the trap of U.S. domestic regulations. In other words, through expert work, all U.S. sanctions acts and regulations that were in a way or other linked with the nuclear issue were identified and necessary steps that needed to be taken were added to the JCPOA in the annex. Meantime, the end result of termination of sanctions was also incorporated so that U.S. commitment to lift sanctions would not be limited to paper. It was also noted in the JCPOA that anytime it becomes clear that there are other sanctions or policies that may deny Iran the benefits of termination of nuclear sanctions, such cases should be addressed through consultation. Failure to satisfy Iran would authorize it to take remedial steps to reverse its nuclear commitments in part or in whole.

Therefore, the way the U.S. and Europe fulfilled their obligations was regularly monitored. Any negligence or violation in respecting commitments were meticulously documented and pursued. Some problems were resolved through this process¹⁷². The remaining cases

¹⁷¹ The six-volume account of JCPOA negotiations in Persian.

¹⁷² In all of these cases, the opposite party wrongly claimed to have fully respected its obligations and that if economic actors from other nations (chiefly from the private sector) are unwilling to work with Iran, it has nothing to do with the United States and it cannot force them to work with Iran. The US baselessly claimed that what prevents Iran from benefiting further from the termination of sanctions was rooted in other factors like the US's non-nuclear sanctions still effective (which caused obstacles to economic actors or at least made it tough and costly to conduct due diligence for activities in Iran), mismanagement in Iran and other restrictions like those imposed by the FATF against Iran.

were officially notified to the JCPOA coordinator and in some cases also to the UN Secretary General. That was not limited to the Trump era; many U.S. violations under President Obama too were the subject of Iranian complaints, some even under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA (Dispute Resolution Mechanism—or the so-called “snapback” provision¹⁷³: Objection to Visa Waiver Program under Improvement and Terrorist Travel Prevention Act of 2015, objection to financial and banking hardships and obstacles in purchase of Airbus and Boeing civilian aircraft by Iran (Letter dated 2 September 2016), objection to Iran Sanctions Act (ISA) (Letter dated 16 November 2016) and objection to the application of ISA (Letter dated 17 December 2016, under paragraph 36 of JCPOA).

Under President Trump, up until his exit from the JCPOA (January 2017–May 2018), we recorded instances of violation by the U.S. and Europe: objection to the U.S. Administration’s destructive position and procedure in the JCPOA implementation (letters dated 28 March, 28 May and 19 July 2017); objection to the persistent non-performance of the JCPOA by the Trump Administration (letter dated 13 August 2017); objection to the U.S. Permanent Representative to the United Nations failed visit to Vienna to pressure the IAEA into finding Iran in non-compliance in order to give the U.S. a pretext to invoke the so-called “snapback” mechanism (letter dated 19 August 2017); objection to U.S. attempts to manufacture a pretext to quit the JCPOA (letter dated 18 September 2017); objection to allegation of Iran’s non-compliance by the U.S. and attempt to justify its own non-compliance with the JCPOA under the pretext of domestic legislations including Iran Nuclear Agreement Review Act of 2015 (INARA) and objection to the adoption of Countering America’s Adversaries Through Sanctions Act (CAATSA) (letter dated 16 October 2017); and objection to U.S. ultimatum for non-renewal of waivers (letter dated 1 February 2018).

Trump was led to perceive that the JCPOA was harmful to U.S. and Israeli interests. Unable to terminate the JCPOA at Iran’s cost or impose effective sanctions with the JCPOA still in effect, President Trump unilaterally and unlawfully withdrew from the agreement and subsequently re-imposed

¹⁷³ These letters were compiled in Letter to Secretary General circulated as a UN document and published as a book in Persian and English in summer 2021. A/75/968 and S/2021/669, 20 July 2021.

all sanctions that had been lifted under the JCPOA and continued to impose more sanctions on Iran. In reaction, we officially filed our fully documented objection in letters addressed to the JCPOA Joint Commission's coordinator and other relevant parties.

Such correspondence provided necessary political and legal ground for Iran's remedial measures of scaling back on nuclear commitments with minimum global consequences: Letter dated 10 May 2018 about the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA; Letter dated 10 May 2018 to the Secretary General of the UN with regards to the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA; Letter dated 23 May 2018 to foreign ministers of various countries following the U.S. withdrawal; Letter dated 17 June 2018 demanding a ministerial meeting of the Joint Commission under paragraph 36; responding to Mike Pompeo in English in Iran Daily newspaper and in Persian in Ettela'at daily newspaper on 21 June 2018; Letter dated 19 August 2018 to the UN High Commissioner on Human Rights to explain the consequences of unlawful sanctions on the Iranian nation's human rights; Letter dated 10 April 2019 to the Secretary General of the UN regarding the U.S. listing of the IRGC as a foreign terrorist organization; and letter dated 15 April 2019 to foreign ministers of various nations regarding the U.S. listing of the IRGC as a foreign terrorist organization.

Diplomatic measures were not limited to sending letters although registering those letters posed a major legal and political challenge to the remaining signatories to the JCPOA for reinstating UN resolutions. These letters also provided a legal and political basis for Iran and other JCPOA participants to block to the U.S. Administration's efforts in summer and autumn 2020 in the Security Council and the United Nations General Assembly to revive UN sanctions.

After the JCPOA participants failed to dissuade the U.S. from withdrawing from the JCPOA, their highest officials requested Iranian authorities to exercise restraint and remain committed to the JCPOA. They condemned the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA and pledged to take necessary steps to guarantee Iran's economic benefit from the JCPOA despite U.S. exit. A case in point was a joint statement on 8 May 2018 by Britain's Prime Minister, Germany's Chancellor and France's President, reaffirming their commitment to the JCPOA. The EU foreign policy chief,

Federica Mogherini, also said in a statement that as long as Iran remained committed to its nuclear obligations, the EU would remain compliant with the JCPOA.

In two separate meetings on 15 May 2018, Ms. Mogherini met with the foreign ministers of Iran, France, Britain and Germany to discuss coordinated action in reaction to the U.S. violation of the JCPOA. It was decided that intensive expert talks be held to facilitate access to effective solutions. In a 17 May 2018 meeting in Sofia, Bulgaria, the European Commission announced it would trigger the “blocking statute” preventing European companies and courts from complying with U.S. sanctions against Iran, which it did on 6 June. Updating European Investment Bank (EIB) bylaws for foreign loan payment with a view to covering investment in Iran was another step by the Europeans. The EC said it “acts to protect the interests of EU companies investing in Iran as part of the EU’s continued commitment to the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action”.

On 6 July 2018, along with five other ministers participating in the JCPOA Joint Commission meeting in Vienna, we released a statement to “ensure the continued implementation of the nuclear deal in all its aspects and review unresolved issues arising from the unilateral withdrawal of the United States from the agreement”. Under this statement, the signatories to the JCPOA accepted 11 commitments in the financial, banking, transport and energy sectors in return for Iran’s continued compliance with the JCPOA.

On 16 July 2018, Federica Mogherini said at a press conference that the U.S. had dismissed a request from France, Germany, Britain and the EU to exempt European entities operating in Iran from sanctions. On 6 August, the E3 foreign ministers and EU foreign policy chief Federica Mogherini issued a joint statement deploring U.S. sanctions while reaffirming their determination to support the economic interests of European companies in Iran pursuant to Resolution 2231.

On 24 September 2018, I met with foreign ministers of France, Britain, Germany, China and Russia plus EU foreign policy chief in New York to discuss the JCPOA. We decided to set up a “special channel” to help allay concerns of economic actors willing to transact with Iran so that Iran’s export of oil and import of commodities would not be affected by U.S.

financial impediments. Finally, after several months of effort, the E3 set up the Instrument in Support of Trade Exchanges (INSTEX) on 31 January 2019.

The JCPOA participants showed that in practice they could not fulfil their obligations. Of course, they did not have significant economic gains in remaining committed to their pledges. On the other hand, after quitting the JCPOA and reinstating sanctions, the U.S. Administration took unprecedented enforcement measures including tasking a group of senior officials and experts in the Departments of State and the Treasury as well as U.S. mission abroad to enforce the implementation of its unlawful sanctions against Iran and compel everyone to comply. To that end, individuals and companies that were doing business with Iran were contacted in person and threatened to stop working with Iran.

Blocking financial transaction channels, even in the foodstuff and medication sectors, creating bottlenecks for transnational payments, investment and insurance market, and seizing assets of Iranians overseas were among unprecedented steps by the Trump Administration. Significant decline in oil and petroleum products exports and the flight of capital in the energy sector was among the most devastating consequences of U.S. pressure on Iran's energy sector. Cancellation of agreements for civilian aircraft purchase, obstacles to the activity of Iranian airlines outside the country, pullout of global shipping companies from Iran and bottlenecking Iranian maritime and port operations were the consequences of U.S. economic warfare in the transportation sector. The exit of foreign car manufacturers from Iran, increased car prices and halt in the modernization of domestic car manufacturing industry were among the most impactful consequences of U.S. sanctions in the auto industry.

Negative economic growth, national currency depreciation, galloping inflation, flight of capital from Iran along with the downward trend of foreign investment attraction inflicted heavy damage on national economy and people's livelihood in the economic, social and healthcare sectors. Growing household costs, particularly among vulnerable families and working class, closure of industrial and manufacturing enterprises, increased unemployment and growing housing prices showed that the U.S. sanctions were aimed at collective punishment of citizens and ramping up

pressure on them, particularly the most vulnerable segments of society, with a view to achieving political objectives. This amounts to a casebook definition of “economic terrorism”.

In parallel, blocking Iran’s access to global achievements for preventing and treating covid-19, targeting national healthcare service and pharmaceutical entities by blocking their access to financial transactions to supply medical and healthcare needs were among the consequences of President Trump’s maximum pressure policy, which, in addition to being inhumane, ran counter to the provisional order of the International Court of Justice in its ruling on Iranian complaint pursuant to the 1955 Iran-U.S. Treaty of Amity.

In official correspondence with the EU high representative as the JCPOA coordinator, we documented the E3/EU’s failure to fulfil their obligations following the U.S. withdrawal and denying Iran any economic benefit arising from the removal of restrictions as “significant non-performance of JCPOA obligations” by the E3/EU. We thus invoked the JCPOA dispute resolution mechanism under paragraph 36; a procedure that we had already initiated against the US. The main legal steps undertaken by Iran included a letter dated 21 August 2018, invoking paragraph 36 of the JCPOA, on Europe’s failure to fulfil its commitments, a letter dated 6 November 2018 on the futility of our effort for dispute resolution and start of remedial measures under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA. This was followed by another letter on 7 April 2019 under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA, documenting further significant non-performance by the E3/EU because of their participation in the adoption of the 6 April 2019 statement by the Group of Seven (G7).

Domestic pressure grew for Iran to quit the JCPOA or take reciprocal steps without preparing the legal and international grounds. These steps would have brought no technical, nuclear or political achievement for the country and would have even given President Trump and his hawkish allies a pretext to portray Iran as the threat. Therefore, for one painful year, we exercised restraint and went through the procedure provided for in paragraph 36 of the JCPOA without giving any pretext to Europe to invoke paragraphs 36 and 37 of the JCPOA or paragraphs 11 and 12 of Resolution 2231. We documented all of Europe’s shortcomings in solid-

based letters to the JCPOA Coordinator. Finally in May 2019, it was decided that Iran should begin a gradual reduction of its nuclear obligations under paragraphs 26 and 36 of the JCPOA. Iran scaled back its nuclear commitments in five steps. After the fifth step on 5 January 2020, we ended all nuclear restrictions, stating that Iran would enhance its peaceful nuclear capabilities as necessary, while also underlining Iran's readiness to resume full implementation of the JCPOA based on reciprocity.

In the first step (8 May 2019), we stopped applying restrictions pertaining to stockpiles of enriched uranium and heavy water. In the second step (5 July 2019), we ceased to comply with uranium enrichment level restrictions and reconfiguration of the Arak heavy-water reactor. The third step (6 September 2019) was to expand and accelerate nuclear R&D activities based on our technical needs without compliance with JCPOA restrictions. In the fourth step (6 November 2019), gas feeding started into the centrifuge machines at the Fordow facility. And in the fifth and final step (5 January 2020), we set aside all operational restrictions set forth in the JCPOA (enrichment capacity, enrichment purity, amounts of enriched reserves, and R&D). During this eight-month period, in a bid to prevent securitization and demonization of Iran, we continued to voluntarily implement the Additional Protocol.

We documented all these points in carefully drafted letters to deprive the U.S. and Europe of any exploitation: Letter dated 8 May 2019 by Iranian President, addressed to the heads of state of JCPOA participants regarding exhaustion of the dispute resolution mechanism and initiation of remedial measures by Iran under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA; letter dated 8 May 2019 regarding start of steps to scale back compliance with nuclear commitments; letter dated 25 June 2019 rejecting the demarche by the E3 ambassadors; letter dated 7 August 2019 regarding Iran's second step under paragraph 36; letter dated 17 August 2019 documenting significant non-performance of the JCPOA by the E3/EU under paragraph 36; letter dated 5 September 2019 regarding Iran's third step under paragraph 36; and letter dated 3 October 2019 documenting significant non-performance of the JCPOA caused by a joint statement by the E3 heads of state.

When following our fifth step, the E3 sought to exploit paragraph 36 of the JCPOA in their 14 January 2020 letter, our previously listed letters

and documentations proved very effective for us and neutralized the E3 resort to dispute resolution mechanism. Several letters from Iran as well as letters from the Russian and Chinese foreign ministers were founded on the background documented in our letters: Letter dated 29 January 2020 in rejection of the E3 letter of 14 January 2020 invoking paragraph 36 of the JCPOA; letter dated 10 March 2020 on Iran exhausting paragraph 36 process and dismissing the E3's exploitation of the dispute resolution mechanism; letter dated 18 June 2020 regarding the consequence of the U.S.'s decision to stop issuing nuclear waivers; and letter dated 2 July 2020 regarding the E3's significant non-performance under paragraph 36.

During my tenure as foreign minister, smart diplomacy, round-the-clock efforts and correspondence, speeches and carefully drafted statements stripped the U.S. and its allies of any pretext to resort to the dispute resolution mechanism and reinstate Chapter VII resolutions. Thus, the efforts to re-securitize Iran that had been planned through allegations by Netanyahu and maximum pressure policy of President Trump failed. As shall be discussed in the following segments, the purported success of this effort in 2025 cannot be attributed to the JCPOA or my performance as foreign minister.

The Trump Administration was convinced that maximum pressure would either result in the collapse of the Islamic Republic or force the country to accept U.S. demands. However, people's resilience during nearly four years of full-blown economic warfare despite all pressures and bottlenecks, along with prudent leadership to run the country without oil income, shattered Trump's dreams during his first term.

In 2019, the Trump Administration embarked on a campaign to engage Iran in direct negotiations based on his terms and conditions. In a surprise move, Senator Rand Paul in a meeting in New York in summer of 2019, invited me on behalf of President Trump to meet with the president in the Oval Office. Three weeks later, he imposed sanctions on the Leader and me in order to pressure Iran to come to the negotiating table on his terms. Trump also sought mediation of allies like French President Emanuel Macron and Japanese Prime Minister Abe Shinzo for a direct dialogue with President Rouhani. President Trump also requested, through Macron, to meet with me on the sidelines of G7 Summit in Biarritz, France.

It has to be recalled that although President Rouhani and I were not authorized to meet with President Trump, meeting with him before U.S. return to the JCPOA was in fact only a photo opportunity to advance his personal motives. However, we never closed the channel for indirect talks or maybe direct talks within the framework of E33+ in case preliminary steps were taken. Numerous visits by me and my deputy, Dr. Araghchi, to France and Japan and also meeting with French and Japanese officials in Tehran, reciprocal visits by Iran's president and Japan's PM, continuous phone conversation between heads of state, ministers and deputy ministers of Iran, France and Japan, welcoming offers by regional nations, particularly Qatar, to find face-saving solutions for President Trump to return to the JCPOA and finally my visit to Moscow and offering a deal through President Putin were among a flurry of diplomatic initiatives aimed at finding a prudent and durable solution to bring President Trump back to the JCPOA.

For instance, Republican Senator Rand Paul, who had close ties with President Trump but was not among hawks, came at his request to the residence of our Permanent Representative in New York on 15 July 2019 to meet with me. In the meeting, he said he had met Trump earlier the same day and the U.S. president had shown interest to receive me at the Oval Office¹⁷⁴. President Trump had also expressed his readiness to lift oil sanctions in a step-by-step manner in case Iran returned to its JCPOA obligations and helped stabilize the Persian Gulf. In response, I said that meeting at the White House would be difficult, but I proposed other possible methods to break the deadlock. I offered Iran's assurance of cooperation for Persian Gulf security provided that Iran could also benefit through cessation of unlawful U.S. obstacles for the sale of Iranian oil and repatriation of its proceeds. I also said Ayatollah Khamenei's anti-bomb fatwa may be used. "If Trump is only worried about Iran's access to nuclear weapons, we have ideas in this regard to offer". Senator Paul insisted that to be effective, I should tell everything to Trump directly. I said to him: "I need permission from Tehran, but I'm quite sure Tehran's

¹⁷⁴ <https://www.newyorker.com/news/news-desk/irans-foreign-minister-invited-to-meet-trump-in-the-oval-office>

response would be negative, but you can deliver all of this on my behalf". Interestingly, in his book *The Room Where It Happened*, Bolton recounts that he was about to tender his resignation in case I met with President Trump¹⁷⁵. At the end of our meeting, Senator Paul said President Trump would impose sanctions on me within three weeks. I told him that it did not matter to me; of course it occurred as threatened¹⁷⁶.

In the summer of 2019, a flurry of negotiations was held between Iranian and French presidents, ministers of foreign affairs and deputy ministers to find a solution for a face-saving return of President Trump to the JCPOA. These efforts culminated during my two visits to France on 23 August and 25 August 2019 at the invitation of the French president. In the 23 August meeting with President Macron in the Elysée Palace, we explored various methods of Iran's phased return to its JCPOA obligations in return for the removal of barriers to Iran's oil sales and repatriation of its proceeds. President Macron promised to take up the proposals with President Trump on the sidelines of the G7 summit scheduled for the following day in Biarritz.

I returned to Tehran and I was about to travel to China on an official visit. French Foreign Minister Jean-Yves Le Drian contacted me to invite me on behalf of President Macron to travel to Biarritz to learn about the result of President Macron's positive dialogue with President Trump. The French side insisted on meeting with President Trump and U.S. Treasury Secretary Steven Mnuchin in the French city hosting the G7 summit. Bound by standing instruction not to meet with U.S. officials and in order not to miss my schedule visit to China, I expressed readiness to meet briefly with President Macron and his foreign and finance ministers. I received a commitment by the French foreign minister that no accidental meeting will happen with Trump or other American officials. I flew to Biarritz, France on 25 August and during a five-hour layover in Biarritz, I met

¹⁷⁵ Rand Paul, by this time, was working to have Zarif come from New York to Washington to meet with Trump, as North Korea's Kim Yong Chol had done the year before. Just in case, I prepared at home a typed copy of my two-sentence resignation letter, handwritten in June, to bring in at a moment's notice. I was ready. (John Bolton, *The Room Where It Happened*, p. 374)

¹⁷⁶ "Would you put the Leader's name in there?" "Yes, sir," I said again. "I don't know if it's good or bad, but I want to do it. Put it in. They have to have a reason to negotiate. Add Zarif," said Trump, further making my day." (Ibid, p. 370)

with President Macron, Minister Le Drian and Minister Bruno Le Maire. Upon my insistence, our meeting with President Macron was held outside the hotel where he and President Trump were staying to prevent even an accidental encounter.

Upon arriving at the office of the Biarritz mayor, President Macron said: "I was just with Trump. When I wanted to leave the hotel to come here, Trump asked if he could come with me¹⁷⁷." We had fruitful talks about Iran's return to JCPOA obligations in return for Europe's financial commitments that required U.S. authorization. Iran also offered to cooperate with the Persian Gulf nations to guarantee the security of this key waterway in exchange for the U.S. halting its sanctions against Iran. Despite President Trump's desire and agreement on constructive solutions I reached with President Macron, Bolton and Pompeo blocked any positive step.

The interesting point Bolton has noted in his book is that even Netanyahu had tried to reach Trump to prevent any meeting between President Trump and me in Biarritz.

Despite President Trump's apparent interest in finding a solution, all efforts by us and mediators were neutralized by Bolton and Pompeo and even after Bolton's dismissal by Pompeo who bore a deep personal grudge against Iran and me in person. I do not think that even direct talks between President Rouhani and President Trump or between me and President Trump would have resulted in the U.S. returning to the JCPOA or lifting sanctions. Trump could not go beyond a statement like his joint declaration with North Korean leader Kim Jong-un. When it came to discussing details for U.S. return to the JCPOA and lifting sanctions,

¹⁷⁷ She (Trump's assistant) sent a note back saying Trump had read mine and Macron had invited him to meet Zarif today. "POTUS definitely wants to do this," she wrote...but if Trump met with Zarif, my inclination was to return home and resign...Netanyahu had heard about the possible Zarif meeting and was pressing to call Trump at five thirty p.m. Biarritz time...Kushner was on the phone to David Friedman, US Ambassador to Israel, telling that he was not going to allow Netanyahu's call to go through...I went into Trump's suite at about 5:25, accompanied by Mulvaney and Kushner... Trump raised Zarif, said he wanted to meet with him, and asked, "Do you think it's a good idea?" "No, sir, I do not," I answered, and then laid out why this was not the moment to meet, let alone to relax the economic sanctions, let alone to extend the \$5-15 billion credit line France had proposed and Mnuchin had been negotiating with Le Maire. I said that once we took the pressure off Iran, it would be very hard to put it back on...Kushner said he would have the meeting because there was nothing to lose. These people had an attention span no longer than the deal in front of them. (Ibid, pp. 377-381)

everything would rest with Bolton, Pompeo and other hawks around Trump, as it was the case with President Putin and our Moscow initiative.

The Moscow initiative took place in summer 2020. After Iran and the U.S. successfully exchanged prisoners without direct talks, the idea was raised in Tehran for U.S. return to the JCPOA without any direct negotiations. Given President Putin's ties with President Trump, it was decided to pursue this avenue with the Russian president. Following a telephone conversation between President Rouhani and President Putin, I travelled to Moscow on 21 July 2020 to discuss details of the project with President Putin. The Covid-19 protocol for meeting with President Putin required a two-week quarantine, which was impossible for us. Therefore, Sergey Lavrov and I agreed that I would talk to President Putin in Moscow through a secure internal phone link. In a fifty-minute three-way conversation with President Putin and Minister Lavrov, we reached an agreement on a new proposal which presented a new approach to provide a face-saving exit for Trump from a self-imposed challenge. Within the framework of this proposal, Iran and the U.S. would take reciprocal steps in autumn 2020. Both steps would be simultaneous pertaining to action by our two legislatures scheduled in the JCPOA for 2023: ratification of the Additional Protocol by Iran's parliament simultaneously with the full lifting of nuclear sanctions by U.S. Congress. In light of President Trump's clout with Congress, it would have been possible and entirely in Iran's interests. President Trump could also claim victory in having improved Obama-era JCPOA or preventing Iran from developing nuclear weapons for good. Meantime, Iran's would start talks with Persian Gulf littoral states under the Hormuz Peace Endeavor (HOPE). The three of us agreed that given President Trump's narcissism, this proposal would be appealing to him.

President Putin warmly welcomed this proposal. It was decided that he discusses the matter with President Trump. It was also agreed that President Putin proposes that instead of Secretary Pompeo, President Trump's son-in-law Jared Kushner finalize details with Minister Lavrov. Our research indicated that Kushner was more prepared than Pompeo for an agreement. This conclusion has been confirmed in Bolton's book. Based on Minister Lavrov's report, President Putin had told President

Trump on the phone that Kushner or Mnuchin should finalize the details with Lavrov. Mr. Trump had nominated Kushner. On 24 July, Kushner called Minister Lavrov but informed him that Secretary Pompeo was also listening in. Minister Lavrov had outlined Iran's proposal. Kushner had promised to review the matter, but Pompeo had immediately said Iran's proposal was a repeat of ideas that had been raised in Biarritz. This response showed that Secretary Pompeo had managed to intervene and impose his bellicose vision on President Trump and Kushner. After receiving Lavrov's message from the Russian ambassador, I immediately replied to him that Pompeo would block the deal. That exactly happened and the United States finally dismissed the proposal.

Therefore, the assertion by certain detractors that I had pinned my hopes on the presidency of Joe Biden, and we did not therefore engage with Trump is groundless and amounts only to political demagoguery. Although our perception of President Trump's conduct and his aides' view was well-grounded and fully researched, until Trump's last days in office, we did not give up on diplomatic efforts to find a solution. The most effective cause of the Trump Administration's repeated failures in reconstructing a security consensus against Iran was our diplomatic offensive, which gave a constructive and prudent image of Iran to Europe and other actor; an Iran seeking to break political deadlocks to find a bilateral and constructive solution versus a Trump-led America that is unstable, illogical and belligerent. This global perception was regrettably reversed both for Iran and the U.S. during Raisi and Biden administrations. However, after the tragic events of 2025 and early 2026, I have continued to blame myself for not risking the domestic fallout of even an unsuccessful meeting with Trump. Since his election to the second term, I have continuously advocated direct contact with him, albeit unsuccessfully.

Trump's Repeated Diplomatic Failures

Since autumn 2019, the U.S. State Department started expressing alarm over the imminent application of one key provision in Resolution 2231 on the termination of arms restrictions against Iran. As the deadline of October 2020 was approaching, Secretary Pompeo got further obsessed

with the matter. Massive efforts by senior officials at the State Department to block the application of this section of the resolution reached the point of setting a countdown on the website of the Department¹⁷⁸. The U.S. diplomatic mission at the UN on 22 June 2020 submitted a 37-paragraph draft resolution to the Security Council, covering all provisions of former resolutions including arms embargo and tough inspection regime. In parallel, the U.S. Administration and some of its allies sought to convince or compel fellow Security Council members, particularly their European allies, to present a draft resolution for the extension of arms restrictions. Word also spread that certain European JCPOA participants were inclined to help the U.S. in this regard¹⁷⁹.

My colleagues and I told JCPOA participants that any modification in the timeframes set forth in Resolution 2231 or any other step leading to that end result would amount to a fundamental breach and end of the JCPOA. Through our extensive diplomatic efforts, we prevented even the closest allies of the U.S. from becoming involved in this process. Following extensive consultations, the Trump Administration found that the 37-paragraph resolution would be voted down. To add insult to injury, U.S. allies refused to submit any alternative draft. Strong opposition from China and Russia to any draft resolution added to the U.S. frustration.

In a major concession, the U.S. mission proposed a simple four paragraph draft that would have only extended Resolution 2231's arms restrictions against Iran until the Council decides otherwise. This resolution was eventually put to vote and received only two votes in favor – the U.S. and the Dominican Republic. Eleven other Security Council members, including E3 nations, abstained. Russia and China voted against¹⁸⁰. The draft resolution fell far short of the nine positive votes required, even without the double negative votes by Russia and China.

¹⁷⁸ <https://twitter.com/SecPompeo/status/1163958192176545792>

<https://www.reuters.com/article/us-usa-iran-un-idUSKCN1VA253>

<https://www.armscontrol.org/act/2020-06/news/us-aims-extend-iran-embargo>

¹⁷⁹ <https://en.radiofarda.com/a/europe-looking-for-a-compromise-on-iran-arms-embargo-issue/30677378.html> https://ecfr.eu/article/commentary_how_europe_can_avert_a_clash_over_the_iran_arms_embargo/

¹⁸⁰ S/2020/837

Before the JCPOA, Russia and China had voted in favor of all Security Council resolutions against Iran. But thanks to our effective diplomacy, they did not even abstain; rather they voted against, even when no veto was required due to the U.S. failure to receive the necessary 9 votes. That openly indicates the absurdity of accusation against the Rouhani administration that we abandoned Russia and China, pinning our hopes on the West. This vote was an indication of my colleagues' unprecedented achievement in strengthening ties with China and Russia to a strategic level.

In the wake of the humiliating failure of the United States in extending arms restrictions, the Trump Administration embarked on fresh efforts to invoke the so-called snapback mechanism and reinstate terminated Security Council resolutions. Several months earlier, in the winter of 2020, the U.S. State Department's Legal Advisor had produced a pseudo-legal analysis purporting to Washington's right to trigger this mechanism.

We embarked on extensive diplomatic and legal efforts to block this dubious effort by the U.S. On the anniversary of the U.S.'s JCPOA withdrawal, May 9, 2020, I sent a letter to the UN Secretary General, refuting the exploitation of this mechanism by the United States and providing legal arguments supported by irrefutable documents about the repeated violations of international law and the UN Charter by the United States¹⁸¹. Furthermore, in a speech at the virtual meeting of the UN Security Council on 30 June 2020 (Non-Proliferation: implementation of Security Council resolution 2231 (2015)), I offered Iran's irrefutable arguments against the unjustifiable abuse of the mechanism by the United States¹⁸².

Prior to the imminent notification by Secretary Pompeo for reinstating sanctions pursuant to paragraph 11 of Resolution 2231, I wrote a rebuttal to the President of the Security Council on 20 August 2020. As predicted, the U.S. Secretary of State sent a letter on the same day to the Security Council to invoke the dispute resolution mechanism for restoring Security Council resolutions that had been terminated under the JCPOA¹⁸³. The letter claimed that Iran had committed significant non-performance of its JCPOA obligations and therefore the U.S., as a JCPOA participant

¹⁸¹ A/74/850 & S/2020/380

¹⁸² S/2020/644, Annex XVI

¹⁸³ S/2020/815

under paragraph 10 of UNSCR 2231, was triggering the process provided in paragraphs 11 and 12 of Resolution 2231 for reinstating the provisions that been terminated pursuant to paragraph 7.

In reaction, all Security Council member states, except for the Dominican Republic, sent letters to the President of the Security Council, dismissing U.S. notification. Four African members of the Security Council – Niger, Tunisia, South Africa and Saint Vincent – signed a joint letter, dismissing U.S. invocation of the mechanism. The E3, China, Russia, Belgium, Estonia, Indonesia and Vietnam also rejected U.S. notification in separate letters. In the end, the President of the Security Council declared in a letter that in light of the views of Council members, he could not take any step in the case¹⁸⁴.

However, upon U.S. insistence, the UN Secretary General expressed doubt about the consequences of U.S. action, and the UN Secretariat voiced readiness to revive the Sanctions Committee and other sanction mechanisms subject to a Security Council decision¹⁸⁵. But the Security Council ignored his dubious letter. For my part, in a letter on 5 October 2020 addressed to the UN Secretary General, I rejected his insinuation.

After U.S. failure to restore previous resolutions and as UN Security Council member states did not respond to the Secretary General's unprincipled action, the U.S. sought once more to go through the Fifth Committee of the General Assembly (also known as the Administrative and Budgetary Committee)¹⁸⁶ to restore budget for the Sanctions Committee and Sanctions expert group and clear the way for restoring the sanction mechanism that had been terminated under Resolution 2231. This time too, the U.S. proposal was rejected with 110 votes against and only 10 votes in favor.

Therefore, owing to our effective diplomacy, over the span of two months, the JCPOA managed to inflict three humiliating defeats on the U.S. at the Security Council and the General Assembly; first with 2 votes

¹⁸⁴ <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-53912771>

¹⁸⁵ S/2020/921

¹⁸⁶ Since the US contributes nearly one-fourth of the UN budget, it enjoys a remarkable standing in the Fifth Committee that deals with administrative and budgetary matters, and no decision is made there without US consent. The US's attempt in this committee for action against Iran was based on its undisputed superiority there. Therefore, the US failure takes on added significance.

against, 2 votes in favor and 11 abstentions; second with 13 members against and only one in favor; and third, with 110 votes against and only 10 votes in favor. It is important to note that all of these victories for Iran were scored several months after Iran had suspended the implementation of any of its commitments in remedial measures under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA.

The Fallacy of “Snapback”

It may be useful here to address the issue of the purported restoration of the terminated Security Council resolution which was dubbed as “snapback” by the United States for self-serving domestic reasons and was widely used to refer to what is properly called the “Dispute Resolution Mechanism” in the JCPOA and Security Council Resolution 2231. During JCPOA negotiations, Western parties used the term “snapback” to imply automatic restoration of resolutions. As shown in the preceding pages, the fallacy of this contention was proven by the rejection of Pompeo’s notification, showing that the process was neither automatic nor immediate. Furthermore, as I repeatedly emphasized, neither the JCPOA nor Resolution 2231 uses the word “snapback”; the term remains a Western propaganda device, repeated even in Iran for shortsighted domestic purposes by our detractors, without noting that it is detrimental to Iranian national interest. In reality, through persistent efforts by my colleagues and I in the course of JCPOA negotiations, this term which existed in the preliminary drafts of the JCPOA and the resolution was replaced by “Dispute Resolution Mechanism” and never used in official documents¹⁸⁷.

Although we have discussed this issue in various sections of this book, it may be useful to address it in one single section for the sake of clarity at the risk of repetition. Mutual mistrust was predominant during the JCPOA, not just between Iran and E3/EU+3 or even between the West and Russia and China, but in fact among Western countries themselves. Some episodes were displayed publicly while many remained buried in behind-the-scenes rivalry among allies. The most widely seen public

¹⁸⁷ The Untold Story, Vol. 4, Annex 10, pp. 418–431

episodes were displayed early on in Geneva after the French learned about secret agreement between Iran and the United States to the point that Laurent Fabius publicly called the draft “a sucker’s deal”¹⁸⁸. More serious conflicts of interest between Western powers would emerge during bilateral private meetings when each would push for their own economic gains at the expense of their allies. In one interesting discussion about the very subject of the so-called “snapback”, the Americans clearly stated that they were more concerned about the French not going along with them than even the Russians.

In such circumstances of wide-spread mutual distrust between the parties in multilateral agreements, the remedy is usually confidence building through step-by-step reciprocal implementation of the agreement, starting with less controversial issues and building confidence for reciprocal taking of more challenging steps. The theories of neo-functionalism in international relations are rooted in efforts to address this challenge.

Since 2003, when we first started nuclear negotiations with E3/EU, our proposals were based on reciprocal step-by-step approach. The package that I presented on 23 March 2005 to E3/EU was also based on this approach.¹⁸⁹ Later, during the latter parts of negotiations during the Ahmadinejad administration, Russia proposed the same approach in one of Astana rounds. Even the solution that I proposed to President-Elect Rouhani before accepting the responsibility of the foreign ministry was based on the same approach.¹⁹⁰ The interim agreement known as the Joint Program of Action (JPOA) adopted in Geneva in November 2013 also had a phased setting. The novelty of JPOA was that we agreed on the final outcome as well as the initial step in rather concrete detail, leaving the rest for negotiations on the comprehensive solution following the successful implementation of the first step.

This comprehensive solution would involve a reciprocal, step-by-step process, and would produce the comprehensive lifting of all UN Security Council sanctions, as well as multilateral and

¹⁸⁸ <https://www.reuters.com/article/us-iran-nuclear-fabius/france-says-no-certainty-iran-talks-will-succeed>

¹⁸⁹ The Untold Story, Vol 1, p. 497

¹⁹⁰ Ibid, p. 529

national sanctions related to Iran's nuclear program. There would be additional steps in between the initial measures and the final step, including, among other things, addressing the UN Security Council resolutions, with a view toward bringing to a satisfactory conclusion the UN Security Councils consideration of this matter. The E33+ and Iran will be responsible for conclusion and implementation of mutual near-term measures and the comprehensive solution in good faith.

The initial proposal that I presented at the start of comprehensive talks in Vienna was based on this framework¹⁹¹. However, as we proceeded with the implementation of the provisions of JPOA, the Iranian authorities witnessed a major caveat primarily due to the U.S. "addiction to sanctions" which had created a spider's web of sanctions that would have made step-by-step reciprocal implementation detrimental to Iranian interest. We observed that Iranian steps were to a large extent independent of one another and each step that Iran would take will become an important gain for the other side. However, American steps were inter-related and without all, Iran's benefit would be minimal. We observed during the January-May 2014 period that although some restrictions on the sale of oil and repatriation of its proceeds had been lifted, the remaining restrictions on shipping, insurance, financial transactions and the likes made Iranian benefits minimal.

Based on this unpleasant experience, we were compelled – against everything that I had studied and prepared for in the preceding 30 odd years – to present a comprehensive package to be implemented at once. This was done in a meeting with Cathy Ashton in Istanbul in May 2014¹⁹². With the atmosphere of mistrust that had been exacerbated rather than reduced after the initial JPOA implementation – particularly in Iran due to U.S. sanction-web complications, we had to forge a distant second-best alternative to address the mistrust. Based on the suggestion from a very senior and experienced Iranian politician, who was sympathetic to

¹⁹¹ Ibid, Volume 2, p. 407.

¹⁹² Ibid, p. 443.

the negotiations, we proposed the idea of reversibility, and the E3/EU+3 reluctantly accepted it in the Spring 2014. In a nutshell, it meant that as a last resort and if everything else failed, all sides (Primarily Iran and the Western countries) could go back lawfully and without breaking the JCPOA, to their pre-JCPOA status in case of significant non-performance by Iran or E3/EU+3.

Having reluctantly accepted the general concept, we all started working on the details and more importantly on the language with a view to making (a) non-compliance costly for all and (b) putting in place a mechanism to prevent baseless, arbitrary and instantaneous remedial/retaliatory measures. One of the reasons the word “snapback” was removed in the course of negotiations was exactly to preclude this eventuality as connotations of the word implied automaticity. Despite baseless statement that this was done at the last minutes, or between Kerry and me, this was a collective process, involving all, but most actively Russia and France – obviously in addition to Iran and the U.S. – spanning from May 2014 to April 2015.

The reason for the active role of Russia and France in the process was their exclusive focus on preserving their veto privileges in the Security Council in the whatever mechanism that was agreed. The main reason explaining the joint draft by Russia and France on the so-called “snapback” provision was their shared obsession with their veto privilege. This episode, in addition to its significance for the JCPOA negotiations, is particularly important from the perspective of global power transitions which I have addressed elsewhere in this book and in my other publications.¹⁹³ Among the five permanent members of the Security Council, only two – China and the United States – have capabilities outside the Council that match their unique veto privilege inside. While U.K. focuses primarily on its special relations with the U.S., France and Russia face a significance disparity between their role as permanent members inside the Council with their role as not-so-great powers outside. As mentioned earlier, for Russia, strategic stability – meaning mutually assured destruction – and

¹⁹³ J. Zarif and S. Karimi, “A World in Transition: Rethinking the Current Global Order” *China Quarterly of International Strategic Studies*, Vol. 9, No. 1, 1–29.

veto privilege in the Security Council are the two main advantages that distinguish it from others. France is even in a more difficult situation, trying to balance its lost power position with the EU, promoting European strategic autonomy and aforesaid attempt to be “in the focus”.

The easier part of the negotiations was about the rather lengthy and cumbersome procedure within the JCPOA between the invocation of dispute resolution mechanism by a complaining participant and the time it can start taking remedial measures. This process is explained in paragraph 36 of the JCPOA.

36. If Iran believed that any or all of the E3/EU+3 were not meeting their commitments under this JCPOA, Iran could refer the issue to the Joint Commission for resolution; similarly, if any of the E3/EU+3 believed that Iran was not meeting its commitments under this JCPOA, any of the E3/EU+3 could do the same. The Joint Commission would have 15 days to resolve the issue, unless the time period was extended by consensus. After Joint Commission consideration, any participant could refer the issue to Ministers of Foreign Affairs, if it believed the compliance issue had not been resolved. Ministers would have 15 days to resolve the issue, unless the time period was extended by consensus. After Joint Commission consideration – in parallel with (or in lieu of) review at the Ministerial level – either the complaining participant or the participant whose performance is in question could request that the issue be considered by an Advisory Board, which would consist of three members (one each appointed by the participants in the dispute and a third independent member). The Advisory Board should provide a non-binding opinion on the compliance issue within 15 days. If, after this 30-day process the issue is not resolved, the Joint Commission would consider the opinion of the Advisory Board for no more than 5 days in order to resolve the issue. If the issue still has not been resolved to the satisfaction of the complaining participant, and if the complaining participant deems the issue to constitute significant non-performance, then that participant could treat the unresolved issue as grounds to cease performing its commitments under this JCPOA in whole or

in part and/or notify the UN Security Council that it believes the issue constitutes significant non-performance.

The non-binding arbitration mechanism mentioned in this paragraph was initially proposed as a binding mechanism. However, all members of the E3/EU+3 – most vehemently the United States – opposed binding arbitration on the grounds that they would not subject their sovereign decision to any third party. The Iranian leadership also disfavored binding arbitration due to their understandable pessimism about the nature of international relations and the ability of major powers to pressure the independent member of the panel. Thus, we settled for non-binding arbitration panel.

Paragraph 36 dealt with only half of the problem; that is reversibility of Iranian nuclear program and bilateral, extra-territorial and multilateral sanctions imposed by EU and U.S. The first Trump administration tried for 14 months and failed to create any presentable grounds to invoke paragraph 36 – as explained in the preceding sections¹⁹⁴ – and resorted to unlawful unilateral withdrawal from the JCPOA in May 2018 – 15 months after assuming office. On the other hand, Iran used the procedure lawfully and meticulously and started remedial measures on May 8, 2019. Although the span of one year (May 2018–May 2019) was not required under paragraph 36, Iran proceeded with caution in order to deprive the U.S. and Israel from any pretext to re-securitize Iran. By January 2020, Iran had officially informed the JCPOA Coordinator that as a remedial measure, pending the return of Western parties to compliance, it had suspended observance of any nuclear limit set in the JCPOA.

But another important aspect was the United Nations Security Council resolutions. As I have pointed out elsewhere in this book as well as in my confirmation speech before the Iranian Majlis, my priority objective in the negotiations – which may have not been shared by all in the Iranian leadership – was to break the global security consensus against Iran. The most prominent globally recognized indication of Iran's securitization was the Security Council resolutions adopted against it under Chapter

¹⁹⁴ Including the visit of Nikki Hailey to Vienna to force IAEA to find Iran in non-compliance

VII of the Charter – Threats to the peace, breaches of the peace and acts of aggression. Ironically the primary agent and agitator in the two-decade long project of securitizing Iran was Israel with an illegal nuclear weapons program and a volume of Security Council resolutions about its mischiefs.

In order to break the cycle and de-securitize Iran, those Security Council resolutions had to be terminated. We insisted on this from the very beginning and faced resistance from every member of the Security Council. As stated before, even my old friend Sergey Lavrov believed that this demand was unrealistic, suggesting that we should instead agree to suspension and leave termination for the end of the process, putting a condition that would have almost been impossible to meet. Obviously, in addition to Russia's reliance on its permanent membership in the Council as a primary source of power, it would not be strange for Russia to want to have Iran in a situation of indefinite need for Russian assistance in the Council.

Against all odds, we succeeded in terminating all previous resolutions in operative paragraph 7 of Security Council resolution 2231:

Decides, acting under Article 41
of the Charter of the United Nations,
that, upon receipt by the Security Council of the report
from the IAEA described in paragraph 5:
(a) The provisions of resolutions 1696 (2006), 1737 (2006),
1747 (2007), 1803 (2008), 1835 (2008), 1929 (2010) and 2224 (2015) shall
be terminated;

Unlike the process of reversing national measures which after the exhaustion of procedures set out in paragraph 36, at the end of the day rested on the sovereign decision of each JCPOA participants, restoring terminated Security Council resolutions required a decision by the Council. In other words, for Iran to take remedial measures, it did not need to seek approval by the Security Council. That is why at the end of paragraph 36, referring the case to the Security Council is an option (the phrase and/or) and not a requirement. It only pertains to situations where JCPOA participants – obviously other than Iran – after exhausting procedures of

paragraph 36, are not satisfied with the dispute resolution outcome and wish to restore terminated Security Council resolutions.

The United States was concerned that the resolution on restoration of terminated resolutions could have been vetoed by another permanent member – including but from American point of view not limited to Russia and China. Other permanent members – particularly Russia and France – were concerned over their veto privileges – using the euphemism of “erosion of Security Council authority” instead.

This was probably one of the most difficult issues involving competing and even rival interest of all participants. Iran and the United States had agreed to a wording that would have addressed the concerns of the two countries. But apparently Russia and France were concerned that it “eroded the authority of the Council,” and we had to re-start negotiating about this provision in Lausanne March 2015. Eventually and after many ups and downs and sleepless nights, the struggle culminated in a very complex procedure in paragraph 37 of the JCPOA and paragraphs 1013- of UNSCR 2231, enabling in practice a permanent member to veto the validity of terminations under resolution 2231 for a period of 10 years which ended in October 2025. The language of these paragraphs is so complicated and technical that among the E3/EU+3 ministers and senior officials, only Sergey Lavrov who was a UN veteran could have drafted it. Wendy Sherman credits him for this assistance to the U.S. objective. Obviously, Lavrov’s utmost concern and objective was to preserve the Russian veto privilege which he achieved, but at the same time helped the United States.

It should be noted that invoking paragraph 37 requires the prior exhaustion of the procedures of paragraph 36, which end with this sentence:

If the issue still has not been resolved to the satisfaction of the complaining participant, and if the complaining participant deems the issue to constitute significant non-performance, then that participant could treat the unresolved issue as grounds to cease performing its commitments under this JCPOA in whole or in part and/or notify the UN Security Council that it believes the issue constitutes significant non-performance.

This important provision was never implemented by the U.S. in 2020 or the E3 in 2025. Hence, the purported “snapback” of the E3 in 2025 is as unlawful and without any legal effect as was the attempt by the U.S. in 2020. While the EU agreed with Iran in 2020, it had changed sides in 2025 and reversed its own logic by purporting to use snapback after trying to resolve the issue not through the dispute resolution mechanism of paragraph 36, but through supporting Israel and American aggression against Iran in June 2025, which was praised by German Chancellor Merz as “Israel doing dirty work for us”¹⁹⁵.

In what I wrote in my last letter as Iran’s foreign minister to UN Secretary-General Guterres on the sixth anniversary of UNSCR 2231 on 20 July 2021 – and was partially reiterated by foreign minister Araghchi in July 2025 – remains a strong rebuttal of the purported snapback by the E3 in September 2025.

UN Security Council Resolution 2231 also emphasizes “that the JCPOA is conducive to promoting and facilitating the development of normal economic and trade contacts and cooperation with Iran...”¹⁹⁶ and that Member States must “give due regard to the termination” of sanctions. The JCPOA participants have underlined that “the lifting of sanctions, including the economic dividends arising from it, constitutes an essential part of the JCPOA.”¹⁹⁷

However, the United States—aided and abetted by its European accomplices—never implemented these and many other provisions of Resolution 2231 and the JCPOA in good faith. The western JCPOA participants continued to use economic pressure to achieve those illegitimate political objectives that they had failed to achieve in the course of the long and tedious JCPOA negotiations: the same objectives that they had finally agreed to address and dispose of in a way that was not fully satisfactory to any of the JCPOA participants, including—and especially—Iran. Indeed, Iran clearly stated its positions in the Security Council meeting on 20

¹⁹⁵ <https://www.dw.com/en/germanys-merz-says-israel-doing-dirty-work-for-us-in-iran/live-72939104>

¹⁹⁶ Preambular Paragraph 13 of UNSCR 2231(2015)

¹⁹⁷ Paragraph 6 of Statement of the JCPOA Joint Commission held at ministerial level on 6 July 2018, (See Annex 5).

July 2015¹⁹⁸ and immediately after the adoption of the Resolution¹⁹⁹. However, it fulfilled all its JCPOA commitments in good faith, verified by numerous IAEA reports²⁰⁰—even 15 months after the U.S. unlawful withdrawal²⁰¹.

The U.S. and E3 have been transparent about their transgressions and have repeatedly stated their ill-intention to compel Iran to renegotiate those provisions through economic pressure and blackmail. Such intentions—which in and of themselves constitute a grave violation of Paragraphs 28 and 29 of the JCPOA²⁰² were uttered privately and even publicly after the “Implementation Day”²⁰³, and repeated by former U.S. president Trump²⁰⁴ and regrettably the E3²⁰⁵

¹⁹⁸ S/PV.7488

¹⁹⁹ See Annex 1, Statement of the Islamic Republic of Iran following the adoption of United Nations Security Council resolution 2231 (2015) endorsing the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action, 20 July 2015 (S/2015/550)

²⁰⁰ See 10 IAEA Reports before U.S withdrawal: GOV/INF/2016/1 of 16 January 2016; GOV/2016/8 of 26 February 2016; GOV/2016/23 of 27 May 2016; GOV/2016/46 of 8 September 2016; GOV/2016/55 of 9 November 2016; GOV/2017/10 of 24 February 2017; GOV/2017/24 of 2 June 2017; GOV/2017/35 of 31 August 2017; GOV/2017/48 of 13 November 2017; GOV/2018/7 of 22 February 2018.

²⁰¹ See 5 IAEA Reports after US withdrawal: GOV/2018/24 of 24 May 2018; GOV/2018/33 of 30 August 2018; GOV/2018/47 of 12 November 2018; GOV/2019/10 of 22 February 2019; and GOV/2019/21 of 31 May 2019.

²⁰² “28. The E3/EU+3 and Iran commit to implement this JCPOA in good faith and in a constructive atmosphere, based on mutual respect, and to refrain from any action inconsistent with the letter, spirit and intent of this JCPOA that would undermine its successful implementation. Senior Government officials of the E3/EU+3 and Iran will make every effort to support the successful implementation of this JCPOA including in their public statements. The E3/EU+3 will take all measures required to lift sanctions and will refrain from imposing exceptional or discriminatory regulatory and procedural requirements in lieu of the sanctions and restrictive measures covered by the JCPOA.”

“29. The EU and its Member States and the United States, consistent with their respective laws, will refrain from any policy specifically intended to directly and adversely affect the normalisation of trade and economic relations with Iran inconsistent with their commitments not to undermine the successful implementation of this JCPOA.”

²⁰³ In letter of 1 February 2018 (See Annex 2), Iran referred to this and clearly refuted the logic: “In contravention of the explicitly restricted scope of the JCPOA, attempts have been made to link the JCPOA to or condition the fulfilment of the obligations of other participants upon extraneous issues—deliberately excluded by the JCPOA participants from the deal. This includes Iran’s necessary and proportionate defensive missile program. Let me remind all JCPOA participants that the clearly stated objective of the JCPOA is to ensure that Iran’s nuclear program will remain exclusively peaceful, and as U.S. Under-Secretary Sherman testified before the US Senate on 3 December 2014 “if the peaceful nature of Iranian nuclear program was successfully assured then the question of delivery systems would become irrelevant.”

²⁰⁴ <https://trumpwhitehouse.archives.gov/briefings-statements/statement-president-iran-nuclear-deal/>

²⁰⁵ “Conscious of the importance of collective efforts to guarantee regional stability and security, we reiterate our conviction that the time has come for Iran to accept negotiation on a long-term framework for its nuclear programme as well as on issues related to regional security, including its missiles programme and other means

since 2017. The Biden administration—again, aided and abetted by the E3, has since its inauguration in January 2021 continued Trump’s economic terrorism against Iranians as supposed “leverage” to achieve the same objectives.

The U.S. and E3 illusion that there can ever be a renegotiation of the timetable enshrined in the JCPOA and Resolution 2231 represents utter bad faith. The timetable for termination of voluntary restrictions accepted by Iran in the JCPOA—maliciously called “JCPOA sunset clauses,” in order to evoke fear—were the subject of the longest and most difficult negotiating process—which began from the very first day of the Muscat discussions in August 2012, and continued until the evening of July 13, 2015. Agreement on the current timetable required great flexibility and compromise on the part of the Islamic Republic of Iran, and huge sacrifices by Iran on other significant issues.

Obviously, no one was fully satisfied with the agreed timetable—certainly not Iran, which rightly believed that there was no reason for any restriction on its nuclear program, because in its view, the so-called nuclear crisis had been artificially manufactured from the start. Iran moved from zero limitations to the current time-bound restrictions, and the U.S. and E3 in return abandoned their desire for longer timeframes. However, after Trump withdrew from the deal, the U.S. and E3 believed that they could reap the fruits of their poisonous tree and resume their old habit of “what’s mine is mine and what’s yours is negotiable.”

It should not be forgotten today that to show the pivotal importance of the agreed timeframe, the Resolution in its first operative paragraph “Endorses the JCPOA, and urges its full implementation on the timetable established in the JCPOA.” Thus, the timetable—or the so-called “sunset clauses”—is an inseparable, non-negotiable component of the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231. Thus, any attempt to

of delivery.” <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/joint-statement-by-the-heads-of-state-and-government-of-france-germany-and-the-united-kingdom>;

See also para 52 in http://www.g8.utoronto.ca/foreign/g7_-_foreign_ministers_communique.pdf

extort an extension of the agreed timetable undermines both the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231 in their entirety.

Moreover, the bargains made in Resolution 2231 and its two annexes were in total cognizance of Iran's disagreement—frequently supported by Russia and China—with the western members of the E3+ over certain issues, including Iran's defense capabilities and western malign behavior in West Asia, and particularly the Persian Gulf region. While the E3 and U.S. were not prepared to—or probably even capable of—addressing Iran's grave concerns over the unfathomable level of their arms sales²⁰⁶ and malign behavior and constant interventions in Iran's own neighborhood, which have left our region in ruins²⁰⁷, Iran was still compelled to pay a hefty price in Paragraphs 2, 3, 4 and 5 of Annex B of UNSCR 2231. As Iran and the EU/E3+ had agreed in the preliminary JPOA—reached on 23 November 2013 in Geneva—to address previous Security Council resolutions in the final accord (JCPOA)²⁰⁸, what is reflected in Annex B of UNSCR 2231—despite Iran's objection—concludes those issues as having been addressed.

Illegitimate as they are, these three areas of extortion have been the primary cause of perpetual significant non-performance of the JCPOA in various forms during the past (almost) 6 years; primarily by the United States, but also by the EU/E3, resulting in irreparable harm to the Iranian people who have been wrongfully deprived of the economic benefits that they were entitled to. This practice has been fully documented in numerous official letters to the JCPOA Joint Commission Coordinator—mostly under JCPOA Dispute

²⁰⁶ After the deal, the U.S. seemed to be convinced of the logic of the deal. Secretary Kerry pointed out in a meeting at the Council on Foreign Relations on 24 July 2015: "The [Persian] Gulf States currently spend about \$130 billion a year on their military. Saudi Arabia spends 80 billion (dollars). Iran spends 15 billion (dollars). So, you've got to think about, so, what's going on out there? What's going on is that a lot of these countries have fancy toys—F-16s and missiles and different, you know, missile defense—but they don't have enough people on the ground who are prepared to fight, prepared to stand up and take the fight to the bad guys" (<https://www.cfr.org/event/assessing-iran-nuclear-accord>).

²⁰⁷ See Annex 14.

²⁰⁸ The Preamble of JPOA states: "There would be additional steps in between the initial measures and the final step, including, among other things, addressing the UN Security Council resolutions, with a view toward bringing to a satisfactory conclusion the UN Security Council's consideration of this matter."

Resolution Mechanism—and the UN Secretary-General. The blatant disregard of the United States for its JCPOA obligations began with a minimalist and lackluster implementation of the JCPOA during the Obama administration²⁰⁹, continued with blatant hostility and a campaign to destroy the JCPOA during the first year of the Trump administration²¹⁰, further exacerbated by its withdrawal from the JCPOA²¹¹, its “maximum pressure” policy—indeed what is economic terrorism²¹² and medical terrorism²¹³—and punishment of those complying with UNSCR 2231 in the remaining three years of the administration²¹⁴, and extended by the Biden administration’s

²⁰⁹ See Annex 2. Letter of 2 September 2016 to JCPOA Coordinator on U.S. not issuing license for the sale or lease of passenger aircrafts, hindering Iran’s free access to its assets abroad, obstructing reengagement of the non-American banking and financial community with Iran, re-introduction of certain sanctions under Executive Order 13645 and failure of U.S. President to use his constitutional authority to prevent “the US Visa Waiver Program Improvement and Terrorist Travel Prevention Act of 2015 as well as EU/E3 serious failures and unconstructive attitude in the UNSC; Letter of 17 November 2016 to the JCPOA Coordinator on “Iran Sanctions Extension Act”, and lackluster implementation of JCPOA by especially with regard to banking and financial services as well as harassment of Iran’s business partners; and Letter of 16 December 2016 to JCPOA Coordinator on US significant breach of its obligations by the extension of “Iran Sanctions Act” on 14 December 2016. These non-compliance instances were also reported by the UN Secretary General and reflected in his report to the Security Council (See: S/2016/589 dated 12 July 2016).

²¹⁰ See Annex 3. Letters on significant non-performance by the Trump Administration Before U.S. Withdrawal: Letter of 28 March 2017 to the JCPOA Coordinator on open hostility of Trump administration towards JCPOA and malicious prevention of normalization of trade with Iran; Letter of 28 May 2017 to the JCPOA Coordinator on U.S. policy of reversing Iran’s benefits from JCPOA even when it purported to comply by renewing the required waivers; Letter of 19 July 2017 to the JCPOA Coordinator on United States’ systematic policy of dissuading Iran’s economic partners from engaging with Iran and President Trump pressure on world leaders to stop doing business with Iran; Letter of 13 August 2017 to the JCPOA Coordinator on U.S. allegation of non-compliance by Iran in spite of repeated verifications by the IAEA; Letter of 19 August 2017 to JCPOA Coordinator and IAEA Director General on U.S. efforts to affect the professional work of the IAEA; Letter of 18 September 2017 to JCPOA Coordinator on U.S. manufacturing of fabricated excuses to get out of the JCPOA; Letter of 16 October 2017 to JCPOA Coordinator on unlawful decertification within a U.S. domestic procedure on 13 October 2017; Letter of 1 February 2018 to JCPOA Coordinator, objecting to the ultimatum by President Trump on 12 January 2018, demanding other JCPOA participants to follow him in unlawfully altering the terms of the agreement

²¹¹ See Annex 4. Letters on U.S. Withdrawal: Letter dated 10 May 2018 to JCPOA Coordinator under Paragraph 36 of JCPOA on measures that need to be taken through the Joint Commission to address the wrongful acts by the United States against Iran and international law, including its unlawful withdrawal from the accord and the re-imposition of sanctions; Letter of 10 May 2018 to the Secretary-General of the United Nations on unlawful U.S. withdrawal and history of U.S. non-performance and E3 failures (A/72/869-S/2018/453)

²¹² Terrorism= the unlawful use of violence and intimidation, especially against civilians, in the pursuit of political aims.

²¹³ See Annex 10 Letter of 12 March 2020 to UN Secretary-General on U.S. unlawful prevention of Iranian access to medicine and supplies to deal with COVID-19.

²¹⁴ See Annex 6. Letters under paragraph 36 to register multiple cases of significant non-performance by U.S. and EU/E3: Letter of 17 June 2018 to JCPOA Coordinator requesting the convening of a ministerial meeting

attempt to use Trump's crimes against humanity²¹⁵ as bargaining "leverage" for their illegitimate objectives outside of the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231 (2015)²¹⁶.

The EU/E3 for their part remained politically committed to the JCPOA and initially took a measured and mild diplomatic stance against the unlawful U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA and its re-imposition of sanctions. However, as it became gradually clear to the EU/E3 that they were incapable of performing their own obligations under the JCPOA and commitments undertaken following the U.S.'s withdrawal at the highest level²¹⁷, they sought to conceal their multiple cases of significant non-performance²¹⁸ by calling

of the Joint Commission under Paragraph 36 procedures; Letter of 21 August 2018 to JCPOA Coordinator under Paragraph 36 on failure of EU/E3+2 to implement their commitments of 25 May and 6 July 2018; Letter of 6 November 2018 to JCPOA Coordinator on Iran's exhaustion of all DRM procedures and its initiation of remedial action under Paragraph 36; Letter of 7 April 2019 to JCPOA Coordinator under Paragraph 36 on EU/E3 significant non-performance emanating from G7 Foreign Ministers' Communiqué of 6 April 2019; Letter of 17 July 2019 to JCPOA Coordinator on cases of significant non-performance by EU/E3 under Paragraph 36; Letter of 3 October 2019 to JCPOA Coordinator on the joint statement of E3 leaders constituting a breach of JCPOA and UNSCR 2231; Letter of 18 June 2020 to JCPOA Coordinator on implications of U.S. decision to stop nuclear waivers; Letter of 2 July 2020 to JCPOA Coordinator under Paragraph 36 on cases of significant non-performance by E3.

Also see Annex 9, Letter of 10 April 2019 to UN Secretary-General on the unlawful designation of IRGC by the United States and Annex 11, Letter of 8 May 2020 to UN Secretary-General on U.S. persistent violations of international law and UN Charter.

²¹⁵ According to Newsweek (<https://www.newsweek.com/mike-pompeo-says-iran-must-listen-us-if-they-want-their-people-eat-1208465>) "Mike Pompeo Says Iran Must Listen to U.S. 'If They Want Their People to Eat'". This amounts to public acknowledgment of a policy intentionally designed to deprive an entire population of food and medicine, with the intention of causing mass starvation to advance illegitimate political objectives; a textbook case of a "crime against humanity". Furthermore, the United States' sanctions and hostile conduct and policy also flagrantly breach the Order of the International Court of Justice, issued on 3 October 2018. (<https://www.icj-cij.org/public/files/case-related/175/175-20181003-ORD-01-00-EN.pdf>)

²¹⁶ See Annex 13, Letters on requirements for a possible U.S. return to JCPOA: Letter dated 12 March 2021 to the Coordinator of JCPOA Joint Commission on the pre-requisites for return of the United States to JCPOA; Letter dated 11 April 2021 to the Coordinator of JCPOA Joint Commission on the sanction-lifting obligations of the United States.

²¹⁷ See Annex 5, Commitments by EU/E3 and EU/E3+3 following U.S. withdrawal: Statement of the meeting between EU/E3 Minister with Minister of Foreign Affairs of the Islamic Republic of Iran (Brussels, 15 May 2018); Statement from the Joint Commission of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action 6 July 2018; Joint Ministerial Statement (24 September 2018).

²¹⁸ See Annex 6, particularly letters of 21 August 2018, 6 November 2018, 7 April 2019, 17 July 2019, 3 October 2019 and 2 July 2020 to JCPOA Coordinator.

for a “Trump deal,”²¹⁹ in clear violation of Paragraphs 28 and 29 of the JCPOA, and Operative Paragraph 2 of UNSCR 2231(2015)²²⁰.

Following the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA, the UN Secretary General²²¹, the remaining JCPOA participants²²² and many other members of the international community called on Iran to use the Dispute Resolution Mechanisms under the JCPOA and to allow the remaining JCPOA participants to rectify the negative consequences of the unlawful U.S. withdrawal. While expressly reserving its right to undertake immediate reciprocal action²²³ under Paragraph 26²²⁴, Iran officially initiated—for the third time²²⁵—the Dispute Resolution Mechanism under Paragraph

²¹⁹ “Boris Johnson: Replace Iran nuclear plan with ‘Trump deal’, says PM”, <https://www.bbc.com/news/uk-politics-51104386>. Also see Op. cit., <https://www.gov.uk/government/news/joint-statement-by-the-heads-of-state-and-government-of-france-germany-and-the-united-kingdom>.

²²⁰ “Calls upon all Members States, regional organizations and international organizations to take such actions as may be appropriate to support the implementation of the JCPOA, including by taking actions commensurate with the implementation plan set out in the JCPOA and this resolution and by refraining from actions that undermine implementation of commitments under the JCPOA”.

²²¹ “Statement by the Secretary-General on the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA)”, 08 May 2018. Available at: <https://www.un.org/sg/en/content/sg/statement/2018-05-08/statement-secretary-general-joint-comprehensive-plan-action-jcpoa>

²²² “Remarks by High Representative/Vice President Federica Mogherini on the Statement by U.S. President Trump Regarding the Iran Nuclear Deal (JCPOA)”, Rome, 8 May 2018.

²²³ See Annex 4, particularly letter of 10 May 2018 to the Coordinator of the JCPOA Joint Commission: “It is Iran’s unquestionable right—recognized also under the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231—to take appropriate action in response to persistent numerous unlawful acts by the U.S., particularly its withdrawal and re-imposition of all sanctions. However, as President Rouhani announced in his televised response on 8 May and further elaborated in the Statement of the Government on 10 May 2018, the Islamic Republic of Iran will decide its next step in the course of few weeks following consultations with the remaining JCPOA Participants to see if and how the commitments collectively undertaken by EU/E3+3 vis-a-vis Iran could be fulfilled in the absence of a reneging party by EU/E3+2. Nothing in this period would affect Iran’ right to react and protect its national interest as appropriate, a right which is manifestly recognized in the JCPOA and the UNSC resolution 2231(2015).”

²²⁴ Paragraph 26 of the JCPOA: “Iran has stated that it will treat such a re-introduction or re-imposition of the sanctions specified in Annex II, or such an imposition of new nuclear-related sanctions, as grounds to cease performing its commitments under this JCPOA in whole or in part.”

²²⁵ The first two instances of invoking paragraph 36 of the JCPOA were in the letter of 16 December 2016 (see Annex 2) and the letter of 1 February 2019 (see Annex 3).

36 of the JCPOA²²⁶ on 10 May 2018²²⁷. However, acting in good faith, Iran refrained from applying the ‘remedy’ foreseen in Paragraph 36 of the JCPOA in order to enable the remaining JCPOA participants to make good on their promises²²⁸. Unfortunately, instead of implementing their obligations under UNSCR 2231, and the JCPOA—in particular paragraph 3 of Annex II—and their commitments under the Statements made on 15 May, 6 July and 24 September 2018²²⁹, the private as well as public sectors of the EU/E3 engaged in over-compliance with the U.S.’ “maximum pressure” targeting all Iranians. Considering the economic prowess and size of the EU/E3, their utter impotence—even in operationalizing a minimalist

²²⁶ Paragraph 36 of the JCPOA: “If Iran believed that any or all of the E3/EU+3 were not meeting their commitments under this JCPOA, Iran could refer the issue to the Joint Commission for resolution; similarly, if any of the E3/EU+3 believed that Iran was not meeting its commitments under this JCPOA, any of the E3/EU+3 could do the same. The Joint Commission would have 15 days to resolve the issue, unless the time period was extended by consensus. After Joint Commission consideration, any participant could refer the issue to Ministers of Foreign Affairs, if it believed the compliance issue had not been resolved. Ministers would have 15 days to resolve the issue, unless the time period was extended by consensus. After Joint Commission consideration – in parallel with (or in lieu of) review at the Ministerial level - either the complaining participant or the participant whose performance is in question could request that the issue be considered by an Advisory Board, which would consist of three members (one each appointed by the participants in the dispute and a third independent member). The Advisory Board should provide a non-binding opinion on the compliance issue within 15 days. If, after this 30-day process the issue is not resolved, the Joint Commission would consider the opinion of the Advisory Board for no more than 5 days in order to resolve the issue. If the issue still has not been resolved to the satisfaction of the complaining participant, and if the complaining participant deems the issue to constitute significant non-performance, then that participant could treat the unresolved issue as grounds to cease performing its commitments under this JCPOA in whole or in part and/or notify the UN Security Council that it believes the issue constitutes significant non-performance.”

²²⁷ See Annex 4, particularly letter of 10 May 2018 to the Coordinator of the JCPOA Joint Commission.

²²⁸ IAEA Reports to the Security Council: S/2016/57 (19 January 2016), S/2016/250 (15 March 2016), S/2016/535 (13 June 2016), S/2016/808 (22 September 2016), S/2016/983 (21 November 2016), S/2017/234 (20 March 2017), S/2017/502 (14 June 2017), S/2017/777 (13 September 2017), S/2017/994 (28 November 2017), S/2018/205 (8 March 2018), S/2018/540 (6 June 2018), S/2018/835 (12 September 2018), S/2018/1048 (26 November 2018), S/2019/212 (6 March 2019), S/2019/496 (14 June 2019).

²²⁹ The EU/E3 unfulfilled commitments following U.S. withdrawal include: maintaining and deepening economic relations with Iran; the continued sale of Iran’s oil, gas, condensate, petroleum products and petrochemicals and related transfers; effective banking transactions with Iran; continued sea, land, air and rail transportation relations with Iran; the further provision of export credit and development of special purpose vehicles in financial, banking, insurance and trade areas with the aim of facilitating economic and financial cooperation, including by offering practical support for trade and investment; the further development and implementation of Memoranda of Understandings and contracts between European companies and Iranian counterparts; further investment in Iran; the protection of EU economic operators and ensuring legal certainty; the further development of a transparent, rules-based business environment in Iran”. See Statement of 15 May 2018 in Annex 5.

INSTEX for humanitarian trade indicate apparent complicity with the Trump administration to extort concessions from Iran through inhuman economic pressure, even amid a worldwide pandemic.

Following the abject failure of the EU/E3 to implement even one of their eleven commitments following the U.S. withdrawal, coupled with the significant non-performance of their own JCPOA obligations, Iran on 6 November 2018 put the Coordinator and the remaining JCPOA participants on notice that it will no longer postpone taking remedial action under Paragraph 36 of the JCPOA.²³⁰ No action was taken by the EU/E3 and none of the European JCPOA Participants even bothered to write a rebuttal for another 6 months. Having repeatedly exhausted the Dispute Resolution Mechanism to absolutely no avail, the Islamic Republic of Iran was left with no recourse but to exercise its rights under Paragraphs 26 and 36 of the JCPOA and to apply remedial action and cease performing its commitments in part on 8 May 2019. Iran duly informed the Coordinator of the Joint Commission that its “decision is fully consistent with the JCPOA and within the terms foreseen by it. We reaffirm our resolve to continue to support the JCPOA in good faith and in a constructive atmosphere. The Islamic Republic of Iran remains prepared to engage in good faith dialogue with the E3+2 at all levels, and to resume implementation of all the above provisions commensurate with the realization of the objectives set out in the JCPOA and commitments made by the Joint Commission since May 8, 2018.”²³¹

A review of the above-mentioned documents—reproduced in full in annexes to this letter—clearly illustrates that from the beginning of the process, the U.S. and EU/E3 kept Iran’s enjoyment of economic dividends and normalization of trade and economic relations, that it had been promised in the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231, contingent upon meeting extraneous demands that had already been settled in the JCPOA

²³⁰ See Letter of 6 November 2018 in Annex 6.

²³¹ Annex 7. Letters on Iran taking remedial measures: Letter of 8 May 2019 from President Rouhani to E3+2 leaders on the exhaustion of procedures under Paragraph 36 and beginning of remedial measures by Iran under Paragraph 36; Letter of 8 May 2019 to JCPOA Coordinator informing them of remedial measures by Iran following the exhaustion of procedures under Paragraph 36; Letter of 7 July 2019 to JCPOA Coordinator on Iran’s second remedial step under Paragraph 36; Letter of 5 September 2019 on third remedial step by Iran under Paragraph 36.

negotiations and addressed in Annex B of UNSCR 2231. Moreover, it can be readily ascertained from a review of the enclosed documents that the EU/E3—and regrettably the Coordinator of the Joint Commission—failed to address the complaints by Iran, even after the U.S.’s unlawful withdrawal, in a fair and objective manner.

Having considered the above factual background of nearly 6 years of JCPOA practice, one cannot but conclude that from legal, moral and practical points of view, the United States and the E3 have practically forfeited any reasonable and legitimate grounds for resorting to the mechanism foreseen in Paragraphs 36 and 37 of the JCPOA and operative Paragraphs 11 and 12 of the UNSCR 2231 concerning a possible reapplication of provisions of previous resolutions terminated under Paragraph 7(a) of UNSCR 2231. When the JCPOA was being negotiated, the parties agreed to the Dispute Resolution Mechanism in Paragraphs 36 and 37 of the JCPOA—which form the precondition for the activation of Paragraphs 11 and 12 of UNSCR 2231, a complicated and intentionally cumbersome procedure—as an avenue of last resort for ensuring mutual implementation of commitments under the JCPOA in an atmosphere of mutual distrust. This innovation was a method of ensuring compliance, and not a mechanism to protect non-performance by one-side wielding a threatening stick of recourse to Paragraphs 11 and 12, even when the injured party had previously invoked the same provisions of the JCPOA, and in good faith²³². This procedure most definitely was never intended to be utilized in an arbitrary manner; giving participants a *carte blanche* to unilaterally destroy a comprehensive solution carefully and painstakingly negotiated after years of a stalemate. The absurdity of this logic was shown in the circus created by then U.S. Secretary of State Pompeo in the autumn of 2020.²³³

²³² Annex 8. Letters on inadmissibility of E3 resort to Dispute Resolution Mechanism: Letter of 25 June 2019 to JCPOA Coordinator responding to the 21 June demarche of E3 ambassadors in Iran concerning Iran’s actions under Paragraph 36; Letter of 29 January 2020 to new JCPOA Coordinator, rejecting his letter of 14 January purporting to activation of DRM by E3 under Paragraph 36; Letter of 10 March 2020 to JCPOA Coordinator illustrating Iranian exhaustion of DRM procedures under Paragraph 36 and inadmissibility of E3 recourse to DRM.

²³³ Annex 12. Letters Rejecting U.S. Abuse of Security Council Process: Letter dated 20 August 2020 to the President of the Security Council on the inadmissibility of U.S. “notification”; Letter dated 4 October 2020 to the Secretary-General rejecting the abuse the processes of UN Security Council by the United States;

The International Court of Justice clearly established in its 1971 advisory opinion on Namibia that “one of the fundamental principles governing international relationships thus established is that a party which disowns or does not fulfil its own obligations cannot be recognized as retaining the rights which it claims to derive from the relationship.”²³⁴

In this context, the United States and the E3—with their history of disowning and/or not fulfilling their obligations under the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231—“cannot be recognized as retaining the rights which [they] claim to derive from” the two documents. The United Nations’ credibility rests on preventing a repeat of the abuse of a procedure that has become defunct for the E3 and the United States due to their own proven malice. This must remain so until they prove, with action, a good-faith commitment to respect all the terms of the JCPOA as initially agreed, ensure full economic benefits therefrom for Iran and its people, and compensate them for the immense losses they incurred.

Throughout the past six years the Islamic Republic of Iran has proven its commitment to the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action in deeds and not just words. My government and the people of Iran have made enormous sacrifices—almost single-handedly—to preserve the JCPOA in spite of U.S. contempt for it and EU/E3 complacency in the face of that contempt. As history has shown, the Iranian people have throughout the course of their millennia-old and glorious civilization triumphed over intimidation, coercion or extortion.²³⁵

Biden Election

The failure of Trump’s maximum pressure policy on the political and global arenas turned the necessity for U.S. return to the JCPOA into one of the key campaign issues in the U.S. presidential election. In summer 2020, an 80-page document indicating the Democratic Party Platform was released under the title of “Renewing American Leadership”, expressing the top priorities and main orientations of the Democratic Party on economic

²³⁴ Legal Consequences for States of the Continued Presence of South Africa in Namibia (South West Africa) notwithstanding Security Council Resolution 276 (1970), Advisory Opinion, I.C.J. Reports 1971, Para. 91.

²³⁵ A/75/968–S/2021/669

issues, domestic policy and foreign relations in case their nominee was elected president. In this document, Democrats pledged to steer clear of the Trump Administration's approach towards Iran and instead of war would embrace nuclear diplomacy, détente and regional dialogue. In this document, the JCPOA was described as best tool to prevent Iran from acquiring nuclear weapons, thereby laying emphasis on faster return to the JCPOA²³⁶. Before that, the Democratic Party's National Committee in a resolution on 20 February 2019 said the "United States should return to its obligations under the JCPOA and utilize multilateral and bilateral diplomacy to achieve political solutions to remaining challenges regarding Iran".

Democratic nominee Joe Biden and his aides in their statements had made the U.S. return to the JCPOA conditional on issues outside the agreement. Therefore, in a bid to strike a balance to the status of both countries and preclude any U.S. excessive demand in case Biden was elected, I pointed out in a virtual meeting at the Council on Foreign Relations on 21 September 2020 that it is Iran and not the U.S. that can set conditions for the U.S.'s return to the JCPOA. I said that Iran is insisting that the United States implement its commitments, compensate Iran for its losses, and give us guarantees that it won't repeat this behavior before we take any action²³⁷.

After Biden's election victory, the likelihood of U.S. returning to the JCPOA gathered steam. Many foreign policy experts in the U.S. believed that Biden would return to the JCPOA in the first days after inauguration²³⁸. American and regional opponents of the JCPOA, particularly Netanyahu, did their utmost to prevent Biden's return. In his final days in office, the Trump Administration took childish steps in a bid to block U.S. return to the JCPOA and lifting of sanctions²³⁹.

Netanyahu and other Israeli officials threatened unilateral action in case the U.S. returned to the JCPOA²⁴⁰. The assassination of Mohsen

²³⁶ <https://democrats.org/where-we-stand/party-platform/renewing-american-leadership/>

²³⁷ <https://www.cfr.org/event/conversation-foreign-minister-mohammad-javad-zarif-iran>

²³⁸ <https://responsiblestatecraft.org/2021/02/18/why-hasnt-biden-returned-to-the-iran-nuclear-deal/>

²³⁹ <https://www.nytimes.com/2020/11/17/world/middleeast/iran-biden-trump-nuclear-sanctions.html>

²⁴⁰ <https://www.reuters.com/article/uk-iran-nuclear-israel-usa-idUKKBN282ON6>

Fakhrizadeh on 27 November 2020 (only three weeks after Biden's election victory) was the first manifestation of Israel's approach to obstruct U.S. return²⁴¹ that continued with a series of guided terrorist operations, particularly at the Natanz enrichment plant on 10 April 2021, shortly after Vienna talks started²⁴².

Unfortunately, domestic reactions to the assassination of Fakhrizadeh consisted of attacks on the JCPOA instead of condemnation of Israel which was the biggest enemy of the deal. That campaign was suspicious or at least playing well into Israeli hands. Therefore, in my interviews with local media and even in message on my Instagram account, I warned against falling into this trap²⁴³.

But unfortunately, my warnings proved ineffective and the concerns of certain groups about the coming presidential elections prevailed. Thus, what should not have happened did. A piece of legislation by parliament made return to the JCPOA impossible permanently, unless a solution were to be found to circumvent the so-called "Strategic Measures Act".

²⁴¹ <https://foreignpolicy.com/2020/11/30/israel-biden-iran-policy-netanyahu>

²⁴² <https://www.bbc.com/news/world-middle-east-56724039>

<https://www.al-monitor.com/originals/2020/11/israel-iran-us-benjamin-netanyahu-joe-biden-ehud-barak.html>

²⁴³ Text inscription with the charts on my Instagram accounts: Dear Friends, I once again offer my condolences on the savage assassination of prominent nuclear scientist Dr. Mohsen Fakhrizadeh. Let me confide a significant point with you. As you have heard in the news, the founders and supporters of the bankrupt policy of maximum pressure against the brave nation of Iran are trying their best to benefit from the last days in office of the Trump Administration to trigger tensions and influence the atmosphere created for the lifting unjust sanctions. Pompeo's sudden visit to the region, trilateral meeting in Saudi Arabia and Netanyahu's statements entirely indicate a conspiracy that was activated on Friday in the cowardly act of terrorism against a senior official. But simultaneously with this act of terrorism, counterintelligence campaign and psychological warfare guided by this axis of evil started in the failed hope of completing the evil plan of Pompeo, Netanyahu and MBS for spreading tensions. In the first piece of news on the assassination of Dr. Fakhrizadeh in Persian-language media, it has been wrongly claimed that Mossad had found the name of this scientist through IAEA lists. Sheer lie. The name of Dr. Fakhrizadeh was given to the IAEA in mid-2000s by the US and Israel, which was placed on the Security Council sanctions list via Resolution 1747 (2007). Reviewing and analyzing keywords of some 10,000 tweets posted during the first hours of this assassination shows that nearly 79% of them were biased for the purpose of sowing discord internally (opposition to the JCPOA, cooperation with the IAEA and negotiations) and only the remaining 21% are directed against the instigators and perpetrators of this savage crime. More interestingly, nearly 93% of these tweets belong to unidentified and fake accounts created less than a year ago and mainly based overseas. However, Iran's officials and prudent people will never be tricked by this last endeavor of international terrorists and notorious belligerent and extremist Zionists, and they will preserve their solidarity and integrity for the purpose of finalizing achievements of their heroic resistance against economic warfare by Trump and his partners.

Coincidentally, Israel managed to dissuade Biden from returning to the JCPOA. Domestic reactions to the assassination of Dr. Fakhrizadeh, explosion in Natanz, stopping implementation of the Additional Protocol and start of uranium enrichment to 60% purity made the U.S. return more complicated. Efforts in both Iran and the U.S. to build leverage against one another further complicated the situation impeding U.S. return to JCPOA and gradually obliterated the agreement²⁴⁴.

With such background, contrary to all predictions, Biden refused to override his predecessor's Executive Order on withdrawal from the JCPOA although he returned to many international agreements from which Trump had pulled out²⁴⁵. But within one month, he withdrew Trump Administration's failed attempt to restore Security Council resolutions and reaffirmed his readiness to return to JCPOA obligations reciprocally and unconditionally²⁴⁶.

As soon as the U.S. decision for reciprocal return to the JCPOA became clear, the European JCPOA participants, prioritizing settlement of their four-year challenges with Trump-led U.S., forgot about the U.S. treatment of the JCPOA and joined the U.S. to ramp up pressure against Iran on the pretext of reduced cooperation between Iran and the IAEA and negative international climate following the election of the late president Raisi²⁴⁷.

In a bid to prevent the West from engaging in "blame game" and "reciprocal leveraging" in the JCPOA, in a letter dated 12 March 2021, I portrayed a realistic account of Iran's conditions and the proper way of U.S. return to the JCPOA²⁴⁸. In this letter, I reaffirmed Iran's compliance with the JCPOA and announced readiness for immediate return to obligations, precluding any pretext for pressure:

Iran will stop its remedial measures as soon as the causes of action clearly established in Iran's letters—inter alia—of 16 December 2016, 10 May 2018, 21 August 2018, 6 November 2018, 8 May 2019,

²⁴⁴ <https://www.crisisgroup.org/middle-east-north-africa/gulf-and-arabianpeninsula/iran/biden-should-cap-freeze-and-roll-back-irans-nuclear-program>

²⁴⁵ <https://www.politico.com/news/2021/02/18/biden-iran-nuclear-deal-470000>

²⁴⁶ <https://www.wsj.com/articles/u-s-says-it-would-meet-for-nuclear-talks-with-iran-other-powers-11613687193>

²⁴⁷ <https://www.state.gov/briefings/department-press-briefing-march-4-2021/#post-223881-IRAN>

²⁴⁸ Letter to Secretary General, p. 211

29 January 2020, 10 March 2020, and 2 July 2020 to the Coordinator of the JCPOA Joint Commission under Paragraph 36 of the JCPOA and letters of 10 May 2018 and 10 April 2019 to the Secretary-General of the United Nations are removed.

In this letter to the European countries who were trying to shift from the position of defendant to the position of claimant, I reminded them of the following points:

There is no problem of mutual mistrust. The party that has failed to establish confidence in its adherence to its obligations is certainly not Iran, but the United States and to a lesser extent its E3/EU partners... The E3/EU have not been able—in spite of verbal commitments and claims to the contrary—to effectively perform their obligations under the JCPOA or those made after the U.S. withdrawal, as detailed in Iran’s notification of 2 July 2020 under Paragraph 36 of the JCPOA... The United States is accountable for hundreds of billions of dollars of unjustifiable direct and indirect irreparable harm to the economy and livelihoods of the people of Iran, coupled with the losses of life directly caused by its indiscriminate economic terrorism targeting the Iranian people... The U.S. should not arrogate to itself—nor can the EU/E3—the right to demand anything from Iran before it rectifies its dismal record of non-performance and outright brutality against the Iranian people—which continues to date, and amid an ongoing pandemic at that.

Simultaneously with diplomatic steps aimed at preventing European and American “blame game” against Iran, we submitted a number of proposals to the Supreme National Security Council of Iran in February and March 2021 on how to bring the U.S. back to the JCPOA. However, our proposals went nowhere due to internal dynamics dominated by the presidential campaign. My repeated insistence that I was not running in the election was of no help. When the time came for the JCPOA Joint Commission to meet at the level of deputy foreign ministers of JCPOA participants, at the EU initiative, the special envoy of the United States was invited to Vienna in order to coordinate modalities of U.S. return without

physical presence in the meetings. In Spring 2021, Dr. Araghchi entered breath-taking negotiations with the remaining JCPOA participants and indirectly with the US. These talks, six rounds of which were held under the Rouhani Administration, were based on the policy announced by the Leader on the first day of Iranian new year on March 21, 2021, that “the Americans should [first] lift all sanctions, after which we will verify and then return to the JCPOA”.

Based on the agreed framework during Vienna talks, in case an agreement was reached and the U.S. returned to the JCPOA, all sanctions that had been initially removed under the JCPOA would be removed anew. However, Since Dr. Araghchi was not allowed to conclude the negotiations, no agreement was finalized. In all complicated multilateral negotiations, the rule is that nothing is agreed until everything is agreed.

Furthermore, based on the framework negotiated by Dr. Araghchi, all new sanctions imposed by Trump that could not have been imposed had the U.S. continued to be a JCPOA participant would also be lifted. Had these sanctions been lifted, non-U.S. individuals would face no U.S. penalty for cooperating with Iran. Sanctions imposed on the Leader and me would have also been lifted. A general agreement had been reached that also paved the way for delisting the IRGC as a foreign terrorist organization (FTO). However, negotiations did not come to conclusion and specifically foreign minister of all JCPOA participants who were supposed to meet and issue a statement did not meet and no statement was ever issued. Therefore, like all other agreements which constitute an integrated whole, no one can claim that we had reached full agreement on any provision.

A ministerial meeting was set to be held to announce the agreement. In addition to the Joint Commission’s decision, a ministerial statement would have also been issued and most of its content had been agreed upon. Of course, the U.S. had refused to lift primary sanctions that blocked U.S. individuals and entities from transacting with Iran, which have been in effect since the early years of the Islamic Revolution and have gradually been stacked up. Also, Iranian individuals and entities that had been designated under non-nuclear pretexts (like terrorism, missile and human rights) were not de-listed. Iran on its part had not been prepared to discuss those issues either.

Had an agreement been achieved in Vienna so that the U.S. would have lifted its sanctions, Iran would have also done returned to its JCPOA obligations following proper verification. Unfortunately, pinning hope on a more advantageous outcome or more probably due to domestic political concerns, finalization of that achievement was blocked. Even senior officials of the next administration belatedly came to the conclusion that agreement was no longer achievable. Now everyone knows that the opportunity was lost forever.

In my 22nd and last report on the JCPOA implementation that I submitted to the National Security and Foreign Policy Commission of the parliament on 2 July 2020, I enumerated some of the aforesaid points and presented the following conclusion, which after nearly five years continue to be my beliefs:

After two years of intensive and exhausting negotiations to reach an acceptable agreement, followed by six grueling years of strenuous effort to safeguard the rights of the noble Iranian people and prevent the agreement from collapsing, along with eight years of enduring insults, swallowing pride, and remaining silent in the face of unfounded accusations, the time has now come—on the eve of handing over responsibility to a new generation of energetic and motivated brothers and sisters—to present a few experiences and reflections as an honest summation and a sincere, well-intentioned counsel.

The JCPOA was the result of a devoted and painstaking effort to free Iran from the trap of U.S. securitization and unjust sanctions, while preserving the country's nuclear capabilities within clearly defined red lines under exceptionally difficult conditions. Like any agreement, however, it was the product of dialogue and global give-and-take, shaped under specific circumstances in 2013, following the decisive vote of the Iranian people in favor of resolving the nuclear dossier through constructive and dignified engagement. No agreement is flawless for any of its parties. Each side is dissatisfied with certain aspects of the deal; this is the nature of all agreements. Consequently, reaching an agreement requires recognition of the reality that compromise is impossible without addressing at least

a minimum acceptable level of the concerns and demands of all parties. Excessive maximalism leads only to protracted and endless negotiations, which in almost all circumstances impose losses—or at best foregone benefits—on the country and its people. These losses are more damaging than the hypothetical gains of achieving an ideal agreement that is, in practice, unattainable. Efforts by any actor to secure victory at the expense of the other—a zero-sum approach—ultimately result in failure for both sides, producing a negative-sum outcome, even if the losses are not equally distributed. In today's interconnected world, only by taking into account the interests of all parties—a positive-sum approach—can a viable and constructive outcome be achieved.

For this reason, reaching an agreement requires courage, self-sacrifice, and readiness to bear reputational costs, while prioritizing national interests over personal considerations. Accommodation—inevitably involving compromise—is not admired or celebrated in any culture or society. The historical heroes of most nations have been warriors and battlefield fighters, not diplomats engaged in negotiation and compromise. Yet the reality is that the outcomes of every war are ultimately settled at the negotiating table, and the failures of every battlefield confrontation are adjusted—though not reversed—through diplomatic engagement.

National interests and the highest interests of the people and the country demand that foreign policy not become an arena for domestic political or factional conflict. Those responsible for this domain must be supported by national consensus, solidarity, and broad public backing—naturally accompanied by oversight and constructive, well-intentioned criticism. Constructive criticism requires the presentation of practical and realistic alternatives, not mere critique, even if fair-minded. Offering concrete proposals allows, on the one hand, the exchange of ideas to lead to the selection of more effective and efficient options, and on the other, creates the possibility of genuine dialogue accompanied by accountability on the part of officials. At the same time, it must be acknowledged that diplomats and foreign-policy practitioners—whether experts,

ambassadors, or ministers—are not the final decision-makers. Everywhere in the world, they are executors of decisions made by higher authorities. A country's supreme interests cannot be reduced to a single issue, and the ultimate decision-maker must weigh all dimensions. A diplomat or official in the field cannot expect to make the final decision, or even that the final decision will align with their personal preferences, outlook, or recommended option. Nevertheless, they must express their expert opinions honestly and courageously; but once a decision is made, they must devote their fullest effort to its optimal and comprehensive implementation and defend that policy with conviction—even if it contradicts their own views or those of their organization.

Every policy has strengths and weaknesses. Opponents of a policy, while expressing their views and engaging in constructive criticism, should not obstruct the implementation of an adopted policy. Obstruction by opponents not only fails to correct the policy, but also hardens its supporters, prevents the realization of even its minimum potential benefits, and consistently provides an excuse for defenders of the policy to resist necessary evaluation and revision—claiming that success would have been achieved had obstructions not been present. In any case, if a policy is properly implemented, it yields certain benefits; but if its implementation becomes entangled in disputes over the policy's very legitimacy, then all the harms cited by opponents will inevitably materialize, while none of the anticipated benefits will be realized.

Had we, instead of engaging in internal disputes over whether the JCPOA was an outright victory or a total failure—which it certainly was neither—and collectively focused on extracting the maximum possible benefit from it, circumstances might well have unfolded differently. Had we, from the outset, sought to capitalize on every level of JCPOA achievements—even under the most pessimistic interpretations—and attracted greater foreign investment while bringing a larger number of companies from across the world into the country, sanctioning Iran and imposing “maximum pressure” would have become far more difficult. Had we reached a national

consensus on the need for balanced engagement with both East and West, refrained on the one hand from naïvely alienating long-standing partners in the illusion that Western companies would flood in, and on the other hand fully utilized the JCPOA to create tangible economic interests for all stakeholders—including foreign subsidiaries of American companies—then our partners would not have become disillusioned and abandoned us in difficult times, and President Trump would have faced serious resistance from global capital interests, including within the United States itself, in pursuing maximum pressure. All that was required was unity and a shared commitment to making full and optimal use of all available tools to implement the country's chosen policy regarding the JCPOA.

Now is the best possible moment to create this unity and shared resolve. Success in the recent Vienna talks and the final failure of the maximum-pressure policy—through the United States' return to its JCPOA commitments—can, within the new political environment of the country, lay the groundwork for fully harnessing all the JCPOA's potential. By prioritizing relations with all partners, establishing balance in foreign economic relations—and, of course, by relying on an economic resilience framework rooted in both internal capacity and external engagement—this path can bring unprecedented growth and prosperity to the country and future generations. The 25-year cooperation program with China, strategic relations with Russia, the neighborhood-first policy and prioritization of neighboring countries and maximizing the benefits of Western commitments under the JCPOA together provide a solid foundation for such a future.

God is sufficient for us, and He is the best disposer of affairs

Concluding Remarks

Although many important developments have taken place since the first Persian edition of this book was completed in Winter 2023, and while I briefly touched upon two most important ones – fall of Assad in Syria in 2024 and purported JCPOA snapback in 2025 – I decided to keep my concluding remarks intact. Below is exactly what I wrote over 2 years ago.

When I was relieved of my responsibilities at the foreign ministry two years ago, nearly forty-two years had passed since I had first entered the Consulate General of the Islamic Republic of Iran in San Francisco as an unpaid volunteer. In the past two years, I have also been fortunate to engage in academic discussions with professors and students in scholarly and university settings on many of these same dossiers. I have been among a very small number of people, especially in the early years after the revolution, whose education and professional life have been devoted to a single field. Throughout my academic and professional career, I have never jumped from one discipline to another; rather, I have spent my entire life learning, examining, teaching, reassessing, writing, and working exclusively in the fields of international relations, global organizations, human rights, and foreign policy. Inevitably, this meant that I learned very little about anything else.

I have always tried to say and write nothing but realities—realities that have, more often than not, been bitter rather than sweet. Perhaps my twice experiencing unemployment after holding what were, respectively, the second highest and the highest positions in the foreign policy apparatus was the natural consequence of this approach. Critics, of course, have a different view.

I am neither regretful nor embittered by this repeated outcome. My only regret is that I was unable to serve the people of Iran in a manner worthy of them—those very people who have been, and will remain, the greatest pillar of our national security and the firmest foundation of the

country's deterrence; the same people without whose resilience the many pressures, from Saddam's imposed war to Trump's economic war, could well have brought Iran to ruin.

I have never sought political or administrative office. Once the people's vote and their will were clearly expressed at the ballot box, I could not evade the difficult duty for which I had been called, and I was compelled to accept the responsibility of serving as Iran's foreign minister, with all its structural constraints and limitations. Until my very last day, I endeavored to regard the pursuit of national interests and the will of the Iranian people as my highest objective. As I emphasized in my first address to the Islamic Consultative Assembly, I considered this responsibility a heavy burden upon my shoulders. For this reason, contrary to the assumptions and anxieties of many permanent residents of the antechambers of politics, I neither intended to run for presidency in 2021 nor will I enter the race for presidency in the future. Even regarding the responsibilities I have already borne, I fear divine accountability—yet remain hopeful of God's forgiveness.

The product of these forty-four years of life is a set of reflections on the opportunities and challenges of Iran's foreign policy. Iran is a capable country that can—and must—play a pivotal role in regional and global affairs. Iran's material capabilities and motivational resources are unparalleled in the region and significant on a global scale. Their intelligent deployment can bring development, prosperity, security, and dignity together for the Iranian people—who are, indeed, deserving of the very best.

From the academic and experiential perspective of this civil servant, who now has the honor of teaching, ideational power and material power are not in opposition to one another—particularly in the case of Iran—but rather are complementary and mutually reinforcing. Iran's most decisive advantages lie in its motivational and ideational capacities as a civilization-state. From its ancient history and culture to Islam and the school of the Ahl al-Bayt (peace be upon them), and from the independence-seeking and anti-oppression ethos of the Islamic Revolution to the Constitution itself—these are the firmest pillars and deepest roots of Iran's national power. We must not be deceived by claims that pit ideals against national

interests. Those who preach the necessity of choosing between “cause and state” have never been willing, in their own countries, to abandon ideals—whether genuine or fabricated—from their foreign policy or national-interest calculations. Proportionality, balance, and prioritization, however, are different matters that have been neglected by both schools of thought in our political discourse.

Here, as the culmination of more than four decades of experience, I do not focus on opportunities—not because opportunities are few or insignificant, but because, in my perhaps correct or perhaps mistaken judgment, what has received less attention, or has been deliberately ignored for various reasons, are the challenges of Iran’s external relations. These challenges fall into two categories—foundational and historical challenges, and immediate challenges—and are presented here as a concluding statement, or a kind of political testament.

A key point is that I consider myself complicit in the creation and intensification of these challenges; I do not see myself as standing apart or above them. I make no claim that the views expressed here are free of error, or even of personal or temperamental bias—although I have earnestly tried to make them transparent to myself and to keep such biases out of my analysis. As the Qur’an relates in the words of the Prophet Joseph (peace be upon him):

“Yet I do not absolve myself; indeed, the Nafs is ever inclined to evil, except those upon whom my Lord has mercy. Indeed, my Lord is Forgiving and Merciful.” (Qur’an 12:53)

A. Foundational and Historical Challenges

The Challenge of Understanding National, Regional, and Global Processes

Global conditions in the post–Cold War era differ fundamentally from those of the bipolar world. The pace of events—driven by technological advancement, the rise of new state and non-state actors, and the disruption of the state-centric global governance system through artificial intelligence, smart weapons, transnational networks beyond state control, and more—is staggering. Fluidity and unpredictability have become inseparable

from our world, making up-to-date understanding of ongoing processes indispensable. Misperceptions of the international environment and of states' positions in the post–Cold War era led to flawed assessments and abstract decision-making—whether in aggressive forms, as with Saddam Hussein or Slobodan Milošević, or in forms of capitulation, as with Muammar Gaddafi—each of which can culminate in the destruction of a regime or even a country.

Successful states and actors today invest unprecedented effort and resources in understanding events, even as they simultaneously engage in shaping perceptions to serve their own interests. Post–Cold War scholarly production is remarkable in both volume and diversity, though much of it reflects national agendas or the political and economic interests and affiliations of its authors. In other words, many theories are interest-driven rather than Truth-driven. Amid this global cacophony, accurate understanding is exceedingly difficult and demands precision, depth, research, avoidance of prejudice, and dialogue aimed at mutual understanding rather than indoctrination—among elites, scholars, and policymakers alike.

Personal assumptions of leaders, bureaucratic tendencies to selectively arrange data to confirm superiors' views, sectoral and organizational interests, and political and economic incentives ultimately lead to the formation, institutionalization, and persistence of distorted perceptions of external realities. This phenomenon is not unique to our country. In the Global North, mechanisms exist to mitigate this universal problem. Unfortunately, not only do we lack such mechanisms, but by sanctifying viewpoints and prescriptions, opportunists and power-seekers institutionalize this corrupt cycle. Reliance on translations rather than original sources further opens the door to deliberate misperception-building.

Lack of Domestic Consensus on National Interests, Security, Ideals, and Priorities

All material and ideational pillars of national interest and security—such as survival, domestic legitimacy and citizen satisfaction, identity, territorial integrity, general welfare, sustainable development, internal security and cohesion, military capability, healthy global linkages, external influence,

regional engagement, and international standing—are valuable and together constitute national power. None should be sacrificed for another. The alleged incompatibility between national interests and ideals is a false and unfounded claim. With competent governance, ideals reinforce rather than rival national interests. Those who call for choosing between “State and Cause” have never abandoned motivational power rooted in ideals within their own foreign policies.

Naturally, officials responsible for any one pillar of national security and interest may advance their own mandate without regard for its impact on others, potentially inflicting irreparable harm—unaware that such imbalance ultimately weakens aggregate national power and even damages their own domain.

Fragmentation in Iran’s external relations is not limited to tensions between military-security institutions and political-economic ones. Even economic agencies within the administration, particularly in relations with neighbors, often pursue narrow institutional objectives without regard for overarching national policy, creating unprecedented disorder even within the administration itself.

Optimal governance requires intelligent identification of all pillars of national interest and the creation of domestic consensus around them—based on accurate, up-to-date understanding of changing domestic and international conditions, and structured in a balanced and rational manner acceptable to both political elites and the public.

In ideal conditions, all pillars of national interest and security can be safeguarded simultaneously. Yet the world rarely offers ideal conditions. Unforeseen domestic and external crises are frequent. When safeguarding all pillars becomes impossible, decisions must be made based on priorities—priorities that must be defined before crises arise and agreed upon domestically, though implemented only in times of necessity.

Temporary imbalance among these pillars may be unavoidable in exceptional circumstances, but balance must be restored immediately afterward. Permanently sacrificing certain pillars to address imagined threats is neither sustainable nor effective. Ultimately, even the domain ostensibly being protected will suffer.

Ignoring Capabilities and Setting Goals Based on Wishful Thinking

Human progress requires aspiration and imagination; societies cannot thrive without hopeful visions. Yet aspirations cannot substitute for realistic planning. Policy must be grounded in capabilities when pursuing ideals.

Iran's past five centuries show repeated instances in which policies were shaped by aspirations rather than realities, leading not only to failure but to the loss of existing assets. Planning based on wishful thinking reflects not strength but a lack of self-confidence.

In such a mindset, dialogue, cooperation, and compromise are treated as vice rather than virtue. Diplomacy becomes a last resort—akin to eating carrion—used only in desperation. No country can sustain effective diplomacy under such conditions; repeated cycles of intransigent resistance followed by reluctant concession only reinforce the belief that diplomacy yields nothing but humiliation.

Optimal governance must align national dreams with realistic assessments of internal and external capacities, delivering tangible achievements that sustain public hope. Public perceptions of dignity or humiliation are shaped less by outcomes than by the behavior and narratives of leaders and media.

The Illusion of Attachment and Aversion

One of Iran's key cognitive challenges is the persistence of bipolar assumptions, leading to unrealistic expectations of loyalty from partners. In the post-polar world, loyalty has eroded—even among allies of the most powerful states. Neither the United States nor its allies can rely on steadfast loyalty today. The outreach of Persian Gulf states to Russia, China, and even Iran reflects this sobering reality.

Permanent alliances have given way to fluid, issue-based coalitions. States act based on tangible gains and will not sacrifice core interests for partners' preferences.

B. Immediate Challenges in External Relations

Relations with Neighbors

For all countries, including great powers, relations with neighbors constitute the most critical foreign-policy domain. Iran's material, human, and motivational strengths naturally generate concern among neighbors, who seek to balance these advantages through regional and extra-regional alliances—a reality requiring mature, confidence-building responses from Iran.

The most effective strategy for the stronger regional actor is leadership in trust-building, respectful conduct, emphasis on shared interests, and avoidance of condescension. Postwar Germany's strategy of humility and European integration restored its central role without alarming neighbors.

The problematic presence of the United States and Israel around Iran serves their anti-Iranian objectives, not genuine regional security. The question is how Iran should respond. Threats and saber-rattling only reinforce securitization narratives. The most effective response is proactive promotion of inclusive regional cooperation mechanisms—undermining Israeli threat narratives and mobilizing regional public opinion against destabilizing external actors.

Iran's absence from emerging regional mechanisms does not prevent their formation; it merely excludes Iran from decision-making. In multilateral diplomacy, those not at the table often end up on the table.

Fragmented management and informal cross-border trade further undermine relations. Sanctions have encouraged uncoordinated actions by various entities, sidelining diplomacy. Restoring the central role of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs is imperative; further delay risks irreversible strategic damage.

Relations with China and Russia

Strong and constructive relations are imperative with Russia, as a key neighbor, and China, as a rising global power. These relationships must be understood realistically, without emotional overinvestment or misplaced expectations.

Ties with China and Russia should be intrinsic and based on their own merits, not merely reactions to tensions with the West. Even in the event of normalized relations with the United States, Iran should maintain privileged relations with both. Yet permanent alliances are illusory; neither Russia nor China will jeopardize their core interests for Iran.

Their rivalry with the United States is primarily economic and technological, not military. Russia's past caution toward confrontation and China's restraint—visible in Taiwan-related crises—underscores this reality. Blocking Iran's Shanghai Cooperation Organization membership during UN Chapter VII sanctions further illustrates their aversion to anti-U.S. alignment.

Iran must pursue pragmatic, interest-based partnerships—building on agreements such as the 25-year Iran–China roadmap, Eurasian integration, the SCO, BRICS, and bilateral accords with Russia—without illusions of strategic loyalty.

The Legal Regime of the Caspian Sea

One of the most painful examples of regional arrangements formed without Iran is the division of the Caspian seabed. Iran's insistence on joint ownership, based on the 1921 and 1940 treaties, lacked justiciable possibilities and enabled other littoral states—led by Russia—to finalize seabed divisions without Iran's participation.

With no agreed legal forum for adjudication, Iran had no effective legal recourse. Participation in negotiating the Comprehensive Caspian Convention was therefore essential to prevent unilateral decisions on other issues such as surface waters, territorial seas, navigation, environmental protection, and military presence.

The unresolved issue remains baseline determination. Iran's leverage lies in withholding parliamentary ratification until a fair baseline is agreed. Submitting the convention prematurely to Majlis would forfeit Iran's negotiating power.

The Caucasus

The key issue in the Caucasus today is transport corridors. Iran faces a choice between opposing emerging routes or actively shaping regional

frameworks such as the proposed 33+ mechanism involving Iran, Russia, Turkey, and the three South Caucasus states. Passive opposition risks exclusion, expanded Turkish and Israeli influence, and securitization of Iran's role.

Marginalization from Regional Transit Routes

Iran's historic role as a global transit hub is not guaranteed. Sanctions, financial restrictions, domestic inefficiencies, and regulatory unpredictability have driven regional actors to develop alternative corridors—such as the Lapis Lazuli route, Trans-Caspian pipelines, and new India–Middle East–Europe links.

Once established, alternative routes are difficult to reverse. Reviving Iran's role requires strategic investment in corridors like North–South and South–West, including the Rasht–Astara railway.

The Unresolved Legacy of the Imposed Iraq War

Dredging the Arvand Rud (Shatt al-Arab) under the 1975 Algiers Agreement remains a sensitive and unresolved issue. While progress was achieved through bilateral cooperation, Iran must avoid unilateral concessions and ensure that all related water issues remain conditional on actual dredging.

The Securitization of Iran

Israel's most effective global strategy has been the securitization of its adversaries. The construction of Iran as a global security threat—particularly through the nuclear dossier—enabled multiple Chapter VII UN resolutions and normalized Israeli relations with regional states.

Some Iranian actors mistakenly interpreted securitization as recognition of Iran's strength, inadvertently reinforcing the narrative. Securitization operates through discourse, narratives and imagery, not objective reality. Human-rights narratives mobilize civil society, while nuclear and missile narratives target states.

Today, allegations of Iran's involvement in the Ukraine war serve as the primary vehicle for re-securitization. While dangerous, securitization can be countered through effective narrative production—as demonstrated by the failure of Trump's re-securitization efforts, later reversed under Biden.

Managing Tensions with the United States

While U.S. decline is real, America remains the world's most powerful aggregated actor. Resisting U.S. hegemony is essential to Iran's identity, but permanent military-economic confrontation is unsustainable and deters even temporary coalitions with Iran.

Iran should emulate China's calibrated approach—categorizing disputes into irreconcilable, conditionally cooperative, and manageable conflict domains. Nuclear and missile issues fall into the third category, requiring tension management rather than escalation.

The core challenge remains U.S. financial power and sanctions, which have crippled Iran's external relations. Barter, national currencies, and alternative mechanisms have repeatedly failed. Thus, managing tensions with Washington is not optional but a prerequisite for meaningful global engagement.

I began these reflections with the words of God as spoken by the Prophet Joseph, and I conclude with the words of God as spoken by the Prophet Hud (peace be upon them all):

"I desire nothing but reform, so far as I am able; and my success is only by God. Upon Him I rely, and to Him I return." (Qur'an 11:88)

Appendices

Annex I: Publications

Books

Raz-e Sar be Mohr, Kusheshi Setorg Baray-e Hoquq, Amniat va Tos'eh Iran (The Unsealed Secret, Big Endeavor for Iran Rights, Security and Development), Ettela'at Edition, 2021, six volumes (with Ali Akbar Salehi, Seyed Abbas Araghchi, Majid Takht Ravanchi and Seyed Ali Mojani)

Dowran-e Gozar-e Ravabet-e Bein ul-Melal dar Jahan-e Pasagharbi (International Relations Transition Period in Post-Western World), Center for International Education and Research, 2016 (with Seyed Mohammad Kazem Sajjadpour and Ebadollah Mowlaei)

Diplomasiy-e Chandjanebeh; Pouyayi-e Mafhoumi va Karbordi-ye Sazmanhay-e Mantaghe'i va Beinolmelali (Multilateral Diplomacy: Conceptual and Functional Dynamism of Regional and International Organizations), Center for International Education and Research, 2022 (with Seyed Mohammad Kazem Sajjadpour)

Sazmanhya-e Beinolmelali (International Organizations), Mizan Edition, 2020 (with Seyed Mohammad Kazem Sajjadpour)

Diplomasiy-e Chandjanebeh; Nazarieh va Amalkerd-e Sazmanhay-e Mantaghe'i va Beinolmelali (Multilateral Diplomacy; Theory and Performance of Regional and International Organizations), SIR, 2008, three volumes (with Seyed Mohammad Kazem Sajjadpour)

Ravandhay-e Jadid-e Beinolmelali (New International Trends), Edition FMI, 2005 (with Mostafa Zahraei)

Crossing the Divide: Dialogue among Civilization, (South Orange, NJ, USA: Seton Hall University, 2001).

Articles

"Trump's Campaign to Re-securitize Iran", International Studies Journal (ISJ), Vol. 20, No. 2 (78). Fall 2023. (with S.J. Afjei).

"Chandjanebegeyayie va Qodrat-e Ide" (Multilateralism and Power of Idea). Mehdi Zakerian, Jahan-e Siasat, 2023

"Naqsh-e Dilomasi-e Chandjanbeh bar Amniat-e Beinolmelali" (The Role of Multilateralism Diplomacy in International Security), Mehdi Zakerian, Jahan-e Siasat, 2023

"Securitization in the Transitional Period; A Threat to World Peace", International Conference on Peace and Conflict Resolution (4th: 2023: Tehran)

"Iran va Chalesh-e Shenakhti dar Tanavo'e Ma'naei-ye Ettehad-e Rahbordi dar Ravabet-e Beinolmelal" (Iran and the Cognitive Challenge in the Semantic Diversity of Strategic Unity in International Relations), Motale'at-e Keshvarha, Issue 3 (Sasan Karimi)

"Tajali-ye Khelalhay-e Darouni va Birouni-ye Demokrasiha dar Nakarai" (Manifestation of Internal and External Disruptions of Democracies in Inefficiency), *Quarterly of International Relations (Issue 76)*, Spring 2023 (Aryan Qasemi)

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«لتفهم أميركا: القوة لا تصنع الحق» الاخبار 13 ابريل 2020.

"Autoriser les Etats-Unis à détruire définitivement l'accord sur le nucléaire iranien serait retourner à la loi de la jungle" *Le Monde*, 202012/08/.

"International community must stop US destroying the world of laws" *Global Times*, 202012/8/.

"Strait of Hormuz region can find its own solution" *Financial Times*, 10 October 2019.

«مبادره هرمز للسلام... مشروع الامل» الراى، 10 اكتوبر 2019

"US Foreign Policy in Crisis" *Iran Daily*, 21 June 2018.

«ايران و جيرانها العرب ... ما الذى يجمعنا؟» الجزيرة 2018/3/27

«نحو نموذج أمنى جديد فى المنطقة» العربى الجديد 2018/3/19

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Annex II

Foreign Visits

During the first four years of my tenure as Minister of Foreign Affairs, from 2013 to 2017, I visited nearly 200 destinations across 121 trips. Asia accounted for 48 percent of these missions, ranking first among all continents. Switzerland and Austria, each visited ten times due to the nuclear negotiations, represented the most frequent destinations in this period.

In the second term of office, from 2017 to 2021, I undertook 150 missions covering 193 destinations abroad. Turkey, with 14 visits, and Asia, with 60 percent of all trips, registered the highest share.

Over the course of eight years, up to May 2021, I traveled to 393 destinations through 271 officially scheduled trips. At the continental level, Asia ranked first, comprising nearly 54 percent of all visits. The single most frequent destination during the eight-year period was Turkey, with 33 visits. In terms of the nature of the travels, bilateral engagements constituted the majority, with 126 official visits falling under this category.

Date	Country / City	Remarks
8–9 Sept. 2013	Iraq (Baghdad, Karbala, Najaf)	Bilateral talks
12–13 Sept. 2013	Kyrgyzstan	Shanghai Cooperation Organization Summit
18 Sept.–5 Oct. 2013	New York	United Nations General Assembly
14–17 Oct. 2013	Switzerland (Geneva)	Nuclear negotiations
30 Oct.–2 Nov. 2013	South Africa – Turkey	Joint Commission – Bilateral talks
5–10 Nov. 2013	France – Switzerland (Geneva)	UNESCO Meeting – Nuclear negotiations
19–24 Nov. 2013	Italy – Switzerland	Bilateral talks – Nuclear negotiations
1–2 Dec. 2013	Kuwait – Oman – Qatar	Joint Commission – Bilateral talks
4–5 Dec. 2013	United Arab Emirates (Abu Dhabi, Dubai)	Bilateral talks

19–20 Dec. 2013	Pakistan	D8 Foreign Ministers' Meeting
4–5 Jan. 2014	Turkey (Istanbul)	Bilateral talks
12–17 Jan. 2014	Lebanon – Iraq – Jordan – Syria – Russia	Bilateral talks
20–22 Jan. 2014	Turkmenistan	Joint Commission
23–27 Jan. 2014	Switzerland (Davos)	World Economic Forum
31 Jan.–4 Feb. 2014	Germany (Munich, Berlin)	Munich Security Conference
17–21 Feb. 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
26 Feb.–1 Mar. 2014	India	Bilateral talks
3–6 Mar. 2014	Japan – Indonesia	Bilateral talks
12–13 Mar. 2014	Oman	With the President of the Republic
14 Mar. 2014	Turkey (Van)	Iran–Turkey–Azerbaijan trilateral
17–21 Mar. 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
27 Mar. 2014	Afghanistan	International Nowruz Celebration
7–10 Apr. 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
14–16 Apr. 2014	United Arab Emirates	Joint Commission
21–23 Apr. 2014	Russia	Caspian Foreign Ministers' Meeting
13–17 May 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
19–21 May 2014	China (Shanghai)	With the President – CICA Summit
26–31 May 2014	Turkey – Algeria	Bilateral talks – NAM Foreign Ministers' Meeting
10–11 June 2014	Turkey	With the President
16–21 June 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
1–18 July 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
5–6 Aug. 2014	Oman	Bilateral talks
24–26 Aug. 2014	Iraq	Bilateral talks
28–29 Aug. 2014	Turkey – Russia	Bilateral talks

1–4 Sept. 2014	Belgium – Luxembourg – Italy	Bilateral talks
8–12 Sept. 2014	Kazakhstan – Tajikistan	Bilateral talks – Shanghai Cooperation Organization Summit
16 Sept.–29 Sept. 2014	New York – Russia	United Nations General Assembly – Caspian Summit
14–17 Oct. 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
29 Oct.–1 Nov. 2014	China	“Heart of Asia” Foreign Ministers’ Conference
8–12 Nov. 2014	Oman	Bilateral talks
13–14 Nov. 2014	Azerbaijan	With the President
18–27 Nov. 2014	Austria	Nuclear negotiations
15–19 Dec. 2014	Switzerland	Nuclear negotiations
30 Dec. 2014	Afghanistan	Bilateral talks
22–25 Jan. 2015	Switzerland (Davos) – Saudi Arabia	World Economic Forum – Funeral of the King of Saudi Arabia
6–8 Feb. 2015	Germany (Munich)	Munich Security Conference
18–23 Feb. 2015	Switzerland (Geneva) – France	Nuclear negotiations – Bilateral talks
1–4 Mar. 2015	Switzerland (Geneva)	Nuclear negotiations
14–17 Mar. 2015	Switzerland (Lausanne)	Nuclear negotiations
25 Mar.–2 Apr. 2015	Switzerland (Lausanne)	Nuclear negotiations
14–15 Apr. 2015	Spain – Portugal	Bilateral talks
16–17 Apr. 2015	Indonesia	Asia–Africa Summit
21–24 Apr. 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Nuclear negotiations
26–29 Apr. 2015	Kuwait – Oman	Bilateral talks
11–15 May 2015	New York	NPT Review Conference
22–29 May 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Nuclear negotiations
1–4 June 2015	Oman – Qatar – Pakistan – India	Bilateral talks

16–19 June 2015	Russia	Caspian Foreign Ministers' Meeting
26 June–3 July 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Nuclear negotiations
6–15 July 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Nuclear negotiations
21 July 2015	Iraq (Najaf)	Bilateral talks
3–5 Aug. 2015	Qatar – Kuwait – Iraq	Bilateral talks
12–13 Aug. 2015	Lebanon – Syria	Bilateral talks
23–27 Aug. 2015	Russia – Belgium	Bilateral talks
10–13 Sept. 2015	Turkey – Russia	Bilateral talks
24 Sept.–7 Oct. 2015	New York – Italy	United Nations General Assembly – Bilateral talks
14–15 Oct. 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Syria negotiations
19–23 Oct. 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Syria negotiations
28–30 Oct. 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Syria negotiations
6–7 Nov. 2015	Pakistan	Heart of Asia Foreign Ministers' Meeting
13–14 Nov. 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Syria negotiations
20–23 Nov. 2015	Austria (Vienna)	Syria negotiations
5–7 Dec. 2015	Greece	Bilateral talks
9–11 Dec. 2015	Pakistan – Afghanistan	Bilateral talks
17–19 Dec. 2015	New York	Syria negotiations
20–21 Jan. 2016	Switzerland (Davos)	World Economic Forum
26–28 Jan. 2016	Kuwait – Iraq	Bilateral talks
3–5 Feb. 2016	United Kingdom	Syria conference – Bilateral talks
11–13 Feb. 2016	Germany (Munich)	Munich Security Conference
16–20 Feb. 2016	Belgium – Norway – Germany	Bilateral talks
26–27 Feb. 2016	Iraq	Bilateral talks
7–8 Mar. 2016	Indonesia	OIC Foreign Ministers' Meeting
13–15 Mar. 2016	Australia – New Zealand	Bilateral talks
20–22 Mar. 2016	Turkey (Istanbul)	OIC Summit

10–15 Apr. 2016	Turkey – Uzbekistan – Tajikistan – Turkmenistan – Georgia	Bilateral talks
18–22 Apr. 2016	New York	Signing of Paris Climate Accord
27–29 Apr. 2016	Syria – Lebanon	Bilateral talks
9–11 May 2016	Jordan – Poland – Finland – Sweden	Bilateral talks
15–16 May 2016	Turkey (Istanbul)	OIC Summit on Palestine
18–20 May 2016	Pakistan – India	Bilateral talks
21–25 May 2016	Afghanistan	Bilateral talks
27–28 May 2016	Turkey (Antalya)	International Meeting on Afghanistan
6–10 June 2016	Norway – Germany – France	Bilateral talks
14–16 June 2016	Azerbaijan – Turkey – Kazakhstan	Bilateral talks
17–21 June 2016	Russia (St. Petersburg, Moscow)	International Economic Forum – Bilateral talks
31 May–8 Jun 2016	Cuba / Nicaragua / Ecuador / Chile / Bolivia / Venezuela	Bilateral talks
23 Jun–7 Jul 2016	Mexico / Venezuela / Cuba / New York / Ankara	Accompanying Presidency / UN General Assembly / Bilateral talks
14–19 Jul 2016	Malaysia / Vietnam / Thailand	Accompanying Presidency
24–25 Jul 2016	Switzerland	Syria Meeting
7 Aug 2016	Russia	Iran–Russia–Syria trilateral
17–22 Aug 2016	Lebanon / Romania / Slovakia / Czech Republic	Bilateral talks
13–19 Sep 2016	India (Amritsar) / China / Japan	“Heart of Asia” Summit / Bilateral talks
30 Sep 2016	Russia	Iran–Turkey–Russia trilateral

1–3 Oct 2016	Armenia / Kazakhstan / Kyrgyzstan	Accompanying Presidency
28 Oct–1 Nov 2016	Switzerland (Davos) / Malaysia	World Economic Forum / OIC Foreign Ministers
27–28 Nov 2016	Oman / Kuwait	Accompanying Presidency
29 Nov–3 Dec 2016	Germany	Munich Security Conference
10–12 Dec 2016	Pakistan	OIC Ministers / ECO Leaders
15–19 Dec 2016	Indonesia / Qatar / Indian Ocean Rim Countries	Bilateral talks
7–9 Jan 2017	Russia	Accompanying Presidency
25 Jan 2017	Russia	Syria trilateral
27–30 Jan 2017	Turkmenistan / Kyrgyzstan / Georgia	Bilateral talks
3–5 Feb 2017	Greece	Ancient Civilizations Summit
13 Feb 2017	Pakistan	Bilateral talks
17 Feb 2017	Afghanistan	Bilateral talks
17–19 Mar 2017	Turkey / Kazakhstan	Bilateral talks
22–24 Mar 2017	Norway	Oslo Forum
28–30 Mar 2017	Algeria / Tunisia / Mauritania	Bilateral talks
5–10 Apr 2017	Germany (Berlin) / Italy / France	European Council / Bilateral talks
22–30 Apr 2017	USA (New York)	Sustainable Development Meeting
10–11 May 2017	Turkey	OIC Executive Committee
18–19 Jun 2017	Kazakhstan	Accompanying Presidency, Islamic Summit on Science & Technology
22–23 Jun 2017	Russia (Sochi)	Bilateral talks
25 Jun–8 Jul 2017	USA (New York)	UN General Assembly
10–11 Jul 2017	Oman / Qatar	Bilateral talks
14 Jul 2017	Iraq	Bilateral talks

29 Jul–5 Aug 2017	South Africa / Uganda / Niger	Joint Commission / Bilateral talks
10–11 Aug 2017	Turkey (Antalya)	Iran–Turkey–Qatar trilateral
17–20 Aug 2017	Tajikistan / Uzbekistan	Bilateral talks /
7–9 Sep 2017	Iran, Russia, Turkey	Accompanying the Presidency, trilateral meeting
9–10 Sep 2017	Armenia	Bilateral talks
13–14 Sep 2017	Italy, Azerbaijan	Bilateral talks
21–22 Sep 2017	Russia	Bilateral talks
28–29 Sep 2017	Turkey (Istanbul)	Accompanying the Presidency, Islamic Summit
20–21 Oct 2017	Azerbaijan	Iran, Turkey, and Azerbaijan trilateral
24–25 Nov 2017	Belgium, Russia	Bilateral talks
26–29 Nov 2017	Kuwait	Iraq Reconstruction Summit
29–30 Nov 2017	India	Accompanying the Presidency
7–12 Dec 2017	Germany (Munich), Russia	Munich Security Conference / Bilateral talks
7–9 Jan 2018	Serbia, Bulgaria, Croatia, Bosnia	Bilateral talks
14–17 Jan 2018	Turkmenistan, Azerbaijan	Accompanying the Presidency
19–24 Jan 2018	Turkey, Azerbaijan	Trilateral / Non-Aligned Movement Foreign Ministers Meeting
27–28 Jan 2018	Senegal, Brazil, Uruguay, Namibia	Bilateral talks
30 Jan–6 Feb 2018	Tajikistan	ECO Summit
8 Feb 2018	New York, Belgium	Sustainable Peace Summit / Syria Summit
22–26 Feb 2018	Russia	Trilateral meeting

28–29 Feb 2018	China, Russia, Belgium	Bilateral talks
6–8 Mar 2018	Turkey (Istanbul)	OIC Summit
18–21 Mar 2018	India	Bilateral talks
22–24 Mar 2018	China	Accompanying the Presidency, Shanghai Summit
10–11 Apr 2018	South Africa	Bilateral talks
11–16 Apr 2018	Qatar, Oman	Bilateral talks
9–13 May 2018	Switzerland, Austria	Bilateral talks
20–21 May 2018	Sri Lanka, Singapore	Bilateral talks / ASEAN Foreign Ministers Meeting
7–8 Jun 2018	Kazakhstan (Aktau)	Accompanying the Presidency, Caspian Summit
8–9 Jun 2018	Turkey	Bilateral talks
12 Jun 2018	Pakistan	Bilateral talks
1–14 Jul 2018	Syria	Bilateral talks
7–9 Jul 2018	New York	UN General Assembly
7–9 Aug 2018	Turkey, Pakistan	Trilateral meeting / Bilateral talks
10–12 Aug 2018	Qatar, Turkey	Five-Party Summit / D8 Summit
30 Aug–3 Sep 2018	Italy	Mediterranean talks
5–8 Sep 2018	France, Switzerland (Geneva)	Bilateral talks / Afghanistan Conference
24–25 Sep 2018	Qatar	Doha Assembly
27–29 Sep 2018	Switzerland (Geneva), Turkey	Bilateral talks / Accompanying the Presidency
17–20 Oct 2018	India	Bilateral talks
23–27 Oct 2018	Iraq	Bilateral talks
14–15 Nov 2018	Turkey	Five-Party Summit
21–23 Nov 2018	Lebanon	Bilateral talks
25–26 Nov 2018	Russia (Sochi)	Accompanying the Presidency

26–28 Nov 2018	Germany (Munich)	Munich Security Conference
29 Nov–2 Dec 2018	China	Accompanying the Parliament Speaker
18–22 Dec 2018	Iraq (Baghdad, Karbala, Najaf)	Accompanying the Presidency
1–3 Jan 2019	Turkey (Istanbul)	OIC Foreign Ministers Meeting
27 Jan 2019	Syria	Bilateral talks
27–29 Jan 2019	Turkey	Bilateral talks
3–9 Feb 2019	New York	Multilateralism Summit
10–11 Feb 2019	Qatar	Asian Dialogue Assembly
17–18 Feb 2019	Russia	Bilateral talks
22–23 Feb 2019	Turkmenistan	Bilateral talks
23–25 Feb 2019	India	Bilateral talks
25–27 Feb 2019	Japan	Bilateral talks
27–28 Feb 2019	China	Bilateral talks
2–4 Mar 2019	Pakistan	Bilateral talks
4–6 Mar 2019	Iraq	Bilateral talks
22–24 Mar 2019	Kyrgyzstan	Shanghai Summit
24–26 Mar 2019	Tajikistan	CICA Summit
29–31 Mar 2019	Isfahan	Meeting with Turkish Foreign Minister
31 Mar–1 Apr 2019	Oman	Bilateral talks
22–23 Apr 2019	Norway (Bergen)	Refueling stop
23–28 Apr 2019	New York	Economic and Social Council
29–31 Apr 2019	Venezuela	Non-Aligned Movement Summit
1 May 2019	Nicaragua	Bilateral talks
2–3 May 2019	Bolivia (Santa Cruz)	Bilateral talks
4 May 2019	Senegal	Bilateral talks
20–21 May 2019	Qatar	Bilateral talks
23 May 2019	Russia (Sochi)	Sochi Summit

25–26 May 2019	Kuwait	Bilateral talks
27–28 May 2019	Finland	Bilateral talks
29–30 May 2019	Sweden	Bilateral talks
31 May 2019	Norway	Bilateral talks
1–2 Jun 2019	France	Bilateral talks
3–4 Jun 2019	France (Biarritz)	Meeting with French President
4–5 Jun 2019	China	Bilateral talks
6 Jun 2019	Japan	Bilateral talks
7–8 Jun 2019	Malaysia	Bilateral talks
10–12 Jun 2019	Russia	Bilateral talks
12–14 Jun 2019	Bangladesh	Bilateral talks
15–16 Jun 2019	Indonesia	Bilateral talks
24–26 Jun 2019	Turkey	Trilateral meeting
29 Jun–7 Jul 2019	New York	UN General Assembly
7–9 Jul 2019	Armenia	Eurasian Economic Union Summit
30 Jul–3 Aug 2019	Baku	Accompanying the Presidency, NAM Summit
6–7 Aug 2019	Qatar	Munich Limited Summit
8–9 Aug 2019	Switzerland (Geneva)	Syria Summit
17–19 Aug 2019	Turkey (Antalya)	ECO Foreign Ministers Summit
20–21 Aug 2019	Kazakhstan	Astana Club Summit
11–12 Sep 2019	Qatar	Coordination of Malaysia Conference
15–16 Sep 2019	Switzerland (Zurich)	Return of Professor Soleimani
17–19 Sep 2019	Turkey (Istanbul)	Afghanistan Conference
23–25 Sep 2019	Qatar	Doha talks
26–28 Sep 2019	Malaysia	Accompanying the Presidency, Islamic Summit
29–30 Sep 2019	Japan	Accompanying the Presidency

2–3 Oct 2019	Oman	Bilateral talks
8–9 Oct 2019	Russia	Bilateral talks
10–12 Oct 2019	China	Bilateral talks
22 Oct 2019	Oman	Death of Sultan Qaboos
24–27 Oct 2019	India	Raisina Summit
27 Oct 2019	Oman	Bilateral talks
23–28 Nov 2019	Germany (Munich)	Munich Security Conference
1 Feb 2020	Syria	Bilateral talks
25–27 Mar 2020	Turkey, Russia	Bilateral talks
29–30 Apr 2020	Iraq (Baghdad, Erbil)	Bilateral talks
31 Apr–1 May 2020	Russia	Bilateral talks
23–24 May 2020	Lebanon	Bilateral talks
2–4 Jul 2020	Russia	Bilateral talks
13 Jul 2020	Kuwait	Bilateral talks
18–20 Jul 2020	China (Yunnan)	Bilateral talks
20–21 Jul 2020	Turkey (Istanbul)	Bilateral talks
13–19 Aug 2020	Venezuela, Cuba, Bolivia	Bilateral talks / Accompanying the Presidency
20–22 Aug 2020	Pakistan	Bilateral talks
5–11 Nov 2020	Baku, Moscow, Yerevan, Tbilisi, Istanbul, Nakhichevan	Caucasus Initiative Follow-up
28–29 Dec 2020	Turkey (Istanbul)	Bilateral talks
8–10 Jan 2021	Tajikistan	Bilateral talks
15–16 Jan 2021	Uzbekistan	Bilateral talks
16–17 Jan 2021	Kyrgyzstan	Bilateral talks
17–18 Jan 2021	Kazakhstan	Bilateral talks
18–19 Jan 2021	Turkmenistan	Bilateral talks
29–31 Jan 2021	Indonesia	Bilateral talks
5–6 Feb 2021	Qatar	Bilateral talks
6–7 Feb 2021	Iraq	Bilateral talks
7–8 Feb 2021	Iraq (Erbil)	Bilateral talks

8–9 Feb 2021	Oman	Bilateral talks
9–10 Feb 2021	Kuwait	Bilateral talks
22 Feb 2021	Syria	Bilateral talks
23–25 Feb 2021	Spain	Bilateral talks
26–28 Feb 2021	Italy	Bilateral talks
28 Feb–2 Mar 2021	Ireland	Bilateral talks
2–3 Mar 2021	Azerbaijan (Qabala)	Caucasus Initiative Follow-up
4–5 Mar 2021	Armenia	Caucasus Initiative Follow-up
27–30 Mar 2021	Turkey (Antalya)	Antalya Forum

Annex III:

Interviews with Domestic and International Media

Local Media Outlet

	Date
ISNA News Agency	26/5/1392
Group of Domestic Journalists	3/6/1392
Press TV	25/6/1392
Special News Program, Channel 2	15/7/1392
IRNA Journalists & IRIB Central News	13/7/1392
ISNA News Agency	20/7/1392
Majlis News Agency (Khaneh Mellat)	14/8/1392
IRNA	18/8/1392
ISNA	26/8/1392
Special News Program, Channel 2	21/8/1392
Mehr News Agency	21/8/1392

Special News Program, Channel 2	27/9/1392
Group of Domestic Journalists	22/11/1392
Etemaad Newspaper	11/1/1393
Jam-e Jam Newspaper	11/1/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	19/1/1393
Shargh Newspaper	25/1/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	2/2/1393
IRNA	5/3/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	10/3/1393
Al-Alam Network	31/3/1393
IRNA	27/3/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	26/3/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	23/4/1393
Majlis News Agency	31/4/1393
IRIB News Network	1/5/1393
Majlis News Agency	24/5/1393
ISNA	1/6/1393
ISNA	5/6/1393
Fars News Agency	5/6/1393
Special News Program, Channel 2	2/6/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	24/7/1393
IRNA	18/8/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	30/10/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	7/11/1393
Mehr News Agency	8/11/1393
Fars News Agency	8/11/1393
IRNA	8/11/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	5/12/1393
IRIB Central News	3/12/1393
IRIB Central News	12/12/1393
Seda Weekly	25/12/1393
Khorasan Newspaper	24/12/1393

Etemaad Newspaper	24/12/1393
Iran Newspaper	24/12/1393
Group of Domestic Journalists	9/1/1394
Young Journalists Club	16/1/1394
Negaah-e Yek Program	16/1/1394
IRNA	26/1/1394
IRIB News Agency in New York	7/2/1394
IRIB News Agency	8/2/1394
IRIB News Agency	10/3/1394
Fars News Agency	16/3/1394
Donya-ye Eqtesad Newspaper	30/3/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	9/4/1394
IRNA	8/4/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	6/4/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	1/4/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	22/4/1394
IRNA	29/4/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	24/4/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	21/5/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	25/5/1394
Diplomat Monthly	31/5/1394
Press Conference with Isfahan Media	8/6/1394
Radio Goftogu	3/6/1394
IRIB News Network	23/6/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	1/7/1394
Majlis News Agency	28/6/1394
IRNA	6/7/1394
Special News Program, Channel 2	6/7/1394
IRIB News Network	5/7/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	14/7/1394
Majlis News Agency	27/7/1394
Majlis News Agency	5/8/1394

Group of Domestic Journalists	9/8/1394
Shargh Newspaper	20/8/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	19/8/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	30/8/1394
IRIB News Agency	28/8/1394
IRNA	22/9/1394
ISNA	22/9/1394
IRIB News Network	29/10/1394
Negaah-e Yek Program	29/10/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	26/10/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	11/11/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	24/11/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	20/11/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	19/11/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	28/11/1394
Khabar Online	27/11/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	24/11/1394
ISNA	3/12/1394
Did dar Shab Program	15/12/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	12/12/1394
ISNA	9/12/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	9/12/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	17/12/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	16/12/1394
Group of Domestic Journalists	17/1/1395
IRIB News Agency	8/1/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	21/1/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	17/1/1395
Group of Domestic & Foreign Journalists	4/2/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	9/3/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	24/3/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	11/4/1395

IRNA	23/5/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	1/6/1395
Iran Newspaper	9/6/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	8/6/1395
IRIB News Agency	4/7/1395
Majlis News Agency	13/7/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	11/7/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	9/8/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	17/8/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	13/9/1395
Majlis News Agency	24/9/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	1/10/1395
Entekhab Newspaper	24/11/1395
Etemaad Newspaper	19/11/1395
Fars News Agency	7/12/1395
ISNA	15/12/1395
Etemaad Newspaper	11/12/1395
Group of Domestic Journalists	25/12/1395
Shargh Newspaper	14/1/1396
Radio Eghtesad	6/1/1396
Group of Domestic Journalists	27/1/1396
IRNA	31/1/1396
ISNA	12/2/1396
IRNA	26/2/1396
Group of Domestic Journalists	10/3/1396
Group of Domestic Journalists	23/3/1396
IRIB News Agency	9/4/1396
Iran Newspaper	8/5/1396
Group of Domestic Journalists	11/5/1396
Group of Domestic Journalists	29/5/1396
ISNA	4/6/1396
ISNA	1/6/1396

Government Information Portal	11/6/1396
Khabar Online	14/6/1396
IRNA	10/7/1396
IRIB News Agency	17/7/1396
Negaah-e Yek Program	23/7/1396
IRNA	29/9/1396
Etemaad Newspaper	14/12/1396
Shargh Newspaper	20/12/1396
Tasnim News Agency	5/3/1397
Iran Newspaper	17/5/1397
Special News Program	27/5/1397
Group of Domestic Journalists	14/9/1397
Majlis News Agency	13/9/1397
Etemaad Newspaper	13/11/1397
Majlis News Agency	21/11/1397
Al-Alam Network	10/3/1398
Group of Domestic & Foreign Journalists	16/5/1398
Iran Newspaper	10/6/1398
Social Media Activists	24/7/1398
ISNA	17/9/1398
Group of Domestic & Foreign Journalists	17/10/1398
Media Directors	27/5/1399
Kaar o Kargar Newspaper	13/7/1399
Special News Program, Channel 2	19/11/1399

International Media Outlet

	Date
"This Week with Stephanopoulos," ABC (USA)	8/7/1392
NBC (USA)	22/4/1393
NBC News	14/12/1393
Foreign Journalists at École Polytechnique Fédérale de Lausanne	14/1/1394
Al Mayadeen TV Network	12/3/1394

Iraqi Journalists	6/5/1394
Indian Journalists	25/5/1394
Tunisian Journalists	10/6/1394
The New Yorker (USA)	19/7/1394
Editors and Media Directors from Jordan, Syria, Iraq, Oman, Kuwait, Lebanon, Egypt	27/7/1394
Al-Safir Newspaper (Lebanon)	23/8/1394
Pakistani Journalists	17/9/1394
The New Yorker (USA)	29/9/1394
Nicaraguan Journalists at Parliament	3/6/1395
Kyodo News Agency (Japan)	5/7/1395
Czech Journalist	21/8/1395
Al Mayadeen TV Network	27/12/1395
Editorial Board, The New York Times	2/7/1396
Editorial Board, Associated Press	5/7/1396
CBS (USA)	29/7/1396
RT (Russia Today)	14/9/1396
CNN	30/5/1397
CBS (USA)	7/8/1397
Fox News	8/2/1398
Sputnik News	17/2/1398
Three Japanese Media (NHK/Kyodo/TBS)	26/2/1398
Al Arabi TV	23/3/1398
NBC	25/4/1398
PBS, New York	28/4/1398
Bloomberg, New York	26/4/1398
CNN	24/4/1398
BBC Hardtalk	24/4/1398
NBC	24/4/1398
RT and Russia 24	11/6/1398
CNN	28/6/1398
CBS (USA)	30/6/1398
TRT (Turkey)	20/7/1398

Media Directors, Azerbaijan	20/8/1398
Four US Networks: CNN, ABC, NBC, NPR	17/10/1398
Al Jazeera	17/10/1398
CNN	13/10/1398
Indian Media	25/10/1398

Annex IV:

Proposal Submitted to Oman, (March 2014)

Concept Paper on the “Regional Dialogue Forum”

A. Motivations and Rationale

- The responsibility of all countries in the region to ensure peace, stability, progress, and prosperity;
- Common ties of religion, culture, tradition, history, geography, and kinship that bind our peoples and nations together;
- The strategic importance of waterways in the region for regional and international peace, security, welfare, and development;
- The necessity of regional efforts to prevent war, conflict, violence, extremism, terrorism, and sectarian tensions, which have caused significant human and resource losses in the region.

B. Objectives

- Ensure peace, stability, progress, and prosperity in the region;
- Promote mutual understanding, peaceful, and friendly relations and cooperation among the peoples and governments of the region;
- Preserve territorial integrity, political independence, and international borders of all countries in the region;
- Strengthen Islamic solidarity and avoid conflict, violence, extremism, and sectarian tensions;
- Enhance the global role and status of the region;
- Expand cooperation and interaction at various levels and fields;
- Protect the regional environment;
- Guarantee freedom of navigation and the free flow of oil and other resources to and from the region; and
- Prevent and neutralize regional tensions through increased communication, early warning systems, and dialogue.

C. Principles

- Adherence to the exalted teachings of Islam, which call Muslims to unity and cooperation for the common welfare;
- Respect for the purposes and principles of the United Nations and the Organization of Islamic Cooperation as stated in their charters;
- Mutual respect, mutual benefit, and equality;
- Dialogue and mutual understanding;
- Respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity;
- Inviolability of international borders;
- Peaceful settlement of all disputes;
- Rejection of threats or the use of force;
- Non-interference in domestic or foreign affairs;
- Respect for the sacred sites, historical, religious, and national symbols of the states and peoples of the region;
- Unimpeded commercial use of regional waterways; and
- Free flow of resources to and from the region.

D. Action Plan

A Regional Dialogue Forum could initiate discussions on a wide range of security and cooperation issues, including:

- Mutual understanding, dialogue, and cooperation;
- Arms control, disarmament, and confidence-building measures;
- Exchange of military information, military contacts, awareness-raising, and visits;
- Promotion of non-proliferation and the establishment of a region free of weapons of mass destruction; and
- Concluding a non-aggression pact among regional countries.

Several joint working groups could also be established to plan practical steps for gradually expanding cooperation in the following areas:

- Common security, including combating drugs, terrorism, and human trafficking;
- Economic cooperation, including in oil, gas, and energy;
- Cultural and social cooperation, including interfaith dialogue, cultural exchanges, and tourism;
- Scientific cooperation, including exchange of researchers and students and joint scientific and technological projects;
- Environmental protection, particularly marine environments and the adverse effects of dust and fog; and
- Humanitarian cooperation on issues related to migrants, refugees, and

displaced persons.

The UN Secretary-General could be invited to provide the necessary international framework. The role of the United Nations, as previously outlined in paragraph 8 of Security Council Resolution 598, helps reduce concerns—especially for smaller countries—provides guarantees and mechanisms for the international community to protect its legitimate interests, and establishes the necessary channels to address issues that inherently transcend regional borders.

Draft of a Possible Declaration

The above concept paper could be reflected in a potential declaration, which could, for example, be adopted in Mecca. The declaration may read as follows:

In the Name of God, the Most Gracious, the Most Merciful
Peace and blessings upon the Prophet Muhammad, his family, and companions.

Declaration of Mecca

We, the heads of state and governments of the Kingdom of Bahrain, the Islamic Republic of Iran, the Republic of Iraq, the State of Kuwait, the Sultanate of Oman, the State of Qatar, the Kingdom of Saudi Arabia, the United Arab Emirates, and the Republic of Yemen, gathered in Mecca, the birthplace of Islam that unites us all, aware of our historical responsibility to ensure peace, stability, progress, and prosperity for our peoples and nations, emphasizing the shared ties of religion, culture, tradition, history, geography, and kinship that connect our peoples and nations, recognizing the strategic importance of the waterways located within and around our territories for regional and international peace, security, welfare, and development, We are determined to free our region from the scourge of war and violence, which has repeatedly inflicted enormous human and financial losses; We are determined to rid the region and beyond of conflict, violence, extremism, terrorism, and sectarian tensions; and We are committed to creating a region of friendship, consultation, and cooperation. Before God and our peoples, we solemnly commit to seek the best and most beneficial path for the Islamic Ummah and to faithfully

observe the following principles and rigorously implement the action plan below:

Objectives:

- Ensure peace, stability, progress, and prosperity in the region;
 - Promote mutual understanding, peaceful, and friendly relations and cooperation among the peoples and governments of the region;
 - Preserve territorial integrity, political independence, and international borders of all countries in the region;
 - Strengthen Islamic solidarity and avoid conflict, violence, extremism, and sectarian tensions;
 - Enhance the global role and status of the region;
 - Expand cooperation and interaction at various levels and fields;
 - Protect the regional environment;
 - Guarantee freedom of navigation and the free flow of oil and other resources to and from the region; and
 - Strengthen communication, early warning systems, and dialogue to prevent and neutralize regional tensions.
- Principles:**
- adherence to the exalted teachings of Islam, calling Muslims to unity and cooperation for public welfare;
 - Respect for the purposes and principles of the UN and OIC as stated in their charters;
 - Mutual respect, mutual benefit, and equality;
 - Dialogue and mutual understanding;
 - Respect for sovereignty and territorial integrity;
 - Inviolability of international borders;
 - Peaceful settlement of all disputes;
 - Rejection of threats or the use of force;
 - Non-interference in domestic or foreign affairs;
 - Respect for sacred sites, historical, religious, and national symbols of the states and peoples of the region;
 - Unimpeded commercial use of regional waterways; and
 - Free flow of resources to and from the region.

Action Plan:

- Establish a Regional Dialogue Forum to initiate discussions on a wide range of security and cooperation issues, including:
- Mutual understanding, dialogue, and cooperation;
- Arms control, disarmament, and confidence-building measures;

- Exchange of military information, military contacts, awareness-raising, and visits;
- Promotion of non-proliferation and establishment of a region free of weapons of mass destruction;
- Concluding a non-aggression pact among regional countries;
- Form six joint working groups in security, economic, cultural, scientific, environmental, and humanitarian cooperation, tasked with planning practical steps for gradually expanding cooperation in:
 - Common security, including combating drugs, terrorism, and human trafficking;
 - Economic cooperation, including oil, gas, and energy;
 - Cultural and social cooperation, including interfaith dialogue, cultural exchanges, and tourism;
 - Scientific cooperation, including exchange of researchers and students and joint scientific and technological projects;
 - Environmental protection, particularly marine environments and adverse effects of dust and fog;
 - Humanitarian cooperation on issues related to migrants, refugees, and displaced persons.

Invite the UN Secretary-General, under the institutional framework of Security Council Resolution 598, to provide the necessary international umbrella, thereby reducing regional concerns, ensuring guarantees and mechanisms for the international community to protect its legitimate interests, and taking necessary actions on matters inherently beyond regional borders.

Annex V:

Address to Security Council About Hormuz Peace Plan, 20 October 2020

In the Name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful

Mr. President,

Allow me to begin by thanking you for convening this important meeting, and thank Russia for its constructive initiatives. I would also like

to acknowledge and welcome the initiative by my friend, State Councilor Wang Yi.

A year ago, I participated in a similar meeting of the Security Council, presided by you, Minister Lavrov, to present the Hormuz Peace Endeavor—or HOPE—that had just been launched by President Rouhani in his address to the General Assembly.

Iran stands by that initiative which is the culmination of various Iranian proposals for security and confidence building in the Persian Gulf region. Our first proposal in 1985 became the foundation of paragraphs 5 and 8 of Security Council Resolution 598, which read:

5. Calls upon all other States to exercise the utmost restraint and to refrain from any act which may lead to further escalation and widening of the conflict and thus to facilitate the implementation of the present resolution;

....

8. Further requests the Secretary-General to examine in consultation with Iran and Iraq and with other states of the region measures to enhance the security and stability of the region;

Regrettably—and despite our persistent follow-ups—those paragraphs remain unimplemented.

And our region has since been the scene of several wars, massive foreign military buildups, ensuing nightmare of extremism and terrorism, dangerous accumulation of the most sophisticated weaponry, and aggression and power projection by various actors.

The disparities in power, geographic size, and natural and human resources are very real. Historical anxieties and rivalries among many regional countries cannot be overlooked. But three flawed prescriptions have caused catastrophic consequences:

First, that you can purchase security from others: Be it from Saddam Hussein invading Iran on some of our neighbor's behalf; or from the U.S. coming to rescue our neighbors from the monster that they had together created; or through unprecedented purchase of military hardware.

Second, that you can have security at the expense of the insecurity of your neighbors: Be it Iran, Kuwait or Qatar at one time or another.

And third, that you can establish regional hegemony: Be it in Yemen, North Africa or the Horn of Africa.

Extra-regional actors have looked at our regional disparities, unending rivalries, and new hegemonic illusions as opportunities to expand their military presence and to sell more weapons.

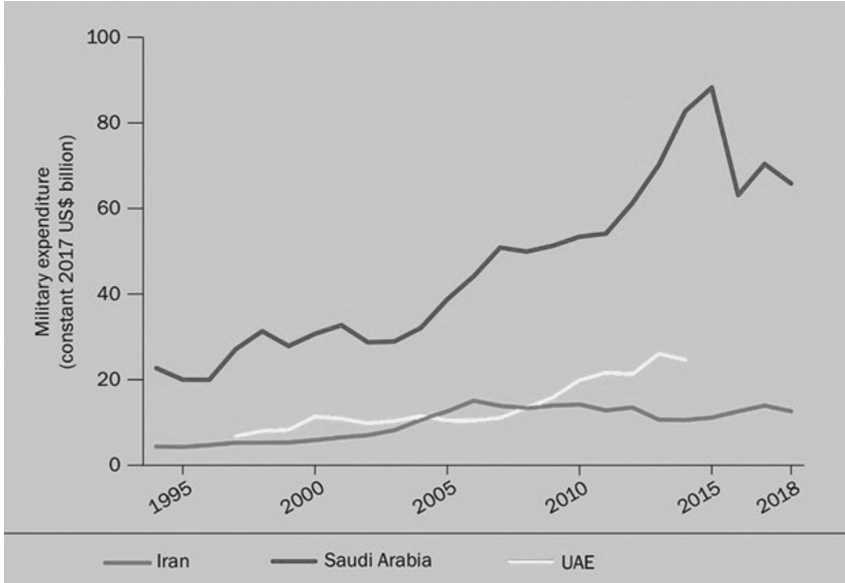
The U.S. has deployed nearly 50,000 troops in the Persian Gulf region in 29 military installations with more than 300 combat aircraft.

It has at least one aircraft carrier patrolling our waters at any given time, as well as tens of destroyers and other vessels with four Central Command Headquarters for its Army and its Special Forces, Air Force, and Navy.



And, from 2014 to 2018, the Persian Gulf States accounted for nearly one quarter of global arms imports, almost double compared to the

preceding five years. Unsurprisingly, the United States sold most of these lethal armaments.



Let me take this opportunity here and express our appreciation to the overwhelming majority of Security Council members for rejecting U.S. efforts to kill the JCPOA and Security Council Resolution 2231. Iran does not intend to engage in an arms race in the region and start a buying spree in spite of the end of Security Council restrictions.

For too long, foreign forces have come to our region to project their power, not to protect our people.

7,592 mi

Distance from Persian Gulf to Miami



The illegitimate U.S. presence—7600 miles from its shores—culminated in the cowardly assassination by President Trump of General Qassem Soleimani, Daesh's Enemy No.1.

Dear Friends,

Security is contingent on a reliance on our own peoples and cooperation with our own neighbors.

Yes, with money one can buy the most sophisticated weaponry. But the truth is: security and stability can never be bought.

We need collective efforts by regional countries to establish inclusive dialogue and security networking in this region. Otherwise, we will all be engulfed in turmoil for generations to come.

And our turmoil will be everyone's turmoil.

We need a fundamental paradigm shift in our region.

We need a strong region that precludes hegemonic illusions by any power—regional or global.

A strong region that requires homegrown political and territorial stability.

And a strong region in which all neighbors exercise strategic self-restraint.

Our Hormuz Peace Endeavor (or HOPE) is founded on these imperatives.

HOPE also rests on the responsibility of every state in the region to ensure peace, stability and prosperity in our neighborhood, and to benefit from it.

HOPE is founded on a commitment by all littoral states to:

- Promote mutual understanding, peaceful and friendly relations and cooperation among all States and peoples of the Persian Gulf region:
- Ensure the territorial integrity and inviolability of international boundaries of all Persian Gulf littoral states;
- Cooperate in eradicating terrorism, extremism and sectarian tensions across the region;
- Promote peaceful resolution of all regional tensions and conflicts through enhanced communication and early warning; and
- Ensure the freedom of navigation and energy security for all.

To achieve these objectives, we propose adherence to common principles such as

- dialogue and mutual respect;
- equal footing;
- respect for each other's sovereignty;
- rejection of the threat or use of force;
- non-aggression and non-intervention in the internal affairs of each other; and
- rejection of participation in alliances and coalitions against one another.

We believe that a new regional approach should be the outcome of collective deliberations. Last year, President Rouhani shared our initial thoughts with all the leaders of the littoral states of the Persian Gulf, inviting them to enrich these ideas and participate in their implementation.

Together we can envisage a broad spectrum of cooperation and confidence-building measures that include water management, environmental protection, nuclear safety, energy security, education, tourism, economic cooperation, trade, investment, poverty eradication and people empowerment.

We can agree on regional early warning systems and on military contacts among Persian Gulf littoral states.

We can agree to establish joint task forces regarding practical measures to gradually expand cooperation.

Mr. President,

We know that most of our neighbors prefer peace and dialogue. That cannot be achieved if one or two pursue confrontation and wishfully wait for alien vampires to "cut their neighbor's head". That delusion will never be realized.

My Friends,

We all have anxieties and grievances.

Certainly, Iranians will never forget 8 years of an imposed war: the aggressor fully financed by our neighbors.

So, we can choose to remain prisoners of the past and perpetuate instability and tension.

Or, all of us—and I stress all—can choose peace, security, stability and prosperity for all.

The choice, surely, should be obvious to everyone.

Thank you.

Annex VI

Phase	Action by Iran	Action by E3/EU
1- April- July 2005	- Approval of the Additional Protocol in the Cabinet - Policy Declaration on Iran's Open Fuel Cycle (No Reprocessing) - Presentation of Legislation on Peaceful Use of Nuclear Technology, including Permanent Ban on Production, Stockpiling and Use of Nuclear Weapons to the Majlis - Resumption of the Work of the UCF - Storage of UF6 Under Agency Surveillance	- Declaration of EU Policy to Guarantee Iran's Access to EU Markets and Financial and Public and Private Investment Resources - Declaration of EU Recognition of Iran as a Major Source of Energy Supply for Europe - Launching of Feasibility Studies for Building of New Nuclear Power Plants in Iran by E3/EU Members
	Establishment of a Joint Counter-Terrorism Task Force Establishment of a Joint Export Control Task Force	
2	- Presentation of the Additional Protocol to the Majlis for Ratification - Strengthening of Legal Export Control Mechanisms - Policy Declaration on the Ceiling of Enrichment at LEU Level - Policy Declaration on Conversion of All Enriched Uranium to Fuel Rods - Assembly, Installation and Testing of 3000 Centrifuges in Natanz	- Declaration of EU Policy to Guarantee Iran's Access to Advanced and Nuclear Technology - Declaration of EU Readiness to Participate in Building New Nuclear Power Plants in Iran - Signing of Contracts for Construction of Nuclear Power Plants in Iran by E3/EU Members
	Joint Commitment to Principles Governing Relations Cooperation on Security in the Persian Gulf	

3	- Employing All Appropriate Measures for Adoption of the Legislation on Peaceful Use of Nuclear Technology, including Permanent Ban on Production, Stockpiling and Use of nuclear weapons by the Majlis - Allowing Continuous On-Site Presence of IAEA Inspectors, which Can Include E3/EU Nationals, at the UCF and Natanz - Commissioning of the Above Centrifuges in Natanz - Immediate Conversion of the Total Product of the Above to Fuel Rods - Incremental Manufacturing, Assembly and Installation of Centrifuge Components up to the Numbers Envisaged for Natanz	- Normalizing Iran's Status Under G8 Export Control Regulations - Firm Guarantees on the Supply of Fuel Necessary for Iranian Nuclear Power Reactors to compliment Iran's Domestic Production - Presentation and Active Follow up of an EU Initiative to Establish a Zone Free from Weapons of Mass Destruction in the Middle East
	Establishment of a Task Force on Strategic Cooperation Establishment of a Task Force on Defense Requirements	
4	- Employing All Appropriate Measures for Ratification of the Additional Protocol by the Majlis - Commencement of Phased Commissioning of Natanz - Immediate Conversion of the Total Product of the Above to Fuel Rods	- Conclusion of Contracts for Defense Items - Beginning of Construction of New Nuclear Power Plants in Iran by E3/EU Members

Annex VII:

Statement before the United Nations Security Council, 30 June 2020

In the name of God, the Compassionate, the Merciful
 Mr. President,

I wish to begin my statement with words Prime Minister Mosaddegh used in this Council 69 years ago.

“The Security Council was established so that large and small nations alike might sit around the same table and cooperate for the maintenance of peace in accordance with the purposes and principles of the United

Nations. The Council cannot perform its great task ... unless big powers respect the principles which it was created to embody.”

Two years later, he was overthrown in a CIA coup.

Mr. President, If this Council falters again, it will be a generational setback for the cause of multilateralism and the rule of law.

We have all in past years seen how malign U.S. unilateralism has intently assaulted international cooperation and international institutions. Through its parallel endeavor to supplant international law with U.S. domestic laws, this has directly undermined global peace and security.

Regrettably, complacency has enabled and encouraged this recklessness.

Indeed, complacency is a root cause for why we are gathered here today.

Iran and other members of the international community have, since the 8th of May 2018, been witnessing the U.S. Government—a co-sponsor of Security Council Resolution 2231—persistently flouting the Resolution, while also trying to force other States to join it in violating the very text it put forward itself. More dangerously, and for the first time in UN history, a permanent member of the Security Council is punishing law-abiding States and private citizens for not violating a Council resolution, which emphasized, and I quote, “promoting and facilitating the development of normal economic and trade contacts and cooperation with Iran.”²⁴⁹

And yet, not a single Council session has been convened to reprove the U.S. Government, or to at least investigate its repeated violations. Instead, some European members of the Council are contemplating further undermining the Resolution and the Council while further reneging on their own JCPOA commitments.

To cover this up, the U.S. has—with some of its enablers—pressured the Secretariat to adopt a perverse reading of Resolution 2231—rejected by 3 JCPOA Participants,²⁵⁰ which is the polar opposite of the clear affirmation by the Security Council “that conclusion of the JCPOA marks a fundamental shift in its consideration of this issue...”²⁵¹

²⁴⁹ Preambular Paragraph 13 of UNSCR 2231 (2015).

²⁵⁰ This flawed interpretation of JCPOA and the unacceptable approach by the Secretariat over the past 4 years has been repeatedly rejected by at least three members of the JCPOA Joint Commission, namely, China, Iran and Russian Federation.

²⁵¹ Preambular Paragraph 7 of UNSCR 2231 (2015).

The U.S.—along with its accomplices in war crimes in Yemen—have gone further in their now-infamous²⁵² campaign of intimidation against international institutions. Most recently, they coerced the Secretariat to rely on self-serving allegations and forged documents to produce an utterly unprofessional report outside the scope of its mandate under UNSCR 2231.²⁵³ Not surprisingly, the Secretariat simultaneously absolved the Saudi coalition of its well-documented child-killing in Yemen.

This status quo is neither acceptable nor sustainable.

The international community in general—and the UN Security Council in particular—are facing an important decision: Do we maintain respect for the rule of law, or do we return to the law of the jungle by surrendering to the whims of an outlaw bully?

Mr. President,

In spite of our strong and legitimate objections to the historic mistreatment of Iran by the Security Council—particularly throughout 8 years of aggression by Saddam Hussein, as well as in the course of the unnecessary nuclear crisis—Iran showed its good faith by engaging in negotiations to reach a diplomatic solution as called for by all Security Council Resolutions on the nuclear issue²⁵⁴. After thirteen years of complex negotiations, in 2015 Iran and the five permanent members of this Council plus Germany signed the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action, which is annexed to—and inseparable from—Resolution 2231. Iran clearly stated

²⁵² The Whitehouse, “Executive Order on Blocking Property Of Certain Persons Associated With The International Criminal Court”, 11 June 2020. Available at: <https://www.whitehouse.gov/presidential-actions/executive-order-blocking-property-certain-persons-associated-international-criminal-court/>

²⁵³ The Islamic Republic of Iran has already categorically rejected allegations contained in that report (S/2020/531). From a legal point of view, such types of investigation can only meet the established norms of international law when they are characterized by lawfulness, fairness and diligence. The evidence—indeed allegations—the Secretariat relied upon do not meet the criteria set by established norms of international law. According to the ICJ, a charge of such exceptional gravity against a State requires “a proper degree of certainty” and the standard, which should leave no room for reasonable doubt. (Corfu Channel: United Kingdom of Great Britain and Northern Ireland v. Albania, Merits, Judgment, I.C.J. Reports 1949, p. 17.) and must be proven by fully conclusive evidence. (Application of the Convention on the Prevention and Punishment of the Crime of Genocide: Bosnia and Herzegovina v. Serbia and Montenegro, Judgment of 26 February 2007, para. 208.) Such are totally absent in the uncorroborated self-serving allegations by the U.S. and Saudi Arabia.

²⁵⁴ UNSCR 1696, Para 3; UNSCR 1737, Para 20; UNSCR 1747, Para 9; UNSCR 1803, preamble; UNSCR 1929, preamble.

its positions immediately after the adoption of the Resolution²⁵⁵ and again more recently.²⁵⁶ Yet, it fulfilled all its commitments in good faith, verified by numerous IAEA reports.

In spite of this great achievement of multilateral diplomacy, the president of the United States in May 2018 announced his country's unilateral withdrawal from the JCPOA, and the unlawful re-imposition of all U.S. sanctions, in material breach of Resolution 2231. Prior to that, the U.S. had persistently committed multiple cases of "significant non-performance" of its JCPOA obligations. It is important to note that even the previous U.S. Administration made every effort to minimize the positive impact of its sanction lifting obligations under the JCPOA and Resolution 2231.

This has all been documented in my numerous letters to the JCPOA Joint Commission Coordinator and the UN Secretary-General²⁵⁷, all of which, unfortunately, have been ignored by the European JCPOA Participants.

Following the U.S. withdrawal from the JCPOA, the UN Secretary General²⁵⁸, the remaining JCPOA participants²⁵⁹ and many other members of the international community called on Iran to address its concerns through the mechanisms established in the JCPOA and to allow the remaining JCPOA participants to redress the unlawful withdrawal.

The European JCPOA Participants requested Iran to wait for only a few weeks to allow them to compensate for the losses Iran incurred as a result of re-imposed U.S. sanctions.

²⁵⁵ S/2015/550

²⁵⁶ A/74/850-S/2020/380

²⁵⁷ A/72/869-S/2018/453

²⁵⁸ "Statement by the Secretary-General on the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA)", 08 May 2018. Available at: <https://www.un.org/sg/en/content/sg/statement/2018-05-08/statement-secretary-general-joint-comprehensive-plan-action-jcpoa>

²⁵⁹ "Remarks by High Representative/Vice President Federica Mogherini on the Statement by U.S. President Trump Regarding the Iran Nuclear Deal (JCPOA)", Rome, 8 May 2018.

While expressly reserving Iran's immediate right²⁶⁰ under Paragraph 26,²⁶¹ I initiated the Dispute Resolution Mechanism under Paragraph 36 of the JCPOA on 10 May 2018²⁶². However, acting in good faith, we refrained from applying the 'remedy' in order to enable the remaining JCPOA participants to make good on their promises. For a full year, we continued full implementation of the JCPOA. I trust you are all aware of the 15 consecutive IAEA reports which verified Iran's full compliance with its JCPOA commitments.²⁶³

Unfortunately, the E3 response to our "strategic patience" was not a long overdue assertion of European "strategic autonomy". Rather it was over-compliance with the U.S.' "maximum pressure" targeting all Iranians.

On 6 November 2018, I made a final call on the Coordinator and the remaining JCPOA Participants under paragraph 36 of the JCPOA. "The United States has now re-imposed with full effect all sanctions specified in the JCPOA and its Annex II, and as elaborated above, no remedial measure has been implemented by the remaining JCPOA Participants. Most have effectively joined the restrictive measures against Iran... Either EU/E32+—who have repeatedly underlined the security and strategic ramifications of JCPOA—should ensure Iran's legitimate benefits by fulfilling their commitments made in their statements of 6 July and 24

²⁶⁰ In my letter of 10 May 2018 to the Coordinator of the JCPOA Joint Commission, I stated "It is Iran's unquestionable right—recognized also under the JCPOA and UNSCR 2231—to take appropriate action in response to persistent numerous unlawful acts by the U.S., particularly its withdrawal and re-imposition of all sanctions. However, as President Rouhani announced in his televised response on 8 May and further elaborated in the Statement of the Government on 10 May 2018, the Islamic Republic of Iran will decide its next step in the course of few weeks following consultations with the remaining JCPOA Participants to see if and how the commitments collectively undertaken by EU/E3+3 vis-a-vis Iran could be fulfilled in the absence of a reneging party by EU/E3+2. Nothing in this period would affect Iran's right to react and protect its national interest as appropriate, a right which is manifestly recognized in the JCPOA and the UNSC resolution 2231(2015)."

²⁶¹ Paragraph 26 of the JCPOA: "Iran has stated that it will treat such a re-introduction or re-imposition of the sanctions specified in Annex II, or such an imposition of new nuclear-related sanctions, as grounds to cease performing its commitments under this JCPOA in whole or in part."

²⁶² My Letter of 10 May 2018 to the Coordinator of the JCPOA Joint Commission.

²⁶³ IAEA Reports to the Security Council: S/2016/57 (19 January 2016), S/2016/250 (15 March 2016), S/2016/535 (13 June 2016), S/2016/808 (22 September 2016), S/2016/983 (21 November 2016), S/2017/234 (20 March 2017), S/2017/502 (14 June 2017), S/2017/777 (13 September 2017), S/2017/994 (28 November 2017), S/2018/205 (8 March 2018), S/2018/540 (6 June 2018), S/2018/835 (12 September 2018), S/2018/1048 (26 November 2018), S/2019/212 (6 March 2019), S/2019/496 (14 June 2019).

September 2018²⁶⁴ in real and practical terms without further delay, or Iran will have no option but to restore a semblance of balance—as ‘the remedy that the participants contemplated if the dispute mechanism did not resolve the issue’... In view of the above, I formally call for the convening of another ministerial meeting of the Joint Commission.”²⁶⁵

No meeting was convened and none of the European JCPOA Participants even bothered to write a rebuttal for another 6 months. Having repeatedly exhausted the Dispute Resolution Mechanism to absolutely no avail, my Government was left with no recourse but to exercise its rights under Paragraphs 26 and 36 of the JCPOA to apply remedial action and cease performing its commitments in part on 8 May 2019.

In spite of all this, our remedial measures have until now had no impact on the IAEA’s monitoring and verification of our peaceful nuclear program, thereby making any proliferation risks irrelevant. Indeed, Iran’s peaceful nuclear program remains subject to the “most robust” inspection regime in history. From 2016 through 2019, over 92 percent of the Agency’s total comparable global inspections were carried out in Iran.²⁶⁶

Even the recent controversial report by the Director General of the IAEA on 5 June 2020 states that “The Agency continues to verify the non-diversion of declared nuclear material at the nuclear facilities and locations outside facilities where nuclear material is customarily used (LOFs) declared by Iran under its Safeguards Agreement”²⁶⁷.

Having said that, the Agency must resist external pressures to manipulate its agenda. The litany of forged documents at its doorstep have a stated objective of forever killing the JCPOA, thereby ending the Agency’s robust monitoring of current activities in Iran. Resuscitating 17-year-old allegations with no proliferation risk—which were investigated

²⁶⁴ See Statement of EU/E3 and Iran on 15 May 2018 as well as Statements of the JCPOA Ministerial Joint Commissions of 6 July 2018 and 24 September 2018.

²⁶⁵ My letter dated 6 November 2018 to the Coordinator of the Joint Commission and distributed to the Foreign Ministers of all remaining JCPOA Participants.

²⁶⁶ IAEA, “The Safeguards Implementation Report for 2019”, GOV/2020/9.

²⁶⁷ IAEA, Report by the Director General, “Verification and monitoring in the Islamic Republic of Iran in light of United Nations Security Council resolution 2231 (2015)”, 5 June 2020.

and permanently closed by the IAEA Board of Governors in 2015²⁶⁸—will certainly not serve the Agency.

Mr. President,

Matters which are extraneous to the JCPOA by mutual agreement—such as Iran's defensive capabilities and regional policies—are being maliciously raised by the U.S. Administration and parroted by a handful of its allies and clients.²⁶⁹

Here, it must be underlined that the bargain made in the JCPOA was in total cognizance of our disagreement with the Western members of the P51+ over certain issues. Do not be deceived: we mutually agreed not to address these issues; most importantly because the United States was not prepared to—or probably even capable of—addressing our grave concerns over its unfathomable level of arms sales and build-up in our neighborhood²⁷⁰, as well as its malign behavior and constant interventions, which have left our region in ruins.

The United States has carried out numerous acts of armed aggression against Iran²⁷¹ and its neighbors; invaded our neighbors 3 times in the last 3 decades²⁷²; milked the region of its resources through destabilizing arms sales²⁷³; systematically supported terrorists²⁷⁴; and provided material

²⁶⁸ GOV/2015/72 "9. Also notes that all the activities in the Road-map for the clarification of past and present outstanding issues regarding Iran's nuclear programme were implemented in accordance with the agreed schedule and further notes that this closes the Board's consideration of this item;"

²⁶⁹ Russia and China as two important JCPOA Participants—along with several other members of the Council and the United Nations have officially rejected this approach. See for instance S/2020/451 and S/2020/517.

²⁷⁰ <https://www.sipri.org/media/press-release/2019/global-arms-trade-usa-increases-dominance-arms-flows-middle-east-surge-says-sipri>

²⁷¹ The overthrow of democratically elected government in 1953. Armed intervention in Iran on 24 April 1980. Attacks on Iranian oil platforms in October 1987 and April 1988 leading to the ICJ ruling that "the actions of the United States of America against Iranian oil platforms on October 19, 1987 (Operation Nimble Archer) and April 18, 1988 (Operation Praying Mantis) cannot be justified as measures necessary to protect the essential security interests of the United States of America." (International Court of Justice. *Oil Platforms: Islamic Republic of Iran v. United States of America*). This was the largest U.S. naval operation since WWII. (Love, Robert William. *History of the U.S. Navy*. Harrisburg: Stackpole Books, 1992.) The downing of IranAir passenger flight on 3 July 1988 killing 290 civilians. Numerous incursions into Iranian airspace. The terrorist murder of General Qassem Soleimani and high-ranking Iraqi officials in Iraq on 3 January 2020...

²⁷² Iraq 1991; Afghanistan 2001; Iraq 2003.

²⁷³ <https://www.sipri.org/media/press-release/2019/global-arms-trade-usa-increases-dominance-arms-flows-middle-east-surge-says-sipri>

²⁷⁴ "ISIS weapons arsenal included some purchased by U.S. government" <https://www.nbcnews.com/news/world/isis-weapons-arsenal-included-some-purchased-u-s-government-n829201>. "ISIL

support for crimes against humanity in Yemen²⁷⁵. The peoples of our region have had enough of the malign U.S. presence, and demand its termination.²⁷⁶ The bitter irony here is that most Americans also want their troops returned home, where they belong.

This very regime absurdly accuses Iran of “meddling” in its own region. Yes. Of course. We want to partner with all our neighbors to create a strong region that precludes the emergence of hegemonic aspirations, by any power—regional or global. A strong region that requires homegrown political and territorial stability. And a strong region for which all neighbors need to exercise strategic self-restraint. It was to this end that, the President of the Islamic Republic of Iran put forward the Hormuz Peace Endeavor—HOPE. And we can do it. Without U.S. meddling some 6000 miles away from its shores.

Mr. President,

The International Court of Justice clearly underlined in its 1971 advisory opinion on Namibia, and I quote, “One of the fundamental principles governing international relationship thus established is that a party which disowns or does not fulfil its own obligations cannot be recognized as retaining the rights which it claims to derive from the relationship.”²⁷⁷

After officially and explicitly ceasing its participation in the JCPOA at the highest level²⁷⁸, and having violated each and every one of its obligations under the JCPOA and Resolution 2231, the U.S. cannot arrogate to itself

weapons traced to US and Saudi Arabia” <https://www.aljazeera.com/news/2017/12/isil-weapons-traced-saudi-arabia-171214164431586.html>

²⁷⁵ “U.N. report says U.S., Britain, France may be complicit in potential war crimes in Yemen” https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/un-report-says-us-britain-france-complicit-in-potential-war-crimes-in-yemen/2019/09/03/ad278cf6-ce48-11e9-9031-519885a08a86_story.html. “America is likely complicit in war crimes in Yemen. It's time to hold the US to account” <https://www.theguardian.com/commentisfree/2019/oct/03/yemen-airstrikes-saudi-arabia-mbs-us>

²⁷⁶ “Trump administration refuses to heed Iraq’s call for troop withdrawal” https://www.washingtonpost.com/world/middle_east/iraq-asks-united-states-to-set-up-mechanism-for-troop-withdrawal/2020/01/10/794058ea-32f8-11ea-971b-43bec3ff9860_story.html

²⁷⁷ Legal Consequences for States of the Continued Presence of South Africa in Namibia (South West Africa) notwithstanding Security Council Resolution 276 (1970), Advisory Opinion, I.C.J. Reports 1971, Para. 91.

²⁷⁸ “Presidential Memoranda: Ceasing U.S. Participation in the JCPOA and Taking Additional Action to Counter Iran’s Malign Influence and Deny Iran All Path to Nuclear Weapons”, White House, 8 May 2018.

any right under that Resolution. Nor can its enablers try to save its face via so-called middle-ground formulas.

The timetable for the removal of arms restrictions embodied in Resolution 2231 is an inseparable part of the hard-won compromise enabling the JCPOA Participants to finally agree on the overall package of the JCPOA and Resolution 2231. The resolution explicitly urges its “full implementation on the timetable”. Any attempt to change or amend the agreed timetable is thus tantamount to undermining Resolution 2231 in its entirety.²⁷⁹ The Council must not allow a single State to abuse the process.

As specified in the letter of the President of the Islamic Republic of Iran to the leaders of remaining JCPOA participants on 8 May 2019, any new restriction by the Security Council is against the fundamental commitments made to the Iranian people. In such a scenario, Iran’s options, as already notified to the remaining JCPOA participants, will be firm. And the United States and any entity which may assist it—or acquiesce in its illegal behavior—will bear full responsibility.

Mr. President,

The unlawful U.S. unilateral withdrawal from the JCPOA and the re-imposition of its sanctions²⁸⁰ entail the U.S. responsibility under the UNSCR 2231, UN Charter and applicable international law. The United States has also disregarded the decision of the International Court of Justice²⁸¹.

It’s long overdue for the international community, and in particular this Council, to hold U.S. Government accountable for the consequences of its wrongful acts—including its malicious endeavors to wage economic terrorism on the entire Iranian nation, willfully deprive them of food and medicine²⁸², and irreparably harm their economy and their standard of

²⁷⁹ Operative Paragraph 1 of UNSCR 2231 states: “Endorses the JCPOA, and urges its full implementation on the timetable established in the JCPOA;”

²⁸⁰ A list of sanctions imposed by the United States submitted to the Council as attachment of my recent letter (A/74/850-S/2020/380)

²⁸¹ <https://www.icj-cij.org/files/case-related/175/175-20181003-ORD-01-00-EN.pdf>

²⁸² Michael R. Pompeo Interview with Hadi Nili of BBC Persian, 7 November 2018: “the leadership has to make a decision that they want their people to eat”. Available at: <https://www.state.gov/interview-with-hadi-nili-of-bbc-persian/>. Also “Mike Pompeo Says Iran Must Listen to U.S. ‘If They Want Their People to Eat’”, *Newsweek*, 9 November 2018.

living²⁸³. The United States must fully compensate the Iranian people for all damages it has inflicted upon them—appallingly, for no reason other than to satisfy domestic constituencies and personal aggrandizement.

While the Islamic Republic of Iran has shown—in words and deeds—our desire and preference for constructive engagement, we do not depend on others for our security, stability or prosperity. We have learned to solely depend on ourselves. That is why more than 40 years of U.S. pressure—whether through demonization or war, sanctions or terror—including the cowardly assassination of our region’s counter-terrorism hero, General Qassem Soleimani—has failed to “bring Iranians to their knees” or affect our people’s decision-making calculus.

For my final words, let me again borrow from Prime Minister Mossadegh’s speech before the Security Council in 1951: “The Council will not have failed to note the cogency of our arguments to the law. Yet, this is not a legal body, but primarily a political body charged with the highest political responsibilities. It will readily understand therefore, that we will not be coerced whether by foreign governments or by international authorities.”

Thank you, Mr. President.

²⁸³ The Whitehouse, Remarks by President Trump and Prime Minister Abe of Japan in Joint Press Conference: “we’re putting sanctions on Iran, the likes of which nobody has ever seen before, including, frankly, North Korea.” Available at: <https://www.whitehouse.gov/briefings-statements/remarks-president-trump-prime-minister-abe-japan-joint-press-conference-2/>. Also “Brian Hook: Because of our pressure, Iran’s leaders are facing a decision: either negotiate with us or manage economic collapse.” 27 May 2020. Available at: <https://www.state.gov/briefing-with-special-representative-for-iran-and-senior-advisor-to-the-secretary-brian-hook-and-assistant-secretary-for-international-security-and-nonproliferation-dr-christopher-a-ford-o/>. Also, Brian Hook’s Economic Speech at Council on Foreign Relations, 12 December 2019: “Iran’s oil exports have decreased by more than two million barrels per day, driving down Iran’s revenue from oil by more than 80 percent. This amounts to a loss of more than \$30 billion per year ... Our sanctions are also restricting investment in Iran’s oil and gas sector, which will have a lasting impact beyond the immediate loss of revenue from reduced exports ... This year, Iran’s economy will likely shrink by at least 9.5 percent, according to the IMF. This would be the steepest single-year decline in more than 30 years. Some analysts have projected an even steeper contraction, possibly as high as 12 to 14 percent. This would put the economy on the verge of a depression”. Available at: <https://www.state.gov/special-representative-brian-hooks-economic-speech-at-council-on-foreign-relations/>

Annex VIII

Presented by Iran in the Meeting of Steering Committee Paris- March 23, 2005

Elements of Objective Guarantees

1. Strong and Mutually Beneficial Relations between Iran and the EU/E3
2. Confinement of the Program
 - a. Open Fuel Cycle (No Reprocessing)
 - b. Ceiling of Enrichment at LEU Level
 - c. Limitation of the Extent of the Program
 - d. Immediate Conversion of All Enriched Uranium to Fuel Rods
 - e. Incremental and Phased Approach to Implementation
3. Legislative and Regulatory Measures
 - a. Additional Protocol
 - b. Permanent Ban on the Development, Stockpiling and Use of Nuclear Weapons
 - c. Export Controls
4. Enhanced Monitoring
 - a. Continued Implementation of the Additional Protocol
 - b. Continuous On-Site Presence of IAEA Inspectors, Which Can Include E3/EU Nationals, at the UCF and Natanz

Annex to the letter dated 20 July 2015 from the Permanent Representative of the Islamic Republic of Iran to the United Nations addressed to the President of the Security Council

Statement of the Islamic Republic of Iran following the adoption of United Nations Security Council resolution 2231 (2015) endorsing the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action

1. The Islamic Republic of Iran considers science and technology, including peaceful nuclear technology, as the common heritage of mankind. At the same time, on the basis of solid ideological, strategic and international principles, Iran categorically rejects weapons of mass destruction and particularly nuclear weapons as obsolete and inhuman, and detrimental to international peace and security. Inspired by the sublime Islamic teachings, and based on the views and practice of the late founder of the Islamic Revolution, Imam Khomeini, and the historic Fatwa of the leader of the Islamic Revolution, Ayatollah Khamenei, who has declared all weapons of mass destruction (WMD), particularly nuclear weapons, to be Haram (strictly forbidden) in Islamic jurisprudence, the Islamic Republic of Iran declares that it has always been the policy of the Islamic Republic of Iran to prohibit the acquisition, production, stockpiling or use of nuclear weapons.

2. The Islamic Republic of Iran underlines the imperative of the total elimination of nuclear weapons, as a requirement of international security and an obligation under the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons. The Islamic Republic of Iran is determined to engage actively in all international diplomatic and legal efforts to save humanity from the menace of nuclear weapons and their proliferation, including through the establishment of nuclear-weapon-free zones, particularly in the Middle East.

3. The Islamic Republic of Iran firmly insists that States parties to the Treaty on the Non-Proliferation of Nuclear Weapons shall not be prevented from enjoying their inalienable rights under the Treaty to develop research,

production and use of nuclear energy for peaceful purposes without discrimination and in conformity with articles I and II of the Treaty.

4. The finalization of the Joint Comprehensive Plan of Action (JCPOA) on 14 July 2015 signifies a momentous step by the Islamic Republic of Iran and the E3/EU+3 to resolve, through negotiations and based on mutual respect, an unnecessary crisis, which had been manufactured by baseless allegations about the Iranian peaceful nuclear programme, followed by unjustified politically motivated measures against the people of Iran.

5. The JCPOA is premised on reciprocal commitments by Iran and the E3/EU+3, ensuring the exclusively peaceful nature of Iran's nuclear programme, on the one hand, and the termination of all provisions of Security Council resolutions 1696 (2006), 1737 (2006), 1747 (2007), 1803 (2008), 1835 (2008), 1929 (2010) and 2224 (2015) and the comprehensive lifting of all United Nations Security Council sanctions, and all nuclear-related sanctions imposed by the United States and the European Union and its member States, on the other. The Islamic Republic of Iran is committed to implement its voluntary undertakings in good faith contingent upon same good-faith implementation of all undertakings, including those involving the removal of sanctions and restrictive measures, by the E3/EU+3 under the JCPOA.

6. Removal of nuclear-related sanctions and restrictive measures by the European Union and the United States would mean that transactions and activities referred to under the JCPOA could be carried out with Iran and its entities anywhere in the world without fear of retribution from extraterritorial harassment, and all persons would be able to freely choose to engage in commercial and financial transactions with Iran. It is clearly spelled out in the JCPOA that both the European Union and the United States will refrain from reintroducing or reimposing the sanctions and restrictive measures lifted under the JCPOA. It is understood that reintroduction or reimposition, including through extension, of the sanctions and restrictive measures will constitute significant non-performance which would relieve Iran from its commitments in part or in whole. Removal of sanctions further necessitates taking appropriate domestic legal and administrative measures, including legislative and regulatory measures to effectuate the removal of sanctions. The JCPOA

requires an effective end to all discriminatory compliance measures and procedures as well as public statements inconsistent with the intent of the agreement. Iran underlines the agreement by JCPOA participants that immediately after the adoption of the Security Council resolution endorsing the JCPOA, the European Union, its member States and the United States will begin consultation with Iran regarding relevant guidelines and publicly accessible statements on the details of sanctions or restrictive measures to be lifted under the JCPOA.

7. The Islamic Republic of Iran will pursue its peaceful nuclear programme, including its enrichment and enrichment research and development, consistent with its own plan as agreed in the JCPOA, and will work closely with its counterparts to ensure that the agreement will endure the test of time and achieve all its objectives. This commitment is based on assurances by the E3/EU+3 that they will cooperate in this peaceful programme consistent with their commitments under the JCPOA. It is understood and agreed that, through steps agreed with the International Atomic Energy Agency (IAEA), all past and present issues of concern will be considered and concluded by the IAEA Board of Governors before the end of 2015. The IAEA has consistently concluded heretofore that Iran's declared activities are exclusively peaceful. Application of the Additional Protocol henceforth is intended to pave the way for a broader conclusion that no undeclared activity is evidenced in Iran either. To this end, the Islamic Republic of Iran will cooperate with the IAEA, in accordance with the terms of the Additional Protocol as applied to all signatories. The IAEA should, at the same time, exercise vigilance to ensure full protection of all confidential information. The Islamic Republic of Iran has always fulfilled its international non-proliferation obligations scrupulously and will meticulously declare all its relevant activities under the Additional Protocol. In this context, the Islamic Republic of Iran is confident that since no nuclear activity is or will ever be carried out in any military facility, such facilities will not be the subject of inspection.

8. The Joint Commission established under the JCPOA should be enabled to address and resolve disputes in an impartial, effective, efficient and expeditious manner. Its primary role is to address complaints by Iran and ensure that effects of sanctions lifting stipulated in the JCPOA will be

fully realized. The Islamic Republic of Iran may reconsider its commitments under the JCPOA if the effects of the termination of the Security Council, European Union or United States nuclear-related sanctions or restrictive measures are impaired by continued application or the imposition of new sanctions with a nature and scope identical or similar to those that were in place prior to the implementation date, irrespective of whether such new sanctions are introduced on nuclear-related or other grounds, unless the issues are remedied within a reasonably short time.

9. Reciprocal measures, envisaged in the dispute settlement mechanism of the JCPOA, to redress significant non-performance are considered as the last resort if significant non-performance persists and is not remedied within the arrangements provided for in the JCPOA. The Islamic Republic of Iran considers such measures as highly unlikely, as the objective is to ensure compliance rather than provide an excuse for arbitrary reversibility or means for pressure or manipulation. Iran is committed to fully implement its voluntary commitments in good faith. In order to ensure continued compliance by all JCPOA participants, the Islamic Republic of Iran underlines that in case the mechanism is applied against Iran or its entities and sanctions, particularly Security Council measures, are restored, the Islamic Republic of Iran will treat this as grounds to cease performing its commitments under the JCPOA and to reconsider its cooperation with the IAEA.

10. The Islamic Republic of Iran underlines the common understanding and clearly stated agreement of all JCPOA participants that affirms that the provisions of Security Council resolution 2231 (2015) endorsing the JCPOA do not constitute provisions of the JCPOA and can in no way impact the performance of the JCPOA.

11. The Government of the Islamic Republic of Iran is determined to actively contribute to the promotion of peace and stability in the region in the face of the increasing threat of terrorism and violent extremism. Iran will continue its leading role in fighting this menace and stands ready to cooperate fully with its neighbours and the international community in dealing with this common global threat. Moreover, the Islamic Republic of Iran will continue to take necessary measures to strengthen its defence capabilities in order to protect its sovereignty, independence and territorial

integrity against any aggression and to counter the menace of terrorism in the region. In this context, Iranian military capabilities, including ballistic missiles, are exclusively for legitimate defence. They have not been designed for WMD capability, and are thus outside the purview or competence of the Security Council resolution and its annexes.

12. The Islamic Republic of Iran expects to see meaningful realization of the fundamental shift in the Security Council's approach envisaged in the preamble of Security Council resolution 2231 (2015). The Council has an abysmal track record in dealing with Iran, starting with its acquiescing silence in the face of a war of aggression by Saddam Hussain against Iran in 1980, its refusal from 1984 to 1988 to condemn, let alone act against, massive, systematic and widespread use of chemical weapons against Iranian soldiers and civilians by Saddam Hussain, and the continued material and intelligence support for Saddam Hussain's chemical warfare by several of its members. Even after Saddam invaded Kuwait, the Security Council not only obdurately refused to rectify its malice against the people of Iran, but went even further and imposed ostensibly WMD-driven sanctions against these victims of chemical warfare and the Council's acquiescing silence. Instead of at least noting the fact that Iran had not even retaliated against Saddam Hussain's use of chemical weapons, the Council rushed to act on politically charged baseless allegations against Iran and unjustifiably imposed a wide range of sanctions against the Iranian people as retribution for their resistance to coercive pressures to abandon their peaceful nuclear programme. It is important to remember that these sanctions, which should not have been imposed in the first place, are the subject of removal under the JCPOA and Security Council resolution 2231 (2015).

13. Therefore, the Islamic Republic of Iran continues to insist that all sanctions and restrictive measures introduced and applied against the people of Iran, including those applied under the pretext of its nuclear programme, have been baseless, unjust and unlawful. Hence, nothing in the JCPOA shall be construed to imply, directly or indirectly, an admission of or acquiescence by the Islamic Republic of Iran in the legitimacy, validity or enforceability of the sanctions and restrictive measures adopted against Iran by the Security Council, the European Union or its member States,

the United States or any other State, nor shall it be construed as a waiver or a limitation on the exercise of any related right the Islamic Republic of Iran is entitled to under relevant national legislation, international instruments or legal principles.

14. The Islamic Republic of Iran is confident that the good-faith implementation of the JCPOA by all its participants will help restore the confidence of the Iranian people, who have been unduly subjected to illegal pressure and coercion under the pretext of this manufactured crisis, and will open new possibilities for cooperation in dealing with real global challenges and actual threats to regional security. Our region has long been mired in undue tension while extremists and terrorists continue to gain and maintain ground. It is high time to redirect attention and focus on these imminent threats and seek and pursue effective means to defeat this common menace.

